THE BIBLE

in Plain Language

OLD TESTAMENT

THE BIBLE

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

VOLUME 2

2 Samuel to Psalms

With an explanation for every section

EDITED BY ANDREAS RUPP

The Bible in Plain Language
Volume 2: 2 Samuel to Psalms

Edited by Andreas Rupp.

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Some Bibles number the Psalms differently.

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Help

The Bible also tells of suffering and violence.

If something weighs on you: At the end of every volume you will find phone numbers where you can get help.

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2 SAMUEL

24 CHAPTERS

2 SAMUEL

Chapter 1

"How the mighty have fallen!"

Before we begin: What is the book of 2 Samuel?

The book of 2 Samuel continues the book of 1 Samuel. In the beginning both were one single book.

It tells the story of King David, from his start as king until shortly before his death. That is about 40 years.

The book has two big parts:

In the first part (Chapters 1–10) David rises. He becomes king, first over Judah, then over all Israel. He conquers Jerusalem and makes it the capital. He brings the ark of the covenant there. God gives him a great promise: his royal house will last forever.

In the second part (Chapters 11–24) things go downhill. David commits a serious sin with Bathsheba and her husband Uriah. After that, misfortune, violence, and conflict come into his own family. His son Absalom rises up against him.

The book is very honest. It does not show David as a hero without faults. It shows a man who loves God, but who also sins badly. And it shows how David repents and God forgives him, even though the consequences remain.

God's promise to David (Chapter 7) is one of the most important chapters in the whole Bible. Jews expect the Messiah to be a descendant of David. Christians believe that Jesus is this "Son of David."

A messenger brings the news VERSES 1–10

1 Saul was dead.
David had come back from killing many Amalekites.
He had been in Ziklag for two days.
2 On the third day a man came from Saul's camp.
His clothes were torn, and he had dirt on his head.
These were signs of deep sadness.
He came to David and bowed down to the ground to show respect.
3 David asked him, "Where do you come from?"
He answered, "I have escaped from the camp of Israel."
4 David said, "What happened? Please tell me."
The man answered,
"Our soldiers ran away from the battle.
Many of them were killed.
Saul and his son Jonathan are dead too."
5 David asked the young man,
"How do you know that Saul and his son Jonathan are dead?"
6 The young man answered,
"I just happened to be on Mount Gilboa.
There I saw Saul leaning on his spear.
The chariots and the horsemen were right behind him.
7 Saul turned around and saw me.
He called to me, and I answered, 'Here I am.'
8 He asked me, 'Who are you?'
I answered, 'I am an Amalekite.'
9 Then he said to me,
'Please come here and kill me.
I am in terrible pain, but I am still alive.'
10 So I went to him and killed him.
I was sure that he could not live after he had fallen.
I took the crown from his head
and the bracelet from his arm.
I have brought them here to you, my lord."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The man tells a different story than 1 Samuel 31. There it says that Saul fell on his own sword. Here the Amalekite says that he killed Saul.

The man is probably lying. He found Saul's body on the battlefield, took the crown and the bracelet, and made up a story. He thinks: David will be glad that his enemy is dead, and he will reward me.

Notice: he is an Amalekite. Saul had not completely defeated the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15). Now, of all people, an Amalekite claims to have killed Saul.

David mourns and punishes the Amalekite VERSES 11–16

11 Then David took hold of his clothes and tore them.
All the men with him did the same.
12 They mourned and wept.
They did not eat anything until evening.
They mourned for Saul and for his son Jonathan.
They mourned for the people of the LORD and for the nation of Israel,
because so many had been killed in battle.
13 David asked the young man who had brought the news,
"Where are you from?"
He answered,
"I am the son of a foreigner, an Amalekite."
14 David said to him,
"Why were you not afraid to raise your hand
and kill the LORD's anointed king?"
15 David called one of his young men and said,
"Come here and kill him!"
The young man struck him, and he died.
16 David said to the Amalekite,
"You are to blame for your own death.
Your own words have spoken against you.
You said, 'I have killed the LORD's anointed.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is not glad about Saul's death. He mourns, together with all his men. Saul was the man who hunted him, but he was also the king of Israel. And Jonathan was his best friend.

The Amalekite has miscalculated. Instead of a reward, he gets death. David himself had twice chosen not to kill Saul, because he was "the LORD's anointed." Whoever boasts of having killed the king condemns himself.

He was a "foreigner" who lived in the land. He could have known the laws of Israel.

For us today, this quick execution without a trial is hard to understand. It belongs to a time with different ideas about justice. It is not an example for today.

The Song of the Bow: David's lament for Saul and Jonathan VERSES 17–27

17 Then David sang this sad song about Saul and his son Jonathan.
18 He ordered that the people of Judah should learn it.
It is called "the Song of the Bow."
It is written in the book of Jashar:
19 "Israel, your glory lies dead on your hills!
How the mighty have fallen!
20 Don't tell it in Gath.
Don't spread the news in the streets of Ashkelon.
Otherwise the daughters of the Philistines will be glad.
The daughters of the uncircumcised will cheer.
21 You mountains of Gilboa,
may no dew or rain fall on you.
May no fields grow there for offerings.
For there the shield of the mighty was made dirty and thrown away.
The shield of Saul was no longer rubbed with oil.
22 Jonathan's bow never turned back
from the blood of the dead and the fat of the mighty.
Saul's sword never came back empty.
23 Saul and Jonathan
were loved and pleasant in their lives.
In their death they were not divided.
They were faster than eagles.
They were stronger than lions.
24 You daughters of Israel, weep over Saul!
He dressed you in fine red clothes.
He put gold jewelry on your clothes.
25 How the mighty have fallen in the middle of the battle!
Jonathan lies dead on your hills.
26 I am so sad because of you, my brother Jonathan.
You were very dear to me.
Your love to me was wonderful, greater than the love of women.
27 How the mighty have fallen,
and the weapons of war have perished!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This song of mourning is one of the most beautiful poems in the Bible. David was also a great poet.

He does not say one bad word about Saul. He only remembers the good: Saul was a brave warrior who brought wealth to Israel. That is noble: to speak well of a dead man who did you harm.

"The book of Jashar" was an old collection of songs that is lost today. It is also mentioned in Joshua 10:13.

"Don't tell it in Gath": the enemies should not rejoice. This sentence later became a saying.

A shield was rubbed with oil so that the leather stayed soft. Saul's shield now lies thrown away and uncared for. The Hebrew word for "anointed" also reminds us that Saul himself was the anointed one.

Verse 26 is about Jonathan: "Your love to me was wonderful, greater than the love of women." With this David says: our friendship was the deepest and most faithful thing I have ever known. Some readers today ask whether there was more behind it. Most Jewish and Christian interpreters understand it as the expression of a unique, unselfish friendship. Jonathan had given up his own throne for David.

"How the mighty have fallen!" appears three times in the song: at the beginning, in the middle, and at the end. So the pain can be heard again and again.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 2

David becomes king over Judah

David in Hebron VERSES 1–7

1 After this, David asked the LORD,
"Should I go up to one of the cities of Judah?"
The LORD said to him, "Go up."
David asked, "Where should I go?"
The LORD answered, "To Hebron."
2 So David went up to Hebron
with his two wives.
They were Ahinoam from Jezreel and Abigail, who had been the wife of Nabal from Carmel.
3 David also brought the men who were with him,
and each man brought his family.
They lived in the towns around Hebron.
4 Then the men of Judah came to Hebron.
There they anointed David as king over the people of Judah.
They told David,
"The men of Jabesh Gilead buried Saul."
5 So David sent messengers to the men of Jabesh Gilead.
He told them to say,
"May the LORD bless you!
You were kind and loyal to your lord Saul.
You buried him.
6 Now may the LORD be kind and faithful to you.
I will also be good to you,
because you have done this.
7 So now be strong and brave.
Your lord Saul is dead.
And the people of Judah have anointed me as their king."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before David does anything, he asks God. That is what he has mostly done since Chapter 23 of 1 Samuel.

Hebron was an old, important city in Judah. Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were buried there (Genesis 23 and 49:29–31).

David is anointed for the second time, this time in public by the men of his own tribe. The first time, Samuel had

anointed him in secret (1 Samuel 16).

David praises the men of Jabesh for their faithfulness to Saul. He does not want to be king of Judah only. He also wants to win over Saul's followers. His message is friendly, but also wise.

Ishbosheth becomes king over Israel VERSES 8–11

8 Meanwhile Abner, the son of Ner, had taken
Ishbosheth, the son of Saul,
across the river to Mahanaim.
Abner was the commander of Saul's army.
9 He made Ishbosheth king over Gilead, over the
Ashurites,
over Jezreel, over Ephraim, over Benjamin,
and over all Israel.
10 Saul's son Ishbosheth was 40 years old
when he became king over Israel.
He ruled for 2 years.
But the people of Judah followed David.
11 David was king over the people of Judah in Hebron
for 7 years and 6 months.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now there are two kings: David in the south over Judah, and Ishbosheth in the north over the other tribes. The land is divided.

Ishbosheth is a son of Saul, but the man who really holds the power is Abner, the army commander.

The name "Ishbosheth" means "man of shame." That was surely not his real name. In 1 Chronicles 8:33 he is called "Eshbaal." That means: man of Baal, or man of the lord. The word "Baal" first simply meant "lord." Later the scribes did not want to write the name of the foreign god Baal, and they put in "bosheth," "shame," instead.

Mahanaim was east of the Jordan. Probably the west was still too much under the control of the Philistines after the defeat at Gilboa.

The numbers are not easy to fit together: Ishbosheth rules for two years, David in Hebron for seven and a half years. Maybe it took a while until Ishbosheth really became king, or until David got all Israel after his death.

The fight at the pool of Gibeon VERSES 12–17

12 Abner, the son of Ner, went out from Mahanaim to
Gibeon.
The servants of Ishbosheth, the son of Saul, went with
him.
13 Joab, the son of Zeruiah, and David's servants also went
out.
They met by the pool of Gibeon.
One group sat down on one side of the pool.
The other group sat down on the other side.
14 Abner said to Joab,
"Let some of the young men get up and fight each
other in front of us!"
Joab said, "All right, let them do it!"
15 So the young men got up, and they were counted.
There were 12 for Benjamin and for Ishbosheth, the
son of Saul,
and 12 of David's servants.
16 Each man grabbed his opponent by the head
and stabbed his sword into the other man's side.
So they all fell down dead together.
That is why that place in Gibeon is called Helkath
Hazzurim.
17 The battle that day was very hard.
David's servants defeated Abner and the men of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gibeon was about 6 miles northwest of Jerusalem. Archaeologists have found a large water shaft there, cut into the rock.

Joab is David's nephew and his army commander. He will play a big and often dark role in the next chapters.

The "competition" was perhaps meant to decide the conflict with only a few men, as once with David and Goliath. But it ends in death for all 24 men. And after that, a big battle breaks out after all.

"Helkath Hazzurim" probably means "field of swords" or "field of blades."

Israel fights against Israel. Brothers kill brothers. That is the sad result of the division.

Abner kills Asahel VERSES 18–23

18 The three sons of Zeruiah were there: Joab, Abishai,
and Asahel.
Asahel could run as fast as a wild gazelle.
19 Asahel ran after Abner.
He went straight after him.
He did not turn to the right or to the left.
20 Abner looked back and asked,
"Is that you, Asahel?"
He answered, "Yes, it is."
21 Abner said to him,
"Turn to the right or to the left!
Grab one of the young men and take his armor."
But Asahel would not stop chasing him.
22 Abner said to Asahel again,
"Stop chasing me!
I don't want to kill you.
How could I look your brother Joab in the face then?"
23 But Asahel would not turn away.
So Abner stabbed him in the body with the back end of
his spear.
The spear came out of his back.
Asahel fell down and died right there.
Everyone who came to the place where Asahel lay dead
stopped and stood still.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Asahel is young, fast, and ambitious. He wants to defeat the famous Abner.

Abner does not want to kill him. He warns him twice. He knows: if I kill Joab's brother, Joab will take revenge. In those days that was the duty of the "avenger of blood."

In the end Abner does kill Asahel, with the blunt end of the spear, maybe because he really only wanted to hold him off. But the blow is deadly.

Here a blood feud begins that has terrible consequences (2 Samuel 3:27).

Abner asks for peace VERSES 24–32

24 But Joab and Abishai chased Abner.
At sunset they came to the hill of Ammah.
It lies across from Giah, on the road to the wilderness
of Gibeon.

25 The men of Benjamin gathered behind Abner.
They formed one group
and stood on the top of a hill.
26 Then Abner called out to Joab,
"Must the sword keep on killing forever?
Don't you know that this will end in bitterness?
When will you tell your men
to stop chasing their brothers?"
27 Joab said,
"As surely as God lives:
If you had not spoken,
my men would surely have gone away in the morning.
Then each one would have stopped chasing his brother."
28 So Joab blew the trumpet.
All his men stopped.
They did not chase the men of Israel anymore,
and they did not fight anymore.
29 Abner and his men marched all that night through the Arabah.
They crossed the Jordan,
went through the whole area of Bithron,
and came to Mahanaim.
30 Joab came back from chasing Abner.
He gathered all his men together.
Of David's men, 19 were missing, and Asahel too.
31 But David's servants had killed 360 men from Benjamin and from Abner's army.
32 They took Asahel's body and buried him in his father's tomb in Bethlehem.
Then Joab and his men marched all night.
They came to Hebron as the day began.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abner says an important sentence: "Must the sword keep on killing forever? Don't you know that this will end in bitterness?" A war between brothers has no winner. Joab listens and ends the fighting.

The losses: David loses 20 men, counting Asahel. Abner's side loses 360. David's side is much stronger.

The Arabah is the low land of the Jordan Valley. "Bithron" is probably a ravine or an area east of the Jordan.

Asahel is buried in Bethlehem, the hometown of David and his family.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 3

Abner changes sides and is murdered

David grows stronger VERSES 1–5

1 There was a long war between Saul's house and David's house.
David grew stronger and stronger,
but Saul's house grew weaker and weaker.
2 Sons were born to David in Hebron.
His firstborn was Amnon, from Ahinoam of Jezreel.
3 His second was Chileab, from Abigail, the wife of Nabal from Carmel.
The third was Absalom, the son of Maacah, the daughter of Talmai, king of Geshur.
4 The fourth was Adonijah, the son of Haggith.
The fifth was Shephatiah, the son of Abital.
5 The sixth was Ithream, from Eglah, David's wife.
These were born to David in Hebron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David now has six wives and six sons. In those days it was usual for kings to have several wives, often for political reasons. Maacah, for example, was the daughter of a king. In this way David made alliances.

But the law warned the king against having many wives (Deuteronomy 17:17). This list is like a dark preview: Amnon, Absalom, and Adonijah will later bring great misfortune to David's family.

In 1 Chronicles 3:1 Chileab is called "Daniel." We hear nothing more about him.

Abner and Ishbosheth quarrel VERSES 6–11

6 While there was war between Saul's house and David's house,
Abner made himself more and more powerful in Saul's house.
7 Saul had had a concubine whose name was Rizpah, the daughter of Aiah.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
And Ishbosheth said to Abner,
"Why have you slept with my father's concubine?"
8 Then Abner was very angry about Ishbosheth's words, and he said,
"Am I a dog's head that belongs to Judah?
Today I show kindness to the house of your father Saul,
to his brothers, and to his friends.
I have not handed you over to David.
And yet today you accuse me of a wrong about this woman!
9 May God do this to Abner, and even more,
if I don't do for David exactly what the LORD has sworn to him:
10 to take the kingdom away from Saul's house
and to set up David's throne over Israel and over Judah,
from Dan to Beersheba."
11 Ishbosheth could not answer Abner another word,
because he was afraid of him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In those days, whoever slept with the wife of a king who had died was claiming his throne. That is why Ishbosheth is so worried. He accuses Abner of wanting to become king himself.

The text does not say whether Abner really did it. Rizpah is treated here like an object in the power struggle of men.

Later she shows great faithfulness and dignity (2 Samuel 21:10).

Abner is offended. "A dog's head" is an insult for someone who is worth nothing.

Interesting: Abner knows that God has promised David the kingdom. And yet he has fought against David until now. Now he changes sides, out of hurt pride.

Abner makes a deal with David VERSES 12–21

12 Abner sent messengers to David on his behalf and said,
"Whose is the land?"
And he also said,
"Make your agreement with me.
And my hand will be with you
to bring all Israel over to you."
13 David said,
"Good. I will make a treaty with you.
But I ask one thing of you:
You will not see my face
unless you first bring Michal, Saul's daughter,
when you come to see my face."
14 David sent messengers to Ishbosheth, Saul's son, and said,
"Give me my wife Michal,
whom I was given to marry for 100 foreskins of the Philistines."
15 So Ishbosheth sent for her
and took her from her husband, Paltiel the son of Laish.
16 Her husband went with her.
He wept as he went and followed her to Bahurim.
Then Abner said to him,
"Go! Go back!"
And he went back.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David demands Michal back. He had married her lawfully, but Saul had taken her away from him (1 Samuel 25:44). As Saul's daughter she also strengthens David's claim to the throne of all Israel.

Here it says "100 foreskins," as Saul had demanded. In 1 Samuel 18:27 David brought 200.

Paltiel loves Michal. He runs after her weeping until Abner sends him away. It is a sad scene. No one asks what Michal wants. Once again she is pushed back and forth between men.

17 Abner talked with the elders of Israel and said,
"For a long time you have wanted David to be king over you.
18 Now then, do it!
For the LORD has spoken about David and said,
'By the hand of my servant David
I will save my people Israel from the hand of the Philistines
and from the hand of all their enemies.'"
19 Abner also spoke to the people of Benjamin.
Then Abner also went to Hebron to tell David everything
that seemed good to Israel and to the whole house of Benjamin.
20 So Abner came to David at Hebron, and 20 men with him.
David made a feast for Abner and the men who were with him.
21 Abner said to David,
"I will get up and go
and gather all Israel to my lord the king.
Then they can make a covenant with you,
and you can rule over everything your heart desires."
So David sent Abner away,
and he went in peace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abner prepares everything. He talks with the elders in the north, and especially with the tribe of Benjamin, Saul's own tribe. Without Benjamin it would have been hard to come to an agreement.

David welcomes Abner in a friendly way, even though he was his enemy for years. Three times the text stresses: he went "in peace." David wants to make peace, not to take revenge.

Joab murders Abner VERSES 22–30

22 Then David's servants and Joab came back from a raid
and brought a great amount of plunder with them.
But Abner was no longer with David in Hebron,
for David had sent him away, and he had gone in peace.
23 When Joab and the whole army that was with him arrived,
people told Joab,
"Abner the son of Ner came to the king.
And the king has sent him away, and he has gone in peace."
24 Then Joab came to the king and said,
"What have you done?
Look, Abner came to you.
Why have you sent him away, so that he is already gone?
25 You know Abner the son of Ner.
He came to deceive you,
and to find out about your going out and your coming in,
and to find out everything you do."
26 When Joab had left David,
he sent messengers after Abner.
They brought him back from the well of Sirah.
But David did not know it.
27 When Abner had come back to Hebron,
Joab took him aside into the middle of the gate
to speak with him quietly.
And there he struck him in the body, so that he died,
because of the blood of his brother Asahel.
28 Afterward, when David heard it, he said,
"I and my kingdom are forever innocent before the LORD
of the blood of Abner the son of Ner.
29 Let it fall on the head of Joab and on all his father's house.
May the house of Joab never be without someone who has a discharge, or who has leprosy,
or who leans on a staff, or who falls by the sword,
or who lacks bread."
30 So Joab and his brother Abishai killed Abner,
because he had killed their brother Asahel at Gibeon in

the battle.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joab is furious. He says that Abner is a spy. But his real reasons are different: he wants revenge for his brother Asahel. And maybe he is afraid that Abner will take away his place as army commander.

Joab secretly brings Abner back and murders him in the gate of Hebron. That is a serious crime. Hebron was a city of refuge (Joshua 20:7), where no one could be killed without a trial. And Asahel had died in battle, not by murder. Abner had even warned him.

David curses Joab and his family. A "discharge" and "leprosy" were illnesses that made a person unclean. To "lean on a staff" perhaps means being lame or weak.

David declares in public: I have nothing to do with this. That was important, because otherwise the northern tribes would have thought that David had led Abner into a trap.

David mourns for Abner VERSES 31–39

31 David said to Joab and to all the people who were with him,
"Tear your clothes,
put on sackcloth,
and mourn in front of Abner."
Sackcloth is rough cloth that people wore when they mourned.
And King David walked behind the bier.
32 They buried Abner in Hebron.
And the king lifted up his voice and wept at Abner's grave.
And all the people wept.
33 The king sang a song of mourning for Abner and said,
"Should Abner die as a fool dies?
34 Your hands were not tied,
and your feet were not put in chains.
As a man falls before wicked people, so you fell."
And all the people wept over him again.
35 All the people came to urge David to eat bread while it was still day.
But David swore and said,
"May God do this to me, and even more,
if I taste bread or anything else before the sun goes down."
36 All the people noticed it,
and it pleased them,
just as everything the king did pleased all the people.
37 So that day all the people and all Israel understood that it was not the king's will to kill Abner the son of Ner.
38 The king said to his servants,
"Don't you know that a prince and a great man has fallen today in Israel?
39 Today I am weak, even though I am anointed king.
These men, the sons of Zeruiah, are too hard for me.
May the LORD pay back the evildoer according to his wickedness."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David even makes Joab mourn for Abner. He himself walks behind the coffin, weeps, and fasts.

His short song of mourning says: Abner was not a criminal who was tied up and executed. He was free and did not suspect anything. He was murdered by treachery.

The people see David's grief and believe him. Through this David also wins trust in the north.

But David admits: I am too weak against Joab and Abishai. He does not punish Joab. Joab is too powerful and too important for the army. That is a weakness of David that will later bring much more suffering. Only shortly before his death does David tell his son Solomon to settle accounts with Joab (1 Kings 2:5–6).

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 4

The murder of Ishbosheth

Two leaders and a lame child VERSES 1–4

1 When Saul's son heard that Abner was dead in Hebron,
his hands became weak,
and all Israel was alarmed.
2 Saul's son had two men who were captains of raiding groups.
The name of one was Baanah, and the name of the other was Rechab.
They were the sons of Rimmon from Beeroth, of the tribe of Benjamin.
For Beeroth also counts as part of Benjamin.
3 The people of Beeroth had fled to Gittaim
and have lived there as foreigners until today.
4 Jonathan, Saul's son, had a son who was lame in his feet.
He was five years old when the news about Saul and Jonathan came from Jezreel.
His nurse picked him up and fled.
As she hurried to flee, he fell and became lame.
His name was Mephibosheth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Without Abner, Ishbosheth is helpless. "His hands became weak" means: he loses all his courage.

In the middle of the story a child is briefly put in: Mephibosheth, the son of Jonathan. When the news of the death of his father and grandfather came, his nurse fled with him. He fell and was lame from then on.

Why is he mentioned here? When Ishbosheth dies, only this lame boy will be left of Saul's family. He could not become king. David had promised Jonathan to protect his family (1 Samuel 20:15). We hear about Mephibosheth again in Chapter 9.

As with Ishbosheth, this name was also changed: in 1 Chronicles 8:34 he is called "Merib-baal."

Ishbosheth is murdered VERSES 5–8

5 The sons of Rimmon from Beeroth, Rechab and Baanah, set out.

In the heat of the day they came to the house of
Ishbosheth,
while he was taking his rest at noon.
6 They came into the middle of the house as if they were
going to get wheat,
and they stabbed him in the body.
And Rechab and his brother Baanah escaped.
7 For when they came into the house,
he was lying on his bed in his bedroom.
They struck him and killed him.
They cut off his head and took his head with them.
Then they walked all night along the way through the
Arabah.
8 They brought the head of Ishbosheth to David at
Hebron
and said to the king,
"Here is the head of Ishbosheth, the son of Saul, your
enemy,
who tried to take your life!
Today the LORD has avenged my lord the king on Saul
and on his descendants."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Two of Ishbosheth's own officers murder him while he sleeps. They act as if they wanted to get grain. It is a cowardly murder of a man who cannot defend himself.

The old Greek translation tells verse 6 a little differently: the woman who kept the door had been cleaning wheat and had fallen asleep. So the men came into the house without being seen.

The murderers think like the Amalekite in Chapter 1: David will be glad and reward us. They even use God's name: "Today the LORD has avenged my lord the king."

David punishes the murderers VERSES 9–12

9 David answered Rechab and his brother Baanah, the
sons of Rimmon from Beeroth,
and said to them,
"As the LORD lives, who has rescued my life from all
trouble:
10 When someone told me, 'Saul is dead,'
and thought he was bringing good news,
I seized him and killed him in Ziklag.
That was the reward I gave him for his news.
11 How much more, when wicked men have killed a
righteous man in his own house,
on his bed,
should I not now demand his blood from your hand
and rid the earth of you?"
12 David gave the order to his young men, and they killed
them.
They cut off their hands and their feet
and hung them up beside the pool in Hebron.
But they took the head of Ishbosheth
and buried it in Abner's grave in Hebron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David says: it was not you who saved me. The LORD has rescued me from all trouble. I do not need murderers to become king.

He calls Ishbosheth a "righteous man." Righteous means: living right before God. Ishbosheth was David's enemy, but he was innocent of this crime.

David punishes the murderers harshly. Their hands and feet were cut off, because they had murdered with their hands and had run with their feet to report it. The dead bodies were hung up in public as a warning to everyone. This is a cruel punishment from a harsh time, not an example for today.

Once again David shows: he does not want to come to power through violence. He waits for God's way.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 5

David becomes king over all Israel and conquers Jerusalem

All Israel anoints David VERSES 1–5

1 Then all the tribes of Israel came to David at Hebron.
They said,
"We are your bone and your flesh.
2 In the past, Saul was king over us.
But even then, you were the one who led Israel out to
battle and back home again.
And the LORD said to you,
'You will be the shepherd of my people Israel.
You will be the leader over Israel.'"
3 So all the leaders of Israel came to King David at
Hebron.
There, in front of the LORD, King David made a
covenant with them.
A covenant is a binding agreement.
And they anointed David as king over Israel.
4 David was 30 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 40 years.
5 In Hebron he ruled over Judah for 7 years and 6
months.
In Jerusalem he ruled over all Israel and Judah for 33
years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At last the time has come: all 12 tribes come to David. "We are your bone and your flesh" means: we are your family, we belong together.

"Shepherd" is a beautiful picture for a king. David was a shepherd. Now he is to lead and protect God's people like a shepherd, not to use them for himself. Much later Jesus calls himself "the good shepherd" (John 10:11).

This is the third time that David is anointed: first in secret by Samuel, then by Judah, now by all Israel.

The king makes a "covenant" with the people. That means: the king also has duties. He does not stand above the law.

The math: 7½ years in Hebron plus 33 years in Jerusalem are about 40 years.

The conquest of Jerusalem VERSES 6–10

6 The king and his men went to Jerusalem.
They wanted to fight against the Jebusites, who lived there.
The Jebusites said to David,
"You will never get in here.
Even the blind and the lame can keep you out!"
They thought, "David can't get in here."
7 But David captured the fortress of Zion.
It is now called the City of David.
8 On that day David said,
"Whoever wants to attack the Jebusites
must go up through the water shaft.
Then he can strike those lame and blind, who are hated by David's soul."
That is why people say,
"The blind and the lame can't come into the house."
9 David lived in the fortress.
He called it the City of David.
He built up the area all around it, from the Millo inward.
10 David became more and more powerful,
because the LORD, the God of Armies, was with him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Until then Jerusalem had belonged to the Jebusites. The city lay on a hill, well protected by valleys. It lay right on the border between Judah and the northern tribes and belonged to no tribe. That is why it was the perfect capital for everyone.

The Jebusites mock: our city is so safe that even the blind and the lame can keep you out.

The "water shaft" was probably a passage through which the people of the city got water from the spring below the city. Through it David's men came into the city. Archaeologists have found old water shafts like this in Jerusalem.

Verse 8 is very hard to understand in Hebrew. The "lame and blind, who are hated by David's soul" probably means the mocking defenders, not people who were really sick. Sadly, the saying at the end was later used against people with disabilities.

Very important: the Bible does not teach that people with disabilities are worth less. David himself later brings the lame Mephibosheth to his own table (Chapter 9). And Jesus healed the blind and the lame in the temple (Matthew 21:14). With God every person has the same dignity.

"Zion" was first the name of the stronghold. Later "Zion" became a name for all Jerusalem and for the place where God lives.

The "Millo" was probably a filled-in area, a terrace of stones on which people could build.

David's house and family VERSES 11–16

11 Hiram, the king of Tyre, sent messengers to David.
He also sent cedar trees, carpenters, and stonemasons.
They built a palace for David.
12 Then David understood that the LORD had made him a strong king over Israel.
The LORD had made his kingdom great for the sake of his people Israel.
13 After David came from Hebron to Jerusalem,
he took more wives from Jerusalem.
He also took more concubines.
Concubines are women who belong to a man like a wife, but with fewer rights.
More sons and daughters were born to David.
14 These are the names of the children who were born to him in Jerusalem:
Shammua, Shobab, Nathan, Solomon,
15 Ibhar, Elishua, Nepheg, Japhia,
16 Elishama, Eliada, and Eliphelet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tyre was a rich trading city by the sea, in today's Lebanon. The people there were famous for their skill in building. Cedar wood from Lebanon was the best wood for building.

Other kings now recognize David. He becomes a respected king.

Verse 12 is important: David understands that God did not make him great for his own sake, but "for the sake of his people Israel." A king is there for the people.

Once again David takes even more wives. That was usual for kings, but the law warned against it (Deuteronomy 17:17).

Among the sons are Nathan and Solomon. Solomon will be the next king. In the Gospel of Luke, the family tree of Jesus goes through Nathan (Luke 3:31). In the Gospel of Matthew it goes through Solomon (Matthew 1:6).

Two victories over the Philistines VERSES 17–25

17 The Philistines heard that David had been anointed king over Israel.
So their whole army went up to hunt for David.
But David heard about it.
He went down to the fortress.
18 The Philistines came and spread out in the valley of Rephaim.
19 David asked the LORD,
"Should I go up and attack the Philistines?
Will you hand them over to me?"
The LORD answered David,
"Go up.
I will surely hand the Philistines over to you."
20 So David went to Baal Perazim.
There he defeated the Philistines.
He said,
"The LORD has broken through my enemies in front of me,
like a flood of water breaking through."
That is why he named that place Baal Perazim.
21 The Philistines left their idols there.
David and his men carried them away.
22 Once again the Philistines came up.
They spread out in the valley of Rephaim.
23 David asked the LORD again.
This time the LORD said,
"Do not go straight up to them.
Go around behind them.
Attack them in front of the mulberry trees.
24 You will hear a sound like marching in the tops of the mulberry trees.
Then attack quickly!
That will be the sign that the LORD has gone out ahead

of you
to strike the army of the Philistines."
25 David did what the LORD had commanded him.
He defeated the Philistines all the way from Geba to Gezer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As long as David ruled only over Judah, the Philistines left him alone. Now that he unites all Israel, they see him as a danger.

The valley of Rephaim lies southwest of Jerusalem.

"Baal Perazim" means "lord of breaking through." God breaks through the enemies like a flood through a dam.

The Philistines leave their idols behind. Let us remember: earlier the Philistines had captured the ark of God (1 Samuel 4). Now it is the other way around.

The second time God gives a different instruction. David asks again every time. He does not rely on his experience, but on God's guidance.

The WEB, our English source text, says "mulberry trees." We do not know for sure which trees are meant. The rustling in the trees is the sign: God's army is going out ahead of David.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 6

The ark comes to Jerusalem

The new cart VERSES 1–5

1 Once again David gathered the best soldiers of Israel.
There were 30,000 men.
2 David set out with all his people from Baale Judah.
They wanted to bring the ark of God up from there.
The ark is a holy chest.
It is called by the Name of the LORD of Armies.
The LORD sits above the cherubim.
Cherubim are heavenly beings with wings.
3 They put the ark of God on a new cart
and took it out of Abinadab's house on the hill.
Uzzah and Ahio, the sons of Abinadab, drove the new cart.
4 So they brought the cart with the ark of God out of Abinadab's house on the hill.
Ahio walked in front of the ark.
5 David and all the people of Israel celebrated before the LORD.
They played all kinds of instruments made of cypress wood.
They played harps, stringed instruments, and tambourines.
They played castanets and cymbals.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem is now the capital. Now God is to have his place there too. David wants to bring the ark of the covenant, the sign of God's presence.

For many years the ark had been in Abinadab's house in Kiriath Jearim (1 Samuel 7:1–2). "Baale Judah" is another name for this place.

It is a huge celebration with music and joy.

But there is a problem: they carry the ark on a cart. That is how the Philistines had done it (1 Samuel 6). But the law said: the ark is to be carried on poles by Levites (Numbers 4:15; Exodus 25:14).

Uzzah dies VERSES 6–11

6 They came to the threshing floor of Nacon.
There the oxen stumbled.
So Uzzah reached out and took hold of the ark of God.
7 Then the LORD became very angry with Uzzah.
God struck him down there because of his mistake.
Uzzah died there beside the ark of God.
8 David was upset because the LORD had broken out against Uzzah.
So he called that place Perez Uzzah.
It is still called that today.
9 That day David was afraid of the LORD.
He said,
"How can the ark of the LORD ever come to me?"
10 So David did not want to take the ark of the LORD to his home in the City of David.
Instead, he took it to the house of Obed-Edom from Gath.
11 The ark of the LORD stayed in the house of Obed-Edom from Gath for 3 months.
And the LORD blessed Obed-Edom and his whole family.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a story that is hard to understand. Uzzah means well. He wants to keep the ark from falling down. And yet he dies.

Many interpreters explain it like this: God's holiness is not a toy. The ark could only be carried in the way that was commanded, and it was not to be touched (Numbers 4:15). The problem already began when they put the ark on a cart instead of having it carried. David himself later understood this (1 Chronicles 15:13).

Still, the story remains hard. David too is upset and frightened. The Bible allows us to have such questions and feelings.

"Perez Uzzah" means "breaking out against Uzzah." It is the same word as in "Baal Perazim" in 2 Samuel 5:20. God breaks through, against the enemies, but also against his own people when they do not take him seriously.

Obed-Edom is a man from Gath, maybe even a Philistine. Of all people, he receives the blessing of the ark. God's presence brings not only danger, but also great blessing.

David dances before the LORD VERSES 12–19

12 Someone told King David,
"The LORD has blessed the family of Obed-Edom and everything he has,
because of the ark of God."
So David went to the house of Obed-Edom.
With great joy he brought the ark of God up from there to the City of David.

13 The men carrying the ark of the LORD took six steps.
Then David sacrificed an ox and a fattened calf.
14 David danced before the LORD with all his might.
He was wearing a linen ephod.
An ephod is a simple garment like the ones priests wore.
15 So David and all the people of Israel brought up the ark of the LORD.
They shouted for joy and blew trumpets.
16 The ark of the LORD came into the City of David.
Michal, the daughter of Saul, looked out of the window.
She saw King David leaping and dancing before the LORD.
And in her heart she despised him.
17 They brought in the ark of the LORD.
They set it in its place inside the tent that David had set up for it.
Then David offered burnt offerings and peace offerings before the LORD.
18 David finished offering the burnt offerings and the peace offerings.
Then he blessed the people in the name of the LORD of Armies.
19 He gave food to all the people, to the whole crowd of Israel, men and women.
Each person received bread, dates, and raisins.
Then all the people went home.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This time the ark is carried, not driven on a cart. After six steps an offering is made. Everything happens with deep respect.

David dances "with all his might." He is so full of joy about God's presence that he forgets his royal dignity. He does not wear a royal robe, but a simple linen garment like a priest's.

This is a beautiful picture: faith may be joyful. We may praise God with our whole body, with music and dancing.

But Michal watches from the window. She does not celebrate with them. She despises David. She is the "daughter of Saul." That is what the text calls her here, not "the wife of David."

David blesses the people and gives food to everyone, men and women. It is a celebration for the whole people.

The exact meaning of the Hebrew words for "dates" and "raisins" is uncertain. Some Bibles translate "date cakes" and "raisin cakes."

Michal and David VERSES 20–23

20 Then David went home to bless his family.
Michal, the daughter of Saul, came out to meet him.
She said,
"How wonderful the king of Israel looked today!
He uncovered himself today in front of his servants' maids,
just like some worthless fool without any shame!"
21 David said to Michal,
"I did it before the LORD.
He chose me instead of your father and anyone in his family.
He made me the leader over the LORD's people, over Israel.
So I will celebrate before the LORD.
22 I will make myself even less dignified than this.
I will seem worthless even in my own eyes.
But those maids you talked about
will honor me."
23 And Michal, the daughter of Saul, had no children for the rest of her life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Michal makes fun of David. She thinks a king should be dignified, not dance wildly. The short linen garment probably showed a lot while he was dancing.

David answers: I did not dance for people, but for God. Before God it is not embarrassing to make yourself small.

But there is more behind the quarrel: Michal had been taken away from her second husband against her will (2 Samuel 3:15–16). She had once loved David (1 Samuel 18:20). Now nothing is left of this love. David harshly reminds her that God rejected her father.

Verse 23 is a sad ending: Michal has no child. So there is no descendant in whom the families of Saul and David would be united. The text does not say whether this was a punishment from God or whether David stayed away from her.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 7

God's promise to David

David wants to build a house for God VERSES 1–3

1 The king was living in his house,
and the LORD had given him rest from all his enemies all around.
2 Then the king said to Nathan the prophet,
"Look now, I live in a house of cedar,
but the ark of God lives inside tent curtains."
3 Nathan said to the king,
"Go, do everything that is in your heart,
for the LORD is with you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David now has a palace. He has peace. And he thinks: it is not right that I live in a beautiful house while God's ark stands only in a tent. He wants to build a temple for God.

Here the prophet Nathan appears for the first time. He will become very important in David's life (Chapter 12).

At first Nathan says without thinking long: go ahead! He gives his own opinion. But he has not yet asked God.

God's answer through Nathan VERSES 4–17

4 That same night the word of the LORD came to Nathan:

5 "Go and tell my servant David,
'The LORD says:
"Should you build me a house for me to live in?
6 For I have not lived in a house
since the day I brought the people of Israel up out of Egypt, even to this day.
Instead I have moved around in a tent and in a dwelling place.
7 In all the places where I have walked with all the people of Israel,
did I ever say a word to anyone from the tribes of Israel whom I commanded to be shepherd of my people Israel?
Did I ever say, 'Why have you not built me a house of cedar?'"'
8 So now tell my servant David this:
'The LORD of Armies says:
"I took you from the sheep pen, from following the sheep,
to be prince over my people, over Israel.
9 I have been with you wherever you went,
and I have cut off all your enemies in front of you.
I will make your name great,
like the name of the great ones on the earth.
10 I will choose a place for my people Israel
and I will plant them,
so that they can live in their own place and not be moved anymore.
Wicked people will not oppress them anymore, as at the beginning,
11 and as from the day I commanded judges to be over my people Israel.
I will give you rest from all your enemies.
And the LORD tells you that the LORD will make you a house.
12 When your days are over and you die and join your ancestors,
I will raise up your descendant after you,
who will come from your own body,
and I will make his kingdom firm.
13 He will build a house for my name,
and I will make the throne of his kingdom firm forever.
14 I will be his father, and he will be my son.
If he does wrong, I will correct him with the rod of men
and with the blows of human beings.
15 But my loving kindness will not leave him,
as I took it away from Saul, whom I removed before you.
16 Your house and your kingdom will be made sure forever before you.
Your throne will be made firm forever."'"
17 Nathan told David all these words, just as he had seen them in this vision.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God says no to David's plan. But it is a loving no, with a much bigger yes.

God says: I have never needed a house. I have moved around with my people, in a tent. I am not tied to one place.

Then comes a play on the word "house": David wanted to build God a "house," a temple. But God says: you will not build me a house. I will build you a "house," that is, a family, a royal family that will last forever.

This is one of the most important promises in the whole Bible. It is called the "covenant with David."

The descendant who will build the temple is first of all Solomon, David's son. He builds the temple in Jerusalem (1 Kings 6).

"I will be his father, and he will be my son": the king is to have a special, close relationship with God. If he does wrong, God will punish him, but God will not leave him as he left Saul. God's loving kindness remains.

"Forever": David's royal line lasted in Jerusalem for about 400 years. Then Jerusalem was destroyed by the Babylonians, and there was no king anymore. But the people of Israel held on to God's promise. From this grew the hope for the Messiah, the Anointed One, a descendant of David who will rule forever (Isaiah 9:7; Psalm 89).

Christians believe that this promise was fulfilled in Jesus. In the Gospel of Luke the angel says to Mary about Jesus: "The Lord God will give him the throne of his father David. ... There will be no end to his Kingdom" (Luke 1:32–33). The letter to the Hebrews applies verse 14 to Jesus (Hebrews 1:5).

David's prayer VERSES 18–29

18 Then King David went in, sat before the LORD, and said,
"Who am I, Lord GOD,
and what is my house, that you have brought me this far?
19 And this was still a small thing in your eyes, Lord GOD.
You have also spoken about your servant's house for a long time to come.
And this is the way of people, Lord GOD!
20 What more can David say to you?
For you know your servant, Lord GOD.
21 For the sake of your word, and as your own heart wanted, you have done all these great things,
to let your servant know it.
22 That is why you are great, LORD God.
For there is no one like you,
and there is no God besides you,
according to everything we have heard with our ears.
23 What one nation on the earth is like your people, like Israel?
God went to rescue them for himself as a people,
to make a name for himself,
and to do great things for you and awesome things for your land,
in front of your people, whom you rescued for yourself out of Egypt,
from the nations and their gods.
24 You made your people Israel your own people forever.
And you, LORD, became their God.
25 "Now, LORD God,
the word that you have spoken about your servant and about his house,
confirm it forever, and do as you have said.
26 Let your name be great forever, so that people say,
'The LORD of Armies is God over Israel.

And the house of your servant David will be made firm
before you.'
27 For you, LORD of Armies, the God of Israel,
have shown your servant and said,
'I will build you a house.'
That is why your servant has found the courage in his
heart to pray this prayer to you.
28 "Now, Lord GOD, you are God, and your words are
truth,
and you have promised this good thing to your
servant.
29 So now, may it please you to bless the house of your
servant,
so that it may continue forever before you.
For you, Lord GOD, have spoken it.
Let the house of your servant be blessed forever with
your blessing."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is overwhelmed. He sits down before God and prays. The prayer begins with a humble question: "Who am I?" I was a shepherd. And you have made me king and promised me a future that lasts forever.

David wanted to do something for God. But he learns: God does much more for him. That is what grace is: God gives before we can give.

"This is the way of people" in verse 19 is hard to understand in Hebrew. Maybe David means: this is how people talk with each other, but you, God, talk to me like this!

David does not only praise God for himself, but for the whole people of Israel. God rescued this people out of Egypt.

Verse 23 is a little difficult in Hebrew. It switches between "you" as one person and "you" as many. There is a similar text in 1 Chronicles 17:21.

At the end David asks: do what you have promised. That is a good way to pray: we take God at his word.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 8

David's victories and his government

Victories over the Philistines and Moab VERSES 1–2

1 After this, David struck the Philistines and brought
them under his control.
And David took the bridle of the mother city out of the
hand of the Philistines.
2 He also defeated Moab.
He measured them with a line,
by making them lie down on the ground.
He measured two lengths of the line to be put to death,
and one full length of the line to be kept alive.
So the Moabites became David's servants and brought
him tribute.
Tribute is money or goods that a defeated people had
to pay.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is a summary of David's wars. It shows that God's promise "I will give you rest from all your enemies" (2 Samuel 7:11) is coming true.

"The bridle of the mother city" is hard to understand in Hebrew. It says "Metheg Ammah." Maybe it is the name of a place. Maybe it means: David took over the rule of the main city of the Philistines. 1 Chronicles 18:1 says: he took Gath.

What David does with the Moabites is cruel. He has captured soldiers lie down on the ground in rows and has two thirds of them killed. In those days this was a practice of war to weaken a defeated people. The Bible tells it without praising it. It is not an example.

This is all the more shocking because David's great-grandmother Ruth was a Moabite, and the king of Moab had once protected David's parents (1 Samuel 22:3–4). The text does not say why David acted so harshly.

Victories over Zobah and Damascus VERSES 3–8

3 David also struck Hadadezer the son of Rehob, the king
of Zobah,
as he went to win back his rule at the River.
4 David captured 1,700 horsemen and 20,000 foot soldiers
from him.
David hamstrung the chariot horses,
but he kept enough of them for 100 chariots.
5 When the Syrians of Damascus came to help
Hadadezer, the king of Zobah,
David struck down 22,000 men of the Syrians.
6 Then David put groups of soldiers in Syria of Damascus.
And the Syrians became David's servants and brought
him tribute.
The LORD gave David victory wherever he went.
7 David took the shields of gold that the servants of
Hadadezer had carried
and brought them to Jerusalem.
8 And from Betah and from Berothai, cities of
Hadadezer,
King David took a great amount of bronze.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Hebrew the "Syrians" are called "Aram." Many Bibles say "Arameans." They lived in the north, in today's Syria. Zobah and Damascus were kingdoms of the Arameans.

"The River" is the Euphrates. David's kingdom now reached far to the north.

David makes the horses lame by cutting a tendon in their legs. That is what "hamstrung" means. Then they can no longer be used in war. Joshua already did this (Joshua 11:6). God did not want Israel to rely on horses and war chariots (Deuteronomy 17:16; Psalm 20:7).

The numbers are a little different in 1 Chronicles 18:4: 1,000 chariots, 7,000 horsemen, and 20,000 foot soldiers.

"The LORD gave David victory wherever he went": this sentence appears twice in the chapter (verses 6 and 14). The storyteller stresses: the victories come from God.

Gifts from Hamath VERSES 9–14

9 Toi, the king of Hamath, heard
that David had struck the whole army of Hadadezer.

10 Then Toi sent his son Joram to King David,
to greet him and to congratulate him,
because he had fought against Hadadezer and struck him.
For Hadadezer had been at war with Toi.
Joram brought with him objects of silver, gold, and bronze.
11 King David also dedicated these to the LORD,
together with the silver and gold that he had dedicated
from all the nations he had brought under his control:
12 from Syria, from Moab, from the people of Ammon,
from the Philistines, from Amalek,
and from the plunder of Hadadezer, son of Rehob,
king of Zobah.
13 David made a name for himself
when he came back from striking down 18,000 men of the Syrians in the Valley of Salt.
14 He put groups of soldiers in Edom.
Throughout all Edom he put groups of soldiers,
and all the Edomites became David's servants.
The LORD gave David victory wherever he went.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hamath was a kingdom even farther north. Its king is glad that David has defeated his enemy. He sends gifts.

David does not keep the treasures for himself. He dedicates them to the LORD. Later the temple was built from them (1 Chronicles 18:8).

Verse 13: the Valley of Salt lies south of the Dead Sea, in the land of Edom. That is why 1 Chronicles 18:12 and the heading of Psalm 60 say "Edom" instead of "Syrians." In Hebrew the words for Aram and Edom look very much alike. A scribe probably mixed them up.

David's officials VERSES 15–18

15 David ruled over all Israel.
And David did what was just and right for all his people.
16 Joab the son of Zeruiah was over the army.
Jehoshaphat the son of Ahilud was recorder.
17 Zadok the son of Ahitub and Ahimelech the son of Abiathar were priests.
Seraiah was scribe.
18 Benaiah the son of Jehoiada was over the Cherethites and the Pelethites.
And David's sons were chief ministers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15 is the most important sentence in this chapter: David "did what was just and right for all his people." That is the real task of a king. Not only to win wars, but to make sure there is justice, for everyone.

David now has a real state with officials: an army commander, a recorder who kept the records, priests, and a scribe.

Zadok is mentioned here for the first time. Later he becomes the most important priest under Solomon.

In 1 Samuel 22:20 Abiathar was the son of Ahimelech. Here it is the other way around. Maybe Abiathar's son had the same name as his grandfather, or the names were switched when the text was copied.

The "Cherethites and Pelethites" were David's bodyguard, soldiers from other countries who were paid to serve, probably from Crete and from the people of the Philistines.

"Chief ministers": that is what the WEB, our English source text, says. The Hebrew text literally says "priests." That is unusual, because priests were supposed to come from the tribe of Levi. 1 Chronicles 18:17 says: "chief officials serving the king."

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 9

Mephibosheth at David's table

David looks for someone from Saul's family VERSES 1–5

1 One day David asked,
"Is anyone from Saul's family still alive?
I want to be kind to him because of Jonathan."
2 There was a servant from Saul's household.
His name was Ziba.
They called him to come to David.
The king asked him,
"Are you Ziba?"
He answered, "Yes, I am your servant."
3 The king asked,
"Is there no one left from Saul's family?
I want to show him the kindness of God."
Ziba said to the king,
"Jonathan still has a son.
He cannot walk properly, because his feet are lame."
4 The king asked him,
"Where is he?"
Ziba answered the king,
"He is in Lo Debar, in the house of Machir, the son of Ammiel."
5 So King David sent messengers.
They brought Jonathan's son from the house of Machir, the son of Ammiel, in Lo Debar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is now a powerful king. His enemies are defeated. And now he remembers his promise to Jonathan: I will show kindness to your family forever (1 Samuel 20:14–17).

In those days new kings often killed all the descendants of the old king. David does the opposite. He looks for a descendant of Saul in order to do him good.

"The kindness of God": David wants to be as generous as God is generous. The word is again "chesed," faithfulness and kindness.

Mephibosheth lives hidden away in Lo Debar, east of the Jordan. The name of the place perhaps means "no pasture" or "nothing." He lives on the edge, forgotten, without property.

"You will always eat at my table" VERSES 6–8

6 Mephibosheth, the son of Jonathan, the son of Saul,
came to David.
He fell on his face and showed respect.
David said, "Mephibosheth?"
He answered, "Here is your servant!"
7 David said to him,
"Don't be afraid.
I will surely be kind to you because of your father
Jonathan.
I will give back to you all the land that belonged to
your grandfather Saul.
And you will always eat at my table."
8 Mephibosheth bowed down and said,
"Who am I, your servant?
I am no better than a dead dog.
Why should you care about me?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mephibosheth is afraid. He is the grandson of David's enemy. Maybe he expects to be killed.

But the first thing David says is: "Don't be afraid." Then he calls him by name. And then he gives him three things: kindness, land, and a fixed place at his table, forever.

Mephibosheth calls himself a "dead dog." He feels worthless, because of his disability and because of his family background. In those days people with disabilities were often looked down on.

But David treats him like one of his own sons (verse 11). He does not look at the lame feet, but at the person and at his promise to Jonathan.

Many Christians see in this story a picture of God's grace: God brings people who feel worthless to his table. Not because they have earned it, but out of love and faithfulness.

Ziba is to work for Mephibosheth VERSES 9–13

9 Then the king called Ziba, Saul's servant.
He said to him,
"I have given your master's grandson everything
that belonged to Saul and his whole family.
10 You, your sons, and your servants must farm the land
for him.
Bring in the harvest,
so that your master's grandson has food to eat.
But Mephibosheth himself will always eat at my table."
Ziba had 15 sons and 20 servants.
11 Ziba said to the king,
"I am your servant.
I will do everything you command me, my lord the
king."
So Mephibosheth ate at the king's table like one of the
king's sons.
12 Mephibosheth had a young son whose name was Mica.
And all who lived in Ziba's house were servants to
Mephibosheth.
13 So Mephibosheth lived in Jerusalem,
for he always ate at the king's table.
And he was lame in both his feet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David does not only give him a place of honor, but also an income. Ziba and his large family are to farm the land for Mephibosheth. So Mephibosheth is provided for and does not have to beg.

Mephibosheth has a son, Mica. Through him the family of Saul and Jonathan lives on (1 Chronicles 8:34–35).

The last sentence reminds us once more: he was lame. At the king's table no one saw the lame feet. There he was simply a son.

Ziba will play a questionable role in later chapters (Chapters 16 and 19).

2 SAMUEL

Chapter 10

War against the Ammonites and the Syrians

David's messengers are humiliated VERSES 1–5

1 After this, the king of the people of Ammon died,
and his son Hanun became king in his place.
2 David said,
"I will show kindness to Hanun the son of Nahash,
as his father showed kindness to me."
So David sent his servants
to comfort him about his father.
And David's servants came into the land of the people
of Ammon.
3 But the princes of the people of Ammon said to Hanun
their lord,
"Do you think that David wants to honor your father
because he has sent people to comfort you?
Hasn't David sent his servants to you
to search the city, to spy it out, and to destroy it?"
4 So Hanun took David's servants
and shaved off half of their beards.
He cut off their clothes in the middle, up to their
buttocks.
Then he sent them away.
5 When David was told this, he sent people to meet them,
for the men were deeply ashamed.
The king said,
"Wait at Jericho until your beards have grown.
Then come back."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nahash, Hanun's father, was the king who had once threatened Jabesh (1 Samuel 11). Later he probably helped David once, maybe when David was running away from Saul. That is why David wants to show his son sympathy in his grief.

But Hanun's advisers are suspicious. They think David's messengers are spies.

Hanun humiliates the messengers in a terrible way. In those days a beard was a sign of dignity and manhood. A half-shaved beard and clothes that showed the buttocks were a great disgrace.

David is considerate: he makes sure that his men do not have to show themselves in public until their beards have grown back.

Whoever humiliates messengers insults the one who sent them. That was practically a declaration of war.

Joab and Abishai win VERSES 6–14

6 The people of Ammon saw that they had made David
hate them.
So the people of Ammon sent and hired the Syrians of
Beth Rehob
and the Syrians of Zobah, 20,000 foot soldiers,
and the king of Maacah with 1,000 men,
and the men of Tob, 12,000 men.
7 When David heard about it,
he sent Joab and the whole army of the mighty men.
8 The people of Ammon came out
and lined up for battle at the entrance of the gate.
The Syrians of Zobah and of Rehob and the men of Tob
and Maacah were by themselves in the field.
9 When Joab saw that the battle lines were set against
him in front and behind,
he chose some of the best men of Israel
and lined them up against the Syrians.
10 He put the rest of the people under the command of his
brother Abishai.
And he lined them up against the people of Ammon.
11 He said,
"If the Syrians are too strong for me, then you must
help me.
But if the people of Ammon are too strong for you,
then I will come and help you.
12 Be courageous,
and let's be strong for our people and for the cities of
our God.
And may the LORD do what seems good to him."
13 So Joab and the people who were with him went
forward into battle against the Syrians.
And they fled from him.
14 When the people of Ammon saw that the Syrians had
fled,
they also fled from Abishai and went into the city.
Then Joab came back from the people of Ammon and
came to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Ammonites know that David will take revenge. That is why they hire soldiers from the Syrians.

Joab is in a dangerous position: enemies in front of him and behind him. He divides the army: he himself fights against the Syrians, and his brother Abishai against the Ammonites. They promise to help each other.

Joab's words in verse 12 are remarkable: "Be courageous … And may the LORD do what seems good to him." He does what he can and leaves the result to God. Joab is often harsh and violent, but here he also shows trust in God.

David defeats the Syrians VERSES 15–19

15 When the Syrians saw that they had been defeated by
Israel,
they gathered together again.
16 Hadadezer sent and brought out the Syrians who were
beyond the River.
They came to Helam,
with Shobach, the commander of Hadadezer's army, at
their head.
17 David was told this.
So he gathered all Israel together, crossed the Jordan,
and came to Helam.
The Syrians lined up against David and fought with
him.
18 The Syrians fled from Israel.
And David killed 700 chariot fighters of the Syrians
and 40,000 horsemen.
And he struck Shobach, the commander of their army,
so that he died there.
19 All the kings who were servants of Hadadezer saw
that they had been defeated by Israel.
Then they made peace with Israel and served them.
So the Syrians were afraid to help the people of
Ammon anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now a great army of Syrians comes, even from beyond the Euphrates. David himself leads Israel into battle and wins.

1 Chronicles 19:18 says: 7,000 chariot fighters and 40,000 foot soldiers. The numbers are sometimes handed down differently in the old manuscripts.

In the end the Syrians are under Israel's rule. David's kingdom is now at the height of its power.

But the Ammonites are not yet defeated. The war against them goes on in the next chapter. And it is during this very war that David's most serious sin happens.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 11

David, Bathsheba, and Uriah

David takes Bathsheba VERSES 1–5

1 At the turn of the year, at the time when kings go out to
war,
David sent out Joab and his servants with him, and all
Israel.
They destroyed the people of Ammon and laid siege to
Rabbah.
But David stayed in Jerusalem.
2 One evening David got up from his bed
and walked around on the roof of the king's house.
From the roof he saw a woman bathing.
And the woman was very beautiful to look at.
3 David sent someone and asked about the woman.
Someone said,

"Isn't this Bathsheba, the daughter of Eliam, the wife
of Uriah the Hittite?"
4 David sent messengers and took her.
She came to him, and he slept with her.
She had just been made clean from her uncleanness.
Then she went back to her house.
5 The woman became pregnant.
She sent someone to tell David,
"I am pregnant."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the darkest part of David's life begins. The Bible tells it quite openly. It does not hide the guilt of its greatest king.

"At the turn of the year" means the spring. After the rainy season in winter, people went to war again.

"At the time when kings go out to war," David stays at home. He is not where he belongs.

David sees a woman bathing. He even learns that she is married, to Uriah, one of his most faithful soldiers (2 Samuel 23:39). And yet he has her brought to him.

How much choice did Bathsheba have? The king sends messengers to take her. In those days a woman could hardly say no to the king. The text says nothing about her feelings. Many interpreters see here a serious abuse of power by David. Later the Bible makes clear that the whole guilt lies with David, not with Bathsheba (Chapter 12).

"She had just been made clean from her uncleanness": this means the cleansing after her monthly period (Leviticus 15:19–28). This also shows: the child can only be David's, not Uriah's, because Uriah was away at war.

Bathsheba sends only three words, in Hebrew only two: "I am pregnant." In them lies all her distress. In those days adultery was punished by death (Leviticus 20:10).

David tries to cover everything up VERSES 6–13

6 David sent word to Joab:
"Send me Uriah the Hittite."
And Joab sent Uriah to David.
7 When Uriah came to him,
David asked him how Joab was doing, how the people were doing,
and how the war was going.
8 David said to Uriah,
"Go down to your house and wash your feet."
Uriah left the king's house,
and a gift from the king was sent after him.
9 But Uriah slept at the door of the king's house with all the servants of his lord,
and he did not go down to his house.
10 David was told,
"Uriah didn't go down to his house."
Then David said to Uriah,
"Haven't you come from a journey?
Why didn't you go down to your house?"
11 Uriah said to David,
"The ark and Israel and Judah are staying in tents.
And my lord Joab and the servants of my lord are camping in the open field.
Shall I then go into my house to eat and to drink and to sleep with my wife?
As you live, and as your soul lives,
I will not do this!"
12 David said to Uriah,
"Stay here today too.
Tomorrow I will let you go."
So Uriah stayed in Jerusalem that day and the next day.
13 David invited him, and he ate and drank with him.
And David made him drunk.
In the evening he went out to lie down on his bed with the servants of his lord.
But he did not go down to his house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David wants to hide his guilt. He brings Uriah back from the war. If Uriah sleeps with his wife, everyone will think that the child is his.

"Wash your feet" means: go home, rest, make yourself comfortable, also with your wife.

But Uriah does not go home. He is a man of honor. His comrades are sleeping in the field, and the ark of God is in a tent. So he does not want to enjoy himself. In those days soldiers at war had to stay away from their wives (1 Samuel 21:5).

The bitter thing is: Uriah, the foreigner, a Hittite, is more faithful and more devoted to God than the king of Israel.

David tries once more and makes him drunk. But even drunk, Uriah stays faithful.

The death letter VERSES 14–17

14 In the morning David wrote a letter to Joab
and sent it by the hand of Uriah.
15 He wrote in the letter,
"Send Uriah to the front, where the battle is hardest.
Then pull back from him,
so that he is struck and dies."
16 While Joab was keeping watch on the city,
he put Uriah at the place where he knew there were brave men.
17 The men of the city came out and fought against Joab.
Some of the people fell, some of David's servants.
And Uriah the Hittite died too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now adultery turns into murder. David has Uriah killed.

And he makes Uriah carry his own death letter himself. That is a terrible cruelty. Uriah is so faithful that he does not open the letter.

Joab obeys without asking. And not only Uriah dies, but also other innocent soldiers.

One sin leads to the next. Whoever wants to cover up a sin often sinks deeper and deeper into it.

Joab's message to David VERSES 18–25

18 Then Joab sent a messenger and told David everything about the war.
19 He commanded the messenger,
"When you have finished telling the king everything about the war,
20 the king may become angry and ask you,
'Why did you go so near to the city to fight?
Didn't you know that they would shoot from the wall?
21 Who struck down Abimelech the son of Jerubbesheth?
Didn't a woman throw an upper millstone on him from the wall,
so that he died at Thebez?

Why did you go so near the wall?'
Then you must say,
'Your servant Uriah the Hittite is dead too.'"
22 So the messenger went.
He came and told David everything Joab had sent him to say.
23 The messenger said to David,
"The men were stronger than we were.
They came out to us into the field.
But we drove them back to the entrance of the gate.
24 Then the archers shot at your servants from the wall.
And some of the king's servants are dead.
And your servant Uriah the Hittite is dead too."
25 Then David said to the messenger,
"Tell Joab this:
'Don't let this matter upset you,
for the sword devours one as well as another.
Make your attack against the city stronger and destroy it.'
Encourage him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joab knows that the attack was foolish from a military point of view. You do not go so near a city wall. People had already learned that from the story of Abimelech (Judges 9:53). "Jerubbesheth" is another name for Gideon (Jerubbaal), again with "besheth," "shame," instead of "Baal."

But Joab also knows: as soon as David hears that Uriah is dead, he will not be angry anymore. Joab now knows David's secret. That gives him power over the king.

David's answer is cold: "The sword devours one as well as another." That is how he talks about a murder he ordered himself.

David marries Bathsheba VERSES 26–27

26 When Uriah's wife heard that her husband Uriah was dead,
she mourned for her husband.
27 When the time of mourning was over,
David sent for her and brought her into his house.
She became his wife and gave birth to a son for him.
But the thing that David had done displeased the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bathsheba mourns for her husband. Here the text calls her "Uriah's wife." In the eyes of the Bible she still belongs to Uriah.

David marries her quickly. To the people everything looks proper. No one knows anything. David thinks the matter is settled.

But the last sentence shows: God has seen everything. "The thing that David had done displeased the LORD." You can fool people, but not God.

In the family tree of Jesus in the Gospel of Matthew, Bathsheba is not named. She is called "the woman who had been Uriah's wife" (Matthew 1:6). In this way the wrong done to Uriah is not forgotten.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 12

"You are the man!"

Nathan's story about the lamb VERSES 1–6

1 The LORD sent Nathan to David.
Nathan came to David and said,
"There were two men in a city.
One was rich, and the other was poor.
2 The rich man had very many sheep and cattle.
3 But the poor man had nothing except one little female lamb.
He had bought it and raised it.
It grew up together with him and his children.
It ate from his food and drank from his cup.
It slept in his arms.
It was like a daughter to him.
4 One day a traveler came to visit the rich man.
The rich man did not want to take one of his own sheep or cattle
to cook a meal for his guest.
Instead he took the poor man's lamb
and cooked it for the man who had come to him."
5 David became very angry with the rich man.
He said to Nathan,
"As surely as the LORD lives,
the man who did this deserves to die!
6 He must pay back four lambs for that one lamb.
He did this terrible thing, and he had no pity!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Almost a year has passed. The child has already been born. David thinks that everything has been forgotten. But God sends the prophet Nathan.

Nathan does not accuse David directly. He tells a story, like a case in court. David as king is to give a judgment.

The story is wisely chosen: the rich man has everything, the poor man has only one beloved lamb. And the rich man takes it away from him. Everyone sees at once: this is an outrageous injustice.

David is outraged. He still has a feeling for justice. But he does not notice that he is judging himself.

The law says: whoever steals a sheep must pay back four sheep (Exodus 22:1).

"You are the man!" VERSES 7–12

7 Then Nathan said to David,
"You are the man!
This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'I anointed you as king over Israel.
I saved you from Saul.
8 I gave you your master's palace.
I put your master's wives into your arms.
I gave you the people of Israel and of Judah.
And if that had been too little,
I would have given you much more.

9 So why have you treated the word of the LORD with contempt?
Why have you done what is evil in his eyes?
You killed Uriah the Hittite with the sword.
You took his wife to be your own wife.
You had him killed by the sword of the people of Ammon.
10 So now the sword will never leave your family.
You have treated me with contempt.
You took the wife of Uriah the Hittite to be your own wife.'
11 "This is what the LORD says:
'I will bring trouble on you from your own family.
I will take your wives while you watch.
I will give them to another man who is close to you.
He will sleep with your wives in broad daylight.
12 You did this in secret.
But I will do this in front of all Israel, in broad daylight.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"You are the man!" In Hebrew these are only two words. They are among the bravest sentences in the Bible. A prophet tells the most powerful man in the land to his face: you are guilty. Nathan risks his life.

This shows something important: in Israel even the king was under God's law. He could not do whatever he wanted.

God reminds David of everything he has given him. David had so much, and yet he took the poor man's only lamb away.

God names the crime clearly: murder and adultery. The guilt lies with David.

Then comes the judgment: the sword will never leave your family. And trouble will come from your own family. This comes true in the next chapters: one of David's sons rapes his sister, another son murders him, and Absalom rises up against his father and sleeps in public with David's concubines (Chapters 13–18, especially 16:22).

What David did in secret will come back in public.

David repents VERSES 13–14

13 David said to Nathan,
"I have sinned against the LORD."
Nathan said to David,
"The LORD has also taken away your sin.
You will not die.
14 But by this deed you have given the enemies of the LORD great reason to mock him.
So the son who has been born to you will surely die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David makes no excuses. He does not push the blame onto others, as Saul always did. He simply says: "I have sinned against the LORD." That is the great difference between Saul and David.

According to its heading, Psalm 51 is the prayer that David prayed after this conversation: "Have mercy on me, God, because of your loving kindness. ... Create in me a clean heart, O God."

God forgives David at once: "The LORD has also taken away your sin." By the law David actually deserved death. But God is gracious.

But forgiveness does not mean that all the consequences disappear. The child will die.

"Given the enemies of the LORD great reason to mock him": in Hebrew it literally says "despised the enemies of the LORD." Many interpreters think that the scribes added a word here so that they would not have to write "you have despised the LORD."

The death of the child is very hard to understand. Why must an innocent child die for the guilt of his father? The Bible gives no simple answer. We may ask this question and honestly say that it hurts us. In other places the Bible says clearly: children are not to be punished for the guilt of their parents (Deuteronomy 24:16; Ezekiel 18:20).

The child dies VERSES 15–23

15 Then Nathan went home.
The LORD struck the child that Uriah's wife had given birth to for David.
The child became very sick.
16 David begged God to let the child live.
He fasted and did not eat.
He went into his room and lay on the ground all night.
17 The leaders of his household stood around him.
They wanted to help him up from the ground.
But he refused.
He would not eat any food with them.
18 On the seventh day the child died.
David's servants were afraid to tell him that the child was dead.
They said,
"While the child was still alive, we talked to him.
But he would not listen to us.
How can we tell him that the child is dead?
He might do something to hurt himself."
19 But David saw that his servants were whispering to each other.
Then he understood that the child was dead.
He asked his servants,
"Is the child dead?"
They answered, "Yes, he is dead."
20 Then David got up from the ground.
He washed, put oil on his skin, and changed his clothes.
He went into the house of the LORD and worshiped.
Then he went home.
He asked for food.
They served him a meal, and he ate.
21 His servants asked him,
"Why are you acting like this?
While the child was alive, you fasted and wept for him.
But now that the child is dead, you get up and eat."
22 David answered,
"While the child was still alive, I fasted and wept.
I thought,
'Who knows? Maybe the LORD will be gracious to me and let the child live.'
23 But now he is dead.
Why should I fast?
Can I bring him back again?
I will go to him,
but he will not come back to me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David fights in prayer for the life of his child. For seven days he lies on the ground, fasts, and prays. He hopes that God

may still be gracious.

When the child dies, David surprises everyone. He gets up, washes, and worships God. He accepts God's decision, even though it breaks his heart.

His sentence "I will go to him, but he will not come back to me" has comforted many grieving parents. David thinks of meeting his child again in death.

The story also shows: we may wrestle with God and ask him for something as long as there is hope. And afterward we may go on living.

Solomon is born VERSES 24–25

24 David comforted Bathsheba, his wife.
He went to her and slept with her.
She gave birth to a son, and David named him Solomon.
The LORD loved the boy.
25 He sent a message through Nathan the prophet.
Nathan named the boy Jedidiah, for the LORD's sake.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For the first time Bathsheba is called "his wife," no longer "Uriah's wife." And for the first time we are told that David comforts her. She too has lost a child.

The name Solomon is related to the word "shalom," peace.

And through Nathan God gives the child a second name: "Jedidiah" means "loved by the LORD." That is a sign of reconciliation. God has given a new beginning. From this difficult marriage comes the next king of Israel.

The conquest of Rabbah VERSES 26–31

26 Meanwhile Joab fought against Rabbah, the city of the people of Ammon.
He captured the royal part of the city.
27 Joab sent messengers to David.
He told them to say,
"I have fought against Rabbah.
I have taken the city of waters.
28 Now gather the rest of the army.
Surround the city and capture it.
Otherwise I will capture the city myself,
and it will be named after me."
29 So David gathered the whole army and went to Rabbah.
He fought against the city and captured it.
30 He took the crown off the head of their king.
It weighed a talent of gold (about 75 pounds),
and it had precious stones in it.
They put it on David's head.
David took a great amount of plunder out of the city.
31 He brought out the people who lived there.
He made them work with saws, iron picks, and iron axes.
He made them work at the brick kilns.
He did the same to all the cities of the people of Ammon.
Then David and his whole army went back to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rabbah is today's Amman, the capital of Jordan. The "city of waters" was probably the part of the city with the water supply. After that, the city could not hold out much longer.

Joab leaves the glory of the victory to David. He does not want the city to be named after him.

The Bible says "a talent of gold." A talent was about 75 pounds. A crown that heavy could hardly be worn. Maybe it was put on only briefly at a ceremony. Some interpreters think the crown belonged to a statue of a god: the Hebrew word for "their king" (malkam) sounds like "Milcom," the god of the Ammonites.

Verse 31: the defeated Ammonites had to do forced labor. Older translations understood the verse to mean that David killed them cruelly with saws and axes. The WEB, our English source text, and many new translations understand it as forced labor.

The chapter ends with a victory. But after what happened before, this victory tastes bitter. From now on David's family will not get rid of the sword.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 13

Amnon, Tamar, and Absalom

Amnon's evil plan VERSES 1–7

1 Some time later, this happened:
David's son Absalom had a beautiful sister named Tamar.
Amnon, another son of David, fell in love with her.
2 Amnon wanted his sister Tamar so much that he became sick.
She was a virgin.
Amnon thought there was no way he could do anything to her.
3 But Amnon had a friend named Jonadab.
Jonadab was the son of Shimeah, David's brother.
Jonadab was a very clever and sly man.
4 He asked Amnon,
"You are the king's son.
Why do you look so sad day after day?
Won't you tell me?"
Amnon answered,
"I love Tamar, the sister of my brother Absalom."
5 Jonadab said to him,
"Lie down on your bed and pretend to be sick.
Your father will come to see you.
Then tell him,
'Please let my sister Tamar come and give me something to eat.
Let her make the food here, where I can watch her.
Then I can eat it from her hand.'"
6 So Amnon lay down and pretended to be sick.
The king came to see him.
Amnon said to the king,
"Please let my sister Tamar come here.

Let her make a couple of cakes while I watch.
Then I can eat from her hand."

7 So David sent a message to Tamar at the palace:
"Please go to your brother Amnon's house and make some food for him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the trouble begins in David's family that Nathan had announced (2 Samuel 12:10–11).

Amnon is David's oldest son. Tamar is his half-sister, the sister of Absalom. They have the same father but different mothers.

Amnon calls it "love." But what he feels is not love. It is lust. Real love wants what is good for the other person. Amnon only wants to have.

Jonadab, a cousin, helps him with a sly plan. And David himself, without suspecting anything, sends his daughter into the trap.

Amnon rapes Tamar VERSES 8–14

8 So Tamar went to the house of her brother Amnon.
He was lying in bed.
She took some dough and kneaded it.
She made cakes while he watched,
and she baked them.

9 Then she took the pan and served him the cakes.
But he refused to eat.
Amnon said,
"Send everyone out of here."
So everyone left.

10 Then Amnon said to Tamar,
"Bring the food into my bedroom.
I want to eat from your hand."
Tamar took the cakes she had made.
She brought them into the bedroom to her brother Amnon.

11 She held them out to him to eat.
But he grabbed her and said,
"Come, sleep with me, my sister!"

12 She answered him,
"No, my brother, do not force me!
Such a thing must not be done in Israel.
Don't do this shameful thing!

13 Where could I go with my shame?
And you would be seen as one of the worst fools in Israel.
Please speak to the king.
He will not keep me from you."

14 But Amnon would not listen to her.
He was stronger than she was.
He forced her and raped her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a terrible crime is told: Amnon rapes his sister. The Bible describes it clearly and does not make it look better.

Tamar defends herself with all the words she has. She says clearly: No. She calls it force and a shameful thing. She thinks about her future and even about his. She looks for a way out. She is wise and brave. But he does not listen. He uses his strength.

Here the Bible clearly takes the side of the victim. Tamar is not to blame in any way.

"He will not keep me from you": maybe Tamar hopes to gain time. Later the law forbade marriage between half-brother and half-sister (Leviticus 18:9).

If you yourself have experienced violence: it is not your fault. You may look for help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Tamar is thrown out VERSES 15–20

15 Then Amnon hated her very much.
He hated her even more than he had loved her before.
Amnon said to her,
"Get up! Go away!"

16 She said to him,
"No! Sending me away now is an even greater wrong than what you have already done to me!"
But he would not listen to her.

17 He called the young servant who worked for him.
He said,
"Throw this woman out!
And lock the door behind her!"

18 Tamar was wearing a long robe with many colors.
The king's daughters who were virgins wore robes like that.
The servant put her out and locked the door behind her.

19 Tamar put ashes on her head.
She tore the colorful robe she was wearing.
She put her hand on her head.
She went away, crying out loud as she went.

20 Her brother Absalom said to her,
"Has your brother Amnon been with you?
Now be quiet, my sister.
He is your brother.
Don't take it so hard."
So Tamar stayed in her brother Absalom's house, lonely and abandoned.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the deed, Amnon's "love" turns into hatred. That shows that it was never love.

He throws her out like garbage. He does not even call her by her name, but "this woman."

Tamar shows signs of deep grief: ashes on her head, the torn robe. She cries out loud. She is not silent. She makes the wrong known in public.

Absalom says to her: "Be quiet." Maybe he means well and wants to protect her. But for Tamar it means: her pain is to be hidden. Sadly, victims of violence still often experience that people demand their silence.

"Lonely and abandoned": Tamar no longer has a future. She will never marry. Her life is destroyed. After this, the Bible says no more about her. But it has kept her story, so that it will not be forgotten.

David is silent, Absalom hates VERSES 21–22

21 King David heard about all these things.
He was very angry.

22 Absalom did not say a word to Amnon, good or bad.
But Absalom hated Amnon,
because Amnon had raped his sister Tamar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David becomes angry. But he does nothing. He does not punish Amnon. An old manuscript from the Dead Sea and the old Greek translation also say why: "He did not want to hurt Amnon, for he loved him, because he was his firstborn."

Maybe David also feels guilty himself, after what he did with Bathsheba. How can he punish someone else?

Because the father is silent, Absalom takes justice into his own hands. He is silent too, but hatred grows inside him. When a wrong is not justly punished, it often leads to new violence.

Absalom's revenge VERSES 23–29

23 Two full years later,
Absalom's sheep were being sheared at Baal Hazor,
near Ephraim.
Absalom invited all the king's sons to the feast.
24 Absalom came to the king and said,
"I am having my sheep sheared.
Please come with me, my king, and bring your
servants."
25 The king said to Absalom,
"No, my son, we should not all go.
We would be too much of a burden to you."
Absalom kept asking him.
But the king did not want to go.
He gave Absalom his blessing instead.
26 Then Absalom said,
"If you will not come, then please let my brother
Amnon come with us."
The king asked him,
"Why should he go with you?"
27 But Absalom kept asking.
So the king let Amnon and all the king's sons go with
him.
28 Absalom gave orders to his servants.
He said,
"Listen!
Wait until Amnon is happy and has drunk a lot of
wine.
Then I will tell you, 'Strike Amnon!'
Then kill him.
Don't be afraid.
I am the one who is giving you this order.
Be strong and brave!"
29 So Absalom's servants did to Amnon what Absalom had
ordered.
Then all the king's sons jumped up.
Each one got on his mule, and they fled.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Absalom waits two years. He plans his revenge carefully. At the sheep-shearing feast, when everyone is celebrating and drinking wine, he has Amnon killed.

David suspects something: "Why should he go with you?" But he allows it anyway.

Amnon committed a terrible crime. But Absalom's revenge is also a crime: murder. The Bible shows how violence keeps producing new violence.

Now Nathan's word comes true: "The sword will never leave your family." David's son is murdered by David's son.

False news and great grief VERSES 30–39

30 They were still on the way home
when a report came to David:
"Absalom has killed all the king's sons!
Not one of them is left!"
31 Then the king got up and tore his clothes.
He lay down on the ground.
All his servants stood near him with their clothes
torn.
32 But Jonadab, the son of David's brother Shimeah, said,
"My lord, don't think that they have killed all the
young men, the king's sons.
Only Amnon is dead.
Absalom has planned this
since the day Amnon raped his sister Tamar.
33 So my lord the king, don't take it to heart.
Don't think that all the king's sons are dead.
Only Amnon is dead."
34 Meanwhile Absalom ran away.
The young man on watch looked up.
He saw many people coming down the road on the
hillside behind him.
35 Jonadab said to the king,
"Look, the king's sons are coming!
It is just as I said."
36 He had just finished speaking
when the king's sons came in.
They cried out loud and wept.
The king and all his servants also wept very bitterly.
37 But Absalom ran away.
He went to Talmai, the son of Ammihur, the king of
Geshur.
And David mourned for his son every day.
38 Absalom went to Geshur and stayed there for 3 years.
39 King David longed to go out to Absalom.
He had been comforted about Amnon, because
Amnon was dead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jonadab, who had given Amnon the evil plan, knows what is going on now too. He apparently knew for a long time that Absalom would take revenge. He did nothing to stop it.

Absalom flees to his grandfather Talmai, the king of Geshur (2 Samuel 3:3). Geshur was northeast of the Sea of Galilee.

David mourns for a long time. For whom? For Amnon, who is dead? For Absalom, who is gone? Probably for both.

Verse 39 is not completely clear in Hebrew. It can also mean that David's anger against Absalom faded. David misses his son in spite of everything.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 14

Absalom comes back

The wise woman from Tekoa VERSES 1–11

1 Joab the son of Zeruiah noticed that the king's heart
longed for Absalom.
2 So Joab sent to Tekoa and brought a wise woman from
there.
He said to her,
"Please pretend to be in mourning.
Put on mourning clothes, and don't anoint yourself
with oil.
Be like a woman who has mourned a long time for
someone who died.
3 Go in to the king and speak to him like this."
And Joab put the words in her mouth.
4 When the woman from Tekoa spoke to the king,
she fell on her face to the ground, showed respect, and
said,
"Help, O king!"
5 The king said to her,
"What is wrong?"
She answered,
"I am truly a widow, and my husband is dead.
6 Your servant had two sons.
The two of them fought with each other in the field,
and there was no one to separate them.
And the one struck the other and killed him.
7 Now the whole family has risen up against your
servant.
They say,
'Hand over the one who struck his brother,
so that we may kill him for the life of his brother
whom he killed.
That way we will destroy the heir too.'
So they would put out my last glowing coal that is left,
and they would leave my husband neither a name nor
anyone left on the earth."
8 The king said to the woman,
"Go to your house.
I will give an order about you."
9 The woman from Tekoa said to the king,
"My lord, O king, may the guilt be on me and on my
father's house.
May the king and his throne be free of guilt."
10 The king said,
"Whoever says anything to you, bring him to me.
Then he will not bother you anymore."
11 Then she said,
"Please let the king remember the LORD your God,
so that the avenger of blood does not destroy anymore,
and so that they do not destroy my son."
He said,
"As the LORD lives,
not one hair of your son shall fall to the ground."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joab notices that David misses Absalom. He wants to end the conflict, maybe also because Absalom is the likely heir to the throne.

He uses a trick, much like Nathan in Chapter 12. A wise woman tells the king a made-up story. David is to give a judgment that then also applies to himself.

Tekoa was a village south of Bethlehem. Later the prophet Amos came from there.

The woman's story is like David's situation: one son has killed his brother. According to the law of blood revenge, he would have to die. But then the mother would have no son left.

"My last glowing coal" is a beautiful picture: her last son is like the last glowing piece of coal in the fire. If it goes out, everything is dark.

David promises the woman: nothing will happen to your son.

The woman reveals what she really wants VERSES 12–20

12 Then the woman said,
"Please let your servant speak a word to my lord the
king."
He said, "Speak."
13 The woman said,
"Why then have you planned such a thing against the
people of God?
For by speaking this word the king is like someone who
is guilty,
because the king does not bring home again the one he
has banished.
14 For we must all die,
and we are like water spilled on the ground,
which cannot be gathered up again.
But God does not take away life.
Instead he plans ways
so that the one who is banished does not stay an outcast
from him.
15 Now I have come to speak this word to my lord the king,
because the people have made me afraid.
Your servant said,
'I will now speak to the king.
Maybe the king will do what his servant asks.'
16 For the king will listen
and rescue his servant from the hand of the man
who wants to destroy me and my son together from
the inheritance of God.
17 Then your servant said,
'Please let the word of my lord the king bring me rest.
For my lord the king is like an angel of God
in telling good from bad.
May the LORD your God be with you.'"
18 Then the king answered the woman,
"Please don't hide from me anything that I ask you."
The woman said,
"Let my lord the king speak."
19 The king said,
"Is the hand of Joab with you in all this?"
The woman answered,
"As you live, my lord the king,
no one can turn to the right or to the left from
anything my lord the king has said.
Yes, your servant Joab told me to do it,
and he put all these words in your servant's mouth.
20 Your servant Joab has done this to change the way the
matter looks.
But my lord is wise, with the wisdom of an angel of
God,

so that he knows everything that happens on the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the woman shows what it is really about: king, you have shown mercy to my son. Then why do you not bring back your own son?

Verse 14 is an especially beautiful sentence: God "plans ways so that the one who is banished does not stay an outcast from him." God does not want people to be lost forever. He looks for ways to bring them back. Christians see in this a pointer to the reconciliation that God has made in Jesus.

David sees through the trick: is Joab behind this? The woman admits it.

She flatters the king: you are as wise as an angel of God. That is polite, but also a little ironic, because for a long time David did not notice the trick.

Absalom may come back, but not to the king VERSES 21–24

21 The king said to Joab,
"Look, I have granted this.
So go and bring back the young man Absalom."
22 Joab fell on his face to the ground.
He showed respect and blessed the king.
Joab said,
"Today your servant knows that I have found favor in your sight,
my lord, O king,
because the king has done what his servant asked."
23 So Joab got up, went to Geshur,
and brought Absalom to Jerusalem.
24 The king said,
"Let him go back to his own house,
but he must not see my face."
So Absalom went back to his own house
and did not see the king's face.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David allows Absalom to come back. But he does not want to see him. That is only half a reconciliation.

Absalom is back in Jerusalem, but he is still shut out. He has received no punishment, but no real forgiveness either. That is dangerous. The conflict remains unsolved.

Handsome Absalom VERSES 25–27

25 In all Israel there was no man praised as much for his good looks as Absalom.
From the sole of his foot to the top of his head there was no flaw in him.
26 When he had the hair of his head cut,
he weighed it.
He cut it at the end of every year,
because it became too heavy for him.
That is why he cut it.
His hair weighed 200 shekels (about 5 pounds) by the king's weight.
27 Three sons were born to Absalom, and one daughter, whose name was Tamar.
She was a woman with a beautiful face.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Absalom is handsome, as Saul was (1 Samuel 9:2). And as with Saul, the beauty is on the outside. What is in his heart will soon show.

His thick, long hair is his pride. Later it will be his downfall (2 Samuel 18:9).

The Bible says "200 shekels." A shekel is about 0.4 ounces. That is a lot of hair. The number is probably meant to show how unusual he was.

Absalom names his daughter Tamar, after his sister. That is a loving sign of remembering her.

In 2 Samuel 18:18 Absalom says that he has no son. Maybe his sons died young.

Absalom sets Joab's field on fire VERSES 28–33

28 Absalom lived in Jerusalem for two full years
and did not see the king's face.
29 Then Absalom sent for Joab, to send him to the king.
But Joab would not come to him.
He sent for him a second time, but he would not come.
30 So he said to his servants,
"Look, Joab's field is next to mine,
and he has barley there.
Go and set it on fire."
So Absalom's servants set the field on fire.
31 Then Joab got up, came to Absalom at his house, and said to him,
"Why have your servants set my field on fire?"
32 Absalom answered Joab,
"Look, I sent word to you and said,
'Come here, so that I may send you to the king to say,
"Why have I come back from Geshur?
It would be better for me to be there still.
So now let me see the king's face.
And if there is guilt in me, let him kill me."'"
33 So Joab went to the king and told him.
And the king called for Absalom.
He came to the king and bowed down before the king with his face to the ground.
And the king kissed Absalom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For two years Absalom waits. Then he loses his patience. Because Joab does not come, he sets his field on fire. That shows Absalom's character: he gets his way by force.

Absalom says: if I am guilty, let him kill me. He shows no regret for the murder of Amnon. He only demands his rights.

In the end the king kisses his son. It looks like reconciliation. But there is no conversation, no clearing up, no word about the guilt. And in his heart Absalom already has other plans.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 15

Absalom's rebellion and David's escape

Absalom steals the hearts VERSES 1–6

1 After this, Absalom got a chariot and horses for himself,
and 50 men to run in front of him.
2 Absalom got up early
and stood beside the road to the gate.
When anyone had a legal case and was coming to the king for a judgment,
Absalom called him over and said,
"What city are you from?"
He said,
"Your servant is from one of the tribes of Israel."
3 Absalom said to him,
"Look, your case is good and right.
But there is no one appointed by the king to hear you."
4 And Absalom also said,
"Oh, if only I were made judge in the land!
Then everyone who has a dispute or a legal case could come to me,
and I would give him justice!"
5 And when anyone came near to bow down to him,
he stretched out his hand, took hold of him, and kissed him.
6 Absalom did this to all the Israelites who came to the king for a judgment.
So Absalom stole the hearts of the men of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Absalom is preparing to overthrow the king. With a chariot, horses, and a bodyguard, he shows himself like a king.

He stands at the city gate, where people came to get justice. He tells everyone: you are right! But the king does not listen to you. If I were king, everything would be better.

He promises everyone everything. He is friendly, kisses people, and acts as if he were one of them. That is still the method of people who lead others astray today: they stir up discontent, flatter, and make big promises.

"He stole the hearts": he does not win people honestly, but by trickery.

Maybe Absalom was also right with his criticism. During this time David seems to have cared little about justice in the land. David had not done justice in the case of Amnon and Tamar either.

The conspiracy in Hebron VERSES 7–12

7 At the end of 40 years, Absalom said to the king,
"Please let me go to Hebron
and keep my vow that I made to the LORD.
8 For your servant made a vow while I was living at Geshur in Syria.
I said,
'If the LORD really brings me back to Jerusalem,
then I will serve the LORD.'"
9 The king said to him,
"Go in peace."
So he got up and went to Hebron.
10 But Absalom sent spies throughout all the tribes of Israel and said,
"As soon as you hear the sound of the trumpet,
then say, 'Absalom is king in Hebron!'"
11 With Absalom went 200 men from Jerusalem.
They had been invited, and they went along innocently.
They did not know anything.
12 While Absalom was offering the sacrifices,
he sent for Ahithophel the Gilonite, David's adviser, from his city Giloh.
The conspiracy became strong,
for the people with Absalom kept growing in number.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"At the end of 40 years": that is what the Hebrew text and the WEB, our English source text, say. But that does not fit into David's lifetime. Some old translations have "after four years." That fits better.

Absalom lies to his father. He uses a devout vow as an excuse. David says "Go in peace," without suspecting what his son is planning. It is the last word David says to Absalom.

Absalom chooses Hebron. That is where David himself had first become king. Absalom wants to repeat David's story, against David.

The 200 men who go along without knowing anything are like hostages. Everyone is supposed to think that they belong to Absalom.

Ahithophel was David's wisest adviser. That he goes over to Absalom is a heavy blow. Maybe he had a personal reason: Ahithophel was probably Bathsheba's grandfather (compare 2 Samuel 11:3 and 23:34).

David flees from Jerusalem VERSES 13–18

13 A messenger came to David and said,
"The hearts of the men of Israel are with Absalom."
14 Then David said to all his servants who were with him in Jerusalem,
"Get up! Let's flee!
Otherwise none of us will escape from Absalom.
Hurry and leave,
so that he does not catch up with us quickly, bring disaster on us,
and strike the city with the edge of the sword."
15 The king's servants said to the king,
"Look, your servants are ready to do whatever my lord the king chooses."
16 The king went out, and his whole household after him.
The king left 10 women behind, who were concubines, to take care of the house.
17 The king went out, and all the people after him.
And they stopped at Beth Merhak.
18 All his servants passed by beside him,
and all the Cherethites and all the Pelethites
and all the Gittites, 600 men who had followed him from Gath,
passed by in front of the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David flees at once. He does not want Jerusalem to be destroyed in a battle. He wants no bloodshed in the city.

The great king who conquered Jerusalem now has to flee from his own son.

He leaves 10 concubines behind to take care of the palace. That will have terrible consequences (2 Samuel 16:21–22).

"Beth Merhak" means "the distant house." It probably means the last house at the edge of the city.

David's most faithful people are his foreign soldiers: Cherethites, Pelethites, and men from Gath.

Ittai's faithfulness VERSES 19–23

19 Then the king said to Ittai the Gittite,
"Why do you also go with us?
Go back and stay with the king.
For you are a foreigner and also an exile.
Go back to your own place.
20 You came only yesterday.
Should I make you wander up and down with us today,
since I go wherever I can?
Go back, and take your brothers back with you.
May mercy and faithfulness be with you."
21 Ittai answered the king and said,
"As the LORD lives, and as my lord the king lives,
wherever my lord the king is, whether for death or for life,
your servant will be there too."
22 David said to Ittai,
"Go and cross over."
So Ittai the Gittite crossed over,
with all his men and all the little children who were with him.
23 The whole country wept with a loud voice
as all the people crossed over.
The king himself also crossed over the brook Kidron,
and all the people crossed over toward the road to the wilderness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ittai is a Philistine from Gath, the city of Goliath. He has been with David only a short time. David says: you do not have to go into misfortune with me. Stay with the new king.

But Ittai answers with an oath of faithfulness that reminds us of Ruth: "Where you go, I will go" (Ruth 1:16–17). A foreigner is more faithful than David's own son.

"Whether for death or for life": Ittai stays, no matter what comes.

The brook Kidron flows in the valley east of Jerusalem. Much later, in the night before his death, Jesus also went over the brook Kidron to the Mount of Olives (John 18:1). He too was betrayed by someone close to him.

The ark stays in Jerusalem VERSES 24–29

24 Zadok also came, and all the Levites with him.
They were carrying the ark of the covenant of God.
They set down the ark of God,
and Abiathar went up until all the people had finished leaving the city.
25 The king said to Zadok,
"Carry the ark of God back into the city.
If I find favor in the LORD's eyes,
he will bring me back
and let me see both it and his dwelling place again.
26 But if he says, 'I have no delight in you,'
then here I am.
Let him do to me as seems good to him."
27 The king also said to Zadok the priest,
"Aren't you a seer?
Go back into the city in peace,
and your two sons with you,
your son Ahimaaz and Jonathan the son of Abiathar.
28 Look, I will wait at the fords of the wilderness
until word comes from you to tell me what is happening."
29 So Zadok and Abiathar carried the ark of God back to Jerusalem,
and they stayed there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The priests want to take the ark along, as a sign that God is on David's side. But David refuses. He has learned from history: the ark is not a good-luck charm (1 Samuel 4).

David puts his fate completely into God's hands: "Let him do to me as seems good to him." That is real trust. David does not want to fight for his throne by force. He waits for God.

At the same time David is wise. The priests and their sons stay in Jerusalem and are to send him news.

Verse 27: A seer is a prophet.

On the Mount of Olives VERSES 30–37

30 David went up the Mount of Olives
and wept as he went up.
He had his head covered and went barefoot.
And all the people who were with him each covered his head,
and they went up, weeping as they went.
31 Someone told David,
"Ahithophel is among the conspirators with Absalom."
David said,
"LORD, please turn the advice of Ahithophel into foolishness."
32 When David came to the top, where God was worshiped,
Hushai the Archite came to meet him,
with his robe torn and earth on his head.
33 David said to him,
"If you go on with me, you will be a burden to me.
34 But if you go back to the city and tell Absalom,
'I will be your servant, O king.
As I have been your father's servant in the past, so I will now be your servant,'
then you can defeat the advice of Ahithophel for me.
35 Don't you have Zadok and Abiathar the priests there with you?
So whatever you hear from the king's house,
tell it to Zadok and Abiathar the priests.
36 Look, they have their two sons there with them,
Ahimaaz, Zadok's son, and Jonathan, Abiathar's son.
Send me everything you hear through them."
37 So Hushai, David's friend, came into the city.
And Absalom came into Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David goes up the Mount of Olives weeping, barefoot, and with his head covered. These are signs of deep grief and humiliation. The king is broken.

According to its heading, Psalm 3 is a prayer of David when he fled from Absalom: "LORD, how many enemies I have now! ... But you, LORD, are a shield all around me."

David prays a short prayer: "LORD, please turn the advice of Ahithophel into foolishness." And right after that, Hushai comes. He is the answer to David's prayer.

Hushai is called "David's friend." That was probably a title of honor for a close adviser of the king. He is to pretend to go over to Absalom and to spoil Ahithophel's plans.

The last verse shows the tension: Hushai comes into the city, and at the same time Absalom comes. The game begins.

2 SAMUEL

Chapter 16

Ziba, Shimei, and Absalom in Jerusalem

Ziba brings gifts VERSES 1–4

1 David had gone a little way past the top of the hill.
There Ziba, the servant of Mephibosheth, came to meet him.
He had two donkeys with saddles on them.
They carried 200 loaves of bread, 100 bunches of raisins,
100 summer fruits, and a container of wine.
2 The king asked Ziba,
"What are these things for?"
Ziba answered,
"The donkeys are for the king's family to ride on.
The bread and the summer fruit are for the young men to eat.
And the wine is for anyone who gets weak in the wilderness.
They can drink it."
3 The king asked,
"Where is your master's grandson?"
Ziba answered the king,
"He is staying in Jerusalem.
He said,
'Today the people of Israel will give me back my father's kingdom.'"
Here "father" means his grandfather Saul.
4 Then the king said to Ziba,
"Everything that belonged to Mephibosheth is now yours."
Ziba said,
"I bow down before you.
May you always be kind to me, my lord the king."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ziba comes with generous gifts. In his distress that does David good.

But then Ziba slanders his master Mephibosheth: he says Mephibosheth stayed in Jerusalem because he wants to become king himself. That is very unlikely. How could a lame man who lives by David's kindness become king?

David believes Ziba at once, without checking. In his distress and exhaustion he judges too quickly. He gives Ziba all of Mephibosheth's property.

In Chapter 19 we will hear what Mephibosheth himself says about it. In the end it remains open who is telling the truth here.

"Summer fruits" were probably figs or other fruits from the summer harvest.

Shimei curses David VERSES 5–14

5 King David came to Bahurim.
There a man from the family of Saul came out.
His name was Shimei, the son of Gera.
As he came out, he kept cursing.
6 He threw stones at David and at all of King David's servants.
And yet all the people and all the strong soldiers were on David's right and on his left.
7 Shimei cursed and shouted,
"Get out! Get out, you man of blood, you worthless man!
8 The LORD is paying you back for all the blood of Saul's family.
You became king in Saul's place!
Now the LORD has given the kingdom to your son Absalom!
Look, your own evil has caught you,
because you are a man of blood!"
9 Then Abishai, the son of Zeruiah, said to the king,
"Why should this dead dog curse my lord the king?
Please let me go over there and cut off his head."
10 But the king said,
"You sons of Zeruiah, this is not your business!
He is cursing because the LORD told him, 'Curse David.'
So who can ask him, 'Why are you doing this?'"
11 David said to Abishai and to all his servants,
"My own son, my own flesh and blood, is trying to kill me.
So of course this man from Benjamin wants to do the same!
Leave him alone and let him curse.
The LORD told him to do it.
12 Maybe the LORD will see the wrong that is being done to me.
Maybe the LORD will give me good things in return for the curses I hear today."
13 So David and his men went on down the road.
Shimei walked along the hillside across from him.
As he went, he kept cursing, throwing stones at him, and throwing dust.
14 The king and all the people with him were very tired when they arrived.
There David rested and got new strength.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shimei is a relative of Saul. He hates David. He believes that David bought the throne with blood, and that now the just punishment is falling on him.

That is not really true. David spared Saul and his family. But on one point Shimei is not completely wrong: David has shed blood, the blood of Uriah.

Abishai wants to kill Shimei. But David says: no. Maybe God has sent him. I will accept it.

That is great humility. David does not defend himself against the insult. He probably remembers his own guilt.

And he hopes: maybe God will see my suffering and turn it to good.

Later Jesus taught: "Bless those who curse you!" (Luke 6:28). David does not bless Shimei, but he does not take revenge either.

Hushai with Absalom VERSES 15–19

15 Meanwhile Absalom and all the men of Israel came to Jerusalem.
Ahithophel was with him.
16 Hushai the Archite, David's friend, came to Absalom.
Hushai said to Absalom,
"Long live the king! Long live the king!"
17 Absalom asked Hushai,
"Is this how loyal you are to your friend?
Why didn't you go with your friend David?"
18 Hushai answered Absalom,
"No. Whoever the LORD and this people and all the men of Israel have chosen,
I belong to him.
I will stay with him.
19 And besides, whom should I serve?
Shouldn't I serve his son?
I served your father.
In the same way I will now serve you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hushai plays his role as a double agent. Absalom is suspicious: why aren't you loyal to my father?

Hushai's answer is wise and has a double meaning. "Long live the king!" he says, but he does not say which king he means. "Whoever the LORD and this people and all the men of Israel have chosen": in truth that is David.

Absalom is vain enough to believe it.

Ahithophel's first advice VERSES 20–23

20 Then Absalom said to Ahithophel,
"Give us your advice. What should we do?"
21 Ahithophel said to Absalom,
"Your father left some of his concubines here to take care of the palace.
Go and sleep with them.
Then all Israel will hear that your father hates you now.
And all your followers will become bold and strong."
22 So they set up a tent for Absalom on the roof of the palace.
And Absalom slept with his father's concubines while all Israel watched.
23 In those days, people trusted Ahithophel's advice as if someone had asked God himself in his holy place.
David had trusted all of Ahithophel's advice like this, and now Absalom did too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahithophel gives cruel but politically clever advice. If Absalom sleeps with his father's wives in public, he shows: I am now the king. And there is no way back. Reconciliation with David is impossible. So all his followers know that they can rely completely on Absalom.

For the 10 women it is a terrible wrong. They are abused in public, as a tool in the power struggle. No one asks about them.

Here Nathan's announcement comes true exactly: "I will take your wives while you watch. I will give them to another man who is close to you. He will sleep with your wives in broad daylight" (2 Samuel 12:11). And it happens on the same roof from which David had seen Bathsheba (2 Samuel 11:2).

Ahithophel's advice was thought to be as sure as a word from God. That is why he was so dangerous for David.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 17

Ahithophel's advice against Hushai's advice

Ahithophel's second advice VERSES 1–4

1 Ahithophel also said to Absalom,
"Let me now choose 12,000 men.
Then I will get up and chase after David tonight.
2 I will come upon him while he is tired and worn out, and I will make him afraid.
Then all the people who are with him will flee.
And I will strike down only the king.
3 And I will bring all the people back to you.
The man you are looking for is worth as much as if all of them came back.
Then all the people will be at peace."
4 The plan pleased Absalom and all the elders of Israel very much.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahithophel's plan is very good: attack at once, while David is worn out. Kill only David and spare everyone else. Then the war is over with one single blow.

If Absalom had followed this plan, David would probably have died.

Hushai's different advice VERSES 5–14

5 Then Absalom said,
"Now call Hushai the Archite too.
Let's also hear what he says."
6 When Hushai came to Absalom, Absalom said to him,
"Ahithophel has spoken like this.
Shall we do what he says?
If not, you speak."
7 Hushai said to Absalom,
"The advice that Ahithophel has given this time is not good."
8 Hushai also said,
"You know your father and his men.
They are mighty men, and they are furious,
like a bear in the field whose cubs have been stolen.
Your father is a man of war.
He will not spend the night with the people.

9 Look, by now he is hidden in some pit or in some other place.
And if some of your men fall right at the beginning,
then whoever hears it will say,
'There is a slaughter among the people who follow Absalom!'
10 Then even the bravest man, whose heart is like the heart of a lion, will lose all his courage.
For all Israel knows that your father is a mighty man,
and that the men who are with him are brave.
11 But my advice is this:
Let all Israel be gathered to you, from Dan to Beersheba,
as many as the sand by the sea.
And you yourself should go into battle.
12 Then we will come upon him in some place where he can be found.
We will fall on him as the dew falls on the ground.
And not one will be left of him and of all the men who are with him.
13 And if he goes into a city,
then all Israel will bring ropes to that city,
and we will drag it down into the river,
until not even one small stone is found there."
14 Absalom and all the men of Israel said,
"The advice of Hushai the Archite is better than the advice of Ahithophel."
For the LORD had decided
to defeat the good advice of Ahithophel,
so that the LORD might bring disaster on Absalom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hushai is a master of words. He makes Absalom afraid of David: your father is as dangerous as a furious mother bear. He will hide and surprise you.

Then he flatters Absalom's vanity: you yourself should lead a huge army. Absalom likes that.

He exaggerates with big pictures: as many as the sand by the sea, like dew on the ground, dragging a city into the river with ropes. The words sound impressive, but they are not realistic.

Above all, Hushai wins the most important thing for David: time. By the time all Israel is gathered, David can get to safety.

Verse 14 is the key: God himself has answered David's prayer: "LORD, please turn the advice of Ahithophel into foolishness" (2 Samuel 15:31). Here God does not work through miracles, but through human decisions.

The messengers in the well VERSES 15–22

15 Then Hushai said to Zadok and to Abiathar the priests,
"This is what Ahithophel advised Absalom and the elders of Israel,
and this is what I have advised.
16 So now send quickly and tell David,
'Don't spend the night at the fords of the wilderness.
Be sure to cross over,
so that the king and all the people who are with him are not swallowed up.'"
17 Jonathan and Ahimaaz were staying at En Rogel.
A servant girl used to go and report to them,
and they went and told King David.
For they could not risk being seen coming into the city.
18 But a boy saw them and told Absalom.
Then the two of them went away quickly
and came to the house of a man in Bahurim
who had a well in his courtyard.
And they went down into it.
19 The woman took a cover and spread it over the opening of the well,
and she spread crushed grain on it.
So no one knew anything.
20 Absalom's servants came to the woman at the house and said,
"Where are Ahimaaz and Jonathan?"
The woman said to them,
"They have gone over the brook of water."
When they had searched and could not find them,
they went back to Jerusalem.
21 After they had left,
the two men came up out of the well,
went, and told King David.
They said to David,
"Get up and cross the water quickly.
For this is what Ahithophel has advised against you."
22 Then David got up, and all the people who were with him,
and they crossed over the Jordan.
By the light of morning, every one of them had crossed the Jordan.
Not one was missing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hushai does not know for sure whether Absalom might still follow Ahithophel's advice after all. That is why David is to flee at once.

Now an exciting chain of messengers begins: Hushai tells the priests, the priests tell a servant girl, the servant girl tells the priests' sons, the sons tell David.

En Rogel was a spring in the valley south of Jerusalem.

Once again a brave woman saves David's people. She hides the messengers in the well, as Rahab had hidden the spies (Joshua 2). She sends the men chasing them in the wrong direction.

By morning all of David's people are safely across the Jordan. No one is missing.

The end of Ahithophel VERSE 23

23 When Ahithophel saw that his advice was not followed,
he saddled his donkey.
He got up and went home to his city.
He put his house in order and hanged himself.
So he died and was buried in his father's tomb.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahithophel is wise enough to see: if Absalom does not attack at once, David will win. And then he will be punished as a traitor.

He puts his affairs in order and takes his own life. The Bible tells this plainly, without a judgment.

There is a similar story in the New Testament: Judas, who betrayed Jesus, also took his own life (Matthew 27:5).

If you yourself no longer see a way out or are thinking about taking your own life: you are not alone. Please talk to

someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

David in Mahanaim VERSES 24–29

24 Then David came to Mahanaim.
And Absalom crossed over the Jordan, he and all the men of Israel with him.
25 Absalom put Amasa over the army in place of Joab.
Amasa was the son of a man whose name was Ithra the Israelite,
who had slept with Abigail, the daughter of Nahash, the sister of Zeruiah, Joab's mother.
26 Israel and Absalom camped in the land of Gilead.
27 When David had come to Mahanaim,
Shobi the son of Nahash from Rabbah of the people of Ammon,
and Machir the son of Ammiel from Lodebar,
and Barzillai the Gileadite from Rogelim
28 brought beds, bowls, clay pots,
wheat, barley, flour, parched grain, beans, lentils,
roasted grain,
29 honey, butter, sheep, and cheese from the herd,
for David and for the people who were with him to eat.
For they said,
"The people are hungry, tired, and thirsty in the wilderness."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mahanaim lies east of the Jordan. That is where Ishbosheth had once been king (2 Samuel 2:8).

Amasa is a cousin of Joab and also a nephew of David. This Abigail is not David's wife from Chapter 25 of 1 Samuel. 1 Chronicles 2:13–17 says that she was a sister of David. Here it says "daughter of Nahash." Maybe Nahash was another name for Jesse, or the name of her mother. And in 1 Chronicles 2:17 Ithra is called "Jether the Ishmaelite."

In David's greatest need, three men come with everything that is needed. One is an Ammonite, a son of Nahash, the former enemy. One is Machir, who had once taken in Mephibosheth. And one is the rich old man Barzillai.

They do not ask who will win. They only see: these people are hungry, tired, and thirsty. That is real readiness to help.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 18

The death of Absalom

"Deal gently with Absalom!" VERSES 1–5

1 David counted the people who were with him
and put captains of thousands and captains of hundreds over them.
2 David sent the people out:
a third under the command of Joab,
a third under the command of Abishai the son of Zeruiah, Joab's brother,
and a third under the command of Ittai the Gittite.
The king said to the people,
"I will surely go out with you myself too."
3 But the people said,
"You must not go out.
For if we run away, they will not care about us.
And even if half of us die, they will not care about us.
But you are worth 10,000 of us.
So now it is better for you to be ready to help us from the city."
4 The king said to them,
"I will do what seems best to you."
The king stood beside the gate,
and all the people went out by hundreds and by thousands.
5 The king commanded Joab, Abishai, and Ittai,
"For my sake, deal gently with the young man Absalom."
And all the people heard when the king gave all the captains this command about Absalom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is an experienced army leader. He divides his army into three groups. Ittai, the faithful Philistine, also gets a group.

The people do not want David to fight with them. If he dies, everything is lost. The enemy's only goal is David.

David's last command is a command as a father, not as a king: "Deal gently with the young man Absalom." Absalom wants to kill him, but David still loves his son.

The battle in the forest VERSES 6–8

6 So the people went out into the field against Israel.
And the battle took place in the forest of Ephraim.
7 The people of Israel were defeated there by David's servants.
And there was a great slaughter there that day: 20,000 men.
8 For the battle spread out there over the whole countryside.
And the forest devoured more people that day than the sword devoured.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The forest of Ephraim lay east of the Jordan, in the land of Gilead.

The rough land, with ravines, rocks, and thick bushes, is a trap for Absalom's large army. David's experienced fighters know their way around better.

"The forest devoured more people than the sword": many died while running away, in pits, swamps, or in the undergrowth.

Absalom hangs in the oak tree VERSES 9–15

9 Absalom happened to meet David's servants.
Absalom was riding on his mule.
The mule went under the thick branches of a great oak tree.
His head got caught in the oak,

and he was left hanging between the sky and the earth.
And the mule that was under him went on.
10 A man saw it and told Joab. He said,
"Look, I saw Absalom hanging in an oak tree."
11 Joab said to the man who told him,
"Look, you saw it.
Why didn't you strike him to the ground there?
I would have given you 10 pieces of silver and a belt."
12 The man said to Joab,
"Even if I received 1,000 pieces of silver in my hand,
I still would not stretch out my hand against the king's son.
For we heard the king command you, Abishai, and Ittai,
'Be careful that no one touches the young man Absalom.'
13 Otherwise, if I had acted falsely against his life,
then you yourself would have turned against me.
And nothing is hidden from the king."
14 Then Joab said,
"I'm not going to wait like this with you."
He took three darts in his hand
and thrust them into Absalom's heart while he was still alive in the middle of the oak.
15 Then 10 young men who carried Joab's armor surrounded Absalom.
They struck him and killed him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Absalom gets caught by his head in the branches, probably by his long, thick hair that he was so proud of (2 Samuel 14:26). His mule, a sign of royal dignity, runs away. He hangs helplessly between the sky and the earth (verse 9).

The simple soldier obeys the king. He says: I would not kill him for any money in the world. The king has forbidden it.

But Joab does not obey. He knows: as long as Absalom lives, there will be no peace. He kills him, even though he cannot defend himself. Joab acts out of political calculation, not by the king's command. It is not the first time (2 Samuel 3:27).

The 10 pieces of silver are about 4 ounces of silver, and the 1,000 pieces of silver are about 25 pounds.

A heap of stones instead of a monument VERSES 16–18

16 Joab blew the trumpet,
and the people came back from chasing Israel.
For Joab held the people back.
17 They took Absalom,
threw him into a great pit in the forest,
and piled a very large heap of stones over him.
And all Israel fled, each one to his own tent.
18 During his lifetime Absalom had taken and set up for himself the pillar
that is in the king's valley.
For he said,
"I have no son to keep my name remembered."
He called the pillar by his own name.
To this day it is called Absalom's monument.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Absalom's death the war is over. Joab ends the bloodshed.

Absalom gets no royal grave. He is thrown into a pit. A heap of stones over a dead man was a sign of shame, as with Achan (Joshua 7:26).

Absalom had set up a monument for himself so that people would remember him. But his grave is not the monument, but the heap of stones in the forest.

2 Samuel 14:27 said that he had three sons. Maybe they had died young.

Today in the Kidron Valley in Jerusalem there is a tomb that people call "Absalom's Tomb." But it was built much later, around the time of Jesus.

The messengers VERSES 19–32

19 Then Ahimaaz the son of Zadok said,
"Please let me run and take the news to the king,
that the LORD has given him justice against his enemies."
20 Joab said to him,
"You must not be the one to bring news today.
You can bring news another day.
But today you must not bring news,
because the king's son is dead."
21 Then Joab said to the Cushite,
"Go, tell the king what you have seen!"
The Cushite bowed down to Joab and ran.
22 Then Ahimaaz the son of Zadok said to Joab again,
"Whatever happens, please let me also run after the Cushite."
Joab said,
"Why do you want to run, my son?
You will get no reward for the news."
23 "Whatever happens," he said, "I will run."
Joab said to him,
"Run!"
Then Ahimaaz ran by the way of the Plain
and got ahead of the Cushite.
24 David was sitting between the two gates.
The watchman went up to the roof of the gate, on the wall.
He looked up
and saw a man running alone.
25 The watchman shouted and told the king.
The king said,
"If he is alone, there is news in his mouth."
He came closer and closer.
26 Then the watchman saw another man running.
The watchman called to the gatekeeper and said,
"Look, a man is running alone!"
The king said,
"He also brings news."
27 The watchman said,
"I think the first one runs like Ahimaaz the son of Zadok."
The king said,
"He is a good man, and he comes with good news."
28 Ahimaaz called out and said to the king,
"All is well!"
He bowed down before the king with his face to the ground and said,
"Blessed is the LORD your God,
who has handed over the men who raised their hand against my lord the king!"
29 The king said,
"Is the young man Absalom all right?"

Ahimaaz answered,
"When Joab sent the king's servant, that is, me, your servant,
I saw a great commotion.
But I don't know what it was."
30 The king said,
"Step aside and stand here."
He stepped aside and stood still.
31 Then the Cushite came.
The Cushite said,
"Good news for my lord the king!
For today the LORD has given you justice against all those who rose up against you."
32 The king said to the Cushite,
"Is the young man Absalom all right?"
The Cushite answered,
"May the enemies of my lord the king,
and all who rise up against you to do you harm,
be as that young man is."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joab knows: for David this is not good news. Whoever tells him that Absalom is dead brings him pain. That is why he wants to protect Ahimaaz, the young son of the priest. He sends a Cushite, a man from Africa, from the land south of Egypt, probably a servant.

Ahimaaz insists on running. He is faster. But when he stands before David, he does not dare to tell the truth.

David asks both messengers only one thing: "Is the young man Absalom all right?" He does not care about the victory. He thinks only of his son.

The Cushite says it carefully, but clearly: may all your enemies be as he is. Then David understands.

"My son Absalom!" VERSE 33

33 Then the king was deeply shaken.
He went up to the room over the gate and wept.
And as he went, he said,
"My son Absalom!
My son, my son Absalom!
I wish I had died instead of you,
Absalom, my son, my son!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most heartbreaking sentences in the Bible. David has won, but he has lost his son. He says it again and again: "My son, my son." He wishes he had died in his place.

Absalom wanted to kill him. But David still loves him. A father's love does not stop, even when the son betrays him.

Maybe David also feels his own guilt: he did not punish Amnon. He never really talked things through with Absalom. And the sword that Nathan had announced has now struck his third son.

Many Christians see in David's lament a picture of God's love: God loves people, even those who rebel against him. And Christians believe that in Jesus, God really did die in people's place.

In some Bibles this verse is already Chapter 19, verse 1.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 19

David returns to Jerusalem

Joab scolds the grieving king VERSES 1–8

1 Joab was told,
"Look, the king is weeping and mourning for Absalom."
2 So that day the victory turned into mourning for all the people.
For that day the people heard,
"The king is grieving for his son."
3 That day the people sneaked into the city,
the way people sneak away who are ashamed because they ran away in battle.
4 The king covered his face,
and the king cried with a loud voice,
"My son Absalom, Absalom, my son, my son!"
5 Then Joab came into the house to the king and said,
"Today you have put to shame all your servants,
who today have saved your life
and the lives of your sons and your daughters,
the lives of your wives and the lives of your concubines.
6 For you love those who hate you,
and you hate those who love you.
For today you have made it clear that princes and servants mean nothing to you.
For today I see:
if Absalom had lived and all of us had died today,
then you would have been pleased.
7 So now get up, go out,
and speak to encourage your servants.
For I swear by the LORD:
if you don't go out, not one man will stay with you tonight.
And that would be worse for you than all the trouble that has come upon you from your youth until now."
8 Then the king got up and sat in the gate.
And all the people were told,
"Look, the king is sitting in the gate."
Then all the people came before the king.
But Israel had fled, each man to his tent.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles the verse numbers in this chapter are shifted by one. Verse 1 here is verse 2 there, and so on up to verse 44.

The soldiers risked their lives for David. And now, instead of celebrating, they sneak into the city as if they had lost.

Joab harshly tells David the truth. He killed Absalom against David's order. Now he even scolds David. Joab is ruthless. But in this matter he is right: a king must also be there for those who were faithful to him.

David listens to him. He sits down in the gate, where everyone can see him. He puts his private pain aside to do his duty as king.

"Israel" here means Absalom's followers. They have fled.

Israel and Judah want David back VERSES 9–15

9 All the people were quarreling throughout all the tribes of Israel. They said,
"The king rescued us from the hand of our enemies,
and he saved us from the hand of the Philistines.
And now he has fled out of the land because of Absalom.
10 And Absalom, whom we anointed over us, has died in battle.
So why don't you say a word about bringing the king back?"
11 King David sent word to Zadok and to Abiathar the priests:
"Speak to the elders of Judah and say,
'Why are you the last to bring the king back to his house,
since what all Israel is saying has already reached the king,
that they want to bring him back to his house?
12 You are my brothers.
You are my bone and my flesh.
So why are you the last to bring back the king?'
13 And say to Amasa,
'Aren't you my bone and my flesh?
May God do this to me, and even more,
if you are not commander of the army before me from now on, in place of Joab.'"
14 So he won the hearts of all the men of Judah, as if they were one man.
They sent word to the king:
"Come back, you and all your servants."
15 So the king came back and came to the Jordan.
And Judah came to Gilgal to go and meet the king
and to bring the king over the Jordan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The northern tribes are unsure. They had followed Absalom. Now they want David back, but they hesitate.

Surprisingly, Judah, David's own tribe, hesitates the most. Hebron in Judah was the place where Absalom's rebellion had begun.

David is politically wise: he wins Judah back by reminding them that they are family. And he makes Amasa, Absalom's army commander, his own army commander. With this he shows: I want reconciliation, not revenge. And at the same time he takes away the power of Joab, who killed Absalom against his order.

But this will have consequences (2 Samuel 20:10).

Shimei asks for mercy VERSES 16–23

16 Shimei the son of Gera, the Benjamite from Bahurim, hurried and came down with the men of Judah to meet King David.
17 With him were 1,000 men from Benjamin,
and Ziba the servant of Saul's house,
and his 15 sons and his 20 servants with him.
They went through the Jordan in front of the king.
18 A ferry boat went across to bring over the king's household
and to do whatever he thought good.
Shimei the son of Gera fell down before the king
when the king had come over the Jordan.
19 He said to the king,
"Don't let my lord count me guilty.
Don't remember the wrong that your servant did
on the day my lord the king left Jerusalem.
Don't let the king take it to heart.
20 For your servant knows that I have sinned.
That is why I have come today as the first of the whole house of Joseph
to go down and meet my lord the king."
21 But Abishai the son of Zeruiah answered,
"Shouldn't Shimei be put to death for this,
because he cursed the LORD's anointed?"
22 David said,
"What do I have to do with you, you sons of Zeruiah,
that you should be against me today?
Should anyone be put to death in Israel today?
Don't I know that today I am king over Israel?"
23 The king said to Shimei,
"You will not die."
And the king swore it to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shimei, who had cursed David, now comes first and asks for forgiveness. He brings 1,000 men from Benjamin with him. That is also wise: he shows that Saul's tribe now stands with David.

"The house of Joseph" here means the northern tribes, to which Benjamin is counted.

Abishai wants to kill Shimei again. But David says: today is a day of reconciliation, not of revenge. Like Saul once after his victory at Jabesh (1 Samuel 11:13).

David forgives Shimei and swears to him that he does not have to die. But shortly before his death David will tell his son Solomon to settle accounts with Shimei (1 Kings 2:8–9).

Mephibosheth meets David VERSES 24–30

24 Mephibosheth the son of Saul also came down to meet the king.
He had not cared for his feet, he had not trimmed his beard,
and he had not washed his clothes,
from the day the king left
until the day he came home in peace.
25 When he came to Jerusalem to meet the king,
the king said to him,
"Why didn't you go with me, Mephibosheth?"
26 He answered,
"My lord, O king, my servant deceived me.
For your servant said,
'I will saddle a donkey for myself, so that I can ride on it and go with the king.'
For your servant is lame.
27 And he has slandered your servant to my lord the king.
But my lord the king is like an angel of God.
So do what is good in your eyes.
28 For my father's whole house were nothing but dead men before my lord the king.
And yet you put your servant among those who eat at your own table.

So what right do I still have to complain any more to the king?"

29 The king said to him,
"Why do you keep talking about your affairs?
I say: you and Ziba divide the land."

30 Mephibosheth said to the king,
"Yes, let him take it all,
since my lord the king has come home in peace to his own house."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mephibosheth has been mourning the whole time: he did not care for his feet, did not shave, did not wear clean clothes. That suggests that he was faithful to David and that Ziba lied (2 Samuel 16:3).

He explains: I wanted to come along, but I am lame. Ziba was supposed to saddle a donkey for me, but he deceived me and went to you alone.

David does not know whom to believe. He chooses a compromise: divide the land. That is not a just solution if Mephibosheth is telling the truth.

Mephibosheth's answer shows his heart: "Yes, let him take it all." The main thing is that you are back. He does not care about property, but about David.

Verse 24 says "the son of Saul." It means "grandson." The Hebrew word for "son" can also mean "descendant."

Old Barzillai VERSES 31–40

31 Barzillai the Gileadite came down from Rogelim
and went to the Jordan with the king, to go with him over the Jordan.

32 Barzillai was a very old man, 80 years old.
He had provided food for the king while he was staying at Mahanaim,
for he was a very great man.

33 The king said to Barzillai,
"Come over with me,
and I will provide for you with me in Jerusalem."

34 Barzillai said to the king,
"How many more days and years do I have to live,
that I should go up with the king to Jerusalem?

35 I am 80 years old today.
Can I still tell good from bad?
Can your servant still taste what I eat or what I drink?
Can I still hear the voices of singing men and singing women?
Why then should your servant be a burden to my lord the king?

36 Your servant will just go over the Jordan with the king.
Why should the king pay me back with such a reward?

37 Please let your servant turn back,
so that I may die in my own city, by the grave of my father and my mother.
But here is your servant Chimham.
Let him go over with my lord the king.
And do for him what seems good to you."

38 The king answered,
"Chimham will go over with me,
and I will do for him what seems good to you.
And whatever you ask of me, I will do for you."

39 All the people went over the Jordan,
and the king went over too.
Then the king kissed Barzillai and blessed him,
and he went back to his own place.

40 So the king went on to Gilgal,
and Chimham went on with him.
All the people of Judah had brought the king over,
and also half the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Barzillai is a faithful, generous old man. He provided for David in his time of need, without asking for anything in return.

David would like to reward him. But Barzillai humbly says no. He honestly describes what it is like to grow old: you taste less, you hear less well, you can no longer enjoy life at the royal court. He wants to die at home, near his parents.

Instead of asking for himself, he asks for Chimham, probably his son (1 Kings 2:7).

This is a beautiful, calm scene after so much violence: faithfulness is answered with faithfulness. David does not forget his friends.

Quarrel between Israel and Judah VERSES 41–43

41 Then all the men of Israel came to the king
and said to the king,
"Why have our brothers, the men of Judah, stolen you away
and brought the king and his household over the Jordan,
and all David's men with him?"

42 All the men of Judah answered the men of Israel,
"Because the king is a close relative of ours.
So why are you angry about this?
Have we eaten anything at the king's cost?
Or has he given us any gift?"

43 The men of Israel answered the men of Judah and said,
"We have 10 shares in the king,
and we also have more claim to David than you do.
So why did you despise us?
Weren't we the first to speak of bringing back our king?"
But the words of the men of Judah were harsher than the words of the men of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The war is hardly over when a new quarrel begins. The 10 northern tribes feel left out. Judah has brought the king back on its own.

"10 shares": the northern tribes are 10 tribes, Judah is one. They say: there are more of us.

Judah answers harshly and arrogantly. In the next chapter this quarrel between north and south leads to a new rebellion. And much later the kingdom will split along exactly this line (1 Kings 12).

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 20

The rebellion of Sheba

"We have no share in David!" VERSES 1–3

1 There happened to be a wicked fellow there.
His name was Sheba the son of Bichri, a Benjamite.
He blew the trumpet and said,
"We have no share in David,
and we have no inheritance in the son of Jesse.
Every man to his tents, Israel!"
2 So all the men of Israel stopped following David
and followed Sheba the son of Bichri.
But the men of Judah stayed with their king,
from the Jordan all the way to Jerusalem.
3 David came to his house in Jerusalem.
The king took the 10 women, his concubines,
whom he had left to take care of the house,
and put them in a house under guard.
He provided food for them, but he did not sleep with them anymore.
So they were shut up until the day of their death,
living like widows.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The quarrel from Chapter 19 leads at once to a new rebellion. Sheba is a Benjamite, like Saul. His cry will come up again later when the kingdom splits (1 Kings 12:16).

The 10 concubines: they were not guilty. Absalom had abused them against their will (2 Samuel 16:22). Now they are locked away for the rest of their lives and live like widows. David provides for them, but they no longer have a life of their own. Once again women have to bear the consequences of what men have done. The Bible tells it without approving of it.

Joab murders Amasa VERSES 4–13

4 Then the king said to Amasa,
"Call the men of Judah together for me within three days,
and be here yourself."
5 So Amasa went to call the men of Judah together.
But he stayed longer than the time that had been set for him.
6 Then David said to Abishai,
"Now Sheba the son of Bichri will do us more harm than Absalom did.
Take your lord's servants and chase after him,
so that he does not get himself fortified cities and escape from us."
7 So Joab's men went out after him,
with the Cherethites, the Pelethites, and all the mighty men.
They went out of Jerusalem to chase Sheba the son of Bichri.
8 When they were at the great stone that is in Gibeon,
Amasa came to meet them.
Joab was wearing his war clothes that he had put on.
Over them he had a belt with a sword in its sheath fastened at his waist.
And as he went forward, it fell out.
9 Joab said to Amasa,
"Are you well, my brother?"
Joab took Amasa by the beard with his right hand to kiss him.
10 But Amasa did not pay attention to the sword that was in Joab's hand.
So Joab struck him with it in the body,
so that his insides spilled out on the ground.
He did not strike him a second time, and he died.
Then Joab and his brother Abishai chased Sheba the son of Bichri.
11 One of Joab's young men stood beside him and said,
"Whoever is on Joab's side and whoever is for David, follow Joab!"
12 Amasa lay rolling in his blood in the middle of the road.
When the man saw that all the people stood still,
he carried Amasa off the road into the field
and threw a garment over him,
because he saw that everyone who came by him stood still.
13 When he had been taken off the road,
all the people went on after Joab to chase Sheba the son of Bichri.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amasa, the new army commander, is too slow. David sends Abishai, but Joab comes along.

Then another treacherous murder happens. Joab greets Amasa in a friendly way: "Are you well, my brother?" He takes him by the beard to kiss him, as friends did in those days. And with the other hand he stabs him.

Joab had already murdered Abner in a similar way (2 Samuel 3:27). Both times he kills a rival who could take away his place as army commander.

Here Christians remember Judas, who betrayed Jesus with a kiss (Matthew 26:49).

The soldiers stand still in horror by the dead body. Only when it is covered do they follow Joab. Joab has taken back power by violence.

The wise woman of Abel VERSES 14–22

14 Sheba went through all the tribes of Israel to Abel and Beth Maacah,
and through all the land of the Berites.
They gathered together and also followed him.
15 Joab's men came and laid siege to him in Abel of Beth Maacah.
They piled up a ramp of earth against the city,
and it stood against the outer wall.
And all the people who were with Joab battered the wall to break it down.
16 Then a wise woman called out from the city,
"Listen, listen!
Please say to Joab,
'Come here, so that I can speak with you.'"
17 He came near to her.
The woman said, "Are you Joab?"
He answered, "I am."
Then she said to him,
"Listen to the words of your servant."
He answered, "I'm listening."

18 Then she said,
"In the old days people used to say,
'They will surely ask for advice at Abel.'
And that is how they settled a matter.
19 I am one of those who are peaceful and faithful in Israel.
You are trying to destroy a city and a mother in Israel.
Why do you want to swallow up the LORD's inheritance?"
20 Joab answered,
"Far be it, far be it from me
that I should swallow up or destroy!
21 That is not how it is.
But a man from the hill country of Ephraim, Sheba the son of Bichri by name,
has raised his hand against the king, against David.
Just hand him over,
and I will leave the city."
The woman said to Joab,
"His head will be thrown to you over the wall."
22 Then the woman went to all the people with her wisdom.
They cut off the head of Sheba the son of Bichri and threw it out to Joab.
He blew the trumpet,
and they left the city and scattered, each man to his tent.
And Joab went back to the king in Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abel of Beth Maacah lay in the far north, near Dan.

Once again a wise woman saves many lives, like the woman from Tekoa (Chapter 14) and like Abigail (1 Samuel 25). The women in these books are often wiser than the men.

She asks Joab: why do you want to destroy a whole city? A "mother in Israel" is a city that is important for the area around it, like a mother for her children.

She negotiates and finds a solution: only the leader of the rebellion dies, not the whole city.

For us today the bloody ending is hard. But in a time without courts and without prisons, it was a solution that saved many innocent people.

David's officials VERSES 23–26

23 Joab was over the whole army of Israel.
Benaiah the son of Jehoiada was over the Cherethites and over the Pelethites.
24 Adoram was over the men who had to do forced labor.
Jehoshaphat the son of Ahilud was the recorder.
25 Sheva was scribe.
Zadok and Abiathar were priests.
26 And Ira the Jairite was chief minister to David.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end there is again a list of David's officials, as in 2 Samuel 8:16–18. Joab is at the top again. No one punishes him for the murder of Amasa.

Adoram is new. He is in charge of the forced labor. This reminds us of Samuel's warning: the king will take your sons for his work (1 Samuel 8:16). Under Solomon the forced labor becomes a heavy burden, and later Adoram is stoned by the people (1 Kings 12:18).

"Chief minister": in Hebrew it again says "priest," as in 2 Samuel 8:18.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 21

The Gibeonites, Rizpah, and the giants

The famine and Saul's guilt VERSES 1–6

1 In the days of David there was a famine for three years, year after year.
So David sought the face of the LORD.
The LORD said,
"It is because of Saul and because of his house, which is stained with blood,
because he put the Gibeonites to death."
2 The king called the Gibeonites and spoke to them.
The Gibeonites were not part of the people of Israel.
They were part of what was left of the Amorites.
The people of Israel had sworn an oath to them.
But Saul tried to kill them in his zeal for the people of Israel and Judah.
3 David said to the Gibeonites,
"What should I do for you?
And how should I make atonement,
so that you will bless the LORD's inheritance?"
To make atonement means: to make up for a wrong.
4 The Gibeonites said to him,
"Between us and Saul and his house it is not a matter of silver or gold.
And it is not for us to put anyone in Israel to death."
He said,
"Whatever you say, I will do for you."
5 They said to the king,
"The man who destroyed us
and who made plans against us,
so that we would be wiped out from every part of Israel,
6 let seven men of his sons be handed over to us.
Then we will hang them up to the LORD in Gibeah of Saul,
the chosen one of the LORD."
The king said,
"I will give them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapters 21 to 24 are like an appendix to the book. They tell stories from different times of David's rule, not in the order in which they happened.

The Gibeonites were a people in Canaan. In the time of Joshua they had tricked Israel into making a peace treaty with them. But Israel had sworn by the LORD to spare them (Joshua 9). An oath before God is binding.

Saul broke this oath and killed many Gibeonites. Nothing about this is written in 1 Samuel. We learn about it only here.

In those days people believed: a wrong that is not made right weighs on the whole land. That is why a famine comes.

The Gibeonites do not want money. They demand the lives of seven of Saul's descendants. In those days that was the logic of blood revenge: life for life.

Seven descendants of Saul die VERSES 7–9

7 But the king spared Mephibosheth the son of
Jonathan, the son of Saul,
because of the oath before the LORD that was between them,
between David and Jonathan the son of Saul.
8 But the king took the two sons of Rizpah the daughter of Aiah,
whom she had borne to Saul, Armoni and Mephibosheth,
and the five sons of Merab the daughter of Saul,
whom she had borne to Adriel the son of Barzillai the Meholathite.
9 He handed them over to the Gibeonites.
And they hanged them on the mountain before the LORD.
All seven of them fell together.
They were put to death in the days of harvest,
in the first days, at the beginning of the barley harvest.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the hardest stories in the Bible. Seven men die for a guilt that was not their own.

The law actually says clearly: "Children shall not be put to death for their fathers" (Deuteronomy 24:16). This story stands in tension with that. It shows how the old idea of blood revenge was still alive in Israel at that time.

Some interpreters also ask whether David was not glad to get rid of possible rivals from Saul's family. After all, Shimei had accused him of being a "man of blood" toward the house of Saul (2 Samuel 16:8).

David spares Mephibosheth, Jonathan's son. He keeps his promise to Jonathan.

Here there is another Mephibosheth, a son of Saul and Rizpah.

"Merab": that is what the WEB, our English source text, and some manuscripts say. The main Hebrew text says "Michal." But Merab was married to Adriel (1 Samuel 18:19), and Michal had no children (2 Samuel 6:23).

We read this text as a report from a harsh time, not as an example. No one today may punish people for what their parents did.

Rizpah keeps watch VERSES 10–14

10 Rizpah the daughter of Aiah took sackcloth
and spread it out for herself on the rock,
from the beginning of the harvest until water poured down on them from the sky.
She did not let the birds of the sky rest on them by day,
or the animals of the field by night.
11 David was told what Rizpah the daughter of Aiah, the concubine of Saul, had done.
12 So David went and took the bones of Saul and the bones of his son Jonathan
from the men of Jabesh Gilead.
They had stolen them from the town square of Beth Shan,
where the Philistines had hanged them
on the day the Philistines killed Saul at Gilboa.
13 He brought up the bones of Saul and the bones of his son Jonathan from there.
And they also gathered the bones of those who had been hanged.
14 They buried the bones of Saul and his son Jonathan in the land of Benjamin, in Zela,
in the tomb of his father Kish.
And they did everything the king commanded.
After that, God answered prayer for the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rizpah is the mother of two of the men who were killed. She cannot save her sons. But she guards their bodies. From the barley harvest in spring until the first rain in fall, for many months, she sits on the rock day and night. She drives away the birds and the wild animals.

This is a silent, powerful protest by a mother. She has no power, but she gives her sons back their dignity.

Her example even moves David. At last he arranges a worthy burial for Saul, Jonathan, and the seven men who were killed, in the family tomb.

Only after this burial does it say: "God answered prayer for the land." Not the execution, but only the worthy burial brings peace. Maybe the text wants to say: God is pleased with Rizpah's mercy.

David's heroes against the giants VERSES 15–22

15 The Philistines were at war with Israel again.
David went down with his servants, and they fought against the Philistines.
And David became weak and tired.
16 Ishbibenob, who was one of the sons of the giant,
whose spear weighed 300 shekels of bronze (about 7½ pounds),
and who was armed with a new sword,
thought that he could kill David.
17 But Abishai the son of Zeruiah helped him.
He struck the Philistine and killed him.
Then David's men swore to him and said,
"Don't go out to battle with us anymore,
so that you don't put out the lamp of Israel."
18 After this there was war with the Philistines again at Gob.
Then Sibbecai the Hushathite killed Saph, who was one of the sons of the giant.
19 There was war with the Philistines again at Gob.
Then Elhanan the son of Jaare-Oregim from Bethlehem
killed the brother of Goliath the Gittite.
The shaft of his spear was like a weaver's beam.
20 There was war again at Gath.
There was a very tall man there
who had six fingers on each hand and six toes on each foot,
24 in all.
He too was descended from the giant.
21 When he mocked Israel,
Jonathan the son of Shimei, David's brother, killed

him.
22 These four were descended from the giant in Gath.
And they fell by the hand of David and by the hand of his servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David has grown older. He becomes tired in battle and is in danger of his life. Abishai saves him.

"The lamp of Israel": the king is like a light for the whole people. If he dies, the light goes out. That is why David should not fight himself anymore.

The Bible says "300 shekels." A shekel is about 0.4 ounces.

In Hebrew "the giant" is called "Rapha." The "Rephaim" were a people of very tall people who had lived in the land earlier (Deuteronomy 2:11).

Verse 19: here the Hebrew text only says that Elhanan killed Goliath the Gittite. 1 Chronicles 20:5 says: "Elhanan the son of Jair killed Lahmi the brother of Goliath." The WEB, our English source text, added the words "the brother of," so that the text does not contradict 1 Samuel 17. Interpreters explain this passage in different ways.

Six fingers and six toes: this still happens to people sometimes today. It is something a person is born with.

The message: it was not only David who could defeat giants. His men could do it too, trusting in God.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 22

David's song of thanks: The LORD is my rock

The LORD is my rock VERSES 1–4

1 David spoke the words of this song to the LORD
on the day when the LORD rescued him from the power of all his enemies
and from the power of Saul.
2 He said:
"The LORD is my rock, my fortress and my rescuer.
Yes, he is mine.
3 God is my rock. I take refuge in him.
He is my shield and the horn of my salvation.
He is my high tower and my refuge.
You are my Savior.
You save me from violence.
4 I call to the LORD, who deserves to be praised,
and so I am saved from my enemies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end of the book there is a great song of thanks. Almost exactly the same song is also in the book of Psalms, as Psalm 18.

It is one of the oldest prayers in the Bible. David looks back on his whole life: being hunted by Saul, the wars, the dangers. And he says: God has always rescued me.

David uses many pictures for God: rock, fortress, shield, high tower, refuge. These are pictures of safety. When David was running away, he often hid among rocks and in mountain strongholds. But he knows: the real protection was not the rock, but God.

"To take refuge" means: to go to a safe place.

"The horn of my salvation": the horn is a picture for strength, as with Hannah (1 Samuel 2:1).

In my trouble I called to the LORD VERSES 5–7

5 "The waves of death were all around me.
Floods of wickedness frightened me.
6 The ropes of Sheol (the world of the dead) were all around me.
The traps of death caught me.
7 In my trouble I called on the LORD.
Yes, I called to my God.
He heard my voice from his temple.
My cry reached his ears.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David describes the fear of death with pictures: like someone drowning in the waves, like an animal in a trap.

"Sheol" is the Hebrew word for the world of the dead.

And then comes the most important sentence: "In my trouble I called on the LORD. ... He heard my voice." Many people have prayed these words in hard times.

"Temple" here means God's home in heaven. The temple in Jerusalem did not exist yet in David's time.

God comes to help VERSES 8–20

8 "Then the earth shook and trembled.
The foundations of the heavens shook and moved,
because he was angry.
9 Smoke came out of his nostrils.
A fire that burns everything up came out of his mouth.
It set coals on fire.
10 He also bent the heavens down and came down.
Thick darkness was under his feet.
11 He rode on a cherub and flew.
Yes, he was seen on the wings of the wind.
12 He made darkness a shelter around himself:
masses of water, thick clouds in the sky.
13 Out of the brightness in front of him,
burning coals blazed up.
14 The LORD thundered from heaven.
The Most High let his voice be heard.
15 He shot his arrows and scattered them.
He sent lightning and threw them into confusion.
16 Then the beds of the sea could be seen.
The foundations of the world were uncovered
when the LORD scolded,
at the blast of the breath from his nostrils.
17 He reached down from on high. He took hold of me.
He pulled me out of many waters.
18 He rescued me from my strong enemy,
from those who hated me,
for they were too strong for me.
19 They attacked me on the day of my disaster,
but the LORD held me up.

20 He also brought me out into a wide-open place.
He rescued me, because he took delight in me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it becomes dramatic. God comes down from heaven like a mighty thunderstorm: earthquake, fire, smoke, thunder, lightning. These are pictures, not a description of one particular event. They say: when a person cries out to God, God moves heaven and earth.

A cherub is a heavenly being.

The pictures remind us of Mount Sinai (Exodus 19) and of the crossing through the sea (Exodus 14).

And then it becomes very gentle: the great God reaches down and pulls one single person out of the water. The name Moses sounds like "drawn out of the water."

"He also brought me out into a wide-open place": a person who is afraid feels hemmed in. God gives space and freedom.

"Because he took delight in me": God rescues out of love.

God rewards faithfulness VERSES 21–28

21 "The LORD rewarded me because I did what is right.
Because my hands were clean, he rewarded me.
22 For I have kept the ways of the LORD.
I have not done evil by turning away from my God.
23 For all his rules were in front of me.
I did not turn away from his laws.
24 I was also without blame before him.
I kept myself from my sin.
25 That is why the LORD has rewarded me because I did what is right,
because I was clean in his eyes.
26 With those who show mercy, you show yourself merciful.
With the person who is blameless, you show yourself blameless.
27 With the pure, you show yourself pure.
With the crooked, you show yourself clever.
28 You save people who are suffering,
but your eyes are on the proud,
so that you can bring them down.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David says: I did what is right, I kept God's commands. How can he say that, after what happened with Bathsheba and Uriah?

Maybe the song comes from the time before this sin, when David fled from Saul and spared him twice. At that time he really was innocent. Or David means his basic faithfulness to God: he never served other gods. And when he had sinned, he repented. In the Bible "righteous" does not mean "without faults," but: in the right relationship with God.

Verses 26 and 27 say: God meets every person the way that person is. Whoever is merciful experiences mercy. Whoever is false is beaten with his own weapons.

God is on the side of the humble, not of the proud. Hannah had already sung about this (1 Samuel 2:7–8).

With my God I can leap over a wall VERSES 29–37

29 "For you are my lamp, LORD.
The LORD lights up my darkness.
30 For with you I can charge against a troop of soldiers.
With my God I can leap over a wall.
31 As for God, his way is perfect.
The LORD's word has been tested.
He is a shield to all who take refuge in him.
32 For who is God, except the LORD?
Who is a rock, except our God?
33 God is my strong fortress.
He makes my way perfect.
34 He makes his feet like the feet of a deer.
He sets me on my high places.
35 He trains my hands for battle,
so that my arms can bend a bow of bronze.
36 You have also given me the shield of your salvation.
Your gentleness has made me great.
37 You have given me plenty of room for my steps.
My feet have not slipped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"For you are my lamp": God makes the darkness bright. In 2 Samuel 21:17 David himself was called "the lamp of Israel." But David knows: his light comes from God.

"With my God I can leap over a wall": this sentence has become very well known. It means: with God I can get past obstacles that seem impossible to overcome. Many people have written it down to give them courage.

"The feet of a deer": deer climb safely on steep rocks without falling. In the same way God gives a firm footing.

"Your gentleness has made me great": a beautiful thought. Not God's power alone, but his kindness and gentleness made David great.

"His feet" in verse 34: that is what the main Hebrew text says. Psalm 18:33 has "my feet."

Victory over the enemies VERSES 38–46

38 "I have chased my enemies and destroyed them.
I did not turn back until they were finished.
39 I have finished them off.
I have struck them down, so that they cannot get up.
Yes, they have fallen under my feet.
40 For you have given me strength for the battle.
You have made those who rose up against me bow down under me.
41 You have also made my enemies turn their backs to me,
so that I could destroy those who hate me.
42 They looked for help, but there was no one to save them.
They even looked to the LORD, but he did not answer them.
43 Then I ground them as fine as the dust of the earth.
I crushed them like mud in the streets,
and I scattered them.
44 You have also rescued me from the fights of my people.
You have kept me as the head of the nations.
A people I did not know will serve me.
45 Foreigners will bow down to me.
As soon as they hear of me, they will obey me.
46 Foreigners will lose heart.
They will come trembling out of their hiding places.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This part is a victory song, like the songs kings sang in those days. The language is harsh and warlike. It reflects David's world, in which people fought to survive.

David gives God the honor for every victory: "For you have given me strength for the battle."

"The fights of my people": this probably means the rebellions of Absalom and Sheba.

We read these verses as a king's thanks for being rescued from great danger, not as a call to destroy enemies. Jesus teaches: "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44).

Praise for God's faithfulness VERSES 47–51

47 "The LORD lives! Praise be to my rock!
May God, the rock who saves me, be honored above all.
48 He is the God who pays back my enemies for me,
and who makes peoples bow down under me.
49 He takes me away from my enemies.
Yes, you lift me up above those who rise up against me.
You rescue me from the violent man.
50 That is why I will thank you, LORD, among the nations.
I will sing praises to your name.
51 He gives his king great victories.
He shows loving kindness to his anointed one,
to David and to his descendants forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The song ends the way it began: with the picture of the rock. God is the firm ground in David's life.

"That is why I will thank you, LORD, among the nations": not only Israel, but all nations are to hear about God. Paul quotes this verse in his letter to the Romans. He says: through Jesus, people from all nations are also to praise God (Romans 15:9).

The last verse reminds us of God's promise in Chapter 7: God's loving kindness stays with David and his descendants forever. "His anointed one" is in Hebrew "his mashiach," Messiah.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 23

David's last words and his mighty men

David's last words VERSES 1–7

1 These are the last words of David.
David, the son of Jesse, speaks.
The man who was raised up high speaks.
He is the anointed one of the God of Jacob.
He is the sweet psalm singer of Israel.
2 "The Spirit of the LORD spoke through me.
His word was on my tongue.
3 The God of Israel spoke.
The Rock of Israel said to me:
'Someone may rule over people in a just way.
He may rule with respect for God.
4 Then he will be like the light of the morning when the sun comes up.
He will be like a morning without clouds.
He will be like the clear shining after rain,
when the young grass comes up out of the ground.'
5 Isn't my house like this with God?
He has made a covenant with me that lasts forever.
It is in order in every way, and it is sure.
It is all my salvation and all that I long for.
Won't he make it grow?
6 But all the wicked are like thorns that people throw away.
No one can pick them up by hand.
7 The man who touches them must arm himself with iron and the pole of a spear.
They will be burned up completely with fire where they lie."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These are David's last words, like a spiritual will. David looks back on his life: God has raised him, the shepherd boy, up high.

"The sweet psalm singer of Israel": that is how David is remembered to this day. Many psalms are said to be by him.

"The Spirit of the LORD spoke through me": David also sees himself as a prophet.

The picture of the good king is wonderful: a just ruler is like a clear sunrise after rain, when everything becomes fresh and green. Good leadership brings life and growth for everyone.

"Isn't my house like this with God?": this can be understood as a question or as a confession of faith. David knows that he was not always a good king. But he trusts in God's covenant "that lasts forever" (Chapter 7). Not his own achievement, but God's faithfulness is his hope.

The ungodly are like thorn bushes that cannot be touched and that are burned in the end.

The three mighty men VERSES 8–12

8 These are the names of David's mighty men.
The first was Josheb Basshebeth, a Tahchemonite.
He was the chief of the captains.
He was called Adino the Eznite.
He killed 800 men at one time.
9 After him came Eleazar, the son of Dodai, the son of an Ahohite.
He was one of the three mighty men with David.
They mocked the Philistines who had gathered there for battle.
The men of Israel had gone away.
10 But Eleazar got up and struck down the Philistines.
He fought until his hand was tired and stuck to the sword.
The LORD brought about a great victory that day.
The people came back behind him only to take what the dead had left.
11 After him came Shammah, the son of Agee, a Hararite.
The Philistines had gathered together into a troop.
There was a piece of land full of lentils there.
The people ran away from the Philistines.
12 But Shammah stood in the middle of the field and defended it.
He killed the Philistines.
The LORD brought about a great victory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes a list of David's most famous warriors. Without them David would not have become king. The Bible does not forget the people who were faithful in the background.

The names in verse 8 are hard to understand in Hebrew. In 1 Chronicles 11:11 the man is called "Jashobeam," and there he kills 300 men.

Eleazar fights so long that his hand sticks to his sword, like a cramp. Shammah alone defends a field of lentils while all the others flee.

Twice it says: "The LORD brought about a great victory." The mighty men were brave, but the victory was given by God.

Water from Bethlehem VERSES 13–17

13 Three of the 30 chief men went down to David.
It was harvest time, and David was at the cave of Adullam.
The troop of the Philistines was camped in the valley of Rephaim.
14 At that time David was in the stronghold.
A stronghold is a place that is easy to defend.
At that time a group of Philistine soldiers was in Bethlehem.
15 David said with longing,
"Oh, if only someone would give me water to drink from the well of Bethlehem, by the gate!"
16 So the three mighty men broke through the Philistine army.
They drew water out of the well of Bethlehem, by the gate.
They took it and brought it to David.
But David would not drink it.
He poured it out on the ground for the LORD.
17 He said, "LORD, I would never do this!
Isn't this the blood of the men who risked their lives to go there?"
So he would not drink it.
These are the things the three mighty men did.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a beautiful story from the time when David was running away.

David thinks of his hometown Bethlehem. Full of homesickness, he simply says: I would so much like water from the well of my childhood.

Three of his men hear this. And they risk their lives, break through the enemy camp, and get the water. Out of love for their leader.

But David does not drink it. He says: this water is as precious as the lives of these men. It is too valuable for me. It belongs to God. And he pours it out on the ground as an offering to God.

In this way David honors the faithfulness of his men. He shows: their lives are more important to me than my thirst. A good leader does not misuse the love of his people.

Abishai and Benaiah VERSES 18–23

18 Abishai was the brother of Joab, the son of Zeruiah.
Abishai was chief of the three.
He raised his spear against 300 men and killed them.
He was famous among the three.
19 Wasn't he the most honored of the three?
That is why he became their captain.
But he was not counted as one of the three.
20 Benaiah was the son of Jehoiada.
His father was a brave man from Kabzeel who had done great deeds.
Benaiah killed the two sons of Ariel of Moab.
He also went down into a pit and killed a lion there on a snowy day.
21 He killed a huge Egyptian.
The Egyptian had a spear in his hand.
But Benaiah went down to him with only a stick.
He pulled the spear out of the Egyptian's hand.
Then he killed him with his own spear.
22 Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada, did these things.
He was famous among the three mighty men.
23 He was more honored than the 30.
But he did not reach the rank of the three.
David put him in charge of his guard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In verse 18 the WEB, our English source text, says "of the three." Many manuscripts have "of the thirty" here. That fits better, because Abishai "was not counted as one of the three" (verse 19).

Benaiah is an especially brave man. A lion in a pit, on a snowy day when it is easy to slip: that is almost impossible. And he goes against an armed giant with only a stick, as David went against Goliath with his sling.

Under Solomon, Benaiah later becomes the highest army commander, after Joab (1 Kings 2:35).

The 30 VERSES 24–39

24 Asahel, the brother of Joab, was one of the 30.
The 30 were:
Elhanan, the son of Dodo of Bethlehem,
25 Shammah the Harodite, Elika the Harodite,
26 Helez the Paltite, Ira the son of Ikkesh the Tekoite,
27 Abiezer the Anathothite, Mebunnai the Hushathite,
28 Zalmon the Ahohite, Maharai the Netophathite,
29 Heleb the son of Baanah the Netophathite,
Ittai the son of Ribai, from Gibeah in the land of the people of Benjamin,
30 Benaiah a Pirathonite, Hiddai from the brooks of Gaash,
31 Abialbon the Arbathite, Azmaveth the Barhumite,
32 Eliahba the Shaalbonite,
the sons of Jashen, Jonathan,
33 Shammah the Hararite, Ahiam the son of Sharar the Ararite,
34 Eliphelet the son of Ahasbai, the son of the Maacathite,
Eliam the son of Ahithophel the Gilonite,
35 Hezro the Carmelite, Paarai the Arbite,
36 Igal the son of Nathan of Zobah, Bani the Gadite,
37 Zelek the Ammonite,
Naharai the Beerothite, who carried the weapons of Joab the son of Zeruiah,
38 Ira the Ithrite, Gareb the Ithrite,
39 and Uriah the Hittite.
There were 37 in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a list of "the 30," David's best fighting men. "The 30" was probably the name of the group, even if there were sometimes more and sometimes fewer men.

Asahel stands at the beginning. He had died early (2 Samuel 2:23). The list honors the dead too.

Among the mighty men there are also foreigners: an Ammonite, a man from Zobah in Syria, and Uriah the Hittite.

Eliam, the son of Ahithophel, was probably Bathsheba's father (2 Samuel 11:3).

And at the end there is a name that stabs the heart: "Uriah the Hittite." The faithful soldier whom David had killed. The Bible deliberately puts him at the end of this list of honor. He is not forgotten. And David's guilt is not kept quiet.

"37 in all": if you add the three, Abishai, and Benaiah to the names in this list, you get about this number. It is not certain exactly how they were counted.

2 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 24

The census and the altar on the threshing floor

David has the people counted VERSES 1–9

1 Again the anger of the LORD burned against Israel.
And he moved David against them.
He said, "Go, count Israel and Judah."
2 Joab, the commander of the army, was with the king.
The king said to him,
"Go through all the tribes of Israel, from Dan to Beersheba.
Count the people.
I want to know how many people there are."
3 Joab said to the king,
"May the LORD your God make the people 100 times more than they are now.
And may my lord the king see it with his own eyes.
But why does my lord the king want to do this?"
4 But the king's word was stronger than Joab and the commanders of the army.
So Joab and the commanders of the army left the king.
They went out to count the people of Israel.
5 They crossed the Jordan.
They camped in Aroer, on the right side of the city in the middle of the valley of Gad.
Then they went toward Jazer.
6 Then they came to Gilead and to the land of Tahtim Hodshi.
They came to Dan Jaan and went around to Sidon.
7 They came to the stronghold of Tyre
and to all the cities of the Hivites and of the Canaanites.
Then they went out to the south of Judah, to Beersheba.
8 They went through the whole land.
After 9 months and 20 days, they came back to Jerusalem.
9 Joab told the king the number of the people.
In Israel there were 800,000 brave men who could fight with the sword.
In Judah there were 500,000 men.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Why is a census a sin? The Bible does not say exactly. Probably the point was that David wanted to know how strong his army was. He wanted to rely on the number of his soldiers, not on God. It was a count for war and taxes, out of pride.

Even Joab, who usually has few doubts, warns David: why do you want to do this?

Verse 1 is very hard. It says about the LORD: "And he moved David against them." How can God lead someone into sin? 1 Chronicles 21:1, where the same story is told, says: "Satan rose up against Israel. He moved David to count the people of Israel." Here the Bible itself wrestles with the question of where evil comes from. The older text traces everything back to God, because God stands above everything. The later text says more exactly: the tempter was Satan, but God allowed it.

The count takes almost 10 months. The numbers are very high. 1 Chronicles 21:5 has different numbers: 1,100,000 for Israel and 470,000 for Judah.

David's regret and three punishments VERSES 10–14

10 After David had counted the people, his conscience hurt him.
David said to the LORD,
"I have sinned greatly by what I did.
But now, LORD, please take away the guilt of your servant.
I have acted very foolishly."
11 David got up in the morning.
Then the word of the LORD came to the prophet Gad, David's seer.
A seer is a prophet who sees what God shows him.
12 The LORD said, "Go and tell David,
'The LORD says:
"I offer you three things.
Choose one of them, and I will do it to you."'"
13 So Gad came to David and told him,
"Shall seven years of famine come on your land?
Or will you run away from your enemies for three months while they chase you?
Or shall there be three days of disease in your land?
Now think it over.
Decide what answer I should give to the one who sent me."
14 David said to Gad,
"I am in great trouble.
Let us fall into the LORD's hand, because his mercy is great.
But do not let me fall into the hands of people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Once again David's conscience strikes him, as it did in the cave with Saul (1 Samuel 24:5). David regrets it at once. He does not try to talk his way out.

God lets David choose. In 1 Chronicles 21:12 it is three years of famine instead of seven. The old Greek translation also has three here.

David chooses the disease. His reason is a deep confession of faith: I would rather fall into God's hand than into the hand of people, for God is merciful. Even in punishment, David trusts in God's mercy.

The plague and the angel VERSES 15–17

15 So the LORD sent a disease on Israel.
It lasted from the morning until the set time.
From Dan to Beersheba, 70,000 men of the people died.
16 The angel stretched out his hand toward Jerusalem to destroy it.
But the LORD was sorry about the disaster.
He said to the angel who was destroying the people,
"It is enough. Now pull back your hand."
The angel of the LORD was by the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite.
A threshing floor is a flat, hard place where grain is beaten to separate the seeds.
17 David saw the angel who was striking the people.
Then David said to the LORD,
"I am the one who has sinned.
I have done wrong.
But these sheep, what have they done?
Please let your hand be against me and against my father's family."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many people die. That is very hard to understand: why must the people suffer for the sin of the king? But verse 1 says that God was already angry with Israel before. Maybe because of the rebellions against David. The Bible does not explain it further.

But then comes the turning point: God holds the angel back before he destroys Jerusalem. "It is enough." God's mercy is greater than his anger. David was right to hope in God's mercy.

David stands up for his people: I have sinned, not these sheep. Punish me. Here we see David the shepherd again, who stands up for his flock. Christians see in this a picture of Jesus, the good shepherd, who gives his life for his sheep (John 10:11).

The altar on the threshing floor VERSES 18–25

18 That day Gad came to David and said to him,
"Go up and build an altar to the LORD on the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite."
19 David went up, as Gad had said and as the LORD had commanded.
20 Araunah looked out and saw the king and his servants coming toward him.
Araunah went out and bowed down before the king with his face to the ground.
21 Araunah said,
"Why has my lord the king come to his servant?"
David said,
"To buy your threshing floor.
I want to build an altar to the LORD,
so that the plague on the people may stop."
22 Araunah said to David,
"Let my lord the king take whatever he thinks is good, and offer it up.
Here are the cattle for the burnt offering.
And here are the threshing sledges and the yokes of the oxen for the wood.
23 O king, Araunah gives all this to the king."
And Araunah said to the king,
"May the LORD your God accept you."
24 But the king said to Araunah,
"No, I will pay you a price for it.
I will not offer burnt offerings to the LORD my God that cost me nothing."
So David bought the threshing floor and the oxen for 50 shekels of silver (about 1¼ pounds).
25 David built an altar to the LORD there.
He offered burnt offerings and peace offerings.
So the LORD answered the prayers for the land,
and the plague on Israel stopped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Araunah wants to give David everything. But David refuses and says an important sentence: "I will not offer burnt offerings to the LORD my God that cost me nothing." A real offering, real devotion, must cost something. Whoever gives God only what is left over really gives nothing.

50 shekels of silver are about 1¼ pounds of silver. 1 Chronicles 21:25 says that David paid 600 shekels of gold, maybe for the whole area.

This threshing floor is a special place. It is exactly here that Solomon later built the temple, on Mount Moriah (2 Chronicles 3:1). According to Jewish tradition, it is also the mountain on which Abraham was to sacrifice Isaac (Genesis 22:2).

So the book of Samuel does not end with David's death, but with an altar, with forgiveness, and with a place where God and people meet. The plague stops. God answers prayer.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of 2 Samuel?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of 2 Samuel tells the story of King David, with all its highs and lows.

1. David's rise (Chapters 1–10): David mourns for Saul and Jonathan. He becomes king over Judah, then over all Israel. He conquers Jerusalem and brings the ark of the covenant there. God gives him a great promise: "Your throne will be made firm forever" (Chapter 7). David brings Mephibosheth to his table. He "did what was just and right for all his people."

2. David's sin (Chapters 11–12): David takes Bathsheba and has her husband Uriah killed. The prophet Nathan says: "You are the man!" David repents, and God forgives him. But the consequences remain.

3. Misfortune in David's family (Chapters 13–20): Amnon rapes Tamar. Absalom murders Amnon and rises up against his father. David has to flee. Absalom dies, and David cries out: "My son Absalom!" The sword does not leave David's house.

4. Appendix (Chapters 21–24): more stories from David's time, his great song of thanks "The LORD is my rock," his

last words, his mighty men, and the census, which ends with an altar on the later temple mount.

The book shows a person as he really is: a great king, poet, and hero of faith who loves God with all his heart. But also a man who takes heavy guilt on himself, who fails in his family, and who causes much suffering. The Bible does not make anything look better than it was.

What makes David different from Saul is not that he makes no mistakes. It is that he keeps coming back to God, admits his guilt, and trusts in God's mercy: "Let us fall into the LORD's hand, because his mercy is great."

God's promise to David has shaped the whole rest of the Bible. Jews wait for the Messiah, the Son of David. Christians believe that Jesus is this Son of David, the king whose kingdom will have no end.

The books of Kings tell how things go on after David: with Solomon, the building of the temple, and the division of the kingdom.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 11 OF 66

1 KINGS

22 CHAPTERS

1 KINGS

Chapter 1

Who will follow David as king?

Before we begin: What is the book of 1 Kings?

The books of Kings tell the story of the kings of Israel, from Solomon to the fall of Jerusalem. That is about 400 years. In the beginning, 1 Kings and 2 Kings were one single book.

The book of 1 Kings has two big parts:

The first part (Chapters 1–11) is about King Solomon. He is famous for his wisdom and his wealth. He builds the temple in Jerusalem. But at the end of his life he turns to other gods.

In the second part (Chapters 12–22) the kingdom splits into two parts: in the north the kingdom of Israel, in the south the kingdom of Judah. Many kings follow one after another. Most of the kings in the north serve other gods. Then the great prophet Elijah appears. He fights against King Ahab and Queen Jezebel and against the idol Baal.

Again and again the book asks: did the king obey the LORD or not? It does not judge the kings by their wealth or their wars, but by their faithfulness to God.

The books of Kings were probably put together during the time of the exile in Babylon. They want to explain: why did Israel lose its land? The answer is: because the kings and the people were unfaithful to God again and again. But the book also shows: God keeps his promises to David.

The old King David VERSES 1–4

1 King David was old and far along in years.
They covered him with clothes, but he could not keep warm.
2 So his servants said to him,
"Let a young virgin be found for my lord the king.
Let her stand before the king and take care of him.
Let her lie in your arms, so that my lord the king may keep warm."
3 So they looked for a beautiful young woman in all the land of Israel.
They found Abishag the Shunammite and brought her to the king.
4 The young woman was very beautiful.
She took care of the king and served him,
but the king did not have sexual relations with her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The great King David is now an old, sick man. He is cold, he is weak.

The servants bring a young woman, Abishag. She is to take care of him and keep him warm. In those days people believed that the body warmth of a young person could give an old person strength for life.

For Abishag this was surely not a free choice. In those days young women were often not asked.

"The king did not have sexual relations with her": this also shows that David is so weak that he can no longer rule. This is the moment when the struggle over who will follow him begins.

Adonijah wants to become king VERSES 5–10

5 Then Adonijah the son of Haggith became proud and said,
"I will be king."
He got himself chariots and horsemen
and 50 men to run in front of him.
6 His father had never once upset him by asking,
"Why have you done this?"
He was also a very handsome man.
He was born after Absalom.
7 He talked things over with Joab the son of Zeruiah and with Abiathar the priest.
And they followed Adonijah and helped him.
8 But Zadok the priest, Benaiah the son of Jehoiada,
Nathan the prophet,
Shimei, Rei, and David's mighty men were not on Adonijah's side.
9 Adonijah killed sheep, cattle, and fattened animals by the stone of Zoheleth, which is beside En Rogel.
He invited all his brothers, the king's sons,
and all the men of Judah, the king's servants.
10 But he did not invite Nathan the prophet, Benaiah, the mighty men,
or his brother Solomon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Adonijah is David's fourth son (2 Samuel 3:4). Amnon and Absalom are dead, and the second son, Chileab, is not mentioned anymore. So Adonijah is now probably the oldest living son. He believes that he has the right to the throne.

He does it exactly like Absalom: chariots, horses, 50 runners (2 Samuel 15:1). And he is also handsome, like Absalom.

"His father had never once upset him": David never corrected his sons. He spoiled them and set them no limits. That is a weakness that runs like a red thread through David's family.

There are now two groups at the royal court: Joab and Abiathar are for Adonijah. Zadok, Benaiah, and Nathan are for Solomon.

Adonijah is already holding a feast, as if he were king. But he does not invite Solomon. He knows who his rival is.

Nathan and Bathsheba step in VERSES 11–27

11 Then Nathan said to Bathsheba, the mother of Solomon,
"Haven't you heard that Adonijah the son of Haggith has become king,
and our lord David doesn't know it?
12 So come now, let me give you advice,
so that you can save your own life and the life of your son Solomon.
13 Go in to King David and say to him,
'My lord the king, didn't you swear to your servant

and say,
"Surely your son Solomon will be king after me,
and he will sit on my throne"?
Why then has Adonijah become king?'
14 And while you are still talking there with the king,
I will come in after you and confirm your words."
15 So Bathsheba went in to the king in his room.
The king was very old,
and Abishag the Shunammite was serving the king.
16 Bathsheba bowed and showed respect to the king.
The king said, "What would you like?"
17 She said to him,
"My lord, you swore to your servant by the LORD your God,
'Surely your son Solomon will be king after me,
and he will sit on my throne.'
18 But now Adonijah has become king.
And you, my lord the king, don't know it.
19 He has killed cattle, fattened animals, and sheep in great numbers,
and he has invited all the king's sons,
Abiathar the priest, and Joab the commander of the army.
But he has not invited your servant Solomon.
20 My lord the king, the eyes of all Israel are on you.
They are waiting for you to tell them
who will sit on the throne of my lord the king after him.
21 Otherwise this will happen:
when my lord the king dies and joins his ancestors,
I and my son Solomon will be treated as criminals."
22 While she was still talking with the king, Nathan the prophet came in.
23 They told the king,
"Nathan the prophet is here!"
When he came in before the king, he bowed down
before the king with his face to the ground.
24 Nathan said,
"My lord the king, have you said,
'Adonijah will be king after me, and he will sit on my throne'?
25 For today he has gone down
and has killed cattle, fattened animals, and sheep in great numbers.
He has invited all the king's sons, the commanders of the army, and Abiathar the priest.
And they are eating and drinking with him and saying,
'Long live King Adonijah!'
26 But he has not invited me, your servant,
or Zadok the priest, or Benaiah the son of Jehoiada, or your servant Solomon.
27 Was this done by my lord the king,
and you have not told your servants
who should sit on the throne of my lord the king after him?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nathan, the prophet who once called David to turn back with the words "You are the man!", steps in again.

Bathsheba now has a very different role than before. She is no longer the woman who was taken, but a wise, strong mother who fights for her son's future.

She reminds David of an oath that Solomon would become king. This oath is not mentioned earlier in the Bible. But at his birth God had already called Solomon "Jedidiah," which means loved by the LORD (2 Samuel 12:25).

Nathan and Bathsheba plan this together. They know: if Adonijah becomes king, Solomon and Bathsheba are in danger of their lives. New kings often killed their rivals.

David decides: Solomon is to be king VERSES 28–40

28 Then King David answered,
"Call Bathsheba in to me."
She came in before the king and stood before the king.
29 The king made a vow and said,
"As the LORD lives, who has rescued my life from all trouble:
30 as I swore to you by the LORD, the God of Israel,
'Surely your son Solomon will be king after me,
and he will sit on my throne in my place,'
so I will surely do it today."
31 Then Bathsheba bowed with her face to the ground,
showed respect to the king, and said,
"May my lord King David live forever!"
32 King David said,
"Call Zadok the priest, Nathan the prophet, and Benaiah the son of Jehoiada to me."
They came before the king.
33 The king said to them,
"Take with you the servants of your lord.
Have my son Solomon ride on my own mule,
and bring him down to Gihon.
34 Let Zadok the priest and Nathan the prophet anoint him there as king over Israel.
Blow the trumpet and say,
'Long live King Solomon!'
35 Then come up after him.
He is to come and sit on my throne.
For he will be king in my place.
I have appointed him to be prince over Israel and over Judah."
36 Benaiah the son of Jehoiada answered the king and said,
"Amen. May the LORD, the God of my lord the king, say so too.
37 As the LORD has been with my lord the king,
so may he be with Solomon,
and may he make his throne even greater than the throne of my lord King David."
38 So Zadok the priest, Nathan the prophet, Benaiah the son of Jehoiada,
and the Cherethites and the Pelethites went down.
They had Solomon ride on King David's mule
and brought him to Gihon.
39 Zadok the priest took the horn of oil from the Tent and anointed Solomon.
They blew the trumpet,
and all the people said,
"Long live King Solomon!"
40 All the people came up after him.
And the people played on flutes and rejoiced with great joy,
so that the earth shook with their noise.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The old David wakes up once more. He acts quickly and firmly.

Solomon rides on David's own mule. That is a sign for everyone: this is the king's successor.

Gihon is a spring in the valley east of Jerusalem, not far from En Rogel, where Adonijah is celebrating. The two celebrations take place almost within earshot of each other.

Solomon is anointed, like David and Saul before him. He is anointed with oil from the Tent in which the ark stood.

"Long live King Solomon!": the people celebrate so loudly that the earth shakes.

Adonijah hears the news VERSES 41–53

41 Adonijah and all the guests who were with him heard it
just as they had finished eating.
When Joab heard the sound of the trumpet, he said,
"What is this noise?
Why is the city in an uproar?"
42 While he was still speaking,
Jonathan the son of Abiathar the priest came.
Adonijah said,
"Come in, for you are a worthy man, and you bring
good news."
43 Jonathan answered Adonijah,
"Truly, our lord King David has made Solomon king.
44 The king has sent with him Zadok the priest, Nathan
the prophet, Benaiah the son of Jehoiada,
and the Cherethites and the Pelethites.
And they have had him ride on the king's mule.
45 Zadok the priest and Nathan the prophet have anointed
him king at Gihon.
And they have come up from there rejoicing,
so that the city is ringing with it.
That is the noise that you have heard.
46 And Solomon is already sitting on the throne of the
kingdom.
47 And the king's servants have come
to bless our lord King David.
They said,
'May your God make the name of Solomon better than
your name,
and make his throne greater than your throne.'
And the king bowed down on his bed.
48 And the king also said this:
'Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel,
who today has given someone to sit on my throne,
and my eyes can still see it.'"
49 Then all of Adonijah's guests were afraid.
They got up, and each one went his way.
50 Adonijah was afraid of Solomon.
He got up, went, and held on to the horns of the altar.
51 Solomon was told,
"Adonijah is afraid of King Solomon.
He is holding on to the horns of the altar and saying,
'Let King Solomon first swear to me
that he will not kill his servant with the sword.'"
52 Solomon said,
"If he shows himself a worthy man,
not one hair of his will fall to the ground.
But if wickedness is found in him, he will die."
53 So King Solomon sent for him,
and they brought him down from the altar.
He came and bowed down to King Solomon.
And Solomon said to him,
"Go to your house."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the feast the news comes. Adonijah expects good news, but it is the end of his plans. All the guests run away.

Adonijah flees to the altar and holds on to its "horns," the corners of the altar. The altar was a place of protection. Whoever held on to it could not be killed, unless he had murdered someone on purpose (Exodus 21:14).

At the beginning Solomon is generous: if you behave well, nothing will happen to you. But he sets a clear condition.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 2

David's death and Solomon's hard hand

David's last instructions VERSES 1–9

1 When the time came near for David to die,
he gave instructions to his son Solomon and said,
2 "I am going the way of all the earth.
So be strong, and show yourself a man.
3 Keep the instructions of the LORD your God.
Walk in his ways.
Keep his laws, his commandments, his rules, and his
teachings,
as it is written in the law of Moses,
so that you may do well in all that you do and wherever
you turn.
4 Then the LORD will keep his word that he spoke about
me:
'If your children are careful how they live
and walk before me in truth, with all their heart and
with all their soul,
you will never be without a man on the throne of
Israel.'
5 "You also know what Joab the son of Zeruiah did to me,
what he did to the two commanders of the armies of
Israel,
to Abner the son of Ner and to Amasa the son of Jether.
He killed them and shed the blood of war in a time of
peace.
He put the blood of war on the belt around his waist
and on the sandals on his feet.
6 So act according to your wisdom,
and don't let his gray head go down to Sheol (the world
of the dead) in peace.

7 But show kindness to the sons of Barzillai the Gileadite.
Let them be among those who eat at your table.
For they came to help me in this way when I fled from
your brother Absalom.
8 "And there is Shimei the son of Gera with you, the
Benjamite from Bahurim.
He cursed me with a terrible curse
on the day when I went to Mahanaim.
But he came down to meet me at the Jordan,
and I swore to him by the LORD,
'I will not put you to death with the sword.'
9 But now do not treat him as innocent.
For you are a wise man,
and you will know what you should do to him.
You shall bring his gray head down to Sheol with
blood."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"I am going the way of all the earth" means: I am going to die, like all people.

David's first advice is good: keep God's commandments. Then your kingdom will last. God's promise to David (2 Samuel 7) has a condition: faithfulness to God.

But then come instructions that are hard to read. David asks Solomon to settle accounts with Joab and Shimei.

With Joab it can be understood: he murdered two men by treachery, Abner and Amasa, and was never punished for it. Back then David was too weak to punish him (2 Samuel 3:39). Now Solomon is to bring the justice that was missed.

With Shimei it is harder. David had sworn to him that he would not kill him. Now he tells Solomon: you are not bound by my oath. That is a dark moment at the end of David's life.

The Bible tells honestly that David, too, was a person with weaknesses right to the end.

But for Barzillai, who helped David in his time of need, there is thanks and faithfulness.

David's death VERSES 10–12

10 David died and joined his ancestors
and was buried in David's city.
11 The time that David ruled over Israel was 40 years.
He ruled 7 years in Hebron,
and he ruled 33 years in Jerusalem.
12 Solomon sat on the throne of his father David,
and his kingdom was firmly established.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David's death is told in just a few words. The shepherd boy from Bethlehem who defeated Goliath, the king, poet, and sinner, dies.

"David's city" is the fortress of Zion in Jerusalem, which David had captured.

2 Samuel 5:5 was more exact: seven and a half years in Hebron. Here the number is rounded.

Adonijah asks for Abishag VERSES 13–25

13 Then Adonijah the son of Haggith came to Bathsheba,
the mother of Solomon.
She said, "Do you come in peace?"
He said, "In peace."
14 And he went on,
"I have something to tell you."
She said, "Go ahead."
15 He said,
"You know that the kingdom was mine,
and that all Israel was expecting me to be king.
But the kingdom has turned around and has become
my brother's,
for it came to him from the LORD.
16 Now I have one request to ask of you.
Don't turn me down."
She said to him, "Go ahead."
17 He said,
"Please speak to King Solomon,
for he will not tell you 'no,'
and ask him to give me Abishag the Shunammite as my
wife."
18 Bathsheba said,
"All right. I will speak to the king for you."
19 So Bathsheba went to King Solomon to speak to him for
Adonijah.
The king got up to meet her and bowed down to her.
Then he sat down on his throne
and had a throne set up for the king's mother.
And she sat at his right hand.
20 Then she said,
"I have one small request to ask of you.
Don't turn me down."
The king said to her,
"Ask, my mother, for I will not turn you down."
21 She said,
"Let Abishag the Shunammite be given to your
brother Adonijah as his wife."
22 King Solomon answered his mother,
"Why do you ask for Abishag the Shunammite for
Adonijah?
You might as well ask for the kingdom for him too,
for he is my older brother,
for him and for Abiathar the priest and for Joab the
son of Zeruiah!"
23 Then King Solomon swore by the LORD and said,
"May God do this to me and even more,
if Adonijah has not spoken this word against his own
life.
24 And now, as the LORD lives,
who has made me firm and set me on the throne of my
father David,
and who has made me a house as he promised:
Adonijah will surely be put to death today."
25 King Solomon sent Benaiah the son of Jehoiada.
He struck him down, so that he died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Adonijah acts as if he has accepted his defeat. But then he asks for Abishag, the young woman who had taken care of David.

In those days the rule was: whoever takes the women of the dead king lays claim to the throne (compare 2 Samuel 16:21–22). Solomon understands at once: this is a hidden grab for the crown.

Bathsheba does not notice it, or she notices it and lets Adonijah walk into the trap. The text does not say.

Solomon shows his mother great honor: he stands up, bows, and has a throne set up for her at his right hand. The king's

mother had an important position at the royal court.

Once again Abishag is not asked. She is only a tool in the men's struggle for power.

Solomon has his brother killed. In this way he does not directly break his promise in 1 Kings 1:52, because he sees "wickedness" in Adonijah's request.

Abiathar and Joab VERSES 26–35

26 The king said to Abiathar the priest,
"Go to Anathoth, to your own fields,
for you deserve death.
But I will not put you to death at this time,
because you carried the ark of the Lord GOD before my father David,
and because you suffered in everything in which my father suffered."
27 So Solomon drove Abiathar out,
so that he was no longer priest to the LORD.
In this way the word of the LORD was to be fulfilled,
which he had spoken in Shiloh about the house of Eli.
28 This news came to Joab.
For Joab had followed Adonijah,
although he had not followed Absalom.
Joab fled to the Tent of the LORD
and held on to the horns of the altar.
29 King Solomon was told,
"Joab has fled to the Tent of the LORD,
and he is by the altar."
Then Solomon sent Benaiah the son of Jehoiada and said,
"Go, strike him down."
30 Benaiah came to the Tent of the LORD and said to him,
"The king says, 'Come out!'"
He said,
"No, I will die here."
Benaiah brought the answer back to the king and said,
"This is what Joab said, and this is how he answered me."
31 The king said to him,
"Do as he has said.
Strike him down and bury him.
In this way you will take away the blood that Joab shed without cause
from me and from my father's house.
32 The LORD will bring his blood back on his own head.
For he attacked two men who were more righteous and better than he was,
and killed them with the sword, and my father David did not know it:
Abner the son of Ner, commander of the army of Israel,
and Amasa the son of Jether, commander of the army of Judah.
33 So their blood will come back on the head of Joab and on the head of his descendants forever.
But for David and his descendants, for his house and for his throne,
there will be peace from the LORD forever."
34 Then Benaiah the son of Jehoiada went up,
struck him down, and killed him.
And he was buried in his own house in the wilderness.
35 The king put Benaiah the son of Jehoiada over the army in his place.
And the king put Zadok the priest in the place of Abiathar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abiathar had served David faithfully, when he was fleeing from Saul and from Absalom. That is why Solomon spares his life. But he loses his office as priest.

In this way an old word comes true: Eli's family had been told that they would lose the office of priest (1 Samuel 2:30–35). Abiathar was the last priest from Eli's family.

Anathoth was a village north of Jerusalem. Later the prophet Jeremiah came from a family of priests in Anathoth (Jeremiah 1:1).

"More righteous" (verse 32): righteous means living right before God.

Joab flees to the altar like Adonijah. But the protection of the altar was not for murderers (Exodus 21:14). Joab had murdered Abner and Amasa.

So ends the life of the man who brought David many victories, but who also shed so much blood. He dies the way he lived: by the sword.

Benaiah becomes the new commander of the army, Zadok becomes the chief priest. His descendants remain priests until much later times.

Shimei's end VERSES 36–46

36 The king sent for Shimei and said to him,
"Build yourself a house in Jerusalem and live there.
And don't go anywhere else from there.
37 For on the day you go out and cross the brook Kidron,
know for certain that you will surely die.
Your blood will be on your own head."
38 Shimei said to the king,
"What you say is good.
As my lord the king has said, so your servant will do."
And Shimei lived in Jerusalem for a long time.
39 At the end of three years, two of Shimei's slaves ran away
to Achish, son of Maacah, king of Gath.
Shimei was told,
"Your slaves are in Gath."
40 So Shimei got up, saddled his donkey,
and went to Achish in Gath to look for his slaves.
And Shimei went and brought his slaves back from Gath.
41 Solomon was told
that Shimei had gone from Jerusalem to Gath and had come back again.
42 The king sent for Shimei and said to him,
"Didn't I make you swear by the LORD and warn you,
'Know for certain that on the day you go out and walk anywhere else,
you will surely die'?
And you said to me,
'What I have heard is good.'
43 Why then have you not kept the oath of the LORD
and the commandment that I gave you?"
44 The king also said to Shimei,
"You know in your heart all the wickedness that you did to my father David.

So the LORD will bring your wickedness back on your
own head.
45 But King Solomon will be blessed,
and the throne of David will stand firm before the
LORD forever."
46 Then the king gave the command to Benaiah the son of
Jehoiada.
He went out and struck him down, so that he died.
The kingdom was firmly established in the hand of
Solomon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon gives Shimei a chance: he may live, but he must stay in Jerusalem, where he can be watched. That way he cannot stir up a revolt in the tribe of Benjamin.

After three years Shimei breaks the agreement in order to bring back two slaves who had run away. Solomon has him killed.

The chapter ends with the sentence: "The kingdom was firmly established in the hand of Solomon." Solomon has removed all possible enemies: Adonijah, Joab, Shimei. Abiathar is sent away.

This is a hard chapter. It shows what happened in those days when power changed hands. The Bible makes nothing look nicer than it was. We do not read it as an example to follow, but as an honest report about the power politics of that time.

That two slaves run away reminds us that there was slavery in Israel in those days. Actually, the law of Moses had commanded that slaves who had run away should not be sent back (Deuteronomy 23:15).

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 3

Solomon asks for wisdom

Solomon and the high places VERSES 1–4

1 Solomon made a marriage alliance with Pharaoh, the
king of Egypt.
He took Pharaoh's daughter as his wife
and brought her into David's city,
until he had finished building his own house, the
LORD's house,
and the wall around Jerusalem.
2 But the people sacrificed at the high places,
because no house had been built yet for the LORD's
name.
3 Solomon loved the LORD
and followed the laws of his father David.
Only, he also sacrificed and burned incense at the high
places.
4 The king went to Gibeon to sacrifice there,
for that was the great high place.
Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings on that altar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon marries a daughter of Pharaoh. That shows how powerful Israel has become: the king of Egypt gives his daughter to a king of Israel. In those days marriages like this were political alliances.

But the law warned: a king should not have many wives, and he should not lead the people back to Egypt (Deuteronomy 17:16–17). Later Solomon will have many foreign wives, and they will draw his heart to other gods (Chapter 11).

"High places" were places on hills where people offered sacrifices. Because there was no temple yet, people also sacrificed to the LORD there. Later the high places were forbidden, because people often served other gods there too.

"Solomon loved the LORD": at the beginning, Solomon is completely turned toward God.

In those days the Tent of Meeting from the time of Moses stood in Gibeon (2 Chronicles 1:3).

"Ask for what I should give you" VERSES 5–9

5 In Gibeon the LORD appeared to Solomon in a dream at
night.
And God said,
"Ask for what I should give you."
6 Solomon said,
"You have shown great loving kindness to your
servant David, my father,
because he walked before you in truth, in
righteousness, and with an honest heart.
And you have kept this great loving kindness for him
and have given him a son to sit on his throne, as it is
today.
7 And now, LORD my God,
you have made your servant king in the place of my
father David.
I am only a little child.
I don't know how to go out or come in.
8 And your servant is in the middle of your people whom
you have chosen,
a great people, so many that they cannot be numbered
or counted.
9 So give your servant an understanding heart
to judge your people,
so that I can tell the difference between good and evil.
For who is able to judge this great people of yours?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God says to Solomon: make a wish! What would you wish for?

Solomon begins with thanks: you were so good to my father. Then he says honestly: I am still young and have no experience. I don't know how to lead a whole people.

"To go out or come in" means: I don't know how to act as a leader.

And then he does not ask for wealth or power, but for an "understanding heart." In Hebrew it says word for word: "a listening heart." A heart that can listen to God and to people. Only someone who listens well can judge fairly.

That is a wonderful request, for us today too: God, give me a listening heart.

God gives more than was asked VERSES 10–15

10 This request pleased the Lord, that Solomon had asked
for this.
11 God said to him,
"Because you have asked for this,
and have not asked for a long life for yourself,
or asked for riches for yourself,
or asked for the life of your enemies,
but have asked for understanding for yourself, to
know what is just,
12 I have done what you asked.
I have given you a wise and understanding heart,
so that there has been no one like you before you,
and no one like you will arise after you.
13 I have also given you what you have not asked for,
both riches and honor,
so that there will be no one like you among the kings
for all your days.
14 And if you walk in my ways
and keep my laws and my commandments,
as your father David walked,
then I will give you a long life."
15 Solomon woke up, and it was a dream.
Then he came to Jerusalem.
He stood before the ark of the LORD's covenant,
offered burnt offerings and peace offerings,
and made a feast for all his servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is pleased with Solomon's request. Solomon did not think of himself, but of the people and of justice.

And God gives him more than he asked for: wisdom, and also wealth and honor. Later Jesus said something similar: "But seek first God's Kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well" (Matthew 6:33).

But the long life has a condition: if you walk in my ways. God's gifts bring a duty with them.

After the dream Solomon goes to Jerusalem, before the ark. He celebrates with all his servants.

The judgment between the two mothers VERSES 16–28

16 Then two women who were prostitutes came to the
king
and stood before him.
17 One of the women said,
"Oh, my lord, this woman and I live in the same house.
I gave birth to a child while she was in the house.
18 On the third day after I gave birth,
this woman also gave birth.
We were together.
There was no stranger with us in the house,
just the two of us in the house.
19 This woman's child died in the night,
because she lay on him.
20 She got up at midnight
and took my son from beside me while your servant
was asleep.
She laid him in her arms,
and she laid her dead child in my arms.
21 When I got up in the morning to nurse my child,
he was dead.
But when I looked at him closely in the morning,
it was not my son, the one I had given birth to."
22 The other woman said,
"No! The living one is my son, and the dead one is your
son."
The first one said,
"No! The dead one is your son, and the living one is my
son."
So they argued before the king.
23 Then the king said,
"One says, 'This is my son who is alive, and your son is
the dead one.'
And the other says, 'No! Your son is the dead one, and
my son is the living one.'"
24 The king said,
"Bring me a sword."
So they brought a sword before the king.
25 The king said,
"Divide the living child in two,
and give half to the one and half to the other."
26 Then the woman whose child was alive spoke to the
king,
for her heart longed for her son:
"Oh, my lord, give her the living child,
and do not kill him in any way!"
But the other said,
"He will be neither mine nor yours. Divide him!"
27 Then the king answered,
"Give the first woman the living child,
and certainly do not kill him.
She is his mother."
28 All Israel heard about the judgment that the king had
made.
And they were in awe of the king.
For they saw that the wisdom of God was in him to do
justice.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Right after the dream, Solomon's wisdom shows itself. Two women are fighting over a child. There are no witnesses. It is one woman's word against the other's.

Something worth noticing: the women are prostitutes, people who were looked down on in society. But the king listens to them too. Justice is for everyone, not only for people who are respected.

Solomon commands something terrible: to divide the child. But he does not mean it. He wants to test the hearts of the women.

The real mother would rather lose her child than see him die. Her love does not think of herself. The other woman only wants neither of them to get the child. That is how the truth comes out.

The "listening heart" that Solomon had asked for shows itself here: he does not only listen to the words, but to the heart.

This "judgment of Solomon" is still famous all over the world today. People speak of "the wisdom of Solomon" when someone solves a difficult dispute wisely.

Chapter 4

Solomon's kingdom and his wisdom

Solomon's chief officials VERSES 1–6

1 King Solomon was king over all Israel.
2 These were his top officials:
Azariah, the son of Zadok, was the priest.
3 Elihoreph and Ahijah, the sons of Shisha, were scribes.
A scribe is a writer who keeps the records.
Jehoshaphat, the son of Ahilud, was the recorder.
4 Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada, was in charge of the army.
Zadok and Abiathar were priests.
5 Azariah, the son of Nathan, was in charge of the officers.
Zabud, the son of Nathan, was the chief minister and the king's friend.
6 Ahishar was in charge of the palace.
Adoniram, the son of Abda, was in charge of the men who had to do forced labor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon has a large royal court with many officials. The kingdom is now a real state.

We already know some of the names: Benaiah, Zadok, Jehoshaphat. The sons of Nathan may be sons of the prophet Nathan.

Abiathar is still named as a priest, although Solomon had sent him away (1 Kings 2:27). The list probably comes from different times.

"The king's friend" was a title of honor for a close adviser, like Hushai for David.

Adoniram is in charge of the forced labor. Under Solomon the burden of work for the people gets heavier and heavier. Later this will lead to the splitting of the kingdom (Chapter 12).

The 12 officers VERSES 7–19

7 Solomon had 12 officers over all Israel.
They supplied food for the king and his household.
Each one had to supply the food for one month of the year.
8 These are their names:
Ben Hur, in the hill country of Ephraim.
9 Ben Deker, in Makaz, in Shaalbim, Beth Shemesh, and Elon Beth Hanan.
10 Ben Hesed, in Arubboth.
Socoh and all the land of Hepher belonged to him.
11 Ben Abinadab, in all the hills of Dor.
His wife was Taphath, Solomon's daughter.
12 Baana, the son of Ahilud, in Taanach and Megiddo.
He also had all of Beth Shean, which is next to Zarethan, below Jezreel.
His area went from Beth Shean to Abel Meholah and on past Jokmeam.
13 Ben Geber, in Ramoth Gilead.
The towns of Jair, the son of Manasseh, in Gilead belonged to him.
The region of Argob in Bashan also belonged to him.
There were 60 great cities there, with walls and bronze bars on the gates.
14 Ahinadab, the son of Iddo, in Mahanaim.
15 Ahimaaz, in Naphtali.
He also married Basemath, the daughter of Solomon.
16 Baana, the son of Hushai, in Asher and Bealoth.
17 Jehoshaphat, the son of Paruah, in Issachar.
18 Shimei, the son of Ela, in Benjamin.
19 Geber, the son of Uri, in the land of Gilead.
This was the country of Sihon, king of the Amorites, and of Og, king of Bashan.
He was the only officer in that land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon divides the land into 12 districts. Each district has to provide food for the whole royal court for one month a year. That was a kind of tax.

Interesting: the districts do not follow the old borders of the tribes exactly. And Judah, Solomon's own tribe, is not named. Maybe Judah had to pay less. Later that made the northern tribes very angry.

Two of the officers are married to daughters of Solomon. In this way Solomon ties important men to his family.

Ahimaaz may be the son of Zadok who had served David as a messenger (2 Samuel 18). And Baana the son of Hushai may be the son of David's faithful friend.

Wealth and peace VERSES 20–28

20 There were as many people in Judah and Israel as there is sand by the sea.
They ate and drank and were happy.
21 Solomon ruled over all the kingdoms from the River to the land of the Philistines.
He ruled as far as the border of Egypt.
These kingdoms brought tribute and served Solomon as long as he lived.
Tribute is money or goods that a defeated people must pay to the ruler.
22 Each day Solomon's court needed this much food:
30 cors of fine flour (about 180 bushels)
and 60 measures of meal (about 360 bushels),
23 10 fattened cattle, 20 cattle from the pastures, and 100 sheep.
There were also deer, gazelles, roebucks, and fattened birds.
24 He ruled over everything on this side of the River, from Tiphsah to Gaza.
He ruled over all the kings on this side of the River.
He had peace on all sides.
25 Judah and Israel lived in safety, from Dan to Beersheba.
Each man lived under his vine and under his fig tree.
It was like this as long as Solomon lived.
26 Solomon had 40,000 stalls of horses for his chariots.
He had 12,000 horsemen.
27 The officers supplied food for King Solomon and for all who came to eat at King Solomon's table.

Each one did it in his month.
They made sure that nothing was missing.
28 They also brought barley and straw for the horses and the swift horses.
They brought it to the place where the officers were.
Each one did what he was told to do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles these verses are already chapter 5, verses 1–8. From here to the end of this chapter, the numbering is shifted by one chapter.

This is the golden age of Israel. The people are many, they have enough to eat, they live in peace and joy. God's promise to Abraham seems to have come true: "I will make your descendants very many, as many as the stars in the sky and as the sand on the seashore" (Genesis 22:17).

"The River" is the Euphrates. Solomon's power reaches from the Euphrates in the north to Egypt in the south.

"Each man lived under his vine and under his fig tree": this is a picture of peace and wealth: everyone can live calmly from what he grows. Later the prophets used this picture for the time of peace that God will give (Micah 4:4).

Solomon's court uses huge amounts. The Bible says "30 cors of fine flour and 60 measures of meal." Here "measure" is also a cor. A cor is about 6 bushels. So 60 cors are more than 350 bushels. This shows how big the royal court was, maybe several thousand people.

40,000 stalls: 2 Chronicles 9:25 says 4,000. That fits better with the 12,000 horsemen.

Horses and chariots in large numbers: the law had warned the king against this (Deuteronomy 17:16). Behind the shine, the first shadows already show.

Solomon's wisdom VERSES 29–34

29 God gave Solomon very much wisdom and understanding.
He gave him a mind as wide as the sand on the seashore.
30 Solomon was wiser than all the people of the east.
He was wiser than all the wise people of Egypt.
31 He was wiser than anyone else.
He was wiser than Ethan the Ezrahite, and Heman, Calcol, and Darda, the sons of Mahol.
He was famous in all the nations around.
32 He spoke 3,000 proverbs.
A proverb is a short, wise saying.
He wrote 1,005 songs.
33 He spoke about trees,
from the cedar in Lebanon to the hyssop that grows out of the wall.
He also spoke about animals, birds, creeping animals, and fish.
34 People from all nations came to hear Solomon's wisdom.
They were sent by all the kings of the earth
who had heard of his wisdom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon's wisdom was famous in the whole world. In those days there were famous teachers of wisdom in Egypt and in the east, in Mesopotamia. Solomon is greater than all of them.

Ethan and Heman were famous wise men. Psalm 88 and Psalm 89 are named after them.

Solomon wrote proverbs and songs. Many proverbs in the book of Proverbs are said to come from him (Proverbs 1:1), and so is the Song of Songs (Song of Songs 1:1).

Solomon is also interested in nature: plants and animals. The cedar is the biggest and most splendid tree, hyssop is a small plant that grows in cracks in walls. He observes everything, from the biggest to the smallest. In the Bible, wisdom also means understanding God's creation.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 5

Getting ready to build the temple

Solomon writes to Hiram VERSES 1–6

1 Hiram king of Tyre sent his servants to Solomon,
for he had heard that they had anointed him king in the place of his father.
And Hiram had always loved David.
2 Solomon sent a message to Hiram:
3 "You know that my father David could not build a house for the name of the LORD his God
because of the wars that were around him on every side,
until the LORD put his enemies under the soles of his feet.
4 But now the LORD my God has given me rest on every side.
There is no enemy and no misfortune.
5 So I plan to build a house for the name of the LORD my God,
as the LORD said to my father David:
'Your son, whom I will set on your throne in your place,
will build the house for my name.'
6 So now give the command that cedar trees be cut for me in Lebanon.
My servants will be with your servants.
And I will pay you wages for your servants, whatever you say.
For you know that there is no one among us who knows how to cut timber like the Sidonians."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles this chapter is numbered differently. Verse 1 here is chapter 5, verse 15 there. Verse 18 here is verse 32 there.

Hiram was a friend of David. He had already built a palace for David (2 Samuel 5:11).

Solomon explains: my father could not build the temple because he had to fight wars. 1 Chronicles 22:8 gives another reason as well: David had shed too much blood.

Now there is peace. And Solomon fulfills the promise that God had given to David (2 Samuel 7:13).

"A house for the name of the LORD": God does not really live in a house like a person. But his "name," that is, his presence, is to be there.
The Sidonians, the people of Tyre and Sidon, were famous craftsmen and seafarers. Israel itself had no experts that good.

The agreement with Hiram VERSES 7–12

7 When Hiram heard Solomon's words, he was very glad
and said,
"Blessed be the LORD today,
who has given David a wise son to rule over this great people."
8 Hiram sent a message to Solomon:
"I have heard the message that you sent me.
I will do everything you wish with the cedar timber
and the cypress timber.
9 My servants will bring it down from Lebanon to the sea.
I will make it into rafts to go by sea to the place that you name to me.
There I will have the rafts broken up, and you can take the timber.
And you will do what I wish, by giving food for my household."
10 So Hiram gave Solomon cedar timber and cypress timber, as much as he wanted.
11 And Solomon gave Hiram 20,000 cors of wheat (about 120,000 bushels) as food for his household,
and 20 cors of pure oil (about 1,160 gallons).
Solomon gave this to Hiram year after year.
12 The LORD gave Solomon wisdom, as he had promised him.
And there was peace between Hiram and Solomon,
and the two of them made a treaty with each other.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hiram, a king who does not worship the LORD as his God, praises the God of Israel. Solomon's fame also makes God known among other peoples.

It is a trade agreement: timber for food. Tyre was a city by the sea with little farmland. Israel had a lot of grain.

The timber was carried in rafts on the sea along the coast, probably to Joppa. From there it was brought to Jerusalem (2 Chronicles 2:16).

The Bible says "20,000 cors of wheat" and "20 cors of oil." A cor is about 6 bushels, or about 58 gallons. The old Greek translation and 2 Chronicles 2:10 have a much larger amount of oil.

"The LORD gave Solomon wisdom": his wisdom also shows in the fact that he makes peace with his neighbors.

The forced labor VERSES 13–18

13 King Solomon drafted forced laborers out of all Israel.
There were 30,000 men.
14 He sent them to Lebanon, 10,000 a month, taking turns.
They were in Lebanon for 1 month and at home for 2 months.
And Adoniram was over the men who had to do forced labor.
15 Solomon had 70,000 who carried loads
and 80,000 who cut stone in the mountains,
16 besides Solomon's chief officers who were over the work:
3,300 who ruled over the people who did the work.
17 The king gave the command,
and they cut out large stones, costly stones,
to lay the foundation of the house with shaped stone.
18 Solomon's builders and Hiram's builders and the Gebalites
cut them and prepared the timber and the stones to build the house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To build the temple, Solomon needs many workers. He forces men from Israel to work. They have to take turns working in Lebanon for one month, and then they may go home for two months.

This reminds us of Samuel's warning: the king will take your sons for his work (1 Samuel 8:16). And it reminds us of the forced labor that Israel once had to do in Egypt (Exodus 1:11). The splendid temple was built with the burden of many people.

Chapter 9 says that Solomon did not make Israelites into slaves (1 Kings 9:22). The 150,000 who carried loads and cut stone were probably mostly non-Israelites who were still living in the land (2 Chronicles 2:17–18).

2 Chronicles 2:18 says 3,600 overseers instead of 3,300.

Gebal is the city of Byblos in what is Lebanon today. Its people were famous stonemasons.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 6

Building the temple

When and how big VERSES 1–10

1 In the 480th year after the people of Israel had come out of the land of Egypt,
in the fourth year of Solomon's rule over Israel,
in the month of Ziv, which is the second month,
he began to build the LORD's house.
2 The house that King Solomon built for the LORD was about 90 feet long, 30 feet wide, and 45 feet high.
3 The porch in front of the main hall of the house was 30 feet long,
along the width of the house,
and 15 feet deep in front of the house.
4 He made windows with fixed lattice work for the house.
5 Against the wall of the house he built floors all around,
against the walls of the house all around, both of the main hall and of the inner room.
And he made side rooms all around.

6 The lowest floor was about 7½ feet wide,
the middle one was 9 feet wide,
and the third was 10½ feet wide.
For on the outside he made ledges in the wall of the house all around,
so that the beams would not have to be set into the walls of the house.
7 When the house was being built, it was built of stone that had been prepared at the quarry.
No hammer or ax or any iron tool was heard in the house
while it was being built.
8 The door to the middle side rooms was on the right side of the house.
People went up by winding stairs to the middle floor, and from the middle floor to the third.
9 So he built the house and finished it.
He covered the house with beams and boards of cedar.
10 He built the floors all along the house, each about 7½ feet high.
And they rested on the house with cedar beams.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The building of the temple is a high point in the history of Israel. That is why the time is given exactly: 480 years after the exodus from Egypt. 480 is 12 times 40: 12 generations of 40 years each. Maybe the number is also meant as a symbol. Scholars usually date the building of the temple to about 960 BC.

The month of Ziv is about April to May, in spring.

The Bible gives the measurements in cubits. A cubit is about 18 inches. The temple was 60 cubits long, 20 wide, and 30 high. The porch was 20 by 10 cubits. The floors were 5, 6, and 7 cubits wide and each 5 cubits high.

The temple was not huge, about the size of a small church today. But it was very splendid. It was not meant for large gatherings. The people gathered outside in the courtyards. Inside, only the priests served.

Verse 7: the stones were already shaped at the quarry. At the temple itself no noise of tools was heard. God's house was to be built in silence and awe. Iron was also connected with war and weapons (compare Exodus 20:25).

God's promise during the building VERSES 11–14

11 Then the word of the LORD came to Solomon:
12 "About this house that you are building:
if you walk in my laws
and follow my rules
and keep all my commandments and walk in them,
then I will fulfill with you my word that I spoke to your father David.
13 I will live among the people of Israel
and will not abandon my people Israel."
14 So Solomon built the house and finished it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the description of the building, God speaks. He reminds Solomon: the splendid building is not the most important thing, but obedience. God does not live with his people because of the stones and the gold, but when the people are faithful to him.

Later the prophets warned: do not trust in the temple, as if God had to protect you no matter how you live (Jeremiah 7:4). The temple was in fact destroyed later, when the people became unfaithful to God.

Inside the temple VERSES 15–22

15 He built the walls of the house on the inside with cedar boards,
from the floor of the house to the beams of the ceiling.
He covered them on the inside with wood.
And he covered the floor of the house with cypress boards.
16 He built the back 30 feet of the house with cedar boards,
from the floor to the ceiling.
He built this inside as an inner room, as the most holy place.
17 The main hall in front of it was 60 feet long.
18 On the inside of the house there was cedar,
carved with buds and open flowers.
All was cedar. No stone could be seen.
19 He prepared an inner room in the middle of the house, to set the ark of the LORD's covenant there.
20 The inner room was 30 feet long, 30 feet wide, and 30 feet high.
He covered it with pure gold.
And he covered the altar with cedar.
21 So Solomon covered the inside of the house with pure gold.
He stretched gold chains across in front of the inner room,
and he covered it with gold.
22 He covered the whole house with gold, until the whole house was finished.
He also covered with gold the whole altar that belonged to the inner room.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple had three parts: the porch, the main hall (the holy place), and at the very back the most holy place.

The Bible says: the most holy place was 20 cubits long, wide, and high, a perfect cube. The main hall was 40 cubits long. The cube was a sign of perfection. In the New Testament the heavenly Jerusalem is also described as a cube (Revelation 21:16).

The ark of the covenant is put into the most holy place. Only the high priest was allowed to go in there, once a year on the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 16).

The walls were covered with cedar, with carved flowers and buds, and everything was covered with gold. The temple was like a garden, like the Garden of Eden, where God and people met.

The "altar" in front of the most holy place was the altar of incense, on which incense was burned.

The cherubim VERSES 23–28

23 In the inner room he made two cherubim of olive wood,
each 15 feet high.
24 One wing of the cherub was 7½ feet long,
and the other wing of the cherub was 7½ feet long.
From the tip of one wing to the tip of the other wing was 15 feet.

25 The other cherub was also 15 feet.
Both cherubim had the same size and the same shape.
26 One cherub was 15 feet high, and so was the other cherub.
27 He set the cherubim inside the inner room.
The wings of the cherubim were spread out,
so that the wing of one touched one wall
and the wing of the other cherub touched the other wall.
And their wings touched each other in the middle of the room.
28 He covered the cherubim with gold.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cherubim are angel-like beings with wings. In the Bible they guarded what is holy. After the first sin, cherubim guarded the way to the tree of life (Genesis 3:24).

The Bible says: each cherub was 10 cubits high, each wing 5 cubits long. Together their wings reached from wall to wall, across the whole width of the most holy place: 20 cubits.

The ark of the covenant stood under the wings of the cherubim. The ark was seen as the footstool of God's throne. People thought of God as sitting on his throne, unseen, above the cherubim (1 Samuel 4:4).

Important: there was no image of God in the temple. The place above the cherubim was empty. God cannot be pictured (Exodus 20:4).

Carvings and doors VERSES 29–36

29 On all the walls of the house all around he carved figures of cherubim,
palm trees, and open flowers, inside and outside.
30 He covered the floor of the house with gold, inside and outside.
31 For the entrance of the inner room he made doors of olive wood.
The top beam and the door posts were a fifth part of the wall.
32 So he made two doors of olive wood.
He carved on them figures of cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers,
and covered them with gold.
He spread the gold over the cherubim and over the palm trees.
33 For the entrance of the main hall he also made door posts of olive wood,
out of a fourth part of the wall,
34 and two doors of cypress wood.
The two leaves of one door were folding,
and the two leaves of the other door were folding.
35 He carved cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers,
and covered them with gold fitted exactly on the carving.
36 He built the inner court
with three rows of cut stone and one row of cedar beams.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Everywhere in the temple there are cherubim, palm trees, and flowers. It is like a picture of paradise. Whoever enters the temple is meant to feel as if they were in God's garden.

"A fifth part of the wall" and "a fourth part of the wall": the Hebrew words in verses 31 and 33 are hard to understand. Maybe they describe the shape of the door frames.

The "inner court" was the court of the priests, right around the temple. The great altar for burnt offerings stood there.

Seven years of building VERSES 37–38

37 In the fourth year, in the month of Ziv, the foundation of the LORD's house was laid.
38 And in the eleventh year, in the month of Bul, which is the eighth month,
the house was finished in all its parts and according to all its plans.
So he spent seven years building it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The month of Bul is about October to November.

From the second month of the fourth year to the eighth month of the eleventh year is, counted exactly, seven and a half years. The Bible says it in round numbers: seven years. In the Bible the number seven often stands for completeness, like the seven days of creation.

In the next chapter we will read that Solomon spent 13 years building his own palace, almost twice as long (1 Kings 7:1).

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 7

Solomon's palace and the furnishings for the temple

Solomon's palace VERSES 1–12

1 Solomon spent 13 years building his own house,
and he finished his whole house.
2 For he built the House of the Forest of Lebanon.
It was about 150 feet long, 75 feet wide, and 45 feet high,
on four rows of cedar pillars, with cedar beams on the pillars.
3 It was covered with cedar above,
over the 45 beams that were on the pillars, 15 in a row.
4 There were beams in three rows,
and window was facing window in three rows.
5 All the doors and posts were made square with beams,
and window was facing window in three rows.
6 He made the hall of pillars.
It was about 75 feet long and 45 feet wide,
with a porch in front of them,
and pillars and a threshold in front of them.
7 He made the hall of the throne, where he was to judge,
the hall of judgment.
It was covered with cedar from floor to floor.
8 His house where he was to live, in the other court behind the hall,
was built in the same way.
He also made a house for Pharaoh's daughter, whom

Solomon had taken as his wife,
like this hall.
9 All these buildings were made of costly stones,
of stones cut to measure and sawed with saws, inside and outside,
from the foundation to the top edge,
and on the outside to the great court.
10 The foundation was made of costly stones, great stones,
stones of about 15 feet and stones of about 12 feet.
11 Above them were costly stones, cut to measure, and cedar wood.
12 The great court around had three rows of cut stone and one row of cedar beams,
like the inner court of the LORD's house and the porch of the house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon spent 7 years building the temple, but 13 years building his own palace (1 Kings 6:38). And the palace was much bigger than the temple. The storyteller simply puts the two side by side. You can ask yourself: what was more important to Solomon?

The Bible gives the measurements in cubits: the House of the Forest of Lebanon was 100 cubits long, 50 wide, and 30 high, the hall of pillars 50 by 30 cubits, the foundation stones 10 and 8 cubits. A cubit is about 18 inches.

The building was called the "House of the Forest of Lebanon" because it had so many pillars of cedar wood from Lebanon. Inside it looked like a forest. Later weapons were also kept there (1 Kings 10:17).

In the hall of judgment the king judged cases, as Solomon did in the dispute of the two mothers (Chapter 3).

"From floor to floor": that is what the Hebrew text says. Maybe it means: from the floor to the ceiling beams.

Hiram, the bronze worker VERSES 13–14

13 King Solomon sent for Hiram and brought him from Tyre.
14 He was the son of a widow from the tribe of Naphtali,
and his father was a man of Tyre, a worker in bronze.
He was filled with wisdom, understanding, and skill
to do all kinds of work in bronze.
He came to King Solomon and did all his work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This Hiram is not King Hiram, but a craftsman with the same name.

He is half Israelite, half foreigner. He is said to be "filled with wisdom," like Bezalel, who built the Tabernacle in the wilderness (Exodus 31:3). Skill with one's hands is also a gift of God.

The two pillars, Jachin and Boaz VERSES 15–22

15 He shaped the two pillars of bronze.
Each was about 27 feet high,
and a line of about 18 feet went around each of them.
16 He made two capitals of cast bronze
to set on the tops of the pillars.
A capital is the top part of a pillar.
One capital was about 7½ feet high,
and the other capital was about 7½ feet high.
17 There were nets of checker work and wreaths of chain work for the capitals on the top of the pillars,
seven for one capital and seven for the other capital.
18 So he made the pillars.
And there were two rows of pomegranates around the one network,
to cover the capitals on the top of the pillars.
And he did the same for the other capital.
19 The capitals on the top of the pillars in the porch
were made like lilies, about 6 feet.
20 There were also capitals above on both pillars,
close to the rounded part that was beside the network.
And there were 200 pomegranates in rows around the other capital.
21 He set up the pillars at the porch of the temple.
He set up the right pillar and named it Jachin.
And he set up the left pillar and named it Boaz.
22 On the tops of the pillars was lily work.
So the work on the pillars was finished.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible gives the measurements in cubits: the pillars were 18 cubits high and 12 cubits around, the capitals 5 cubits high each, the lily work 4 cubits.

The two pillars stood by themselves in front of the entrance of the temple. They did not hold anything up. They were signs.

Their names have a meaning: "Jachin" means "He (God) will make firm." "Boaz" probably means "In him is strength." Whoever went into the temple was reminded: God gives support and strength. Boaz was also the name of David's great-grandfather (Ruth 4).

Pomegranates and lilies were signs of fruitfulness, life, and beauty.

Some details in these verses are hard to understand in Hebrew. Bible scholars imagine the capitals in different ways.

The sea of bronze VERSES 23–26

23 He made the cast sea.
It was about 15 feet from rim to rim, round in shape.
It was about 7½ feet high.
And a line of about 45 feet went around it.
24 Under its rim all around there were buds that went around it
for about 15 feet, all around the sea.
The buds were in two rows,
cast together with it when it was cast.
25 It stood on 12 oxen:
3 looked toward the north, 3 looked toward the west,
3 looked toward the south, and 3 looked toward the east.
The sea was set on top of them,
and their back parts were all turned inward.
26 It was a handbreadth thick.
A handbreadth is about 3 inches.
Its rim was made like the rim of a cup, like a lily flower.
It held about 11,500 gallons.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "sea" was a huge water basin made of bronze. 2 Chronicles 4:6 tells us what it was for: the priests washed in it.

The Bible says: 10 cubits across, 5 cubits high, 30 cubits around. It held 2,000 baths. A bath is about 6 gallons.

Some people ask: if it is 10 cubits across, it should be more than 31 cubits around, not 30. The Bible rounds the number here. Or the width was measured on the outside of the rim, and the line around it was measured below. The Bible is not a math book. It describes the basin in round numbers.

In verse 24 the WEB, our English source text, says "ten cubits." The Hebrew probably means "ten to a cubit," that is, 10 buds for each cubit.

The 12 oxen remind us of the 12 tribes of Israel.

The word "sea" may also remind us that God rules over the sea and has tamed it (Genesis 1; Psalm 93).

The 10 carts with basins VERSES 27–39

27 He made the 10 stands of bronze.
Each stand was about 6 feet long, 6 feet wide, and 4½ feet high.
28 The stands were made like this:
they had panels, and the panels were between the frames.
29 On the panels between the frames were lions, oxen, and cherubim.
And on the frames there was a stand above.
Below the lions and oxen were hanging wreaths.
30 Each stand had four bronze wheels and bronze axles.
And its four feet had supports.
The supports were cast below the basin, with wreaths at the side of each.
31 Its opening inside the top and above was about 18 inches.
The opening was round like the work of a stand, about 27 inches.
There were also carvings at its opening.
And their panels were square, not round.
32 The four wheels were under the panels,
and the axles of the wheels were on the stand.
A wheel was about 27 inches high.
33 The wheels were made like the wheels of a chariot.
Their axles, rims, spokes, and hubs were all cast metal.
34 There were four supports at the four corners of each stand.
The supports were of one piece with the stand.
35 On the top of the stand there was a round band, about 9 inches high.
And on the top of the stand, its supports and its panels were of one piece with it.
36 On the surfaces of its supports and on its panels
he carved cherubim, lions, and palm trees,
each in its space, with wreaths all around.
37 So he made the 10 stands.
All of them had one casting, one measure, and one form.
38 He made 10 basins of bronze.
One basin held about 230 gallons.
Each basin measured about 6 feet.
There was one basin on each of the 10 stands.
39 He set the stands,
five on the right side of the house and five on the left side of the house.
He set the sea on the right side of the house, toward the east and the south.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These were water basins on wheels that could be moved. In them the parts of the animals for the offerings were washed (2 Chronicles 4:6).

The Bible gives the measurements in cubits: the stands were 4 by 4 by 3 cubits, the opening 1 and 1½ cubits, the wheels 1½ cubits high, the band half a cubit. Each basin held 40 baths and measured 4 cubits.

Archaeologists have found similar smaller carts with basins from this time in Cyprus. In Hebrew the description is hard to understand in many places.

Again we see the pictures of lions, oxen, cherubim, and palm trees: strength, fruitfulness, and God's nearness.

More of Hiram's work VERSES 40–47

40 Hiram made the pots, the shovels, and the basins.
So Hiram finished all the work that he did for King Solomon in the LORD's house:
41 the two pillars;
the two bowls of the capitals on the top of the pillars;
the two networks to cover the two bowls of the capitals on the top of the pillars;
42 the 400 pomegranates for the 2 networks,
2 rows of pomegranates for each network,
to cover the 2 bowls of the capitals on the pillars;
43 the 10 stands and the 10 basins on the stands;
44 the single sea and the 12 oxen under the sea;
45 the pots, the shovels, and the basins.
All these things that Hiram made for King Solomon for the LORD's house
were made of polished bronze.
46 The king cast them in the plain of the Jordan,
in the clay ground between Succoth and Zarethan.
47 Solomon left all the things unweighed, because there were so very many of them.
The weight of the bronze could not be found out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here everything is counted up once more, like in a list.

The large bronze pieces were cast in the Jordan valley. The clay ground there was good for making molds.

So much bronze was used that it could not be weighed. This shows the great wealth.

The gold furnishings VERSES 48–51

48 Solomon made all the things that were in the LORD's house:
the golden altar,
and the table of gold on which the show bread lay;
49 and the lampstands of pure gold,
five on the right side and five on the left, in front of the inner room;
and the flowers, the lamps, and the tongs of gold;
50 the cups, the snuffers, the basins, the spoons, and the fire pans of pure gold;
and the hinges of gold, both for the doors of the inner house, the most holy place,
and for the doors of the house, the main hall.
51 So all the work that King Solomon did in the LORD's house was finished.
Solomon brought in the things that his father David had dedicated:

the silver, the gold, and the vessels.
He put them in the treasuries of the LORD's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Outside there was bronze, inside there was gold. The closer you came to the most holy place, the more precious everything became.

The "golden altar" was the altar of incense. The 12 loaves of show bread lay on the table (Leviticus 24:5–9). In the Tabernacle there was one lampstand with seven branches. In the temple there were 10 lampstands.

Solomon also brings in the treasures that David had collected. So the temple is the shared work of father and son.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 8

The dedication of the temple

The ark comes into the temple VERSES 1–9

1 Then Solomon called the elders of Israel to come to him
in Jerusalem.
He called all the heads of the tribes
and the leaders of the families of the people of Israel.
They were to bring up the ark of the LORD's covenant
out of David's city.
David's city is Zion.
2 All the men of Israel came together to King Solomon at
the feast.
It was in the month of Ethanim, the seventh month.
3 All the elders of Israel came.
The priests picked up the ark.
4 They brought up the LORD's ark,
the Tent of Meeting, and all the holy things that were
in the Tent.
The priests and the Levites brought these up.
5 King Solomon and the whole community of Israel
were gathered with him before the ark.
They sacrificed sheep and cattle.
There were so many that no one could count them.
6 The priests brought the ark of the LORD's covenant to
its place.
They brought it into the inner room of the house, the
most holy place.
They put it under the wings of the cherubim.
Cherubim are heavenly beings with wings.
7 The cherubim spread out their wings over the place of
the ark.
So the cherubim covered the ark and its poles from
above.
8 The poles were very long.
The ends of the poles could be seen from the holy place
in front of the inner room.
But they could not be seen from outside.
They are there to this day.
9 There was nothing in the ark except the two stone
tablets.
Moses had put them there at Horeb.
That was when the LORD made a covenant with the
people of Israel,
when they came out of the land of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The month of Ethanim is about September to October. "The feast" is the Feast of Tabernacles, the great feast in the fall. At this feast people remembered how God had gone with Israel in the wilderness.

The ark is carried from the fortress of Zion, where David had brought it (2 Samuel 6), up into the new temple. This time it is carried the right way, by the priests.

The ark is placed under the wings of the cherubim, in the most holy place. From now on, this is the holiest place in Israel.

In the ark there were only the two stone tablets with the Ten Commandments. At the heart of the temple there is not gold, but God's word and his covenant.

"To this day": when this text was written, the temple was probably still standing. Later, when Jerusalem was destroyed, the ark was lost. No one knows what happened to it.

Horeb is another name for Mount Sinai.

The cloud fills the house VERSES 10–13

10 The priests came out of the holy place.
Then the cloud filled the LORD's house.
11 Because of the cloud, the priests could not stand there
to do their work.
The glory of the LORD filled the LORD's house.
12 Then Solomon said,
"The LORD has said that he would live in the thick
darkness.
13 I have built you a house to live in.
It is a place for you to live in forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the high point: God himself accepts the house. The cloud, the sign of his presence, fills the temple. It was the same with the Tabernacle in the wilderness (Exodus 40:34–35).

God's glory is so strong that even the priests cannot stay.

"Live in the thick darkness": God is a mystery. No one can see him. At Mount Sinai, too, God was in a thick, dark cloud (Exodus 20:21). The most holy place had no windows.

Solomon blesses the people VERSES 14–21

14 The king turned around.
He blessed the whole assembly of Israel,
while the whole assembly of Israel stood there.
15 He said,
"Praise the LORD, the God of Israel!
With his mouth he made a promise to David, your
father.
With his hand he has done what he promised.
He said,
16 'I brought my people Israel out of Egypt.
Since that day, I have not chosen a city in any of the

tribes of Israel
to build a house where my name would be.
But I chose David to rule over my people Israel.'
17 My father David wanted with all his heart
to build a house for the name of the LORD, the God of Israel.
18 But the LORD said to my father David,
'You wanted with all your heart to build a house for my name.
It was good that you wanted this.
19 But you will not build the house.
Your own son will build the house for my name.'
20 The LORD has kept the promise that he made.
I have taken the place of my father David.
I sit on the throne of Israel, as the LORD promised.
And I have built the house for the name of the LORD, the God of Israel.
21 There I have made a place for the ark.
In it is the covenant of the LORD.
He made it with our ancestors when he brought them out of the land of Egypt."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon says again and again: God has kept his word. What he promised David, he has fulfilled.

Verse 18 is beautiful: God praises David for the good wish in his heart, even though he was not allowed to carry it out himself. God already sees the good intention.

Solomon's prayer: God, listen! VERSES 22–30

22 Solomon stood in front of the altar of the LORD,
before the whole assembly of Israel.
He spread out his hands toward heaven.
23 He said,
"LORD, God of Israel,
there is no God like you, in heaven above or on earth below.
You keep your covenant and your faithful love with your servants
who walk before you with all their heart.
24 You have kept your promise to your servant, my father David.
Yes, you spoke with your mouth, and with your hand you have done it, as we see today.
25 And now, LORD, God of Israel,
keep the promise you made to your servant, my father David.
You said to him,
'There will always be a man from your family on the throne of Israel before me,
if only your children are careful how they live
and walk before me as you have walked before me.'
26 And now, God of Israel, please let your word come true,
the word you spoke to your servant, my father David.
27 "But will God really live on the earth?
Look, the heavens, even the highest heavens, cannot hold you.
So this house that I have built can hold you even less!
28 But LORD, my God, please turn to the prayer of your servant and to his plea.
Listen to the cry and the prayer that your servant prays before you today.
29 May your eyes be open toward this house night and day.
You have said about this place, 'My name will be there.'
Listen to the prayer that your servant prays toward this place.
30 Listen to the plea of your servant and of your people Israel
when they pray toward this place.
Yes, listen in heaven, where you live.
And when you listen, forgive.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon prays with his hands spread out toward heaven. In those days that was a common way to stand when praying.

Verse 27 is one of the most important sentences of the prayer: God is so great that not even heaven can hold him. How then could a house of stone? Solomon knows: the temple is not God's prison. God is everywhere. But the temple is a place where people can meet God and pray to him.

The most important word in the whole prayer is: "Listen." And then: "Forgive." Solomon knows that people become guilty again and again. That is why the temple is above all a place of forgiveness.

To this day, Jews all over the world pray facing toward Jerusalem.

Seven requests for the people VERSES 31–53

31 "Someone may sin against his neighbor
and be made to swear an oath.
He may come and swear in front of your altar in this house.
32 Then listen in heaven and act.
Judge your servants.
Find the guilty one guilty, and let what he did come back on his own head.
Find the one who did right innocent, and reward him for the right he has done.
33 "Your people Israel may lose a battle against an enemy because they have sinned against you.
Then they may turn back to you and praise your name.
They may pray and plead with you in this house.
34 Then listen in heaven.
Forgive the sin of your people Israel.
Bring them back to the land that you gave to their ancestors.
35 "The sky may be shut, so that there is no rain,
because the people have sinned against you.
You may punish them.
Then they may pray toward this place and praise your name
and turn away from their sin.
36 Then listen in heaven.
Forgive the sin of your servants and of your people Israel.
Teach them the good way in which they should live.
And send rain on your land.
You have given it to your people to own.
37 "There may be famine in the land.
There may be disease, or crops may dry up or get moldy.
There may be locusts or caterpillars.
An enemy may surround them in their land and their

cities.
There may be any trouble or any sickness.
38 Then any person or all your people Israel may pray and plead.
Each one may know the trouble of his own heart
and spread out his hands toward this house.
39 Then listen in heaven, where you live.
Forgive and act.
Give each person what all his ways deserve.
You know his heart.
You alone know the hearts of all people.
40 Then they will have respect for you all the days they live in the land that you gave to our ancestors.
41 "A foreigner who is not one of your people Israel may also come from a far country because of your name.
42 People will hear of your great name,
of your strong hand and of your outstretched arm.
So a foreigner may come and pray toward this house.
43 Then listen in heaven, where you live.
Do everything that the foreigner asks you for.
Then all the peoples of the earth will know your name.
They will have respect for you, as your people Israel do.
And they will know that this house that I have built is called by your name.
44 "Your people may go out to battle against their enemy, wherever you send them.
They may pray to the LORD toward the city that you have chosen
and toward the house that I have built for your name.
45 Then listen in heaven to their prayer and their plea.
Help them win their cause.
46 "They may sin against you.
There is no one who doesn't sin.
You may be angry with them and hand them over to the enemy.
The enemy may take them away as prisoners to the enemy's land, far away or near.
47 Then they may come to their senses in the land where they are prisoners.
They may turn back and plead with you in the land of those who took them away.
They may say,
'We have sinned and done wrong. We have done evil.'
48 They may come back to you with all their heart and with all their soul
in the land of their enemies who took them away.
They may pray to you toward their land, which you gave to their ancestors,
toward the city that you have chosen,
and toward the house that I have built for your name.
49 Then listen in heaven, where you live, to their prayer and their plea.
Help them win their cause.
50 Forgive your people who have sinned against you.
Forgive all the wrong things they have done against you.
Make those who took them away kind to them,
so that they show them mercy.
51 They are your people.
They belong to you.
You brought them out of Egypt, out of the furnace for iron.
52 May your eyes be open to the plea of your servant
and to the plea of your people Israel.
Listen to them whenever they cry out to you.
53 You set them apart from all the peoples of the earth to belong to you.
You said this through your servant Moses
when you brought our ancestors out of Egypt, Lord GOD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon prays for many situations in which people in need pray to God: in a dispute in court, in a defeat in war, in a drought, in famine and sickness, and even as captives in a foreign land.

Again and again: "Listen in heaven." And: "Forgive." Solomon knows: "There is no one who doesn't sin" (verse 46). That is why everyone needs God's forgiveness.

Verse 38 says: "Each one may know the trouble of his own heart." God also hears the very personal prayer of a single person.

The request for the foreigner is especially beautiful (verses 41–43): people from other nations should also be allowed to pray to God, and God should answer them. The temple is not only there for Israel. Later Jesus quoted the prophet Isaiah: "My house will be called a house of prayer for all the nations" (Mark 11:17; Isaiah 56:7).

The last request (verses 46–53) sounds like a sense of what was coming: what if Israel is taken captive? That is exactly what happened later, in the exile to Babylon. There Daniel prayed three times a day with his windows open toward Jerusalem (Daniel 6:10). For the captives these verses were a great hope: even far away, God hears us.

"The furnace for iron" is a picture of the hard slavery in Egypt.

Solomon's blessing VERSES 54–61

54 Solomon finished praying all this prayer and plea to the LORD.
He had been kneeling in front of the LORD's altar,
with his hands spread out toward heaven.
Then he got up.
55 He stood and blessed the whole assembly of Israel with a loud voice.
He said,
56 "Praise the LORD!
He has given rest to his people Israel, just as he promised.
Not one word has failed of all his good promise
that he made through his servant Moses.
57 May the LORD our God be with us as he was with our ancestors.
May he never leave us or give up on us.
58 May he turn our hearts to himself,
so that we live in all his ways
and keep his commandments, his rules, and his laws.
He gave them to our ancestors.
59 I have pleaded with the LORD with these words.
May they stay near the LORD our God day and night.
Then he will help his servant and his people Israel win

their cause,
as each day needs.
60 Then all the peoples of the earth will know
that the LORD is God.
There is no one else.
61 So let your heart be fully devoted to the LORD our God.
Live by his rules and keep his commandments, as you
do today."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon had been kneeling while he prayed. Now he stands up and blesses the people.

"Not one word has failed of all his good promise": that is a great confession of faith. God keeps what he promises. You can rely on his word.

Solomon asks: may God turn our hearts to himself. He knows: we cannot stay faithful to God by our own strength. We need God's help for that.

At the end comes the warning: "Let your heart be fully devoted to the LORD our God." Sadly, it is Solomon himself who will not follow this warning later (1 Kings 11:4).

The great feast VERSES 62–66

62 The king and all Israel with him offered sacrifices
before the LORD.
63 Solomon offered peace offerings to the LORD:
22,000 cattle and 120,000 sheep.
In this way the king and all the people of Israel
dedicated the LORD's house.
To dedicate means: to give something to God in a
special way.
64 On the same day the king made the middle of the
courtyard holy.
It was in front of the LORD's house.
There he offered the burnt offering, the grain
offering, and the fat of the peace offerings.
The bronze altar before the LORD was too small for all
of them.
65 So at that time Solomon held the feast, and all Israel
with him.
It was a great assembly.
People came from the entrance of Hamath to the
brook of Egypt.
They celebrated before the LORD our God
for 7 days and 7 more days, 14 days in all.
66 On the eighth day he sent the people away.
They blessed the king.
Then they went home to their tents.
They were joyful and glad in their hearts
for all the good things the LORD had done for his
servant David and for his people Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The number of animals offered is huge. The meat of the peace offerings was eaten together. So it became a great feast for the whole people.

"From the entrance of Hamath to the brook of Egypt": people came from the whole land, from the far north to the far south. Some Bibles call the place in the north "Lebo Hamath."

The feast lasted 14 days: 7 days for the dedication and 7 days for the Feast of Tabernacles.

"On the eighth day": this probably means the day after the second feast. 2 Chronicles 7:9–10 tells it more exactly.

The people go home joyful. This is the high point of Israel's history under the kings: God lives in the middle of his people, and everyone is thankful.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 9

God appears to Solomon a second time

Promise and warning VERSES 1–9

1 Solomon finished building the LORD's house and the
king's house.
He finished everything that he wanted to build.
2 Then the LORD appeared to Solomon a second time,
as he had appeared to him at Gibeon.
3 The LORD said to him,
"I have heard your prayer and your plea that you made
before me.
You have built this house, and I have made it holy.
I have put my name there forever.
My eyes and my heart will always be there.
4 Now you must live before me as your father David
lived.
He lived with an honest heart and did what was right.
Do everything that I have commanded you.
Keep my rules and my laws.
5 Then I will make the throne of your kingdom over
Israel last forever.
I promised this to your father David.
I said, 'There will always be a man from your family on
the throne of Israel.'
6 But you or your children may turn away from
following me.
You may not keep my commandments and my rules
that I have given you.
You may go and serve other gods and worship them.
7 Then I will remove Israel from the land that I have
given them.
I have made this house holy for my name.
But I will throw it away, out of my sight.
Israel will become a saying and a joke among all
peoples.
8 This house is so great.
But everyone who passes by it will be shocked and will
hiss.
They will say,
'Why has the LORD done this to this land and to this
house?'
9 And people will answer,
'Because they left the LORD their God.
He brought their ancestors out of the land of Egypt.

But they held on to other gods.
They worshiped them and served them.
That is why the LORD has brought all this disaster on them.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers Solomon's prayer: I have heard you. I have accepted the temple.

But then comes a serious warning. God's presence is not something you own forever, no matter how you live. If Israel worships other gods, God will even leave this temple.

That really happened later. About 400 years later the Babylonians destroyed Jerusalem and the temple (2 Kings 25). These verses explain to the people in exile: it was not that God was too weak. It was the result of unfaithfulness.

In those days "hissing" was a gesture of shock or of mocking.

Solomon and Hiram VERSES 10–14

10 Solomon spent 20 years building the two houses,
the LORD's house and the king's house.
11 Hiram, the king of Tyre, had given Solomon cedar wood and cypress wood
and gold, as much as he wanted.
After the 20 years, King Solomon gave Hiram 20 cities in the land of Galilee.
12 Hiram came out of Tyre to see the cities that Solomon had given him.
But he did not like them.
13 He said,
"My brother, what kind of cities are these that you have given me?"
He called them the land of Cabul.
They still have that name today.
14 Hiram sent the king 120 talents of gold (about 9,000 pounds).

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

20 years of building: 7 years for the temple and 13 for the palace.

Solomon pays Hiram with 20 cities. That is worth noticing: he gives away land of Israel. The land was really God's inheritance for his people.

Hiram is disappointed. In Hebrew "Cabul" sounds like "as good as nothing."

The Bible says "120 talents of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds. It is not fully clear whether Hiram paid the gold for the cities or had given it earlier as a loan.

2 Chronicles 8:2 tells it differently: there Hiram gives cities to Solomon.

Solomon's buildings and the forced labor VERSES 15–25

15 This is why King Solomon made people do forced labor.
He needed them to build the LORD's house, his own house, the Millo, and the wall of Jerusalem.
He also needed them to build Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer.
16 Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, had attacked Gezer and captured it.
He had burned it with fire.
He had killed the Canaanites who lived in the city.
Then he had given it as a wedding gift to his daughter, Solomon's wife.
17 Solomon built up Gezer in the land, and Lower Beth Horon,
18 Baalath, and Tamar in the wilderness.
19 He built all his storage cities,
the cities for his chariots, and the cities for his horsemen.
He built whatever he wanted to build in Jerusalem, in Lebanon,
and in all the land that he ruled.
20 Some people were still left of the Amorites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites.
They were not Israelites.
21 Their descendants were still left in the land.
The Israelites had not been able to destroy them completely.
Solomon made them his slave workers.
They are slave workers to this day.
22 But Solomon did not make any Israelites slaves.
They were his soldiers, his servants, his officials, his captains,
and the commanders of his chariots and of his horsemen.
23 There were 550 chief officers in charge of Solomon's work.
They ruled over the people who did the work.
24 Pharaoh's daughter moved up from David's city to her own house.
Solomon had built it for her.
Then he built the Millo.
25 Three times a year Solomon offered burnt offerings and peace offerings
on the altar that he had built for the LORD.
With them he burned incense on the altar that was before the LORD.
So he finished the house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon built not only the temple and the palace, but also fortresses: Hazor in the north, Megiddo in the Valley of Jezreel, Gezer in the west. In these three cities archaeologists have found large city gates from the same time that are very much alike. Many connect them with Solomon.

The forced labor was demanded mostly from the descendants of the Canaanites who were still living in the land. They had to work as slaves. For them it was a hard fate. The Bible tells it honestly.

Verse 22 says that Israelites did not become slaves. But 1 Kings 5:13 said that Israelites also had to do forced labor. Maybe for Israelites it was a duty to work for a limited time, not slavery.

Solomon offered sacrifices three times a year: at the three great feasts, Passover, the Feast of Weeks, and the Feast of Tabernacles (Exodus 23:14–17).

2 Chronicles 8:10 says 250 officers instead of 550.

Solomon's ships VERSES 26–28

26 King Solomon built a fleet of ships in Ezion Geber.
It is near Eloth, on the shore of the Red Sea, in the land of Edom.
27 Hiram sent his servants with the ships.
They were sailors who knew the sea.
They sailed together with Solomon's servants.

28 They came to Ophir and got 420 talents of gold there
(about 31,500 pounds).
They brought it to King Solomon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezion Geber and Eloth are in the far south, on the Gulf of Aqaba. There Israel had a way to the sea toward the south, toward Arabia and Africa.

"Red Sea": the Hebrew says "Yam Suf," "Sea of Reeds." Here it means the Gulf of Aqaba.

Israel had no experience with sailing. That is why the sailors of Hiram from Tyre help.

Today no one knows for sure where Ophir was. Maybe in Arabia, in East Africa, or in India. It was famous for its gold.

The Bible says "420 talents of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds. 2 Chronicles 8:18 says 450 talents.

1 KINGS

Chapter 10

The queen of Sheba and Solomon's wealth

The queen of Sheba visits Solomon VERSES 1–13

1 The queen of Sheba heard of Solomon's fame,
connected with the name of the LORD.
So she came to test him with hard questions.
2 She came to Jerusalem with a very large caravan,
with camels that carried spices, very much gold, and
precious stones.
When she had come to Solomon,
she talked with him about everything that was in her
heart.
3 Solomon answered all her questions.
There was nothing hidden from the king that he did
not explain to her.
4 The queen of Sheba saw all the wisdom of Solomon,
the house that he had built,
5 the food on his table, how his servants sat,
how his officials served, their clothing, his cupbearers,
and the stairway by which he went up to the LORD's
house.
Then she was left breathless.
6 She said to the king,
"What I heard in my own land
about your deeds and your wisdom was true.
7 But I didn't believe the words
until I came and saw it with my own eyes.
Not even half was told to me!
Your wisdom and your wealth are greater than the
fame I heard about.
8 Happy are your men,
happy are these servants of yours who always stand
before you and hear your wisdom.
9 Blessed be the LORD your God,
who was pleased with you and set you on the throne of
Israel.
Because the LORD loves Israel forever,
he has made you king,
to do justice and righteousness."
10 She gave the king 120 talents of gold (about 9,000
pounds),
a very great amount of spices, and precious stones.
Never again was there such a great amount of spices
as the queen of Sheba gave to King Solomon.
11 Hiram's fleet, which brought gold from Ophir,
also brought from Ophir great amounts of almug
wood and precious stones.
12 The king made pillars of the almug wood for the
LORD's house and for the king's house,
and also harps and stringed instruments for the
singers.
No such almug wood ever came again, and it has not
been seen to this day.
13 King Solomon gave the queen of Sheba everything she
wanted, whatever she asked for,
besides what Solomon gave her out of his royal wealth.
Then she turned and went back to her own land, she
and her servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sheba was probably in the south of Arabia, in what is Yemen today. It was rich from trading in incense and spices. Some people also think of Ethiopia.

The queen travels more than 1,200 miles. She does not come only because of the wealth, but because of the wisdom, and "connected with the name of the LORD." She wants to know where this wisdom comes from.

"She was left breathless": word for word it says, "There was no more spirit in her." She was completely overwhelmed.

A foreign queen praises the God of Israel (verse 9). She sees: a king is there to do justice and righteousness. That is the purpose of power.

Later Jesus reminded people of her: the "Queen of the South" came "from the ends of the earth to hear the wisdom of Solomon. And someone greater than Solomon is here" (Matthew 12:42).

In Ethiopia there is an old tradition that the queen and Solomon had a son, Menelik. That is not in the Bible.

The Bible says "120 talents of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds.

No one knows for sure what "almug wood" was, maybe red sandalwood. Instead of "pillars," the Hebrew word could also be translated "railings" or "supports."

Solomon's gold VERSES 14–22

14 The gold that came to Solomon in one year weighed 666
talents
(about 50,000 pounds).
15 Besides that, there was what the traders brought, the
business of the merchants,
and of all the kings of the mixed peoples and of the
governors of the land.
16 King Solomon made 200 large shields of beaten gold.
He used 600 shekels of gold (about 15 pounds) for each
shield.

17 And he made 300 small shields of beaten gold.
He used 3 minas of gold (almost 4 pounds) for each shield.
The king put them in the House of the Forest of Lebanon.
18 The king also made a great throne of ivory
and covered it with the finest gold.
19 The throne had six steps.
The top of the throne was round at the back.
There were armrests on both sides of the seat,
and two lions stood beside the armrests.
20 There were 12 lions standing on the 6 steps,
on one side and on the other.
Nothing like it was made in any kingdom.
21 All of King Solomon's drinking cups were made of gold,
and all the things in the House of the Forest of Lebanon were made of pure gold.
None were made of silver, because silver was thought of as worth little in the days of Solomon.
22 For the king had a fleet of ships of Tarshish at sea,
together with Hiram's fleet.
Once every three years the fleet of Tarshish came and brought gold, silver, ivory, apes, and peacocks.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The numbers are huge. The Bible says "666 talents of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds.

For the shields the Bible says "600 shekels" (a shekel is about 0.4 ounces) and "3 minas" (a mina is about 1¼ pounds). The gold shields were not for fighting. They were for showing off, for feasts and parades.

The House of the Forest of Lebanon was a large hall in Solomon's palace (1 Kings 7:2).

"Ships of Tarshish" were large ships for long journeys across the sea. It is not certain where Tarshish was, maybe in Spain. The translation "peacocks" is not certain. Some translate "baboons."

This description shows Solomon's splendor. But there is a catch: Deuteronomy 17:16–17 says that a king should not pile up many horses, many wives, and a lot of silver and gold. That is exactly what Solomon does. The next chapter shows where this leads.

Solomon's wisdom, chariots, and horses VERSES 23–29

23 So King Solomon was greater than all the kings of the earth in riches and in wisdom.
24 The whole world wanted to see Solomon,
to hear his wisdom, which God had put into his heart.
25 Year after year, everyone brought his tribute:
things of silver, things of gold, clothing, armor, spices, horses, and mules.
26 Solomon gathered chariots and horsemen.
He had 1,400 chariots and 12,000 horsemen.
He kept them in the chariot cities and with the king in Jerusalem.
27 In Jerusalem the king made silver as common as stones,
and cedars as common as the sycamore trees in the lowland.
28 The horses that Solomon had were brought from Egypt.
The king's merchants got them in herds, each herd at a price.
29 A chariot was brought from Egypt for 600 shekels of silver (about 15 pounds),
and a horse for 150 shekels (almost 4 pounds).
And in the same way they sold them to all the kings of the Hittites and to the kings of Syria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon is described as the richest and wisest king in the world. But verse 24 says it clearly: his wisdom came from God.

Solomon was also a horse trader. He bought horses and chariots and sold them on to other kings.

The Bible says "600 shekels of silver" and "150 shekels." A shekel is about 0.4 ounces.

"From Egypt": some experts think that the text first said "Muzri," a land in what is Turkey today. In Hebrew the name sounds almost the same as "Egypt."

In Hebrew "Syria" is "Aram," the land of the Arameans.

The sycamore tree was a very ordinary tree. Cedars were precious. Under Solomon, precious things were as everyday as ordinary things.

Again this points to Deuteronomy 17:16: the king should not get horses from Egypt. The splendor has a dark side.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 11

Solomon's heart turns away

Solomon's many wives VERSES 1–8

1 King Solomon loved many foreign women,
together with the daughter of Pharaoh:
women of the Moabites, Ammonites, Edomites, Sidonians, and Hittites,
2 from the nations about which the LORD had said to the people of Israel,
"You must not go among them, and they must not come among you.
For they will surely turn your heart away to their gods."
Solomon held on to these women in love.
3 He had 700 wives who were princesses, and 300 concubines.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
His wives turned his heart away.
4 When Solomon was old, his wives turned his heart away to other gods.
And his heart was no longer wholly with the LORD his God,
as the heart of his father David had been.

5 For Solomon followed Ashtoreth, the goddess of the Sidonians,
and Milcom, the disgusting idol of the Ammonites.
6 Solomon did what was evil in the LORD's sight
and did not follow the LORD fully, as his father David had.
7 Then Solomon built a high place for Chemosh, the disgusting idol of Moab,
on the mountain that is east of Jerusalem,
and for Molech, the disgusting idol of the people of Ammon.
8 He did the same for all his foreign wives,
who burned incense and sacrificed to their gods.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the deep fall of the wise king. In those days many marriages were politics: a king married the daughter of another king to make an alliance.

The problem is not that the women were foreigners. Ruth was also a Moabite, and she was David's great-grandmother. The problem is: Solomon worships their gods along with them. His heart is divided.

God had warned against exactly this (Exodus 34:16; Deuteronomy 7:3–4). And Deuteronomy 17:17 says: the king should not take many wives, so that his heart does not turn away.

The numbers 700 and 300 are huge. They show how Solomon had lost all sense of limits.

"Disgusting idol" is a strong word for a false god that God hates.

Ashtoreth was a goddess of fertility and war. Chemosh was the god of the Moabites. Molech is connected with cruel sacrifices of children (Leviticus 18:21). In verses 5 and 33 the god of the Ammonites is called "Milcom." Many experts think that the same god is meant in verse 7.

"The mountain east of Jerusalem" is the Mount of Olives. Later King Josiah had these high places destroyed (2 Kings 23:13).

Solomon, who built the temple, now builds altars for other gods. This shows: even a great beginning does not protect you from a bad end. You have to guard your heart every day.

God announces the splitting of the kingdom VERSES 9–13

9 The LORD was angry with Solomon,
because his heart had turned away from the LORD, the God of Israel,
who had appeared to him twice
10 and had commanded him about this very thing: that he should not follow other gods.
But he did not keep what the LORD commanded.
11 So the LORD said to Solomon,
"Because you have done this
and have not kept my covenant and my laws, which I commanded you,
I will surely tear the kingdom away from you and give it to your servant.
12 But I will not do it in your lifetime, for the sake of your father David.
I will tear it out of your son's hand.
13 But I will not tear away the whole kingdom.
I will give one tribe to your son,
for the sake of my servant David
and for the sake of Jerusalem, which I have chosen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God had appeared to Solomon twice (Chapters 3 and 9). He had received so much. That makes his unfaithfulness all the more serious.

The punishment is hard: the kingdom will be split. But even now God stays faithful to his promise to David. One part of the kingdom stays with David's family, because of Jerusalem.

"One tribe": this means Judah. Later the small tribe of Benjamin was added to it (1 Kings 12:21).

Hadad the Edomite VERSES 14–22

14 The LORD raised up an enemy against Solomon:
Hadad the Edomite.
He came from the royal family in Edom.
15 For when David was in Edom,
and Joab the commander of the army had gone up to bury the dead,
he had struck down every male in Edom
16 – for Joab and all Israel stayed there six months,
until he had wiped out every male in Edom.
17 Then Hadad fled, he and some Edomites of his father's servants with him,
to go to Egypt.
Hadad was still a little child at that time.
18 They set out from Midian and came to Paran.
They took men with them from Paran
and came to Egypt, to Pharaoh king of Egypt.
He gave him a house, gave him food, and gave him land.
19 Hadad found great favor with Pharaoh,
so that he gave him as his wife the sister of his own wife,
the sister of Queen Tahpenes.
20 The sister of Tahpenes gave birth to his son Genubath.
Tahpenes raised him in Pharaoh's house until he no longer nursed.
And Genubath was in Pharaoh's house among the sons of Pharaoh.
21 When Hadad heard in Egypt that David died and joined his ancestors
and that Joab the commander of the army was dead,
Hadad said to Pharaoh,
"Let me go, so that I may go to my own country."
22 Then Pharaoh said to him,
"But what have you been missing with me, that you now want to go to your own country?"
He answered,
"Nothing, but please let me go."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a dark side of David's wars is told: Joab killed all the men in Edom that he could find (compare 2 Samuel 8:13–14). Little Hadad survived and fled to Egypt.

The Bible tells it honestly: violence creates new hatred. The boy who fled back then later becomes an enemy of Israel.

"Died and joined his ancestors" is an old way of saying that someone died.

Midian and Paran are desert areas in the south, between Edom and Egypt.

Rezon of Damascus VERSES 23–25

23 God raised up another enemy against him:
Rezon the son of Eliada,
who had fled from his master Hadadezer king of Zobah.
24 He gathered men around him and became the leader of a band,
when David killed the men of Zobah.
They went to Damascus, lived there, and ruled in Damascus.
25 He was an enemy of Israel all the days of Solomon,
in addition to the harm that Hadad did.
He hated Israel and ruled over Syria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rezon founded his own kingdom in Damascus. Later Damascus, the kingdom of the Arameans (Syrians), will be a dangerous enemy of Israel.

From the outside Solomon's kingdom looked splendid and peaceful. But at the edges it was already crumbling.

In Hebrew "Syria" is "Aram."

Jeroboam and the prophet Ahijah VERSES 26–40

26 Jeroboam the son of Nebat also lifted up his hand against the king.
He was an Ephraimite from Zeredah, a servant of Solomon.
His mother's name was Zeruah, and she was a widow.
27 This was the reason why he lifted up his hand against the king:
Solomon built the Millo
and closed up the gap in the city of his father David.
28 Jeroboam was a strong, brave man.
Solomon saw that the young man was hard-working, and he put him in charge of all the forced labor of the house of Joseph.
29 At that time, when Jeroboam went out of Jerusalem, the prophet Ahijah the Shilonite met him on the way.
Ahijah had put on a new cloak.
And the two of them were alone in the field.
30 Ahijah took the new cloak that he was wearing and tore it into 12 pieces.
31 He said to Jeroboam,
"Take 10 pieces for yourself.
For the LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'I will tear the kingdom out of the hand of Solomon and will give 10 tribes to you
32 – but he will keep one tribe,
for the sake of my servant David
and for the sake of Jerusalem, the city that I have chosen out of all the tribes of Israel –
33 because they have abandoned me
and have worshiped Ashtoreth the goddess of the Sidonians, Chemosh the god of Moab,
and Milcom the god of the people of Ammon.
They have not walked in my ways,
to do what is right in my eyes,
and to keep my laws and my rules, as his father David did.
34 But I will not take the whole kingdom out of his hand.
I will make him prince all the days of his life,
for the sake of my servant David, whom I chose,
who kept my commandments and my laws.
35 But I will take the kingdom out of his son's hand
and will give it to you, 10 tribes.
36 I will give one tribe to his son,
so that my servant David may always have a lamp before me in Jerusalem,
the city that I have chosen for myself to put my name there.
37 But I will take you,
and you will rule over everything that your soul desires,
and you will be king over Israel.
38 If you listen to everything that I command you,
and walk in my ways,
and do what is right in my eyes,
and keep my laws and my commandments, as my servant David did,
then I will be with you
and build you a lasting house, as I built for David,
and I will give Israel to you.
39 Because of this I will bring the descendants of David low, but not forever.'"
40 That is why Solomon tried to kill Jeroboam.
But Jeroboam got up and fled to Egypt,
to Shishak king of Egypt.
And he stayed in Egypt until Solomon died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeroboam was a gifted overseer of the workers from the "house of Joseph," that is, from the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh in the north. He saw for himself how heavy the burdens on the people were.

The prophet Ahijah does an action that is a sign: he tears a new cloak into 12 pieces, for the 12 tribes. Jeroboam gets 10. The picture is strong: something new and whole is torn apart.

10 and 1 together are only 11. The twelfth tribe, Levi, had no land of its own. Or Benjamin is counted here as part of Judah. The Bible does not explain the numbers exactly.

"A lamp in Jerusalem": David's family is not to die out. From it come the kings of Judah. Christians believe that Jesus later came from this family line. Jews expect the Messiah from the house of David.

God makes Jeroboam a great offer: the same as David, if he stays faithful. The next chapter shows whether he accepts it.

"But not forever" (verse 39): in the middle of the punishment there is already hope.

Shishak is Pharaoh Shoshenq I. He is also known from Egyptian sources. He ruled from about 945 to 924 BC.

Solomon's death VERSES 41–43

41 The rest of the acts of Solomon,
everything he did, and his wisdom,
aren't they written in the book of the acts of Solomon?
42 Solomon ruled in Jerusalem over all Israel for 40 years.
43 Solomon died and joined his ancestors
and was buried in the city of his father David.
And his son Rehoboam became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "book of the acts of Solomon" is an old book that is lost today. The writer used it as a source.

Solomon ruled from about 970 to 930 BC.

Solomon's life is a great lesson: he began with a humble prayer for wisdom. He built the temple and was famous in the whole world. But in the end he let wealth, power, and other gods pull his heart away. Wisdom alone is not enough. What matters is that the heart stays with God.

1 KINGS

Chapter 12

The kingdom is split

The people ask for relief VERSES 1–5

1 Rehoboam went to Shechem,
for all Israel had come to Shechem to make him king.
2 Jeroboam the son of Nebat heard about it.
He was still in Egypt, where he had fled from King Solomon,
and Jeroboam was living in Egypt.
3 And they sent for him and called him.
Then Jeroboam and the whole assembly of Israel came
and spoke to Rehoboam and said,
4 "Your father made our yoke hard.
Now make the hard service of your father
and his heavy yoke that he put on us lighter.
Then we will serve you."
5 He said to them,
"Go away for three days, then come back to me."
So the people went away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shechem was in the north, in the land of Ephraim. It was an old, important place: there Joshua had renewed the covenant with the people (Joshua 24). That Rehoboam has to come there shows: the northern tribes did not want to simply accept him as king. They wanted to bargain.

A "yoke" is a wooden beam used to hitch animals to a plow. It is a picture of burden and oppression. The people suffered under Solomon's high taxes and the forced labor.

The request is reasonable: "Make it lighter, then we will serve you."

The advice of the old men and the advice of the young men VERSES 6–15

6 King Rehoboam asked the old men for advice,
who had served his father Solomon while he was still alive.
He said,
"What advice do you give me for answering these people?"
7 They answered,
"If you will be a servant to this people today and serve them,
and answer them with good words,
then they will be your servants forever."
8 But he left aside the advice that the old men had given him,
and asked for advice from the young men who had grown up with him
and who served him.
9 He said to them,
"What advice do you give, so that we may answer these people
who have said to me,
'Make the yoke that your father put on us lighter'?"
10 The young men who had grown up with him said to him,
"Tell these people who said to you,
'Your father made our yoke heavy, but make it lighter for us,'
tell them,
'My little finger is thicker than my father's waist.
11 My father loaded you with a heavy yoke,
but I will make your yoke even heavier.
My father punished you with whips,
but I will punish you with scorpions.'"
12 So Jeroboam and all the people came to Rehoboam on the third day,
as the king had said:
"Come back to me on the third day."
13 The king answered the people harshly.
He left aside the advice that the old men had given him,
14 and spoke to them as the young men had advised. He said,
"My father made your yoke heavy,
but I will make your yoke even heavier.
My father punished you with whips,
but I will punish you with scorpions."
15 So the king did not listen to the people.
For this was brought about by the LORD,
so that he might fulfill his word
that the LORD had spoken through Ahijah the Shilonite to Jeroboam the son of Nebat.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The old men give wise advice: "If you will be a servant to this people today ... then they will be your servants forever." A good ruler is a servant. Later Jesus said something very similar: "Whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant" (Mark 10:43).

The young men grew up with Rehoboam in the palace. They do not know the hard life of the people. They advise harshness and showing off.

"My little finger is thicker than my father's waist": that is crude boasting. "Scorpions" were maybe whips with spikes or hooks.

Verse 15 says: God brought this about. That does not mean that Rehoboam was not guilty. He made his choice himself. But God also works through people's mistakes, so that his word comes true.

The northern tribes break away VERSES 16–20

16 When all Israel saw that the king did not listen to them,
the people answered the king,
"What share do we have in David?

We have no inheritance in the son of Jesse.
To your tents, Israel!
Now look after your own house, David!"
So Israel went home to their tents.
17 But Rehoboam ruled over the people of Israel who lived
in the cities of Judah.
18 Then King Rehoboam sent Adoram, who was over the
men who had to do forced labor.
But all Israel stoned him to death.
King Rehoboam hurried to get up into his chariot
to flee to Jerusalem.
19 So Israel rebelled against David's house, to this day.
20 When all Israel heard that Jeroboam had come back,
they sent for him and called him to the assembly
and made him king over all Israel.
No one followed David's house except the tribe of
Judah alone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The cry "To your tents, Israel!" had been heard once before, in the revolt of Sheba (2 Samuel 20:1). It means: we are going home, we no longer belong to you.

Rehoboam sends of all people the head of the forced labor to the angry crowd. That was very unwise. Adoram is killed. He is probably the same man as Adoniram in 1 Kings 4:6 and 5:14.

From now on there are two kingdoms:

– in the north the kingdom of **Israel** (10 tribes), King Jeroboam,

– in the south the kingdom of **Judah** (with Benjamin), King Rehoboam, capital Jerusalem.

This happened about 930 BC. The division lasted about 200 years, until the northern kingdom was destroyed by Assyria in 722 BC.

From now on in the books of Kings, "Israel" usually means only the northern kingdom.

No war between brothers VERSES 21–24

21 When Rehoboam had come to Jerusalem,
he gathered the whole house of Judah and the tribe of
Benjamin,
180,000 chosen warriors,
to fight against the house of Israel
and bring the kingdom back to Rehoboam the son of
Solomon.
22 But the word of God came to Shemaiah the man of God:
23 "Speak to Rehoboam the son of Solomon, king of
Judah,
and to the whole house of Judah and Benjamin,
and to the rest of the people, and say:
24 'The LORD says:
"You must not go up or fight against your brothers,
the people of Israel.
Everyone go back to his house, for this thing is from
me."'"
So they listened to the LORD's word
and turned back and went their way, as the LORD had
said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rehoboam wants to bring back unity by force. But through the prophet Shemaiah God says: do not fight against your brothers!

This is worth noticing: this time the king listens to God. A civil war is prevented. Even though the kingdom is split, the people remain "brothers."

Jeroboam's golden calves VERSES 25–33

25 Then Jeroboam built up Shechem in the hill country of
Ephraim and lived there.
From there he went out and built up Penuel.
26 Jeroboam said in his heart,
"Now the kingdom will go back to David's house.
27 If these people go up to offer sacrifices in the LORD's
house in Jerusalem,
then the heart of these people will turn back to their
lord,
to Rehoboam king of Judah.
Then they will kill me
and go back to Rehoboam king of Judah."
28 So the king asked for advice and made two calves of
gold.
And he said to the people,
"It is too much for you to go up to Jerusalem.
Look, Israel, these are your gods,
who brought you up out of the land of Egypt!"
29 He set up one in Bethel,
and the other he put in Dan.
30 This became a sin.
For the people went even as far as Dan to worship
before the one there.
31 He built houses on the high places
and made priests from among all the people, who were
not from the sons of Levi.
32 Jeroboam set up a feast in the eighth month, on the
fifteenth day of the month,
like the feast that was held in Judah,
and he went up to the altar.
He did this in Bethel:
he sacrificed to the calves that he had made.
And in Bethel he appointed the priests of the high
places that he had made.
33 He went up to the altar that he had made in Bethel
on the fifteenth day of the eighth month,
in the month that he had made up in his own heart.
He set up a feast for the people of Israel
and went up to the altar to burn incense.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeroboam is afraid. If the people keep going to the temple in Jerusalem, he might lose them. That is why he builds his own places of worship: in Bethel in the far south of his kingdom and in Dan in the far north.

He makes two golden calves. His words are almost exactly the same as with the golden calf at Mount Sinai (Exodus 32:4). That is no accident. The text wants to show: Jeroboam repeats the worst sin from the wilderness.

Maybe the calves were only meant to be the base on which the invisible God stands, like the cherubim above the ark. But for the people they quickly became idols.

Jeroboam does even more wrong: he appoints priests who are not from the tribe of Levi, and he makes up his own date for a feast: one month later than the Feast of Tabernacles in Jerusalem.

God had promised Jeroboam a lasting house if he stayed faithful (1 Kings 11:38). But out of fear for his power he

abandons God. From now on we will read again and again that a king of Israel "walked in the sins of Jeroboam." These calves will shape the history of the northern kingdom.

Penuel is east of the Jordan. There Jacob had wrestled with God (Genesis 32:31).

1 KINGS

Chapter 13

The man of God from Judah

A word against the altar in Bethel VERSES 1–10

1 The LORD sent a man of God from Judah to Bethel with
a message.
Jeroboam was standing by the altar to burn incense.
2 The man of God shouted against the altar the message
of the LORD:
"Altar! Altar! The LORD says:
'A son will be born to David's family.
His name will be Josiah.
He will sacrifice on you the priests of the high places
who burn incense on you.
Human bones will be burned on you.'"
3 On the same day the man of God gave a sign.
He said, "This is the sign that the LORD has given:
The altar will split apart.
The ashes on it will be poured out."
4 King Jeroboam heard what the man of God shouted
against the altar in Bethel.
He stretched out his hand from the altar and said,
"Grab him!"
But the hand that he stretched out against him dried
up.
He could not pull it back.
5 The altar also split apart,
and the ashes poured out of the altar.
It happened just as the man of God had said in the sign
from the LORD.
6 Then the king said to the man of God,
"Please ask the LORD your God to be kind to me.
Pray for me, so that my hand becomes well again."
The man of God prayed to the LORD.
Then the king's hand became well again, as it was
before.
7 The king said to the man of God,
"Come home with me and have something to eat.
I will give you a gift."
8 But the man of God said to the king,
"Even if you gave me half of everything you own,
I would not go in with you.
I will not eat bread or drink water in this place.
9 The LORD commanded me with his word:
'Do not eat bread, and do not drink water.
And do not go back by the same way that you came.'"
10 So he went another way.
He did not go back by the way he had come to Bethel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet from Judah, whose name we do not know, comes to Bethel, right to Jeroboam's new altar. He announces: a king named Josiah will make this altar unclean.

That is an amazing prediction: Josiah lived about 300 years later. 2 Kings 23:15–18 tells how he did exactly that. He burned bones on the altar there, so that the altar became unclean and could no longer be used.

Jeroboam wants to have the prophet arrested. But his hand goes stiff. When the prophet prays for him, it becomes healthy again. The prophet even prays for the king who wanted to arrest him.

The prophet is not allowed to eat or drink anything in this place. In those days eating together meant: we are joined to each other. The prophet is to show: there can be no fellowship with this false worship.

The old prophet lies VERSES 11–19

11 An old prophet lived in Bethel.
One of his sons came and told him everything that the
man of God had done that day in Bethel.
His sons also told their father what the man of God had
said to the king.
12 Their father asked them,
"Which way did he go?"
His sons had seen which way the man of God from
Judah had gone.
13 He said to his sons,
"Saddle the donkey for me."
So they saddled the donkey for him, and he rode on it.
14 He followed the man of God and found him sitting
under an oak tree.
He asked him,
"Are you the man of God who came from Judah?"
He answered,
"I am."
15 Then the old prophet said to him,
"Come home with me and eat some bread."
16 But he said,
"I must not go back with you or go into your house.
I will not eat bread or drink water with you in this
place.
17 The LORD told me with his word,
'Do not eat bread or drink water there.
And do not go back by the same way that you came.'"
18 The old prophet said to him,
"I am a prophet too, just like you.
An angel gave me a message from the LORD.
He said, 'Bring him back with you to your house, so
that he can eat bread and drink water.'"
But the old prophet was lying to him.
19 So the man of God went back with him.
He ate bread in his house and drank water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Why does the old prophet lie? The Bible does not say. Maybe he wanted to have the famous guest at his house. Maybe he wanted to test whether he would stay faithful.

The man of God had received a clear task from God himself. Now someone comes and says: "An angel told me something different." And he believes him.

The lesson is serious: if God has told you something clearly, do not let others turn you away from it, not even religious people who appeal to God or an angel. Paul writes something similar in Galatians 1:8.

The lion on the road VERSES 20–32

20 They were sitting at the table.
Then the word of the LORD came to the prophet who had brought him back.
21 He shouted to the man of God from Judah,
"The LORD says:
'You have not obeyed the word of the LORD.
You have not kept the command that the LORD your God gave you.
22 You came back.
You ate bread and drank water in the place where he told you, "Do not eat bread, and do not drink water."
So your body will not come to the tomb of your ancestors.'"
23 The man of God had eaten bread and had drunk.
Then the old prophet saddled the donkey for the prophet he had brought back.
24 The man of God left.
On the road a lion met him and killed him.
His body lay thrown down on the road.
The donkey stood beside it.
The lion also stood beside the body.
25 Some men passed by.
They saw the body lying on the road and the lion standing beside it.
They went and told about it in the city where the old prophet lived.
26 The prophet who had brought him back from his way heard about it.
He said,
"It is the man of God who did not obey the word of the LORD.
So the LORD has handed him over to the lion.
The lion has attacked him and killed him,
just as the LORD had told him."
27 He said to his sons,
"Saddle the donkey for me."
And they saddled it.
28 He went and found the body lying on the road.
The donkey and the lion were standing beside the body.
The lion had not eaten the body.
It had not attacked the donkey.
29 The prophet picked up the body of the man of God.
He laid it on the donkey and brought it back.
He came to his own city to mourn for him and to bury him.
30 He laid the body in his own grave.
They mourned over him and said,
"Oh, my brother!"
31 After he had buried him, he said to his sons,
"When I die,
bury me in the tomb where the man of God is buried.
Lay my bones beside his bones.
32 The LORD gave him a message against the altar in Bethel
and against all the temples on the high places in the cities of Samaria.
What he shouted will surely happen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is hard to understand. Of all people, the liar receives a real word from God. And the man who was lied to has to die.

The text probably wants to show: God's word is serious. If even the prophet who brings it has to die because he did not obey it, how much more serious is the word against the altar in Bethel!

The lion acts very unnaturally: it eats neither the dead man nor the donkey. Everyone sees: this is no accident, this is a sign from God.

"Your body will not come to the tomb of your ancestors" meant: to die and be buried in a foreign place. In those days that was very bad.

At the end the old prophet mourns honestly: "Oh, my brother!" He even wants to be buried next to him. He has understood that the man from Judah was a true prophet.

300 years later King Josiah spares exactly this tomb (2 Kings 23:17–18).

"Samaria": this city was only built later (1 Kings 16:24). Here the name is already used for the whole northern kingdom.

Jeroboam does not turn back VERSES 33–34

33 Even after this, Jeroboam did not turn away from his evil ways.
Again he made priests for the high places from all kinds of people.
Anyone who wanted to could become a priest.
Jeroboam consecrated him as a priest for the high places.
To consecrate means: to set someone apart for a holy task.
34 This was the sin of Jeroboam's family.
Because of it, his family was cut off and destroyed from the face of the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeroboam has experienced a miracle in his own body. He has seen the altar split apart. Even so, he changes nothing.

Anyone who wanted to could become a priest under him. Word for word, "consecrate" here means: "to fill the hand." It means putting someone into the office of priest.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 14

Ahijah's word against Jeroboam, and King Rehoboam

Jeroboam's sick son VERSES 1–6

1 At that time Abijah, the son of Jeroboam, became sick.
2 Jeroboam said to his wife,
"Please get up and disguise yourself.
No one should know that you are Jeroboam's wife.
Go to Shiloh.
Ahijah the prophet is there.
He is the one who told me that I would be king over this people.
3 Take 10 loaves of bread with you, some cakes, and a jar of honey.
Go to him.
He will tell you what will happen to the boy."
4 Jeroboam's wife did this.
She got up and went to Shiloh.
She came to Ahijah's house.
Ahijah could not see.
His eyes had gone stiff because he was old.
5 But the LORD said to Ahijah,
"Jeroboam's wife is coming to ask you about her son.
He is sick.
Tell her this and that.
When she comes in, she will pretend to be another woman."
6 Ahijah heard the sound of her feet as she came in at the door.
He said,
"Come in, wife of Jeroboam!
Why are you pretending to be someone else?
I have been sent to you with heavy news.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeroboam is in trouble. His son is sick. He does not go to his golden calves, but sends his wife to the true prophet of the LORD. In his trouble he knows where the truth is.

But he sends his wife in disguise. He wants to trick God. But the blind prophet "sees" more than anyone else: God has told him who is coming.

Do not mix up this Abijah with Abijam, the king of Judah (Chapter 15).

The heavy news VERSES 7–16

7 Go and tell Jeroboam,
'The LORD, the God of Israel, says:
"I lifted you up from among the people.
I made you leader over my people Israel.
8 I tore the kingdom away from David's family and gave it to you.
But you have not been like my servant David.
He kept my commandments.
He followed me with all his heart.
He did only what was right in my eyes.
9 But you have done more evil than all who came before you.
You have made yourself other gods, idols of metal.
You did it to make me angry.
You have thrown me behind your back.
10 So I will bring disaster on Jeroboam's family.
I will cut off from Jeroboam everyone who urinates on a wall,
the one who is shut up and the one who is free in Israel.
I will sweep away Jeroboam's family completely,
as a man sweeps away dung until it is all gone.
11 Anyone from Jeroboam's family who dies in the city will be eaten by the dogs.
Anyone who dies in the open country will be eaten by the birds.
The LORD has said it."'
12 And you, get up and go home.
When you set foot in the city, the boy will die.
13 All Israel will mourn for him and bury him.
He is the only one of Jeroboam's family who will be put in a grave.
In Jeroboam's family, only he has something good toward the LORD, the God of Israel.
14 The LORD will put a king over Israel for himself.
That king will cut off Jeroboam's family.
This is the day!
What am I saying? It is already happening!
15 The LORD will strike Israel,
so that it shakes like a reed in the water.
He will pull Israel up by the roots out of this good land that he gave to their ancestors.
He will scatter them beyond the River.
He will do this because they have made their Asherah poles.
With them they made the LORD angry.
16 He will give Israel up because of the sins of Jeroboam.
Jeroboam sinned, and he made Israel sin."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The same prophet who once promised Jeroboam the kingdom now has to announce his end. God had given Jeroboam everything. But Jeroboam "threw God behind his back," that is, he forgot him on purpose.

"Everyone who urinates on a wall" is a crude expression of the language back then. It means all male descendants. "The one who is shut up and the one who is free" probably means: everyone, with no exception.

For the dead not to be buried, but to be eaten by animals, was seen as the worst disgrace.

In the middle of this harsh judgment there is a tender word: in the sick boy there was "something good toward the LORD." He may die in peace and be buried with honor. God sees the good even in a child from a bad family.

"Beyond the River": this means the Euphrates. Here the later carrying away of Israel by the Assyrians (2 Kings 17) is already announced.

"Asherah poles" were holy wooden poles for the goddess Asherah, a goddess of fertility.

The death of the child and Jeroboam's end VERSES 17–20

17 Jeroboam's wife got up and left.
She came to Tirzah.
As she stepped through the doorway of the house, the boy died.
18 All Israel buried him and mourned for him.
It happened as the LORD had said through his servant Ahijah the prophet.
19 The rest of Jeroboam's story is written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.
It tells how he fought and how he ruled.
20 Jeroboam ruled for 22 years.
Then he died and joined his ancestors.

His son Nadab became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For a mother this is unbearably hard: she comes home, and at that very moment her child dies. The Bible tells it without making it look nicer.

Anyone who has lost a child today is not alone in their grief. Lament has its place in the Bible. Help is available, for example: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

At that time Tirzah was the capital of the northern kingdom.

The "book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel" is an old book that is lost today. It is not the same as the books of Chronicles in the Bible.

Jeroboam ruled from about 930 to 909 BC.

Rehoboam, king of Judah VERSES 21–31

21 Rehoboam, the son of Solomon, ruled in Judah.
Rehoboam was 41 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 17 years in Jerusalem.
That is the city that the LORD had chosen out of all the tribes of Israel to put his name there.
His mother's name was Naamah the Ammonitess.

22 The people of Judah did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
They sinned more than their ancestors had ever done.
With their sins they made him jealous.

23 They also built themselves high places, sacred pillars, and Asherah poles.
They built them on every high hill and under every green tree.

24 There were also male shrine prostitutes in the land.
The people did all the disgusting things of the nations that the LORD had driven out before the people of Israel.

25 In the fifth year of King Rehoboam,
Shishak, the king of Egypt, attacked Jerusalem.

26 He took away the treasures of the LORD's house and the treasures of the king's house.
He took everything.
He also took all the gold shields that Solomon had made.

27 So King Rehoboam made shields of bronze to take their place.
He gave them to the commanders of the guard.
They guarded the door of the king's house.

28 Every time the king went into the LORD's house,
the guards carried the shields.
Then they brought them back to the guard room.

29 The rest of Rehoboam's story and everything he did are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Judah.

30 There was war between Rehoboam and Jeroboam the whole time.

31 Rehoboam died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried with his ancestors in David's city.
His mother's name was Naamah the Ammonitess.
His son Abijam became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even in the southern kingdom of Judah, where the temple stands, the worship of idols spreads. The temple alone does not make a people faithful.

"Sacred pillars" and "Asherah poles" were signs of Canaanite gods. "Under every green tree" means: everywhere in the land.

Verse 24: The WEB, our English source text, says "sodomites." We write "male shrine prostitutes." The Hebrew says "qadesh," word for word "one who is set apart." This probably means people who performed sexual acts in the service of other gods (so-called cult prostitution). Scholars disagree about what exactly this looked like. The verse is speaking about the worship of idols. It should not be used to look down on people.

The military campaign of Shishak (Pharaoh Shoshenq I) is also known from outside the Bible: in the temple of Karnak in Egypt there is an inscription with a list of the places he conquered in Palestine. That was about 925 BC.

Solomon's gold shields are gone. Rehoboam replaces them with bronze. That is a sad picture: from the outside it still looks similar, but the shine is lost.

Rehoboam's mother was an Ammonite, one of Solomon's foreign wives. That it is mentioned twice reminds us of Chapter 11.

Rehoboam ruled from about 930 to 913 BC.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 15

The kings Abijam, Asa, Nadab, and Baasha

Abijam, king of Judah VERSES 1–8

1 In the eighteenth year of King Jeroboam, the son of Nebat,
Abijam became king over Judah.

2 He ruled for three years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Maacah, the daughter of Abishalom.

3 He committed all the same sins that his father had committed before him.
His heart was not fully devoted to the LORD his God, as the heart of his father David had been.

4 But for David's sake the LORD his God gave him a lamp in Jerusalem.
He did this so that Abijam's son would be king after him,
and so that Jerusalem would stay strong.

5 David had done what was right in the LORD's eyes.
All his life he had not turned away from anything that the LORD commanded him.
The only exception was the matter of Uriah the Hittite.

6 There was war between Rehoboam and Jeroboam as long as he lived.

7 The rest of Abijam's story and everything he did
are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings
of Judah.
There was war between Abijam and Jeroboam.
8 Abijam died and joined his ancestors.
They buried him in David's city.
His son Asa became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

From now on the book takes turns telling about the kings in the south (Judah) and in the north (Israel). The years are always compared with the other kingdom: "In the eighteenth year of King Jeroboam."

Abishalom is probably Absalom, the son of David. Then Maacah was his daughter or granddaughter.

In 2 Chronicles 13 this king is called Abijah.

Again we hear: God stays faithful "for David's sake." The "lamp" in Jerusalem does not go out.

Verse 5 is honest: David, too, was not without guilt. His great wrong was the matter of Bathsheba and her husband Uriah (2 Samuel 11). The Bible does not keep quiet about it.

Verse 6: here it says "Rehoboam" once again. Some old copies of the Bible have "Abijam" instead. In any case, the war between north and south went on.

Abijam ruled from about 913 to 911 BC.

Asa, a good king of Judah VERSES 9–15

9 In the twentieth year of Jeroboam, the king of Israel,
Asa became king over Judah.
10 He ruled for 41 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Maacah, the daughter of
Abishalom.
11 Asa did what was right in the LORD's eyes, as his father
David had done.
12 He sent the male shrine prostitutes out of the land.
He removed all the idols that his ancestors had made.
13 He also removed his mother Maacah from her place as
queen.
She had made a disgusting image for Asherah.
Asa cut down her image and burned it at the brook
Kidron.
14 But the high places were not removed.
Even so, Asa's heart was fully devoted to the LORD as
long as he lived.
15 He brought into the LORD's house the gifts that his
father had set apart for God.
He also brought the gifts that he himself had set apart:
silver, gold, and other objects.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Finally a good king! Asa clears away the worship of idols.

"As his father David": this means his ancestor David. In Hebrew "father" can also mean "ancestor." It is the same with "his mother Maacah": according to verse 2, Maacah was the mother of Abijam, so she was really Asa's grandmother. As "queen mother" she had an important position at the royal court.

Asa removes her because she made an idol. That takes courage: he puts God above his own family.

The "high places" were altars on hills all over the land. Many of them were probably dedicated to the LORD, but according to Deuteronomy 12 people were to sacrifice only at the one place that God chooses. Asa did not do away with them. Even so, the Bible praises his honest heart.

The brook Kidron flows in the valley east of Jerusalem.

In verse 12 the WEB, our English source text, again says "sodomites." We write "male shrine prostitutes." See the explanation for 1 Kings 14:24.

Asa and Baasha at war VERSES 16–24

16 There was war between Asa and Baasha, the king of
Israel, as long as they lived.
17 Baasha, the king of Israel, attacked Judah.
He built up the town of Ramah into a fortress.
He wanted to stop anyone from going out to Asa, the
king of Judah, or coming in to him.
18 Then Asa took all the silver and gold
that was left in the treasure rooms of the LORD's
house and of the king's house.
He gave it to his servants.
King Asa sent them to Ben Hadad in Damascus.
Ben Hadad was the king of Syria.
He was the son of Tabrimmon, the son of Hezion.
Asa sent him this message:
19 "Let us make a treaty between me and you,
like the one between my father and your father.
I have sent you a gift of silver and gold.
Go and break your treaty with Baasha, the king of
Israel,
so that he will leave me alone."
20 Ben Hadad did what King Asa asked.
He sent the commanders of his armies against the
cities of Israel.
He attacked Ijon, Dan, Abel Beth Maacah, all of
Chinneroth,
and all the land of Naphtali.
21 Baasha heard about it.
Then he stopped building up Ramah.
He stayed in Tirzah.
22 Then King Asa called all the people of Judah together.
No one was allowed to stay home.
They carried away the stones and the wood that Baasha
had used to build up Ramah.
King Asa used them to build up Geba in Benjamin, and
Mizpah.
23 The rest of Asa's story is written in the book of the
chronicles of the kings of Judah.
It tells about all his strength, all that he did, and the
cities that he built.
But when he was old, he got a disease in his feet.
24 Asa died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried with his ancestors in the city of his
father David.
His son Jehoshaphat became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ramah was only about 5 miles north of Jerusalem. Baasha built it up into a fortress to cut off Jerusalem.

Asa defends himself with money instead of trust in God: he pays the king of Syria (Aram) to attack Israel in the north. The plan works. But for it he takes the treasures out of the temple. And he brings a foreign great power into the land, which later becomes dangerous for both kingdoms. Later the prophet Hanani scolds him for this (2 Chronicles 16:7–9).

Chinneroth is the area around the Sea of Galilee. Naphtali is the land in the north of Galilee.

In Hebrew "Syria" is "Aram," the land of the Arameans.

Asa ruled from about 911 to 870 BC, so a very long time.

Nadab and Baasha, kings of Israel VERSES 25–34

25 Nadab, the son of Jeroboam, became king over Israel.
It was in the second year of Asa, the king of Judah.
Nadab ruled over Israel for two years.
26 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He lived the way his father had lived.
He committed the same sin that his father had made Israel commit.
27 Baasha, the son of Ahijah, from the family of Issachar, made a plot against him.
Baasha killed him at Gibbethon, a town that belonged to the Philistines.
Nadab and all Israel were attacking Gibbethon at that time.
28 Baasha killed him in the third year of Asa, the king of Judah.
Then Baasha became king in his place.
29 As soon as he was king, he killed Jeroboam's whole family.
He did not leave alive anyone in Jeroboam's family.
He destroyed them all.
This was what the LORD had said through his servant Ahijah from Shiloh.
30 It happened because of the sins of Jeroboam.
Jeroboam sinned, and he made Israel sin.
He made the LORD, the God of Israel, angry.
31 The rest of Nadab's story and everything he did are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.
32 There was war between Asa and Baasha, the king of Israel, as long as they lived.
33 In the third year of Asa, the king of Judah,
Baasha, the son of Ahijah, became king over all Israel.
He ruled in Tirzah for 24 years.
34 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He lived the way Jeroboam had lived.
He committed the same sin that Jeroboam had made Israel commit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the northern kingdom a sad series begins: a king is murdered, and the murderer becomes king. Baasha kills Nadab and the whole family of Jeroboam.

In this way Ahijah's word comes true (1 Kings 14:10). But that does not make Baasha's murder good. Baasha himself is held to account for his deeds (1 Kings 16:7). The Bible shows: God can even fit evil deeds into his plan, but he does not approve of the violence.

And Baasha makes exactly the same mistakes as Jeroboam. He has learned nothing.

This Ahijah, Baasha's father, is not the prophet Ahijah from Shiloh.

Gibbethon was in the west, on the border with the land of the Philistines.

Nadab ruled from about 909 to 908 BC, Baasha from about 908 to 886.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 16

Kings come and go – and then comes Ahab

The word against Baasha VERSES 1–7

1 The word of the LORD came to Jehu, the son of Hanani.
It was a message against Baasha:
2 "I lifted you up out of the dust.
I made you leader over my people Israel.
But you have lived the way Jeroboam lived.
You have made my people Israel sin.
With their sins they make me angry.
3 So I will sweep away Baasha and his family completely.
I will make your family like the family of Jeroboam, the son of Nebat.
4 Anyone from Baasha's family who dies in the city will be eaten by the dogs.
Anyone from his family who dies in the open country will be eaten by the birds of the sky."
5 The rest of Baasha's story is written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.
It tells what he did and how strong he was.
6 Baasha died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried in Tirzah.
His son Elah became king in his place.
7 The word of the LORD also came through the prophet Jehu, the son of Hanani.
It was against Baasha and his family.
It came because of all the evil that Baasha did in the LORD's eyes.
With what he did, he made the LORD angry.
He was like the family of Jeroboam.
And he had also killed Jeroboam's family.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Baasha receives the same judgment as Jeroboam. God had lifted him up "out of the dust," that is, from a simple background. But he made nothing of it.

This prophet Jehu is not the later King Jehu (2 Kings 9).

Verse 7 is important: Baasha is also judged because he murdered Jeroboam's family. Even though God had announced Jeroboam's end, the murder was still a guilty act. God does not need murderers to fulfill his word, and he does not excuse violence.

Elah and Zimri VERSES 8–20

8 In the 26th year of Asa, the king of Judah,
Elah, the son of Baasha, became king over Israel.
He ruled in Tirzah for two years.
9 His servant Zimri made a plot against him.
Zimri was the commander of half of his chariots.
Elah was in Tirzah.

He was getting drunk in the house of Arza.
Arza was in charge of the king's household in Tirzah.
10 Zimri came in, attacked Elah, and killed him.
This was in the 27th year of Asa, the king of Judah.
Then Zimri became king in his place.
11 As soon as Zimri sat on the throne as king,
he attacked Baasha's whole family.
He did not leave alive a single one who urinates on a wall.
He killed Baasha's male relatives and his friends.
12 So Zimri destroyed Baasha's whole family.
This was what the LORD had said against Baasha through Jehu the prophet.
13 It happened because of all the sins of Baasha and of his son Elah.
They sinned, and they made Israel sin.
With their worthless idols they made the LORD, the God of Israel, angry.
14 The rest of Elah's story and everything he did
are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.
15 In the 27th year of Asa, the king of Judah,
Zimri ruled in Tirzah for seven days.
At that time the army was camped near Gibbethon to attack it.
Gibbethon belonged to the Philistines.
16 The soldiers in the camp heard the news:
Zimri had made a plot and had even killed the king.
So that same day in the camp, all Israel made Omri king over Israel.
Omri was the commander of the army.
17 Omri and all Israel with him left Gibbethon.
They went and surrounded Tirzah.
18 Zimri saw that the city was taken.
Then he went into the strongest part of the king's house.
He set the king's house on fire over himself,
and he died.
19 This happened because of the sins that he had committed.
He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He lived the way Jeroboam had lived.
He committed the same sin that Jeroboam had made Israel commit.
20 The rest of Zimri's story and the plot that he made
are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Another murder of a king. Elah is drunk when his own officer kills him.

Zimri rules for only seven days. The army makes its commander Omri king. Zimri sees no way out and burns himself to death in the palace.

"Worthless idols": word for word it says "empty things" or "breath." Idols are empty, without power.

The northern kingdom has no fixed royal family as Judah does. Whoever has the power becomes king. That leads to new violence again and again.

Omri and the new capital, Samaria VERSES 21–28

21 Then the people of Israel split into two groups.
Half of the people followed Tibni, the son of Ginath.
They wanted to make him king.
The other half followed Omri.
22 But the people who followed Omri were stronger
than the people who followed Tibni, the son of Ginath.
So Tibni died, and Omri became king.
23 In the 31st year of Asa, the king of Judah,
Omri became king over Israel.
He ruled for 12 years.
Six of these years he ruled in Tirzah.
24 He bought the hill of Samaria from Shemer
for two talents of silver (about 150 pounds).
He built a city on the hill.
He named the city Samaria,
after Shemer, the owner of the hill.
25 Omri did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He did more evil than all the kings before him.
26 He lived the way Jeroboam, the son of Nebat, had lived.
He committed all the same sins that Jeroboam had made Israel commit.
With their worthless idols they made the LORD, the God of Israel, angry.
27 The rest of Omri's story is written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.
It tells what he did and how strong he was.
28 Omri died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried in Samaria.
His son Ahab became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says "two talents of silver." A talent is about 75 pounds. So two talents are about 150 pounds.

Omri founds the city of Samaria. For almost 150 years it will be the capital of the northern kingdom. Later the name was also used for the whole region. That is also where the "Samaritans" of the New Testament come from.

The Bible tells only a little about Omri. But outside the Bible he was very well known: Omri is named on the Mesha Stone, an inscription of the king of Moab. And long after that, the Assyrians still called Israel "the house of Omri."

But for the Bible, what counts is not political power, but faithfulness to God. That is why the judgment is short and harsh.

Omri ruled from about 885 to 874 BC.

Ahab and Jezebel VERSES 29–34

29 In the 38th year of Asa, the king of Judah,
Ahab, the son of Omri, became king over Israel.
Ahab, the son of Omri, ruled over Israel in Samaria for 22 years.
30 Ahab, the son of Omri, did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He did more evil than all the kings before him.
31 To live in the sins of Jeroboam, the son of Nebat, was not enough for him.
He married Jezebel.
She was the daughter of Ethbaal, the king of the Sidonians.
Ahab went and served Baal and worshiped him.

32 Ahab had built a temple for Baal in Samaria.
In this temple of Baal he set up an altar for Baal.
33 Ahab also made the Asherah pole.
Ahab did more to make the LORD, the God of Israel, angry
than all the kings of Israel before him.
34 In Ahab's time, Hiel from Bethel built Jericho again.
When he laid its foundation, it cost him Abiram, his firstborn son.
When he set up its gates, it cost him Segub, his youngest son.
This was what the LORD had said through Joshua, the son of Nun.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now a new, dark time begins. Ahab marries Jezebel, a princess from Sidon in Phoenicia (in what is Lebanon today). With her the worship of Baal comes to Israel, and officially, with a temple in the capital.

Baal was the god of the weather, of rain, and of fertility. People believed that he gave rain and good harvests. That is important for the next chapters.

Ahab is also known from outside the Bible: an Assyrian inscription (the Kurkh Monolith) names "Ahab the Israelite." In 853 BC he fought against the Assyrians with 2,000 chariots in the battle of Qarqar.

Verse 34 reminds us of Joshua's curse on Jericho (Joshua 6:26): whoever builds the city again will lose his sons. The text does not say exactly whether Hiel sacrificed his sons or whether they died during the building. Both would be terrible. The Bible wants to show: God's word comes true, even after hundreds of years.

Ahab ruled from about 874 to 853 BC.

1 KINGS

Chapter 17

Elijah, the ravens, and the widow

Elijah announces the drought VERSES 1–7

1 Elijah the Tishbite, one of the settlers of Gilead, said to Ahab,
"As the LORD, the God of Israel, lives, before whom I stand:
in these years there will be no dew or rain,
except at my word."
2 Then the word of the LORD came to him:
3 "Go away from here, turn east,
and hide yourself by the brook Cherith, which is east of the Jordan.
4 You will drink from the brook.
And I have commanded the ravens to feed you there."
5 So he went and did what the LORD had said.
He went and lived by the brook Cherith, which is east of the Jordan.
6 The ravens brought him bread and meat in the morning,
and bread and meat in the evening.
And he drank from the brook.
7 After a while the brook dried up,
because there was no rain in the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now one of the greatest prophets of the Bible appears: Elijah. His name means "My God is the LORD." Even his name is a message against the worship of Baal.

Elijah announces a drought. That is a direct challenge to Baal, who was supposed to be the god of rain. Who really has power over the rain?

"Before whom I stand" means: whom I serve.

God takes care of Elijah in an unusual way: ravens bring him food. Ravens were seen as unclean birds. God can also provide through helpers you would not expect.

It is not certain where Tishbe was. Gilead is the hill country east of the Jordan.

The WEB, our English source text, says "before the Jordan." This probably means "east of the Jordan," because Elijah is to "turn east."

The widow in Zarephath VERSES 8–16

8 Then the word of the LORD came to him:
9 "Get up, go to Zarephath, which belongs to Sidon, and stay there.
I have commanded a widow there to take care of you."
10 So he got up and went to Zarephath.
When he came to the gate of the city,
a widow was there gathering sticks.
He called to her and said,
"Please get me a little water in a jar, so that I may drink."
11 As she was going to get it, he called to her and said,
"Please also bring me a piece of bread."
12 She said,
"As the LORD your God lives,
I don't have anything baked,
only a handful of flour in a jar and a little oil in a jug.
I am gathering two sticks.
Then I will go in and bake it for me and my son.
Then we will eat it and die."
13 Elijah said to her,
"Don't be afraid.
Go and do as you have said.
But first make me a little cake from it and bring it out to me.
After that, make some for yourself and your son.
14 For the LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'The jar of flour will not run out,
and the jug of oil will not run dry,
until the day that the LORD sends rain on the earth.'"
15 She went and did as Elijah had said.
And she, he, and her household ate for many days.
16 The jar of flour did not run out,
and the jug of oil did not run dry,
as the LORD had said through Elijah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Of all places, God sends Elijah to Sidon, Jezebel's homeland, right into the land of Baal. And there a poor foreign widow helps him.

The woman has almost nothing left. She expects that she and her son will starve. Even so, she shares the last she has. That takes great trust.

Elijah's first words are: "Don't be afraid." And God takes care of all three of them, day after day.

In Nazareth Jesus reminded people of this woman: there were many widows in Israel, but Elijah was sent to a foreign woman (Luke 4:25–26). God's goodness is not only for one people.

The widow's son comes back to life VERSES 17–24

17 After this, the son of the woman who owned the house
became sick.
His sickness was so bad that there was no breath left in
him.
18 She said to Elijah,
"What do I have to do with you, you man of God?
You have come to me to remind me of my sin
and to kill my son!"
19 He said to her,
"Give me your son."
He took him from her arms
and carried him up into the upper room where he was
staying,
and laid him on his own bed.
20 He cried out to the LORD and said,
"LORD my God,
have you also brought disaster on the widow I am
staying with,
by killing her son?"
21 He stretched himself out over the child three times,
cried out to the LORD, and said,
"LORD my God, please let this child's soul come back
into him."
22 The LORD listened to Elijah's voice.
And the child's soul came back into him, and he came
back to life.
23 Elijah took the child,
brought him down from the upper room into the
house,
and gave him to his mother.
And Elijah said,
"Look, your son is alive."
24 The woman said to Elijah,
"Now I know that you are a man of God
and that the word of the LORD in your mouth is
truth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The mother is in despair. She thinks: my child is dying because of my guilt. Many people have this thought when something terrible happens. The Bible shows: sickness and death are not a punishment for the mother. God gives the child his life back.

Elijah, too, honestly complains to God: "Have you also brought disaster on the widow I am staying with, by killing her son?" We are allowed to complain to God and to ask him questions.

This is the first time in the Bible that a dead person is raised to life. Elijah's successor Elisha later does something similar (2 Kings 4). And Jesus also raised the son of a widow, in Nain (Luke 7:11–17).

In Hebrew, the word "soul" here means the life force of a person.

At the end the foreign woman confesses: the word of the LORD is truth.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 18

Elijah on Mount Carmel

Elijah and Obadiah VERSES 1–16

1 Many days passed.
In the third year, the LORD spoke to Elijah.
He said, "Go and let Ahab see you.
Then I will send rain on the earth."
2 So Elijah went to let Ahab see him.
The famine was very bad in Samaria.
3 Ahab called Obadiah, who was in charge of the palace.
Obadiah had great respect for the LORD.
4 Once Jezebel was killing the LORD's prophets.
Then Obadiah took 100 prophets
and hid them in caves, 50 in each cave.
He gave them bread and water.
5 Ahab said to Obadiah,
"Go through the land to all the springs and to all the
streams.
Maybe we will find grass.
Then we can keep the horses and mules alive.
We do not want to lose all the animals."
6 So they divided the land between them to go through
it.
Ahab went one way by himself.
Obadiah went another way by himself.
7 Obadiah was on his way.
Suddenly Elijah met him.
Obadiah knew who he was.
He bowed down with his face to the ground and said,
"Is it you, my lord Elijah?"
8 He answered him,
"Yes, it is me.
Go and tell your master, 'Elijah is here!'"
9 Obadiah said,
"What wrong have I done?
Why do you want to hand me, your servant, over to
Ahab?
He will kill me.
10 As surely as the LORD your God lives,
my master has sent people to every nation and
kingdom to look for you.

When they said, 'He is not here,'
he made that kingdom and nation swear that they had not found you.
11 And now you say,
'Go and tell your master, "Elijah is here."'
12 As soon as I leave you,
the Spirit of the LORD will carry you away.
I don't know where.
Then I will come and tell Ahab, and he will not find you.
Then he will kill me.
But I, your servant, have had respect for the LORD since I was young.
13 Hasn't anyone told my lord what I did
when Jezebel killed the LORD's prophets?
I hid 100 of the LORD's prophets in caves,
50 in each cave.
I gave them bread and water.
14 And now you say,
'Go and tell your master, "Elijah is here."'
He will kill me."
15 Elijah said,
"I serve the LORD of Armies.
As surely as he lives, I will let Ahab see me today."
16 So Obadiah went to meet Ahab and told him.
Then Ahab went to meet Elijah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

It has not rained for more than two years. The land is suffering. Ahab is worried about his horses.

Obadiah is a brave man. He works directly for the king. But in secret he saves 100 prophets from Queen Jezebel. He shows: even in a difficult place you can stay faithful to God and save lives.

Obadiah is afraid. He fears that Elijah will disappear again and that Ahab will then kill him. Elijah promises him: I will stay.

This Obadiah is not the same as the prophet Obadiah after whom a book of the Bible is named.

"The LORD of Armies" (in Hebrew "Sabaoth") is a name of God. It means: God is the Lord over all powers in heaven and on earth.

Who brings trouble on Israel? VERSES 17–19

17 Ahab saw Elijah.
He said to him,
"Is that you, you troublemaker of Israel?"
18 Elijah answered,
"I have not brought trouble on Israel.
You and your father's family have done it.
You have turned away from the LORD's commandments.
You have followed the Baals.
19 Now send messengers.
Call all Israel to me at Mount Carmel.
Also bring the 450 prophets of Baal
and the 400 prophets of the Asherah, who eat at Jezebel's table."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahab blames Elijah for the drought. Elijah answers clearly: the messenger is not to blame, but the one who has abandoned God.

Mount Carmel is on the Mediterranean Sea, near what is Haifa today. It was on the border between Israel and Phoenicia. Baal may also have been worshiped there.

"The Baals": Baal was worshiped in many places under different names.

"Who eat at Jezebel's table" means: Jezebel paid these prophets and provided for them.

The decision on Mount Carmel VERSES 20–29

20 So Ahab sent messengers to all the people of Israel.
He brought the prophets together at Mount Carmel.
21 Elijah came close to all the people and said,
"How long will you waver between the two sides?
If the LORD is God, follow him.
But if Baal is God, then follow him."
The people did not say a word.
22 Then Elijah said to the people,
"I am the only prophet of the LORD who is left.
But Baal has 450 prophets.
23 Let them give us two bulls.
Let them choose one bull for themselves.
They should cut it into pieces and lay it on the wood.
But they must not light a fire under it.
I will prepare the other bull.
I will lay it on the wood.
I will not light a fire under it either.
24 Then you call on the name of your god.
I will call on the name of the LORD.
The God who answers with fire, he is God."
All the people answered,
"That is a good idea."
25 Elijah said to the prophets of Baal,
"Choose one bull for yourselves and prepare it first, because there are many of you.
Call on the name of your god.
But do not light a fire under it."
26 They took the bull that was given to them
and prepared it.
They called on the name of Baal from morning until noon.
They shouted, "Baal, hear us!"
But there was no sound.
No one answered.
They danced around the altar they had made.
27 At noon Elijah made fun of them.
He said,
"Shout louder! After all, he is a god!
Maybe he is deep in thought.
Or he has gone somewhere.
Or he is on a trip.
Or maybe he is asleep, and someone must wake him up."
28 So they shouted louder.
They cut themselves with knives and spears, as they usually did.
They did it until blood poured down over them.
29 Noon passed.
They kept on raving like prophets
until the time of the evening offering.
But there was no sound and no answer.
No one paid any attention.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Waver between the two sides": word for word the Hebrew says "limp on two crutches." The people want both, the LORD and Baal. Elijah says: make up your minds! You cannot serve two masters (compare Matthew 6:24).

The test is fair, even favorable for Baal: Baal was thought to be the god of storms and lightning. Fire from heaven should be easy for him.

The prophets of Baal shout for hours. They dance and hurt themselves. But no answer comes. That is the heart of it: idols cannot hear and cannot answer.

Elijah's mocking is sharp: "Maybe he is asleep." Behind "he has gone somewhere" there is probably a crude Hebrew expression that can also mean "he is in the toilet."

The evening offering was brought in the late afternoon.

Fire from heaven VERSES 30–40

30 Then Elijah said to all the people,
"Come close to me!"
So all the people came close to him.
The altar of the LORD had been torn down.
Elijah repaired it.
31 Elijah took 12 stones.
That was the number of the tribes of the sons of Jacob.
The LORD had spoken to Jacob and said,
"Your name will be Israel."
32 With the stones Elijah built an altar in the name of the LORD.
He dug a ditch around the altar.
It was big enough to hold about 3½ gallons of seed.
33 He put the wood in order.
He cut the bull into pieces and laid it on the wood.
He said,
"Fill four jars with water.
Pour it on the burnt offering and on the wood."
34 He said,
"Do it again."
And they did it again.
He said,
"Do it a third time."
And they did it a third time.
35 The water ran all around the altar.
He also filled the ditch with water.
36 It was the time of the evening offering.
Elijah the prophet stepped forward and said,
"LORD, God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel,
show today that you are God in Israel.
Show that I am your servant.
Show that I have done all these things because you told me to.
37 Hear me, LORD, hear me!
Then this people will know that you, LORD, are God.
They will know that you have turned their hearts back again."
38 Then the fire of the LORD fell.
It burned up the burnt offering, the wood, the stones, and the dirt.
It also dried up the water in the ditch.
39 All the people saw it.
They bowed down with their faces to the ground.
They said,
"The LORD, he is God!
The LORD, he is God!"
40 Elijah said to them,
"Grab the prophets of Baal!
Don't let a single one of them get away!"
They grabbed them.
Elijah brought them down to the brook Kishon and killed them there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elijah rebuilds the old altar with 12 stones, for all 12 tribes. Even though the kingdom is split, for God all of Israel belongs together.

Then he has everything soaked with water, and that in a drought, when water is so precious! No one should be able to say it was a trick.

Elijah's prayer is short and simple. He does not dance, he does not cut himself. He only asks: "Hear me, LORD, hear me! Then this people will know that you, LORD, are God." And God answers.

The people cry: "The LORD, he is God!" In Hebrew: "Adonai hu ha-Elohim!" To this day, this cry is part of Jewish worship at the end of Yom Kippur, the Day of Atonement.

Verse 40 is very hard: Elijah has the prophets of Baal killed. In those days, according to the law, the death penalty was for those who led people into the worship of idols (Deuteronomy 13). Jezebel had also killed the LORD's prophets before. Even so: this story is not an example for today. No one may kill people or use violence against them in God's name. Jesus clearly forbade his disciples to call down fire from heaven on people who believed differently (Luke 9:54–55).

For the ditch, the Bible says "two seahs of seed." A seah is about 7 quarts.

The brook Kishon flows into the Mediterranean Sea at the foot of Mount Carmel.

The rain comes VERSES 41–46

41 Elijah said to Ahab,
"Get up, eat and drink.
I hear the sound of heavy rain."
42 So Ahab went up to eat and drink.
But Elijah went up to the top of Mount Carmel.
He bowed down to the ground.
He put his face between his knees.
43 He said to his servant,
"Go up and look toward the sea."
The servant went up and looked.
He said,
"There is nothing."
Seven times Elijah said,
"Go again."
44 The seventh time, the servant said,
"A small cloud is rising out of the sea.
It is as small as a man's hand."
Elijah said,
"Go up and tell Ahab,
'Get ready and go down,
so that the rain does not stop you.'"
45 In a short time the sky became black with clouds and wind.
A heavy rain began.
Ahab rode off and went to Jezreel.

46 The hand of the LORD was on Elijah.
That means: the LORD gave him special strength.
Elijah tucked his cloak into his belt.
He ran ahead of Ahab all the way to the entrance of Jezreel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the great fire, Elijah prays very quietly and humbly, with his face between his knees. He keeps on praying, up to the seventh time. The letter of James calls Elijah an example in prayer. He was "a person like us" (James 5:17–18).

At first the cloud is only as small as a hand. But from it comes a great rain. Great things often start very small.

The rain proves: not Baal, but the LORD gives the rain.

Elijah runs ahead of the king's chariot, about 15 to 20 miles to Jezreel. God gives him strength beyond what is natural. It is also a sign: Elijah honors the king, even though he has spoken against him.

Jezreel was a second royal city of Ahab, in the fertile plain east of Mount Carmel.

1 KINGS

Chapter 19

Elijah at Mount Horeb

Elijah runs away and wants to die VERSES 1–8

1 Ahab told Jezebel everything that Elijah had done.
He told her how Elijah had killed all the prophets with the sword.
2 Then Jezebel sent a messenger to Elijah with this message:
"May the gods do this to me and even more,
if by this time tomorrow I have not made your life like the life of one of them!"
3 Elijah saw this.
He got up and ran for his life.
He came to Beersheba, which belongs to Judah.
He left his servant there.
4 But he himself went a day's journey into the wilderness.
He sat down under a juniper tree.
He asked that he might die.
He said,
"It is enough.
Now, LORD, take my life.
I am no better than my ancestors."
5 He lay down under the juniper tree and fell asleep.
Suddenly an angel touched him.
The angel said to him,
"Get up and eat!"
6 Elijah looked around.
There by his head was a flat bread baked on hot coals, and a jar of water.
He ate and drank.
Then he lay down again.
7 The angel of the LORD came a second time.
He touched Elijah and said,
"Get up and eat.
The journey is too far for you."
8 Elijah got up, ate, and drank.
The food gave him strength.
In that strength he walked 40 days and 40 nights to Horeb, God's mountain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Just a little while ago Elijah saw the great victory on Mount Carmel. Now Jezebel threatens him, and he breaks down. He runs away as far as he can, all the way to the south.

Elijah is worn out and in despair. He does not want to live anymore. The Bible does not keep quiet about this: even a great person of faith can come to the end of their strength and feel deep sadness.

God does not scold him. He sends an angel who touches him gently, gives him food and water, and lets him sleep. First rest and strength, then the journey. "The journey is too far for you": God knows our limits.

If you yourself are thinking, "It is enough, I don't want to live anymore": you are not alone. Please talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

"Juniper tree": in Hebrew the plant is called "rotem." It is a broom bush that grows in the desert and gives a little shade.

The 40 days and nights remind us of Moses, who was on Mount Sinai for 40 days (Exodus 34:28). Jesus, too, was in the wilderness for 40 days (Matthew 4:2). Horeb is Mount Sinai, where God met Moses.

God speaks in a quiet voice VERSES 9–18

9 There he came to a cave and spent the night in it.
Then the word of the LORD came to him.
The LORD said to him,
"What are you doing here, Elijah?"
10 Elijah said,
"I have been very jealous for the LORD, the God of Armies.
The people of Israel have turned away from your covenant.
They have torn down your altars.
They have killed your prophets with the sword.
I am the only one left.
And now they are trying to kill me too."
11 The LORD said,
"Go out and stand on the mountain before the LORD."
Then the LORD passed by.
A great, strong wind tore the mountains apart and broke the rocks into pieces before the LORD.
But the LORD was not in the wind.
After the wind there was an earthquake.
But the LORD was not in the earthquake.
12 After the earthquake there was a fire.
But the LORD was not in the fire.
After the fire there was a still small voice.

13 When Elijah heard it, he covered his face with his cloak.
He went out and stood at the entrance of the cave.
Then a voice came to him and said,
"What are you doing here, Elijah?"
14 Elijah said,
"I have been very jealous for the LORD, the God of Armies.
The people of Israel have turned away from your covenant.
They have torn down your altars.
They have killed your prophets with the sword.
I am the only one left.
And now they are trying to kill me too."
15 The LORD said to him,
"Go back the way you came, to the wilderness of Damascus.
When you get there, anoint Hazael to be king over Syria.
16 Anoint Jehu, the son of Nimshi, to be king over Israel.
And anoint Elisha, the son of Shaphat, from Abel Meholah.
He will be prophet in your place.
17 Whoever escapes from the sword of Hazael, Jehu will kill.
Whoever escapes from the sword of Jehu, Elisha will kill.
18 But I have kept 7,000 people in Israel for myself.
Their knees have not bowed down to Baal.
Their mouths have not kissed him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the best-known passages of the Bible. Twice God asks: "What are you doing here, Elijah?" He does not ask harshly, but invites Elijah to talk.

Elijah pours out his heart: I have given everything, and now I am all alone.

Then come storm, earthquake, and fire, as once at Mount Sinai. But God is not in them. God comes in a "still small voice." Word for word the Hebrew says something like: "a sound of thin silence." God is not only in what is spectacular. Often he meets us quietly, in the silence.

Elijah had seen the great fire on Mount Carmel. Now he learns: God also works quietly and in hidden ways.

God gives Elijah new tasks. He has not been written off. And he gets a successor, Elisha. He no longer has to carry the burden alone.

And Elijah is not the only one: 7,000 people have stayed faithful to God. Someone who feels alone often does not know how many others there still are. Paul quotes this verse in Romans 11:4.

Verse 17 sounds harsh. Hazael and Jehu will later bring war and judgment on the house of Ahab and the worship of Baal (2 Kings 8–10). With Elisha it probably means his prophetic word, not that he himself kills with the sword.

"Kissing Baal": in those days people kissed idols as a sign of worship.

In Hebrew "Syria" is "Aram."

Elisha is called VERSES 19–21

19 So Elijah left that place.
He found Elisha, the son of Shaphat.
Elisha was plowing with 12 pairs of oxen in front of him.
He himself was with the twelfth pair.
Elijah went over to him and threw his cloak over him.
20 Elisha left the oxen and ran after Elijah.
He said,
"Please let me kiss my father and my mother goodbye.
Then I will follow you."
Elijah said to him,
"Go back again.
What have I done to you?"
21 Elisha went back.
He took the pair of oxen and killed them.
He used the oxen's equipment as firewood and boiled their meat.
He gave it to the people, and they ate.
Then he got up and followed Elijah.
He served him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elisha was a rich farmer: 12 pairs of oxen were a lot.

Elijah throws his cloak over him. That is a sign: you are to be my successor.

Elijah's answer, "What have I done to you?", probably means: decide for yourself. I am not forcing you.

Elisha makes a clear decision: he kills the oxen and burns the plow as firewood. There is no going back. And he holds a farewell meal with the people.

Jesus hinted at this story: "No one who puts his hand to the plow and then looks back is fit for God's Kingdom" (Luke 9:61–62).

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 20

Ahab's wars against Syria

Ben Hadad surrounds Samaria VERSES 1–12

1 Ben Hadad, the king of Syria, gathered his whole army.
There were 32 kings with him, with horses and chariots.
He went up, surrounded Samaria, and fought against it.
2 He sent messengers into the city to Ahab king of Israel and said to him,
"Ben Hadad says:
3 'Your silver and your gold are mine.
Your wives and your children, the best ones, are mine too.'"
4 The king of Israel answered,
"It is as you say, my lord the king.
I am yours, with all that I have."
5 The messengers came again and said,
"Ben Hadad says:

'I sent to you and said,
"You must give me your silver, your gold, your wives,
and your children."
6 But tomorrow about this time I will send my servants
to you.
They will search your house and the houses of your
servants.
Whatever you like, they will take in their hands and
carry away.'"
7 Then the king of Israel called all the elders of the land
and said,
"Please notice how this man is looking for trouble.
He sent to me for my wives and my children,
for my silver and my gold,
and I did not refuse him."
8 All the elders and all the people said to him,
"Don't listen, and don't agree."
9 So he said to the messengers of Ben Hadad,
"Tell my lord the king:
'Everything you first asked of your servant I will do.
But this thing I cannot do.'"
The messengers left and brought him the answer.
10 Ben Hadad sent word to him:
"May the gods do this to me and even more,
if the dust of Samaria is enough
to give a handful to each of the people who follow me!"
11 The king of Israel answered,
"Tell him:
'Don't let the one who puts on his armor boast like the
one who takes it off.'"
12 Ben Hadad heard this answer while he was drinking
with the kings in the tents.
He said to his servants,
"Get ready to attack!"
And they got ready to attack the city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ben Hadad was the king of the Arameans in Damascus. "Ben Hadad" means "son of Hadad." Hadad was a weather god. Several kings had this name.

The 32 kings were probably rulers of small cities and tribes who were his allies.

Ben Hadad wants to humiliate Ahab. First Ahab is to submit. Then Ben Hadad even wants to have Ahab's house plundered. Then the elders say: enough!

Verse 10 means: we are so many that there will not even be enough dust left of Samaria for each of us.

Ahab's answer is a proverb: someone who is only going into battle should not boast like someone who has already won. In other words: don't celebrate too soon.

An unexpected victory VERSES 13–22

13 A prophet came to Ahab king of Israel and said,
"The LORD says:
'Have you seen this whole great crowd?
I will hand it over to you today.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.'"
14 Ahab asked,
"Through whom?"
He said,
"The LORD says:
'Through the young men of the leaders of the
provinces.'"
Then he asked,
"Who should begin the battle?"
He answered,
"You."
15 So he called up the young men of the leaders of the
provinces.
There were 232.
After them he called up all the people, all the people of
Israel: 7,000.
16 They went out at noon.
But Ben Hadad was drinking himself drunk in the
tents,
he and the kings, the 32 kings who were helping him.
17 The young men of the leaders of the provinces went out
first.
Ben Hadad sent out scouts, and they told him,
"Men are coming out from Samaria."
18 He said,
"If they have come out for peace, take them alive.
And if they have come out for war, take them alive
too."
19 So they went out of the city,
the young men of the leaders of the provinces and the
army that followed them.
20 Each one killed his man.
The Syrians fled, and Israel chased them.
Ben Hadad the king of Syria escaped on a horse with
some horsemen.
21 The king of Israel went out,
struck the horses and the chariots,
and brought a great defeat on the Syrians.
22 The prophet came to the king of Israel and said to him,
"Go, make yourself strong, and think about what you
must do.
For when the year comes around again, the king of
Syria will come up against you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even though Ahab is a bad king, God helps Israel. He even sends a prophet. The reason: "Then you will know that I am the LORD." God gives Ahab one more chance to know him.

The army is small: at first only 232 young men. They attack at noon, when Ben Hadad is already drunk. God does not win through large numbers.

"When the year comes around again" means: in spring. In those days military campaigns began in spring.

God of the hills and of the valleys VERSES 23–30

23 The servants of the king of Syria said to him,
"Their god is a god of the hills.
That is why they were stronger than we were.
But let's fight against them in the plain,
and we will surely be stronger than they are.
24 Do this:
remove the kings, each one from his place,
and put captains in their place.
25 Gather an army like the army that you lost,
horse for horse and chariot for chariot.
We will fight against them in the plain,
and we will surely be stronger than they are."
He listened to their advice and did so.

26 When the year came around again,
Ben Hadad called up the Syrians
and went up to Aphek to fight against Israel.
27 The people of Israel were also called up and given supplies,
and they went out against them.
The people of Israel camped opposite them like two little flocks of young goats.
But the Syrians filled the countryside.
28 A man of God came and said to the king of Israel,
"The LORD says:
'Because the Syrians have said,
"The LORD is a god of the hills, but he is not a god of the valleys,"
I will hand over this whole great crowd to you.
And you will know that I am the LORD.'"
29 They camped opposite each other for seven days.
On the seventh day the battle began.
The people of Israel killed 100,000 Syrian foot soldiers in one day.
30 The rest fled to Aphek, into the city.
Then the wall fell on the 27,000 men who were left.
Ben Hadad fled and came into the city, into an inner room.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Arameans thought: each god is only in charge of a certain area. The God of Israel is a god of the hills, so we will fight in the valley.

God shows: I am not tied to one place. I am the Lord over hills and valleys, over the whole world.

Aphek was probably east of the Sea of Galilee, on a plain.

The numbers are very large. In old reports of wars, numbers were often exaggerated or given in round numbers. Some experts think that the Hebrew word for "thousand" here means a military unit.

Ahab sets Ben Hadad free VERSES 31–34

31 His servants said to him,
"Look, we have heard that the kings of the house of Israel are merciful kings.
Please let us put sackcloth around our waists and ropes on our heads,
and go out to the king of Israel.
Maybe he will spare your life."
32 So they put sackcloth around their waists and ropes on their heads,
came to the king of Israel, and said,
"Your servant Ben Hadad says, 'Please let me live.'"
He said,
"Is he still alive? He is my brother."
33 The men were watching closely for a sign.
They quickly took up this word and said,
"Your brother Ben Hadad!"
He said,
"Go, bring him."
Then Ben Hadad came out to him,
and he had him come up into his chariot.
34 Ben Hadad said to him,
"I will give back the cities that my father took from your father.
And you may set up market streets for yourself in Damascus,
as my father did in Samaria."
Ahab said,
"With this agreement I will let you go."
So he made an agreement with him and let him go.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sackcloth (rough cloth) and ropes around the neck were signs of surrender and of asking for mercy.

Ahab calls his enemy "my brother." Among kings that meant: we are allies of equal rank. Ahab makes a good deal for himself: cities and trading rights.

At first sight this looks generous. But God had given the victory, and Ahab does not ask God what he should do. He only acts for his own advantage. Ben Hadad will fight against Israel again later.

A prophet with a parable VERSES 35–43

35 By the word of the LORD a man from the sons of the prophets said to his companion,
"Please strike me!"
But the man refused to strike him.
36 Then he said to him,
"Because you have not obeyed the voice of the LORD, as soon as you leave me, a lion will kill you."
And as soon as he left him, a lion found him and killed him.
37 Then he found another man and said,
"Please strike me!"
The man struck him and wounded him.
38 So the prophet went and waited for the king by the road.
He disguised himself with his headband over his eyes.
39 As the king passed by, he called out to the king,
"Your servant went out into the middle of the battle.
And a man came over and brought a man to me and said,
'Guard this man!
If he goes missing in any way, your life will be for his life,
or else you must pay a talent of silver (about 75 pounds).'
40 While your servant was busy here and there, he was gone."
The king of Israel said to him,
"That will be your sentence.
You yourself have decided it."
41 Then he quickly took the headband away from his eyes.
And the king of Israel recognized that he was one of the prophets.
42 He said to him,
"The LORD says:
'Because you have let go out of your hand the man whom I had set apart for destruction,
your life will take the place of his life,
and your people will take the place of his people.'"
43 The king of Israel went home sullen and angry,
and came to Samaria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "sons of the prophets" were groups of students who lived and learned together with a prophet.

The prophet needs a real wound so that he looks like a wounded soldier. The story with the lion is hard. It reminds

us of Chapter 13: a clear word of God must be taken seriously.

The prophet tells the king a parable, as Nathan once did with David (2 Samuel 12). With his own judgment, Ahab declares himself guilty.

The Bible says "a talent of silver." A talent is about 75 pounds. That was a huge sum, which a simple soldier could never pay.

"Set apart for destruction" means: God had handed Ben Hadad over to judgment. Ahab set him free for his own advantage. It is important to see: this is about a king who is waging war. It is not a command to people today to kill others.

Ahab is "sullen and angry." He is upset, but he does not turn back.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 21

Naboth's vineyard

Ahab wants the vineyard VERSES 1–7

1 After these things, this happened:
Naboth from Jezreel had a vineyard in Jezreel.
It was next to the palace of Ahab, the king of Samaria.
2 Ahab spoke to Naboth.
He said,
"Give me your vineyard.
I want to use it for a vegetable garden,
because it is near my house.
I will give you a better vineyard for it.
Or, if you like, I will give you what it is worth in money."
3 Naboth said to Ahab,
"May the LORD keep me from doing that!
I will not give you the inheritance of my ancestors."
4 Ahab went into his house sullen and angry,
because of what Naboth from Jezreel had said to him.
Naboth had said,
"I will not give you the inheritance of my ancestors."
Ahab lay down on his bed.
He turned his face away.
He would not eat any food.
5 But his wife Jezebel came to him.
She said to him,
"Why are you so sad?
Why won't you eat any food?"
6 He said to her,
"I spoke to Naboth from Jezreel.
I said to him,
'Sell me your vineyard for money.
Or, if you like, I will give you another vineyard for it.'
But he answered,
'I will not give you my vineyard.'"
7 His wife Jezebel said to him,
"Are you the king of Israel or not?
Get up and eat some food.
Be happy.
I will give you the vineyard of Naboth from Jezreel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahab's offer seems fair. But for Naboth it is not about money. The land was "the inheritance of my ancestors," as Naboth says. According to God's law the land was to stay in the family, because it really belonged to God (Leviticus 25:23). Naboth acts faithfully according to God's commandment.

Ahab behaves like a sulking child: he goes to bed, turns his face away, and eats nothing.

Jezebel thinks differently. In her homeland, Phoenicia, the king could take whatever he wanted. In Israel even the king was meant to stand under God's law.

Jezebel's evil plan VERSES 8–16

8 So Jezebel wrote letters in Ahab's name.
She sealed them with his seal.
She sent the letters to the elders and the nobles in Naboth's city.
They lived in the same city as Naboth.
9 In the letters she wrote:
"Announce a day of fasting.
Give Naboth a seat of honor among the people.
10 Seat two wicked men across from him.
Let them testify against him:
'You cursed God and the king!'
Then take him out and stone him to death."
11 The men of Naboth's city did what Jezebel had told them.
They were the elders and the nobles who lived in his city.
They did what was written in the letters that she had sent them.
12 They announced a day of fasting.
They gave Naboth a seat of honor among the people.
13 The two wicked men came in and sat across from him.
In front of the people, the wicked men testified against Naboth:
"Naboth cursed God and the king!"
Then the people took Naboth out of the city.
They threw stones at him until he was dead.
14 Then they sent a message to Jezebel:
"Naboth has been stoned. He is dead."
15 Jezebel heard that Naboth had been stoned and was dead.
Then she said to Ahab,
"Get up and take the vineyard of Naboth from Jezreel.
He refused to sell it to you for money.
But Naboth is not alive anymore.
He is dead."
16 Ahab heard that Naboth was dead.
Then Ahab got up.
He went down to the vineyard of Naboth from Jezreel to take it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is murder carried out through the courts. Jezebel uses the king's name, a religious fast, and a trial with false

witnesses to kill an innocent man.

According to the law, two witnesses were needed for a person to be found guilty (Deuteronomy 17:6). Jezebel gets exactly two, but liars. Here three of the Ten Commandments are broken (Exodus 20:13–17). The commandment "You must not give false testimony against your neighbor" is broken in order to break the commandment "You must not murder." And all this only because Ahab wants someone else's vineyard. The tenth commandment forbids exactly that.

It is also shocking that the elders and nobles of the city go along with it. No one speaks up. Out of fear or cowardice they become partners in the crime.

According to 2 Kings 9:26, Naboth's sons were also killed. So no one could claim the land anymore.

This story shows how power is misused. Here the Bible stands clearly on the side of the ordinary person, against the powerful king.

Elijah confronts Ahab VERSES 17–26

17 Then the word of the LORD came to Elijah the Tishbite:
18 "Get up and go down to meet Ahab, the king of Israel.
He lives in Samaria.
Right now he is in Naboth's vineyard.
He has gone down there to take it.
19 Say to him,
'The LORD says:
"Have you killed and also taken possession?"'
And say to him,
'The LORD says:
"In the place where dogs licked up the blood of Naboth,
dogs will lick up your blood, yes, yours."'"
20 Ahab said to Elijah,
"Have you found me, my enemy?"
Elijah answered,
"Yes, I have found you.
You have sold yourself to do what is evil in the LORD's eyes.
21 I will bring disaster on you.
I will sweep you away completely.
I will cut off from Ahab everyone who urinates against a wall in Israel,
the one who is shut up and the one who is free.
22 I will make your family like the family of Jeroboam,
the son of Nebat,
and like the family of Baasha, the son of Ahijah.
You have made me angry,
and you have made Israel sin."
23 The LORD also spoke about Jezebel:
"The dogs will eat Jezebel by the wall of Jezreel.
24 Anyone from Ahab's family who dies in the city will be eaten by the dogs.
Anyone who dies in the open country will be eaten by the birds of the sky."
25 There was really no one like Ahab.
He sold himself to do what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
His wife Jezebel stirred him up to do it.
26 He did very disgusting things.
He followed idols,
just as the Amorites had done.
The LORD had driven the Amorites out before the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God sees what happens in secret. No human court helped Naboth. But God sends Elijah.

"Have you killed and also taken possession?" Elijah calls things by their name. Ahab did not kill Naboth himself. But he let it happen and gained from it. He shares the guilt.

"My enemy": Ahab sees Elijah as an enemy. And yet Elijah is the only one who tells him the truth.

"To sell yourself" means: Ahab has given himself over to evil like a slave.

"Everyone who urinates against a wall" is a crude expression for all male descendants (see 1 Kings 14:10).

These announcements come true later: Ahab dies in war (1 Kings 22:38). Jezebel dies in Jezreel (2 Kings 9:30–37).

The Amorites were one of the peoples who lived in Canaan before Israel.

Important: Jezebel is named here as the one who stirred him up. But Ahab himself remains responsible. You cannot simply push your own guilt onto another person.

Ahab humbles himself VERSES 27–29

27 Ahab heard these words.
Then he tore his clothes.
He put sackcloth on his body
and fasted.
He slept in sackcloth.
He walked around with his head bowed low.
28 Then the word of the LORD came to Elijah the Tishbite:
29 "Do you see how Ahab humbles himself before me?
He humbles himself before me.
So I will not bring the disaster while he is alive.
I will bring the disaster on his family in his son's time."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is surprising: of all people, Ahab, the worst king, is sorry. He shows signs of grief and repentance.

And God sees it right away. He says to Elijah: "Do you see how Ahab humbles himself before me?" God is glad about every turning back, even that of a very guilty person.

God is merciful and puts off the judgment. There is no person who is completely lost for God.

Whether Ahab's sorrow was deep and lasting remains open. In the next chapter he again does not listen to God's prophet.

1 KINGS

CHAPTER 22

The prophet Micaiah and Ahab's death

Ahab and Jehoshaphat plan a war VERSES 1–12

1 For three years there was no war between Syria and Israel.

2 In the third year Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah, went
down to visit the king of Israel.
3 The king of Israel said to his officials,
"You know that Ramoth Gilead belongs to us.
But we do nothing to take it back from the king of
Syria."
4 He asked Jehoshaphat,
"Will you go with me to fight at Ramoth Gilead?"
Jehoshaphat answered the king of Israel,
"I am with you.
My people are your people.
My horses are your horses."
5 Jehoshaphat also said to the king of Israel,
"But first, please ask what the LORD says."
6 So the king of Israel called the prophets together.
There were about 400 men.
He asked them,
"Should I go to fight against Ramoth Gilead, or should
I stay here?"
They said,
"Go up! The Lord will hand it over to the king."
7 But Jehoshaphat asked,
"Isn't there a prophet of the LORD here?
Then we could ask him."
8 The king of Israel answered Jehoshaphat,
"There is still one man through whom we can ask the
LORD.
It is Micaiah, the son of Imlah.
But I hate him.
He never says anything good about me, only bad
things."
Jehoshaphat said,
"The king should not say that."
9 So the king of Israel called an official and said,
"Bring Micaiah, the son of Imlah, quickly."
10 The king of Israel and Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah,
were each sitting on a throne.
They were wearing their royal robes.
They sat in an open place at the entrance of the gate of
Samaria.
All the prophets were prophesying in front of them.
11 Zedekiah, the son of Chenaanah, had made himself
horns of iron.
He said,
"The LORD says:
'With these horns you will push the Syrians until they
are destroyed.'"
12 All the prophets were saying the same thing.
They said,
"Go up to Ramoth Gilead! You will win.
The LORD will hand it over to the king."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoshaphat is a good king of Judah. He has made an alliance with Ahab. Later his son married Ahab's daughter (2 Kings 8:18).

Ramoth Gilead was an important border city east of the Jordan.

Jehoshaphat wants to ask God first. That is good. But Ahab's 400 prophets all say what the king wants to hear.

Jehoshaphat senses: something is wrong here. He asks for a real prophet of the LORD.

Ahab's words give him away: "But I hate him. He never says anything good about me." Many people do not want to hear the truth, but only to be told they are right.

The horns of iron are an action that is a sign: as a bull pushes with its horns, Ahab is to defeat his enemies.

This Micaiah is not the prophet Micah, after whom a book of the Bible is named.

Micaiah tells the truth VERSES 13–28

13 The messenger who had gone to get Micaiah said to
him,
"Listen, all the prophets agree.
They are telling the king good things.
Please say the same as they do.
Say something good."
14 But Micaiah said,
"As surely as the LORD lives,
I will say what the LORD tells me."
15 Micaiah came to the king.
The king asked him,
"Micaiah, should we go to fight at Ramoth Gilead, or
should we stay here?"
Micaiah answered,
"Go up! You will win.
The LORD will hand it over to the king."
16 The king said to him,
"How many times must I make you swear an oath?
In the name of the LORD, tell me nothing but the
truth!"
17 Then Micaiah said,
"I saw all Israel scattered on the mountains,
like sheep that have no shepherd.
And the LORD said,
'These people have no master.
Let each of them go home in peace.'"
18 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat,
"Didn't I tell you?
He never says anything good about me, only bad
things."
19 Micaiah said,
"So listen to the word of the LORD.
I saw the LORD sitting on his throne.
The whole army of heaven was standing around him,
on his right and on his left.
20 The LORD asked,
'Who will trick Ahab,
so that he goes up to Ramoth Gilead and dies there?'
One said one thing, and another said something else.
21 Then a spirit came forward.
It stood in front of the LORD and said,
'I will trick him.'
22 The LORD asked it,
'How?'
The spirit answered,
'I will go out and be a lying spirit in the mouth of all
his prophets.'
The LORD said,
'You will trick him, and you will succeed.
Go and do it.'
23 So now the LORD has put a lying spirit in the mouth of
all these prophets of yours.
The LORD has decided to bring disaster on you."

24 Then Zedekiah, the son of Chenaanah, came up to
Micaiah.
He slapped Micaiah on the cheek and said,
"Which way did the Spirit of the LORD go
when he left me to speak to you?"
25 Micaiah said,
"You will find out on the day
when you go into an inner room to hide."
26 The king of Israel said,
"Take Micaiah.
Bring him back to Amon, the governor of the city,
and to Joash, the king's son.
27 Tell them,
'The king says:
"Put this man in prison.
Give him only the bread of suffering and the water of
suffering,
until I come back safely."'"
28 Micaiah said,
"If you ever come back safely,
then the LORD has not spoken through me."
And he said,
"Listen, all you people!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Micaiah is under great pressure: 400 prophets against one. But he stands firm: "I will say what the LORD tells me."

At first Micaiah mockingly repeats the words of the others. Ahab notices right away that he does not mean it. Then Micaiah tells the truth: Israel will be like sheep without a shepherd. That means: the king, the shepherd of the people, will die.

The vision of the heavenly council around God's throne is hard to understand. Does God really let people lie? You have to look closely: Micaiah is telling Ahab the whole plan! God warns Ahab openly. Ahab has the choice. He wanted to hear the lie, and God leaves him with the lie he has chosen. Paul writes something similar in 2 Thessalonians 2:10–11.

The true prophet is struck and locked up. That has happened to many faithful people in history. Telling the truth can cost a lot.

"The bread of suffering and the water of suffering" means: only very little bread and water, just enough to survive.

Micaiah's last sentence, "Listen, all you people!", is the same call as at the beginning of the book of the prophet Micah (Micah 1:2).

Ahab's death VERSES 29–40

29 So the king of Israel and Jehoshaphat, the king of
Judah, went up to Ramoth Gilead.
30 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat,
"I will dress so that no one knows me, and go into the
battle.
But you wear your royal robes."
So the king of Israel dressed so that no one would know
him.
He went into the battle.
31 The king of Syria had given an order to his 32 chariot
commanders.
He had said,
"Do not fight with anyone, small or great.
Fight only with the king of Israel."
32 The chariot commanders saw Jehoshaphat.
They said,
"That must be the king of Israel!"
So they turned to attack him.
Then Jehoshaphat cried out.
33 The chariot commanders saw that he was not the king
of Israel.
So they stopped chasing him.
34 But a man shot an arrow from his bow without aiming.
It hit the king of Israel between the pieces of his
armor.
The king said to the driver of his chariot,
"Turn around and take me out of the battle.
I am badly wounded."
35 The battle grew worse that day.
The king was held up in his chariot, facing the Syrians.
In the evening he died.
The blood from his wound ran onto the floor of the
chariot.
36 At sunset a shout went through the army:
"Every man go back to his city!
Every man go back to his land!"
37 So the king died.
He was brought to Samaria.
They buried the king in Samaria.
38 They washed the chariot at the pool of Samaria.
The dogs licked up his blood there.
That was the place where the prostitutes washed
themselves.
It happened as the LORD had said.
39 The rest of Ahab's story and everything he did
are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings
of Israel.
It also tells about the ivory house and all the cities he
built.
40 So Ahab died and joined his ancestors.
His son Ahaziah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahab tries to escape God's word. He disguises himself, and Jehoshaphat is to stand out as king. That is cowardly and dangerous for Jehoshaphat.

But an arrow shot "without aiming" hits exactly the gap in Ahab's armor. What looks like chance is the fulfillment of God's word.

But we must also give Ahab credit: he bravely stays standing in his chariot until evening, so that his army does not lose heart.

Micaiah's word comes true: the army scatters "like sheep that have no shepherd." And Elijah's word comes true: dogs lick Ahab's blood (1 Kings 21:19). In Chapter 21 it said "in the place where" Naboth died. But Ahab's blood was licked up in Samaria. Because Ahab was sorry, God put off part of the judgment (1 Kings 21:29). The rest came true with his son in Jezreel (2 Kings 9:25–26).

The "ivory house": in Samaria archaeologists have found many artistic ivory carvings from this time. They were used to decorate furniture and walls.

Ahab died about 853 BC.

Jehoshaphat, king of Judah VERSES 41–50

41 Jehoshaphat, the son of Asa, became king over Judah.
It was in the fourth year of Ahab, the king of Israel.

42 Jehoshaphat was 35 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 25 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Azubah, the daughter of Shilhi.
43 He lived the way his father Asa had lived.
He did not turn away from it.
He did what was right in the LORD's eyes.
But the high places were not removed.
The people still offered sacrifices and burned incense on the high places.
44 Jehoshaphat made peace with the king of Israel.
45 The rest of Jehoshaphat's story is written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Judah.
It tells about the strength he showed and how he fought.
46 There were still some male shrine prostitutes left from the days of his father Asa.
Jehoshaphat sent them out of the land.
47 At that time there was no king in Edom.
A governor ruled there.
48 Jehoshaphat built ships of Tarshish.
They were to go to Ophir to get gold.
But they never sailed.
The ships were wrecked at Ezion Geber.
49 Then Ahaziah, the son of Ahab, said to Jehoshaphat, "Let my servants sail with your servants in the ships."
But Jehoshaphat did not want that.
50 Jehoshaphat died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried with his ancestors in the city of his father David.
His son Jehoram became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoshaphat was a good king, like his father Asa. 2 Chronicles 17–20 tells much more about him.

He made peace with Israel. After many years of war between north and south, that was good. But the close ties with the house of Ahab later brought great disaster to Judah.

Like Solomon, Jehoshaphat wanted to send ships to Ophir. But the ships were broken even before they set out.

In verse 46 the WEB, our English source text, again says "sodomites." We write "male shrine prostitutes" (see the explanation for 1 Kings 14:24).

At that time Edom was under the rule of Judah. That is why Jehoshaphat could use the port of Ezion Geber.

In some Bibles the verse numbers from here on are shifted by one: the second part of verse 43 is verse 44 there. Verse 44 here is verse 45 there, and so on up to verse 53 here, which is verse 54 there.

Jehoshaphat ruled from about 870 to 848 BC.

Ahaziah, king of Israel VERSES 51–53

51 Ahaziah, the son of Ahab, became king over Israel in Samaria.
It was in the 17th year of Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah.
Ahaziah ruled over Israel for two years.
52 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He lived the way his father and his mother had lived.
He lived the way Jeroboam, the son of Nebat, had lived.
Jeroboam had made Israel sin.
53 Ahaziah served Baal and worshiped him.
He made the LORD, the God of Israel, angry, just as his father had done.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahab's son carries on like his parents, Ahab and Jezebel. The book ends in the middle of the story. The story of Ahaziah goes on in 2 Kings. In the beginning the two books were one single book.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of 1 Kings?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of 1 Kings tells about 120 years of history, from about 970 to 850 BC.

The splendor: Solomon becomes king. He asks God for wisdom, not for wealth, and receives both. He builds the temple in Jerusalem. God fills the house with his glory. Solomon's prayer at the dedication shows: God is greater than any heaven, and he hears everyone who prays to him, even the foreigner.

The fall: But Solomon's heart becomes divided. Many wives, much gold, and other gods pull him away from God. After his death the kingdom breaks apart: Israel in the north, Judah in the south.

Two kingdoms: In the north Jeroboam sets up golden calves. Murders of kings and struggles for power follow there. In the south David's family stays on the throne, "a lamp in Jerusalem," as God had promised.

The prophets: The darker it gets, the more strongly God's messengers appear: Ahijah, Jehu, the man of God from Judah, Micaiah, and above all Elijah. They tell the kings the truth, often at the risk of their lives. On Mount Carmel Elijah shows who the true God is. And at Mount Horeb he learns that God also speaks to him in a quiet voice.

The lesson of the book: What matters is not power, wealth, or great buildings. What counts is a heart that is wholly devoted to God. God stays faithful, even when people are unfaithful. He keeps his promises, and he gives even bad people like Ahab the chance to turn back.

What comes next? In 2 Kings Elijah is taken up to heaven, and Elisha becomes his successor. The story of the two kingdoms goes on, until they fall.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 12 OF 66

2 KINGS

25 CHAPTERS

2 KINGS

Chapter 1

King Ahaziah and the prophet Elijah

Before we begin: What is the book of 2 Kings?

The book of 2 Kings continues the book of 1 Kings. In the beginning, both were one single book. It tells about 300 years of history, from about 850 to 560 BC.

At the beginning are the prophets Elijah and Elisha. Elijah is taken up into heaven. Elisha becomes the one who follows him, and he does many miracles. He helps poor people, sick people, and even enemies.

Then the book goes on telling about the two kingdoms: Israel in the north and Judah in the south. In the north many kings follow one after another who are not faithful to God. In the year 722 BC the Assyrians conquer the northern kingdom. Many people are carried away. The northern kingdom comes to an end.

Judah in the south lasts about 135 years longer. There are good kings there, like Hezekiah and Josiah, who want to lead the people back to God. But in the end the Babylonians conquer Jerusalem. In the year 587 BC the temple is destroyed, and many people are carried away to Babylon.

The book asks: why did this happen? The answer is: because the people and their kings left God again and again, even though the prophets warned them.

But the book does not end without hope: in the last section King Jehoiachin is set free from prison in Babylon. That is a small sign: God has not forgotten David's family.

Ahaziah asks a foreign god VERSES 1–8

1 After the death of Ahab, Moab rebelled against Israel.
2 Ahaziah fell down through the lattice in his upper
room in Samaria,
and he was sick.
A lattice is a screen made of crossed strips of wood.
So he sent messengers and said to them,
"Go and ask Baal Zebub, the god of Ekron,
whether I will get well from this sickness."
3 But the LORD's angel said to Elijah the Tishbite,
"Get up, go up to meet the messengers of the king of
Samaria,
and tell them,
'Is there no God in Israel?
Is that why you go to ask Baal Zebub, the god of Ekron?
4 So now the LORD says,
"You will not come down from the bed you have gone
up on.
You will surely die."'"
Then Elijah went away.
5 The messengers came back to Ahaziah.
He said to them,
"Why have you come back?"
6 They said to him,
"A man came up to meet us and said to us,
'Go, go back to the king who sent you, and tell him,
"The LORD says,
'Is there no God in Israel?
Is that why you send people to ask Baal Zebub, the god
of Ekron?
So you will not come down from the bed you have
gone up on.
You will surely die.'"'"
7 He said to them,
"What kind of man was he who came up to meet you
and told you these words?"
8 They answered him,
"He was a hairy man,
and he wore a leather belt around his waist."
He said,
"It is Elijah the Tishbite."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahaziah is the son of Ahab and Jezebel. In his house he falls through a wooden lattice, probably at a window or on the roof, and he is badly hurt.

Instead of asking the God of Israel, he sends messengers to a god of the Philistines in Ekron. "Baal Zebub" means "lord of the flies." This is probably a mocking name. The real name was perhaps "Baal Zebul," "Baal, the prince." In the New Testament, "Beelzebul" is a name for the chief of the demons (Mark 3:22).

Elijah's question is the heart of the story: "Is there no God in Israel?" Ahaziah looks for help everywhere, only not from God.

"A hairy man": this can also mean that he wore a coat made of animal hair or skin. Later John the Baptist is described in a similar way, with camel's hair and a leather belt (Mark 1:6). Many people saw John as a new Elijah (Malachi 4:5; Matthew 11:14).

Moab's rebellion is told further in Chapter 3.

In some Bibles the name of this king is spelled a little differently.

Fire from the sky VERSES 9–16

9 Then the king sent a captain with his 50 men to Elijah.
The captain went up to him.
Elijah was sitting on the top of the hill.
The captain said to him,
"Man of God, the king has said, 'Come down!'"
10 Elijah answered the captain,
"If I am a man of God,
then let fire come down from the sky
and burn up you and your 50 men!"
Then fire came down from the sky
and burned up the captain and his 50 men.
11 Again the king sent another captain with his 50 men to
Elijah.
The captain said to him,
"Man of God, the king has said, 'Come down quickly!'"
12 Elijah answered them,
"If I am a man of God,

then let fire come down from the sky
and burn up you and your 50 men!"
Then God's fire came down from the sky
and burned up the captain and his 50 men.
13 Again the king sent a third captain with his 50 men.
The third captain went up.
He came and fell on his knees in front of Elijah.
He begged him and said to him,
"Man of God, please let my life and the life of these 50 men, your servants,
be precious in your eyes.
14 Look, fire came down from the sky
and burned up the first two captains with their 50 men each.
But now let my life be precious in your eyes."
15 The LORD's angel said to Elijah,
"Go down with him. Don't be afraid of him."
So Elijah got up and went down with him to the king.
16 Elijah said to the king,
"The LORD says,
'You have sent messengers to ask Baal Zebub, the god of Ekron.
Is there no God in Israel whose word you can ask?
So you will not come down from the bed you have gone up on.
You will surely die.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king wants to have Elijah brought to him by force. The first two captains act very proudly: they give orders to the man of God in the name of the king. The question is: who has more power, the king or God?

The third captain is different. He kneels down and humbly begs for his life. He is spared. Humility is protected.

This story is hard. More than 100 soldiers die who were only following orders. The Bible wants to show how serious it is to stand against God. But it is not an example for us to follow: later, when the disciples asked Jesus whether they should call down fire from the sky like Elijah on a village that had not welcomed them, Jesus told them they were wrong (Luke 9:54–55).

In the end Elijah goes to the king without fear and tells him God's word to his face.

Ahaziah's death VERSES 17–18

17 So Ahaziah died, just as the LORD had said through Elijah.
Ahaziah had no son.
So Jehoram became king in his place.
This was in the second year of Jehoram, the son of Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah.
18 The rest of Ahaziah's story and everything he did are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahaziah had no son. That is why his brother Jehoram became king.

This can be confusing: at the same time there were two kings named Jehoram (also called Joram): one in Israel (Ahab's son) and one in Judah (Jehoshaphat's son).

The dates in the books of Kings are sometimes hard to fit together. 2 Kings 3:1 gives a different date. Probably some kings ruled together with their father for a while, and the years were counted in different ways.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 2

Elijah goes up into heaven

Elisha stays with Elijah VERSES 1–8

1 When the LORD was about to take Elijah up into heaven in a whirlwind,
Elijah went with Elisha from Gilgal.
A whirlwind is a strong storm wind that turns around and around.
2 Elijah said to Elisha,
"Please wait here, because the LORD has sent me as far as Bethel."
Elisha said,
"As surely as the LORD lives, and as surely as you live,
I will not leave you."
So they went down to Bethel.
3 The sons of the prophets who were at Bethel came out to Elisha and said to him,
"Do you know that the LORD will take your master away from over you today?"
He said,
"Yes, I know it. Be quiet."
4 Elijah said to him,
"Elisha, please wait here, because the LORD has sent me to Jericho."
He said,
"As surely as the LORD lives, and as surely as you live,
I will not leave you."
So they came to Jericho.
5 The sons of the prophets who were at Jericho came near to Elisha and said to him,
"Do you know that the LORD will take your master away from over you today?"
He answered,
"Yes, I know it. Be quiet."
6 Elijah said to him,
"Please wait here, because the LORD has sent me to the Jordan."
He said,
"As surely as the LORD lives, and as surely as you live,
I will not leave you."
Then the two of them went on.
7 Then 50 men of the sons of the prophets went too.
They stood facing them, some distance away.
And the two of them stood by the Jordan.
8 Elijah took his cloak, rolled it up, and struck the water.
Then the water divided to this side and to that side,
so that the two of them went across on dry ground.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elijah knows that his end on earth is near. Three times he says to Elisha: "Wait here." Perhaps he wants to test him. But Elisha stays faithful: "I will not leave you." This reminds us of Ruth, who said to Naomi: "For where you go, I will go" (Ruth 1:16).

The road leads from Gilgal through Bethel and Jericho to the Jordan. It is like a journey backward through Israel's history: under Joshua, Israel came across the Jordan to Jericho and Gilgal.

Elijah divides the Jordan with his cloak, just as Moses divided the Red Sea (Exodus 14) and Joshua the Jordan (Joshua 3).

"Sons of the prophets" were groups of students who lived and learned with a prophet.

The chariot of fire VERSES 9–14

9 When they had gone across, Elijah said to Elisha,
"Ask what I should do for you, before I am taken away from you."
Elisha said,
"Please let a double share of your spirit be on me."
10 He said,
"You have asked a hard thing.
If you see me when I am taken from you,
it will be so for you.
But if not, it will not be so."
11 As they went on and talked,
look, a chariot of fire and horses of fire separated the two of them.
And Elijah went up into heaven in a whirlwind.
12 Elisha saw it, and he cried out,
"My father, my father,
the chariots of Israel and its horsemen!"
And he did not see him anymore.
Then he took hold of his own clothes and tore them in two pieces.
13 He also picked up Elijah's cloak that had fallen from him.
He went back and stood on the bank of the Jordan.
14 He took Elijah's cloak that had fallen from him,
struck the water, and said,
"Where is the LORD, the God of Elijah?"
When he too had struck the water,
it divided to this side and to that side,
and Elisha went across.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"A double share": by the law, the oldest son received a double share of the inheritance (Deuteronomy 21:17). So Elisha asks to be Elijah's true heir and the one who follows him.

Elijah does not die. He is taken up into heaven alive. Elsewhere in the Bible this is only told about Enoch (Genesis 5:24).

That is why the Jews expected that Elijah would come back one day, before the great day of the LORD (Malachi 4:5). To this day, at the Jewish Passover feast, a cup is set out for Elijah and the door is opened for him. In the New Testament, Elijah appears when Jesus is transfigured on the mountain (Mark 9:4).

"The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!": Elisha means: Elijah was Israel's true strength, more than all the chariots and soldiers.

Elisha tears his clothes in grief. Then he picks up Elijah's cloak. The cloak is the sign: now you are the prophet. And God confirms it: the Jordan divides for Elisha too.

"Where is the LORD, the God of Elijah?" That is the question of every new generation: is God still with us when the great examples are no longer there? The answer is: yes.

The sons of the prophets look for Elijah VERSES 15–18

15 The sons of the prophets who were at Jericho, facing him, saw him.
They said,
"The spirit of Elijah rests on Elisha."
They came to meet him and bowed down in front of him to the ground.
16 They said to him,
"See now, with your servants there are 50 strong men.
Please let them go and look for your master.
Perhaps the LORD's Spirit has taken him up
and put him on some mountain or in some valley."
He said,
"Don't send them."
17 But they kept urging him until he was ashamed, and he said,
"Send them."
So they sent 50 men.
They searched for three days, but they did not find him.
18 They came back to him while he was staying in Jericho.
He said to them,
"Didn't I tell you, 'Don't go'?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The sons of the prophets accept Elisha as their new leader.

They cannot believe that Elijah is really gone. The useless search shows everyone: Elijah is not somewhere on earth. God has really taken him to himself.

Elisha heals the water VERSES 19–22

19 The men of the city said to Elisha,
"Look, please, this city is in a pleasant place, as my lord sees.
But the water is bad, and the land is barren."
Barren means: nothing grows there.
20 He said,
"Bring me a new jar, and put salt in it."
They brought it to him.
21 He went out to the spring of water,
threw salt into it, and said,
"The LORD says,
'I have healed this water.
From there, no more death or barren wasteland will come.'"
22 So the water was healed, and it stays healed to this day, just as Elisha had said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elisha's first miracle is a miracle of healing and of life. That will be typical for him: he helps people in their need.

The salt does not work by itself. Elisha says clearly: the LORD has healed the water.

The Hebrew word for "barren" can also mean "causing miscarriages." The water made the land barren and perhaps also harmed people and animals.

Near Jericho there is a large spring to this day. It is called "Elisha's Spring."

The youths of Bethel VERSES 23–25

23 From there he went up to Bethel.
As he was going up on the road,
some youths came out of the city and mocked him.
They called to him,
"Go up, you baldy! Go up, you baldy!"
24 He turned around, looked at them,
and cursed them in the LORD's name.
Then two female bears came out of the woods
and mauled 42 of those youths.
25 From there he went to Mount Carmel,
and from there he went back to Samaria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is one of the hardest in the Bible. Many people are troubled by it, and that is understandable.

What you should know: the Hebrew word for "youths" can also mean young men, not only small children. It was a large group, at least 42. They came from Bethel, the place of Jeroboam's golden calf. Their mocking is aimed at God's prophet. "Go up" is perhaps a hint at Elijah going up into heaven, as if to say: "Why don't you disappear too!"

"Mauled" means badly hurt. The text does not say clearly that they all died.

The text wants to show: whoever despises God's messengers despises God himself. Even so, this story is not an example for how we should act. Jesus taught: "Bless those who curse you!" (Luke 6:28).

Jews and Christians have thought a lot about this passage. The Talmud (Sotah 47a) even says that Elisha later became sick partly because of it.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 3

The war against Moab

Jehoram, king of Israel VERSES 1–3

1 Jehoram, the son of Ahab, became king over Israel in Samaria.
It was in the eighteenth year of Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah.
Jehoram ruled for 12 years.
2 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
but not like his father and his mother.
For he took away the pillar of Baal that his father had made.
3 But he held on to the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat,
the sins through which Jeroboam had made Israel sin.
He did not turn away from them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoram is another son of Ahab and Jezebel. He is not quite as bad as his parents. He takes away a sign of the worship of Baal. But he stays with Jeroboam's golden calves.

Jehoram ruled from about 852 to 841 BC.

Three kings march against Moab VERSES 4–12

4 Mesha king of Moab was a sheep breeder.
He had to supply the king of Israel with 100,000 lambs and the wool of 100,000 rams.
5 But when Ahab was dead,
the king of Moab rebelled against the king of Israel.
6 King Jehoram went out of Samaria at that time
and gathered all Israel for war.
7 He went and sent a message to Jehoshaphat the king of Judah:
"The king of Moab has rebelled against me.
Will you go with me to fight against Moab?"
He said,
"I will go up.
I am as you are, my people as your people, my horses as your horses."
8 Then he asked,
"Which way shall we go up?"
Jehoram answered,
"The way through the wilderness of Edom."
9 So the king of Israel went with the king of Judah and the king of Edom.
They marched for seven days on a roundabout way.
There was no water for the army or for the animals that followed them.
10 The king of Israel said,
"Oh no!
The LORD has called these three kings together to hand them over to Moab."
11 But Jehoshaphat said,
"Isn't there a prophet of the LORD here, so that we can ask the LORD through him?"
One of the king of Israel's servants answered,
"Elisha the son of Shaphat is here,
who poured water on the hands of Elijah."
12 Jehoshaphat said,
"The LORD's word is with him."
So the king of Israel and Jehoshaphat and the king of Edom went down to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moab lies east of the Dead Sea. Every year it had to pay Israel a high tax in the form of sheep and wool.

Mesha is also known outside the Bible: in 1868 the "Mesha Stone" was found in Jordan. It is a large inscription. In it Mesha himself tells how Moab freed itself from Israel. There he also names Omri, the king of Israel, and the God of Israel by his name. Today the stone is in the Louvre in Paris.

The three kings want to attack Moab from the south, through Edom. But in the wilderness they run out of water.

Again it is Jehoshaphat who asks: "Isn't there a prophet of the LORD here" (as in 1 Kings 22:7).

"Who poured water on the hands of Elijah" means: who was Elijah's servant and student.

Elisha promises water VERSES 13–20

13 Elisha said to the king of Israel,
"What do I have to do with you?
Go to the prophets of your father and to the prophets of your mother."
The king of Israel said to him,
"No, for the LORD has called these three kings together
to hand them over to Moab."
14 Elisha said,
"As surely as the LORD of Armies lives, before whom I stand:
if I did not respect Jehoshaphat the king of Judah,
I would not look at you or even see you.
15 But now bring me a musician."
When the musician played, the LORD's hand came on Elisha.
16 He said,
"The LORD says,
'Make this valley full of ditches.'
17 For the LORD says,
'You will not see wind, and you will not see rain,
yet that valley will be filled with water.
And you will drink, you and your livestock and your other animals.
18 This is an easy thing in the LORD's eyes.
He will also hand the Moabites over to you.
19 You will strike every walled city and every fine city.
You will cut down every good tree.
You will block all springs of water.
And you will ruin every good field with stones.'"
20 In the morning, about the time when the sacrifice is offered,
look, water came from the direction of Edom,
and the land was filled with water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elisha is very direct with Jehoram: go to your prophets of Baal! He helps only because of the faithful King Jehoshaphat.

Elisha has music played before he prophesies. Music can help us become quiet and listen to God. David also played the harp for Saul (1 Samuel 16:23).

The water comes without rain. Probably it rained far away in the mountains of Edom, and the water flowed down through the dry riverbed. For the people there it was still a miracle at the right time.

Verse 19 is hard: cutting down trees and ruining fields was a common way of making war in those days. In Deuteronomy 20:19 God had even forbidden cutting down fruit trees during a siege. Here it is announced, not necessarily approved. Today international law clearly forbids destroying what ordinary people need to live.

The victory over Moab and a terrible sacrifice VERSES 21–27

21 All the Moabites heard that the kings had come up to fight against them.
So everyone who could put on armor gathered together, young and old,
and they stood at the border.
22 They got up early in the morning.
The sun shone on the water,
and the Moabites saw the water across from them, as red as blood.
23 They said,
"This is blood!
The kings have surely been destroyed, and they have struck each other.
So now, Moab, go and take the plunder!"
24 When they came to the camp of Israel,
the Israelites got up and struck the Moabites,
so that they fled in front of them.
And they went forward into the land, attacking the Moabites.
25 They tore down the cities.
On every good field each man threw his stone, until it was filled.
They blocked all the springs of water and cut down all the good trees.
In the end, in Kir Hareseth, only its stones were left.
But the men with slings surrounded it and attacked it.
26 The king of Moab saw that the battle was too hard for him.
He took with him 700 men who drew the sword,
to break through to the king of Edom.
But they could not.
27 Then he took his oldest son, who would have become king in his place,
and offered him as a burnt offering on the wall.
There was great anger against Israel.
And they went away from him and went back to their own land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The water shines red in the morning sun, perhaps because of the red earth in Edom. The Moabites think it is blood, and they run into a trap.

In the end Mesha is shut in his fortress Kir Hareseth. In his despair he sacrifices his own son on the city wall, probably to his god Chemosh. This is cruel and horrible. In many places the Bible strongly condemns sacrificing children (Leviticus 18:21; Deuteronomy 12:31).

"Great anger against Israel" is hard to understand. Perhaps it was horror among the Israelites themselves. Perhaps the Moabites' fighting spirit grew so much that Israel had to withdraw. The text does not say exactly. It does not say that Chemosh really had power.

Elisha's announcement had come true: Israel won. But they did not get the final victory. On the Mesha Stone, Mesha describes the end of the war as Moab being set free.

Kir Hareseth (also called Kir Heres) was the capital city of Moab. People think it lay near today's Kerak in Jordan.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 4

Elisha helps in times of need

The widow's oil VERSES 1–7

1 A woman, one of the wives of the sons of the prophets,
cried out to Elisha,
"Your servant, my husband, is dead.
You know that your servant feared the LORD.
Now the man he owed money to has come
to take my two children as his slaves."
2 Elisha said to her,
"What should I do for you?
Tell me, what do you have in the house?"
She said,
"Your servant has nothing in the house except a pot of oil."
3 Then he said,
"Go, borrow empty containers from all your neighbors.
Don't borrow just a few containers.
4 Then go in
and shut the door behind you and your sons.
Pour oil into all those containers,
and set aside the ones that are full."
5 So she went away from him
and shut the door behind herself and her sons.
They brought the containers to her, and she poured oil.
6 When the containers were full, she said to her son,
"Bring me another container."
He said to her,
"There isn't another container."
Then the oil stopped flowing.
7 She came and told the man of God.
He said,
"Go, sell the oil and pay your debt.
And you and your sons can live on the rest."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A widow is in great need. Her husband is dead, and she has debts. In those days a person who was owed money could take the children as slaves for the debt, until the debt was worked off.

Elisha asks: "What do you have in the house?" God begins with the little that is already there.

The oil flows as long as there are containers. The woman could have received even more if she had had more containers. God's gifts are greater than we often expect.

God sees the poor and the weak. In the Bible, widows and orphans are under God's special protection (Exodus 22:22–24).

Anyone today whose debts have grown too big for them can turn to a free debt counseling service. In many countries, nonprofit debt counseling services help for free.

The woman from Shunem VERSES 8–17

8 One day Elisha went to Shunem.
An important woman lived there.
She urged him to eat a meal.
So whenever he passed by, he stopped there to eat a meal.
9 She said to her husband,
"Look, I can see that this man who keeps passing by us is a holy man of God.
10 Please, let's make a little room on the roof.
Let's put a bed, a table, a chair, and a lampstand there for him.
When he comes to us, he can stay there."
11 One day he came there.
He went into the room and lay down there.
12 He said to Gehazi his servant,
"Call this Shunammite."
He called her, and she stood in front of him.
13 Elisha said to Gehazi,
"Say to her now,
'Look, you have taken all this trouble to care for us.
What can be done for you?
Would you like someone to speak for you to the king or to the commander of the army?'"
She answered,
"I live among my own people."
14 He said,
"Then what can be done for her?"
Gehazi answered,
"Well, she has no son, and her husband is old."
15 He said,
"Call her."
He called her, and she stood in the doorway.
16 He said,
"At this time next year you will hold a son in your arms."
She said,
"No, my lord, you man of God, don't lie to your servant."
17 The woman became pregnant.
She gave birth to a son at that same time the next year, as Elisha had told her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The woman from Shunem is rich and generous. She builds Elisha his own guest room, without expecting anything for it.

When Elisha wants to do something good for her, she says: "I live among my own people." That means: I don't need anything, I am content.

But she carries a deep pain that she does not talk about: she has no son. She hardly dares to hope: "Don't lie to your servant." She does not want to be disappointed.

The story reminds us of Sarah, who still had a son in her old age (Genesis 18:10–14).

Shunem lay in the plain of Jezreel, in the north of Israel.

The son dies VERSES 18–28

18 When the child had grown,
one day he went out to his father, to the men who were cutting the grain.
19 He said to his father,
"My head! My head!"
The father said to his servant,
"Carry him to his mother."

20 The servant took him and brought him to his mother.
He sat on her knees until noon.
Then he died.
21 She went up and laid him on the bed of the man of God.
She shut the door behind him and went out.
22 She called to her husband and said,
"Please send me one of the servants and one of the donkeys.
I want to hurry to the man of God and come back again."
23 He said,
"Why do you want to go to him today?
It is not a new moon or a Sabbath."
She said,
"It is all right."
24 Then she saddled a donkey and said to her servant,
"Drive on and go forward!
Don't slow down for me unless I tell you to."
25 So she went and came to the man of God at Mount Carmel.
When the man of God saw her far away, he said to Gehazi his servant,
"Look, there is the Shunammite.
26 Please run now to meet her and ask her,
'Is it well with you? Is it well with your husband? Is it well with your child?'"
She answered,
"It is well."
27 When she came to the man of God on the hill,
she took hold of his feet.
Gehazi came near to push her away.
But the man of God said,
"Leave her alone, for her soul is deeply troubled.
And the LORD has hidden it from me and has not told me."
28 Then she said,
"Did I ask you for a son, my lord?
Didn't I say, 'Don't deceive me'?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The child suddenly gets a strong headache, perhaps from too much sun during the harvest, and dies on his mother's lap. That is the worst thing parents can go through.

The mother tells no one anything. She only says: "It is well." With all her strength she holds back her pain until she is with the man of God. Only there does it break out of her.

Elisha does not know what is wrong. Even a prophet does not know everything. But he lets the desperate woman come close to him.

Her accusation is honest: "Did I ask you for a son, my lord?" Whoever loses something that was a gift suffers twice. The Bible allows such laments.

"New moon" and "Sabbath" were holy days on which people went to a prophet.

In Hebrew, verses 22 and 24 probably say "female donkey." In those days people liked to ride female donkeys.

Anyone who has lost a child can find help, for example, in support groups for bereaved parents, or here: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The boy comes back to life VERSES 29–37

29 Then Elisha said to Gehazi,
"Tuck your cloak into your belt,
take my staff in your hand, and go.
If you meet anyone, don't greet him.
And if anyone greets you, don't answer him.
Lay my staff on the child's face."
30 The child's mother said,
"As surely as the LORD lives, and as surely as you live,
I will not leave you."
So he got up and followed her.
31 Gehazi went ahead of them
and laid the staff on the child's face.
But there was no sound and no sign that he heard.
So he went back to meet Elisha and told him,
"The child has not woken up."
32 When Elisha came into the house,
look, the child was dead, lying on his bed.
33 He went in,
shut the door behind the two of them,
and prayed to the LORD.
34 He went up and lay on the child.
He put his mouth on his mouth,
his eyes on his eyes,
and his hands on his hands.
He stretched himself out on him,
and the child's body grew warm.
35 Then he got up again
and walked back and forth in the house once.
Then he went up and stretched himself out on him again.
Then the child sneezed seven times,
and the child opened his eyes.
36 He called Gehazi and said,
"Call this Shunammite!"
So he called her.
When she came in to him, he said,
"Pick up your son."
37 Then she went in, fell at his feet,
and bowed down to the ground.
Then she picked up her son and went out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The mother says the same thing that Elisha once said to Elijah: "I will not leave you" (Chapter 2). She does not give up.

The staff alone does not help. No magic is needed, but prayer and Elisha's whole effort.

Elisha prays and lies on the child, very much like Elijah with the son of the widow in Zarephath (1 Kings 17:21). God gives the child his life back.

Sneezing seven times is a lively detail: the breath comes back.

The mother does not say a word. She falls down, full of thanks, and takes her son in her arms.

Death in the pot VERSES 38–41

38 Elisha came back to Gilgal.
There was a famine in the land.
A famine is a time when there is not enough food.
The sons of the prophets were sitting in front of him.
He said to his servant,

"Put on the large pot and cook stew for the sons of the prophets."

39 One of them went out into the field to gather herbs.
He found a wild vine
and gathered wild gourds from it, as many as his clothes could hold.
A gourd is a fruit like a small, hard pumpkin.
He came and cut them up into the pot of stew,
because they did not know what they were.

40 Then they poured it out for the men to eat.
As they were eating the stew, they cried out,
"Man of God, there is death in the pot!"
And they could not eat it.

41 But he said,
"Then bring flour."
He threw it into the pot and said,
"Serve it to the people, so that they can eat."
And there was nothing harmful in the pot anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

During the famine the men gather whatever they can find. One of them picks poisonous fruit. They were probably colocynths, a kind of wild gourd that is very bitter and poisonous and causes strong diarrhea.

Elisha throws flour into the pot. As with the salt in Chapter 2, it is not the flour itself that works. God makes the food safe to eat.

Bread for 100 men VERSES 42–44

42 A man came from Baal Shalishah.
He brought the man of God bread from the first part of the harvest:
20 loaves of barley bread and fresh heads of grain in his sack.
Elisha said,
"Give it to the people, so that they can eat."

43 His servant said,
"What? How can I set this in front of 100 men?"
But he said,
"Give it to the people, so that they can eat.
For the LORD says,
'They will eat and have some left over.'"

44 So he set it in front of them.
They ate and had some left over,
just as the LORD had said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first part of the harvest really belonged to God and to the priests. Because there were no rightful priests in the northern kingdom, the man brings it to the prophet.

Only 20 small loaves of barley bread for 100 men is far too little. But God makes sure that everyone has enough to eat and that some is even left over.

This story is very much like Jesus feeding the 5,000. There too there were barley loaves, the disciples doubted, everyone had enough to eat, and some was left over (John 6:9–13).

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 5

Naaman is healed

A girl gives advice VERSES 1–7

1 Naaman was the commander of the army of the king of Syria.
He was a great man in his master's eyes and highly respected,
because through him the LORD had given victory to Syria.
He was also a mighty and brave warrior.
But he was a leper.
A leper is a person with leprosy, a serious skin disease.

2 The Syrians had gone out in raiding groups.
They had taken a little girl captive from the land of Israel.
She served Naaman's wife.

3 She said to her mistress,
"I wish that my lord were with the prophet who is in Samaria!
Then he would heal him of his leprosy."

4 Someone went in and told his lord,
"The girl from the land of Israel said this."

5 The king of Syria said,
"Go now,
and I will send a letter to the king of Israel."
Naaman set out.
He took with him 10 talents of silver (about 750 pounds),
6,000 pieces of gold, and 10 changes of clothes.

6 He brought the letter to the king of Israel. It said,
"When this letter comes to you, look:
I have sent my servant Naaman to you,
so that you may heal him of his leprosy."

7 When the king of Israel had read the letter,
he tore his clothes and said,
"Am I God?
Can I kill and make alive?
This man sends someone to me,
so that I will heal him of his leprosy!
Please think about it.
See how he is looking for a quarrel with me!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Naaman is a powerful man, a successful general from Syria (Aram), Israel's enemy. But he has a disease against which all his power is no help.

Remarkable: the Bible says that the LORD gave victory to Syria through Naaman. God is not only the God of Israel. He guides the history of all peoples.

In those days "leprosy" was a name for many different skin diseases, not only for what is called leprosy today. Sick people were often pushed out of the community.

The real hero at the beginning is a little girl without a name. She was carried away from her home and has to serve as a

slave. Even so, she wishes healing for her master. She has no bitterness, but compassion, and she trusts in God.

The king of Israel (probably Jehoram) becomes afraid. He thinks the letter is a trap. He does not think of the prophet Elisha.

The Bible says "10 talents of silver." A talent is about 75 pounds. The "6,000 pieces of gold" probably means shekels, together about 150 pounds of gold. That was a huge fortune.

Wash in the Jordan VERSES 8–14

8 Elisha the man of God heard
that the king of Israel had torn his clothes.
So he sent a message to the king:
"Why have you torn your clothes?
Let him come to me now.
Then he will know that there is a prophet in Israel."
9 So Naaman came with his horses and his chariots
and stopped at the door of Elisha's house.
10 Elisha sent a messenger out to him, who said,
"Go and wash in the Jordan seven times.
Then your body will be healthy again,
and you will be clean."
11 But Naaman became angry, went away, and said,
"Look, I thought,
'He will surely come out to me and stand there
and call on the name of the LORD his God,
and wave his hand over the place
and heal the leprosy.'
12 Aren't Abanah and Pharpar, the rivers of Damascus,
better than all the waters of Israel?
Couldn't I wash in them and be clean?"
So he turned and went away in a rage.
13 His servants came near, spoke to him, and said,
"My father, if the prophet had told you to do some
great thing,
wouldn't you have done it?
How much more, then, when he only says to you,
'Wash, and be clean'?"
14 Then he went down and dipped himself seven times in
the Jordan,
just as the man of God had said.
And his body became like the body of a little child
again,
and he was clean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Naaman arrives in grand style, with horses and chariots. But Elisha does not even come out. He only sends a messenger.

Naaman is offended. He had imagined an impressive healing. Instead he is to wash in a small, muddy river. His pride stands in his way.

Again it is servants, ordinary people, who bring the powerful man to his senses: "If the prophet had told you to do some great thing, wouldn't you have done it?"

Naaman has to become humble. He goes down, quite literally, into the Jordan. And he is healed. His skin becomes like that of a little child.

In Nazareth Jesus reminded people of Naaman: there were many lepers in Israel, but the one who was healed was a foreigner (Luke 4:27).

Abanah and Pharpar are rivers near Damascus.

Naaman turns to the LORD VERSES 15–19

15 He went back to the man of God, he and all the people
with him.
He came, stood in front of him, and said,
"Look, now I know
that there is no God in all the earth except in Israel.
So now, please accept a gift from your servant."
16 But Elisha said,
"As surely as the LORD lives, before whom I stand,
I will accept nothing."
Naaman urged him to take it,
but he refused.
17 Naaman said,
"If not, then please let your servant be given as much
earth as two mules can carry.
For from now on your servant will not offer burnt
offerings or sacrifices to other gods anymore,
but only to the LORD.
18 In one thing may the LORD forgive your servant:
when my master goes into the house of Rimmon to
worship there,
and he leans on my hand,
and I bow down in the house of Rimmon.
When I bow down in the house of Rimmon,
may the LORD forgive your servant in this thing."
19 He said to him,
"Go in peace."
So Naaman went a short distance away from him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Naaman is not only healed in his body. He has come to know the living God. An enemy of Israel becomes a worshiper of the LORD.

Elisha accepts no gift. God's help cannot be bought. It is a gift.

Naaman wants to take earth from Israel with him. In those days people thought that a god was tied to his land. On this earth Naaman wants to offer sacrifices to the LORD in his home country.

Naaman has an honest problem: as an official, he has to go with his king into the temple of the god Rimmon (Rimmon is a name of the storm god Hadad). He asks for forgiveness ahead of time. Elisha answers wisely and kindly: "Go in peace." He does not put a burden on him that he cannot carry.

Gehazi's greed VERSES 20–27

20 But Gehazi, the servant of Elisha the man of God, said,
"Look, my master has let this Naaman the Syrian off
easily.
He did not accept from his hand what he brought.
As surely as the LORD lives,
I will run after him and take something from him."
21 So Gehazi ran after Naaman.
When Naaman saw someone running after him,
he got down from the chariot to meet him and said,
"Is everything all right?"
22 He said,
"Everything is all right.
My master has sent me to say,
'Look, just now two young men of the sons of the
prophets
have come to me from the hill country of Ephraim.

Please give them a talent of silver (about 75 pounds)
and two changes of clothes.'"
23 Naaman said,
"Please take two talents (about 150 pounds)."
He urged him.
He tied up two talents of silver in two bags,
with two changes of clothes,
and gave them to two of his servants.
They carried them in front of Gehazi.
24 When he came to the hill, he took them from their hands
and stored them in the house.
Then he let the men go, and they went away.
25 But he went in and stood in front of his master.
Elisha said to him,
"Where have you come from, Gehazi?"
He said,
"Your servant went nowhere."
26 He said to him,
"Didn't my heart go with you
when the man turned from his chariot to meet you?
Is this a time to take money and to take clothes,
olive groves and vineyards,
sheep and cattle,
and male and female servants?
27 So the leprosy of Naaman will cling to you and to your descendants forever."
And Gehazi went out from his presence a leper, as white as snow.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gehazi is greedy. He lies to Naaman and then also to his master Elisha. He turns God's gift into a business deal.

In this way he damages the message: Naaman was meant to learn that God's help is free. Gehazi destroys this witness.

Elisha knows what happened: "Didn't my heart go with you?" He saw it in his spirit.

Gehazi probably wanted to buy land, animals, and servants with the money. Elisha lists all of these.

In the end the foreigner is healed and the Israelite is a leper. What matters is not where someone comes from, but the heart.

The Bible says "a talent of silver" and "two talents." A talent is about 75 pounds.

"Forever" is a hard punishment. But later Gehazi is mentioned again, telling the king about Elisha's deeds (2 Kings 8:4–5).

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 6

Chariots of fire and a city under siege

The floating iron VERSES 1–7

1 The sons of the prophets said to Elisha,
"Look, the place where we live and meet with you is too small for us.
2 Please let us go to the Jordan.
Each man can get a beam there,
and let's build a place there for us to live."
He answered,
"Go!"
3 One of them said,
"Please be willing to go with your servants."
He answered,
"I will go."
4 So he went with them.
When they came to the Jordan, they cut down trees.
5 But as one of them was cutting down a tree,
the iron head of the ax fell into the water.
He cried out,
"Oh no, my master!
It was borrowed!"
6 The man of God asked,
"Where did it fall?"
He showed him the place.
Elisha cut off a stick, threw it in there,
and made the iron float.
7 He said,
"Pick it up."
So he reached out his hand and took it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A small miracle for a small need. In those days iron was expensive. A poor student of the prophets could hardly have replaced the borrowed ax.

God cares not only about big things like wars and kings, but also about the everyday worries of an ordinary person.

Elisha sees through the Syrians VERSES 8–14

8 The king of Syria was at war with Israel.
He talked things over with his servants and said,
"My camp will be in such and such a place."
9 The man of God sent a message to the king of Israel:
"Be careful not to pass by this place,
because the Syrians are coming down there."
10 The king of Israel sent men to the place
that the man of God had told him about and warned him of.
So he saved himself there, not just once or twice.
11 The heart of the king of Syria was very troubled about this.
He called his servants and said to them,
"Won't you tell me which of us is on the side of the king of Israel?"
12 One of his servants said,
"No one, my lord the king.
But Elisha, the prophet who is in Israel,
tells the king of Israel the words that you speak in your bedroom."
13 He said,
"Go and see where he is,
so that I can send men and get him."

He was told,
"Look, he is in Dothan."
14 So he sent horses, chariots, and a great army there.
They came by night and surrounded the city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king of Syria thinks he has a traitor among his own people. But it is God who shows Elisha the secret plans.

Nothing is secret before God, not even in a king's bedroom.

Dothan lay about 12 miles north of Samaria. Long before, Joseph's brothers had sold him there (Genesis 37:17).

More are with us VERSES 15–23

15 The servant of the man of God got up early and went out.
Look, an army with horses and chariots was all around the city.
His servant said to him,
"Oh no, my master! What shall we do?"
16 He answered,
"Don't be afraid,
because those who are with us are more than those who are with them."
17 Elisha prayed and said,
"LORD, please open his eyes, so that he may see."
Then the LORD opened the young man's eyes, and he saw.
And look, the mountain was full of horses and chariots of fire all around Elisha.
18 When the Syrians came down to him,
Elisha prayed to the LORD and said,
"Please strike these people with blindness."
And he struck them with blindness, just as Elisha had said.
19 Elisha said to them,
"This is not the way, and this is not the city.
Follow me, and I will bring you to the man you are looking for."
And he led them to Samaria.
20 When they had come into Samaria, Elisha said,
"LORD, open these men's eyes, so that they may see."
Then the LORD opened their eyes, and they saw.
And look, they were in the middle of Samaria.
21 When the king of Israel saw them, he said to Elisha,
"My father, shall I strike them? Shall I strike them?"
22 He answered,
"You shall not strike them.
Would you strike down people you had taken captive with your own sword and bow?
Set bread and water in front of them,
so that they may eat and drink,
and then let them go to their master."
23 So he prepared a great feast for them.
After they had eaten and drunk,
he sent them away, and they went to their master.
And the raiding groups of Syria stopped coming into the land of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The young servant sees only the enemies and becomes afraid. Elisha sees more: God's heavenly army is there. "Those who are with us are more than those who are with them." Whoever trusts in God is never alone.

Elisha prays: "Open his eyes." Faith sometimes means seeing God's unseen reality.

The horses and chariots of fire remind us of Elijah going up into heaven (2 Kings 2:11).

Then something surprising happens: Elisha does not let the enemies be killed. He has a feast given to them and sends them home. And so peace comes: the raids stop.

This is one of the most beautiful stories of peace in the Old Testament. It reminds us of Proverbs 25:21: "If your enemy is hungry, give him food to eat." Paul quotes this in Romans 12:20. And Jesus says: "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44).

"Strike with blindness" probably means a kind of confusion here: they do not recognize where they are.

Famine in Samaria VERSES 24–33

24 After this, Benhadad, the king of Syria, gathered his whole army.
He went up and laid siege to Samaria.
A siege means: an army surrounds a city so that no one can get in or out.
25 There was a great famine in Samaria.
Look, they kept up the siege so long
that a donkey's head was sold for 80 pieces of silver,
and about half a pint of dove's dung for 5 pieces of silver.
26 As the king of Israel was walking along on the wall,
a woman cried out to him,
"Help, my lord the king!"
27 He said,
"If the LORD doesn't help you, where could I get help for you?
From the threshing floor, or from the winepress?"
28 Then the king asked her,
"What is wrong?"
She answered,
"This woman said to me,
'Give up your son, so that we can eat him today.
And tomorrow we will eat my son.'
29 So we boiled my son and ate him.
And on the next day I said to her,
'Give up your son, so that we can eat him.'
But she has hidden her son."
30 When the king heard the words of the woman,
he tore his clothes.
He was walking along on the wall.
And the people looked,
and look, he had sackcloth underneath, on his body.
Sackcloth is rough cloth that people wore when they were sad or sorry.
31 Then he said,
"May God do this to me, and even more,
if the head of Elisha the son of Shaphat stays on him today."
32 But Elisha was sitting in his house,
and the elders were sitting with him.
The king sent a man ahead of him.
But before the messenger came to him, Elisha said to the elders,
"Do you see how this son of a murderer has sent someone to take away my head?
Look, when the messenger comes, shut the door

and hold the door shut against him.
Isn't the sound of his master's feet behind him?"
33 While he was still talking with them,
look, the messenger came down to him.
And the king said,
"Look, this trouble is from the LORD.
Why should I wait for the LORD any longer?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most terrible passages in the Bible. The siege lasts so long that people are starving. For a donkey's head, which was actually seen as unclean and has hardly any meat, people pay a fortune.

"Dove's dung": perhaps this is meant literally, as fuel or even as food in the greatest need. Perhaps it is also the name of a plant, for example a kind of wild onion or seed pod. The Bible says "the fourth part of a kab." A kab is a little more than 1 quart, so a fourth of it is about half a pint.

The need is so great that mothers eat their own children. That is the most extreme horror. This is exactly what God had warned about if the people left him (Deuteronomy 28:53–57). The Bible does not keep silent about this horror. It shows how war and siege destroy what is human in people. Sadly, there are also reports of such horror during famines in more recent history, for example during the siege of Leningrad.

The king secretly wears sackcloth under his clothes, as a sign of repentance. But instead of turning back to God, he wants to kill Elisha. He blames the prophet.

"Son of a murderer": this means King Jehoram, the son of Ahab, who had Naboth murdered.

The last sentence shows the despair: "Why should I wait for the LORD any longer?" The next chapter gives a surprising answer.

2 KINGS

Chapter 7

Four lepers bring good news

Elisha's unbelievable announcement VERSES 1–2

1 Elisha said,
"Hear the LORD's word.
The LORD says,
'Tomorrow at about this time, in the gate of Samaria,
about 2 gallons of fine flour will be sold for a shekel,
and about 4 gallons of barley for a shekel.'"
2 Then the officer on whose hand the king leaned
answered the man of God,
"Look, even if the LORD made windows in heaven,
could this thing happen?"
Elisha said,
"Look, you will see it with your own eyes,
but you will not eat any of it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the worst famine, Elisha announces: already tomorrow there will be food at quite normal prices. That sounds impossible.

The Bible says "a seah of fine flour for a shekel, and two seahs of barley for a shekel." A seah is about 2 gallons. A shekel is about 0.4 ounces of silver.

The officer mocks: not even if God made windows in heaven and let food rain down! He does not believe that God can help.

"On whose hand the king leaned" means: he was a close and trusted helper of the king.

The lepers in the empty camp VERSES 3–11

3 There were four men with leprosy at the entrance of the gate.
They said to one another,
"Why do we sit here until we die?
4 If we say, 'We will go into the city,'
the famine is in the city, and we will die there.
And if we stay sitting here, we will die too.
So come, let's give ourselves up to the army of the Syrians.
If they let us live, we will live.
And if they kill us, we will only die."
5 They got up at twilight to go to the camp of the Syrians.
When they came to the edge of the camp of the Syrians,
look, no one was there.
6 For the Lord had made the army of the Syrians
hear the sound of chariots and the sound of horses,
the noise of a great army.
They said to one another,
"Look, the king of Israel has hired the kings of the Hittites
and the kings of the Egyptians against us, to attack us."
7 So they got up and fled at twilight.
They left their tents, their horses, and their donkeys,
the whole camp just as it was,
and they fled for their lives.
8 When these lepers came to the edge of the camp,
they went into one tent and ate and drank.
Then they carried away silver, gold, and clothes,
and went and hid them.
Then they came back and went into another tent.
They carried things away from there too,
and went and hid them.
9 Then they said to one another,
"We aren't doing right.
Today is a day of good news, and we keep silent.
If we wait until morning light, punishment will catch up with us.
So come, let's go and tell the king's household."
10 So they came and called to the gatekeepers of the city.
They told them,
"We came to the camp of the Syrians,
and look, no one was there, not even the voice of a man.
Only the horses were tied up and the donkeys were tied up,
and the tents were just as they had been."

11 Then the gatekeepers called out,
and it was told to the king's household inside.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The lepers were not allowed into the city. They were outcasts and had nothing left to lose. Of all people, they are the first to discover the rescue.

God frightened the Syrians with a noise. They thought a huge army was coming. They fled and left everything behind. No Israelite had to fight.

At first the lepers think only about themselves. They eat and hide treasures. That is understandable after so much hunger. But then they realize: "We aren't doing right. Today is a day of good news, and we keep silent." You must not keep good news to yourself while others are starving.

Many Christians see a picture in this: whoever has received good news from God should pass it on.

The "kings of the Hittites" were rulers of small kingdoms in the north, in the area of today's Turkey and Syria.

The king does not trust it VERSES 12–15

12 The king got up in the night and said to his servants,
"Let me tell you what the Syrians have done to us.
They know that we are hungry.
So they have gone out of the camp to hide in the field.
They think, 'When they come out of the city,
we will take them alive and get into the city.'"

13 One of his servants answered,
"Please let some men take five of the horses that
remain, that are left in the city.
Look, they are like the whole crowd of Israel who are
left in it.
Look, they are like the whole crowd of Israel who have
already died.
Let's send them and see."

14 So they took two chariots with horses.
And the king sent them after the Syrian army and said,
"Go and see."

15 They followed them as far as the Jordan.
And look, the whole road was full of clothes and
equipment
that the Syrians had thrown away in their hurry.
The messengers came back and told the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king does not trust the good news. He suspects a trap. The servant is wise: the horses will soon die of hunger anyway. We have nothing to lose if we go and look.

Verse 13 repeats a sentence almost the same way. Perhaps this is a copying mistake in the old handwritten copies. It means: the horses are like everyone else. Whether they stay or go, they will die anyway.

The word comes true VERSES 16–20

16 Then the people went out and plundered the camp of
the Syrians.
So about 2 gallons of fine flour were sold for a shekel,
and about 4 gallons of barley for a shekel,
just as the LORD had said.

17 The king had put the officer on whose hand he leaned in
charge of the gate.
But the people trampled him in the gate,
and he died.
It happened just as the man of God had said.
He had said it when the king came down to him.

18 It happened just as the man of God had told the king:
"Tomorrow at about this time, in the gate of Samaria,
about 4 gallons of barley will be sold for a shekel,
and about 2 gallons of fine flour for a shekel."

19 And that officer had answered the man of God,
"Look, even if the LORD made windows in heaven,
could such a thing happen?"
And Elisha had said,
"Look, you will see it with your own eyes,
but you will not eat any of it."

20 That is exactly what happened to him.
For the people trampled him in the gate, and he died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Everything happens exactly as Elisha announced. God saved his people without a battle.

The officer sees the miracle with his own eyes, but he cannot enjoy any of it. The hungry crowd pushes through the gate and tramples him.

The text tells the story again in detail. It wants to stress: God's word can be trusted, even when it sounds impossible. Mocking and unbelief bring nothing good.

In verse 16 the WEB, our English source text, speaks of two measures of barley. This again means two seahs, as in verse 1.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 8

The Shunammite woman, Hazael, and two kings of Judah

The woman from Shunem gets her land back VERSES 1–6

1 Elisha had spoken to the woman whose son he had
brought back to life.
He had said,
"Get up and go away, you and your household,
and live for a while wherever you can.
For the LORD has called for a famine.
It will come on the land for seven years."

2 The woman got up and did what the man of God had
said.
She went away with her household
and lived in the land of the Philistines for seven years.

3 At the end of seven years, the woman came back from
the land of the Philistines.
Then she went to the king to beg him for her house and
her land.

4 The king was just talking with Gehazi, the servant of
the man of God.
He said,
"Please tell me all the great things that Elisha has
done."

5 He was just telling the king
how Elisha had brought a dead person back to life.
And look, the woman whose son he had brought back to life
came and begged the king for her house and her land.
Gehazi said,
"My lord the king, this is the woman,
and this is her son, whom Elisha brought back to life."
6 The king asked the woman, and she told him.
So the king gave her an officer and said,
"Give back everything that was hers,
and all the harvest of the field from the day she left the land until now."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elisha warns the woman from Shunem about a famine. She flees to another country, to the Philistines. She is a refugee for seven years.

When she comes back, others have taken her house and field. She has to beg the king for them.

And at exactly this moment Gehazi is telling the king about her. That is no accident: God makes sure that she comes at the right time. She gets everything back, even the harvest of the seven years.

Here the text probably does not tell things in the order they happened. Gehazi had become a leper in Chapter 5. This story perhaps takes place before that, or it shows that he still talked with the king anyway.

Hazael becomes king of Syria VERSES 7–15

7 Elisha came to Damascus.
Benhadad, the king of Syria, was sick.
He was told,
"The man of God has come here."
8 The king said to Hazael,
"Take a gift in your hand,
go to meet the man of God,
and ask the LORD through him,
'Will I get well from this sickness?'"
9 So Hazael went to meet him.
He took a gift with him, of every good thing from Damascus,
as much as 40 camels could carry.
He came, stood in front of him, and said,
"Your son Benhadad, the king of Syria, has sent me to you.
He asks,
'Will I get well from this sickness?'"
10 Elisha said to him,
"Go and tell him, 'You will surely get well.'
But the LORD has shown me that he will surely die."
11 He stared at him without looking away, until Hazael was ashamed.
Then the man of God wept.
12 Hazael asked,
"Why is my lord weeping?"
He answered,
"Because I know the evil that you will do to the people of Israel.
You will set their fortresses on fire.
You will kill their young men with the sword.
You will dash their little children to pieces.
And you will rip open their pregnant women."
13 Hazael said,
"But what is your servant, who is only a dog, that he could do this great thing?"
Elisha answered,
"The LORD has shown me that you will be king over Syria."
14 Then he went away from Elisha and came to his master.
His master asked him,
"What did Elisha say to you?"
He answered,
"He told me that you would surely get well."
15 The next day he took a thick cloth,
dipped it in water,
and spread it over the king's face,
so that he died.
And Hazael became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elisha is known and respected even in the land of the enemies. The king of Syria calls himself "your son."

Elisha's answer sounds contradictory: the sickness itself will not kill Benhadad. But he will die anyway, by murder.

Then Elisha looks at Hazael for a long time and weeps. He sees ahead how much suffering this man will bring on Israel. The prophet is not glad about the coming disaster. He weeps over the victims.

The cruel acts in verse 12 were sadly common in war in those days. The Bible describes them as evil, not as something good. Today such acts are war crimes.

Hazael pretends to be too small and unimportant ("only a dog"). But the very next day he murders his king. In truth he wanted power.

At Horeb, God had told Elijah that Hazael was to become king (1 Kings 19:15). That now comes true, but through Hazael's own evil deed.

Hazael is also known outside the Bible. An Assyrian inscription calls him a "son of a nobody," that is, a man without royal family who grabbed the throne for himself.

Jehoram, king of Judah VERSES 16–24

16 Joram, the son of Ahab, was king of Israel.
In the fifth year of his rule, Jehoram became king of Judah.
Jehoram was the son of Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah.
At that time Jehoshaphat was still king of Judah.
17 Jehoram was 32 years old when he became king.
He ruled for eight years in Jerusalem.
18 He lived the way the kings of Israel lived,
just as Ahab's family did.
He had married Ahab's daughter.
He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
19 But the LORD did not want to destroy Judah,
for the sake of his servant David.
He had promised David to give him a lamp for his children forever.
20 In Jehoram's time, Edom rebelled against the rule of Judah.
The Edomites made a king for themselves.
21 Then Joram crossed over to Zair with all his chariots.
He got up by night.
The Edomites had surrounded him and the commanders of his chariots.

He attacked them.
And the people fled to their tents.
22 So Edom broke away from the rule of Judah,
and it is still that way to this day.
At the same time Libnah also rebelled.
23 The rest of Joram's story and everything he did
are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings
of Judah.
24 Joram died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried with his ancestors in David's city.
His son Ahaziah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Ahab's house also has influence in Judah: King Jehoram of Judah has married Ahab's daughter Athaliah. With this, the worship of Baal also comes to Jerusalem.

Do not mix them up: at the same time another Joram, the son of Ahab, ruled in the north.

Even so, God stays faithful to his promise to David. The "lamp" in Jerusalem is not to go out.

Edom makes itself independent. The battle in verse 21 is hard to understand. Joram was probably barely able to escape from being surrounded.

Libnah was a city in the west of Judah, at the border with the Philistines.

Jehoram of Judah ruled from about 848 to 841 BC.

Ahaziah, king of Judah VERSES 25–29

25 Joram, the son of Ahab, was king of Israel.
In the twelfth year of his rule, Ahaziah became king of
Judah.
Ahaziah was the son of Jehoram, the king of Judah.
26 Ahaziah was 22 years old when he became king.
He ruled for one year in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Athaliah.
She was the daughter of Omri, the king of Israel.
27 Ahaziah lived the way Ahab's family lived.
He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes, just as Ahab's
family did.
He was related to Ahab's family by marriage.
28 He went with Joram, the son of Ahab, to war
against Hazael, the king of Syria, at Ramoth Gilead.
The Syrians wounded Joram.
29 So King Joram went back to Jezreel
to be healed from his wounds.
The Syrians had wounded him at Ramah,
when he fought against Hazael, the king of Syria.
Ahaziah, the son of Jehoram, the king of Judah,
went down to Jezreel to see Joram, the son of Ahab,
because Joram was sick.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Another Ahaziah: this one is king of Judah, a grandson of Ahab.

Here Athaliah is called "the daughter of Omri." In Hebrew, "daughter" can also mean "granddaughter" or "descendant". She was the daughter of Ahab and the granddaughter of Omri. She will play a terrible part in Chapter 11.

"Ramah" is a short form for Ramoth Gilead here.

The two kings, Joram of Israel and Ahaziah of Judah, are now together in Jezreel. That is important for the next chapter.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 9

Jehu becomes king

Jehu is anointed VERSES 1–13

1 Elisha the prophet called one of the sons of the
prophets and said to him,
"Put your belt around your waist,
take this little bottle of oil in your hand,
and go to Ramoth Gilead.
2 When you get there,
find Jehu the son of Jehoshaphat, the son of Nimshi.
Go in, have him get up from among his brothers,
and take him into an inner room.
3 Then take the bottle of oil,
pour it on his head,
and say,
'The LORD says,
"I have anointed you king over Israel."'
Then open the door, run away, and don't wait."
4 So the young man, the young prophet, went to
Ramoth Gilead.
5 When he came, look, the commanders of the army
were sitting together.
He said,
"I have a message for you, commander."
Jehu asked,
"For which one of us?"
He said,
"For you, commander."
6 So Jehu got up and went into the house.
The young man poured the oil on his head and said to
him,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, says,
'I have anointed you king over the LORD's people,
over Israel.
7 You must strike the family of your master Ahab.
Then I will take revenge on Jezebel for the blood of my
servants the prophets
and for the blood of all the LORD's servants.
8 The whole family of Ahab will die.
I will cut off from Ahab everyone who urinates against
a wall in Israel,
the one who is shut up and the one who is free.
9 I will make Ahab's family like the family of Jeroboam,
the son of Nebat,
and like the family of Baasha, the son of Ahijah.
10 The dogs will eat Jezebel on the piece of ground at
Jezreel,

and there will be no one to bury her.'"
Then he opened the door and ran away.

11 Jehu came out to the servants of his lord.
One of them said to him,
"Is everything all right? Why did this madman come to you?"
He said to them,
"You know the man and how he talks."

12 They said,
"That's a lie. Tell us now."
He said,
"He said to me,
'The LORD says, I have anointed you king over Israel.'"

13 Then they hurried.
Each man took his cloak and put it under him on the top of the stairs.
They blew the trumpet and said,
"Jehu is king!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now what God had told Elijah at Horeb comes true: Jehu is to become king (1 Kings 19:16).

Jehu is an army commander. A young prophet anoints him in secret and then runs away at once, because this is life-threatening: it is a revolt against the king.

The soldiers call the prophet a "madman." Prophets often seemed strange to other people.

The officers lay their cloaks under Jehu's feet. That is a way of honoring a king. In a similar way, people spread their clothes on the road when Jesus rode into Jerusalem (Matthew 21:8).

God's command to Jehu is very harsh. The Bible tells it because Ahab and Jezebel had killed many innocent people, among them prophets and Naboth. But you need to know: later Jehu goes far beyond the command. A later prophet, Hosea, condemns the blood that Jehu shed at Jezreel (Hosea 1:4). God's judgment is no permission for human cruelty.

Jehu kills Joram VERSES 14–26

14 So Jehu the son of Jehoshaphat, the son of Nimshi,
plotted against Joram.
(Joram, he and all Israel, had been defending Ramoth Gilead against Hazael king of Syria.

15 But King Joram had gone back to Jezreel to be healed from the wounds that the Syrians had given him when he fought against Hazael king of Syria.)
Jehu said,
"If this is what you think,
then let no one escape from the city
to go and tell it in Jezreel."

16 So Jehu got into a chariot and went to Jezreel,
because Joram was lying there.
Ahaziah king of Judah had also come down to see Joram.

17 The watchman was standing on the tower in Jezreel.
He saw Jehu's troop coming and said,
"I see a troop."
Joram said,
"Take a horseman and send him to meet them.
Let him ask, 'Is it peace?'"

18 So a man rode on horseback to meet him and said,
"The king says, 'Is it peace?'"
Jehu said,
"What do you have to do with peace? Fall in behind me!"
The watchman said,
"The messenger came to them, but he isn't coming back."

19 Then he sent out a second horseman.
He came to them and said,
"The king says, 'Is it peace?'"
Jehu answered,
"What do you have to do with peace? Fall in behind me!"

20 The watchman said,
"He came to them and isn't coming back.
And the driving is like the driving of Jehu the son of Nimshi,
because he drives like a madman."

21 Joram said,
"Get ready!"
And they got his chariot ready.
Then Joram king of Israel and Ahaziah king of Judah went out,
each in his chariot.
They went out to meet Jehu
and found him on the land of Naboth the Jezreelite.

22 When Joram saw Jehu, he said,
"Is it peace, Jehu?"
He answered,
"What peace can there be,
as long as the prostitution of your mother Jezebel and her witchcraft are everywhere?"

23 Then Joram turned his chariot around and fled.
He said to Ahaziah,
"This is treason, Ahaziah!"

24 Jehu drew his bow with all his strength
and struck Joram between his arms.
The arrow went out through his heart,
and he sank down in his chariot.

25 Then Jehu said to Bidkar his officer,
"Pick him up and throw him onto the field of Naboth the Jezreelite.
Remember how you and I were riding together behind his father Ahab
when the LORD spoke this heavy word against him:

26 'Surely I saw the blood of Naboth and the blood of his sons yesterday,'
says the LORD,
'and I will pay you back on this piece of ground,'
says the LORD.
So now pick him up and throw him onto the piece of ground, just as the LORD said."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Between his arms" probably means: in the back, between the shoulder blades, when Joram turned around to flee.

Jehu is known for his wild driving. The watchman recognizes him by it from far away.

Three times the question is asked: "Is it peace?" But there is no peace.

In the Bible, "prostitution" is often a picture for worshiping idols: being unfaithful to God, like being unfaithful in marriage. Jezebel had brought the worship of Baal to Israel.

Joram dies on Naboth's field, of all places. Here the circle closes: Ahab and Jezebel had had Naboth murdered there (1 Kings 21). Now the payback comes at this place.
Here we also learn that Naboth's sons were murdered with him (verse 26).

Ahaziah of Judah dies VERSES 27–29

27 When Ahaziah the king of Judah saw this,
he fled along the road to the garden house.
Jehu chased him and said,
"Strike him too, in the chariot!"
They struck him at the slope going up to Gur, which is near Ibleam.
He fled to Megiddo and died there.
28 His servants carried him in a chariot to Jerusalem.
They buried him in his tomb with his ancestors in David's city.
29 Ahaziah had become king over Judah in the eleventh year of Joram the son of Ahab.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king of Judah also loses his life, because he was connected with Ahab's house.
Interesting: in 1993 and 1994 an inscription was found at Tel Dan in the north of Israel. In it a king of Damascus, probably Hazael, boasts that he killed Joram the king of Israel and Ahaziah of the "house of David." The Bible says it was Jehu. Perhaps Hazael saw himself as the winner because Jehu worked together with him, or he was simply boasting. This inscription is famous because it mentions the "house of David". It is one of the oldest pieces of evidence outside the Bible for David's royal family.
Verse 29 gives a different year than 2 Kings 8:25 (the eleventh instead of the twelfth year). The years were probably counted in different ways.

The end of Jezebel VERSES 30–37

30 When Jehu came to Jezreel, Jezebel heard about it.
She painted her eyes with makeup, made her hair beautiful,
and looked out of the window.
31 As Jehu came in at the gate, she said,
"Do you come in peace, Zimri, you murderer of your master?"
32 He lifted up his face to the window and said,
"Who is on my side? Who?"
Two or three eunuchs looked down at him.
Eunuchs were servants at the royal court who had been made unable to father children.
33 He said,
"Throw her down!"
So they threw her down.
Some of her blood splashed on the wall and on the horses.
Then he trampled her under his horses' feet.
34 When he had gone in, he ate and drank.
Then he said,
"Now take care of this cursed woman and bury her, because she is a king's daughter."
35 They went to bury her,
but they found nothing more of her than the skull, the feet, and the palms of her hands.
36 So they came back and told him.
He said,
"This is the LORD's word,
which he spoke through his servant Elijah the Tishbite:
'The dogs will eat the flesh of Jezebel on the piece of ground at Jezreel.
37 And the body of Jezebel will be like dung lying on the field in the land of Jezreel,
so that no one will be able to say, "This is Jezebel."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jezebel knows that her end is coming. But she dies proud. She puts on makeup and faces Jehu as a queen. She calls him "Zimri": about 45 years earlier, Zimri had murdered his king and then ruled for only seven days (1 Kings 16:9–18). Jezebel wants to say: the same will happen to you.
The eunuchs, officials of the royal court, quickly change sides and throw their mistress out of the window.
Jehu eats and drinks as if nothing had happened. That shows how hard he is.
So Elijah's word comes true (1 Kings 21:23). Jezebel had had many of God's prophets and Naboth killed. The Bible shows: even the powerful do not escape God's judgment.
Even so, this scene is cruel and not an example to follow. The Bible tells it to show how violence and the worship of idols bring their own punishment, not to approve of them.
The name "Jezebel" later became a symbol for leading people to worship idols (Revelation 2:20). Sadly, it has also been used to put women down. That is wrong: Jezebel is not condemned because she was a woman, but because of what she did.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 10

Jehu's bloody rule

The 70 sons of Ahab VERSES 1–11

1 Ahab had 70 sons in Samaria.
Jehu wrote letters and sent them to Samaria,
to the rulers of Jezreel, the elders,
and to those who were bringing up Ahab's sons.
He wrote:
2 "Your master's sons are with you.
You have chariots and horses, a walled city, and weapons.
As soon as this letter comes to you,
3 choose the best and most able of your master's sons.
Put him on his father's throne,
and fight for your master's house."
4 But they were terribly afraid and said,
"Look, the two kings could not stand against him!
How then can we stand?"

5 Then a message came to Jehu.
It was from the man in charge of the palace, the man in charge of the city,
the elders, and those who were bringing up the children:
"We are your servants.
We will do everything you tell us.
We will not make anyone king.
Do what is good in your eyes."
6 Then he wrote them a second letter:
"If you are on my side, and if you will listen to my voice,
take the heads of the men, your master's sons,
and come to me at Jezreel by this time tomorrow."
The king's sons, 70 persons, were with the great men of the city.
These men were bringing them up.
7 When the letter came to them,
they took the king's sons and killed them, 70 persons.
They put their heads in baskets
and sent them to him at Jezreel.
8 A messenger came and told him,
"They have brought the heads of the king's sons."
He said,
"Lay them in two heaps at the entrance of the gate until morning."
9 In the morning he went out, stood there, and said to all the people,
"You are righteous.
Look, I plotted against my master and killed him.
But who killed all these?
10 Know now that nothing of the LORD's word will fall to the ground,
the word that the LORD spoke against Ahab's house.
For the LORD has done what he said through his servant Elijah."
11 So Jehu struck down all who were left of Ahab's house in Jezreel,
all his great men, his close friends, and his priests,
until he left him no one.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is very bloody and hard to read.

"70 sons" probably means all of Ahab's male descendants, including grandsons.

Verse 9: "Righteous" means: living right before God. Here Jehu means: you are not guilty.

Jehu is clever and ruthless. He has the leading men of Samaria kill the princes. Then he says to the people: I killed only one, but who killed all these? In this way he makes everyone share the guilt.

Jehu points to God's word. But he goes far beyond it. He also kills friends, officials, and priests. About 100 years later the prophet Hosea condemns the blood shed at Jezreel (Hosea 1:4). God had announced a judgment on Ahab's house. But he had not given Jehu permission for violence without limits.

The Bible reports these deeds honestly. They are not an example to follow. No one may point to God to justify killing people.

Ahaziah's brothers VERSES 12–14

12 He got up and set out and went to Samaria.
On the way he was at the shearing house of the shepherds.
A shearing house is a place where sheep are sheared, that is, where their wool is cut off.
13 There Jehu met the brothers of Ahaziah king of Judah.
He asked,
"Who are you?"
They answered,
"We are the brothers of Ahaziah.
We are going down to greet the sons of the king and the sons of the queen."
14 He said,
"Take them alive!"
They took them alive
and killed them at the pit of the shearing house, 42 men.
He did not leave any of them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The relatives of the king of Judah do not yet know anything about the overthrow. They want to visit Ahab's family. Jehu has them all killed too.

"Brothers" here probably means relatives in general. Ahaziah's real brothers had already died earlier (2 Chronicles 21:17).

"The queen" is Jezebel, the queen mother.

Jehonadab the son of Rechab VERSES 15–17

15 When he had left there,
he met Jehonadab the son of Rechab coming to meet him.
He greeted him and said to him,
"Is your heart true, as my heart is with your heart?"
Jehonadab answered,
"It is."
Jehu said,
"If it is, give me your hand."
He gave him his hand,
and Jehu took him up into the chariot with him.
16 He said,
"Come with me, and see how zealous I am for the LORD."
Being zealous means: being full of eager, burning devotion.
So they had him ride in his chariot.
17 When he came to Samaria,
he struck down all who were left of Ahab's family in Samaria,
until he had destroyed them,
just as the LORD had said to Elijah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehonadab was the leader of an especially strict group, the Rechabites. They drank no wine, built no houses, and lived in tents, as a sign of their faithfulness to God and against the comfortable life in the cities. Later the prophet Jeremiah praises them for their faithfulness (Jeremiah 35).

With Jehonadab, Jehu wants to show that he is on the side of the devout people. "See how zealous I am for the LORD" sounds proud. True zeal for God does not need an audience.

The worshipers of Baal are killed VERSES 18–28

18 Jehu gathered all the people together and said to them,
"Ahab served Baal a little.
Jehu will serve him much.
19 So now call all the prophets of Baal to me,
all his worshipers and all his priests.
Let no one be missing,
because I have a great sacrifice for Baal.
Whoever is missing will not live."
But Jehu was acting with a trick,
so that he could destroy the worshipers of Baal.
20 Jehu said,
"Set apart a holy gathering for Baal!"
So they announced it.
21 Jehu sent messengers through all Israel.
And all the worshipers of Baal came.
Not one man was left who did not come.
They came into the house of Baal,
and the house of Baal was filled from one end to the other.
22 He said to the man in charge of the wardrobe,
"Bring out robes for all the worshipers of Baal!"
So he brought robes out for them.
23 Jehu went into the house of Baal with Jehonadab the son of Rechab.
Then he said to the worshipers of Baal,
"Search and make sure that none of the LORD's servants are here with you,
but only the worshipers of Baal."
24 So they went in to offer sacrifices and burnt offerings.
Jehu had placed 80 men outside and had said,
"If any of the men I bring into your hands escapes,
the man who lets him go will pay for it with his own life."
25 As soon as he had finished offering the burnt offering,
Jehu said to the guards and to the officers,
"Go in and kill them! Let no one escape!"
So they struck them down with the sword.
The guards and the officers threw the bodies out
and went into the inner room of the house of Baal.
26 They brought out the stone pillars that were in the house of Baal
and burned them.
27 They broke down the pillar of Baal
and broke down the house of Baal
and made it into a toilet, and it is that to this day.
28 So Jehu destroyed Baal out of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With a lie, Jehu lures all the worshipers of Baal into the temple and has them killed there.

With this, the worship of Baal in the northern kingdom comes to an end. But the means are lies and mass murder. That is deeply shocking.

We have to see this story in its own time: in those days a struggle for power between royal families and religions was often carried out with the greatest cruelty. The Bible reports it, but in other places it makes clear that God takes no pleasure in death (Ezekiel 18:32). Religious violence is not God's will. Jesus clearly rejected violence in God's name (Matthew 26:52).

The temple of Baal is turned into a latrine, that is, a toilet. That was the greatest contempt that could be shown.

Jehu stays with the golden calves VERSES 29–36

29 But Jehu did not turn away from the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat,
the sins through which he had made Israel sin:
the golden calves that were in Bethel and in Dan.
30 The LORD said to Jehu,
"You have done well in doing what is right in my eyes,
and you have done to Ahab's house all that was in my heart.
So your descendants will sit on the throne of Israel down to the fourth generation."
31 But Jehu was not careful to live by the law of the LORD, the God of Israel,
with all his heart.
He did not turn away from the sins of Jeroboam,
the sins through which he had made Israel sin.
32 In those days the LORD began to cut away parts of Israel.
Hazael struck them in all the territory of Israel,
33 from the Jordan eastward:
all the land of Gilead, the Gadites, the Reubenites, and the Manassites,
from Aroer, which is by the valley of the Arnon,
both Gilead and Bashan.
34 The rest of Jehu's story is written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.
It tells everything he did and how strong he was.
35 Jehu died and joined his ancestors.
They buried him in Samaria.
His son Jehoahaz became king in his place.
36 The time that Jehu ruled over Israel in Samaria was 28 years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehu has gotten rid of Baal. For this he receives a promise: his family is to rule for four generations. And that is what happens: Jehoahaz, Joash, Jeroboam II, and Zechariah.

But Jehu goes only halfway. He leaves Jeroboam's golden calves standing. He probably cared more about power than about God. He was zealous against others, but not with his whole heart for God.

At the same time, under Jehu, Israel loses all the land east of the Jordan to Hazael of Syria.

On the "Black Obelisk" of the Assyrian king Shalmaneser III (today in the British Museum in London) there is a picture of a man bowing down to the ground before the Assyrian king. The inscription calls him "Jehu, son of Omri" (or a messenger of Jehu). It is the oldest known picture of an Israelite king. Jehu had to pay tribute to the Assyrians.

Jehu ruled from about 841 to 814 BC.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 11

Queen Athaliah and little Joash

A child is saved VERSES 1–3

1 Athaliah, the mother of Ahaziah, saw that her son was dead.
Then she got up and killed all the descendants of the royal family.
2 But Jehosheba, the daughter of King Joram and sister of Ahaziah,
took Joash the son of Ahaziah.
She secretly stole him away from among the king's sons who were being killed,
him and his nurse,
and put them in the bedroom.
So they hid him from Athaliah,
and he was not killed.
3 He was hidden with her in the LORD's house for six years,
while Athaliah ruled over the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Athaliah is the daughter of Ahab and Jezebel. After the death of her son she wants to rule herself. For this she kills her own grandchildren. That is a horrible crime.

With this, David's family is in the greatest danger. God had promised David that his "lamp" would not go out. Now everything depends on one single baby.

A brave woman, Jehosheba, saves the child at the risk of her own life. She is the boy's aunt. According to 2 Chronicles 22:11 she was married to the priest Jehoiada. That is why she could hide the child in the temple.

Athaliah is the only woman who ruled over Judah as queen. She ruled from about 841 to 835 BC.

The plan of Jehoiada the priest VERSES 4–12

4 In the seventh year Jehoiada sent for the captains over hundreds of the Carites and of the guard.
He had them come to him into the LORD's house.
He made a covenant with them.
He made a covenant with them in the LORD's house,
and he showed them the king's son.
5 He commanded them,
"This is what you must do:
a third of you, who come on duty on the Sabbath,
shall keep watch over the king's house.
6 A third of you shall be at the gate Sur,
and a third at the gate behind the guard.
So you shall keep watch over the house and be a barrier.
7 And your two groups, all who go off duty on the Sabbath,
shall keep watch over the LORD's house around the king.
8 You shall surround the king, every man with his weapons in his hand.
Whoever comes inside the ranks must be killed.
Be with the king when he goes out and when he comes in."
9 The captains over hundreds did everything that Jehoiada the priest commanded.
Each one took his men,
those who were to come on duty on the Sabbath,
together with those who were to go off duty on the Sabbath,
and they came to Jehoiada the priest.
10 The priest gave the captains over hundreds the spears and shields
that had belonged to King David
and that were in the LORD's house.
11 The guards stood there, every man with his weapons in his hand,
from the right side of the house to the left side of the house,
along the altar and the house, all around the king.
12 Then he brought out the king's son,
put the crown on him,
and gave him the covenant.
They made him king and anointed him.
They clapped their hands and shouted,
"Long live the king!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For six years Jehoiada the priest waits. Then he plans everything carefully. He uses the Sabbath, because that is when the guards change. So twice as many soldiers are there, without anyone noticing.

The "Carites" were probably foreign soldiers who were paid to serve as bodyguards.

David's weapons are used. That is a sign: this is about David's rightful family.

"Gave him the covenant": probably a scroll with God's law or with the words of the covenant. The king is to rule by God's word (Deuteronomy 17:18–19).

"Long live the king!" Seven-year-old Joash is crowned.

The end of Athaliah VERSES 13–16

13 When Athaliah heard the noise of the guards and of the people,
she came to the people in the LORD's house.
14 She looked and saw the king standing by the pillar, as was the custom,
and the captains and the trumpeters were by the king.
And all the people of the land were rejoicing and blowing trumpets.
Then Athaliah tore her clothes and cried out,
"Treason! Treason!"
15 Jehoiada the priest commanded the captains of hundreds who were in charge of the army,
"Bring her out between the ranks.
Kill with the sword anyone who follows her."
For the priest said,
"Don't let her be killed in the LORD's house."
16 So they seized her.
She went along the way where the horses go into the king's house,
and there she was killed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Athaliah hears the cheering and hurries there. She cries "Treason!", even though she herself came to power through murder.

Jehoiada makes sure that no blood is shed in the temple. The holy place must not be made unclean.

A new covenant VERSES 17–21

17 Jehoiada made a covenant between the LORD and the king and the people,
that they would be the LORD's people.
He also made a covenant between the king and the people.
18 All the people of the land went to the house of Baal and tore it down.
They smashed his altars and his images completely to pieces,
and they killed Mattan the priest of Baal in front of the altars.
And the priest put officers in charge of the LORD's house.
19 He took the captains over hundreds, the Carites, the guards,
and all the people of the land.
They brought the king down from the LORD's house
and came by the way of the gate of the guards to the king's house.
And he sat on the throne of the kings.
20 So all the people of the land rejoiced,
and the city was quiet.
They had killed Athaliah with the sword at the king's house.
21 Jehoash was seven years old when he became king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The covenant is renewed: God, king, and people belong together. And there is also a covenant between king and people. The king has duties toward the people.

The temple of Baal in Jerusalem is destroyed. Unlike in Jehu's time, only the priest of Baal is killed here. The city stays quiet.

In some Bibles, verse 21 is already Chapter 12, verse 1. That is why the verse numbering in the next chapter is shifted by one.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 12

King Jehoash repairs the temple

A good beginning VERSES 1–3

1 Jehoash became king in the seventh year of Jehu,
and he ruled for 40 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Zibiah, from Beersheba.
2 Jehoash did what was right in the LORD's eyes
all his days in which Jehoiada the priest taught him.
3 But the high places were not taken away.
The people still offered sacrifices and burned incense on the high places.
High places were places of worship on hills.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoash (also called Joash) has a good teacher: Jehoiada the priest. As long as Jehoiada lives, Jehoash acts well.

"All his days in which Jehoiada the priest taught him" is a quiet hint: after Jehoiada's death things changed. 2 Chronicles 24:17–22 tells that Joash later even had Jehoiada's son killed.

In some Bibles the verse numbering in this chapter is shifted by one: verse 1 here is verse 2 there, and so on up to verse 21 here, which is verse 22 there.

Jehoash ruled from about 835 to 796 BC.

Money for repairing the temple VERSES 4–8

4 Jehoash said to the priests,
"All the money from the holy gifts that is brought into the LORD's house,
paid in the usual money:
the money that each person pays according to the value set for him,
and all the money that anyone freely decides in his heart to bring into the LORD's house,
5 the priests shall take for themselves, each one from his donor.
And they shall repair the damage to the house,
wherever any damage is found."
6 But in the twenty-third year of King Jehoash,
the priests still had not repaired the damage to the house.
7 Then King Jehoash called Jehoiada the priest and the other priests
and said to them,
"Why aren't you repairing the damage to the house?
So now take no more money from your treasurers,
but hand it over for repairing the damage to the house."
8 The priests agreed
that they would take no more money from the people,
and that they would not repair the damage to the house themselves.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple was more than 100 years old and had been neglected under Athaliah. There was a lot of damage.

Jehoash orders: the gifts are to be used for the repairs. But for more than 20 years nothing happens. The text does not say directly where the money went.

"The value set for him": whoever had made a vow could buy himself free with a fixed amount of money (Leviticus 27:1–8).

The Hebrew word for "donor" and "treasurer" is unclear. Word for word, it probably means "someone you know". Perhaps it means an official who received the money from the people.

The collection chest VERSES 9–16

9 Then Jehoiada the priest took a chest,
bored a hole in its lid,
and set it beside the altar,
on the right side as you come into the LORD's house.
The priests who kept watch at the doorway
put into it all the money that was brought into the LORD's house.

10 When they saw that there was a lot of money in the chest,
the king's scribe and the high priest came up.
They put it in bags
and counted the money that was found in the LORD's house.
11 They gave the money that had been weighed out into the hands of the work supervisors,
who were in charge of the LORD's house.
They paid it out to the carpenters and the builders who worked on the LORD's house,
12 and to the masons and the stonecutters.
They also bought wood and cut stone
to repair the damage to the LORD's house,
and paid for everything that was spent on repairing the house.
13 But from the money that was brought into the LORD's house,
no silver cups, wick trimmers, basins, or trumpets were made,
no objects of gold or silver for the LORD's house.
14 For they gave it to the workers,
and with it they repaired the LORD's house.
15 And they did not ask for an accounting from the men to whom they gave the money to pay the workers,
because they were honest.
16 The money for the guilt offerings and the money for the sin offerings
was not brought into the LORD's house.
It belonged to the priests.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoiada finds a simple solution: a collection chest with a hole in its lid. The money is counted together by an official of the king and by the high priest. So no one can take anything for himself alone. This is an early example of good, well-controlled handling of money.

To this day many churches and synagogues have such collection boxes.

At first all the money is used for the repairs, not for beautiful new objects. The important things first.

The work supervisors were so honest that no one had to ask them for an accounting.

Even so, the priests receive what is due to them: the money from certain offerings. They too have to live.

Wick trimmers were needed to trim the wicks of the lamps.

Hazael threatens Jerusalem VERSES 17–18

17 Then Hazael king of Syria went up,
fought against Gath, and captured it.
Then Hazael made up his mind to go up to Jerusalem.
18 Jehoash king of Judah took all the holy gifts
that his ancestors Jehoshaphat, Jehoram, and Ahaziah, kings of Judah, had dedicated,
and his own holy gifts,
and all the gold that was found in the treasuries of the LORD's house
and of the king's house,
and he sent it to Hazael king of Syria.
Then Hazael went away from Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hazael, the cruel king of Syria, advances right up to Jerusalem. Jehoash buys his freedom with the treasures of the temple.

That is bitter: the king who has just repaired the temple must now strip it, in order to save Jerusalem.

Gath was a city of the Philistines.

The end of Joash VERSES 19–21

19 The rest of the things Joash did, and all that he did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Judah?
20 His servants rose up and made a plot.
They struck down Joash at the house of Millo, on the road that goes down to Silla.
21 For Jozacar the son of Shimeath and Jehozabad the son of Shomer, his servants,
struck him, and he died.
And they buried him with his ancestors in David's city.
And his son Amaziah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joash, who was saved so wonderfully as a child, is murdered in the end by his own servants. According to 2 Chronicles 24:25 this happened as revenge for the son of Jehoiada the priest, whom Joash had had killed.

Joash's life shows: a good beginning with a good teacher is a great gift. But each person must stay faithful to God himself, even when the teacher is no longer there.

No one knows exactly where "Millo" and "Silla" were. Millo was probably a fortification in Jerusalem.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 13

Elisha's last prophecy

Jehoahaz, king of Israel VERSES 1–9

1 In the twenty-third year of Joash the son of Ahaziah, king of Judah,
Jehoahaz the son of Jehu became king over Israel in Samaria, for 17 years.
2 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He followed the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat,
the sins through which Jeroboam had made Israel sin.
He did not turn away from them.
3 The LORD's anger burned against Israel.
Again and again he handed them over to Hazael king of Syria
and to Benhadad the son of Hazael.
4 Jehoahaz begged the LORD,
and the LORD listened to him,
because he saw how Israel was oppressed,
how the king of Syria oppressed them.
To oppress means: to treat people harshly and keep them down.

5 (The LORD gave Israel a savior,
so that they got out from under the power of the Syrians.
And the people of Israel lived in their tents as before.
6 But they did not turn away from the sins of the house of Jeroboam,
the sins through which he had made Israel sin,
but they kept living in them.
And the Asherah also remained in Samaria.)
An Asherah was a wooden pole or image of a goddess.
7 For the king of Syria had not left Jehoahaz any more of the army
than 50 horsemen, 10 chariots, and 10,000 foot soldiers.
For the king of Syria had destroyed them
and made them like the dust at threshing time.
8 The rest of the things Jehoahaz did,
all that he did, and his power,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel?
9 Jehoahaz died and joined his ancestors,
and they buried him in Samaria.
And his son Joash became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Under Jehu's son Jehoahaz, Israel is almost destroyed by Syria. Only 10 chariots are left of the army. For comparison: Ahab still had 2,000 chariots.

Jehoahaz prays in his need, and God listens to him, even though he is not a good king. God's mercy is greater than what we deserve.

The text does not say who the "savior" was. Perhaps it means the later King Jeroboam II. Or the Assyrian king, who attacked Syria and so gave Israel room to breathe.

Verses 5–6 are in parentheses: they are an insertion in the middle of the report.

Jehoahaz ruled from about 814 to 798 BC.

Jehoash, king of Israel VERSES 10–13

10 In the thirty-seventh year of Joash king of Judah,
Jehoash the son of Jehoahaz became king over Israel in Samaria, for 16 years.
11 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He did not turn away from all the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat,
the sins through which Jeroboam had made Israel sin,
but he lived in them.
12 The rest of the things Joash did,
all that he did, and his power with which he fought against Amaziah king of Judah,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel?
13 Joash died and joined his ancestors,
and Jeroboam sat on his throne.
Joash was buried in Samaria with the kings of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again the names are confusing: at the same time, the king of Judah was called Joash, and so was the king of Israel. Both are sometimes also called "Jehoash".

Here the end of Joash is already told. After that the text goes back once more and tells a story from his time.

Joash of Israel ruled from about 798 to 782 BC.

The arrows of victory VERSES 14–19

14 Elisha became sick with the sickness from which he was going to die.
Joash the king of Israel came down to him.
He wept over him and said,
"My father, my father,
the chariots of Israel and its horsemen!"
15 Elisha said to him,
"Take a bow and arrows."
And he took a bow and arrows for himself.
16 He said to the king of Israel,
"Put your hand on the bow."
And he put his hand on it.
Elisha laid his hands on the king's hands.
17 He said,
"Open the window toward the east."
And he opened it.
Then Elisha said,
"Shoot!"
And he shot.
He said,
"The LORD's arrow of victory,
the arrow of victory over Syria!
For you will strike the Syrians at Aphek until you have destroyed them."
18 He said,
"Take the arrows."
And he took them.
He said to the king of Israel,
"Strike the ground."
He struck three times and stopped.
19 The man of God was angry with him and said,
"You should have struck five or six times.
Then you would have struck Syria until you had destroyed it.
But now you will strike Syria only three times."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elisha is old and dying. The king weeps and says the same words that Elisha once cried out when Elijah was taken from him (2 Kings 2:12). Elisha was Israel's true strength.

Elisha's last prophecy is an action that is a sign. He lays his hands on the king's hands: victory comes from God, not from one's own strength.

The arrow flies toward the east, in the direction of Syria.

Then the king is to strike the ground with the arrows. But he strikes only three times, half-heartedly. Elisha is disappointed. The lesson: whoever trusts only timidly also receives only a part. God invites us to believe and to act with our whole heart.

Elisha's death and his bones VERSES 20–21

20 Elisha died, and they buried him.
Raiding groups of Moabites would come into the land when the year began.
21 Once, as people were burying a man,
suddenly they saw a raiding group.
So they threw the man into Elisha's tomb.
As soon as the man touched Elisha's bones,
he came back to life and stood up on his feet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elisha dies. Unlike Elijah, he is not taken up into heaven. He dies like all people.

But even after his death another miracle happens: a dead man who is thrown into his tomb comes back to life. God's power works beyond death.

The miracle does not come from the bones themselves. It is a sign that God is the Lord over life and death.

"When the year began" means: in spring, when military campaigns and raids began.

Later this passage was often used to defend honoring relics, that is, the remains of holy people. Christians of different churches see this differently.

God has mercy on Israel VERSES 22–25

22 Hazael king of Syria oppressed Israel all the days of
Jehoahaz.
23 But the LORD was gracious to them.
He had compassion on them and turned toward them,
because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and
Jacob.
He would not destroy them,
and up to that time he did not throw them away from
his presence.
24 Hazael king of Syria died,
and his son Benhadad became king in his place.
25 Jehoash the son of Jehoahaz took back from Benhadad
the son of Hazael
the cities that Benhadad had taken from his father
Jehoahaz in war.
Joash struck him three times
and won back the cities of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23 is a great word of hope: God remembers his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Even when the people are unfaithful, God stays faithful.

"Up to that time" is a quiet, sad hint: about 60 years later the northern kingdom will come to an end after all.

Elisha's word comes true exactly: Joash wins against Syria three times, not more.

2 KINGS

Chapter 14

Amaziah of Judah and Jeroboam II of Israel

Amaziah, king of Judah VERSES 1–7

1 In the second year of Joash the son of Joahaz, king of
Israel,
Amaziah the son of Joash king of Judah began to rule.
2 He was 25 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for 29 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Jehoaddin, from Jerusalem.
3 He did what was right in the LORD's eyes,
but not like his ancestor David.
He did everything just as his father Joash had done.
4 But the high places were not taken away.
The people still offered sacrifices and burned incense
on the high places.
5 As soon as the kingdom was firmly in his hand,
he killed his servants who had killed his father the
king.
6 But he did not put the children of the murderers to
death,
as it is written in the book of the law of Moses,
where the LORD commanded,
"The fathers shall not be put to death for the children,
and the children shall not be put to death for the
fathers.
But every man shall die for his own sin."
7 He killed 10,000 Edomites in the Valley of Salt.
He captured Sela in war
and called it Joktheel, and that is its name to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amaziah is a fairly good king, but not as faithful as David.

Verse 6 is remarkable: in those days it was common to kill the family of a criminal too, so that no one would take revenge. Amaziah keeps God's law (Deuteronomy 24:16): each person is responsible only for his own guilt. That was a big step forward for justice. Today too this is a basic rule of our law: a family is not punished for the crime of one of its members.

The Valley of Salt probably lies south of the Dead Sea. Sela means "rock". It is not certain exactly where it was.

The thistle and the cedar VERSES 8–14

8 Then Amaziah sent messengers to Jehoash the son of
Jehoahaz, the son of Jehu, king of Israel.
He said,
"Come, let's look each other in the face."
9 Jehoash the king of Israel sent a message to Amaziah
king of Judah:
"The thistle in Lebanon sent a message to the cedar in
Lebanon:
'Give your daughter to my son as his wife.'
Then a wild animal in Lebanon passed by
and trampled the thistle.
10 You have indeed struck Edom,
and your heart has become proud.
Enjoy your glory and stay at home.
Why should you go looking for trouble,
so that you fall, you and Judah with you?"
11 But Amaziah would not listen.
So Jehoash king of Israel went up.
He and Amaziah king of Judah looked each other in
the face
at Beth Shemesh, which belongs to Judah.
12 Judah was defeated by Israel,
and every man fled to his tent.
13 Jehoash king of Israel captured Amaziah king of
Judah,
the son of Jehoash, the son of Ahaziah, at Beth
Shemesh.
Then he came to Jerusalem

and broke down the wall of Jerusalem
from the Gate of Ephraim to the Corner Gate, about
600 feet.
14 He took all the gold and silver
and all the objects that were found in the LORD's
house
and in the treasuries of the king's house,
and hostages too,
and went back to Samaria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After his victory over Edom, Amaziah has become overconfident. He challenges the king of Israel to battle. "Let's look each other in the face" means: let's fight.

Jehoash answers with a fable: a small thistle wants to be equal with the great cedar, and it gets trampled. He means: you think too highly of yourself.

"Pride goes before destruction" (Proverbs 16:18). Amaziah does not listen and loses everything.

For the first time Jerusalem is conquered by a king from Israel. A war between brothers.

The Bible says "400 cubits." A cubit is about 18 inches.

The death of Jehoash and the end of Amaziah
VERSES 15–22

15 The rest of the things Jehoash did, and his power,
and how he fought against Amaziah king of Judah,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Israel?
16 Jehoash died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried in Samaria with the kings of Israel.
And his son Jeroboam became king in his place.
17 Amaziah the son of Joash, king of Judah,
lived for 15 years after the death of Jehoash the son of
Jehoahaz, king of Israel.
18 The rest of the things Amaziah did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Judah?
19 People made a plot against him in Jerusalem.
He fled to Lachish.
But they sent men after him to Lachish and killed him
there.
20 They brought him back on horses,
and he was buried in Jerusalem with his ancestors in
David's city.
21 All the people of Judah took Azariah, who was 16 years
old,
and made him king in the place of his father Amaziah.
22 He built up Elath and gave it back to Judah.
After that the king died and joined his ancestors.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amaziah is murdered too, just like his father Joash. Lachish was a large fortress city in the southwest of Judah.

Azariah becomes king at the age of 16. He is also called Uzziah (2 Kings 15:13). Elath lies on the Red Sea, on the Gulf of Aqaba. With this, Judah has a harbor again.

"The king died and joined his ancestors": this probably means Amaziah. Azariah built up Elath after his father's death.

Amaziah ruled from about 796 to 767 BC.

Jeroboam II, king of Israel
VERSES 23–29

23 In the fifteenth year of Amaziah the son of Joash, king
of Judah,
Jeroboam the son of Joash king of Israel became king
in Samaria, for 41 years.
24 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He did not turn away from all the sins of Jeroboam the
son of Nebat,
the sins through which that Jeroboam had made
Israel sin.
25 He won back the border of Israel,
from the entrance of Hamath to the sea of the Arabah,
just as the LORD, the God of Israel, had said
through his servant Jonah the son of Amittai, the
prophet, who was from Gath Hepher.
26 For the LORD saw the suffering of Israel,
that it was very bitter for everyone, slave and free,
and that there was no one to help Israel.
27 The LORD had not said that he would wipe out the
name of Israel from under the sky.
So he saved them through Jeroboam the son of Joash.
28 The rest of the things Jeroboam did,
all that he did, and his power, how he fought,
and how he won back for Israel Damascus and
Hamath, which had belonged to Judah,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Israel?
29 Jeroboam died and joined his ancestors, the kings of
Israel.
And his son Zechariah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeroboam II is one of the most successful kings of the northern kingdom. He rules for a very long time and wins back a lot of land. Israel is great again, almost as in the time of Solomon.

Even so, the Bible's judgment is short: "He did what was evil." Success and wealth are no sign that someone is faithful to God.

The prophet Jonah is mentioned here. He is the same Jonah that the book of Jonah tells about. Gath Hepher lay in Galilee, near the later town of Nazareth.

The prophets Amos and Hosea also worked in this time. They sharply criticized that the rich lived in luxury while the poor were oppressed (Amos 6:4–6).

Verses 26–27 show God's mercy: he saw the need and helped, even though the king was not faithful to him.

"The sea of the Arabah" is the Dead Sea. "The entrance of Hamath" is also called Lebo Hamath. It means the far north.

Verse 28 is hard to understand: Damascus and Hamath had once belonged to the kingdom of David and Solomon. That is probably why it says "which had belonged to Judah" here.

Jeroboam II ruled from about 793 to 753 BC. The years overlap with those of his father, because he probably ruled together with him for some years.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 15

Kings in quick succession

Azariah (Uzziah), king of Judah VERSES 1–7

1 In the twenty-seventh year of Jeroboam king of Israel,
Azariah the son of Amaziah, king of Judah, began to rule.
2 He was 16 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for 52 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Jecoliah, from Jerusalem.
3 He did what was right in the LORD's eyes,
just as his father Amaziah had done.
4 But the high places were not taken away.
The people still offered sacrifices and burned incense on the high places.
5 The LORD struck the king,
so that he was a leper until the day of his death.
He lived in a separate house.
Jotham, the king's son, was in charge of the palace
and judged the people of the land.
6 The rest of the things Azariah did, and all that he did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Judah?
7 Azariah died and joined his ancestors,
and they buried him with his ancestors in David's city.
And his son Jotham became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Azariah is also called Uzziah. He ruled for a very long time and with success. 2 Chronicles 26 tells more about him: he became powerful, but then proud. He wanted to burn incense in the temple himself, which only priests were allowed to do. After that he became a leper.

Because he was a leper, he had to live apart. His son Jotham ruled for him.

In the year that King Uzziah died, the prophet Isaiah had his great vision in the temple, in which God called him (Isaiah 6:1).

In Jerusalem a stone tablet was found that was made much later. It says in Aramaic that the bones of Uzziah, king of Judah, were brought here. Today it is in the Israel Museum.

Azariah (Uzziah) ruled from about 792 to 740 BC, partly together with his father and his son.

Zechariah and Shallum, kings of Israel VERSES 8–16

8 In the thirty-eighth year of Azariah king of Judah,
Zechariah the son of Jeroboam ruled over Israel in Samaria for six months.
9 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes, as his ancestors had done.
He did not turn away from the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat,
the sins through which that Jeroboam had made Israel sin.
10 Shallum the son of Jabesh plotted against him.
He struck him in front of the people and killed him,
and he became king in his place.
11 The rest of the things Zechariah did,
they are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.
12 This was the LORD's word that he spoke to Jehu:
"Your sons down to the fourth generation will sit on the throne of Israel."
And so it happened.
13 Shallum the son of Jabesh became king in the thirty-ninth year of Uzziah king of Judah.
He ruled for one month in Samaria.
14 Then Menahem the son of Gadi went up from Tirzah.
He came to Samaria,
struck Shallum the son of Jabesh in Samaria,
killed him, and became king in his place.
15 The rest of the things Shallum did, and the plot that he made,
they are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Israel.
16 Then Menahem attacked Tiphsah
and all who were in it and the land around it, starting from Tirzah.
He attacked it because they did not open their gates to him.
And he ripped open all their women who were pregnant.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Zechariah, Jehu's family comes to an end after four generations, just as God had said.

After that, chaos begins in the northern kingdom: Zechariah rules for six months, Shallum for only one month. Each one is murdered by the one who comes after him. In this time the prophet Hosea laments: "They have set up kings, but not by my choice" (Hosea 8:4).

Menahem commits a horrible war crime against a city that did not want to surrender to him. The Bible names it without making it sound better. Such cruelty against defenseless people, especially against women and unborn children, can never be justified.

It is not certain where Tiphsah lay. Some old translations have "Tappuah" here, a city in Israel.

Menahem and the Assyrians VERSES 17–22

17 In the thirty-ninth year of Azariah king of Judah,
Menahem the son of Gadi became king over Israel, for 10 years in Samaria.
18 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
All his life he did not turn away from the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat,
the sins through which that Jeroboam had made Israel sin.
19 Pul the king of Assyria came against the land.
Menahem gave Pul 1,000 talents of silver (about 75,000 pounds),
so that Pul would help him make the kingdom firm in his hand.
20 Menahem forced Israel to pay the money,
all the wealthy and powerful men,
50 shekels of silver (about 20 ounces) from each man,
to give it to the king of Assyria.
So the king of Assyria turned back
and did not stay there in the land.

21 The rest of the things Menahem did, and all that he did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Israel?
22 Menahem died and joined his ancestors,
and his son Pekahiah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now a new great power appears: Assyria, in the area of today's Iraq. The Assyrians were feared for their cruelty.

"Pul" is another name for Tiglath Pileser III, who ruled from 745 to 727 BC. He is known from many Assyrian inscriptions. They also mention that "Menahem of Samaria" paid him tribute.

The Bible says "1,000 talents of silver" (a talent is about 75 pounds) and "50 shekels" for each man (a shekel is about 0.4 ounces). If you do the math, about 60,000 wealthy men had to pay.

Menahem buys himself protection. With this, Israel becomes dependent on Assyria.

Pekahiah and Pekah, kings of Israel VERSES 23–31

23 In the fiftieth year of Azariah king of Judah,
Pekahiah the son of Menahem became king over Israel
in Samaria, for two years.
24 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He did not turn away from the sins of Jeroboam the
son of Nebat,
the sins through which that Jeroboam had made
Israel sin.
25 Pekah the son of Remaliah, his officer, plotted against
him.
He attacked him in Samaria, in the fortress of the
king's house,
together with Argob and Arieh.
With him were 50 men of the Gileadites.
He killed him and became king in his place.
26 The rest of the things Pekahiah did, and all that he did,
they are written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Israel.
27 In the fifty-second year of Azariah king of Judah,
Pekah the son of Remaliah became king over Israel in
Samaria, for 20 years.
28 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He did not turn away from the sins of Jeroboam the
son of Nebat,
the sins through which that Jeroboam had made
Israel sin.
29 In the days of Pekah king of Israel,
Tiglath Pileser king of Assyria came.
He captured Ijon, Abel Beth Maacah, Janoah, Kedesh,
Hazor, Gilead, and Galilee,
all the land of Naphtali,
and he carried the people away captive to Assyria.
30 Hoshea the son of Elah made a plot against Pekah the
son of Remaliah.
He attacked him, killed him, and became king in his
place,
in the twentieth year of Jotham the son of Uzziah.
31 The rest of the things Pekah did, and all that he did,
they are written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One murder of a king follows the next.

Under Pekah the Assyrians conquer the whole north of Israel, Galilee, and the land east of the Jordan. For the first time many Israelites are carried away to Assyria. That was about 733/732 BC.

The northern kingdom gets smaller and smaller. Almost only the area around the capital city Samaria is left.

In this time the prophet Isaiah speaks of "the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali": "The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light" (Isaiah 9:1–2). Matthew applies this word to Jesus, who began his work in Galilee (Matthew 4:13–16).

Pekah's 20 years are hard to fit in. Perhaps he had already ruled earlier in the east of the land, alongside other kings.

Hoshea is also mentioned in Assyrian inscriptions. There Tiglath Pileser claims that he made Hoshea king.

Jotham, king of Judah VERSES 32–38

32 In the second year of Pekah the son of Remaliah, king
of Israel,
Jotham the son of Uzziah, king of Judah, began to
rule.
33 He was 25 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for 16 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Jerusha, the daughter of
Zadok.
34 He did what was right in the LORD's eyes.
He did just as his father Uzziah had done.
35 But the high places were not taken away.
The people still offered sacrifices and burned incense
on the high places.
He built the upper gate of the LORD's house.
36 The rest of the things Jotham did, and all that he did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Judah?
37 In those days the LORD began
to send Rezin the king of Syria and Pekah the son of
Remaliah against Judah.
38 Jotham died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried with his ancestors in the city of his
ancestor David.
And his son Ahaz became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jotham was a good king, like his father Uzziah.

Syria and Israel join together against Judah. They want to force Judah to fight with them against Assyria. That is told in the next chapter.

Compared with the northern kingdom, Judah is more stable: there the sons follow their fathers, from David's family. In the north, on the other hand, there were six kings in only about 20 years, and four of them were murdered.

Jotham ruled from about 750 to 735 BC, at first for his sick father.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 16

King Ahaz and the foreign altar

Ahaz, an evil king in Judah VERSES 1–4

1 In the seventeenth year of Pekah the son of Remaliah,
Ahaz the son of Jotham, king of Judah, began to rule.
2 Ahaz was 20 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for 16 years in Jerusalem.
He did not do what was right in the eyes of the LORD his God,
as his ancestor David had done.
3 But he walked in the way of the kings of Israel.
He even made his son pass through the fire,
following the disgusting practices of the nations
whom the LORD had driven out from before the people of Israel.
4 He offered sacrifices and burned incense on the high places,
on the hills, and under every green tree.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahaz is one of the worst kings of Judah.

"Made his son pass through the fire" very probably means: he burned his child as a sacrifice to a foreign god. That is a horrible crime. God's law clearly forbids it (Leviticus 18:21; Deuteronomy 18:10). God does not want human sacrifices. Already with Abraham and Isaac he showed: no child is to be sacrificed (Genesis 22).

Ahaz ruled from about 735 to 715 BC.

Ahaz calls the Assyrians for help VERSES 5–9

5 Then Rezin king of Syria and Pekah the son of Remaliah, king of Israel,
came up to Jerusalem to make war.
They laid siege to Ahaz, but they could not defeat him.
6 At that time Rezin king of Syria won Elath back for Syria
and drove the Jews out of Elath.
And the Syrians came to Elath, and they live there to this day.
7 So Ahaz sent messengers to Tiglath Pileser king of Assyria with this message:
"I am your servant and your son.
Come up and save me from the power of the king of Syria
and from the power of the king of Israel,
who are rising up against me."
8 Ahaz took the silver and gold that was found in the LORD's house
and in the treasuries of the king's house,
and he sent it as a gift to the king of Assyria.
9 The king of Assyria listened to him.
The king of Assyria went up against Damascus and captured it.
He carried its people away captive to Kir,
and he killed Rezin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Syria and Israel want to force Judah to fight with them against Assyria. They lay siege to Jerusalem.

In this time of need the prophet Isaiah said to Ahaz: "Be careful, and stay calm! Don't be afraid" (Isaiah 7:4). And he gave him the famous sign: "Look, the virgin will become pregnant and give birth to a son, and she will call him Immanuel" (Isaiah 7:14). Immanuel means: God with us. Later, Christians apply this word to Jesus (Matthew 1:23).

But Ahaz does not trust in God. Instead he buys the help of the Assyrians. He calls himself their "servant and son". With this he makes Judah dependent on cruel Assyria.

In 732 BC the Assyrians conquer Damascus. The kingdom of the Arameans comes to an end.

In verse 6 some Hebrew manuscripts have "Edom" instead of "Aram" (Syria). In Hebrew the two words look almost the same. Many scholars think that the Edomites were meant originally.

The new altar VERSES 10–18

10 King Ahaz went to Damascus to meet Tiglath Pileser king of Assyria.
There he saw the altar that was in Damascus.
And King Ahaz sent Urijah the priest a drawing of the altar
and plans for building it.
11 Urijah the priest built an altar.
He made it exactly according to everything King Ahaz had sent from Damascus.
Urijah the priest finished it before King Ahaz came back from Damascus.
12 When the king came back from Damascus, the king saw the altar.
The king went up to the altar and offered sacrifices on it.
13 He burned his burnt offering and his grain offering,
poured out his drink offering,
and sprinkled the blood of his peace offerings on the altar.
14 He moved the bronze altar, which stood before the LORD,
away from the front of the house,
from between his altar and the LORD's house,
and put it on the north side of his own altar.
15 King Ahaz commanded Urijah the priest,
"On the great altar burn
the morning burnt offering and the evening grain offering,
the king's burnt offering and his grain offering,
with the burnt offering of all the people of the land,
their grain offering, and their drink offerings.
And sprinkle on it all the blood of the burnt offering
and all the blood of the sacrifice.
But I will use the bronze altar to ask God for guidance."
16 Urijah the priest did everything just as King Ahaz commanded.
17 King Ahaz cut off the side panels of the stands
and took the basins off them.
He took down the Sea from the bronze oxen that were under it
and put it on a stone pavement.
The Sea was a very large bronze basin for water.
18 He removed from the LORD's house the covered walkway for the Sabbath

that they had built in the house,
and the king's outer entrance,
because of the king of Assyria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Damascus Ahaz has to bow down to the Assyrian king. There he sees an altar and wants to have a copy of it built in Jerusalem.

Solomon's altar is pushed aside. The new, foreign altar becomes the main altar. That shows: Ahaz shapes the worship of God to please the powerful. Instead of putting God in the center, he puts the great power in the center.

Urijah the priest goes along with everything without saying a word against it.

Ahaz also takes bronze off the temple objects, probably to pay the tribute to Assyria.

No one knows for sure what the "covered walkway for the Sabbath" was. Ahaz probably removed royal signs at the temple so as not to anger the Assyrian king.

Ahaz dies VERSES 19–20

19 The rest of the things Ahaz did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Judah?
20 Ahaz died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried with his ancestors in David's city.
And his son Hezekiah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One of the worst kings is followed by one of the best: Hezekiah. A son does not have to go the way of his father.

A seal impression with the name "Ahaz, son of Jotham, king of Judah" is known. It comes from the antiquities trade, so where it really comes from is not certain.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 17

The end of the northern kingdom of Israel

Hoshea, the last king of Israel VERSES 1–6

1 In the twelfth year of Ahaz king of Judah,
Hoshea the son of Elah became king in Samaria over Israel, for nine years.
2 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
but not like the kings of Israel who were before him.
3 Shalmaneser king of Assyria came up against him.
Hoshea became his servant and paid him tribute.
Tribute is money or goods that a weaker king must pay to a stronger king.
4 But the king of Assyria discovered a plot by Hoshea.
For Hoshea had sent messengers to So king of Egypt,
and he no longer paid tribute to the king of Assyria, as he had done year by year.
So the king of Assyria seized him
and put him in chains in prison.
5 Then the king of Assyria came up through the whole land.
He went up to Samaria
and laid siege to it for three years.
6 In the ninth year of Hoshea the king of Assyria captured Samaria
and carried Israel away to Assyria.
He settled them in Halah, on the Habor, the river of Gozan,
and in the cities of the Medes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hoshea tries to free himself from Assyria with the help of Egypt. But Egypt does not help. Assyria attacks.

After a siege of three years Samaria falls, about 722 BC. The northern kingdom of Israel comes to an end. It had lasted about 200 years.

The Assyrian king Sargon II, who came after Shalmaneser, boasts in his inscriptions that he carried away more than 27,000 people from Samaria.

Halah, Habor, and Gozan lay in the north of Mesopotamia, in the area of today's border between Syria and Turkey. The Medes lived in today's Iran.

It is not certain who "So king of Egypt" was. At that time Egypt had broken apart into several small kingdoms.

Hoshea ruled from about 732 to 722 BC.

Why did this happen? VERSES 7–23

7 This happened because the people of Israel had sinned against the LORD their God,
who had brought them up out of the land of Egypt,
out from under the power of Pharaoh king of Egypt.
They had worshiped other gods.
8 They had lived by the customs of the nations
whom the LORD had driven out from before the people of Israel,
and by the customs that the kings of Israel had made.
9 The people of Israel secretly did things against the LORD their God that were not right.
They built high places for themselves in all their cities,
from the watchtower to the walled city.
10 They set up stone pillars and Asherah poles for themselves
on every high hill and under every green tree.
11 There they burned incense on all the high places,
as the nations had done whom the LORD carried away before them.
And they did wicked things to make the LORD angry.
12 They served idols,
about which the LORD had said to them,
"You shall not do this."
13 Yet the LORD had warned Israel and Judah
through every prophet and every seer:
"Turn from your evil ways,
and keep my commandments and my laws,
following the whole law that I commanded your ancestors
and that I sent to you through my servants the prophets."

14 But they would not listen.
They made their necks stiff, like the necks of their ancestors,
who did not believe in the LORD their God.
15 They rejected his laws and his covenant that he had made with their ancestors,
and his warnings that he had given them.
They followed worthless things and became worthless themselves.
They followed the nations around them,
although the LORD had commanded them not to do as they did.
16 They left all the commandments of the LORD their God.
They made metal images for themselves, two calves,
and they made an Asherah pole.
They worshiped all the stars of the sky
and served Baal.
17 They made their sons and their daughters pass through the fire.
They practiced fortune-telling and magic.
And they sold themselves to do what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
to make him angry.
18 So the LORD was very angry with Israel
and removed them from his sight.
No one was left except the tribe of Judah alone.
19 Judah also did not keep the commandments of the LORD their God,
but lived by the customs that Israel had made.
20 The LORD rejected all the descendants of Israel.
He made them suffer and handed them over to raiders,
until he had thrown them out of his sight.
21 For he had torn Israel away from David's house.
And they made Jeroboam the son of Nebat king.
And Jeroboam drove Israel away from following the LORD
and made them commit a great sin.
22 The people of Israel lived in all the sins that Jeroboam had committed.
They did not turn away from them,
23 until the LORD removed Israel from his sight,
as he had said through all his servants the prophets.
So Israel was carried away from its own land to Assyria, and it is still there to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important passages in the books of Kings. The text stops and asks: why did the northern kingdom come to an end?

The answer is: not because God was too weak. Not because Assyria was so strong. But because the people left God again and again, even though God warned them through many prophets: through Elijah, Elisha, Amos, Hosea, and many others.

God was patient for a long time, about 200 years. Again and again he called: "Turn from your evil ways!" But they would not listen.

"They followed worthless things and became worthless themselves": whoever runs after empty things becomes empty himself. You become like what you worship.

Verse 19 is already a warning to Judah: you too are in danger.

This explanation is a way of understanding history through faith. It wants to call the people of that time to turn back to God. It does not say that every misfortune in a person's life is a punishment from God. Jesus clearly rejected that idea (John 9:2–3; Luke 13:1–5).

What became of the ten tribes? Many were scattered and became part of other peoples. Some fled to Judah and lived on there. The question of the "lost ten tribes" has kept people busy until today.

Foreign peoples in Samaria VERSES 24–33

24 The king of Assyria brought people from Babylon, from Cuthah, from Avva, from Hamath, and from Sepharvaim.
He settled them in the cities of Samaria in place of the people of Israel.
They took Samaria for their own and lived in its cities.
25 When they first began to live there, they did not fear the LORD.
So the LORD sent lions among them,
which killed some of them.
26 So people said to the king of Assyria,
"The nations that you carried away and settled in the cities of Samaria
do not know the law of the god of the land.
That is why he has sent lions among them.
And look, the lions are killing them,
because they do not know the law of the god of the land."
27 Then the king of Assyria commanded,
"Take there one of the priests whom you brought from there.
Let him go and live there
and teach them the law of the god of the land."
28 So one of the priests whom they had carried away from Samaria came
and lived in Bethel.
And he taught them how they should fear the LORD.
29 But every nation made gods of its own.
They put them in the houses of the high places that the Samaritans had made,
every nation in the cities where it lived.
30 The men of Babylon made Succoth Benoth.
The men of Cuth made Nergal.
The men of Hamath made Ashima.
31 And the Avvites made Nibhaz and Tartak.
And the Sepharvites burned their children in the fire to Adrammelech and Anammelech,
the gods of Sepharvaim.
32 So they feared the LORD.
But they also made priests of the high places from among their own people,
who offered sacrifices for them in the houses of the high places.
33 They feared the LORD,
and they also served their own gods,
following the customs of the nations from which they had been carried away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Assyrians had a cruel method: they carried away conquered peoples and settled foreign peoples in their land. In this way no revolts were supposed to start.

The new settlers bring their own gods with them. They worship the LORD in addition, as one god among many. A mixed religion comes about.

The lions became more numerous because the land was ruined and empty after the war. The people understood this as a sign from the god of the land.

In the Jewish view, the Samaritans later came from this population. But the Samaritans see themselves as descendants of the Israelites who stayed in the land, especially of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh. They still exist today, a small community near Nablus and in Holon in Israel.

Jews and Samaritans were enemies for a long time. Jesus broke through this hostility: he told the parable of the Good Samaritan (Luke 10:25–37) and spoke with the Samaritan woman at the well (John 4).

The names of the foreign gods are hardly known otherwise. Nergal was a god of the underworld from Mesopotamia.

The Sepharvites also sacrificed children. The Bible names this as the worst example of worshiping idols.

To this day VERSES 34–41

34 To this day they do what they did before.
They do not fear the LORD,
and they do not follow the laws or the rules,
the law or the commandment
that the LORD commanded the descendants of Jacob,
whom he named Israel.
35 With them the LORD had made a covenant and
commanded them,
"You shall not fear other gods.
You shall not bow down to them,
serve them, or sacrifice to them.
36 But you shall fear the LORD,
who brought you up out of the land of Egypt with
great power and with an outstretched arm.
You shall bow down to him,
and you shall sacrifice to him.
37 You shall carefully keep forever
the laws and the rules,
the law and the commandment that he wrote for you.
You shall not fear other gods.
38 You shall not forget the covenant that I have made
with you.
You shall not fear other gods.
39 But you shall fear the LORD your God.
Then he will save you from the power of all your
enemies."
40 But they did not listen.
They did what they had done before.
41 So these nations feared the LORD,
and they also served their carved images.
Their children did the same, and so did their children's
children.
They do as their ancestors did, to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The text repeats the most important commandment: "You shall not fear other gods." It appears three times here. It is the first of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:3).

Verse 33 says: "They feared the LORD." Verse 34 says: "They do not fear the LORD." This is not a contradiction. It means: they honored him a little, but not him alone and not from the heart. For the Bible, half-hearted worship of God is not true fear of God.

In the Bible, "fearing God" does not mean being afraid of God. It means: taking God seriously, honoring him, and trusting him.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 18

Hezekiah and the threat from Assyria

Hezekiah, a king who trusts God VERSES 1–8

1 In the third year of Hoshea the son of Elah, king of
Israel,
Hezekiah the son of Ahaz, king of Judah, began to
rule.
2 He was 25 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for 29 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Abi, the daughter of
Zechariah.
3 He did what was right in the LORD's eyes,
just as his ancestor David had done.
4 He removed the high places,
broke the stone pillars,
and cut down the Asherah pole.
He also broke to pieces the bronze snake that Moses
had made,
because up to that time the people of Israel burned
incense to it.
He called it Nehushtan.
5 He trusted in the LORD, the God of Israel.
After him there was no one like him among all the
kings of Judah,
nor among those who were before him.
6 For he held on to the LORD.
He did not turn away from following him,
but kept his commandments, which the LORD had
commanded Moses.
7 And the LORD was with him.
Wherever he went, he had success.
He rebelled against the king of Assyria and did not
serve him.
8 He struck the Philistines as far as Gaza and its territory,
from the watchtower to the walled city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At last a king like David again! Hezekiah is one of the best kings of Judah. What is special about him: "He trusted in the LORD."

He is the first king to get rid of the high places. From now on God is to be worshiped only in the temple in Jerusalem, as Deuteronomy 12 says.

He even destroys the bronze snake that Moses had made in the wilderness (Numbers 21:8–9). Back then it was a sign of rescue. But over time it was worshiped itself, like an idol. Hezekiah shows courage: even something old and honored must go when it takes God's place.

"Nehushtan" is a play on words: it sounds like "snake" and like "bronze", so it means something like: "just a piece of bronze".

Hezekiah ruled from about 715 to 686 BC. The dates in this chapter are hard to fit together. Perhaps at first he ruled together with his father.

Samaria falls VERSES 9–12

9 In the fourth year of King Hezekiah,
which was the seventh year of Hoshea the son of Elah,
king of Israel,
Shalmaneser king of Assyria came up against Samaria
and laid siege to it.
10 At the end of three years they captured it.
In the sixth year of Hezekiah, which was the ninth
year of Hoshea king of Israel,
Samaria was captured.
11 The king of Assyria carried Israel away to Assyria.
He put them in Halah, on the Habor, the river of
Gozan,
and in the cities of the Medes,
12 because they had not obeyed the voice of the LORD
their God,
but had broken his covenant,
everything that Moses the servant of the LORD had
commanded.
They would not listen to it or do it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fall of the northern kingdom is told here once more in short. Hezekiah lived through it. Now he knows: Judah is in danger too. How will he act?

Sennacherib attacks Judah VERSES 13–16

13 In the fourteenth year of King Hezekiah,
Sennacherib king of Assyria came up against all the
walled cities of Judah
and captured them.
14 Hezekiah king of Judah sent a message to the king of
Assyria at Lachish:
"I have done wrong. Go away from me.
Whatever you put on me, I will carry."
The king of Assyria demanded from Hezekiah king of
Judah
300 talents of silver (about 22,500 pounds)
and 30 talents of gold (about 2,250 pounds).
15 Hezekiah gave him all the silver that was found in the
LORD's house
and in the treasuries of the king's house.
16 At that time Hezekiah cut off the gold from the doors of
the LORD's temple
and from the doorposts that Hezekiah king of Judah
had covered with gold,
and he gave it to the king of Assyria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the year 701 BC the Assyrian king Sennacherib attacks Judah. He conquers many cities, among them the great fortress of Lachish.

These events are also well documented outside the Bible:

– In Sennacherib's palace in Nineveh there were large stone carvings that show the conquest of Lachish. Today they are in the British Museum in London.

– On a clay prism Sennacherib boasts that he conquered 46 cities of Judah and shut Hezekiah up in Jerusalem "like a bird in a cage". He also names 30 talents of gold as tribute, exactly as the Bible does. For the silver he gives a higher number (800 talents).

– In Lachish archaeologists have found the siege ramp of the Assyrians.

Hezekiah gives in and pays a huge tribute. He even has to take the gold off the temple doors.

The Bible says "300 talents of silver" and "30 talents of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds.

Rabshakeh mocks Jerusalem VERSES 17–25

17 The king of Assyria sent Tartan, Rabsaris, and
Rabshakeh
with a great army from Lachish to King Hezekiah at
Jerusalem.
They went up and came to Jerusalem.
When they had come up, they came
and stood by the water channel of the upper pool,
which is on the highway to the field where cloth is
washed.
18 When they called for the king,
Eliakim the son of Hilkiah, who was in charge of the
palace,
Shebnah the scribe,
and Joah the son of Asaph, the recorder, came out to
them.
19 Rabshakeh said to them,
"Now tell Hezekiah,
'The great king, the king of Assyria, says:
"What is this confidence that you are trusting in?
20 You say (but they are only empty words),
'There is wise planning and strength for war.'
Now whom are you trusting in, that you have rebelled
against me?
21 Look, now you are trusting in the staff of this broken
reed, Egypt.
If a man leans on it,
it will go into his hand and pierce it.
That is what Pharaoh king of Egypt is like for all who
trust in him.
22 But if you tell me,
'We trust in the LORD our God,'
isn't he the one whose high places and altars Hezekiah
has taken away?
And Hezekiah has said to Judah and to Jerusalem,
'You shall worship in front of this altar in Jerusalem.'
23 So now, please make a deal with my master the king of
Assyria:
I will give you 2,000 horses,
if you are able to find riders for them on your side.
24 How then can you drive back even one captain,
one of the least of my master's servants?
And you trust in Egypt for chariots and horsemen!
25 Have I now come up against this place to destroy it
without the LORD?

The LORD said to me,
'Go up against this land and destroy it.'"'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Tartan", "Rabsaris", and "Rabshakeh" are not names, but Assyrian titles: the supreme commander, a high official of the royal court, and the chief cupbearer, an important adviser of the king.

Rabshakeh is a skillful speaker. He wants to take away the courage of the people in Jerusalem. He attacks everything they trust in:

– Egypt? A broken staff that pierces your hand.

– Your own army? You don't even have enough riders for 2,000 horses.

– God? Hezekiah has torn down his altars! (He does not understand that in this way Hezekiah was faithful to God.)

– And then the meanest claim of all: your God himself has sent me!

This is psychological warfare: he wants to plant doubts.

The "upper pool" was a water basin near Jerusalem. Years before, at exactly this place, Isaiah had met Ahaz and called him to trust in God (Isaiah 7:3). Ahaz did not trust. Will Hezekiah trust?

The speech to the people VERSES 26–37

26 Then Eliakim the son of Hilkiah, Shebnah, and Joah
said to Rabshakeh,
"Please speak to your servants in the Syrian language,
because we understand it.
Don't speak with us in the Jews' language
while the people on the wall are listening."
27 But Rabshakeh said to them,
"Has my master sent me to your master and to you to
speak these words?
Hasn't he sent me to the men who sit on the wall,
who will have to eat their own dung and drink their
own urine with you?"
28 Then Rabshakeh stood
and called out with a loud voice in the Jews' language:
"Hear the word of the great king, the king of Assyria!
29 The king says,
'Don't let Hezekiah deceive you,
because he will not be able to save you from his hand.
30 Don't let Hezekiah make you trust in the LORD
by saying,
"The LORD will surely save us,
and this city will not be handed over to the king of
Assyria."
31 Don't listen to Hezekiah.'
For the king of Assyria says,
'Make peace with me and come out to me.
Then each of you can eat from his own vine and from
his own fig tree,
and each of you can drink water from his own well,
32 until I come and take you away to a land like your own
land:
a land of grain and new wine, a land of bread and
vineyards,
a land of olive trees and of honey,
so that you may live and not die.
Don't listen to Hezekiah when he tries to persuade you
by saying,
"The LORD will save us."
33 Has any of the gods of the nations ever saved his land
from the power of the king of Assyria?
34 Where are the gods of Hamath and of Arpad?
Where are the gods of Sepharvaim, of Hena, and of
Ivvah?
Have they saved Samaria from my hand?
35 Who among all the gods of the countries has saved his
country from my hand,
that the LORD should save Jerusalem from my
hand?'"
36 But the people stayed quiet and did not answer him a
word.
For the king's command was,
"Don't answer him."
37 Then Eliakim the son of Hilkiah, who was in charge of
the palace,
came with Shebna the scribe
and Joah the son of Asaph, the recorder,
to Hezekiah with their clothes torn,
and they told him Rabshakeh's words.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The Syrian language" is Aramaic. In those days it was the language used between nations. The officials of Judah understood it, the ordinary people did not. "The Jews' language" is the Hebrew that was spoken in Judah.

But Rabshakeh wants the people to listen. He speaks in the people's language and paints a crude picture of the hunger of a siege.

Then he makes a tempting offer: surrender, and you will be fine. To be honest, he also says that afterward he will carry them away, only to a "land like your own land".

His biggest mistake: he puts the God of Israel on the same level as the gods of other peoples. In other words: none of them could save their land, so your God cannot either. With this he challenges God himself.

The people stay quiet, as the king commanded. Sometimes silence is the strongest answer to mocking.

Hamath and Arpad were cities in Syria that the Assyrians had conquered.

The story is also told in the book of Isaiah (Isaiah 36–37), almost in the same words.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 19

Hezekiah prays, and God saves Jerusalem

Hezekiah sends to Isaiah VERSES 1–7

1 When King Hezekiah heard it,
he tore his clothes,
covered himself with sackcloth,
and went into the LORD's house.

2 He sent Eliakim, who was in charge of the palace,
Shebna the scribe,
and the leaders of the priests, covered with sackcloth,
to the prophet Isaiah the son of Amoz.
3 They said to him,
"Hezekiah says,
'Today is a day of trouble, of punishment, and of shame.
For the children have come to the point of birth,
and there is no strength to give birth to them.
4 Perhaps the LORD your God will hear all the words of Rabshakeh,
whom his master the king of Assyria has sent to mock the living God.
Perhaps he will punish him for the words that the LORD your God has heard.
So pray for the remnant that is still left.'"
A remnant is the small part that is left over.
5 So the servants of King Hezekiah came to Isaiah.
6 Isaiah said to them,
"Tell your master this:
'The LORD says,
"Don't be afraid of the words that you have heard,
with which the servants of the king of Assyria have insulted me.
7 Look, I will put a spirit in him,
and he will hear news
and go back to his own land.
And I will make him fall by the sword in his own land."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hezekiah reacts quite differently from his father Ahaz: he goes into the temple and seeks God. He sends for the prophet Isaiah.

The picture of giving birth is powerful: the child is ready to be born, but the mother has no strength left. Jerusalem is in a hopeless situation.

Hezekiah says: Rabshakeh has not only mocked us, but "the living God". The gods of the other peoples were dead images. The God of Israel lives.

Isaiah's answer begins with the words: "Don't be afraid."

A threatening letter VERSES 8–13

8 So Rabshakeh went back
and found the king of Assyria fighting against Libnah,
because he had heard that the king had left Lachish.
9 Then the king heard people say about Tirhakah king of Ethiopia,
"Look, he has come out to fight against you."
So he sent messengers to Hezekiah again with this message:
10 "Tell Hezekiah king of Judah this:
'Don't let your God, whom you trust in, deceive you by saying,
Jerusalem will not be handed over to the king of Assyria.
11 Look, you have heard what the kings of Assyria have done to all lands,
how they destroyed them completely.
And will you be saved?
12 Did the gods of the nations save them, the nations that my ancestors destroyed:
Gozan, Haran, Rezeph, and the people of Eden who were in Telassar?
13 Where is the king of Hamath, the king of Arpad,
and the king of the city of Sepharvaim, of Hena, and of Ivvah?'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An Egyptian army is coming to help Judah. Tirhakah (in Egyptian, Taharqa) was a pharaoh from Cush, the land south of Egypt in today's Sudan. Here "Ethiopia" is the old name for this land.

Sennacherib has to deal with this. But he sends another letter to Jerusalem: don't imagine that your God can save you!

The places named were cities and kingdoms that the Assyrians had conquered.

Hezekiah's prayer VERSES 14–19

14 Hezekiah took the letter from the hand of the messengers and read it.
Then Hezekiah went up to the LORD's house
and spread it out before the LORD.
15 Hezekiah prayed before the LORD and said,
"LORD, the God of Israel,
you who sit on your throne above the cherubim,
you alone are God of all the kingdoms of the earth.
You have made heaven and earth.
16 Turn your ear, LORD, and hear!
Open your eyes, LORD, and see!
Hear the words of Sennacherib,
which he has sent to mock the living God.
17 It is true, LORD:
the kings of Assyria have laid waste the nations and their lands.
18 They have thrown their gods into the fire.
For they were not gods,
but the work of human hands, wood and stone.
That is why they could destroy them.
19 So now, LORD our God,
please save us from his hand,
so that all the kingdoms of the earth may know
that you, LORD, are God alone."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a wonderful example of how to pray in times of need. Hezekiah takes the threatening letter and spreads it out before God. In a very practical way he puts his problem into God's hands.

He does not begin with his fear, but with God's greatness: you alone are God. You have made heaven and earth.

He is honest: yes, the Assyrians are strong, they have defeated many peoples. But those peoples' gods were only wood and stone.

And he does not pray only for himself, but for God's honor: "so that all the kingdoms of the earth may know that you, LORD, are God alone."

"You who sit on your throne above the cherubim": this means the cherubim above the ark of the covenant in the most holy place. Cherubim are heavenly beings with wings.

God's answer through Isaiah VERSES 20–34

20 Then Isaiah the son of Amoz sent a message to
Hezekiah:
"The LORD, the God of Israel, says,
'You have prayed to me about Sennacherib king of
Assyria, and I have heard you.'
21 This is the word that the LORD has spoken about him:
'The virgin daughter of Zion despises you and laughs
at you.
The daughter of Jerusalem shakes her head at you.
22 Whom have you mocked and insulted?
Against whom have you raised your voice
and lifted up your eyes in pride?
Against the Holy One of Israel!
23 Through your messengers you have mocked the Lord
and said,
"With my many chariots
I have come up to the heights of the mountains,
to the innermost parts of Lebanon.
I will cut down its tall cedars and its finest cypress
trees.
I will go into its farthest resting place,
the forest of its fruitful land.
24 I have dug wells and drunk foreign waters.
And with the soles of my feet I will dry up all the rivers
of Egypt."
25 Haven't you heard how I did it long ago,
and planned it in ancient times?
Now I have made it happen,
so that you could turn walled cities into heaps of ruins.
26 That is why their people had little strength.
They were terrified and put to shame.
They were like the grass of the field and like green
plants,
like grass on the rooftops,
and like grain that dries up before it has grown.
27 But I know when you sit down, when you go out, and
when you come in,
and how you rage against me.
28 Because you rage against me,
and because your pride has come up to my ears,
I will put my hook in your nose
and my bridle in your lips,
and I will turn you back on the road by which you
came.'
29 "This will be the sign for you:
This year you will eat what grows by itself,
and in the second year what springs up from that.
But in the third year sow and harvest,
plant vineyards and eat their fruit.
30 The remnant of the house of Judah that has escaped
will again take root below
and bear fruit above.
31 For out of Jerusalem a remnant will go out,
and out of Mount Zion those who escape.
The zeal of the LORD will do this.
32 "So the LORD says about the king of Assyria,
'He will not come into this city
or shoot an arrow there.
He will not come against it with a shield
or build up a ramp of earth against it.
33 He will go back by the same road by which he came,
and he will not come into this city,'
says the LORD.
34 'For I will defend this city to save it,
for my own sake and for the sake of my servant
David.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers in a poem. Jerusalem is pictured as a young woman who laughs at the mighty king and shakes her head at him.

Sennacherib boasts about his deeds. But God says: without me you could not have done anything at all. I guide history. You are only a tool.

"I will put my hook in your nose and my bridle in your lips": this is how the Assyrians themselves led away their prisoners. Now the same will happen to him, like an animal that is led away.

Verse 28: A bridle is the set of straps by which a horse is led.

The sign: because of the war, the fields cannot be properly farmed for two years. But in the third year people will sow and harvest normally again. Life goes on.

The "remnant" is an important idea in Isaiah: even when much is destroyed, a remnant is left from which something new can grow, like a tree that takes root again.

The rescue VERSES 35–37

35 That night the LORD's angel went out
and struck down 185,000 men in the camp of the
Assyrians.
When people got up early in the morning,
they saw that all of them were dead bodies.
36 So Sennacherib king of Assyria left,
went home,
and stayed in Nineveh.
37 As he was worshiping in the house of his god Nisroch,
Adrammelech and Sharezer struck him down with the
sword.
They escaped into the land of Ararat.
And his son Esar Haddon became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem is saved without a single arrow being shot. God himself steps in.

No one knows exactly what happened. Many think of a deadly disease that broke out in the camp. The Greek historian Herodotus tells a similar story: in one night, mice attacked Sennacherib's army. Mice can spread diseases.

Remarkable: in his own inscriptions Sennacherib does not say that he conquered Jerusalem. He only says that he shut Hezekiah up "like a bird in a cage". An Assyrian king would surely have mentioned a conquest.

The number 185,000 is very large. As with other numbers in ancient war reports, it is hard to say how it is meant.

About 20 years later, in 681 BC, Sennacherib was murdered by one or more of his sons. Babylonian sources also report this. His son Esar Haddon became king.

Ararat is the area of today's Armenia.

The god Nisroch is not known otherwise.

Chapter 20

Hezekiah's sickness and the messengers from Babylon

Hezekiah is deathly sick and prays VERSES 1–7

1 In those days Hezekiah was sick and close to death.
The prophet Isaiah the son of Amoz came to him and said to him,
"The LORD says,
'Put your house in order, because you will die and not live.'"
2 Then he turned his face to the wall
and prayed to the LORD:
3 "Please, LORD, remember
how I have lived before you faithfully and with my whole heart,
and have done what is good in your eyes."
And Hezekiah wept bitterly.
4 Isaiah had not yet gone out into the middle part of the city
when the LORD's word came to him:
5 "Turn back and tell Hezekiah, the leader of my people,
'The LORD, the God of your ancestor David, says:
"I have heard your prayer.
I have seen your tears.
Look, I will heal you.
On the third day you will go up to the LORD's house.
6 I will add 15 years to your life.
I will save you and this city from the power of the king of Assyria.
I will defend this city for my own sake and for the sake of my servant David."'"
7 Isaiah said,
"Get a cake of figs."
They got it and laid it on the boil,
and he got well.
A boil is a painful, swollen sore on the skin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hezekiah receives terrible news: you will die. He turns to the wall to be alone with God, and he weeps.

God answers at once, even before Isaiah has gone far: "I have heard your prayer. I have seen your tears." God sees our tears. Prayer can change things.

In those days a cake of figs was a well-known remedy for boils. Here God heals through a miracle and at the same time through an ordinary remedy. Faith and medicine are not opposites.

Instead of "the middle part of the city", many Hebrew manuscripts have "the middle courtyard". Then Isaiah was still in the palace.

A prayer of Hezekiah after his healing is found in Isaiah 38:9–20.

The shadow goes back VERSES 8–11

8 Hezekiah said to Isaiah,
"What will be the sign that the LORD will heal me,
and that I will go up to the LORD's house on the third day?"
9 Isaiah said,
"This will be the sign for you from the LORD
that the LORD will do what he has said:
Should the shadow go forward 10 steps,
or go back 10 steps?"
10 Hezekiah answered,
"It is easy for the shadow to go forward 10 steps.
No, let the shadow go back 10 steps."
11 Isaiah the prophet cried out to the LORD.
And the LORD brought the shadow back 10 steps,
on the steps it had already gone down on the sundial of Ahaz.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "sundial of Ahaz" was probably a staircase on which the shadow moved on, step by step, during the day. In this way people could tell the time.

The shadow going back is a sign: God can even turn back time. He gives Hezekiah more time to live.

The Bible does not say exactly how this happened.

The messengers from Babylon VERSES 12–19

12 At that time Berodach Baladan the son of Baladan, king of Babylon,
sent letters and a gift to Hezekiah,
because he had heard that Hezekiah had been sick.
13 Hezekiah listened to them
and showed them his whole storehouse of precious things:
the silver, the gold, the spices, and the precious oil,
his armory,
and everything that was found in his treasuries.
There was nothing in his house or in all his kingdom
that Hezekiah did not show them.
14 Then Isaiah the prophet came to King Hezekiah and said to him,
"What did these men say?
Where did they come to you from?"
Hezekiah said,
"They have come from a faraway country, from Babylon."
15 He asked,
"What have they seen in your house?"
Hezekiah answered,
"They have seen everything that is in my house.
There is nothing among my treasures that I have not shown them."
16 Then Isaiah said to Hezekiah,
"Hear the LORD's word:
17 'Look, the days are coming
when everything that is in your house,
and what your ancestors have stored up until this day,
will be carried away to Babylon.
Nothing will be left,'
says the LORD.
18 'And some of your sons who will come from you,
whom you will father,
will be taken away,

and they will be eunuchs in the palace of the king of
Babylon.'"
19 Then Hezekiah said to Isaiah,
"The LORD's word that you have spoken is good."
And he said,
"Isn't it so, if there will be peace and truth in my days?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Berodach Baladan (also called Merodach Baladan) was a king of Babylon who fought against the Assyrians. He was looking for allies. He is also known from Assyrian and Babylonian sources.

Hezekiah feels flattered and proudly shows the messengers all his treasures and weapons. He looks for help from people and wants to impress them.

Isaiah announces: one day Babylon will take everything away. That happened more than 100 years later (Chapters 24–25). The prophet Daniel and his friends were also brought to the royal court in Babylon as young men (Daniel 1:3–6).

"Eunuchs" here means servants at the royal court.

Hezekiah's answer is hard to understand. Perhaps he humbly accepts the judgment. Perhaps he is also thinking a little selfishly: the main thing is that there is peace while I live. The Bible leaves this open.

The end of Hezekiah VERSES 20–21

20 The rest of the things Hezekiah did,
all his power,
and how he made the pool and the water channel
and brought water into the city,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Judah?
21 Hezekiah died and joined his ancestors,
and his son Manasseh became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hezekiah had a tunnel dug through the rock to bring the water of the Gihon spring into the city. In this way Jerusalem had water even during a siege.

This tunnel still exists today. It is about 1,750 feet long, and you can still walk through it. In 1880 an inscription was found in it that tells how two groups of workers dug from both sides and met in the middle. Today it is in a museum in Istanbul.

In 2015, during excavations in Jerusalem, a seal impression was also found with the words: "Hezekiah, son of Ahaz, king of Judah".

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 21

Manasseh and Amon

Manasseh, the worst king of Judah VERSES 1–9

1 Manasseh was 12 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for 55 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Hephzibah.
2 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
following the disgusting practices of the nations
whom the LORD had driven out before the people of
Israel.
3 For he built again the high places that his father
Hezekiah had destroyed.
He set up altars for Baal
and made an Asherah pole, as Ahab king of Israel had
done.
He worshiped all the stars of the sky and served them.
4 He built altars in the LORD's house,
about which the LORD had said,
"I will put my name in Jerusalem."
5 He built altars for all the stars of the sky
in the two courtyards of the LORD's house.
6 He made his son pass through the fire.
He practiced magic and fortune-telling,
and he dealt with people who called up the spirits of
the dead and with sorcerers.
He did much evil in the LORD's eyes, to make him
angry.
7 He put the carved image of Asherah that he had made
in the house about which the LORD had said to David
and to his son Solomon,
"In this house, and in Jerusalem,
which I have chosen out of all the tribes of Israel,
I will put my name forever.
8 And I will not make the feet of Israel wander away
anymore from the land
that I gave their ancestors,
if only they will be careful to do everything I have
commanded them,
and to follow the whole law that my servant Moses
commanded them."
9 But they did not listen.
And Manasseh led them astray to do evil,
more than the nations had done whom the LORD
destroyed before the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Manasseh is the son of the good King Hezekiah. But he undoes everything his father had built up. He rules for a very long time, 55 years, longer than any other king of Judah.

"The stars of the sky" (the WEB, our English source text, says "the army of the sky") are the stars and planets. The Assyrians worshiped them as gods. Manasseh takes over this worship, probably also to please the Assyrians. Assyrian inscriptions name "Manasseh, king of Judah" as one of the kings who had to pay tribute.

He even puts an idol in God's temple. That is the worst breaking of the covenant.

He also sacrifices his son in the fire, like his grandfather Ahaz.

Manasseh ruled from about 697 to 642 BC, at first together with his father.

God's judgment on Jerusalem VERSES 10–16

10 The LORD spoke through his servants the prophets:
11 "Manasseh king of Judah has done these disgusting things.
He has done more evil than everything the Amorites did, who were before him.
And with his idols he has also made Judah sin.
12 So the LORD, the God of Israel, says,
'Look, I will bring such disaster on Jerusalem and Judah
that both ears of everyone who hears about it will ring.
13 I will stretch over Jerusalem the measuring line of Samaria
and the plumb line of Ahab's house.
I will wipe Jerusalem clean as a man wipes a dish:
he wipes it and turns it upside down.
14 I will throw away the remnant of my inheritance
and hand them over to their enemies.
They will become prey and plunder for all their enemies,
15 because they have done what is evil in my eyes
and have made me angry,
from the day their ancestors came out of Egypt until this day.'"
16 Besides this, Manasseh shed very much innocent blood, until he had filled Jerusalem with it from one end to the other.
This was in addition to his sin through which he made Judah sin,
so that they did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now God announces that Jerusalem too will fall, like Samaria.

The pictures are strong: with a measuring line and a plumb line a builder checks whether a wall is straight. Jerusalem will be measured with the same standard as Samaria and Ahab's house. And as you wipe out a dirty dish and turn it upside down, so Jerusalem will be emptied.

Verse 13: A plumb line is a string with a weight on it, used to check whether a wall is straight.

Manasseh also had many innocent people killed. According to an old Jewish tradition, even the prophet Isaiah is said to have been killed under Manasseh. This is not in the Bible.

2 Chronicles 33:11–17 also tells that Manasseh was later taken captive to Babylon, turned back to God there, prayed to God, and was heard. Even for such an evil person there was still a way back. The "Prayer of Manasseh" is an old prayer of repentance that is printed in an appendix in some Bibles.

Manasseh's death VERSES 17–18

17 The rest of the things Manasseh did,
all that he did, and the sin that he committed,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Judah?
18 Manasseh died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried in the garden of his own house, in the garden of Uzza.
And his son Amon became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Manasseh is not buried in the royal tombs in David's city, but in the garden of his palace. No one knows who Uzza was.

Amon, king of Judah VERSES 19–26

19 Amon was 22 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for two years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Meshullemeth the daughter of Haruz, from Jotbah.
20 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
as his father Manasseh had done.
21 He walked in all the ways that his father had walked in.
He served the idols that his father had served,
and he worshiped them.
22 He left the LORD, the God of his ancestors,
and did not walk in the way of the LORD.
23 The servants of Amon plotted against him
and killed the king in his own house.
24 But the people of the land killed all those who had plotted against King Amon.
And the people of the land made his son Josiah king in his place.
25 The rest of the things Amon did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Judah?
26 He was buried in his tomb in the garden of Uzza.
And his son Josiah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amon continues on his father's way. After only two years he is murdered.

"The people of the land" were probably the free men of Judah who owned land. They punish the murderers and make sure that David's family stays on the throne.

The new king is a child of eight years: Josiah. He will become one of the best kings of Judah. 300 years before, a prophet had already named him (1 Kings 13:2).

Amon ruled from about 642 to 640 BC.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 22

The book that was found again

Josiah, a good king VERSES 1–2

1 Josiah was eight years old when he became king.
He ruled for 31 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Jedidah.
She was the daughter of Adaiah, from Bozkath.
2 Josiah did what was right in the LORD's eyes.
He lived in all the ways of his ancestor David.

He did not turn away from them, to the right or to the left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Josiah becomes king while still a child, after his father Amon is murdered. In spite of his evil father and grandfather, he becomes one of the most faithful kings.

"To the right or to the left": he stays on God's straight path, without turning aside (compare Deuteronomy 5:32).

Josiah ruled from about 640 to 609 BC. In his time the prophet Jeremiah also began his work (Jeremiah 1:2).

The repair of the temple VERSES 3–7

3 In the eighteenth year of King Josiah,
the king sent Shaphan the scribe to the LORD's house.
Shaphan was the son of Azaliah, the son of Meshullam.
The king said,
4 "Go up to Hilkiah, the high priest.
Let him count the money that people have brought into the LORD's house.
The guards at the door have collected it from the people.
5 They should give it to the men who are in charge of the work on the LORD's house.
These men should pay the workers in the LORD's house
to repair the damage to the house.
6 They should pay the carpenters, the builders, and the stonemasons.
They should also buy wood and cut stone to repair the house.
7 But do not ask them to report what they did with the money they get.
They are honest."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Josiah is now 26 years old. He has the temple repaired, which had been neglected under Manasseh and Amon. The method is the same as under King Joash (Chapter 12).

The eighteenth year of Josiah was about 622 BC.

Shaphan and his family also play an important part later: his son Ahikam protected the prophet Jeremiah (Jeremiah 26:24). In Jerusalem a seal impression with the name of Gemariah son of Shaphan was found. A Gemariah son of Shaphan is mentioned in Jeremiah 36:10.

The book of the law is found VERSES 8–13

8 Hilkiah, the high priest, said to Shaphan the scribe,
"I have found the book of the law in the LORD's house."
Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan, and Shaphan read it.
9 Shaphan the scribe went to the king.
He reported to the king,
"Your servants have emptied out the money that was in the house.
They have given it to the men who are in charge of the work on the LORD's house."
10 Then Shaphan the scribe told the king,
"Hilkiah the priest has given me a book."
And Shaphan read it to the king.
11 The king heard the words of the book of the law.
Then he tore his clothes.
12 The king gave an order to Hilkiah the priest,
Ahikam the son of Shaphan,
Achbor the son of Micaiah,
Shaphan the scribe,
and Asaiah, the king's servant.
He said,
13 "Go and ask the LORD about the words of this book that has been found.
Ask for me, for the people, and for all Judah.
The LORD is very angry with us.
His anger burns against us,
because our ancestors did not listen to the words of this book.
They did not do what is written in it for us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

During the building work a forgotten book is found: the book of the law. Under the evil kings God's word had been so neglected that people no longer knew it at all.

Which book was it? Most scholars think that it was the book of Deuteronomy, all of it or a part of it. For Josiah's reforms fit exactly with what it says there: only one place for worship, no foreign gods, the Passover feast in Jerusalem.

Josiah hears God's word and is shocked. He tears his clothes as a sign of grief and repentance. He realizes: we have lived completely wrongly.

This shows how powerfully God's word can work when people really listen to it.

The prophetess Huldah VERSES 14–20

14 So Hilkiah the priest, Ahikam, Achbor, Shaphan, and Asaiah went
to Huldah the prophetess.
She was the wife of Shallum, the son of Tikvah, the son of Harhas, the keeper of the wardrobe.
Huldah lived in Jerusalem, in the Second Quarter.
They talked with her.
15 She said to them,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, says,
'Tell the man who sent you to me:
16 "The LORD says,
'I will bring disaster on this place and on the people who live here.
Everything the king of Judah has read in the book will happen.
17 They have left me.
They have burned incense to other gods.
With everything they have made, they have made me angry.
So my anger will burn against this place,
and it will not go out.'"
18 But the king of Judah sent you to ask the LORD.
Tell him,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, says this about the words you have heard:
19 'You heard what I said against this place and against the people who live here.
I said that they would become a ruin and a curse.
Your heart was tender.
You humbled yourself before the LORD.
You tore your clothes and cried before me.
So I have heard you,'
says the LORD.

20 ‘That is why I will let you die and join your ancestors.
You will go to your grave in peace.
Your eyes will not see all the disaster
that I will bring on this place.’”’”
So the men brought this message back to the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king’s men go to a woman: to the prophetess Huldah. Even though Jeremiah and Zephaniah were also working as prophets at that time, they ask Huldah. Her word is taken seriously and is accepted as God’s word. The Bible has several prophetesses, for example Miriam (Exodus 15:20) and Deborah (Judges 4:4).

In Jerusalem, the “Huldah Gates” on the south side of the Temple Mount still remind people of her today.

Huldah’s message has two parts: the disaster on Jerusalem can no longer be stopped. But Josiah himself will not live to see it, because he humbled himself.

“Your heart was tender”: God pays attention to a heart that lets itself be moved.

“You will go to your grave in peace”: it is true that Josiah later dies in war (2 Kings 23:29). But he dies before Jerusalem is destroyed. He does not have to see its fall.

The “Second Quarter” was probably a newer part of Jerusalem that had been added under Hezekiah.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 23

Josiah’s great reform

The covenant is renewed VERSES 1–3

1 The king sent messengers,
and they gathered to him all the elders of Judah and of Jerusalem.
2 The king went up to the LORD’s house,
and with him all the men of Judah and all the people living in Jerusalem,
the priests, the prophets, and all the people, both small and great.
And he read aloud to them all the words of the book of the covenant
that had been found in the LORD’s house.
3 The king stood by the pillar
and made a covenant before the LORD:
to follow the LORD
and to keep his commandments, his testimonies, and his laws
with all his heart and all his soul,
and to carry out the words of this covenant that were written in this book.
And all the people agreed to the covenant.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Josiah does not keep the book to himself. He reads it aloud to the whole people, to everyone, small and great. God’s word is there for everyone.

Then king and people together renew the covenant with God. “With all his heart and all his soul” reminds us of the most important commandment: “You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your strength” (Deuteronomy 6:5). Jesus called it the greatest commandment (Mark 12:29–30).

The temple is cleansed VERSES 4–14

4 The king commanded Hilkiah the high priest,
the priests of the second rank, and the keepers of the doorway
to bring out of the LORD’s temple all the objects
that had been made for Baal, for the Asherah, and for all the stars of the sky.
He burned them outside Jerusalem in the fields of the Kidron
and carried their ashes to Bethel.
5 He got rid of the idol priests
whom the kings of Judah had appointed
to burn incense on the high places in the cities of Judah and in the places around Jerusalem,
and also those who burned incense to Baal, to the sun, to the moon, to the planets, and to all the stars of the sky.
6 He brought the Asherah out of the LORD’s house,
outside Jerusalem, to the Kidron Valley.
He burned it at the Kidron Valley,
ground it to dust,
and threw its dust on the graves of the common people.
7 He broke down the houses of the male shrine prostitutes that were in the LORD’s house,
where the women wove hangings for the Asherah.
8 He brought all the priests out of the cities of Judah.
He made the high places unclean where the priests had burned incense,
from Geba to Beersheba.
He broke down the high places of the gates
that were at the entrance of the gate of Joshua the governor of the city,
on the left as you go in at the city gate.
9 But the priests of the high places did not come up to the LORD’s altar in Jerusalem.
Yet they ate bread made without yeast among their brothers.
10 He made Topheth unclean, which is in the Valley of the Sons of Hinnom,
so that no one could make his son or his daughter pass through the fire to Molech anymore.
11 He took away the horses that the kings of Judah had dedicated to the sun,
at the entrance of the LORD’s house,
by the room of Nathan Melech the officer, which was in the court.
And he burned the chariots of the sun with fire.
12 The king broke down the altars on the roof of the upper room of Ahaz, which the kings of Judah had made,
and the altars that Manasseh had made in the two courtyards of the LORD’s house.

He smashed them there
and threw their dust into the Kidron Valley.
13 The king made unclean the high places that were east of Jerusalem,
on the right side of the Mount of Corruption,
which Solomon the king of Israel had built for
Ashtoreth, the disgusting idol of the Sidonians,
for Chemosh, the disgusting idol of Moab,
and for Milcom, the disgusting idol of the people of Ammon.
14 He broke the stone pillars to pieces,
cut down the Asherah poles,
and filled their places with human bones.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Josiah cleans up thoroughly. The list is long and shows how much worship of idols had piled up, even in God's own temple.

"The stars of the sky" (the WEB, our English source text, says "the army of the sky"): sun, moon, and stars were worshiped as gods. There were even horses and chariots for the sun god.

"Topheth" in the Valley of Hinnom was the place where children were sacrificed. Josiah puts an end to this. The Valley of Hinnom (in Hebrew "Ge-Hinnom") later became a picture for the place of punishment. From this came the word "Gehenna", which is used for hell in the New Testament.

Even Solomon's altars for foreign gods were still standing after about 300 years (1 Kings 11:7). The "Mount of Corruption" is a mocking name for a part of the Mount of Olives.

Human bones made a place unclean. With this, these places could never be used for worship again.

The priests of the high places in the countryside were not allowed to serve at the altar in Jerusalem. But they received a share of their brothers' gifts. They were not simply dropped.

In verse 7 our English source text speaks of male shrine prostitutes (see the explanation on 1 Kings 14:24).

Bethel and Samaria VERSES 15–20

15 He also broke down the altar at Bethel
and the high place that Jeroboam the son of Nebat had made,
who had made Israel sin.
He broke down that altar and the high place too.
He burned the high place, ground it to dust,
and burned the Asherah.
16 As Josiah turned around,
he saw the tombs that were there on the hill.
He sent men and took the bones out of the tombs.
He burned them on the altar and made it unclean,
just as the LORD's word had said,
which the man of God had announced, who had announced these things.
17 Then he asked,
"What is that monument that I see?"
The men of the city told him,
"It is the tomb of the man of God who came from Judah
and announced these things that you have done against the altar of Bethel."
18 He said,
"Leave him alone!
Let no one move his bones."
So they left his bones alone,
together with the bones of the prophet who came from Samaria.
19 Josiah also took away all the houses of the high places that were in the cities of Samaria,
which the kings of Israel had made to make the LORD angry.
He did to them everything that he had done in Bethel.
20 He killed all the priests of the high places who were there, on the altars,
and burned human bones on them.
Then he went back to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a word comes true that is about 300 years old: the unnamed man of God from Judah had announced exactly this, even with the name Josiah (1 Kings 13:2). Now it happens.

Josiah leaves the prophet's tomb untouched, and with it the tomb of the old prophet from Bethel, who had wanted to be buried next to him (1 Kings 13:31).

The northern kingdom had been destroyed for 100 years. The Assyrians had become weak. So Josiah could carry out his reform in the area of the old northern kingdom too.

Verse 20 is very hard: Josiah has the priests of the high places in the north killed. In Judah he had only removed them from their office. The Bible reports this, but it is not an example for today. Questions of faith must never be decided by violence.

A Passover like never before VERSES 21–23

21 The king commanded all the people,
"Keep the Passover to the LORD your God,
as it is written in this book of the covenant."
22 Surely no such Passover had been kept
since the days of the judges who judged Israel,
nor in all the days of the kings of Israel or of the kings of Judah.
23 But in the eighteenth year of King Josiah,
this Passover was kept to the LORD in Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Passover feast remembers the rescue from Egypt (Exodus 12). Now it is celebrated again, and together in Jerusalem, as Deuteronomy 16:1–8 says.

To this day Jews celebrate the Passover feast (Pesach) every year. Jesus too celebrated the Passover with his disciples on the evening before his death. From this came the Lord's Supper of the Christians.

No one was like Josiah VERSES 24–27

24 Josiah also got rid of the people who called up the spirits of the dead, the sorcerers,
the teraphim, the idols, and all the disgusting things that were seen in the land of Judah and in Jerusalem,
so that he might carry out the words of the law
that were written in the book
that Hilkiah the priest had found in the LORD's house.
25 Before him there was no king like him,
who turned to the LORD with all his heart, with all his soul, and with all his strength,

following all the law of Moses.
And after him no one like him arose.
26 But the LORD did not turn away from the heat of his great anger,
with which his anger burned against Judah,
because of all the things by which Manasseh had made him angry.
27 The LORD said,
"I will also remove Judah from my sight,
as I have removed Israel.
And I will throw away this city that I have chosen, Jerusalem,
and the house about which I said, 'My name will be there.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Josiah receives the highest praise in all the books of Kings. He loves God exactly as the most important commandment asks: with all his heart, with all his soul, and with all his strength.

"Teraphim" were small figures of household gods.

But then comes the sad sentence: even so, Jerusalem will fall. The guilt that had piled up over generations, especially under Manasseh, was too great. Josiah's reform came late. And after his death the people quickly went back to the old ways.

This is hard to understand. It shows: a single good person can do a lot, but he cannot undo everything that a whole people has done over a long time. The prophet Jeremiah, who lived in this time, lamented that the people had not truly turned back with their whole heart (Jeremiah 3:10).

Josiah's death VERSES 28–30

28 The rest of the things Josiah did, and all that he did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Judah?
29 In his days Pharaoh Necoh king of Egypt went up against the king of Assyria at the Euphrates River.
King Josiah went out against him.
But Pharaoh Necoh killed him at Megiddo when he saw him.
30 His servants carried him dead in a chariot from Megiddo.
They brought him to Jerusalem and buried him in his own tomb.
And the people of the land took Jehoahaz the son of Josiah,
anointed him, and made him king in his father's place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the year 609 BC the Egyptian Pharaoh Necoh II marches north. He wants to help the Assyrians, who are fighting against the Babylonians. Josiah stands in his way and is killed at Megiddo. He is only 39 years old.

The Bible does not say exactly why Josiah went out against Necoh. Perhaps he wanted to keep Assyria, the old enemy, from being rescued.

His early death was a great shock. Jeremiah wrote a lament about him (2 Chronicles 35:25).

Megiddo was an important place for battles. From it comes the name "Armageddon" (mountain of Megiddo) in Revelation 16:16.

Jehoahaz and Jehoiakim VERSES 31–37

31 Jehoahaz was 23 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for three months in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Hamutal the daughter of Jeremiah, from Libnah.
32 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
just as his ancestors had done.
33 Pharaoh Necoh put him in chains at Riblah in the land of Hamath,
so that he could not rule in Jerusalem.
And he made the land pay a tribute of 100 talents of silver (about 7,500 pounds)
and a talent of gold (about 75 pounds).
34 Pharaoh Necoh made Eliakim the son of Josiah king in the place of his father Josiah
and changed his name to Jehoiakim.
But he took Jehoahaz away,
and Jehoahaz came to Egypt and died there.
35 Jehoiakim gave the silver and the gold to Pharaoh.
But he had to tax the land to give the money as Pharaoh commanded.
He forced the people of the land to pay the silver and the gold,
from everyone according to what was set for him,
to give it to Pharaoh Necoh.
36 Jehoiakim was 25 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for 11 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Zebidah the daughter of Pedaiah, from Rumah.
37 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
just as his ancestors had done.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After Josiah's death things go downhill quickly. Judah is now dependent on Egypt. Pharaoh removes kings and puts kings in place as he likes.

He even gives the new king a new name. That shows: Judah is no longer free.

The Jeremiah in verse 31 is not the prophet Jeremiah, but another man from Libnah.

The Bible says "100 talents of silver" and "a talent of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds.

Jehoiakim was a harsh king. The prophet Jeremiah accused him because he had a splendid palace built for himself without paying the workers their wages (Jeremiah 22:13–19). Jehoiakim even burned the scroll with Jeremiah's words (Jeremiah 36).

Jehoiakim ruled from about 609 to 598 BC.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 24

Babylon comes

Jehoiakim and Nebuchadnezzar VERSES 1–7

1 In his days Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon came up.
Jehoiakim became his servant for three years.
Then he turned and rebelled against him.
2 The LORD sent bands of raiders of the Chaldeans,
bands of the Syrians,
bands of the Moabites,
and bands of the people of Ammon against him.
He sent them against Judah to destroy it,
according to the LORD's word that he had spoken
through his servants the prophets.
3 Yes, at the LORD's command this came on Judah,
to remove them from his sight,
because of the sins of Manasseh, because of all that he
had done,
4 and also because of the innocent blood that he had shed.
For he had filled Jerusalem with innocent blood,
and the LORD would not forgive.
5 The rest of the things Jehoiakim did, and all that he did,
aren't they written in the book of the chronicles of the
kings of Judah?
6 Jehoiakim died and joined his ancestors,
and his son Jehoiachin became king in his place.
7 The king of Egypt did not come out of his land
anymore.
For the king of Babylon had taken everything that
belonged to the king of Egypt,
from the Brook of Egypt to the Euphrates River.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the new world power arrives: Babylon, in the south of today's Iraq. The Babylonians are also called "Chaldeans". Their king Nebuchadnezzar II ruled from 605 to 562 BC. In 605 BC he defeated the Egyptians at Carchemish.

Jehoiakim becomes a servant of Babylon, but then he rebels. That was a big mistake. The prophet Jeremiah had warned against rebelling against Babylon.

Again the text says: the disaster is the result of guilt, especially the guilt of Manasseh. "Innocent blood" is a heavy guilt. God does not take it lightly when innocent people are killed.

"Syria" is called "Aram" in Hebrew.

Jehoiachin and the first exile VERSES 8–17

8 Jehoiachin was 18 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for three months in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Nehushta the daughter of
Elnathan, from Jerusalem.
9 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
just as his father had done.
10 At that time the servants of Nebuchadnezzar king of
Babylon came up to Jerusalem,
and the city was besieged.
11 Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon came to the city
himself
while his servants were besieging it.
12 Then Jehoiachin the king of Judah went out to the
king of Babylon,
he, his mother, his servants, his princes, and his
officers.
And the king of Babylon took him prisoner in the
eighth year of his reign.
13 He carried away from there all the treasures of the
LORD's house
and the treasures of the king's house.
And he cut in pieces all the gold objects
that Solomon king of Israel had made in the LORD's
temple,
as the LORD had said.
14 He carried away all Jerusalem:
all the princes and all the brave warriors, 10,000
captives,
and also all the craftsmen and the smiths.
No one was left except the poorest people of the land.
15 He carried Jehoiachin away to Babylon,
and also the king's mother, the king's wives, his
officers,
and the powerful men of the land.
He took them as captives from Jerusalem to Babylon.
16 All the warriors, 7,000,
and the craftsmen and smiths, 1,000,
all strong and fit for war,
the king of Babylon brought as captives to Babylon.
17 The king of Babylon made Mattaniah, Jehoiachin's
uncle, king in his place
and changed his name to Zedekiah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the year 597 BC Jerusalem is taken by the Babylonians for the first time. A Babylonian chronicle reports this too and even gives the day: in March 597 BC.

Jehoiachin surrenders. So at first the city is not destroyed. But the upper class, the soldiers, and the craftsmen are taken away to Babylon. Among them was the prophet Ezekiel (Ezekiel 1:1–3).

With this the word comes true that Isaiah had spoken to King Hezekiah (2 Kings 20:17).

The numbers in verses 14 and 16 are not quite the same. Perhaps 10,000 is the total number. Jeremiah 52:28 gives a smaller number (3,023).

Only the poorest stay in the land. The Babylonians took the educated and skilled people with them, so that Judah could not rise up again.

Zedekiah too receives a new name from the foreign king.

Zedekiah, the last king of Judah VERSES 18–20

18 Zedekiah was 21 years old when he became king,
and he ruled for 11 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Hamutal the daughter of
Jeremiah, from Libnah.
19 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
just as Jehoiakim had done.
20 For because of the LORD's anger this happened to
Jerusalem and Judah,
until he had thrown them out from his presence.
And Zedekiah rebelled against the king of Babylon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zedekiah is a son of Josiah, a brother of Jehoahaz and Jehoiakim.

He was a weak king, torn back and forth. He often secretly asked the prophet Jeremiah for advice, but he did not have the courage to follow it (Jeremiah 37–38). Jeremiah advised

him to submit to Babylon to save the city. But Zedekiah rebelled.

Zedekiah ruled from about 597 to 587 BC.

2 KINGS

CHAPTER 25

Jerusalem is destroyed

The siege and the king's escape VERSES 1–7

1 In the ninth year of his reign,
in the tenth month, on the tenth day of the month,
Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon came with his whole army against Jerusalem.
He camped against the city
and built siege walls all around it.
2 So the city was under siege until the eleventh year of King Zedekiah.
3 On the ninth day of the fourth month the famine in the city was so bad
that the people of the land had no more bread.
4 Then a hole was broken in the city wall.
All the warriors fled at night
by the way of the gate between the two walls, which was by the king's garden.
(The Chaldeans were all around the city.)
And the king went by the way toward the Arabah.
5 But the army of the Chaldeans chased the king
and caught up with him in the plains of Jericho.
His whole army was scattered and left him.
6 They captured the king
and brought him up to the king of Babylon at Riblah.
And they passed judgment on him.
7 They killed Zedekiah's sons before his eyes.
Then they blinded Zedekiah,
put him in chains,
and took him to Babylon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The siege lasts about a year and a half. The people in the city are starving.

Zedekiah tries to escape at night, toward the Jordan Valley. But he is caught.

The punishment is cruel: his sons are killed before his eyes. That is the last thing he sees. Then he is blinded. The Bible tells of this cruelty without softening it. It shows the whole suffering of war.

To this day Jews remember these events with days of fasting: the beginning of the siege on the tenth of Tevet and the hole in the wall in the month of Tammuz.

In Lachish letters written on pieces of pottery were found that come from this time. In them an officer writes that the fire signals of Azekah can no longer be seen. This fits Jeremiah 34:7.

The temple burns VERSES 8–17

8 In the fifth month, on the seventh day of the month,
that was the nineteenth year of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon,
Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard, a servant of the king of Babylon, came to Jerusalem.
9 He burned the LORD's house,
the king's house,
and all the houses of Jerusalem.
He burned every great house with fire.
10 The whole army of the Chaldeans who were with the captain of the guard
broke down the walls all around Jerusalem.
11 The rest of the people who were left in the city,
and those who had gone over to the king of Babylon,
all the rest of the crowd,
Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard took away as captives.
12 But the captain of the guard left some of the poorest of the land
to work the vineyards and the fields.
13 The Chaldeans broke up the bronze pillars that were in the LORD's house,
the stands, and the bronze sea that were in the LORD's house,
and carried the bronze to Babylon.
14 They also took away the pots, the shovels, the wick trimmers, the bowls,
and all the bronze objects that were used for the service.
15 The fire pans and the basins,
what was of gold, for its gold,
and what was of silver, for its silver,
the captain of the guard took away.
16 The two pillars, the one sea, and the stands
that Solomon had made for the LORD's house:
the bronze of all these objects could not even be weighed.
17 The one pillar was about 27 feet high.
On it was a bronze capital.
The capital was about 4½ feet high,
with network and pomegranates all around it, all of bronze.
And the second pillar with its network was just the same.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the saddest day in the history of ancient Israel: the temple that Solomon had built almost 400 years before is burned. This happened in the year 587 or 586 BC.

Jews remember this day to this day. On the fast day "Tisha B'Av" (the ninth day of the month of Av) they mourn the destruction of the first and the second temple. Then the Book of Lamentations is read, which laments this destruction.

Jeremiah 52:12 has the tenth day instead of the seventh. Perhaps Nebuzaradan arrived on the seventh day and set the temple on fire on the tenth.

The exact description of the pillars and objects reminds us how splendid everything once was (1 Kings 7:15–22). Now it

is smashed into scrap metal.

The Bible gives the measurements in cubits: 18 cubits and 3 cubits. A cubit is about 18 inches. In 1 Kings 7:16 the capital is 5 cubits.

The poorest stay in the land. They even receive fields and vineyards (Jeremiah 39:10). For them the disaster is also a new beginning.

The leading men are executed VERSES 18–21

18 The captain of the guard took Seraiah the chief priest,
Zephaniah the second priest,
and the three keepers of the doorway as prisoners.
19 From the city he took an officer who was in charge of the warriors,
five men of those who were allowed to see the king's face
and who were found in the city,
the scribe of the army commander, who called up the people of the land for the army,
and 60 men of the people of the land who were found in the city.
20 Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard took them
and brought them to the king of Babylon at Riblah.
21 The king of Babylon had them struck down and put to death at Riblah in the land of Hamath.
So Judah was carried away captive out of its land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Babylonians kill the leading men who had supported the rebellion.

"So Judah was carried away captive out of its land." With this short sentence the history of the kingdom of Judah ends after about 400 years. The time of the Babylonian captivity begins, also called the "exile".

A descendant of this chief priest Seraiah was Ezra, who came back from Babylon to Jerusalem about 140 years later (Ezra 7:1).

Gedaliah VERSES 22–26

22 Over the people who were left in the land of Judah,
whom Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon had left behind,
he made Gedaliah the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan, governor.
23 When all the army commanders and their men heard
that the king of Babylon had made Gedaliah governor,
they came to Gedaliah at Mizpah:
Ishmael the son of Nethaniah,
Johanan the son of Kareah,
Seraiah the son of Tanhumeth the Netophathite,
and Jaazaniah the son of the Maacathite,
they and their men.
24 Gedaliah swore to them and to their men and said to them,
"Don't be afraid of the servants of the Chaldeans.
Stay in the land and serve the king of Babylon,
and it will go well with you."
25 But in the seventh month Ishmael the son of Nethaniah, the son of Elishama, from the royal family, came,
and 10 men with him.
They struck Gedaliah so that he died,
and also the Jews and the Chaldeans who were with him at Mizpah.
26 Then all the people, both small and great,
and the army commanders got up
and went to Egypt,
because they were afraid of the Chaldeans.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gedaliah was a grandson of Shaphan, from the family that had protected the prophet Jeremiah. He wanted to rebuild the destroyed land and keep the peace.

But Ishmael, a man from the royal family, murders him. Perhaps out of envy, or because he thought Gedaliah was a traitor.

Out of fear of the Babylonians' revenge, many flee to Egypt. They take the prophet Jeremiah with them against his will (Jeremiah 40–43).

To this day Jews remember this murder on the "Fast of Gedaliah", after the New Year festival.

In Lachish a seal impression was found with the words "Gedaliah, who is over the house." Whether it is the same Gedaliah is not certain.

A light of hope: Jehoiachin is set free VERSES 27–30

27 In the thirty-seventh year of the captivity of Jehoiachin king of Judah,
in the twelfth month, on the twenty-seventh day of the month,
Evilmerodach king of Babylon, in the year that he became king,
set Jehoiachin king of Judah free from prison.
28 He spoke kindly to him
and set his throne above the thrones of the kings who were with him in Babylon.
29 And he was allowed to take off his prison clothes.
Jehoiachin always ate at the king's table for the rest of his life.
30 And for his support the king always gave him what he needed,
a portion every day, for the rest of his life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After so much darkness the book ends with a small light. In about 560 BC King Jehoiachin is set free from prison in Babylon. He may eat at the king's table and is honored.

This is a sign of hope: David's family still lives. God has not forgotten his promise to David. The "lamp" has not gone out completely.

In Babylon clay tablets were found on which the oil rations for Jehoiachin, king of Judah, and his sons are written down. Today they are in a museum in Berlin.

Evilmerodach (in Babylonian Amel-Marduk) was the son of Nebuchadnezzar. He ruled only briefly, from 562 to 560 BC.

A descendant of Jehoiachin was Zerubbabel, who later led the return to Jerusalem (Ezra 3:2). In the Gospel of Matthew Jehoiachin (there called Jechoniah) is in the family tree of Jesus (Matthew 1:12).

Looking back: What have we read in 2 Kings?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Second Book of Kings tells almost 300 years of history, from about 850 to 560 BC.

The prophets: At the beginning are Elijah and Elisha. Elijah goes up to heaven in a chariot of fire. Elisha does many miracles: he helps poor widows, heals the sick, and gives food to the hungry. He even heals the enemy general Naaman and lets captured enemies go free. Later Jonah, Amos, Hosea, Isaiah, Jeremiah, and the prophetess Huldah warn the people.

The fall of the northern kingdom: In the north many kings follow one another, most of them unfaithful to God, many of them murdered. In 722 BC the Assyrians conquer Samaria. The Bible asks: Why? And it answers: because they did not listen to God's prophets.

Judah: In the south there are good and evil kings. Hezekiah trusts God and sees Jerusalem rescued from the Assyrians. Josiah finds the forgotten book of the law and renews the covenant. But the guilt, especially under Manasseh, weighs too heavily.

The fall of Jerusalem: In 587 BC the Babylonians destroy Jerusalem and the temple. The people are taken away to Babylon.

The hope: The book does not end with death, but with a king set free who may eat at the king's table. God has not forgotten his people and his promises.

The lesson of the book: God is patient. He warns again and again. But whoever leaves him for good loses what he has received from God. At the same time the book shows: even after the greatest disaster, God's faithfulness has not come to an end.

What comes next? The books of Chronicles tell the same story once more, from a different point of view. The books of Ezra and Nehemiah tell of the return from Babylon and the rebuilding of Jerusalem.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 13 OF 66

1 CHRONICLES

29 CHAPTERS

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 1

From Adam to Esau

Before we begin: What is the first book of Chronicles?

The books of Chronicles tell the history of Israel once more, from Adam to the end of the exile in Babylon. In the beginning, 1 and 2 Chronicles were one single book.

We already know much of it from the books of Samuel and Kings. But Chronicles tells it from a different point of view. It was probably written after the return from Babylon, around 400 to 300 BC. At that time people asked: Who are we? Do we still belong to God's people? Has God forgotten us?

The answer of Chronicles is: You belong. You stand in a long line that goes back to Adam. God has never given up his people.

That is why the book begins with long lists of names (Chapters 1–9). For us today this is unusual. But for the people back then every name was important: here stood their family, their origin, their place in God's people. That is why we do not leave out a single name here either.

After that, the first book of Chronicles tells mainly about King David (Chapters 10–29). Especially important are the temple, the priests, the Levites and the music in worship.

In Hebrew the book is called "Dibre ha-yamim", which means "events of the days". The word "Chronicles" comes from the Greek word for time.

From Adam to Noah VERSES 1–4

1 Adam, Seth, Enosh,
2 Kenan, Mahalalel, Jared,
3 Enoch, Methuselah, Lamech,
4 Noah, Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chronicles begins at the very beginning: with Adam, the first human. In this way it shows: the history of Israel is part of the history of all people.

The names come from Genesis 5. There you can read more about these people. Enoch, for example, "walked with God", and Methuselah became very old.

Noah had three sons: Shem, Ham and Japheth. According to the Bible, all the peoples of the earth come from them.

The descendants of Japheth VERSES 5–7

5 The sons of Japheth were
Gomer, Magog, Madai, Javan, Tubal, Meshech, and Tiras.
6 The sons of Gomer were
Ashkenaz, Diphath, and Togarmah.
7 The sons of Javan were
Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim, and Rodanim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These names come from Genesis 10, the so-called "Table of Nations". Many names stand for peoples or countries.

As people thought back then, the descendants of Japheth lived mainly in the north and west, for example in Asia Minor (today Turkey) and on the islands of the Mediterranean Sea.

"Javan" is probably the old name for the Greeks (Ionians). "Madai" are the Medes. "Kittim" are the people of Cyprus.

In Genesis 10:3 it says "Riphath" instead of Diphath, and in Genesis 10:4 "Dodanim" instead of Rodanim. In Hebrew the letters D and R look almost the same.

The descendants of Ham VERSES 8–16

8 The sons of Ham were
Cush, Mizraim, Put, and Canaan.
9 The sons of Cush were
Seba, Havilah, Sabta, Raama, and Sabteca.
The sons of Raamah were
Sheba and Dedan.
10 Cush was the father of Nimrod.
Nimrod was the first mighty ruler on the earth.
11 Mizraim was the father of the Ludim, Anamim,
Lehabim, Naphtuhim,
12 Pathrusim, Casluhim, and Caphtorim.
The Philistines came from the Casluhim.
13 Canaan was the father of Sidon, his firstborn son, and of Heth.
14 He was also the father of the Jebusites, the Amorites, the Girgashites,
15 the Hivites, the Arkites, the Sinites,
16 the Arvadites, the Zemarites, and the Hamathites.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As people thought back then, the descendants of Ham lived mainly in the south: in Africa and Arabia, and in Canaan.

"Cush" is the land south of Egypt (today Sudan). "Mizraim" is the Hebrew name for Egypt. "Put" is perhaps Libya.

Nimrod was a famous hunter and ruler in Mesopotamia (Genesis 10:8–12).

The names in verses 14–16 are the peoples who lived in Canaan before Israel came.

Important: This list orders peoples by regions and relationships, not by skin color or worth. The Bible teaches that all people come from one human couple and are of equal worth. Sadly, the list was misused in the past to justify racism. That is wrong and against the meaning of the Bible.

The descendants of Shem VERSES 17–23

17 The sons of Shem were
Elam, Asshur, Arpachshad, Lud, Aram, Uz, Hul, Gether, and Meshech.
18 Arpachshad was the father of Shelah.
Shelah was the father of Eber.
19 Eber had two sons.
One was named Peleg, because in his time the earth was divided.
His brother was named Joktan.

20 Joktan was the father of Almodad, Sheleph,
Hazarmaveth, Jerah,
21 Hadoram, Uzal, Diklah,
22 Ebal, Abimael, Sheba,
23 Ophir, Havilah, and Jobab.
All these were the sons of Joktan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

From Shem come the "Semites": the peoples of the Middle East, among them the Arameans, the Arabs and the Israelites.

Eber is probably the one who gave his name to the "Hebrews".

"Peleg" means "division". Perhaps this means the scattering of the peoples after the tower of Babel (Genesis 11).

In Genesis 10:23, Uz, Hul, Gether and Meshech are sons of Aram. Chronicles names them here in short form.

Joktan's descendants lived mainly in Arabia. Ophir was famous for its gold (1 Kings 9:28).

From Shem to Abraham VERSES 24–27

24 Shem, Arpachshad, Shelah,
25 Eber, Peleg, Reu,
26 Serug, Nahor, Terah,
27 Abram, who is also called Abraham.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the line becomes narrower. Of all the descendants of Shem, only one line is followed: the line to Abraham.

God gave Abram a new name: Abraham, "father of many nations" (Genesis 17:5). With him God's special history with Israel begins.

The descendants of Abraham: Ishmael and Keturah VERSES 28–33

28 The sons of Abraham were
Isaac and Ishmael.
29 These are their families:
Nebaioth was Ishmael's firstborn son.
After him came Kedar, Adbeel, Mibsam,
30 Mishma, Dumah, Massa, Hadad, Tema,
31 Jetur, Naphish, and Kedemah.
These are the sons of Ishmael.
32 Keturah was Abraham's concubine.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
Keturah gave birth to Zimran, Jokshan, Medan,
Midian, Ishbak, and Shuah.
The sons of Jokshan were
Sheba and Dedan.
33 The sons of Midian were
Ephah, Epher, Hanoch, Abida, and Eldaah.
All these were the sons of Keturah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ishmael, the older son of Abraham, also had 12 sons, just as God had promised (Genesis 17:20). Many Arabs and Muslims see Ishmael as their ancestor.

Keturah was another wife of Abraham after Sarah's death (Genesis 25:1–4). From her son Midian come the Midianites. Moses' wife Zipporah was a Midianite.

Chronicles does not forget Abraham's other sons. God had promised Abraham that all nations would be blessed through him.

The descendants of Esau VERSES 34–37

34 Abraham was the father of Isaac.
The sons of Isaac were
Esau and Israel.
35 The sons of Esau were
Eliphaz, Reuel, Jeush, Jalam, and Korah.
36 The sons of Eliphaz were
Teman, Omar, Zephi, Gatam, Kenaz, Timna, and
Amalek.
37 The sons of Reuel were
Nahath, Zerah, Shammah, and Mizzah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Isaac had two sons: Esau and Jacob. Here Jacob is called "Israel", with the name God gave him (Genesis 32:28).

From Esau come the Edomites. The list comes from Genesis 36.

In Genesis 36:12, Timna is the concubine of Eliphaz and the mother of Amalek. Chronicles counts her here in short form among his descendants.

The people of Seir VERSES 38–42

38 The sons of Seir were
Lotan, Shobal, Zibeon, Anah, Dishon, Ezer, and
Dishan.
39 The sons of Lotan were
Hori and Homam.
Lotan's sister was Timna.
40 The sons of Shobal were
Alian, Manahath, Ebal, Shephi, and Onam.
The sons of Zibeon were
Aiah and Anah.
41 The son of Anah was
Dishon.
The sons of Dishon were
Hamran, Eshban, Ithran, and Cheran.
42 The sons of Ezer were
Bilhan, Zaavan, and Jaakan.
The sons of Dishan were
Uz and Aran.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Seir is the hill country where the Edomites lived. Before them the Horites lived there. Here their families are named (Genesis 36:20–28).

Esau's family mixed with them. Esau married Oholibamah, a granddaughter of Zibeon (Genesis 36:2).

The kings and chiefs of Edom VERSES 43–54

43 These are the kings who ruled in the land of Edom,
before any king ruled over the people of Israel:
Bela, the son of Beor.
His city was called Dinhabah.
44 When Bela died,
Jobab, the son of Zerah, from Bozrah, became king in
his place.
45 When Jobab died,
Husham, from the land of the Temanites, became king
in his place.

46 When Husham died,
Hadad, the son of Bedad, became king in his place.
Hadad defeated Midian in the country of Moab.
His city was called Avith.
47 When Hadad died,
Samlah, from Masrekah, became king in his place.
48 When Samlah died,
Shaul, from Rehoboth by the River, became king in his place.
49 When Shaul died,
Baal Hanan, the son of Achbor, became king in his place.
50 When Baal Hanan died,
Hadad became king in his place.
His city was called Pai.
His wife's name was Mehetabel.
She was the daughter of Matred, the daughter of Mezahab.
51 Then Hadad died.
The chiefs of Edom were:
chief Timna, chief Aliah, chief Jetheth,
52 chief Oholibamah, chief Elah, chief Pinon,
53 chief Kenaz, chief Teman, chief Mibzar,
54 chief Magdiel, and chief Iram.
These are the chiefs of Edom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Edom already had kings long before Israel had a king. The list comes from Genesis 36:31–43.

Interesting: these kings did not form one family. Each one came from a different city.

"Chiefs" were the leaders of the tribes or regions of Edom. Some names are probably rather names of areas.

In Genesis 36:39 the city is called "Pau" instead of "Pai".

In Genesis 10:28 Ebal is called "Obal".

With this the look at the other peoples ends. From Chapter 2 on, it is only about Israel.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 2

The sons of Israel and the tribe of Judah

The 12 sons of Israel VERSES 1–2

1 These are the sons of Israel:
Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun,
2 Dan, Joseph, Benjamin, Naphtali, Gad, and Asher.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Chronicles comes to its real subject: to Israel, that is, to Jacob and his 12 sons. From them come the 12 tribes of Israel.

The order is almost as in Genesis 35:23–26. Only Dan comes earlier here.

Judah and his sons VERSES 3–8

3 The sons of Judah were
Er, Onan, and Shelah.
Their mother was the daughter of Shua, a Canaanite woman.
Er was Judah's firstborn son.
He was wicked in the LORD's eyes,
so the LORD killed him.
4 Tamar, Judah's daughter-in-law, gave birth to his sons
Perez and Zerah.
Judah had five sons in all.
5 The sons of Perez were
Hezron and Hamul.
6 The sons of Zerah were
Zimri, Ethan, Heman, Calcol, and Dara, five in all.
7 The son of Carmi was
Achar.
He brought trouble on Israel.
He took things that were set apart for God, and that was a sin.
8 The son of Ethan was
Azariah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chronicles begins with Judah, not with Reuben, the firstborn. For King David comes from Judah, and the book is mainly about him.

Judah's family history was not easy. The story of Judah and Tamar is in Genesis 38. Chronicles does not hide the dark sides. Still, God chose this tribe.

Achar (in Joshua 7 he is called Achan) had secretly taken plunder after the conquest of Jericho. Here his name is connected with the Hebrew word for "bringing trouble": "achar".

Ethan, Heman, Calcol and Dara were famous for their wisdom (1 Kings 4:31). There Dara is called "Darda".

Carmi is probably a descendant of Zimri (Joshua 7:1, where he is called "Zabdi").

From Hezron to David VERSES 9–17

9 Hezron had these sons:
Jerahmeel, Ram, and Chelubai.
10 Ram was the father of Amminadab.
Amminadab was the father of Nahshon.
Nahshon was the leader of the people of Judah.
11 Nahshon was the father of Salma.
Salma was the father of Boaz.
12 Boaz was the father of Obed.
Obed was the father of Jesse.
13 Jesse's firstborn son was Eliab.
His second son was Abinadab.
His third son was Shimea.
14 His fourth son was Nethanel.
His fifth son was Raddai.
15 His sixth son was Ozem.
His seventh son was David.
16 Their sisters were Zeruiah and Abigail.
Zeruiah had three sons:
Abishai, Joab, and Asahel.

17 Abigail gave birth to Amasa.
The father of Amasa was Jether the Ishmaelite.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the line that matters to Chronicles: from Judah through Boaz and Obed to Jesse and David. We know it from the book of Ruth (Ruth 4:18–22).

Nahshon was the leader of the tribe of Judah in the wilderness (Numbers 1:7).

David was Jesse's seventh son. In 1 Samuel 16:10–11 eight sons are mentioned. Perhaps one died early.

David's nephews Joab, Abishai and Asahel were important army commanders (2 Samuel 2:18).

In 2 Samuel 17:25 Jether is called "Ithra the Israelite".

"Chelubai" is another form of the name Caleb (verse 18).

The descendants of Caleb VERSES 18–24

18 Caleb, the son of Hezron, had children with his wife Azubah, and with Jerioth.
These were her sons:
Jesher, Shobab, and Ardon.
19 When Azubah died,
Caleb married Ephrath.
She gave birth to his son Hur.
20 Hur was the father of Uri.
Uri was the father of Bezalel.
21 Later Hezron slept with the daughter of Machir.
Machir was the father of Gilead.
Hezron married her when he was 60 years old.
She gave birth to his son Segub.
22 Segub was the father of Jair.
Jair had 23 cities in the land of Gilead.
23 But Geshur and Aram took the towns of Jair from them.
They also took Kenath and its villages, 60 cities in all.
All these were descendants of Machir, the father of Gilead.
24 Hezron died in Caleb Ephrathah.
After that, Hezron's wife Abijah gave birth to his son Ashhur.
Ashhur was the father of Tekoa.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bezalel was the gifted craftsman who built the tabernacle in the wilderness (Exodus 31:1–5).

Hezron married a woman from the tribe of Manasseh (Machir was a son of Manasseh). So the tribe of Judah also had connections to the land east of the Jordan, to Gilead.

"Father of Tekoa" here probably means: founder or leader of the town of Tekoa. In these lists "father" often stands for the founder of a place.

In Hebrew verse 18 is hard to understand. Perhaps Jerioth was a second wife, perhaps another name for Azubah.

Verse 24 is also unclear. The Greek translation says: After Hezron's death Caleb went to Ephrathah.

The descendants of Jerahmeel VERSES 25–33

25 Jerahmeel was the firstborn son of Hezron.
These were the sons of Jerahmeel:
Ram, the firstborn, then Bunah, Oren, Ozem, and Ahijah.
26 Jerahmeel had another wife.
Her name was Atarah.
She was the mother of Onam.
27 Ram was the firstborn son of Jerahmeel.
The sons of Ram were
Maaz, Jamin, and Eker.
28 The sons of Onam were
Shammai and Jada.
The sons of Shammai were
Nadab and Abishur.
29 The wife of Abishur was named Abihail.
She gave birth to his sons Ahban and Molid.
30 The sons of Nadab were
Seled and Appaim.
Seled died without children.
31 The son of Appaim was
Ishi.
The son of Ishi was
Sheshan.
The son of Sheshan was
Ahlai.
32 Jada was the brother of Shammai.
The sons of Jada were
Jether and Jonathan.
Jether died without children.
33 The sons of Jonathan were
Peleth and Zaza.
These were the descendants of Jerahmeel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Jerahmeelites were a part of the tribe of Judah that lived in the south, in the Negev (1 Samuel 27:10).

Chronicles also mentions who died without children. No name is forgotten, not even the names of people whose family ended.

An Egyptian servant becomes part of the family VERSES 34–41

34 Sheshan had no sons, only daughters.
Sheshan had a servant from Egypt.
His name was Jarha.
35 Sheshan gave his daughter to his servant Jarha as his wife.
She gave birth to his son Attai.
36 Attai was the father of Nathan.
Nathan was the father of Zabad.
37 Zabad was the father of Ephlal.
Ephlal was the father of Obed.
38 Obed was the father of Jehu.
Jehu was the father of Azariah.
39 Azariah was the father of Helez.
Helez was the father of Eleasah.
40 Eleasah was the father of Sismai.
Sismai was the father of Shallum.
41 Shallum was the father of Jekamiah.
Jekamiah was the father of Elishama.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A lovely little story in the middle of the list: Sheshan has no son. He gives his daughter to his Egyptian servant as wife. So a foreigner, even a servant, becomes a full member of the

family in Judah. His descendants are listed over 13 generations.

Verse 31 says that Sheshan had a son named Ahlai. Perhaps Ahlai was the daughter, or the son died early. The Bible does not explain this.

More descendants of Caleb VERSES 42–50A

42 Caleb was the brother of Jerahmeel.
These were Caleb's sons:
Mesha, his firstborn, who was the father of Ziph,
and the sons of Mareshah, the father of Hebron.
43 The sons of Hebron were
Korah, Tappuah, Rekem, and Shema.
44 Shema was the father of Raham.
Raham was the father of Jorkeam.
Rekem was the father of Shammai.
45 The son of Shammai was Maon.
Maon was the father of Beth Zur.
46 Ephah was Caleb's concubine.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
Ephah gave birth to Haran, Moza, and Gazez.
Haran was the father of Gazez.
47 The sons of Jahdai were
Regem, Jothan, Geshan, Pelet, Ephah, and Shaaph.
48 Maacah was also Caleb's concubine.
She gave birth to Sheber and Tirhanah.
49 She also gave birth to Shaaph, the father of
Madmannah,
and to Sheva, the father of Machbena and the father of Gibea.
Caleb's daughter was Achsah.
50 These were the sons of Caleb.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many of these names are also names of towns in the south of Judah: Ziph, Hebron, Tappuah, Maon, Beth Zur, Madmannah, Gibea. "Father of" here means: founder or leader of this town.

We know Achsah, the daughter of Caleb, from Joshua 15:16–19. But there it is the famous Caleb, the son of Jephunneh, the spy. It is unclear whether Chronicles means the same person here.

We are not told who Jahdai was.

Here Chronicles names women on purpose: Azubah, Ephrath, Abijah, Atarah, Abihail, Ephah, Maacah and Achsah. They are part of the history too.

The descendants of Hur VERSES 50B–55

The descendants of Hur, the firstborn of Ephrathah, were
Shobal, the father of Kiriath Jearim,
51 Salma, the father of Bethlehem,
and Hareph, the father of Beth Gader.
52 Shobal, the father of Kiriath Jearim, had sons:
Haroeh, half of the Menuhoth.
53 The families of Kiriath Jearim were
the Ithrites, the Puthites, the Shumathites, and the Mishraites.
The Zorathites and the Eshtaolites came from them.
54 The descendants of Salma were
Bethlehem, the Netophathites, Atroth Beth Joab,
and half of the Manahathites, the Zorites.
55 Families of scribes lived at Jabez.
Scribes are people who can read and write.
These families were the Tirathites, the Shimeathites,
and the Sucathites.
They are the Kenites who came from Hammath,
the father of the family of Rechab.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Well-known places appear here: Kiriath Jearim, where the ark of the covenant stayed for 20 years (1 Samuel 7:1–2), and Bethlehem, the city of David. Later Jesus was born there.

In the WEB, our English source text, verse 50 can be understood like this: Caleb is a son of Hur. But probably it means: These were the sons of Caleb. And then a new start: The son of Hur … Verses 50 to 55 then list the descendants of Hur.

The Kenites were at first not an Israelite tribe. Moses' father-in-law belonged to them (Judges 1:16). They became part of Judah. The Rechabites, whom we know from 2 Kings 10:15, belonged to them.

"Scribes" were people who could read and write. That was rare and important back then.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 3

David's family

David's sons from Hebron VERSES 1–4A

1 These were the sons of David who were born in Hebron:
The firstborn was Amnon.
His mother was Ahinoam, the woman from Jezreel.
The second was Daniel.
His mother was Abigail, the woman from Carmel.
2 The third was Absalom.
His mother was Maacah, the daughter of Talmai, king of Geshur.
The fourth was Adonijah.
His mother was Haggith.
3 The fifth was Shephatiah.
His mother was Abital.
The sixth was Ithream.
His mother was Eglah, David's wife.
4 These six sons were born to David in Hebron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David first reigned in Hebron, over the tribe of Judah (2 Samuel 2:1–4). These six sons were born there. The list is also in 2 Samuel 3:2–5.

In 2 Samuel 3:3 Daniel is called "Chileab". He is not the prophet Daniel.

Many of these sons have a sad story: Amnon did violence to his half sister Tamar and was killed by Absalom. Absalom rose up against his father and died. Adonijah wanted to become king and was killed.

David's sons from Jerusalem VERSES 4B–9

David ruled there for seven years and six months.
Then he ruled for 33 years in Jerusalem.
5 These sons were born to him in Jerusalem:
Shimea, Shobab, Nathan, and Solomon.
These four were the sons of Bathshua, the daughter of Ammiel.
6 Then there were Ibhar, Elishama, Eliphelet,
7 Nogah, Nepheg, Japhia,
8 Elishama, Eliada, and Eliphelet.
These were nine sons.
9 All these were the sons of David.
David also had sons by his concubines.
Concubines are wives of lower rank.
Tamar was the sister of these sons.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Bathshua" is another form of the name Bathsheba. Her father Ammiel is called "Eliam" in 2 Samuel 11:3.

Here Solomon is named as Bathsheba's fourth son, although he was probably the oldest one who stayed alive. Perhaps the order is not by age.

Nathan, another son of David, is important in the family tree of Jesus in Luke (Luke 3:31).

Two names appear twice: Elishama and Eliphelet. Perhaps the first sons with this name died young, and later sons got the same name. Instead of the first Elishama, 2 Samuel 5:15 has "Elishua".

Tamar is the only daughter of David who is named. Her terrible story is in 2 Samuel 13.

The kings of Judah VERSES 10–16

10 Solomon's son was Rehoboam.
Rehoboam's son was Abijah.
His son was Asa.
His son was Jehoshaphat.
11 His son was Joram.
His son was Ahaziah.
His son was Joash.
12 His son was Amaziah.
His son was Azariah.
His son was Jotham.
13 His son was Ahaz.
His son was Hezekiah.
His son was Manasseh.
14 His son was Amon.
His son was Josiah.
15 The sons of Josiah were:
Johanan, the firstborn,
Jehoiakim, the second,
Zedekiah, the third,
and Shallum, the fourth.
16 The sons of Jehoiakim were
his son Jeconiah
and his son Zedekiah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the list of all the kings of Judah from David's family, over almost 400 years. We know them from the books of Kings. Queen Athaliah is missing, because she did not belong to David's family.

In the books of Kings Abijah is called "Abijam". Azariah is also called "Uzziah".

Shallum is probably the same as King Jehoahaz (2 Kings 23:31; Jeremiah 22:11). We know nothing else about Johanan.

Jeconiah is another name for King Jehoiachin.

The Zedekiah in verse 16 is probably a different one from King Zedekiah in verse 15. Or it is the same one after all, and "son" here means "successor".

David's family after the exile VERSES 17–24

17 Jeconiah was taken away as a prisoner.
His sons were
his son Shealtiel,
18 Malchiram, Pedaiah, Shenazzar, Jekamiah, Hoshama, and Nedabiah.
19 The sons of Pedaiah were
Zerubbabel and Shimei.
The sons of Zerubbabel were
Meshullam and Hananiah.
Their sister was Shelomith.
20 There were also five more:
Hashubah, Ohel, Berechiah, Hasadiah, and Jushab Hesed.
21 The sons of Hananiah were
Pelatiah and Jeshaiah.
Then came the sons of Rephaiah,
the sons of Arnan,
the sons of Obadiah,
and the sons of Shecaniah.
22 The son of Shecaniah was
Shemaiah.
The sons of Shemaiah were
Hattush, Igal, Bariah, Neariah, and Shaphat, six in all.
23 The sons of Neariah were
Elioenai, Hizkiah, and Azrikam, three in all.
24 The sons of Elioenai were
Hodaviah, Eliashib, Pelaiah, Akkub, Johanan, Delaiah, and Anani, seven in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is an important message: David's family did not perish in the exile! Jeconiah (Jehoiachin) was a prisoner in Babylon (2 Kings 25:27). But his descendants lived on.

After the exile Zerubbabel led the first group of Jews back to Jerusalem and began to rebuild the temple (Ezra 3:2; Haggai 1:1). In other places he is called "son of Shealtiel". Perhaps Shealtiel was his uncle or adoptive father, or there was a levirate marriage. That means: a man married the widow of his brother who had died without children.

The list goes on for several generations after Zerubbabel. From this you can see that Chronicles was written only long after the return.

Verse 22 says "six", but only five names are given. Perhaps Shemaiah is counted too, or a name was lost when the text was copied.

In Hebrew verse 21 is hard to understand. In the Greek translation the names form one continuous line of father and son.

Matthew names Jeconiah, Shealtiel and Zerubbabel in the family tree of Jesus (Matthew 1:12). In this way Christians connect the hope for the Messiah from David's family with

Jesus. In Judaism the Messiah from the house of David is still expected.

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 4

More families from Judah and the tribe of Simeon

Families from Judah VERSES 1–8

1 The sons of Judah were
Perez, Hezron, Carmi, Hur, and Shobal.
2 Reaiah, the son of Shobal, was the father of Jahath.
Jahath was the father of Ahumai and Lahad.
These are the families of the Zorathites.
3 These were the sons of the father of Etam:
Jezreel, Ishma, and Idbash.
Their sister's name was Hazzelelponi.
4 Penuel was the father of Gedor.
Ezer was the father of Hushah.
These are the sons of Hur.
Hur was the firstborn of Ephrathah and the father of Bethlehem.
5 Ashhur, the father of Tekoa, had two wives, Helah and Naarah.
6 Naarah gave birth to his sons Ahuzzam, Hepher, Temeni, and Haahashtari.
These were the sons of Naarah.
7 The sons of Helah were Zereth, Izhar, and Ethnan.
8 Hakkoz was the father of Anub and Zobebah.
The families of Aharhel, the son of Harum, also came from him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The list in verse 1 is not a list of brothers, but a line over several generations: Perez was Judah's son, Hezron his grandson, and so on.

Many names are also place names: Etam, Jezreel, Gedor, Bethlehem, Tekoa. "Father of" here often means "founder of".

Here too Chronicles names women: Hazzelelponi, Helah and Naarah.

In some Bibles "Hakkoz" is called "Koz". The "ha" is the article in Hebrew.

The prayer of Jabez VERSES 9–10

9 Jabez was more respected than his brothers.
His mother named him Jabez.
She said, "I gave birth to him in pain."
10 Jabez prayed to the God of Israel.
He said, "Please bless me richly!
Give me more land!
May your hand be with me.
Keep me safe from harm,
so that I do not cause pain!"
And God gave him what he asked for.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the long lists of names there is suddenly a little story with a prayer.

In Hebrew the name Jabez sounds like "pain". A name with a heavy meaning, like a shadow over his life.

Jabez asks God: Bless me, be with me, and keep me safe from harm, so that I do not cause pain. He does not want his name to decide his fate.

God hears him. The message: No one is bound to a hard beginning. You can ask God for a new way.

Some years ago this prayer became very well known through a book. What matters is this: It is not a magic spell for riches, but a person's request for God's nearness and protection.

More families from Judah VERSES 11–23

11 Chelub, the brother of Shuhah, was the father of Mehir.
Mehir was the father of Eshton.
12 Eshton was the father of Beth Rapha, Paseah, and Tehinnah.
Tehinnah was the father of Ir Nahash.
These are the men of Recah.
13 The sons of Kenaz were
Othniel and Seraiah.
The son of Othniel was
Hathath.
14 Meonothai was the father of Ophrah.
Seraiah was the father of Joab.
Joab was the father of Ge Harashim.
They got this name because they were craftsmen.
15 The sons of Caleb, the son of Jephunneh, were
Iru, Elah, and Naam.
The son of Elah was Kenaz.
16 The sons of Jehallelel were
Ziph, Ziphah, Tiria, and Asarel.
17 The sons of Ezrah were
Jether, Mered, Epher, and Jalon.
Mered's wife gave birth to Miriam, Shammai, and Ishbah.
Ishbah was the father of Eshtemoa.
18 His wife from Judah gave birth to Jered, the father of Gedor,
Heber, the father of Soco,
and Jekuthiel, the father of Zanoah.
These are the sons of Bithiah, the daughter of Pharaoh.
Mered had married her.
19 Hodiah's wife was the sister of Naham.
Her sons were the fathers of Keilah the Garmite
and of Eshtemoa the Maacathite.
20 The sons of Shimon were
Amnon, Rinnah, Ben Hanan, and Tilon.
The sons of Ishi were
Zoheth and Ben Zoheth.
21 The sons of Shelah, the son of Judah, were
Er, the father of Lecah,
and Laadah, the father of Mareshah.

The families of the linen workers in the house of
Ashbea also came from him.
22 So did Jokim, the men of Cozeba,
Joash, and Saraph, who ruled in Moab,
and Jashubilehem.
These records are very old.
23 They were the potters.
They lived in Netaim and Gederah.
They lived there with the king and worked for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Othniel was the first judge of Israel (Judges 3:9–11). Caleb the son of Jephunneh was one of the two faithful spies (Numbers 14:6–9).

"Ge Harashim" means "valley of craftsmen". Chronicles also honors craftsmen, potters and linen workers. Every kind of work has its worth.

Remarkable in verse 18: Mered married Bithiah, a daughter of Pharaoh. An Egyptian princess became part of the tribe of Judah. Her name "Bithiah" means "daughter of the LORD". Jewish tradition connects her with the daughter of Pharaoh who saved Moses from the Nile.

In Hebrew verses 17–18 are a little mixed up. The Greek translation puts the end of verse 18 before the words "Mered's wife gave birth to Miriam" in verse 17.

"These records are very old": The writer honestly says that he draws from old sources.

"Er" here is a grandson of Judah, named after Judah's oldest son Er, who had died.

The tribe of Simeon VERSES 24–33

24 The sons of Simeon were
Nemuel, Jamin, Jarib, Zerah, and Shaul.
25 Then came his son Shallum,
his son Mibsam,
and his son Mishma.
26 The descendants of Mishma were
his son Hammuel,
his son Zaccur,
and his son Shimei.
27 Shimei had 16 sons and 6 daughters.
But his brothers did not have many children.
Their whole family did not grow as large as the tribe of Judah.
28 They lived in Beersheba, Moladah, Hazarshual,
29 Bilhah, Ezem, Tolad,
30 Bethuel, Hormah, Ziklag,
31 Beth Marcaboth, Hazar Susim, Beth Biri, and Shaaraim.
These were their cities until David became king.
32 Their villages were Etam, Ain, Rimmon, Tochen, and Ashan, five towns.
33 They also had all the villages around these towns, as far as Baal.
These were the places where they lived.
They kept a written record of their families.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Simeon was a small tribe. It lived in the middle of Judah's land, in the south (Joshua 19:1–9). Over time it almost completely became part of Judah.

Jacob had said about Simeon and Levi that they would be scattered in Israel (Genesis 49:7).

In Genesis 46:10 Nemuel is called "Jemuel" and Jarib "Jachin".

Simeon looks for new pasture VERSES 34–43

34 Meshobab, Jamlech, Joshah the son of Amaziah,
35 Joel, Jehu the son of Joshibiah, the son of Seraiah, the son of Asiel,
36 Elioenai, Jaakobah, Jeshohaiah, Asaiah, Adiel, Jesimiel, Benaiah,
37 and Ziza the son of Shiphi, the son of Allon, the son of Jedaiah, the son of Shimri, the son of Shemaiah:
38 these men named here were leaders of their families.
Their families grew very large.
39 They went to the entrance of Gedor,
to the east side of the valley.
They were looking for pasture for their flocks.
40 They found rich, good pasture.
The land was wide, quiet, and peaceful.
The people who lived there before were descendants of Ham.
41 The men whose names are written here came in the time of Hezekiah, king of Judah.
They attacked the tents of the people there and the Meunim they found there.
They destroyed them completely, and they are gone to this day.
Then they lived there in their place,
because there was pasture there for their flocks.
42 Some of them, 500 men of the descendants of Simeon, went to Mount Seir.
Their leaders were Pelatiah, Neariah, Rephaiah, and Uzziel, the sons of Ishi.
43 They killed the rest of the Amalekites who had escaped.
They have lived there to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the time of King Hezekiah the families of Simeon need more room for their flocks. They move on into the south and drive out the people who lived there.

This is a harsh report about driving people out and violence. The Bible tells how it happened back then. For the people who lived there peacefully it was an injustice and great suffering. These verses are no example for taking other people's land.

The Meunim were probably a people from the area south of the Dead Sea.

The Amalekites had been enemies of Israel since the time in the wilderness (Exodus 17:8–16).

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 5

The tribes east of the Jordan

Reuben, the firstborn VERSES 1–3

1 These are the sons of Reuben, the firstborn son of Israel.
Reuben was the firstborn.
But he dishonored his father's bed.
That means: he slept with one of his father's wives.
That is why his rights as the firstborn were given to the sons of Joseph, the son of Israel.
So Reuben is not listed in the family records as the firstborn.
2 Judah became stronger than his brothers.
The ruler came from him.
But the rights of the firstborn belonged to Joseph.
3 The sons of Reuben, the firstborn of Israel, were
Hanoch, Pallu, Hezron, and Carmi.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Reuben was Jacob's oldest son. But he had slept with Bilhah, a wife of his father (Genesis 35:22). That is why he lost his special right as the firstborn.

The birthright was divided: Joseph got the double share of the land (his sons Ephraim and Manasseh became two tribes). Judah got the leadership: from him came King David.

"The ruler": this means David. Later people also connected this word with the Messiah they were waiting for.

The families of Reuben VERSES 4–10

4 The descendants of Joel were
his son Shemaiah,
his son Gog,
his son Shimei,
5 his son Micah,
his son Reaiah,
his son Baal,
6 and his son Beerah.
Tilgath Pilneser, the king of Assyria, took Beerah away as a prisoner.
Beerah was the leader of the Reubenites.
7 These were his relatives by their families,
as they were written in the family records:
Jeiel, the chief, and Zechariah,
8 and Bela, the son of Azaz, the son of Shema, the son of Joel.
Bela lived in Aroer and as far as Nebo and Baal Meon.
9 To the east he lived as far as the edge of the wilderness that reaches to the Euphrates River.
They lived there because they had so many animals in the land of Gilead.
10 When Saul was king, they fought a war against the Hagrites.
They defeated them.
Then they lived in their tents in the whole land east of Gilead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

We are not told how Joel is connected with Reuben.

Tilgath Pilneser is another spelling of Tiglath Pileser. He was the Assyrian king who carried away the tribes east of the Jordan around 733 BC (2 Kings 15:29).

Aroer, Nebo and Baal Meon were east of the Dead Sea. These places are also named on the Mesha Stone.

The Hagrites were probably an Arab tribe. Their name reminds us of Hagar, the mother of Ishmael.

The tribe of Gad VERSES 11–17

11 The descendants of Gad lived next to them,
in the land of Bashan as far as Salecah.
12 Joel was the chief.
Shapham was the second.
Then came Janai and Shaphat in Bashan.
13 Their relatives, by their families, were
Michael, Meshullam, Sheba, Jorai, Jacan, Zia, and Eber, seven in all.
14 These were the sons of Abihail.
Abihail was the son of Huri, the son of Jaroah, the son of Gilead,
the son of Michael, the son of Jeshishai, the son of Jahdo, the son of Buz.
15 Ahi, the son of Abdiel, the son of Guni,
was the chief of their families.
16 They lived in Gilead, in Bashan and its towns,
and in all the pasture lands of Sharon, as far as their borders.
17 All these were written in the family records
when Jotham was king of Judah
and Jeroboam was king of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gad lived east of the Jordan, in Gilead and Bashan. That was good pasture for herds of cattle.

"Sharon" here is probably not the well-known coastal plain, but an area east of the Jordan.

The family records were written down under King Jotham of Judah and King Jeroboam II of Israel, so around 750 BC.

War against the Hagrites VERSES 18–22

18 The descendants of Reuben, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh had brave soldiers.
They could carry shield and sword.
They could shoot with the bow.
They were skilled in war.
There were 44,760 men who could go out to war.
19 They fought a war against the Hagrites,
against Jetur, Naphish, and Nodab.
20 They received help against these enemies.
The Hagrites were handed over to them,
together with all who were with them.
During the battle they cried out to God.
He answered them because they trusted in him.
21 They took away the animals of the Hagrites:
50,000 camels,
250,000 sheep,
and 2,000 donkeys.
They also took away 100,000 people.
22 Many enemies were killed, because the war came from God.
They lived in the land of the Hagrites until they were taken away as prisoners.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The message of Chronicles: They won because they cried to God in their need and trusted him.

Jetur and Naphish were sons of Ishmael (1 Chronicles 1:31). So the Hagrites were Arab tribes.

The numbers are very large. As with other old war reports, it is unclear how exactly they are meant.

"The war came from God" is an interpretation from the point of view of the winners. For the defeated it was great suffering, death and captivity. Today no one may call on God to justify war against other peoples.

The half-tribe of Manasseh and the deportation

VERSES 23–26

23 The people of the half-tribe of Manasseh lived in the land.
They became many, from Bashan to Baal Hermon, Senir, and Mount Hermon.
24 These were the heads of their families:
Epher, Ishi, Eliel, Azriel, Jeremiah, Hodaviah, and Jahdiel.
They were brave soldiers, famous men, and heads of their families.
25 But they were unfaithful to the God of their ancestors.
They acted like prostitutes
and ran after the gods of the peoples of the land.
God had destroyed these peoples before them.
26 So the God of Israel moved Pul, the king of Assyria, to act.
He moved Tilgath Pilneser, the king of Assyria.
He took away the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh as prisoners.
He brought them to Halah, Habor, Hara, and to the river of Gozan.
They are still there to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The half-tribe of Manasseh lived in the north, as far as Mount Hermon. Hermon is the highest mountain of the region. "Senir" is another name for it.

Chronicles explains briefly: They lost their land because they became unfaithful to God. "They acted like prostitutes": this is a picture for worshiping idols: being unfaithful to God like being unfaithful in marriage.

"Pul" and "Tilgath Pilneser" are probably two names for the same king (2 Kings 15:19, 29). Chronicles names them here side by side.

This was the first deportation of Israelites, around 733 BC.

In some Bibles, Chapter 5 goes on to verse 41. There, verses 1–15 of the next chapter are 5:27–41.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 6

The tribe of Levi: priests, singers and their cities

The high priests from Aaron to the exile VERSES 1–15

1 The sons of Levi were
Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.
2 The sons of Kohath were
Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel.
3 The children of Amram were
Aaron, Moses, and Miriam.
The sons of Aaron were
Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar, and Ithamar.
4 Eleazar was the father of Phinehas.
Phinehas was the father of Abishua.
5 Abishua was the father of Bukki.
Bukki was the father of Uzzi.
6 Uzzi was the father of Zerahiah.
Zerahiah was the father of Meraioth.
7 Meraioth was the father of Amariah.
Amariah was the father of Ahitub.
8 Ahitub was the father of Zadok.
Zadok was the father of Ahimaaz.
9 Ahimaaz was the father of Azariah.
Azariah was the father of Johanan.
10 Johanan was the father of Azariah.
Azariah served as priest in the house that Solomon built in Jerusalem.
11 Azariah was the father of Amariah.
Amariah was the father of Ahitub.
12 Ahitub was the father of Zadok.
Zadok was the father of Shallum.
13 Shallum was the father of Hilkiah.
Hilkiah was the father of Azariah.
14 Azariah was the father of Seraiah.
Seraiah was the father of Jehozadak.
15 Jehozadak was taken away as a prisoner
when the LORD sent the people of Judah and Jerusalem away.
He used Nebuchadnezzar to do it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles these verses are at the end of chapter 5 (verses 27–41). That is why the verse numbering in this whole chapter is different: verse 16 here is chapter 6, verse 1 there, and so on. Verse 81 here is verse 66 there.

Levi was the tribe of the priests and temple servants. Moses, Aaron and Miriam came from Levi. Chronicles names Miriam on purpose together with her brothers.

Here the line of the high priests is listed, from Aaron to the exile in Babylon, about 800 years.

Hilkiah is the high priest who found the book of the law under Josiah (2 Kings 22:8). Seraiah was executed by the Babylonians (2 Kings 25:18–21).

Jehozadak (also called Jozadak) was the father of Jeshua, the first high priest after the return from Babylon (Ezra 3:2). In this way Chronicles shows: the office of priest was not lost either.

The list is not complete. Well-known priests like Eli or Jehoiada are missing. Such lists often name only the most important members.

The families of the Levites VERSES 16–30

16 The sons of Levi were
Gershom, Kohath, and Merari.

17 These are the names of the sons of Gershom:
Libni and Shimei.
18 The sons of Kohath were
Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel.
19 The sons of Merari were
Mahli and Mushi.
These are the families of the Levites, listed by their ancestors' families.
20 The descendants of Gershom were
his son Libni,
his son Jahath,
his son Zimmah,
21 his son Joah,
his son Iddo,
his son Zerah,
and his son Jeatherai.
22 The descendants of Kohath were
his son Amminadab,
his son Korah,
his son Assir,
23 his son Elkanah,
his son Ebiasaph,
his son Assir,
24 his son Tahath,
his son Uriel,
his son Uzziah,
and his son Shaul.
25 The sons of Elkanah were
Amasai and Ahimoth.
26 The descendants of Elkanah were
his son Zophai,
his son Nahath,
27 his son Eliab,
his son Jeroham,
and his son Elkanah.
28 The sons of Samuel were
Joel, the firstborn,
and Abijah, the second.
29 The descendants of Merari were
Mahli,
his son Libni,
his son Shimei,
his son Uzzah,
30 his son Shimea,
his son Haggiah,
and his son Asaiah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites were divided into three large families, after the three sons of Levi: Gershom (or Gershon), Kohath and Merari. Each family had its own tasks (Numbers 3–4).

Interesting: the prophet Samuel is also counted among the Levites here. In 1 Samuel 1:1 his family is connected with Ephraim. Probably he was a Levite who lived in the land of Ephraim.

Samuel's sons are called Joel and Abijah (1 Samuel 8:2). In the Hebrew text of verse 28 the name Joel is missing. The WEB, our English source text, adds it from verse 33.

The singers in the temple VERSES 31–47

31 The ark came to rest in the LORD's house.
After that, David put these men in charge of the singing there.
32 They served with songs in front of the tabernacle, the Tent of Meeting,
until Solomon built the LORD's house in Jerusalem.
They did their work in the order that was set for them.
33 These are the men who served, and their sons.
From the Kohathites:
Heman the singer, the son of Joel, the son of Samuel,
34 the son of Elkanah, the son of Jeroham, the son of Eliel, the son of Toah,
35 the son of Zuph, the son of Elkanah, the son of Mahath, the son of Amasai,
36 the son of Elkanah, the son of Joel, the son of Azariah, the son of Zephaniah,
37 the son of Tahath, the son of Assir, the son of Ebiasaph, the son of Korah,
38 the son of Izhar, the son of Kohath, the son of Levi, the son of Israel.
39 Heman's relative Asaph stood at his right side.
Asaph was the son of Berechiah, the son of Shimea,
40 the son of Michael, the son of Baaseiah, the son of Malchijah,
41 the son of Ethni, the son of Zerah, the son of Adaiah,
42 the son of Ethan, the son of Zimmah, the son of Shimei,
43 the son of Jahath, the son of Gershom, the son of Levi.
44 Their relatives, the descendants of Merari, stood at the left side.
There was Ethan, the son of Kishi, the son of Abdi, the son of Malluch,
45 the son of Hashabiah, the son of Amaziah, the son of Hilkiah,
46 the son of Amzi, the son of Bani, the son of Shemer,
47 the son of Mahli, the son of Mushi, the son of Merari, the son of Levi.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Music in worship is very important to Chronicles. David introduced it.

Three great families of singers: Heman (from the family of Kohath), Asaph (from the family of Gershom) and Ethan (from the family of Merari). They stood in the middle, on the right and on the left. Every family of the Levites was represented.

Heman was a grandson of the prophet Samuel.

Many psalms carry the names of these singers: Psalms 50 and 73–83 are "by Asaph", Psalm 88 "by Heman" and Psalm 89 "by Ethan". The "sons of Korah" (Psalms 42–49 and others) also belong to this family.

The list shows: these singers could trace their origin back over many generations to Levi and Jacob.

The tasks of the priests VERSES 48–53

48 Their relatives, the other Levites, were given all the other work
at the tabernacle, God's house.
49 But Aaron and his sons offered the sacrifices
on the altar of burnt offering and on the altar of incense.
They did all the work in the most holy place.
They made atonement for Israel.

They did everything that Moses, the servant of God,
had commanded.
50 These are the descendants of Aaron:
his son Eleazar,
his son Phinehas,
his son Abishua,
51 his son Bukki,
his son Uzzi,
his son Zerahiah,
52 his son Meraioth,
his son Amariah,
his son Ahitub,
53 his son Zadok,
and his son Ahimaaz.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The work was divided: the Levites helped with the service at the sanctuary. Only the priests, the descendants of Aaron, were allowed to offer the sacrifices and go into the sanctuary.

"To make atonement" means: through the sacrifices the guilt of the people was to be covered before God, and the fellowship with God was to be restored.

The list repeats the high priests up to Zadok and Ahimaaz, the time of David and Solomon.

The cities of the Levites VERSES 54–81

54 These are the places where they lived, the areas that were given to them.
The descendants of Aaron from the families of the Kohathites
were the first to be chosen by lot.
55 So they were given Hebron in the land of Judah,
together with the pasture land around it.
56 But the fields of the city and its villages were given to Caleb, the son of Jephunneh.
57 The descendants of Aaron were given the cities of refuge:
Hebron, Libnah with its pasture land,
Jattir, Eshtemoa with its pasture land,
58 Hilen with its pasture land, Debir with its pasture land,
59 Ashan with its pasture land, and Beth Shemesh with its pasture land.
60 From the tribe of Benjamin they were given
Geba with its pasture land, Allemeth with its pasture land,
and Anathoth with its pasture land.
Their families had 13 cities in all.
61 The other descendants of Kohath were given 10 cities by lot.
These cities came from the family of the tribe,
from the half-tribe of Manasseh.
62 The descendants of Gershom, family by family, were given 13 cities.
These cities came from the tribe of Issachar, the tribe of Asher, the tribe of Naphtali,
and the tribe of Manasseh in Bashan.
63 The descendants of Merari, family by family, were given 12 cities by lot.
These cities came from the tribe of Reuben, the tribe of Gad, and the tribe of Zebulun.
64 So the people of Israel gave the Levites these cities with their pasture land.
65 They gave them by lot
from the tribe of Judah, the tribe of Simeon,
and the tribe of Benjamin.
These are the cities that are named here.
66 Some of the families of the descendants of Kohath were given cities from the tribe of Ephraim.
67 They were given the cities of refuge:
Shechem in the hill country of Ephraim with its pasture land,
Gezer with its pasture land,
68 Jokmeam with its pasture land, Beth Horon with its pasture land,
69 Aijalon with its pasture land, and Gath Rimmon with its pasture land.
70 From the half-tribe of Manasseh
the rest of the family of the descendants of Kohath were given
Aner with its pasture land and Bileam with its pasture land.
71 The descendants of Gershom were given these cities:
from the family of the half-tribe of Manasseh,
Golan in Bashan with its pasture land and Ashtaroth with its pasture land;
72 from the tribe of Issachar,
Kedesh with its pasture land, Daberath with its pasture land,
73 Ramoth with its pasture land, and Anem with its pasture land;
74 from the tribe of Asher,
Mashal with its pasture land, Abdon with its pasture land,
75 Hukok with its pasture land, and Rehob with its pasture land;
76 from the tribe of Naphtali,
Kedesh in Galilee with its pasture land,
Hammon with its pasture land, and Kiriathaim with its pasture land.
77 The rest of the Levites, the descendants of Merari, were given these cities:
from the tribe of Zebulun,
Rimmono with its pasture land and Tabor with its pasture land;
78 from the tribe of Reuben, on the other side of the Jordan,
on the east side of the Jordan, across from Jericho,
Bezer in the wilderness with its pasture land, Jahzah with its pasture land,
79 Kedemoth with its pasture land, and Mephaath with its pasture land;
80 from the tribe of Gad,
Ramoth in Gilead with its pasture land, Mahanaim with its pasture land,
81 Heshbon with its pasture land, and Jazer with its pasture land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites did not get their own tribal land. Instead they got cities spread over the whole country, in the lands of the

other tribes (Numbers 35:1–8). So they were everywhere among the people and could teach the people God's law.

This list is also in Joshua 21 in a similar form. Some names are spelled a little differently, for example Hilen is called "Holon" there and Ashan is called "Ain" there.

"Cities of refuge" were cities to which someone could flee who had killed a person without meaning to. There he was safe from blood revenge until a court decided (Numbers 35:9–15). That was an early protection against people taking the law into their own hands.

Anathoth is the hometown of the prophet Jeremiah (Jeremiah 1:1).

In verse 57 it sounds as if all the cities named were cities of refuge. According to Joshua 21:13 only Hebron was a city of refuge.

In verses 61 and 77 the Hebrew text is shortened in some places. Joshua 21 names more cities here.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 7

The tribes in the north

Issachar VERSES 1–5

1 The sons of Issachar were
Tola, Puah, Jashub, and Shimron, four in all.
2 The sons of Tola were
Uzzi, Rephaiah, Jeriel, Jahmai, Ibsam, and Shemuel.
They were heads of their families in the family of Tola.
They were brave soldiers in their time.
When David was king, there were 22,600 of them.
3 The son of Uzzi was Izrahiah.
The sons of Izrahiah were
Michael, Obadiah, Joel, and Isshiah, five in all.
All of them were leaders.
4 Together with them, by their families,
there were troops ready for war, 36,000 men.
They had many wives and sons.
5 Their relatives in all the families of Issachar
were brave soldiers too.
In the family records there were 87,000 of them in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Issachar lived in the fertile Valley of Jezreel in the north. The judge Tola came from this tribe (Judges 10:1).

In verse 3 five are counted, but only four sons are named. Probably Izrahiah himself is counted too.

The numbers probably refer to a census under David (2 Samuel 24). They are very high. Some scholars think that the Hebrew word for "thousand" here means a unit of the army.

In Genesis 46:13 Puah is called "Puvah", and Jashub is called "Iob" there.

Benjamin VERSES 6–12

6 The sons of Benjamin were
Bela, Becher, and Jediael, three in all.
7 The sons of Bela were
Ezbon, Uzzi, Uzziel, Jerimoth, and Iri, five in all.
They were heads of their families and brave soldiers.
In the family records there were 22,034 of them.
8 The sons of Becher were
Zemirah, Joash, Eliezer, Elioenai, Omri, Jeremoth,
Abijah, Anathoth, and Alemeth.
All these were the sons of Becher.
9 They were written in the family records by their families.
They were heads of their families and brave soldiers,
20,200 in all.
10 The son of Jediael was Bilhan.
The sons of Bilhan were
Jeush, Benjamin, Ehud, Chenaanah, Zethan,
Tarshish, and Ahishahar.
11 All these were descendants of Jediael.
They were heads of their families and brave soldiers.
There were 17,200 men who could go out to war in the army.
12 Shuppim and Huppim were also there, the sons of Ir,
and Hushim, and the sons of Aher.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Benjamin was Jacob's youngest son. King Saul came from this tribe. Chapter 8 gives a longer list for Benjamin.

The names of Benjamin's sons are different in the different lists of the Bible (compare Genesis 46:21; Numbers 26:38–41; 1 Chronicles 8:1–5). Such lists were written down at different times.

Anathoth and Alemeth are also names of cities (1 Chronicles 6:60).

Verse 12 is hard to understand. Perhaps the names still belong to Benjamin. In Genesis 46:23 "Hushim" is a son of Dan. Some scholars think that the tribe of Dan was mentioned here at first. Otherwise Dan is missing in these lists.

Naphtali VERSE 13

13 The sons of Naphtali were
Jahziel, Guni, Jezer, Shallum,
and the sons of Bilhah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Naphtali gets only one single verse. Bilhah was the mother of Naphtali and Dan, a servant of Rachel (Genesis 30:4–8).

In Genesis 46:24 Shallum is called "Shillem".

Manasseh VERSES 14–19

14 The sons of Manasseh were
Asriel, whose mother was Manasseh's concubine, a woman from Aram.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
She also gave birth to Machir, the father of Gilead.
15 Machir took a wife from Huppim and Shuppim.
Their sister's name was Maacah.
The name of the second was Zelophehad.
Zelophehad had daughters.

16 Maacah, the wife of Machir, gave birth to a son.
She named him Peresh.
His brother was named Sheresh.
His sons were Ulam and Rakem.
17 The son of Ulam was Bedan.
These were the descendants of Gilead, the son of
Machir, the son of Manasseh.
18 His sister Hammolecheth gave birth to Ishhod,
Abiezer, and Mahlah.
19 The sons of Shemida were Ahian, Shechem, Likhi, and
Aniam.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Manasseh was a son of Joseph. His family had connections with the Arameans, as verse 14 shows.

Zelophehad had only daughters. These five daughters won the right before Moses that daughters could also inherit when there were no sons (Numbers 27:1–11). An important step for the rights of women.

Abiezer was the family that the judge Gideon came from (Judges 6:11).

In Hebrew this section is hard to understand in several places. The family relationships are not completely clear.

This means the half-tribe of Manasseh west of the Jordan. The other half-tribe was named in 1 Chronicles 5:23–24.

Ephraim VERSES 20–29

20 The descendants of Ephraim were
Shuthelah,
his son Bered,
his son Tahath,
his son Eleadah,
his son Tahath,
21 his son Zabad,
and his son Shuthelah.
Ephraim also had the sons Ezer and Elead.
The men of Gath, who were born in that land, killed
Ezer and Elead.
They had come down to take away their animals.
22 Their father Ephraim mourned for them a long time.
His brothers came to comfort him.
23 Then he slept with his wife.
She became pregnant and gave birth to a son.
Ephraim named him Beriah,
because trouble had come to his family.
24 Ephraim's daughter was Sheerah.
She built Lower Beth Horon and Upper Beth Horon,
and Uzzen Sheerah.
25 Then came his son Rephah,
his son Resheph,
his son Telah,
his son Tahan,
26 his son Ladan,
his son Ammihud,
his son Elishama,
27 his son Nun,
and his son Joshua.
28 Their land and the places where they lived were
Bethel and its towns,
Naaran to the east,
Gezer and its towns to the west,
and Shechem and its towns,
as far as Azzah and its towns.
29 Along the borders of the land of Manasseh there were
Beth Shean and its towns,
Taanach and its towns,
Megiddo and its towns,
and Dor and its towns.
The descendants of Joseph, the son of Israel, lived in
these places.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A sad little story: sons of Ephraim are killed during a cattle raid. Their father Ephraim mourns for a long time. His brothers come and comfort him. Then a new son is born to him. He names him Beriah, "in trouble". The name reminds us of the pain, but the child is also a new beginning.

A woman as a builder of towns: Sheerah, the daughter of Ephraim, built three places. That is something special in the Bible.

At the end of the line stands Joshua the son of Nun, the successor of Moses. He came from Ephraim.

A city's "towns" are the smaller places that belonged to a city.

"Azzah" here is not Gaza in the south, but probably a place in the hill country of Ephraim. Many Hebrew manuscripts have "Aiah" here.

Asher VERSES 30–40

30 The sons of Asher were
Imnah, Ishvah, Ishvi, and Beriah.
Their sister was Serah.
31 The sons of Beriah were
Heber and Malchiel.
Malchiel was the father of Birzaith.
32 Heber was the father of Japhlet, Shomer, and Hotham,
and of their sister Shua.
33 The sons of Japhlet were
Pasach, Bimhal, and Ashvath.
These are the children of Japhlet.
34 The sons of Shemer were
Ahi, Rohgah, Jehubbah, and Aram.
35 Helem was his brother.
The sons of Helem were
Zophah, Imna, Shelesh, and Amal.
36 The sons of Zophah were
Suah, Harnepher, Shual, Beri, Imrah,
37 Bezer, Hod, Shamma, Shilshah, Ithran, and Beera.
38 The sons of Jether were
Jephunneh, Pispa, and Ara.
39 The sons of Ulla were
Arah, Hanniel, and Rizia.
40 All these were descendants of Asher.
They were heads of their families,
the best men and brave soldiers,
the most important leaders.
In the family records there were 26,000 men who
could serve in war.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Asher lived in the northwest, on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea.

Serah, the sister, is already named in Genesis 46:17. There is a lovely Jewish legend: she is said to have brought old Jacob the news with a song that Joseph was still alive. This legend is not in the Bible.

Shemer (verse 34) is probably the same as Shomer (verse 32), and Helem is probably Hotham. Such small differences in spelling often happen in old lists.

Zebulun and Dan are not named in these lists. We do not know why.

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 8

The tribe of Benjamin and the family of Saul

Benjamin's sons and grandsons VERSES 1–7

1 Benjamin was the father of these sons:
Bela, his firstborn,
Ashbel, the second,
Aharah, the third,
2 Nohah, the fourth,
and Rapha, the fifth.
3 The sons of Bela were
Addar, Gera, Abihud,
4 Abishua, Naaman, Ahoah,
5 Gera, Shephuphan, and Huram.
6 These are the sons of Ehud.
They were the heads of the families who lived in Geba.
They were taken away as prisoners to Manahath.
7 They were Naaman, Ahijah, and Gera.
Gera took them away.
He was the father of Uzza and Ahihud.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Benjamin gets a second, longer list. There is a reason for this: King Saul came from Benjamin. And after the exile many Benjamites lived in and around Jerusalem.

The names are different from 1 Chronicles 7:6–12. The lists probably come from different times and sources.

Ehud is perhaps the judge Ehud, the left-handed man from Benjamin (Judges 3:15). We are not told where he belongs in the family.

It is unclear what being carried away to Manahath means. Perhaps a move within Benjamin.

Shaharaim and his descendants VERSES 8–28

8 Shaharaim had children in the country of Moab,
after he had sent them away.
Hushim and Baara were his wives.
9 With his wife Hodesh he had these sons:
Jobab, Zibia, Mesha, Malcam,
10 Jeuz, Shachia, and Mirmah.
These were his sons.
They were heads of families.
11 With Hushim he had the sons Abitub and Elpaal.
12 The sons of Elpaal were
Eber, Misham, and Shemed.
Shemed built Ono and Lod with its towns.
13 Then there were Beriah and Shema.
They were heads of the families who lived in Aijalon.
They chased away the people who lived in Gath.
14 Ahio, Shashak, Jeremoth,
15 Zebadiah, Arad, Eder,
16 Michael, Ishpah, and Joha were the sons of Beriah.
17 Zebadiah, Meshullam, Hizki, Heber,
18 Ishmerai, Izliah, and Jobab were the sons of Elpaal.
19 Jakim, Zichri, Zabdi,
20 Elienai, Zillethai, Eliel,
21 Adaiah, Beraiah, and Shimrath were the sons of
Shimei.
22 Ishpan, Eber, Eliel,
23 Abdon, Zichri, Hanan,
24 Hananiah, Elam, Anthothijah,
25 Iphdeiah and Penuel were the sons of Shashak.
26 Shamsherai, Shehariah, Athaliah,
27 Jaareshiah, Elijah, and Zichri were the sons of
Jeroham.
28 These were heads of families in their time.
They were leaders.
They lived in Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shaharaim lived in Moab for a time. Does this remind us of Ruth? Naomi's family was in Moab too (Ruth 1:1).

"Sent away" here probably means that he separated from his first wives. But he still had sons by Hushim (verse 11). The text is not completely clear here.

Ono and Lod are in the coastal plain. Today Lod is a city near Ben Gurion Airport, close to Tel Aviv.

Verse 28: These families lived in Jerusalem. Jerusalem lay on the border between Judah and Benjamin.

Here too there are names like Athaliah and Elijah. They are other people than the famous queen and the prophet.

The family of Saul VERSES 29–40

29 The father of Gibeon lived in Gibeon.
His wife's name was Maacah.
30 His firstborn son Abdon lived with him,
and Zur, Kish, Baal, Nadab,
31 Gedor, Ahio, Zecher,
32 and Mikloth.
Mikloth was the father of Shimeah.
They also lived with their families in Jerusalem, near
their relatives.
33 Ner was the father of Kish.
Kish was the father of Saul.
Saul was the father of Jonathan, Malchishua,
Abinadab, and Eshbaal.
34 The son of Jonathan was Merib-baal.
Merib-baal was the father of Micah.
35 The sons of Micah were
Pithon, Melech, Tarea, and Ahaz.

36 Ahaz was the father of Jehoaddah.
Jehoaddah was the father of Alemeth, Azmaveth, and Zimri.
Zimri was the father of Moza.
37 Moza was the father of Binea.
Binea's son was Raphah.
Raphah's son was Eleasah.
Eleasah's son was Azel.
38 Azel had six sons. These are their names:
Azrikam, Bocheru, Ishmael, Sheariah, Obadiah, and Hanan.
All these were the sons of Azel.
39 Azel's brother was Eshek.
The sons of Eshek were
Ulam, his firstborn,
Jeush, the second,
and Eliphelet, the third.
40 The sons of Ulam were brave soldiers and archers.
They had many sons and grandsons, 150 in all.
All these were descendants of Benjamin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is the family tree of King Saul. Saul is the first king of Israel, and Chronicles tells about his death in the next chapter. His family lived on, over many generations.

In 2 Samuel 2:8 "Eshbaal" is called "Ishbosheth", and "Merib-baal" is called "Mephibosheth" there (2 Samuel 4:4). At first "Baal" simply meant "lord" and could also be used for the God of Israel. Later, when "Baal" only reminded people of the idol, scribes often replaced it with "bosheth", which means "shame".

Mephibosheth was Jonathan's lame son whom David took care of (2 Samuel 9).

In verse 29 the name of the "father of Gibeon" is missing in Hebrew. In 1 Chronicles 9:35 he is called Jeiel. There Ner is also named among his sons. In verse 29 the WEB, our English source text, follows the Hebrew text.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 9

The people of Jerusalem after the return

Who lived in the land again? VERSES 1–9

1 So all Israel was listed in family records.
These records are written in the book of the kings of Israel.
Judah was taken away to Babylon as prisoners because of their disobedience.
2 The first people who lived on their own land in their cities
were Israelites, priests, Levites, and temple servants.
3 Some people of Judah, of Benjamin, and of Ephraim and Manasseh
lived in Jerusalem.
These were:
4 Uthai, the son of Ammihud.
Ammihud was the son of Omri, Omri the son of Imri, and Imri the son of Bani.
They were descendants of Perez, the son of Judah.
5 From the Shilonites:
Asaiah, the firstborn, and his sons.
6 From the sons of Zerah:
Jeuel and their relatives.
There were 690 of them.
7 From the tribe of Benjamin:
Sallu, the son of Meshullam.
Meshullam was the son of Hodaviah, and Hodaviah the son of Hassenuah.
8 Also Ibneiah, the son of Jeroham.
Also Elah, the son of Uzzi. Uzzi was the son of Michri.
Also Meshullam, the son of Shephatiah.
Shephatiah was the son of Reuel, and Reuel the son of Ibnijah.
9 With them were their relatives, listed by their generations.
There were 956 of them.
All these men were heads of families in their clans.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With verse 1, Chronicles closes the long family trees. Then it makes a big jump: from the exile to the return.

"Because of their disobedience": Chronicles honestly says why Judah had to go into exile.

Then it shows the hope: people come back and live in Jerusalem again. This list is similar to Nehemiah 11.

Remarkable: not only Judah and Benjamin, but also people from Ephraim and Manasseh, that is, from the old northern kingdom, live in Jerusalem again. For Chronicles, "all Israel" belongs together.

"Temple servants" (in Hebrew "Nethinim") were helpers in the temple service who did not belong to the Levites.

"Shilonites" are probably descendants of Shelah, the son of Judah.

The priests VERSES 10–13

10 From the priests:
Jedaiah, Jehoiarib, and Jachin.
11 Also Azariah, the son of Hilkiah.
Hilkiah was the son of Meshullam, Meshullam the son of Zadok,
Zadok the son of Meraioth, and Meraioth the son of Ahitub.
Azariah was the ruler of God's house.
12 Also Adaiah, the son of Jeroham.
Jeroham was the son of Pashhur, and Pashhur the son of Malchijah.
Also Maasai, the son of Adiel.
Adiel was the son of Jahzerah, Jahzerah the son of Meshullam,
Meshullam the son of Meshillemith, and
Meshillemith the son of Immer.
13 With them were their relatives, the heads of their clans.
There were 1,760 of them.

They were very able men.
They did the work of serving in God's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The priests come back too. Jedaiah and Jehoiarib are names of groups of priests (1 Chronicles 24:7). The Maccabees, a famous Jewish family in the 2nd century BC, came from the group of Jehoiarib.

"The ruler of God's house": that was a high office in the temple, perhaps the high priest or his deputy.

The Levites and the gatekeepers VERSES 14–27

14 From the Levites:
Shemaiah, the son of Hasshub.
Hasshub was the son of Azrikam, and Azrikam the son of Hashabiah.
They were descendants of Merari.
15 Also Bakbakkar, Heresh, and Galal.
Also Mattaniah, the son of Mica.
Mica was the son of Zichri, and Zichri the son of Asaph.
16 Also Obadiah, the son of Shemaiah.
Shemaiah was the son of Galal, and Galal the son of Jeduthun.
Also Berechiah, the son of Asa. Asa was the son of Elkanah.
Berechiah lived in the villages of the Netophathites.
17 The gatekeepers were:
Shallum, Akkub, Talmon, Ahiman, and their relatives.
Shallum was their chief.
18 Before this, they had kept watch at the King's Gate on the east side.
They were the gatekeepers for the camp of the Levites.
19 Shallum was the son of Kore.
Kore was the son of Ebiasaph, and Ebiasaph the son of Korah.
Shallum and his relatives from his family, the Korahites, were in charge of the work.
They guarded the doorways of the tent.
Their ancestors had been in charge of the LORD's camp.
They had guarded the entrance.
20 In earlier times Phinehas, the son of Eleazar, was their leader.
And the LORD was with him.
21 Zechariah, the son of Meshelemiah, was the gatekeeper at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
22 In all, 212 men were chosen to guard the doorways.
They were listed in the family records of their villages.
David and Samuel the seer had given them this position of trust.
A seer is a prophet.
23 So they and their descendants were in charge of the gates of the LORD's house.
That is the house of the tent.
They kept watch there.
24 The gatekeepers stood on all four sides:
on the east, the west, the north, and the south.
25 Their relatives lived in their villages.
From time to time they had to come for seven days and help them.
26 The four chief gatekeepers were Levites.
They had a position of trust.
They were in charge of the rooms and the treasuries in God's house.
27 They stayed around God's house,
because it was their duty to guard it.
And it was their duty to open it every morning.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The gatekeepers were important: they guarded the temple day and night, opened it in the morning and made sure that nothing unclean came in. They also had oversight over the treasures.

Chronicles traces their service back to very old times: to the time in the wilderness, to Phinehas, to Samuel and David. In this way it shows: the worship after the return stands in a long, faithful tradition.

They worked in turns: those who lived in the villages came to Jerusalem to serve for seven days at a time.

Jeduthun was one of David's great singers (1 Chronicles 16:41).

More tasks in the temple VERSES 28–34

28 Some of them took care of the things used in the service.
They counted them when they brought them in.
And they counted them when they took them out.
29 Others were in charge of the furniture
and of all the holy objects of the sanctuary.
They also took care of the fine flour, the wine, the oil, the frankincense, and the spices.
30 Some of the sons of the priests mixed the spices.
31 Mattithiah was one of the Levites.
He was the firstborn son of Shallum the Korahite.
He had the position of trust over the things that were baked in pans.
32 Some of their relatives from the Kohathites
were in charge of the showbread.
They prepared it every Sabbath.
33 These are the singers.
They were heads of Levite families.
They lived in the rooms of the temple.
They did not have to do other work,
because they were busy with their own work day and night.
34 These were the heads of the Levite families, listed by their generations.
They were leaders.
They lived in Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the temple there were many different tasks: counting and keeping the vessels, taking care of flour, wine, oil and frankincense, mixing spices for the holy anointing oil, baking bread.

The "showbread" was 12 loaves of bread that were put fresh on a table in the sanctuary every week, one for each tribe of Israel (Leviticus 24:5–9).

The singers praised God "day and night." That reminds us of Psalm 134: "Praise the LORD, all you servants of the LORD, who stand in the LORD's house at night!"

Every task has its place, whether gatekeeper, baker or singer. Together they all serve God.

Once more: the family of Saul VERSES 35–44

35 Jeiel, the father of Gibeon, lived in Gibeon.
His wife's name was Maacah.
36 His firstborn son was Abdon.
Then came Zur, Kish, Baal, Ner, Nadab,
37 Gedor, Ahio, Zechariah, and Mikloth.
38 Mikloth was the father of Shimeam.
They also lived with their families in Jerusalem, near their relatives.
39 Ner was the father of Kish.
Kish was the father of Saul.
Saul was the father of Jonathan, Malchishua, Abinadab, and Eshbaal.
40 The son of Jonathan was Merib-baal.
Merib-baal was the father of Micah.
41 The sons of Micah were
Pithon, Melech, Tahrea, and Ahaz.
42 Ahaz was the father of Jarah.
Jarah was the father of Alemeth, Azmaveth, and Zimri.
Zimri was the father of Moza.
43 Moza was the father of Binea.
Binea's son was Rephaiah.
Rephaiah's son was Eleasah.
Eleasah's son was Azel.
44 Azel had six sons. These are their names:
Azrikam, Bocheru, Ishmael, Sheariah, Obadiah, and Hanan.
These were the sons of Azel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The family of Saul is named here a second time (compare 1 Chronicles 8:29–38). This is not a mistake: this list forms the bridge to the next chapter. There the real story begins, with the death of Saul.

Small differences from Chapter 8: here the son of Micah is called "Tahrea" instead of "Tarea," the son of Ahaz "Jarah" instead of "Jehoaddah," and the son of Binea "Rephaiah" instead of "Raphah." Such differences came about when the text was copied over the centuries.

With this the family trees end. From Chapter 10 on, Chronicles tells the story of David.

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 10

Saul's death

The battle on Mount Gilboa VERSES 1–7

1 The Philistines fought against Israel.
The men of Israel ran away from the Philistines.
Many of them were killed on Mount Gilboa.
2 The Philistines chased Saul and his sons.
They killed Saul's sons Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malchishua.
3 The fighting was hard around Saul.
The archers found him.
He was in great trouble because of the archers.
4 Then Saul said to the young man who carried his weapons,
"Pull out your sword and stab me with it.
Otherwise these uncircumcised men will come and treat me cruelly."
But the young man did not want to do it.
He was terrified.
So Saul took his own sword and fell on it.
5 The young man saw that Saul was dead.
Then he too fell on his sword and died.
6 So Saul died, and his three sons died.
All his house died together.
7 The men of Israel in the valley saw that the army had run away.
They saw that Saul and his sons were dead.
So they left their cities and ran away.
And the Philistines came and lived in them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chronicles does not begin its story with Saul's rise, but with his death. Above all it wants to tell about David. The story is told in more detail in 1 Samuel 31.

In his despair Saul takes his own life. The Bible tells this without making it look better and without condemning him.

If you yourself are in a situation where you see no way out: you are not alone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

"All his house died together": this is said very sharply. Saul's son Ishbosheth and his grandson Mephibosheth were still alive (2 Samuel 2 and 4). Chronicles wants to say: Saul's rule as king was over.

Mount Gilboa is in the north, at the edge of the Valley of Jezreel.

The men of Jabesh honor Saul VERSES 8–12

8 On the next day the Philistines came to take things from the dead.
They found Saul and his sons lying dead on Mount Gilboa.
9 They took his clothes and his armor.
They cut off his head.
Then they sent messengers all around the land of the Philistines.
They spread the news to their idols and to the people.
10 They put his armor in the house of their gods.
And they hung up his head in the house of Dagon.
11 All the people of Jabesh Gilead heard everything the Philistines had done to Saul.
12 Then all the brave men set out.
They took the body of Saul and the bodies of his sons and brought them to Jabesh.
They buried their bones under the oak tree in Jabesh.

Then they fasted for seven days.
To fast means: not to eat.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Philistines celebrate their victory as a victory of their gods. Dagon was a god of the Philistines.

The men of Jabesh risk their lives to give Saul a worthy burial. They had not forgotten that Saul had once saved them (1 Samuel 11). Thankfulness and faithfulness beyond death.

Why Saul died VERSES 13–14

13 So Saul died because he was unfaithful to the LORD.
He did not keep the LORD's word.
He also asked a medium for advice.
A medium is a person who tries to speak with the spirits of the dead.
14 He did not ask the LORD.
So the LORD put him to death.
And he gave the kingdom to David, the son of Jesse.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chronicles explains Saul's death: he did not keep God's word (1 Samuel 13 and 15), and he asked a medium at Endor (1 Samuel 28). He looked for advice from others instead of from God.

"The LORD put him to death": Chronicles sees God acting behind everything. Saul himself ended his life. But God let his rule come to an end.

1 Samuel 28:6 says that Saul did ask the LORD, but got no answer. Chronicles probably means: he did not truly seek God with his whole heart.

With this the way is open for David, whom the rest of the book is about.

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 11

David becomes king and conquers Jerusalem

David becomes king over all Israel VERSES 1–3

1 Then all Israel came together to David at Hebron.
They said,
"We are your bone and your flesh.
2 Even in the past, when Saul was king,
you were the one who led Israel out to battle and brought them back.
The LORD your God said to you,
'You will be the shepherd of my people Israel.
You will be the leader of my people Israel.'"
3 So all the leaders of Israel came to the king at Hebron.
David made a covenant with them there in Hebron, before the LORD.
A covenant is a binding agreement.
They anointed David as king over Israel.
This happened just as the LORD had said through Samuel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"We are your bone and your flesh" means: we are your relatives, we belong together.

Chronicles tells it briefly. It leaves out the seven years in which David reigned only over Judah and was in conflict with Saul's family (2 Samuel 2–4). What matters to Chronicles is this: "all Israel" stands behind David.

"Shepherd" means: someone who leads and provides like a shepherd. David himself had been a shepherd. A king should take care of his people like a good shepherd takes care of his sheep.

The covenant shows: the king too has duties before God and before the people.

The conquest of Jerusalem VERSES 4–9

4 David and all Israel went to Jerusalem.
Jerusalem was also called Jebus.
The Jebusites lived there.
They were the people of the land.
5 The people of Jebus said to David,
"You will not get in here!"
But David captured the fortress of Zion.
It is the City of David.
6 David had said,
"The first man to attack the Jebusites will become chief and commander."
Joab, the son of Zeruiah, went up first.
So he became chief.
7 David lived in the fortress.
That is why people called it the City of David.
8 David built up the city all around,
from the Millo all the way around.
Joab repaired the rest of the city.
9 David became more and more powerful,
because the LORD of Armies was with him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem was an old city of the Jebusites, on a hill with steep slopes. People thought no one could conquer it. David conquers it and makes it his capital (compare 2 Samuel 5:6–10).

Jerusalem lay between the lands of Judah and Benjamin, that is, between south and north. A good choice to unite the whole people.

"Zion" was first the name of the stronghold. Later it became the name for all of Jerusalem and a picture for the place where God lives.

"Millo" was probably a raised mound of earth or a terrace on which buildings stood.

Chronicles explains why Joab became army commander: he was the first in the attack.

The most important sentence: "The LORD of Armies was with him." David's success came from God.

David's mighty men: the three VERSES 10–14

10 These are the leaders of David's mighty men.
They gave him strong support in his kingdom.
Together with all Israel they made him king,
just as the LORD had promised Israel.

11 This is the list of David's mighty men:
Jashobeam, the son of a Hachmonite.
He was the leader of the thirty.
He raised his spear against 300 men
and killed them all at one time.
12 Next came Eleazar, the son of Dodo, the Ahohite.
He was one of the three mighty men.
13 He was with David at Pasdammim.
The Philistines had gathered there for battle.
There was a field full of barley.
The people ran away from the Philistines.
14 But they took their stand in the middle of the field.
They defended it and killed the Philistines.
And the LORD saved them with a great victory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David had a group of especially brave warriors: "the three" and "the thirty." The list is also in 2 Samuel 23:8–39.

There Jashobeam is called "Josheb Basshebeth." And there he kills 800 instead of 300.

In 2 Samuel 23 a third mighty man is named, Shammah, who also defended a field. Chronicles has shortened this part. That is why here the field is "full of barley," while in 2 Samuel 23:11 it is a field full of lentils.

Here too the text stresses: not the mighty men alone, but the LORD gave the victory.

The water from Bethlehem VERSES 15–19

15 Three of the thirty leaders went down to the rock,
to David at the cave of Adullam.
The army of the Philistines was camped in the Valley of Rephaim.
16 At that time David was in the fortress.
And a troop of Philistine soldiers was in Bethlehem.
17 David had a deep longing.
He said,
"Oh, if only someone would bring me water to drink
from the well by the gate of Bethlehem!"
18 So the three men broke through the army of the Philistines.
They drew water from the well by the gate of Bethlehem
and brought it to David.
But David would not drink it.
Instead he poured it out as an offering to the LORD.
19 He said,
"My God, I must never do this!
Should I drink the blood of these men?
They put their lives in danger!"
They had risked their lives to bring the water.
So David would not drink it.
These are the things the three mighty men did.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David longs for the water from his hometown Bethlehem. Three of his men risk their lives to bring it to him.

But David does not drink it. He pours it out as an offering for God. He says: this water is as precious as the life of my men. I must not simply take it for myself.

A beautiful story about faithfulness, friendship and respect for the lives of others.

Abishai and Benaiah VERSES 20–25

20 Abishai, the brother of Joab, was the leader of the three.
He raised his spear against 300 men and killed them.
So he became famous along with the three.
21 He had more honor than the other two of the three,
and he became their commander.
But he was not one of the three.
22 Benaiah was the son of Jehoiada.
Jehoiada was a brave man from Kabzeel.
Benaiah did great deeds.
He killed the two sons of Ariel of Moab.
He also went down into a pit on a snowy day and killed a lion there.
23 He killed an Egyptian.
The Egyptian was a very tall man, about 7½ feet tall.
The Egyptian had a spear in his hand.
It was as thick as the beam of a loom.
Benaiah went down to him with a staff.
He grabbed the spear out of the Egyptian's hand
and killed him with his own spear.
24 These are the things Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada, did.
He became famous along with the three mighty men.
25 He had more honor than the thirty.
But he was not one of the three.
David put him in charge of his bodyguard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Hebrew verses 20 and 21 are hard to understand. Abishai was a captain, but did not belong to the first three. Perhaps he was the leader of a second group of three.

Later, under Solomon, Benaiah became the highest army commander (1 Kings 2:35).

The Bible says "five cubits." A cubit is about 18 inches.

A loom is a frame for weaving cloth. Its beam was a thick wooden bar. Goliath's spear is described in the same way (1 Samuel 17:7).

The thirty VERSES 26–47

26 These were also mighty men of the army:
Asahel, the brother of Joab;
Elhanan, the son of Dodo, from Bethlehem;
27 Shammoth the Harorite;
Helez the Pelonite;
28 Ira, the son of Ikkesh, the Tekoite;
Abiezer the Anathothite;
29 Sibbecai the Hushathite;
Ilai the Ahohite;
30 Maharai the Netophathite;
Heled, the son of Baanah, the Netophathite;
31 Ithai, the son of Ribai, from Gibeah in the tribe of Benjamin;
Benaiah the Pirathonite;
32 Hurai from the streams of Gaash;
Abiel the Arbathite;
33 Azmaveth the Baharumite;
Eliahba the Shaalbonite;
34 the sons of Hashem the Gizonite;
Jonathan, the son of Shagee, the Hararite;
35 Ahiam, the son of Sacar, the Hararite;
Eliphal, the son of Ur;

36 Hepher the Mecherathite;
Ahijah the Pelonite;
37 Hezro the Carmelite;
Naarai, the son of Ezbai;
38 Joel, the brother of Nathan;
Mibhar, the son of Hagri;
39 Zelek the Ammonite;
Naharai the Berothite, who carried the weapons of Joab, the son of Zeruiah;
40 Ira the Ithrite;
Gareb the Ithrite;
41 Uriah the Hittite;
Zabad, the son of Ahlai;
42 Adina, the son of Shiza, the Reubenite.
He was a leader of the Reubenites, and he had 30 men with him.
43 Hanan, the son of Maacah;
Joshaphat the Mithnite;
44 Uzzia the Ashterathite;
Shama and Jeiel, the sons of Hotham the Aroerite;
45 Jediael, the son of Shimri,
and his brother Joha, the Tizite;
46 Eliel the Mahavite;
Jeribai and Joshaviah, the sons of Elnaam;
Ithmah the Moabite;
47 Eliel, Obed, and Jaasiel the Mezobaite.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here all the mighty men are named. Many are otherwise unknown. But what they did is not forgotten.

Among them is also Uriah the Hittite. He was faithful, and David did him a great wrong: he took his wife Bathsheba from him and had him killed in the war (2 Samuel 11). Chronicles does not tell this story, but it names Uriah in the list of the mighty men.

There are also foreigners among the mighty men: an Ammonite, a Moabite and a Hittite. They firmly belonged to David's men.

The list is longer than in 2 Samuel 23. The names from verse 42 on are only here. Many names are a little different from 2 Samuel 23, for example "Shammoth the Harorite" instead of "Shammah the Harodite."

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 12

Everyone comes to David

Mighty men from Benjamin at Ziklag VERSES 1–7

1 These are the men who came to David at Ziklag.
At that time David was still hiding from Saul, the son of Kish.
These men were among the mighty men who helped David in war.
2 They were armed with bows.
They could sling stones and shoot arrows with the right hand and with the left.
They were relatives of Saul from the tribe of Benjamin.
3 Their leader was Ahiezer.
Then came Joash.
They were the sons of Shemaah the Gibeathite.
Then came Jeziel and Pelet, the sons of Azmaveth;
Beracah; Jehu the Anathothite;
4 Ishmaiah the Gibeonite.
He was a mighty man among the thirty and a leader of the thirty.
Then came Jeremiah; Jahaziel; Johanan; Jozabad the Gederathite;
5 Eluzai; Jerimoth; Bealiah; Shemariah; Shephatiah the Haruphite;
6 the Korahites Elkanah, Isshiah, Azarel, Joezer, and Jashobeam;
7 and Joelah and Zebadiah, the sons of Jeroham from Gedor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even when David was still running away from Saul, men came to him, even from Saul's own tribe of Benjamin. They saw: God's blessing is on David.

Ziklag was a town that the king of the Philistines had given to David (1 Samuel 27:6).

The Benjamites were famous for their skill with both hands (Judges 20:16).

In some Bibles the verse numbering in this chapter is shifted by one from here on: verse 4 here is verses 4 and 5 there. Verse 5 here is verse 6 there, and so on up to verse 40 here, which is verse 41 there.

Mighty men from Gad VERSES 8–15

8 Some men from the tribe of Gad joined David
at the fortress in the wilderness.
They were brave, mighty men.
They were trained for war.
They could fight with shield and spear.
Their faces looked like the faces of lions.
They were as fast as gazelles on the mountains.
These were the men:
9 Ezer was the leader.
Obadiah was second.
Eliab was third.
10 Mishmannah was fourth.
Jeremiah was fifth.
11 Attai was sixth.
Eliel was seventh.
12 Johanan was eighth.
Elzabad was ninth.
13 Jeremiah was tenth.
Machbannai was eleventh.
14 These men from Gad were commanders in the army.
The one who was least was equal to 100,
and the greatest to 1,000.
15 They crossed the Jordan in the first month of the year.
At that time the river was flooding over all its banks.

They chased away everyone who lived in the valleys,
to the east and to the west.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Gadites came from the other side of the Jordan. They crossed the river in spring, when it floods because the snow melts on Mount Hermon. That shows their courage and their determination.

"Like lions and gazelles": strong and fast.

"The one who was least was equal to 100" can also mean: the least was captain over 100, the greatest over 1,000.

Mighty men from Benjamin and Judah VERSES 16–18

16 Some men from Benjamin and Judah also came to
David at the fortress.
17 David went out to meet them.
He said to them,
"Have you come to me in peace to help me?
Then my heart will be one with yours.
I have done nothing wrong.
But maybe you have come to hand me over to my
enemies.
Then may the God of our ancestors see it and punish
it."
18 Then the Spirit came on Amasai, the leader of the
thirty.
He said,
"We are yours, David.
We are on your side, son of Jesse.
Peace, peace be to you.
And peace be to those who help you.
For your God helps you."
So David welcomed them.
He made them commanders of his troops.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is careful. He does not know whether the men are friends or traitors. He asks openly and puts the matter into God's hands.

Moved by God's Spirit, Amasai answers with a confession: "We are yours, David." "Peace, peace be to you." "For your God helps you." Three times the word "peace" (in Hebrew "shalom").

That is the heart of this chapter: people from all the tribes see that God is with David, and they join him.

Mighty men from Manasseh VERSES 19–22

19 Some men from Manasseh also joined David.
That was when David went with the Philistines to fight
against Saul.
But David and his men did not help the Philistines.
The rulers of the Philistines talked it over.
Then they sent David away.
They said,
"He will go back to his master Saul.
And then it will cost us our heads."
20 David went to Ziklag.
On the way some men from Manasseh joined him:
Adnah, Jozabad, Jediael, Michael, Jozabad, Elihu, and
Zillethai.
They were commanders of thousands from Manasseh.
21 They helped David fight against the band of raiders.
They were all brave, mighty men.
And they were commanders in the army.
22 Day after day more men came to David to help him.
At last he had a great army, like the army of God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19 reminds us of 1 Samuel 29: at that time David lived among the Philistines and was supposed to fight with them against Saul. But the Philistines did not trust him and sent him back. So David did not have to fight against his own people.

"The band of raiders" means the Amalekites who had attacked Ziklag (1 Samuel 30).

"Like God's army" means: a very large, mighty army.

The great gathering at Hebron VERSES 23–37

23 Many armed soldiers came to David at Hebron.
They came to give Saul's kingdom to David,
just as the LORD had said.
Here are the numbers of the leaders:
24 From Judah, men who carried shield and spear:
6,800 men ready for war.
25 From Simeon, brave, mighty men for war:
7,100.
26 From Levi:
4,600.
27 Jehoiada was the leader of the family of Aaron.
With him were 3,700 men.
28 Also Zadok, a young man who was strong and brave.
With him came 22 commanders from his family.
29 From Benjamin, the relatives of Saul:
3,000.
Until then most of them had stayed loyal to Saul's
family.
30 From Ephraim:
20,800 brave, mighty men.
They were famous in their families.
31 From the half-tribe of Manasseh:
18,000.
They had been chosen by name
to come and make David king.
32 From Issachar:
200 leaders.
They understood the times and knew what Israel
should do.
All their relatives followed their orders.
33 From Zebulun:
50,000 men who were able to go out with the army.
They could line up for battle with all kinds of weapons.
They were able to lead.
And they did not have a double heart.
That means: They were completely loyal.
34 From Naphtali:
1,000 commanders.
With them were 37,000 men with shield and spear.
35 From Dan:
28,600 men who could line up for battle.
36 From Asher:
40,000 men who were able to go out with the army
and could line up for battle.
37 From the other side of the Jordan,
from Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh:

120,000 men with all kinds of weapons for battle.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

All 12 tribes come to Hebron to make David king. The Levites come too. For Chronicles this is a high point: all Israel is one.

The men from Issachar "understood the times": they had a good sense for the right moment and for what needed to be done. A gift that is valuable today as well.

Zebulun "did not have a double heart": they stood with David fully and honestly.

Interesting: the fewest men come from Judah, David's own tribe. Most come from the tribes that are far away. Perhaps because Judah had already stood with David before.

The numbers are very large, together more than 300,000. As with other old numbers, it is unclear how exactly they are meant.

Jehoiada is probably the father of Benaiah (1 Chronicles 11:22). Zadok later became the high priest under David and Solomon.

A great feast VERSES 38–40

38 All these soldiers could line up for battle.
They came to Hebron with their whole heart
to make David king over all Israel.
All the rest of Israel also agreed with one heart
to make David king.
39 They stayed there with David for three days.
They ate and drank.
Their relatives had prepared food for them.
40 Also their neighbors, as far away as Issachar, Zebulun,
and Naphtali,
brought food on donkeys, camels, mules, and oxen.
They brought plenty of flour, fig cakes, bunches of
raisins, wine, oil, cattle, and sheep.
For there was joy in Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The chapter ends with a great feast. For three days the people eat and drink together. Everyone brings something, even those who live far away.

"With their whole heart" and "with one heart": the people are united.

The last sentence sums everything up: "There was joy in Israel." When God's people come together and God is in the middle, joy is born.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 13

The first attempt to bring the ark

David wants to bring the ark to Jerusalem VERSES 1–8

1 David talked with the commanders of thousands and of
hundreds.
He talked with every leader.
2 Then David said to the whole assembly of Israel,
"If you think it is good,
and if it comes from the LORD our God,
let us send messengers everywhere.
Let us send them to our relatives who are left in all the
land of Israel.
The priests and Levites live with them in their cities
with pastures.
Let us ask them all to come together to us.
3 And let us bring the ark of our God back to us.
We did not seek it in the days of Saul."
4 The whole assembly agreed to do it.
All the people thought it was the right thing.
5 So David gathered all Israel together,
from the Shihor River of Egypt to the entrance of
Hamath.
They came to bring God's ark from Kiriath Jearim.
6 David and all Israel went up to Baalah.
Baalah is Kiriath Jearim, which belonged to Judah.
They wanted to bring up from there the ark of God,
the LORD.
The LORD sits on his throne above the cherubim.
Cherubim are heavenly beings.
The ark is called by his Name.
7 They put God's ark on a new cart
and brought it out of Abinadab's house.
Uzza and Ahio drove the cart.
8 David and all Israel celebrated before God with all their
strength.
They sang songs.
They played harps, lyres, tambourines, cymbals, and
trumpets.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chronicles tells the story of the ark differently from 2 Samuel 6: right after David has become king, he takes care of the ark. Worship is the most important thing to him.

David asks the assembly and wants God's will. He includes everyone, also the priests and Levites.

The ark was the sign that God was present. It had stood forgotten in Kiriath Jearim for about 20 years (1 Samuel 7:1–2). "We did not seek it in the days of Saul" (1 Chronicles 13:3). That means: under Saul, God had been pushed to the edge.

The Shihor is a river at the border of Egypt. "The entrance of Hamath" (Lebo Hamath) is far in the north. The whole land is there.

It is a great celebration with a lot of music.

Uzza dies VERSES 9–14

9 They came to the threshing floor of Chidon.
There the oxen stumbled.
So Uzza reached out his hand to hold the ark.
10 Then the LORD became very angry with Uzza.
He struck him down, because Uzza had put his hand on
the ark.
Uzza died there before God.
11 David was upset,
because the LORD had broken out against Uzza.

He called that place Perez Uzza.
It still has that name today.
12 That day David was afraid of God.
He said,
"How can I ever bring God's ark home to me?"
13 So David did not take the ark with him into the City of David.
Instead he took it aside to the house of Obed-Edom the Gittite.
14 God's ark stayed with the family of Obed-Edom in his house for three months.
And the LORD blessed Obed-Edom's family and everything he had.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is very hard. Uzza only wants to help, and he dies. That seems unfair to us.

Chronicles explains it in 1 Chronicles 15:13: the ark should not have been carried on a cart. It should have been carried by Levites on poles (Numbers 4:15). That is how the Philistines had done it (1 Samuel 6:7), not as God had commanded. And no one was allowed to touch the holy objects.

The story wants to say: God's holiness is serious. God is not an object that you can use according to your own ideas. Still, something hard and hard to understand remains. David too was angry and afraid. He was allowed to show this before God.

"Perez Uzza" means "breaking out against Uzza."

Obed-Edom came from Gath. Perhaps he was a Philistine, perhaps a Levite from the Levite town of Gath Rimmon. His house is blessed: the ark brings blessing when people respect it.

In 2 Samuel 6:6 the threshing floor is called "the threshing floor of Nacon."

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 14

David becomes strong

David's house and family VERSES 1–7

1 Hiram, the king of Tyre, sent messengers to David.
He sent cedar wood, stoneworkers, and carpenters.
They were to build a house for David.
2 David understood that the LORD had made him king over Israel and made his rule firm.
His kingdom was raised up very high,
for the sake of his people Israel.
3 In Jerusalem David married more wives.
He became the father of more sons and daughters.
4 These are the names of the children he had in Jerusalem:
Shammua, Shobab, Nathan, Solomon,
5 Ibhar, Elishua, Elpelet,
6 Nogah, Nepheg, Japhia,
7 Elishama, Beeliada, and Eliphelet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hiram was king of the Phoenicians in Tyre, in today's Lebanon. He was a friend of David and later also of Solomon.

An important sentence: David understands that God has made him great, and that it is "for the sake of his people Israel." The king's power is not there for himself, but for the people.

David took more wives. That was usual for kings back then, but the law warned against it (Deuteronomy 17:17).

The names of the sons are also in 1 Chronicles 3:5–8 and 2 Samuel 5:14–16, with small differences. "Beeliada" is called "Eliada" there. The "Baal" (lord) was often avoided later.

Two victories over the Philistines VERSES 8–17

8 The Philistines heard that David had been anointed king over all Israel.
So all the Philistines went up to search for David.
David heard about it and went out to fight them.
9 The Philistines had come and attacked the Valley of Rephaim.
10 David asked God,
"Should I go up and fight the Philistines?
Will you give them into my power?"
The LORD answered him,
"Go up.
I will give them into your power."
11 So they went up to Baal Perazim.
There David defeated the Philistines.
David said,
"God has broken through my enemies by my hand,
like water that breaks through."
That is why the place is called Baal Perazim.
12 The Philistines left their gods there.
David gave an order, and the gods were burned.
13 The Philistines attacked the valley again.
14 So David asked God again.
God answered him,
"Do not go up after them.
Go around them.
Attack them in front of the mulberry trees.
15 You will hear the sound of marching in the tops of the mulberry trees.
Then go out to battle.
For God has gone out ahead of you
to strike the army of the Philistines."
16 David did what God commanded him.
They struck down the army of the Philistines from Gibeon all the way to Gezer.
17 David became famous in all lands.
And the LORD made all nations afraid of him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Unlike Saul, David asks God before every battle, and each time anew. The second time he gets a completely different instruction. God's way is not always the same. That is why it is worth asking again and again.

"Baal Perazim" means "lord of breaking through." God breaks through the enemies like a flood through a dam.

The Philistines had taken the images of their gods with them into battle. David has them burned, as the law demands (Deuteronomy 7:25). 2 Samuel 5:21 only says that David and his men took them away.

The sound in the treetops is a sign: God himself goes ahead of the army.

"Mulberry trees": it is not certain which trees exactly are meant. Some translate "baca trees" or "balsam trees."

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 15

The ark comes to Jerusalem

This time the right way VERSES 1–15

1 David built houses for himself in the City of David.
He prepared a place for God's ark
and set up a tent for it.
2 Then David said,
"No one may carry God's ark except the Levites.
The LORD chose them to carry God's ark
and to serve him forever."
3 David gathered all Israel in Jerusalem.
They were to bring the LORD's ark up to the place he had prepared for it.
4 David called together the descendants of Aaron and the Levites:
5 from the descendants of Kohath:
Uriel, the leader, and 120 of his relatives;
6 from the descendants of Merari:
Asaiah, the leader, and 220 of his relatives;
7 from the descendants of Gershom:
Joel, the leader, and 130 of his relatives;
8 from the descendants of Elizaphan:
Shemaiah, the leader, and 200 of his relatives;
9 from the descendants of Hebron:
Eliel, the leader, and 80 of his relatives;
10 from the descendants of Uzziel:
Amminadab, the leader, and 112 of his relatives.
11 David called the priests Zadok and Abiathar.
He also called the Levites Uriel, Asaiah, Joel,
Shemaiah, Eliel, and Amminadab.
12 He said to them,
"You are the heads of the Levite families.
Make yourselves holy, you and your relatives.
Then bring the ark of the LORD, the God of Israel,
up to the place I have prepared for it.
13 The first time you did not carry it.
So the LORD our God broke out in anger against us.
We did not seek him according to the rule."
14 So the priests and the Levites made themselves holy.
Then they could bring up the ark of the LORD, the God of Israel.
15 The Levites carried God's ark on their shoulders with its poles.
They did it as Moses had commanded, just as the LORD had said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David has learned from the mistake. He says openly: "We did not seek him according to the rule." He does not look for someone to blame, but says "we."

Now they do it the right way: the Levites carry the ark on their shoulders, with poles, as it says in Exodus 25:14 and Numbers 7:9.

"Make yourselves holy" means: get ready, make yourselves clean, prepare yourselves for the service of God.

Elizaphan, Hebron and Uzziel were smaller families within the Kohathites. They are named here separately.

Zadok and Abiathar were the two priests at the time of David.

Music for God VERSES 16–24

16 David told the leaders of the Levites
to choose some of their relatives as singers.
They were to play music on harps, lyres, and cymbals.
They were to play loudly and sing with joy.
17 So the Levites chose Heman, the son of Joel.
From his relatives they chose Asaph, the son of Berechiah.
From their relatives, the descendants of Merari, they chose Ethan, the son of Kushaiah.
18 With them were their relatives of the second rank:
Zechariah, Ben, Jaaziel, Shemiramoth, Jehiel, Unni, Eliab, Benaiah, Maaseiah,
Mattithiah, Eliphelehu, Mikneiah, Obed-Edom, and Jeiel.
They were the doorkeepers.
19 The singers Heman, Asaph, and Ethan
were to play loudly on bronze cymbals.
20 Zechariah, Aziel, Shemiramoth, Jehiel, Unni, Eliab, Maaseiah, and Benaiah
played lyres set to Alamoth.
21 Mattithiah, Eliphelehu, Mikneiah, Obed-Edom, Jeiel, and Azaziah
played harps tuned to the eight-stringed lyre.
They were to lead.
22 Chenaniah, a leader of the Levites, was in charge of the singing.
He taught the singers, because he was skillful.
23 Berechiah and Elkanah were doorkeepers for the ark.
24 The priests Shebaniah, Joshaphat, Nethanel, Amasai, Zechariah, Benaiah, and Eliezer
blew the trumpets in front of God's ark.
Obed-Edom and Jehiah were also doorkeepers for the ark.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For Chronicles music is an important part of worship. David puts together a large choir and an orchestra. Praise of God should be loud and joyful.

"Alamoth" and "the eight-stringed lyre" (in Hebrew "Sheminith") are musical terms whose exact meaning is unknown today. Perhaps "Alamoth" means a high voice and "Sheminith" a low one. Both words are also in the headings of psalms (Psalm 6; Psalm 46).

Chenaniah was a good music teacher. Skill and talent are valued.

Obed-Edom, in whose house the ark had been, is now a doorkeeper and musician. He stays faithful to the ark.

Joy and contempt VERSES 25–29

25 So David, the leaders of Israel, and the commanders of
thousands went with joy.
They went to bring the ark of the LORD's covenant up
from the house of Obed-Edom.
26 God helped the Levites who carried the ark of the
LORD's covenant.
So they sacrificed seven bulls and seven rams.
27 David wore a robe of fine linen.
All the Levites who carried the ark wore one too.
So did the singers and Chenaniah, the leader of the
singing.
David also wore a linen ephod.
28 So all Israel brought up the ark of the LORD's
covenant.
They shouted and blew the horn and the trumpets.
They played loudly on cymbals, lyres, and harps.
29 The ark of the LORD's covenant came into the City of
David.
Michal, the daughter of Saul, looked out of the
window.
She saw King David dancing and celebrating.
And in her heart she looked down on him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"God helped the Levites": this time everything goes well. Full of thankfulness the Levites offer sacrifices.

David wears clothes like a Levite, of simple linen, not his royal clothes. An ephod was a garment like an apron for the service before God.

David dances for joy. Michal, Saul's daughter and David's wife, thinks this is unworthy of a king. More about this quarrel is in 2 Samuel 6:20–23.

Michal stands for Saul's attitude: no heart for God and his ark. David, on the other hand, rejoices with his whole heart. You may show true joy in God, even if others find it strange.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 16

David's song of thanks

The ark has arrived VERSES 1–7

1 They brought in God's ark.
They put it in the middle of the tent that David had set
up for it.
Then they offered burnt offerings and peace offerings
before God.
2 David finished offering the burnt offerings and the
peace offerings.
Then he blessed the people in the name of the LORD.
3 He gave something to every Israelite, man and woman.
Each one got a loaf of bread, a portion of meat, and a
cake of raisins.
4 David chose some of the Levites
to serve in front of the LORD's ark.
They were to remember the LORD, the God of Israel,
to thank him and to praise him.
5 Asaph was the leader.
Zechariah was second after him.
Then came Jeiel, Shemiramoth, Jehiel, Mattithiah,
Eliab, Benaiah, Obed-Edom, and Jeiel.
They played lyres and harps.
Asaph played loudly on the cymbals.
6 The priests Benaiah and Jahaziel always blew trumpets
in front of the ark of God's covenant.
7 On that day David for the first time gave Asaph and his
relatives this task:
They were to give thanks to the LORD with this song:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At last the ark is in Jerusalem. David blesses the people, and everyone gets something to eat, men and women alike. The celebration is for everyone.

David appoints singers who sing continually before the ark and praise God. Praise and thanks should happen not only on feast days, but every day.

"Cake of raisins": the Hebrew word is not completely certain.

The song of thanks: Tell of God's deeds VERSES 8–22

8 Give thanks to the LORD!
Call on his name!
Tell the peoples what he has done!
9 Sing to him, sing praises to him!
Tell about all his wonderful works!
10 Be proud of his holy name!
Let the hearts of those who seek the LORD be glad.
11 Seek the LORD and his strength!
Seek his face always!
12 Remember the wonderful works he has done,
his wonders, and the judgments he has spoken,
13 you descendants of Israel, his servant,
you children of Jacob, his chosen ones!
14 He is the LORD, our God.
His judgments are in all the earth.
15 Remember his covenant forever,
the word he commanded for 1,000 generations.
16 It is the covenant he made with Abraham,
and the promise he swore to Isaac.
17 He confirmed it to Jacob as a law,
to Israel as a covenant that lasts forever.
18 He said,
"I will give you the land of Canaan.
It will be your share and your inheritance."

19 At that time you were only a few people,
yes, very few, and you were foreigners in the land.
20 They moved around from nation to nation,
from one kingdom to another people.
21 He did not allow anyone to harm them.
Yes, he warned kings because of them:
22 "Do not touch my anointed ones!
Do not harm my prophets!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This song is made of parts of three psalms. Verses 8–22 are also in Psalm 105:1–15.

The song invites us: give thanks to God, sing, tell others about what he has done. Faith is not only something private, but should be passed on.

"Seek his face always!": God wants us to seek his nearness, every day.

Then the song remembers the history: God made a covenant with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. They were only a few, foreigners in the land, always on the move. But God protected them.

"My anointed ones" and "my prophets" here are the ancestors Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. For example, God warned Pharaoh and King Abimelech not to harm them (Genesis 12:17; 20:3–7).

"1,000 generations" means: forever.

The song of thanks: The whole world should praise God
VERSES 23–33

23 Sing to the LORD, all the earth!
Tell about how he saves, day after day!
24 Tell the nations about his glory.
Tell all the peoples about his wonderful works!
25 For the LORD is great, and he deserves great praise!
He is to be feared more than all gods.
26 For all the gods of the peoples are idols,
but the LORD made the heavens.
27 Honor and majesty are before him.
Strength and joy are in his place.
28 You families of the nations, give to the LORD,
give to the LORD glory and strength!
29 Give to the LORD the glory his name deserves!
Bring an offering, and come before him!
Worship the LORD in holy clothing!
30 Tremble before him, all the earth!
The world also stands firm.
It cannot be moved.
31 Let the heavens be glad, and let the earth rejoice!
Let them say among the nations,
"The LORD reigns!"
That means: The LORD is King!
32 Let the sea roar, and everything that fills it!
Let the field and everything in it celebrate!
33 Then the trees of the forest will sing for joy before the LORD,
for he comes to judge the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This part is also in Psalm 96.

Now the view goes beyond Israel: all peoples, the whole earth, should praise God. God is not only the God of one people, but the Creator of the heavens.

All creation rejoices with them: the heavens, the earth, the sea, the fields, even the trees. What a beautiful picture!

"He comes to judge the earth": here this is a reason for joy. God's judgment means: he puts everything right and brings justice for all who suffer wrong.

"Holy clothing" can also mean "holy splendor," that is: with awe and in festive clothes.

The song of thanks: Give thanks to the LORD
VERSES 34–36

34 Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good!
His loving kindness lasts forever.
35 Say,
"Save us, God who saves us!
Gather us together and rescue us from the nations.
Then we will give thanks to your holy name.
Then we will be proud to praise you."
36 Praise the LORD, the God of Israel,
from everlasting to everlasting!
Then all the people said, "Amen,"
and they praised the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This part is also in Psalm 106:1 and 106:47–48.

"Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good! His loving kindness lasts forever": this is one of the most important and most frequent words of praise in the Bible. It is still prayed today in Jewish and Christian worship.

Verse 35 is interesting: "Gather us together and rescue us from the nations." At the time of David the Israelites were not scattered. But for the first readers of Chronicles, after the exile, this was a very real prayer.

"Amen" means: "So it is," "That is certain." All the people agree.

The daily worship VERSES 37–43

37 So David left Asaph and his relatives there
in front of the ark of the LORD's covenant.
They were to serve in front of the ark all the time,
as the work of each day required.
38 He also left Obed-Edom and their 68 relatives there.
Obed-Edom, the son of Jeduthun, and Hosah were to be doorkeepers.
39 And he left the priest Zadok and his relatives, the priests,
in front of the LORD's tabernacle.
It stood at the place of worship on the hill at Gibeon.
40 There they were to offer burnt offerings to the LORD
on the altar of burnt offering.
They were to do this always, morning and evening.
They were to do everything that is written in the LORD's law,
which he gave to Israel.
41 With them were Heman and Jeduthun
and the others who had been chosen by name.
They were to give thanks to the LORD,
because his loving kindness lasts forever.
42 Heman and Jeduthun had trumpets and cymbals for those who played loudly.
They also had instruments for the songs of God.
The sons of Jeduthun were to guard the gate.

43 Then all the people went home.
And David went home to bless his family.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the time of David there were two places for worship: in Jerusalem the ark stood in a tent, and Asaph and his people sang there. In Gibeon the old tabernacle from the time in the wilderness still stood, with the altar of burnt offering. There Zadok and the priests offered sacrifices. Only under Solomon did everything come together in the temple.

Jeduthun was another leader of the music. He is probably also called Ethan (1 Chronicles 15:17).

At the end David goes home "to bless his family." After the great celebration for the whole people, he also thinks of his own family.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 17

God's promise to David

David wants to build a house for God VERSES 1–2

1 David was now living in his own house.
He said to the prophet Nathan,
"Look, I live in a house made of cedar wood.
But the ark of the LORD's covenant stays in a tent."
2 Nathan answered David,
"Do everything you have in mind.
God is with you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David has a beautiful palace. But God's ark stands only in a tent. He does not think this is right. He wants to build a temple for God.

At first the prophet Nathan thinks this is a good idea.

The story is also in 2 Samuel 7.

God wants to build a house for David VERSES 3–15

3 But that same night God spoke to Nathan.
He said,
4 "Go and tell my servant David,
'This is what the LORD says:
"You are not the one to build me a house to live in.
5 I have not lived in a house
from the day I brought Israel up until today.
I have gone from tent to tent,
from one tent to another.
6 I went with all Israel to many places.
I commanded the judges of Israel to be shepherds of my people.
Did I ever say to any of them,
'Why have you not built me a house of cedar?'"'
7 "So now tell my servant David,
'This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"I took you from the sheep pen,
where you followed the sheep.
I made you the leader of my people Israel.
8 I have been with you wherever you went.
I have destroyed all your enemies in front of you.
I will make your name famous,
like the names of the great people on the earth.
9 I will choose a place for my people Israel.
I will plant them there.
Then they can live in their own place,
and no one will drive them away again.
Evil people will not crush them anymore, as they did at first,
10 and as they did ever since I put judges over my people Israel.
I will defeat all your enemies.
And I tell you: The LORD will build a house for you.
11 Your life will come to an end,
and you will go to be with your ancestors.
Then I will raise up one of your descendants after you.
He will be one of your sons.
And I will make his kingdom strong.
12 He will build a house for me.
And I will make his throne firm forever.
13 I will be his father,
and he will be my son.
I will never take my loving kindness away from him,
as I took it away from the king who ruled before you.
14 I will give him a firm place in my house and in my kingdom forever.
His throne will stand firm forever."'"
15 Nathan told David all these words.
He told him everything he had seen in this vision.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important passages in the Old Testament.

God says: not you build a house for me, but I build a "house" for you. The Hebrew word "house" can mean a building, but also a family, a royal family, a dynasty. A beautiful play on words.

God reminds David: I took you from the sheep. Everything you have is my gift.

God promises: a son of David will build the temple (Solomon). And David's throne will stand firm "forever."

"I will be his father, and he will be my son": a very close relationship between God and the king.

Unlike 2 Samuel 7:14, the sentence that God will punish the son when he sins is missing here. Chronicles already sees the king more strongly as a picture of a coming, perfect king.

After the exile there was no more king from David's family. Still, the Jews held on to this promise and waited for an "anointed one" (Messiah) from the house of David. Christians believe that this promise came true in Jesus, whom the New Testament calls "son of David" (Luke 1:32–33).

David's prayer VERSES 16–27

16 Then King David went in and sat before the LORD.
He said,

"Who am I, LORD God, and what is my house, that you
have brought me this far?
17 And even this was a small thing in your eyes, God.
You have also spoken about your servant's house
for a long time to come.
You have looked at me as if I were a man of high
degree, LORD God.
18 What more can I, David, say to you
about the honor you have given your servant?
You know your servant.
19 LORD, you have done this great thing for your
servant's sake.
You did it because you wanted to.
You did it to make all these great things known.
20 LORD, there is no one like you.
There is no God except you.
Everything we have heard with our own ears shows it.
21 There is no other nation on earth like your people
Israel.
God himself went to free them,
so that they would be his own people.
You made your name famous by great and awesome
deeds.
You drove out nations in front of your people,
whom you freed from Egypt.
22 You made your people Israel your own people forever.
And you, LORD, became their God.
23 Now, LORD, you have made a promise about your
servant and his house.
Let it stand firm forever.
Do what you have promised.
24 Let your name stand firm and be great forever.
Then people will say,
'The LORD of Armies is the God of Israel.
He really is Israel's God.
The house of your servant David stands firm before
you.'
25 You, my God, have shown your servant
that you will build a house for him.
That is why I, your servant, have found the courage to
pray to you.
26 LORD, you are God.
You have promised this good thing to your servant.
27 Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your
servant,
so that it will last forever before you.
For you, LORD, have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is overwhelmed. He sits before God and is amazed: "Who am I, LORD God, and what is my house, that you have brought me this far?" True thankfulness makes us humble.

David does not ask for more, but that God does what he has promised. God's promises give him the courage to pray (verse 25).

At the end there is great trust: "You, LORD, have blessed, and it is blessed forever." What God blesses stays blessed.

In verse 17 the Hebrew text is hard to understand. The translation "a man of high degree" is uncertain.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 18

David's victories

Victories on every side VERSES 1–8

1 After this, David defeated the Philistines and brought
them under his control.
He took the city of Gath and its towns away from the
Philistines.
2 He defeated Moab.
The Moabites had to serve David and pay him taxes.
3 David also defeated Hadadezer, the king of Zobah, near
Hamath.
At that time Hadadezer was going to make his rule
firm by the Euphrates River.
4 David captured 1,000 chariots, 7,000 horsemen, and
20,000 foot soldiers from him.
David cut the leg tendons of all the chariot horses.
But he kept enough horses for 100 chariots.
5 The Syrians of Damascus came to help Hadadezer, the
king of Zobah.
But David killed 22,000 of the Syrians.
6 Then David put troops in Syria of Damascus.
The Syrians had to serve David and pay him taxes.
The LORD gave victory to David wherever he went.
7 Hadadezer's officers had shields of gold.
David took them and brought them to Jerusalem.
8 David also took a great amount of bronze
from Tibhath and Cun, cities of Hadadezer.
Later Solomon used it to make the bronze sea, the
pillars, and the bronze objects.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In a short time David defeats all the enemies around: in the west the Philistines, in the east Moab, in the north the Arameans (Syrians). Israel becomes a small empire. The list is also in 2 Samuel 8.

"Cut the leg tendons": David made the horses lame, so that they could no longer be used in war. Israel was not to trust in horses and chariots (Deuteronomy 17:16; Psalm 20:7).

Chronicles stresses: the bronze from these victories was later used for the temple. David is already collecting material for the temple that Solomon will build.

In Hebrew "Syria" is called "Aram." Zobah was an Aramean kingdom north of Damascus.

2 Samuel 8:4 has 1,700 horsemen instead of 1,000 chariots and 7,000 horsemen. Such differences in numbers probably came about when the text was copied.

In 2 Samuel 8:8 the cities are called "Betah" and "Berothai."

A gift from Hamath VERSES 9–13

9 Tou, the king of Hamath, heard
that David had defeated the whole army of Hadadezer,
the king of Zobah.

10 So he sent his son Hadoram to King David.
Hadoram was to greet him and congratulate him,
because David had fought against Hadadezer and
defeated him.
Hadadezer had often been at war with Tou.
Hadoram brought all kinds of objects made of gold,
silver, and bronze.
11 King David dedicated these things to the LORD too.
He did the same with the silver and gold he had taken
from all the nations:
from Edom, Moab, the Ammonites, the Philistines,
and Amalek.
12 Abishai, the son of Zeruiah, killed 18,000 Edomites in
the Valley of Salt.
13 He put troops in Edom.
All the Edomites had to serve David.
The LORD gave victory to David wherever he went.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king of Hamath is glad that his enemy has been defeated. He sends gifts.

David does not keep the treasures for himself. He dedicates them to God, for the later temple.

The sentence appears twice: "The LORD gave victory to David wherever he went." Chronicles wants to say: David's success is God's gift.

In 2 Samuel 8:13 the victory in the Valley of Salt is credited to David himself, in Psalm 60 to Joab. Here it is Abishai. Probably several army commanders took part.

The numbers of the dead are high. War always means great suffering, even when the Bible tells it here from the point of view of the winners.

David's government VERSES 14–17

14 David ruled over all Israel.
He did what was just and right for all his people.
15 Joab, the son of Zeruiah, was in charge of the army.
Jehoshaphat, the son of Ahilud, kept the official
records.
16 Zadok, the son of Ahitub, and Abimelech, the son of
Abiathar, were priests.
Shavsha was the royal writer.
17 Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada, was in charge of the
Cherethites and the Pelethites.
And David's sons were chief officials serving the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14 says what makes a good king: he does "what was just and right for all his people." Not power and victories are most important, but justice for everyone.

The list shows David's most important officials. The "Cherethites and the Pelethites" were David's bodyguard, probably foreign soldiers who were paid to fight.

In the Hebrew text of 2 Samuel 8:18 it says that David's sons were priests. Chronicles writes: they were "chief officials serving the king" (1 Chronicles 18:17). For Chronicles, only descendants of Aaron could be priests.

In 2 Samuel 8:17 the names are "Ahimelech" instead of "Abimelech" and "Seraiah" instead of "Shavsha."

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 19

War with the Ammonites

An insult VERSES 1–5

1 After this, Nahash, the king of the Ammonites, died.
His son became king in his place.
2 David said,
"I will be kind to Hanun, the son of Nahash,
because his father was kind to me."
So David sent messengers to comfort Hanun about the
death of his father.
David's servants came to Hanun in the land of the
Ammonites to comfort him.
3 But the leaders of the Ammonites said to Hanun,
"Do you really think David wants to honor your father
by sending people to comfort you?
No! His servants have come to look around,
to destroy the land, and to spy it out."
4 So Hanun seized David's servants and shaved them.
He cut off their clothes in the middle, up to their
buttocks.
Then he sent them away.
5 Some people went and told David what had happened to
the men.
So David sent people to meet them,
because the men were deeply ashamed.
The king said,
"Stay in Jericho until your beards have grown back.
Then come home."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David wants to be kind and honor an old friendship. But the advisers of the new king are suspicious and turn the kindness into a suspicion.

The messengers are badly humiliated. Shaving off the beard and cutting the clothes off up to the buttocks was a great disgrace back then.

David shows compassion for his men. He lets them wait until they can show themselves again. He protects their dignity.

The story is also in 2 Samuel 10.

Ammon looks for allies VERSES 6–9

6 The Ammonites saw that they had made David hate
them.
So Hanun and the Ammonites sent 1,000 talents of
silver (about 75,000 pounds)
to hire chariots and horsemen from Mesopotamia,
from Aram-maacah, and from Zobah.
7 They hired 32,000 chariots.
They also hired the king of Maacah and his army.
These came and set up camp near Medeba.
The Ammonites also gathered from their cities and
came out to fight.

8 David heard about it.
So he sent Joab with the whole army of mighty men.
9 The Ammonites came out.
They lined up for battle at the gate of their city.
The kings who had come stood apart in the open field.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Instead of saying sorry, the Ammonites prepare for war. They pay foreign armies.

The Bible says "1,000 talents of silver." A talent is about 75 pounds.

The number of 32,000 chariots is very high. 2 Samuel 10:6 has 33,000 men instead.

Medeba lay east of the Dead Sea. Mesopotamia here literally means "Aram of the two rivers," that is, the area along the upper Euphrates.

Joab and Abishai VERSES 10–15

10 Joab saw that the enemy was ready to attack him from the front and from behind.
So he chose some of the best soldiers of Israel.
He lined them up to fight against the Syrians.
11 He put the rest of the army under the command of his brother Abishai.
They lined up to fight against the Ammonites.
12 Joab said,
"If the Syrians are too strong for me, then you must help me.
But if the Ammonites are too strong for you, then I will help you.
13 Be brave!
Let us be strong for our people and for the cities of our God.
May the LORD do what seems good to him."
14 Then Joab and his soldiers went forward to fight against the Syrians.
And the Syrians ran away from him.
15 The Ammonites saw that the Syrians had run away.
So they too ran away from Joab's brother Abishai.
They went back into the city.
Then Joab went back to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joab is surrounded: in front the Ammonites, behind the Syrians. He divides the army and agrees with his brother: we will help each other.

His words are an example of courage and trust in God: we do what we can. And then: "May the LORD do what seems good to him." You should give your best and leave the result to God.

In Hebrew the "Syrians" are called "Arameans."

The victory over the Syrians VERSES 16–19

16 The Syrians saw that Israel had defeated them.
So they sent messengers.
They called for the Syrians from the other side of the River.
Shophach, the commander of Hadadezer's army, led them.
17 David heard about it.
So he gathered all Israel and crossed the Jordan.
He came to the Syrians and lined up his army against them.
David lined up for battle against the Syrians, and they fought against him.
18 But the Syrians ran away from Israel.
David killed 7,000 Syrian chariot drivers and 40,000 foot soldiers.
He also killed Shophach, the commander of the army.
19 The officials of Hadadezer saw that Israel had defeated them.
So they made peace with David and served him.
After that the Syrians did not want to help the Ammonites anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The River" is the Euphrates. The Syrians get help from there.

In the end they make peace with David.

2 Samuel 10:18 says: 700 charioteers and 40,000 horsemen. Such differences in the numbers probably came about when the text was copied over the centuries. There the army commander is called "Shobach."

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 20

Rabbah and the giants from Gath

The conquest of Rabbah VERSES 1–3

1 In the spring, at the time when kings go out to war,
Joab led the army out.
He destroyed the land of the Ammonites.
Then he came to Rabbah and surrounded the city.
But David stayed at Jerusalem.
Joab attacked Rabbah and destroyed it.
2 David took the crown from the head of their king.
He found that it weighed a talent of gold (about 75 pounds).
There were precious stones in it.
It was placed on David's head.
David also took a great amount of plunder from the city.
3 He brought out the people who lived there.
He had them cut with saws, with iron picks, and with axes.
David did this to all the cities of the Ammonites.
Then David and all the army went back to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"When kings go out to war": in spring, after the rainy season.

"But David stayed at Jerusalem." Anyone who knows 2 Samuel 11 knows: exactly at this time the matter with Bathsheba and Uriah happened. Chronicles does not tell it. Above all it wants to show David's role as the founder of the temple. But this gap shows: Chronicles expects its readers to know the story.

The Bible says "a talent of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds. A crown that heavy could hardly be worn. Perhaps it was put on only briefly, or it was the crown of the idol Milcom (the Hebrew word for "their king" sounds very similar).

Verse 3 is very hard. In 2 Samuel 12:31 the Hebrew has a similar word, which can also be understood like this: he made them work with saws, picks and axes, that is, do forced labor. Here the Hebrew says "he sawed." Many scholars think that a letter was switched here and that "he put them to work" is really meant. If it is meant literally, it would be a cruel war crime. Nothing can justify something like that, not even David's reputation.

The giants from Gath VERSES 4–8

4 After this, a war began with the Philistines at Gezer.
There Sibbecai the Hushathite killed Sippai.
Sippai was one of the descendants of the giant.
So the Philistines were defeated.
5 There was war with the Philistines again.
Elhanan, the son of Jair, killed Lahmi, the brother of Goliath the Gittite.
The shaft of Lahmi's spear was as thick as the beam of a loom.
6 There was war at Gath again.
There was a very tall man there.
He had 24 fingers and toes, six on each hand and six on each foot.
He too was a descendant of the giant.
7 He made fun of Israel.
So Jonathan, the son of David's brother Shimea, killed him.
8 These men were descendants of the giant in Gath.
They were killed by David and his servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "giants" (in Hebrew "Rapha") were a family of especially tall warriors among the Philistines. Goliath, whom David had defeated, belonged to them (1 Samuel 17).

Verse 5 clears up a difficult passage: in 2 Samuel 21:19 the Hebrew says that Elhanan killed Goliath. Chronicles says: he killed Lahmi, the brother of Goliath. So there is no contradiction with the story of David and Goliath.

Six fingers and toes: this happens with some people today too (polydactyly). It is something a person is born with, not a disease and not a flaw.

The list is also in 2 Samuel 21:18–22. There a fourth giant is named, Ishbibenob.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 21

David's census and the altar on the threshing floor

The census VERSES 1–7

1 Satan rose up against Israel.
He moved David to count the people of Israel.
2 David said to Joab and to the leaders of the people,
"Go and count the Israelites from Beersheba to Dan.
Then report to me.
I want to know how many there are."
3 Joab said,
"May the LORD make his people 100 times as many as they are now!
But my lord the king, are they not all your servants?
Why do you want to do this, my lord?
Why do you want to bring guilt on Israel?"
4 But the king insisted, and Joab had to obey.
So Joab left and went through all Israel.
Then he came back to Jerusalem.
5 Joab gave David the total number of the people.
In all Israel there were 1,100,000 men who could fight with a sword.
In Judah there were 470,000 men who could fight with a sword.
6 But Joab did not count the tribes of Levi and Benjamin, because he hated the king's order.
7 God did not like what David had done.
So he punished Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David wants to know how many warriors he has. That sounds harmless, but it shows: he trusts in the number of his soldiers, not in God. He treats the people as if they belonged to him, not to God.

Even Joab, who is otherwise not squeamish, warns David.

Here it says "Satan." The Hebrew word means "adversary" or "accuser." In this place 2 Samuel 24:1 says: "Again the anger of the LORD burned against Israel. And he moved David against them." Chronicles, which was written later, says it differently: not God himself, but Satan led David astray. Both texts say: behind the temptation there is a power that is greater than David. And both say: David is still responsible himself.

The numbers are different from 2 Samuel 24:9 (there 800,000 and 500,000).

Levi was not counted because the Levites did not serve in war (Numbers 1:47–49).

David is sorry VERSES 8–13

8 David said to God,
"I have sinned greatly by doing this.
But now, please take away the guilt of your servant.
I have been very foolish."
9 The LORD spoke to Gad, David's seer.
A seer is a prophet.
The LORD said,
10 "Go and tell David,
'This is what the LORD says:
"I offer you three choices.
Choose one of them, and I will do it to you."'"
11 So Gad came to David and said to him,
"This is what the LORD says:
'Choose one:
12 three years of famine,
or three months of running from your enemies while their swords catch up with you,

or three days of the sword of the LORD:
a deadly disease in the land,
with the LORD's angel bringing death in every part of Israel.'
Now think about it.
What answer should I give to the one who sent me?"

13 David said to Gad,
"I am in great trouble.
Please let me fall into the LORD's hands,
because his mercies are very great.
But do not let me fall into human hands."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David sees his mistake and confesses it honestly: "I have sinned greatly."

He must choose between three terrible results. He chooses the one where he is completely in God's hand. His reason: "His mercies are very great." He trusts that God is more merciful than people.

2 Samuel 24:13 has "seven years" of famine instead of three.

Gad was a prophet who was with David.

The plague and the angel over Jerusalem VERSES 14–17

14 So the LORD sent a deadly disease on Israel.
In Israel, 70,000 men died.

15 God sent an angel to Jerusalem to destroy it.
The angel was about to destroy the city.
But the LORD saw it, and he was sorry about the disaster.
He said to the angel who was destroying,
"It is enough!
Now pull back your hand."
At that moment the LORD's angel was standing by the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite.
A threshing floor is a flat place where grain is separated from the straw.

16 David looked up.
He saw the LORD's angel standing between the earth and the sky.
The angel had pulled out his sword.
He held it out over Jerusalem.
Then David and the leaders fell face down to the ground.
They were wearing rough sackcloth as a sign of sorrow.

17 David said to God,
"I am the one who ordered the people to be counted!
I am the one who sinned and did very wrong.
But these sheep, what have they done?
LORD my God, please punish me and my family.
But do not strike your people with this disease."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a very hard story. Many people die because of the guilt of their king. That seems unfair to us. The Bible does not keep quiet about this question. David himself asks it: "These sheep, what have they done?"

David is ready to carry the punishment himself. He wants God to strike him and not the people. A king should stand in front of his people, like a shepherd in front of his sheep.

God has mercy: "It is enough!" He stops the angel before Jerusalem is destroyed. God's mercy is greater than his anger, as David had hoped.

Christians see here a picture of Jesus: as the "good shepherd" he took the guilt of others on himself (John 10:11).

In 2 Samuel 24:16 "Ornan" is called "Araunah."

The altar on the threshing floor VERSES 18–30

18 Then the LORD's angel told Gad to tell David:
David should go up and build an altar to the LORD on the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite.

19 So David went up, as Gad had told him in the LORD's name.

20 Ornan turned around and saw the angel.
His four sons who were with him hid.
Ornan was threshing wheat at that time.

21 David came to Ornan.
Ornan looked up and saw David.
He left the threshing floor
and bowed down before David with his face to the ground.

22 David said to Ornan,
"Sell me this threshing floor.
I want to build an altar to the LORD on it.
Sell it to me for the full price.
Then the disease will stop striking the people."

23 Ornan said to David,
"Take it.
My lord the king, do whatever you think is good.
Look, I will give you the oxen for burnt offerings.
I will give you the threshing boards for firewood,
and the wheat for the grain offering.
I give it all to you."

24 But King David said to Ornan,
"No, I will certainly buy it for the full price.
I will not take what is yours and give it to the LORD.
I will not offer a burnt offering that costs me nothing."

25 So David paid Ornan 600 shekels of gold (about 15 pounds) for the place.

26 David built an altar to the LORD there.
He offered burnt offerings and peace offerings.
He called to the LORD.
And the LORD answered him with fire from the sky on the altar of burnt offering.

27 Then the LORD gave a command to the angel.
And the angel put his sword back into its sheath.

28 David saw that the LORD had answered him at the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite.
So at that time he offered sacrifices there.

29 At that time the LORD's tabernacle, which Moses had made in the wilderness,
and the altar of burnt offering were at the place of worship on the hill at Gibeon.

30 But David could not go there to ask God for guidance.
He was afraid of the sword of the LORD's angel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The place where the angel stops becomes the place of making peace with God. There David builds an altar.

Ornan wants to give David everything. But David says a famous sentence: "I will not ... offer a burnt offering that costs me nothing." True devotion to God costs something.

The Bible says "600 shekels of gold." A shekel is about 0.4 ounces. 2 Samuel 24:24 says "50 shekels of silver." Perhaps

the 50 shekels were only for the threshing floor and the oxen, and the 600 shekels for the whole place.

God answers with fire from the sky, as with Elijah on Mount Carmel. This shows: God accepts the offering.

Most important: later the temple is built on this place (1 Chronicles 22:1; 2 Chronicles 3:1). In 2 Chronicles 3:1 the place is called "Mount Moriah," like the mountain on which Abraham was to sacrifice Isaac (Genesis 22:2). A place of guilt becomes a place of grace.

To this day this place in Jerusalem, the Temple Mount, is holy for Jews, Christians and Muslims.

1 CHRONICLES

Chapter 22

David prepares for building the temple

The place for the temple VERSES 1–5

1 Then David said,
"This is the place for the house of the LORD God.
And this is the altar of burnt offering for Israel."
2 David gave orders to gather the foreigners who lived in the land of Israel.
He made them stoneworkers.
They were to cut stone blocks for building God's house.
3 David got ready a large amount of iron
for the nails for the doors of the gates and for the clamps.
He also got so much bronze that no one could weigh it.
4 He got more cedar logs than anyone could count.
The people of Sidon and Tyre had brought David a great many cedar logs.
5 David said,
"My son Solomon is young and has no experience.
The house to be built for the LORD must be very beautiful and great.
It must be famous and glorious in all countries.
So I will get everything ready for it."
So David prepared a great deal before he died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the story of the angel and the altar (Chapter 21), David knows: here, on Ornan's threshing floor, the temple is to stand.

David is not allowed to build the temple himself. But he prepares everything: stones, iron, bronze and wood. He does what he can so that his son has it easier. Sometimes it is our task to prepare for others what we cannot finish ourselves.

"The foreigners": people from other nations who lived in Israel. They had to work on the building (compare 2 Chronicles 2:17–18).

David gives Solomon the task VERSES 6–16

6 Then David called his son Solomon.
He told him to build a house for the LORD, the God of Israel.
7 David said to his son Solomon,
"I myself wanted to build a house for the name of the LORD my God.
8 But the LORD said to me,
'You have shed a lot of blood.
You have fought great wars.
You must not build a house for my name.
You have shed so much blood on the earth before my eyes.
9 But you will have a son.
He will be a man of peace.
I will give him rest from all his enemies around him.
His name will be Solomon.
During his rule I will give Israel peace and quiet.
10 He will build a house for my name.
He will be my son, and I will be his father.
I will make the throne of his kingdom over Israel firm forever.'
11 Now, my son,
may the LORD be with you and give you success.
May you build the house of the LORD your God,
just as he said about you.
12 May the LORD give you wisdom and understanding
when he puts you in charge of Israel.
Then you can keep the law of the LORD your God.
13 You will have success
if you carefully obey the laws and rules
that the LORD gave Moses for Israel.
Be strong and brave.
Do not be afraid.
Do not lose heart.
14 Look, in my hardship I have prepared these things for the LORD's house:
100,000 talents of gold (about 7.5 million pounds)
and 1,000,000 talents of silver (about 75 million pounds).
I have also prepared so much bronze and iron that no one can weigh it.
There is a great amount of it.
I have also prepared wood and stone.
And you may add more.
15 You also have many workers:
stonecutters, stoneworkers, and woodworkers,
and all kinds of people who are skilled in every kind of work.
16 There is more gold, silver, bronze, and iron than anyone can count.
Now get up and start working!
May the LORD be with you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is the reason why David was not allowed to build the temple: he had shed much blood. God's house is to be a house of peace. That fits Solomon, whose name means "the peaceful one" (the Hebrew word "shalom" means "peace").

David gives his son advice for life: keep God's law. "Be strong and brave. Do not be afraid." Moses had also spoken like this to Joshua (Joshua 1:6–9).

"In my hardship": David gathered the material in spite of many difficulties.

The Bible says "100,000 talents of gold" and "1,000,000 talents of silver." A talent is about 75 pounds. Those would be unimaginably large amounts, much more than all the gold there was in the whole region at that time. The numbers probably want to say: it was beyond measure. Perhaps they were also changed when the text was copied.

David calls on the princes VERSES 17–19

17 David also ordered all the leaders of Israel to help his
son Solomon.
He said,
18 "The LORD your God is with you!
He has given you peace on every side.
He has put the people of the land into my power.
The land is now under the control of the LORD and his
people.
19 Now set your heart and your soul to follow the LORD
your God.
Get up and build the holy house of the LORD God.
Then the ark of the LORD's covenant and the holy
objects of God
can be brought into the house that will be built for the
LORD's name."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple is not only Solomon's task. Everyone is to help.

The most important thing is not the building, but the heart: "Set your heart and your soul to follow the LORD your God." A house for God without a heart for God would be empty.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 23

The order of the Levites

David counts the Levites VERSES 1–6

1 David was now old.
He had lived a long and full life.
He made his son Solomon king over Israel.
2 He called together all the leaders of Israel,
and also the priests and the Levites.
3 The Levites who were 30 years old or older were
counted.
There were 38,000 men in all.
4 David said,
"24,000 of them will be in charge of the work of the
LORD's house.
6,000 will be officials and judges.
5 4,000 will be doorkeepers.
And 4,000 will praise the LORD
with the instruments I made for praising him."
6 David divided them into groups
by the sons of Levi: Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In chapters 23 to 27 David puts everything in order for the temple service: the Levites, the priests, the singers, the doorkeepers and the officials. For Chronicles this is very important: worship should be orderly and well organized.

The Bible says that David was "full of days." That means: he had a long, full life.

The Levites had different tasks: oversight of the work in the temple, administration and judging in the land, guarding the gates, and music.

David also made or designed musical instruments himself. After all, he was a musician himself.

The families of Gershon VERSES 7–11

7 From the Gershonites:
Ladan and Shimei.
8 The sons of Ladan:
Jehiel the leader, Zetham, and Joel.
These were three.
9 The sons of Shimei:
Shelomoth, Haziel, and Haran.
These were three.
They were the heads of the families of Ladan.
10 The sons of Shimei:
Jahath, Zina, Jeush, and Beriah.
These four were the sons of Shimei.
11 Jahath was the leader, and Zizah was second.
Jeush and Beriah did not have many sons.
So they were counted together as one family.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The families were divided by the number of men. Small families were put together so that the divisions were about the same size.

There are two men named Shimei: a son of Ladan (verse 9) and a son of Gershon (verse 10).

"Zina" (verse 10) and "Zizah" (verse 11) are probably the same name, only spelled differently.

The families of Kohath VERSES 12–20

12 The sons of Kohath:
Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel.
These were four.
13 The sons of Amram:
Aaron and Moses.
Aaron was set apart to take care of the most holy
things.
He and his descendants were to do this forever.
They were to burn incense before the LORD and to
serve him.
And they were to bless the people in his name forever.
14 Moses was the man of God.
His sons were counted as part of the tribe of Levi.
15 The sons of Moses:
Gershom and Eliezer.
16 The sons of Gershom:
Shebuel the leader.
17 The son of Eliezer:
Rehabiah the leader.

Eliezer had no other sons.
But Rehabiah had very many sons.
18 The son of Izhar:
Shelomith the leader.
19 The sons of Hebron:
Jeriah was the leader,
Amariah was second,
Jahaziel was third,
and Jekameam was fourth.
20 The sons of Uzziel:
Micah was the leader,
and Isshiah was second.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Aaron and his descendants were priests. They had special tasks: the most holy things, the incense offering, and the blessing in God's name. The "blessing of Aaron" is still spoken today: "The LORD bless you and keep you ..." (Numbers 6:24–26).

Remarkable: the descendants of Moses, the greatest prophet, did not become priests, but ordinary Levites. Moses did not claim special rights for his family.

The families of Merari VERSES 21–23

21 The sons of Merari:
Mahli and Mushi.
The sons of Mahli:
Eleazar and Kish.
22 Eleazar died without sons.
He had only daughters.
Their relatives, the sons of Kish, married them.
23 The sons of Mushi:
Mahli, Eder, and Jeremoth.
These were three.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The daughters of Eleazar married their cousins. So the inheritance stayed in the family, as it is ruled in Numbers 36.

New tasks for the Levites VERSES 24–32

24 These were the descendants of Levi, listed by their families.
They were the heads of the families.
Each man was counted and listed by name.
They did the work for the service of the LORD's house.
They were 20 years old or older.
25 For David had said,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, has given his people rest.
He lives in Jerusalem forever.
26 So the Levites no longer need to carry the tabernacle or any of the objects used in its service."
27 By David's last orders,
the Levites who were 20 years old or older were counted.
28 Their job was to help the descendants of Aaron with the service in the LORD's house.
They worked in the courtyards and in the rooms.
They made all the holy things clean.
They did the work for the service of God's house.
29 They also took care of the showbread and the fine flour for the grain offerings.
That included the thin breads without yeast,
the things baked in a pan,
and the things that were soaked.
They also took care of all the measures of amount and size.
30 Every morning they stood to thank and praise the LORD.
They did the same every evening.
31 They offered all the burnt offerings to the LORD on the Sabbaths, at the new moon festivals, and at the set feasts.
They offered the number that was required for each one.
They did this always before the LORD.
32 So they took care of the Tent of Meeting and the holy place.
And they helped their relatives, the descendants of Aaron,
with the service of the LORD's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In earlier times the Levites had to carry the tabernacle through the wilderness. Now, with the fixed temple, they need new tasks. David gives their service a new order: cleaning, baking bread, checking measures, music and prayer.

In the morning and in the evening they are to thank and praise God. From this came the regular times of prayer that still exist in Judaism and Christianity today.

In verse 3 the Levites are counted from 30 years old, in verses 24 and 27 from 20 years old. Verse 27 explains: by David's last orders the age was lowered, because more people were needed for the temple. (In Numbers 4:3 it was 30 years, in Numbers 8:24 already 25.)

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 24

The 24 divisions of the priests

The priests are divided VERSES 1–6

1 These were the groups of the descendants of Aaron.
The sons of Aaron were
Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar, and Ithamar.
2 But Nadab and Abihu died before their father.
They had no children.
So Eleazar and Ithamar served as priests.
3 David divided the priests into groups for their service.
Zadok helped him.
He was a descendant of Eleazar.
Ahimelech also helped him.
He was a descendant of Ithamar.

4 There were more leaders among the descendants of Eleazar
than among the descendants of Ithamar.
So they divided them like this:
16 heads of families from the descendants of Eleazar,
and 8 heads of families from the descendants of Ithamar.
5 They divided them fairly by drawing lots.
Lots were small objects used to make a choice.
There were leaders of the sanctuary and leaders of God
among the descendants of Eleazar and also among the descendants of Ithamar.
6 The writer Shemaiah, the son of Nethanel, was a Levite.
He wrote down the names.
The king and the leaders were there.
Zadok the priest and Ahimelech, the son of Abiathar, were there.
The heads of the families of the priests and the Levites were there too.
One family was chosen for Eleazar,
and then one for Ithamar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nadab and Abihu died because they brought "strange fire" before God (Leviticus 10:1–2).

The priests are divided into 24 divisions. Each division served in the temple for a certain time, probably one week at a time, twice a year. So every priest had his turn.

The division is done by lot. So it is fair and impartial. No one can be favored.

Everything is written down in public, in front of witnesses. An orderly, fair administration.

The order of the 24 divisions VERSES 7–19

7 The first lot fell to Jehoiarib,
the second to Jedaiah,
8 the third to Harim,
the fourth to Seorim,
9 the fifth to Malchijah,
the sixth to Mijamin,
10 the seventh to Hakkoz,
the eighth to Abijah,
11 the ninth to Jeshua,
the tenth to Shecaniah,
12 the eleventh to Eliashib,
the twelfth to Jakim,
13 the thirteenth to Huppah,
the fourteenth to Jeshebeab,
14 the fifteenth to Bilgah,
the sixteenth to Immer,
15 the seventeenth to Hezir,
the eighteenth to Happizzez,
16 the nineteenth to Pethahiah,
the twentieth to Jehezkel,
17 the twenty-first to Jachin,
the twenty-second to Gamul,
18 the twenty-third to Delaiah,
and the twenty-fourth to Maaziah.
19 This was the order in which they served.
In this order they came into the LORD's house.
They followed the rule their ancestor Aaron had given them,
just as the LORD, the God of Israel, had commanded him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These 24 divisions of priests still existed at the time of Jesus.

The eighth division, Abijah, is especially well known: the priest Zacharias, the father of John the Baptist, belonged to it. When he was serving in the temple, the angel Gabriel appeared to him (Luke 1:5–13).

The first division, Jehoiarib, was the family of the Maccabees, who in the 2nd century BC freed the temple from foreign gods. The festival of lights, Hanukkah, remembers this.

In Caesarea in Israel, pieces of a stone inscription were found on which the 24 divisions of priests are listed, with the places in Galilee where they lived after the temple was destroyed.

In some Bibles "Hakkoz" is called "Koz." The "ha" is the Hebrew article.

The rest of the Levites VERSES 20–31

20 These were the other descendants of Levi:
From the descendants of Amram: Shubael.
From the descendants of Shubael: Jehdeiah.
21 From Rehabiah and his sons:
Isshiah, the leader.
22 From the Izharites: Shelomoth.
From the sons of Shelomoth: Jahath.
23 The sons of Hebron:
Jeriah,
Amariah, the second,
Jahaziel, the third,
and Jekameam, the fourth.
24 The sons of Uzziel: Micah.
From the sons of Micah: Shamir.
25 Micah's brother: Isshiah.
From the sons of Isshiah: Zechariah.
26 The sons of Merari:
Mahli and Mushi.
The son of Jaaziah: Beno.
27 The descendants of Merari through Jaaziah:
Beno, Shoham, Zaccur, and Ibri.
28 From Mahli:
Eleazar, who had no sons.
29 From Kish:
Kish's son Jerahmeel.
30 The sons of Mushi:
Mahli, Eder, and Jerimoth.
These were the Levites, listed by their families.
31 They also drew lots, just like their relatives, the descendants of Aaron.
King David, Zadok, and Ahimelech were there.
The heads of the families of the priests and the Levites were there too.
The family of the oldest brother was treated just like the family of his younger brother.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The other Levites are also divided by lot.

The last sentence is beautiful: "The family of the oldest brother was treated just like the family of his younger

brother." Before the lot everyone was equal. No one was favored because of his rank.

Shubael is called "Shebuel" in 1 Chronicles 23:16. The list continues chapter 23, with one more generation.

In Hebrew verses 26–27 are hard to understand. Jaaziah is not named anywhere else as a son of Merari.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 25

The singers in the temple

The families of the singers VERSES 1–7

1 David and the commanders of the army chose some of
the sons of Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun for a special
service.
They were to prophesy with harps, lyres, and cymbals.
Here is the list of the men who did this work:
2 From the sons of Asaph:
Zaccur, Joseph, Nethaniah, and Asharelah.
The sons of Asaph were led by Asaph.
He prophesied when the king ordered it.
3 From Jeduthun, the sons of Jeduthun:
Gedaliah, Zeri, Jeshaiah, Shimei, Hashabiah, and
Mattithiah.
These were six.
They were led by their father Jeduthun.
He prophesied with the harp.
He gave thanks and praised the LORD.
4 From Heman, the sons of Heman:
Bukkiah, Mattaniah, Uzziel, Shebuel, Jerimoth,
Hananiah, Hanani, Eliathah, Giddalti, Romamti-Ezer,
Joshbekashah, Mallothi, Hothir, and Mahazioth.
5 All these were the sons of Heman.
Heman was the king's seer.
He told the king the words of God.
He was to lift up the horn.
God gave Heman 14 sons and 3 daughters.
6 All these were led by their father.
They made music in the LORD's house
with cymbals, lyres, and harps.
That was their service in God's house.
Asaph, Jeduthun, and Heman took their orders from
the king.
7 They and their relatives were trained in singing to the
LORD.
All of them were skilled.
There were 288 of them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Music and singing in the temple were called "prophesying." That means: through the songs God spoke to the people, and the people spoke to God. Music can touch people deeply and lead them to God.

Heman is called "the king's seer." He was a musician and a prophet at the same time.

"To lift up the horn" is a picture for strength and honor. God gave Heman a large family.

Heman also had three daughters. According to verse 6, probably all his children sang along, the daughters too.

Interesting: the last names of Heman's sons (from Hananiah on) almost form a little prayer in Hebrew when put together: "Be gracious to me, LORD, be gracious to me, you are my God. I have made great and lifted up the help ..." Some scholars think that here the first lines of a psalm became names.

288 is 24 times 12. So there are 24 groups of 12 singers each, like the 24 divisions of priests.

The 24 groups of singers VERSES 8–31

8 They drew lots for their duties.
Everyone was treated the same:
the young and the old,
the teacher as well as the student.
9 The first lot for Asaph fell to Joseph.
The second lot fell to Gedaliah.
He, his relatives, and his sons were 12.
10 The third lot fell to Zaccur.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
11 The fourth lot fell to Izri.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
12 The fifth lot fell to Nethaniah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
13 The sixth lot fell to Bukkiah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
14 The seventh lot fell to Jesharelah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
15 The eighth lot fell to Jeshaiah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
16 The ninth lot fell to Mattaniah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
17 The tenth lot fell to Shimei.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
18 The eleventh lot fell to Azarel.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
19 The twelfth lot fell to Hashabiah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
20 The thirteenth lot fell to Shubael.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
21 The fourteenth lot fell to Mattithiah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
22 The fifteenth lot fell to Jeremoth.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
23 The sixteenth lot fell to Hananiah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
24 The seventeenth lot fell to Joshbekashah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
25 The eighteenth lot fell to Hanani.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
26 The nineteenth lot fell to Mallothi.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
27 The twentieth lot fell to Eliathah.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.

28 The twenty-first lot fell to Hothir.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
29 The twenty-second lot fell to Giddalti.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
30 The twenty-third lot fell to Mahazioth.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.
31 The twenty-fourth lot fell to Romamti-Ezer.
He, his sons, and his relatives were 12.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again the lot decides, as with the priests. "The teacher as well as the student": all are equal, whether experienced or new.

Each group had 12 singers. So there were always enough musicians for worship.

Some names are spelled a little differently than in verses 2–4: Izri is Zeri, Jesharelah is Asharelah, Azarel is Uzziel, Shubael is Shebuel, Jeremoth is Jerimoth.

For the first group (Joseph) the number 12 is missing. It was probably lost when the text was copied.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 26

Doorkeepers, treasurers and officials

The families of the doorkeepers VERSES 1–12

1 These were the groups of the doorkeepers:
From the Korahites:
Meshelemiah, the son of Kore, from the sons of Asaph.
2 Meshelemiah had sons:
Zechariah was the firstborn,
Jediael was second,
Zebadiah was third,
Jathniel was fourth,
3 Elam was fifth,
Jehohanan was sixth,
and Eliehoenai was seventh.
4 Obed-Edom had sons:
Shemaiah was the firstborn,
Jehozabad was second,
Joah was third,
Sacar was fourth,
Nethanel was fifth,
5 Ammiel was sixth,
Issachar was seventh,
and Peullethai was eighth.
For God blessed him.
6 Obed-Edom's son Shemaiah also had sons.
They were leaders in their family,
because they were brave, mighty men.
7 The sons of Shemaiah were
Othni, Rephael, Obed, and Elzabad.
Their relatives Elihu and Semachiah were also brave men.
8 All these were descendants of Obed-Edom.
They, their sons, and their relatives were able men.
They were strong enough for the work.
There were 62 from Obed-Edom.
9 Meshelemiah had sons and relatives.
They were 18 brave men.
10 Hosah, one of the descendants of Merari, also had sons.
Shimri was the leader.
He was not the firstborn, but his father made him the leader.
11 Hilkiah was second,
Tebaliah was third,
and Zechariah was fourth.
Hosah's sons and relatives were 13 in all.
12 These were the groups of the doorkeepers, with their leaders.
Like their relatives, they had duties.
They served in the LORD's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The doorkeepers guarded the entrances of the temple.

Obed-Edom is blessed here with many sons: "For God blessed him." The ark had stayed in his house for three months (1 Chronicles 13:14). Its blessing passed on to his whole family.

"Of the sons of Asaph" in verse 1 is probably a different Asaph from the singer, namely Ebiasaph (1 Chronicles 9:19).

In verse 10 Hosah makes not the firstborn, but another son the chief. Perhaps the firstborn had died or was not suitable.

The gates are given out by lot VERSES 13–19

13 They drew lots for every gate, family by family.
The young and the old were treated the same.
14 The lot for the east gate fell to Shelemiah.
Then they drew lots for his son Zechariah.
Zechariah was a wise adviser.
His lot was the north gate.
15 Obed-Edom got the south gate.
His sons got the storehouse.
16 Shuppim and Hosah got the west gate.
It was by the Shallecheth Gate, on the road that goes up.
Guard stood across from guard.
17 On the east side there were six Levites each day.
On the north side there were four each day.
On the south side there were four each day.
At the storehouse there were two at each place.
18 At the Parbar on the west side,
there were four on the road and two at the Parbar.
19 These were the groups of the doorkeepers
from the descendants of Korah and of Merari.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Each side of the temple had its doorkeepers. In the east, where the main entrance was, the most stood.

Shelemiah is another form of Meshelemiah.

"Parbar" is a rare word. It was probably an open building or courtyard on the west side of the temple.

We do not know what the gate "Shallecheth" was.

The treasurers VERSES 20–28

20 Some of the Levites were in charge of the treasures.
Ahijah took care of the treasures of God's house
and the treasures of the dedicated gifts.
Dedicated gifts are things that people gave to God.
21 Some were descendants of Ladan.
They were Gershonites through Ladan.
They were heads of the families of Ladan the
Gershonite.
One of them was Jehieli.
22 Jehieli's sons were Zetham and his brother Joel.
They were in charge of the treasures of the LORD's
house.
23 There were also leaders from the families of Amram,
Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel:
24 Shebuel was the son of Gershom, the son of Moses.
He was the chief officer over the treasuries.
25 His relatives came from Eliezer.
Eliezer's son was Rehabiah.
Rehabiah's son was Jeshaiah.
Jeshaiah's son was Joram.
Joram's son was Zichri.
Zichri's son was Shelomoth.
26 This Shelomoth and his relatives
were in charge of all the treasuries of the dedicated
gifts.
These gifts were given by King David,
by the heads of the families,
by the commanders of thousands and of hundreds,
and by the commanders of the army.
27 They gave part of the plunder they had taken in battles.
It was to be used to repair the LORD's house.
28 Shelomoth and his relatives also took care of
everything
that Samuel the seer had dedicated,
and Saul, the son of Kish,
and Abner, the son of Ner,
and Joab, the son of Zeruiah.
They took care of everything that anyone had
dedicated.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple had great treasures. Honest and reliable Levites took care of them. Here too it shows: order and honesty with money are important in worship.

Again descendants of Moses are named, Shebuel and Shelomoth. They had responsible tasks.

Even Samuel, Saul, Abner and Joab had dedicated gifts for the temple, long before it was built.

Officials in the whole land VERSES 29–32

29 From the Izharites:
Chenaniah and his sons were given work outside the
temple.
They were officials and judges over Israel.
30 From the Hebronites:
Hashabiah and his relatives were 1,700 brave men.
They were in charge of Israel on the west side of the
Jordan.
They took care of all the LORD's work and of the king's
service.
31 Jerijah was the leader of the Hebronites,
listed by their generations and families.
In the fortieth year of David's rule,
the records of the Hebronites were searched.
They found brave, mighty men among them at Jazer
in Gilead.
32 Jerijah had 2,700 relatives.
They were brave men and heads of families.
King David put them in charge of the Reubenites, the
Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh.
They took care of everything that had to do with God
and everything that had to do with the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Not all Levites worked in the temple. Many served in the whole land as officials and judges. They took care of religious questions and of tasks for the king.

"On the west side of the Jordan": the Hebrew text says "beyond the Jordan westward." For someone standing in the east, this land lay "beyond" the river.

In the fortieth year, that is, in David's last year, he still put all this in order.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 27

David's army commanders and officials

The 12 divisions of the army VERSES 1–15

1 This is the list of the Israelites who served the king.
They were heads of families,
commanders of thousands and of hundreds,
and their officers.
They served the king in all matters of the army
divisions.
Each division came on duty for one month and then
went off duty.
This went on every month of the year.
Each division had 24,000 men.
2 Jashobeam, the son of Zabdiel, was in charge of the
first division, for the first month.
His division had 24,000 men.
3 He was a descendant of Perez.
He was the leader of all the army commanders for the
first month.
4 Dodai the Ahohite was in charge of the division for the
second month.
Mikloth was the leader of his division.
His division had 24,000 men.
5 The third army commander, for the third month, was
Benaiah.

He was the son of Jehoiada, the chief priest.
His division had 24,000 men.
6 This is the Benaiah who was a mighty man among the thirty.
He was in charge of the thirty.
His son Ammizabad was in his division.
7 The fourth commander, for the fourth month, was Asahel, the brother of Joab.
His son Zebadiah came after him.
His division had 24,000 men.
8 The fifth commander, for the fifth month, was Shamhuth the Izrahite.
His division had 24,000 men.
9 The sixth commander, for the sixth month, was Ira, the son of Ikkesh, the Tekoite.
His division had 24,000 men.
10 The seventh commander, for the seventh month, was Helez the Pelonite.
He was from the tribe of Ephraim.
His division had 24,000 men.
11 The eighth commander, for the eighth month, was Sibbecai the Hushathite.
He was from the family of Zerah.
His division had 24,000 men.
12 The ninth commander, for the ninth month, was Abiezer the Anathothite.
He was from the tribe of Benjamin.
His division had 24,000 men.
13 The tenth commander, for the tenth month, was Maharai the Netophathite.
He was from the family of Zerah.
His division had 24,000 men.
14 The eleventh commander, for the eleventh month, was Benaiah the Pirathonite.
He was from the tribe of Ephraim.
His division had 24,000 men.
15 The twelfth commander, for the twelfth month, was Heldai the Netophathite.
He was from the family of Othniel.
His division had 24,000 men.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David had no large standing army. Instead, every month one division served with the king, like a kind of military service in turns. So the men could work at home the rest of the time.

The leaders are old friends: they are David's mighty men from chapter 11.

Asahel had fallen early in the war against Abner (2 Samuel 2:23). That is why it says here: "His son Zebadiah came after him" (1 Chronicles 27:7). The division probably kept his name.

In verse 5 Jehoiada is called "chief priest." The Hebrew text can also be read differently: "Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada the priest, as chief."

The leaders of the tribes VERSES 16–24

16 These were the leaders of the tribes of Israel:
Eliezer, the son of Zichri, was the leader of the Reubenites.
Shephatiah, the son of Maacah, led the Simeonites.
17 Hashabiah, the son of Kemuel, led Levi.
Zadok led the descendants of Aaron.
18 Elihu, one of David's brothers, led Judah.
Omri, the son of Michael, led Issachar.
19 Ishmaiah, the son of Obadiah, led Zebulun.
Jeremoth, the son of Azriel, led Naphtali.
20 Hoshea, the son of Azaziah, led Ephraim.
Joel, the son of Pedaiah, led the half-tribe of Manasseh.
21 Iddo, the son of Zechariah, led the half-tribe of Manasseh in Gilead.
Jaasiel, the son of Abner, led Benjamin.
22 Azarel, the son of Jeroham, led Dan.
These were the leaders of the tribes of Israel.
23 David did not count the men who were 20 years old or younger.
The LORD had promised to make Israel as many as the stars in the sky.
24 Joab, the son of Zeruiah, began to count the people, but he did not finish.
God's anger came on Israel because of this counting.
So the number was not written in the official records of King David.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Each tribe had a leader. Gad and Asher are missing in this list, but Levi and Aaron are named separately. So the number again comes to 12, if you count the half-tribes.

Elihu is probably Eliab, David's oldest brother (1 Samuel 16:6).

Jaasiel was a son of Abner, Saul's former army commander. Saul's people also got responsibility.

Verses 23–24 remind us of the census (Chapter 21). God had promised Abraham to make his people as many as the stars (Genesis 15:5). People should not count again what God has promised.

The managers of the king's property VERSES 25–31

25 Azmaveth, the son of Adiel, was in charge of the king's treasures.
Jonathan, the son of Uzziah, was in charge of the storehouses
in the fields, the cities, the villages, and the towers.
26 Ezri, the son of Chelub, was in charge of the field workers
who farmed the land.
27 Shimei the Ramathite was in charge of the vineyards.
Zabdi the Shiphmite was in charge of the grapes from the vineyards
and the wine cellars.
28 Baal Hanan the Gederite was in charge of the olive trees and the sycamore fig trees
in the lowland.
Joash was in charge of the storerooms for olive oil.
29 Shitrai the Sharonite was in charge of the cattle that grazed in Sharon.
Shaphat, the son of Adlai, was in charge of the cattle in the valleys.
30 Obil the Ishmaelite was in charge of the camels.
Jehdeiah the Meronothite was in charge of the donkeys.
Jaziz the Hagrite was in charge of the sheep and goats.

31 All these were the officials in charge of King David's property.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king had much property of his own: fields, vineyards, olive trees and herds. For each area there was an expert.

Remarkable: an Ishmaelite took care of the camels, a Hagrite of the flocks. The Arabs knew especially well how to handle camels and herds. David used people from other nations where they were good.

In verse 30 the Hebrew says "female donkeys."

David's advisers VERSES 32–34

32 Jonathan, David's uncle, was an adviser.
He was a wise man and a writer.
Jehiel, the son of Hachmoni, took care of the king's sons.
33 Ahithophel was the king's adviser.
Hushai the Archite was the king's friend.
34 After Ahithophel came Jehoiada, the son of Benaiah, and Abiathar.
Joab was the commander of the king's army.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehiel was probably the teacher of the king's sons.

"The king's friend" was a title of honor for a close and trusted adviser.

Later Ahithophel betrayed David and joined Absalom. Hushai stayed faithful to David and defeated Ahithophel's advice (2 Samuel 15–17). Chronicles mentions this only very briefly with the words "after Ahithophel."

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 28

David's last speech

David speaks to all Israel VERSES 1–8

1 David called all the leaders of Israel together in Jerusalem.
These were the leaders of the tribes
and the commanders of the divisions that served the king.
There were the commanders of thousands and the commanders of hundreds.
There were the men in charge of all the property and animals of the king and of his sons.
There were the officials and the mighty men, all the brave warriors.
2 Then King David stood up on his feet.
He said, "Listen to me, my brothers and my people!
I wanted with all my heart to build a house of rest
for the ark of the LORD's covenant.
It was to be the footstool of our God.
I had already made things ready for the building.
3 But God said to me,
'You must not build a house for my name.
You are a man of war, and you have shed blood.'
4 But the LORD, the God of Israel, chose me out of my father's whole family.
He chose me to be king over Israel forever.
He chose Judah to be the leader.
In the tribe of Judah, he chose my father's family.
And among my father's sons, he was pleased with me.
He made me king over all Israel.
5 The LORD has given me many sons.
Out of all my sons, he has chosen my son Solomon.
Solomon will sit on the throne of the LORD's kingdom over Israel.
6 The LORD said to me,
'Your son Solomon will build my house and my courtyards.
I have chosen him to be my son,
and I will be his father.
7 I will make his kingdom firm forever,
if he keeps on doing my commandments and my laws,
as he does today.'
8 So now, all Israel is watching. You are the LORD's assembly.
And our God is listening.
Keep all the commandments of the LORD your God, and search them out.
Then you will own this good land.
And you can pass it on to your children after you forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is old and weak. But now he stands up on his feet and gives a great farewell speech before the whole people.

"The footstool of our God": the ark was like the footstool for God's invisible throne.

David says honestly why he was not allowed to build the temple: because of all the blood.

A special phrase: Solomon sits on "the throne of the LORD's kingdom". For Chronicles the real king of Israel is God himself. The human king sits on his throne only in his place.

The promise has a condition: "if he keeps on doing my commandments". God's faithfulness invites faithfulness.

David speaks to Solomon VERSES 9–10

9 "And you, my son Solomon,
know the God of your father.
Serve him with your whole heart and with a willing mind.
The LORD searches all hearts.
He understands every plan and every thought.
If you seek him, he will let you find him.
But if you turn away from him, he will reject you forever.
10 Be careful now.
The LORD has chosen you
to build a house as his holy place.
Be strong, and do it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is David's personal legacy to his son: "Know the God of your father." Not only know about him, but know him

personally.
"With your whole heart and with a willing mind": God does not want forced service, but an open, ready heart.
"The LORD searches all hearts": you cannot hide anything from him. That is serious, but also comforting: God understands us completely.
"If you seek him, he will let you find him": a wonderful promise. God does not hide from those who honestly seek him (compare Jeremiah 29:13–14).

The plan of the temple VERSES 11–19

11 Then David gave his son Solomon the plans for the temple.
There were plans for the porch, for its buildings,
for its storerooms for treasure, for its upper rooms,
for its inner rooms,
and for the room of the mercy seat.
12 He gave him the plans of everything the Spirit had put in his mind.
There were plans for the courtyards of the LORD's house
and for all the rooms around them.
There were plans for the treasure rooms of God's house
and for the treasure rooms of the things given to God.
13 He also gave him the plans for the divisions of the priests and the Levites,
for all the work of serving in the LORD's house,
and for all the things used for the service in the LORD's house.
14 He told him how much gold to use for all the gold things for every kind of service.
And he told him how much silver to use for all the silver things for every kind of service.
15 He told him the weight of gold for the gold lampstands and their gold lamps.
He gave the weight for each lampstand and its lamps.
He told him the weight of silver for the silver lampstands and their lamps,
for each lampstand, depending on how it was used.
16 He told him the weight of gold for the tables for the holy bread, for each table.
And he told him the weight of silver for the silver tables.
17 The forks, the basins, and the cups were to be made of pure gold.
He gave the weight of gold for each gold bowl
and the weight of silver for each silver bowl.
18 He gave the weight of refined gold for the altar of incense.
And he gave the gold for the plan of the chariot.
That means: the cherubim that spread out their wings and cover the ark of the LORD's covenant.
19 David said, "The LORD wrote all this down for me with his own hand.
He made me understand all the work of this plan."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David gives Solomon an exact building plan. He says: the Spirit put this in his mind, and the LORD wrote it down "with his own hand". Just as Moses received the plan for the tabernacle from God (Exodus 25:9), David receives the plan for the temple.
Everything is planned exactly, down to the weight of every bowl. The best should be given to God, with care.
The "mercy seat" was the lid of the ark of the covenant. On the Day of Atonement blood was sprinkled there to make atonement for the guilt of the people (Leviticus 16:14–15).
"The chariot" is a picture for the cherubim above the ark, on which God is invisibly enthroned, as on a royal chariot. Later the prophet Ezekiel saw a vision of God's throne chariot (Ezekiel 1).

Be strong and courageous VERSES 20–21

20 David said to his son Solomon,
"Be strong and courageous, and do it!
Don't be afraid, and don't lose courage.
The LORD God, my God, is with you.
He will not fail you or leave you
until all the work for the service of the LORD's house is finished.
21 Look, here are the divisions of the priests and the Levites for all the service of God's house.
Every willing man who has skill for any kind of service will be with you in all the work.
And the commanders and all the people will do whatever you tell them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David encourages his son: you are not alone. God is with you. And many people help you.
"He will not fail you or leave you": God also gave this promise to Joshua (Joshua 1:5). It is taken up again in the New Testament (Hebrews 13:5). It is for everyone who has a great task ahead.

1 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 29

Willing gifts, David's prayer and his death

David's own gift VERSES 1–5

1 King David said to the whole assembly,
"God has chosen my son Solomon, and only him.
But he is still young and inexperienced,
and the work is great.
This palace is not for a human being.
It is for the LORD God.
2 I have worked with all my strength to get things ready for the house of my God.
I have gathered gold for the things of gold,
silver for the things of silver,
bronze for the things of bronze,
iron for the things of iron,
and wood for the things of wood.
I have also gathered onyx stones and stones to be set,
stones of different colors for inlaid work,

all kinds of precious stones,
and a great amount of marble.
3 And I love the house of my God very much.
So I am also giving my own treasure of gold and silver
to the house of my God.
This is on top of everything I have gathered for the
holy house.
4 I give 3,000 talents of gold (about 225,000 pounds), gold
from Ophir,
and 7,000 talents of refined silver (about 525,000
pounds).
They are to cover the walls of the buildings.
5 The gold is for the things of gold, and the silver is for
the things of silver.
It is for every kind of work that the craftsmen will
make.
Now who is willing to give himself to the LORD
today?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David does not only give from the royal treasury, but also from his own property. "I love the house of my God very much": where the heart is, there you give gladly.

He goes ahead with a good example, and then he invites the others to give willingly.

A talent is about 75 pounds. So these numbers are also very high.

In the Hebrew text it says literally "to fill your hand". This is an old phrase for: to consecrate yourself to God, to give yourself for his service.

The people give willingly VERSES 6–9

6 Then these men gave willingly:
the leaders of the families,
the leaders of the tribes of Israel,
the commanders of thousands and of hundreds,
and the officials in charge of the king's work.
7 They gave this for the service of God's house:
5,000 talents (about 375,000 pounds) and 10,000 darics
of gold,
10,000 talents of silver (about 750,000 pounds),
18,000 talents of bronze (about 1.35 million pounds),
and 100,000 talents of iron (about 7.5 million pounds).
8 Everyone who had precious stones gave them to the
treasury of the LORD's house.
Jehiel the Gershonite was in charge of it.
9 The people were full of joy, because they had given
willingly.
They had given to the LORD willingly, with their
whole heart.
And King David was also full of great joy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The great men of the people follow David's example. And the most important thing: they give willingly and from the heart. That is why there is joy among the people. Giving willingly makes you glad. Later Paul writes: "God loves a cheerful giver" (2 Corinthians 9:7).

"Darics" were Persian gold coins. They did not exist yet in David's time, but only about 500 years later. The writer of Chronicles changed the value into the money of his own time, so that his readers could understand it. 10,000 darics would be about 185 pounds of gold.

David's prayer of praise VERSES 10–19

10 So David praised the LORD in front of the whole
assembly.
David said,
"Praise be to you, LORD, the God of our father Israel,
forever and ever.
11 Yours, LORD, is the greatness and the power,
the glory, the victory, and the majesty!
Everything in heaven and on earth is yours.
Yours is the kingdom, LORD.
You are lifted high as the head over all.
12 Riches and honor come from you.
You rule over everything!
Power and strength are in your hand!
You have the power to make anyone great and to give
strength to everyone!
13 So now, our God, we thank you.
We praise your glorious name.
14 But who am I? And who are my people?
How could we give so willingly like this?
Everything comes from you.
We have only given you what is already yours.
15 We are strangers and foreigners before you, as all our
ancestors were.
Our days on earth are like a shadow.
Nothing stays.
16 LORD our God,
we have gathered all this wealth
to build a house for your holy name.
But it all comes from your hand.
It all belongs to you.
17 My God, I also know that you test the heart.
You are pleased when people are honest.
I have given all these things willingly, with an honest
heart.
And now I have seen with joy
how your people who are here give willingly to you.
18 LORD, God of our ancestors Abraham, Isaac, and
Israel,
keep this desire in the hearts and thoughts of your
people forever.
Make their hearts faithful to you.
19 And give my son Solomon a whole heart.
Help him keep your commandments, your teachings,
and your laws.
Help him do all these things.
And help him build the palace that I have gathered
everything for."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most beautiful prayers in the Bible.

Verse 11 sounds familiar: "Yours, LORD, is the greatness and the power, the glory … Yours is the kingdom, LORD". Similar words stand at the end of the Lord's Prayer, as it is prayed in many churches. This ending is based on David's prayer.

Verse 14 is the heart of it: "Everything comes from you. We have only given you what is already yours." When we give something to God, we only give back to him what he gave us first. Words like these are still spoken in many church services today at the offering.

Verse 15: "We are strangers and foreigners before you ... Our days on earth are like a shadow." The mighty king knows: life is short. Everything we have is only lent to us.

At the end David does not pray for more wealth, but for a heart that stays turned toward God, for the people and for his son.

Solomon becomes king VERSES 20–25

20 Then David said to the whole assembly,
"Now praise the LORD your God!"
And the whole assembly praised the LORD, the God of their ancestors.
They bowed their heads.
They bowed down to the ground before the LORD and the king.
21 On the next day they offered sacrifices to the LORD.
They offered burnt offerings to the LORD:
1,000 bulls, 1,000 rams, and 1,000 lambs,
with their drink offerings.
They offered many sacrifices for all Israel.
22 On that day they ate and drank before the LORD with great joy.
They made Solomon, the son of David, king a second time.
They anointed him before the LORD to be the ruler.
And they anointed Zadok to be priest.
23 Then Solomon sat on the throne of the LORD.
He became king in place of his father David.
He was successful, and all Israel obeyed him.
24 All the leaders and the mighty men,
and also all of King David's sons,
promised to obey King Solomon.
25 The LORD made Solomon very great in the eyes of all Israel.
He gave him royal majesty.
No king in Israel before him had ever had such majesty.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A great feast with sacrifices, eating and drinking, "with great joy".

"A second time": Solomon had already been made king in 1 Chronicles 23:1. Now he is solemnly confirmed before all the people.

Chronicles tells about the change of kings as a peaceful one. 1 Kings 1 tells that there was a fight about who would be the next king before that, because Adonijah wanted to become king himself. Here Chronicles stresses that all the sons of David promised to obey Solomon.

Again: Solomon sits on "the throne of the LORD".

David's death VERSES 26–30

26 So David, the son of Jesse, ruled over all Israel.
27 He was king over Israel for 40 years.
He ruled 7 years in Hebron.
And he ruled 33 years in Jerusalem.
28 He died at a good old age.
He had a long life, riches, and honor.
And his son Solomon became king in his place.
29 Everything King David did, from first to last, is written down.
It is in the records of Samuel the seer,
in the records of Nathan the prophet,
and in the records of Gad the seer.
30 They tell about his whole reign and his power.
They tell about the events that happened to him, to Israel, and to all the kingdoms of the lands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David dies after a long, full life. He reigned from about 1010 to 970 BC.

Chronicles names its sources: records of the prophets Samuel, Nathan and Gad. These books are lost today. Some of it probably went into the books of Samuel.

Looking back: What have we read in 1 Chronicles?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The family trees (Chapters 1–9): The book begins with Adam and leads through Abraham and the 12 tribes to the people who came back to Jerusalem after the exile. The message to the first readers: you belong. You stand in a long story with God. No one is forgotten, every name counts.

David (Chapters 10–29): After Saul's death David becomes king over all Israel. All the tribes come to him. He conquers Jerusalem and brings the ark into the city with joy and music.

God's promise: God says to David: "The LORD will build a house for you." David's family is to last forever. That is why Jews expect the Messiah from David's family, and Christians see the promise fulfilled in Jesus.

The temple: David is not allowed to build the temple himself, because he has shed much blood. But he prepares everything: the place, the material, the building plan, the priests, the Levites, the singers and the gatekeepers. Everything is in order and fairly shared out by lot.

The heart: Again and again it is about the heart: "Serve him with your whole heart." "If you seek him, he will let you find him." The people give willingly and with joy.

The lesson of the book: The most important thing in the life of a people and of a person is worship, that is, the relationship with God. David's prayer sums it up: "Everything comes from you. We have only given you what is already yours."

What comes next? 2 Chronicles tells about Solomon, the building of the temple, and the kings of Judah until the exile and the return.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 14 OF 66

2 CHRONICLES

36 CHAPTERS

2 CHRONICLES

Chapter 1

Solomon asks for wisdom

Before we begin: What is the second book of Chronicles?

The second book of Chronicles continues the first book of Chronicles. In the beginning, both were one single book.

It tells about King Solomon and about the building of the temple in Jerusalem (Chapters 1–9). After that it tells about the kings of Judah, until Jerusalem is destroyed by the Babylonians (Chapters 10–36).

Unlike the books of Kings, Chronicles tells almost only about Judah, the southern kingdom with Jerusalem and the temple. The northern kingdom of Israel appears only at the edge.

The most important theme is the temple and worship. For every king, Chronicles asks: Did he seek God? Did he respect the temple and worship? When a king seeks God, things go well for him and for the people. When he leaves God, disaster comes.

A favorite word of Chronicles is "seek": to seek God, to ask him, to turn to him. And Chronicles shows: even someone who has sinned badly can turn back, and God hears him.

The book ends with a view full of hope: the Persian king Cyrus allows the Jews to return to Jerusalem and to build the temple again.

We already know many stories from the books of Kings. Where Chronicles tells them differently, the boxes point this out.

Solomon at Gibeon VERSES 1–6

1 Solomon, the son of David, was made strong in his kingdom.
The LORD his God was with him
and made him very great.
2 Solomon spoke to all Israel,
to the commanders of thousands and of hundreds,
to the judges, and to every leader in all Israel, the heads of the families.
3 Then Solomon and all the assembly with him went to the place of worship on the hill at Gibeon.
For God's Tent of Meeting was there,
which the LORD's servant Moses had made in the wilderness.
4 But David had brought God's ark up from Kiriath Jearim
to the place that David had prepared for it.
For he had set up a tent for it in Jerusalem.
5 The bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri, the son of Hur, had made
was also there before the LORD's tabernacle.
And Solomon and the assembly were seeking counsel there.
6 Solomon went up there to the bronze altar before the LORD, which was at the Tent of Meeting,
and offered 1,000 burnt offerings on it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon begins his rule with worship. He does not go alone, but with the whole people.

Gibeon was about 6 miles northwest of Jerusalem. The old tabernacle from the time in the wilderness still stood there. The ark was already in Jerusalem (1 Chronicles 16:39).

Bezalel was the craftsman who had made the altar in the wilderness (Exodus 31:1–5). He came from Judah (1 Chronicles 2:20).

"Were seeking counsel there" can also mean "were seeking the LORD there". The word "seek" is especially important for Chronicles.

God appears to Solomon VERSES 7–13

7 That night God appeared to Solomon and said to him,
"Ask for what you want me to give you."
8 Solomon said to God,
"You have shown great loving kindness to David my father,
and you have made me king in his place.
9 Now, LORD God,
let your promise to David my father come true.
For you have made me king over a people
as many as the dust of the earth.
10 Now give me wisdom and knowledge,
so that I may go out and come in before this people.
For who can judge this great people of yours?"
11 God said to Solomon,
"This was in your heart.
You have not asked for riches, wealth, or honor,
or for the life of those who hate you,
and you have not asked for a long life either.
But you have asked for wisdom and knowledge for yourself,
so that you may judge my people, over whom I have made you king.
12 Because of this, wisdom and knowledge are given to you.
And I will give you riches, wealth, and honor,
such as none of the kings before you have had,
and none after you will have."
13 So Solomon came from the place of worship on the hill at Gibeon,
from before the Tent of Meeting, to Jerusalem.
And he ruled over Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God asks: "Ask for what you want me to give you." Solomon could have wished for anything. But he asks for wisdom, so that he can care well for his people. He does not think of himself, but of the people who are entrusted to him.

"Go out and come in" means: to guide and lead the people well.

God is glad about this request and gives him even more. Jesus said something similar: "But seek first God's Kingdom

and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well" (Matthew 6:33).

The story is told in more detail in 1 Kings 3. There the famous judgment of Solomon about the two women and the child follows.

Solomon's riches VERSES 14–17

14 Solomon gathered chariots and horsemen.
He had 1,400 chariots and 12,000 horsemen.
He placed them in the chariot cities and with the king in Jerusalem.
15 The king made silver and gold as common as stones in Jerusalem.
And he made cedars as common as the sycamore trees in the lowland.
16 The horses that Solomon had were brought out of Egypt and from Kue.
The king's merchants bought them from Kue.
17 They imported a chariot from Egypt for 600 pieces of silver, and a horse for 150,
and then they exported them.
They also exported them to the kings of the Hittites and the kings of Syria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's promise comes true: Solomon becomes rich and powerful.

"Kue" is probably Cilicia, a region in the south of today's Turkey. People bred horses there.

"Pieces of silver" are probably shekels. A shekel is about 0.4 ounces of silver.

In Hebrew, "Syria" is called "Aram".

Similar verses are in 1 Kings 10:26–29.

In some Bibles this chapter has one more verse, verse 18. It is chapter 2, verse 1 here. That is why the verse numbering in the next chapter is shifted.

2 CHRONICLES

Chapter 2

Solomon and King Huram of Tyre

Solomon plans the building VERSES 1–2

1 Solomon decided to build a house for the LORD's name,
and a house for his kingdom.
2 Solomon counted out 70,000 men to carry loads,
80,000 men who cut stone in the mountains,
and 3,600 to oversee them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon builds two houses: the temple for God and a palace for himself.

The numbers of workers are large. Verse 17 says who these people were: foreigners who lived in the land. For them it was hard forced labor.

In some Bibles verse 1 here is chapter 1, verse 18. And all the following verses of this chapter have a number one less there: verse 2 here is verse 1 there, and so on up to verse 18 here, which is verse 17 there.

Solomon's letter to Huram VERSES 3–10

3 Solomon sent word to Huram the king of Tyre:
"You helped David my father.
You sent him cedars, so that he could build himself a house to live in.
Do the same for me.
4 Look, I am about to build a house for the name of the LORD my God,
to dedicate it to him,
to burn sweet-smelling incense before him,
for the show bread that is always there,
and for the burnt offerings morning and evening,
on the Sabbaths, on the new moons, and on the set feasts of the LORD our God.
This is a rule forever for Israel.
5 "The house that I am building will be great,
for our God is greater than all gods.
6 But who is able to build him a house?
Heaven and the heaven of heavens can't contain him.
Who am I, then, that I should build him a house?
Only to burn incense before him.
7 "Now send me a man who is skilled
in working with gold, silver, bronze, and iron,
and with purple, crimson, and blue,
and who knows how to engrave,
to be with the skilled men who are with me in Judah and in Jerusalem,
whom David my father provided.
8 "Also send me cedar trees, cypress trees, and algum trees from Lebanon.
For I know that your servants know how to cut timber in Lebanon.
Look, my servants will be with your servants,
9 to prepare timber in great amounts for me.
For the house that I am about to build will be great and wonderful.
10 Look, I will give to your servants, the men who cut the timber,
about 120,000 bushels of beaten wheat,
about 120,000 gallons of barley,
about 120,000 gallons of wine,
and about 120,000 gallons of oil."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Huram is the same as Hiram in the books of Kings. He was king of the Phoenicians in Tyre.

Solomon explains to a foreign king what the temple is for: for prayer, incense, offerings and feasts.

Verse 6 is remarkable: Solomon knows that God is much too great for a house. "Heaven and the heaven of heavens can't contain him." The temple is not God's home in a narrow sense, but a place where people can meet God and honor him.

Purple and crimson were expensive colors for cloth. The Phoenicians were famous for their purple.

"Algum" was a precious wood, maybe red sandalwood.

The Bible says "20,000 cors" of wheat and "20,000 baths" of barley, wine and oil. A cor is about 6 bushels, a bath about 6 gallons. 1 Kings 5:11 gives other amounts.

Huram's answer VERSES 11–16

11 Then Huram the king of Tyre answered in a letter,
which he sent to Solomon:
"Because the LORD loves his people, he has made you
king over them."
12 Huram went on:
"Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel,
who made heaven and earth,
who has given David the king a wise son,
full of good sense and understanding,
who will build a house for the LORD and a house for
his kingdom.
13 Now I have sent a skilled man, full of understanding,
Huram-abi,
14 the son of a woman of the daughters of Dan.
His father was a man of Tyre.
He is skilled in working with gold, silver, bronze, iron,
stone, and timber,
with purple, blue, fine linen, and crimson.
He can also engrave any kind of engraving
and work out any design that is given to him,
together with your skilled men
and the skilled men of my lord David your father.
15 "Now let my lord send to his servants the wheat, the
barley, the oil, and the wine
that he has spoken of.
16 And we will cut wood from Lebanon, as much as you
need.
We will bring it to you on rafts by sea to Joppa.
Then you shall carry it up to Jerusalem."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A pagan king praises the God of Israel as the Creator of heaven and earth. Chronicles shows: other peoples also see God's greatness.

"Because the LORD loves his people": a good king is a gift of God for the people.

Huram-abi is a man of mixed origin: his mother was an Israelite from the tribe of Dan, his father a Phoenician. And he becomes the most important artist in building the temple. 1 Kings 7:14 says that his mother was a widow from the tribe of Naphtali.

Joppa is today Jaffa, a part of Tel Aviv. From there the wood was brought about 40 miles uphill to Jerusalem.

The foreigners as workers VERSES 17–18

17 Solomon counted all the foreigners who lived in the
land of Israel,
following the census with which David his father had
counted them.
They found 153,600.
18 He set 70,000 of them to carry loads,
80,000 to cut stone in the mountains,
and 3,600 as overseers to give the people their work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The foreigners, that is, people from the earlier peoples of Canaan, had to do forced labor for the building. For them this was a hard fate. The Bible tells it honestly.

God's law actually demanded that foreigners be treated well. About the foreigner it says: "You shall love him as yourself" (Leviticus 19:34). The splendid temple was also built on the hard work of these people. That is part of the truth.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 3

The building of the temple begins

The place and the measurements VERSES 1–4

1 Then Solomon began to build the LORD's house in
Jerusalem
on Mount Moriah,
where the LORD had appeared to David his father,
in the place that David had prepared and chosen,
on the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite.
2 He began to build on the second day of the second
month,
in the fourth year of his reign.
3 These are the foundations that Solomon laid for
building God's house:
The length, by the old measure, was about 90 feet,
and the width about 30 feet.
4 The porch in front was as long as the house was wide,
about 30 feet,
and its height was about 180 feet.
He covered it inside with pure gold.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple is built exactly where the angel stopped and David built the altar (1 Chronicles 21).

Mount Moriah is the place where Abraham was to sacrifice his son Isaac and where God stopped him (Genesis 22:2). Only here in 2 Chronicles 3:1 does the Bible call the Temple Mount by this name. In this way two great stories of the Bible are connected: Abraham and Isaac, David and the angel. Both are stories in which God keeps life safe.

That was around the year 966 BC.

The Bible says "60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide". A cubit is about 18 inches. "By the old measure" means: by the old, longer cubit.

The height of the porch, "120" cubits (about 180 feet), is very high, much higher than the temple itself (30 cubits, 1 Kings 6:2). Some old manuscripts have "20 cubits" here. Maybe the larger number is a copying mistake.

Gold and precious stones VERSES 5–9

5 He gave the larger room a ceiling of cypress wood
and covered it with fine gold.
He decorated it with palm trees and chains.

6 He decorated the house with precious stones, for beauty.
The gold was gold from Parvaim.
7 He also covered the house, the beams, the thresholds, its walls, and its doors with gold,
and he carved cherubim on the walls.
8 He made the most holy place.
Its length, the same as the width of the house, was about 30 feet,
and its width was about 30 feet.
He covered it with fine gold, 600 talents (about 45,000 pounds).
9 The weight of the nails was 50 shekels of gold (about 1¼ pounds).
He also covered the upper rooms with gold.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple was splendid, full of gold and decoration. For God, the most beautiful and the best should be given.

Palm trees and cherubim remind us of the Garden of Eden. There cherubim guarded the entrance to the garden (Genesis 3:24). The temple was like a picture of paradise, the place where God and people are together.

Nobody knows where "Parvaim" was. It was known for its gold.

The most holy place was a cube: 20 cubits long, wide and high (compare 1 Kings 6:20). A cubit is about 18 inches.

A talent is about 75 pounds. A shekel is about 0.4 ounces.

The cherubim in the most holy place VERSES 10–14

10 In the most holy place he made two carved cherubim, and they covered them with gold.
11 The wings of the cherubim were about 30 feet long in all:
One wing of the one cherub was about 7½ feet long and reached to the wall of the house.
The other wing was about 7½ feet long and reached to the wing of the other cherub.
12 One wing of the other cherub was about 7½ feet long and reached to the wall of the house.
The other wing was about 7½ feet long and touched the wing of the first cherub.
13 The wings of these cherubim spread out about 30 feet.
They stood on their feet,
and their faces were turned toward the house.
14 He made the curtain of blue, purple, crimson, and fine linen,
and decorated it with cherubim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Two large cherubim stood in the most holy place. Their wings filled the whole room from wall to wall. Later the ark of the covenant stood under their wings.

Cherubim are heavenly beings who guard God's throne. People imagined that God sits on his throne above them, invisible.

The Bible says "20 cubits" and "5 cubits". A cubit is about 18 inches.

The curtain separated the most holy place from the rest of the temple. Only the high priest was allowed to go in, once a year. The New Testament tells that when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn (Mark 15:38). Christians see in this a sign that the way to God is now open for everyone.

The two pillars VERSES 15–17

15 In front of the house he made two pillars, about 52½ feet high.
The capital on the top of each of them was about 7½ feet high.
A capital is the top part of a pillar.
16 He made chains in the inner sanctuary
and put them on the tops of the pillars.
And he made 100 pomegranates and put them on the chains.
17 He set up the pillars in front of the temple,
one on the right and the other on the left.
He named the one on the right Jachin,
and the one on the left Boaz.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The two large bronze pillars stood free in front of the entrance.

"Jachin" means "He (God) sets up" or "He makes firm". "Boaz" means "In him is strength". Together they say: God gives support and strength.

The Bible says "35 cubits" and "5 cubits". A cubit is about 18 inches. In 1 Kings 7:15 the pillars are only 18 cubits high. Maybe both pillars are counted together here.

"In the inner sanctuary": the Hebrew has a word that can also be read as "like a necklace". What is meant is probably a chain network as decoration.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 4

The objects for the temple

The altar, the sea and the basins VERSES 1–10

1 Then he made an altar of bronze,
about 30 feet long, about 30 feet wide, and about 15 feet high.
2 He also made the cast metal sea,
about 15 feet from rim to rim.
It was round, about 7½ feet high,
and about 45 feet around.
3 Under it were figures of oxen, which went around it,
for about 15 feet, all around the sea.
The oxen were in two rows,
cast together with the sea when it was cast.
4 It stood on 12 oxen.
3 looked toward the north,
3 looked toward the west,
3 looked toward the south,
and 3 looked toward the east.
The sea was set on top of them,
and their back parts all faced inward.

5 It was about 3 inches thick.
Its rim was made like the rim of a cup, like the flower of a lily.
It held about 17,500 gallons.
6 He also made 10 basins,
and put 5 on the right and 5 on the left,
to wash in them.
The things that belonged to the burnt offering were washed in them.
But the sea was for the priests to wash in.
7 He made the 10 lampstands of gold, as the rule for them said,
and he set them in the temple,
5 on the right and 5 on the left.
8 He also made 10 tables
and placed them in the temple,
5 on the right and 5 on the left.
And he made 100 basins of gold.
9 He also made the court of the priests, the great court,
and doors for the court,
and he covered their doors with bronze.
10 He set the sea on the right side of the house, toward the southeast.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the objects for the temple are listed. We know most of them from 1 Kings 7.

The large bronze altar for the burnt offerings is described this exactly only here.

The "sea" was a huge water basin. The priests washed themselves in it before they served. Being clean before God was important.

The 12 oxen face all four directions, maybe a picture of the 12 tribes of Israel.

In 1 Kings 7:24 there are "buds" under the rim instead of the oxen. The Hebrew word means a kind of wild gourd. The two words look similar in Hebrew.

The Bible gives cubits (a cubit is about 18 inches), a "handbreadth" (about 3 inches) and "3,000 baths" (a bath is about 6 gallons). 1 Kings 7:26 says 2,000 baths.

Huram's work VERSES 11–18

11 Huram made the pots, the shovels, and the basins.
So Huram finished the work that he did for King Solomon in God's house:
12 the two pillars,
the bowls and the two capitals on the top of the pillars,
and the two networks to cover the two bowls of the capitals on the top of the pillars,
13 and the 400 pomegranates for the two networks,
two rows of pomegranates for each network,
to cover the two bowls of the capitals on the pillars.
14 He also made the stands,
and the basins on the stands,
15 the one sea, and the 12 oxen under it.
16 Huram-abi also made the pots, the shovels, the forks,
and all the objects that belong to them
for King Solomon, for the LORD's house,
of bright bronze.
17 The king cast them in the plain of the Jordan,
in the clay ground between Succoth and Zeredah.
18 So Solomon made all these objects in great amounts,
so that the weight of the bronze could not be found out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Huram-abi, the artist from Tyre, made the bronze objects.

They were cast in the plain of the Jordan, where there was the right clay for the casting molds.

"The bowls": the Hebrew has a word for "bowls" or "balls". These were the round parts of the capitals.

The golden objects VERSES 19–22

19 Solomon made all the objects that were in God's house:
the golden altar,
the tables with the show bread on them,
20 and the lampstands with their lamps, of pure gold,
to burn before the inner sanctuary, as the rule said,
21 and the flowers, the lamps, and the tongs of gold, of the purest gold,
22 and the snuffers, the basins, the spoons, and the fire pans of pure gold.
As for the entrance of the house:
its inner doors to the most holy place
and the doors of the main hall of the temple were of gold.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Inside the temple everything was of gold. The closer you came to the most holy place, the more precious everything became.

The "golden altar" was the altar of incense. Incense was burned on it. The smoke rose up like a prayer (Psalm 141:2).

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 5

The ark comes into the temple

The temple is finished VERSES 1–6

1 So all the work that Solomon did for the LORD's house was finished.
Then Solomon brought in the things that his father David had given to God:
the silver, the gold, and all the objects.
He put them in the treasure rooms of God's house.
2 Then Solomon called the elders of Israel to Jerusalem.
He also called all the heads of the tribes
and the leaders of the families of the people of Israel.
They were to bring the ark of the LORD's covenant up from the City of David.
The City of David is Zion.
3 So all the men of Israel came together to the king for the feast.
It was in the seventh month.

4 All the elders of Israel came.
And the Levites picked up the ark.
5 They brought up the ark,
the Tent of Meeting, and all the holy objects that were in the Tent.
The Levitical priests brought these up.
6 King Solomon and the whole community of Israel that had gathered around him
stood in front of the ark.
They sacrificed sheep and cattle.
There were so many that no one could count them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The story is told almost the same way in 1 Kings 8.

The feast in the seventh month is the Feast of Tabernacles (Booths) in the fall.

This time the Levites carry the ark the right way, on their shoulders (compare 1 Chronicles 15). Chronicles stresses this: here it is "the Levites", in 1 Kings 8:3 "the priests".

"The Levitical priests": this probably means the priests from the tribe of Levi. Some manuscripts have "the priests and the Levites".

The ark in the most holy place VERSES 7–10

7 The priests brought the ark of the LORD's covenant to its place.
They brought it into the inner room of the house, the most holy place.
They put it under the wings of the cherubim.
8 The cherubim spread out their wings over the place of the ark.
So the cherubim covered the ark and its poles from above.
9 The poles were very long.
The ends of the poles could be seen from the ark, in front of the inner room.
But they could not be seen from outside.
They are still there to this day.
10 There was nothing in the ark except the two tablets.
Moses had put them there at Horeb.
That was when the LORD made a covenant with the people of Israel,
after they came out of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only the two stone tablets with the Ten Commandments lay in the ark. At the heart of the temple is God's word.

"To this day": this sentence comes from the source that Chronicles used (1 Kings 8:8). At the time of Chronicles the ark had not existed for a long time. It was lost when Jerusalem was destroyed in 587 BC.

God's glory fills the house VERSES 11–14

11 Then the priests came out of the holy place.
All the priests who were there had made themselves holy.
They did not keep to their divisions.
12 All the Levites who were singers were there too:
Asaph, Heman, Jeduthun, and their sons and relatives.
They were dressed in fine linen.
They had cymbals, stringed instruments, and harps.
They stood on the east side of the altar.
With them were 120 priests who blew trumpets.
13 The trumpet players and the singers played and sang as one.
They made one sound, to praise and thank the LORD.
They raised their voices together with the trumpets, the cymbals, and the other instruments.
They praised the LORD and sang,
"For he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever!"
Loving kindness means: faithful love.
At that moment a cloud filled the house, the LORD's house.
14 Because of the cloud, the priests could not stand and do their work.
The LORD's glory filled God's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the high point: God himself comes into his house. The cloud is the sign of his presence.

Chronicles adds something that is missing in 1 Kings 8: the great music. All the priests, 120 trumpeters, all the singers sing "as one", with "one sound". And just at the moment when they sing "For he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever", God's glory comes. Praising together opens the space for God's presence.

All the priests were there, no matter which division they belonged to. On this special day they all served together.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 6

Solomon's prayer at the dedication of the temple

Solomon blesses the people VERSES 1–11

1 Then Solomon said,
"The LORD has said that he would live in the thick darkness.
2 But I have built a house for you, a home,
a place where you can live forever."
3 Then the king turned around.
He blessed the whole assembly of Israel,
while the whole assembly of Israel stood.
4 He said,
"Praise the LORD, the God of Israel!
He made a promise to my father David with his own mouth.
And with his own hands he has done what he promised.
He said,
5 'Since the day I brought my people out of the land of Egypt,
I did not choose any city in all the tribes of Israel to

build a house in,
a house where my name would be.
And I did not choose any man to be the ruler over my people Israel.
6 But now I have chosen Jerusalem as the place where my name will be.
And I have chosen David to be over my people Israel.'
7 My father David wanted with all his heart
to build a house for the name of the LORD, the God of Israel.
8 But the LORD said to my father David,
'You wanted with all your heart to build a house for my name.
It was good that you wanted this.
9 But you will not build the house.
Your own son will build the house for my name.'
10 "The LORD has done what he said.
I have taken the place of my father David.
I sit on the throne of Israel, as the LORD promised.
And I have built the house for the name of the LORD, the God of Israel.
11 I have put the ark there.
The LORD's covenant is in the ark,
the covenant he made with the people of Israel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This speech is almost the same in 1 Kings 8:12–21.

Solomon stresses: God has kept his promise. God has chosen Jerusalem and David.

"Live in the thick darkness": God is a mystery. No one can see him. The most holy place had no windows.

God praises David even for the good wish in his heart, although he was not allowed to carry it out himself.

Solomon's prayer: God, listen! VERSES 12–21

12 Then Solomon stood in front of the LORD's altar,
in front of the whole assembly of Israel,
and he spread out his hands.
13 Solomon had made a bronze platform.
It was about 7½ feet long, about 7½ feet wide, and about 4½ feet high.
He had put it in the middle of the courtyard.
He stood on it.
Then he knelt down in front of the whole assembly of Israel
and spread out his hands toward heaven.
14 He said,
"LORD, God of Israel,
there is no God like you in heaven or on earth.
You keep your covenant and show your faithful love to your servants
who live before you with all their heart.
15 You have kept your promise to your servant, my father David.
You spoke with your mouth, and with your hand you have done it, as we see today.
16 "So now, LORD, God of Israel,
keep the promise you made to your servant, my father David.
You said to him,
'There will always be a man from your family to sit before me on the throne of Israel.
But your sons must be careful how they live.
They must walk in my law, as you have walked before me.'
17 So now, LORD, God of Israel,
let your promise to your servant David come true.
18 "But will God really live on earth with human beings?
Even heaven, even the highest heaven, cannot hold you.
So this house that I have built can hold you even less!
19 But listen to the prayer of your servant, LORD my God.
Listen to my plea for help.
Hear the cry and the prayer that your servant prays to you.
20 Keep your eyes open toward this house day and night.
This is the place where you said you would put your name.
Listen to the prayer that your servant prays toward this place.
21 Listen to the requests of your servant and of your people Israel
when they pray toward this place.
Hear from the place where you live, from heaven.
And when you hear, forgive.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chronicles tells a detail that is missing in 1 Kings 8: Solomon stood on a platform so that everyone could see him, and there he knelt down before the whole people. The mighty king kneels before God.

Verse 16 says "walk in my law". 1 Kings 8:25 says "walk before me". For Chronicles, God's law is especially important.

Verse 18 is one of the most important sentences: God is so great that not even heaven can contain him. How then could a house? The temple is not a prison for God, but a place where people can meet him and pray.

The most important word in the prayer is: "Hear." And then: "Forgive." The temple is above all a place of forgiveness.

The Bible says "5 cubits" and "3 cubits". A cubit is about 18 inches.

Requests for many situations VERSES 22–39

22 "Someone may sin against his neighbor.
Then he may have to swear an oath.
He comes and swears the oath in front of your altar in this house.
23 Then hear from heaven, act, and judge your servants.
Punish the guilty one.
Let what he did come back on his own head.
And declare the innocent one to be in the right.
Give him what his right actions deserve.
24 "Your people Israel may lose a battle against an enemy because they have sinned against you.
Then they may turn back to you and praise your name.
They may pray and plead with you in this house.
25 Then hear from heaven.
Forgive the sin of your people Israel.
Bring them back to the land you gave to them and to their ancestors.
26 "The sky may be shut, so that there is no rain,
because the people have sinned against you.
Then they may pray toward this place and praise your

name.
They may turn away from their sin because you have made them suffer.
27 Then hear in heaven.
Forgive the sin of your servants, your people Israel.
Teach them the good way they should live.
And send rain on your land,
the land you gave to your people as their own.
28 "There may be hunger in the land,
or a deadly disease,
or plant diseases, or locusts or caterpillars.
Enemies may surround their cities in their land.
There may be any kind of disaster or sickness.
29 Then someone may pray and plead with you.
It may be one person or all your people Israel.
Each one knows his own trouble and his own pain.
He spreads out his hands toward this house.
30 Then hear from heaven, the place where you live, and forgive.
Give each person what all his ways deserve.
You know his heart.
Only you know the hearts of all people.
31 Then they will fear you.
They will walk in your ways as long as they live in the land you gave to our ancestors.
32 "A foreigner, who is not from your people Israel,
may come from a land far away.
He comes because of your great name,
your mighty hand, and your outstretched arm.
Foreigners may come and pray toward this house.
33 Then hear from heaven, the place where you live.
Do everything the foreigner asks you for.
Then all the peoples of the earth will know your name and fear you,
just like your people Israel.
And they will know that this house I have built is called by your name.
34 "Your people may go out to fight against their enemies, wherever you send them.
They may pray to you toward this city that you have chosen
and toward the house I have built for your name.
35 Then hear their prayer and their plea from heaven.
Help them and give them justice.
36 "Your people may sin against you.
After all, there is no one who doesn't sin.
You may be angry with them and hand them over to an enemy.
Their enemies may take them away as prisoners to another land, far away or near.
37 But in the land where they are prisoners, they may come to their senses.
They may turn back and plead with you in that land.
They may say,
'We have sinned. We have done wrong. We have done evil.'
38 They may turn back to you with all their heart and with all their soul
in the land where they are prisoners.
They may pray toward their own land, the land you gave to their ancestors.
They may pray toward the city you have chosen
and toward the house I have built for your name.
39 Then hear their prayer and their requests from heaven, the place where you live.
Help them and give them justice.
Forgive your people who have sinned against you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These requests are almost the same in 1 Kings 8:31–50. Solomon thinks of every kind of need: quarrels, war, drought, hunger, sickness and captivity.

Again and again: "Hear and forgive." For "there is no one who doesn't sin" (verse 36).

"Each one knows his own trouble and his own pain" (verse 29): God also hears the very personal prayer of a single person in their need.

The foreigner from another people may also pray, and God is to hear him (verses 32–33). God's house is open to all peoples.

The request for the prisoners (verses 36–39) was very important for the first readers of Chronicles. They had lived through the exile in Babylon. These verses told them: even far away, God hears.

The end of the prayer VERSES 40–42

40 "Now, my God, please keep your eyes open.
Let your ears listen to the prayers that are prayed in this place.
41 "Now rise up, LORD God, and come to your resting place,
you and the ark of your strength.
LORD God, let your priests be clothed with salvation.
Let your faithful people be glad about your goodness.
42 "LORD God, do not turn away from your anointed king.
Remember your faithful love to your servant David."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the prayer ends differently than in 1 Kings 8. Chronicles closes with words from Psalm 132:8–10.

"Rise up ... and come to your resting place": the ark, which has wandered for a long time, has now found a fixed place.

"Remember your faithful love to your servant David": at the end, Solomon appeals to God's promise to David. For the readers of Chronicles, who no longer had a king, this was a hope: God does not forget his promise to David.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 7

Fire from heaven and God's answer

Fire from heaven VERSES 1–3

1 Solomon finished praying.
Then fire came down from heaven.

It burned up the burnt offering and the sacrifices.
And the LORD's glory filled the house.
2 The priests could not go into the LORD's house,
because the LORD's glory filled the LORD's house.
3 All the people of Israel watched the fire come down.
They saw the LORD's glory on the house.
They bowed down on the stone floor with their faces to the ground.
They worshiped and thanked the LORD.
They sang, "For he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever!"
Loving kindness means: faithful love.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers Solomon's prayer with fire from heaven, as with Moses in the wilderness (Leviticus 9:24), with David on the threshing floor (1 Chronicles 21:26) and with Elijah on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18:38). The fire shows: God accepts the offering and the house.

The whole people falls down and sings the words of praise: "For he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever!" Only Chronicles tells about the fire and this scene, not 1 Kings 8.

The great feast VERSES 4–10

4 Then the king and all the people offered sacrifices to the LORD.
5 King Solomon sacrificed 22,000 cattle and 120,000 sheep.
In this way the king and all the people dedicated God's house.
That means: they gave it to God.
6 The priests stood in their places.
The Levites stood there too, with the LORD's musical instruments.
King David had made these instruments to give thanks to the LORD.
With them David had praised God through the Levites' service.
They sang, "For his loving kindness endures forever."
In front of them, the priests blew trumpets.
And all Israel stood.
7 Solomon also made the middle of the courtyard in front of the LORD's house holy.
There he offered the burnt offerings and the fat of the peace offerings.
The bronze altar that Solomon had made was too small.
It could not hold all the burnt offerings, the grain offerings, and the fat.
8 So at that time Solomon held the feast for seven days.
All Israel was with him.
It was a very large crowd.
They came from all the land, from the entrance of Hamath to the brook of Egypt.
9 On the eighth day they held a special holy meeting.
They had celebrated the dedication of the altar for seven days,
and the feast for seven days.
10 On the twenty-third day of the seventh month,
Solomon sent the people home to their tents.
They were joyful and glad in their hearts.
They were glad for all the good things
the LORD had done for David, for Solomon, and for his people Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The number of animals for sacrifice is huge. The meat of the peace offerings was eaten together. So it became a great feast meal for the whole people.

The feast lasted two weeks: seven days for the dedication of the altar and seven days for the Feast of Tabernacles (Booths). Then came one more closing day.

"The entrance of Hamath" lies in the far north. Some read the Hebrew words as the name of a town: Lebo Hamath. The "brook of Egypt" is the southern border. People from the whole land had come.

At the end everyone goes home "joyful and glad of heart".

God's answer to Solomon VERSES 11–16

11 So Solomon finished the LORD's house and the king's palace.
He did everything he had planned to do
in the LORD's house and in his own palace.
Everything went well.
12 Then the LORD appeared to Solomon at night.
He said to him,
"I have heard your prayer.
I have chosen this place for myself as a house of sacrifice.
13 "I may shut the sky, so that there is no rain.
I may command locusts to eat up the land.
I may send a deadly disease among my people.
14 My people are called by my name.
If my people will humble themselves, pray, and seek my face,
and if they turn away from their wicked ways,
then I will hear from heaven.
I will forgive their sin,
and I will heal their land.
15 From now on my eyes will be open.
My ears will listen to the prayers that are prayed in this place.
16 I have chosen this house now, and I have made it holy.
My name will be there forever.
My eyes and my heart will always be there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers Solomon's prayer directly: "I have heard your prayer."

Verse 14 is one of the best-known verses of Chronicles. It contains four steps: to humble oneself, to pray, to seek God's face and to turn back. And three promises of God: to hear, to forgive and to heal. This verse is a key sentence of the whole of Chronicles. Again and again the book tells: when a king or the people act like this, help comes.

"Heal their land": God wants to make whole again not only the single people, but also the community and the land.

Verses 13–15 are not in 1 Kings 9. Chronicles has added them.

Promise and warning VERSES 17–22

17 "And you:
Live before me as your father David lived.
Do everything I have commanded you.
Keep my laws and my rules.

18 Then I will make the throne of your kingdom firm.
I promised this in my covenant with your father David.
I said, 'There will always be a man from your family to rule in Israel.'
19 But you may turn away from me.
You may leave the laws and commandments that I have given you.
You may go and serve other gods and worship them.
20 Then I will pull up my people by the roots from my land, the land I gave them.
And I will throw this house out of my sight, the house I have made holy for my name.
I will make it a joke and an object of mockery among all peoples.
21 This house is so great now.
But then everyone who passes by will be shocked.
They will say, 'Why has the LORD done this to this land and to this house?'
22 And people will answer,
'Because they abandoned the LORD, the God of their ancestors,
who brought them out of the land of Egypt.
They turned to other gods.
They worshiped them and served them.
That is why the LORD has brought all this disaster on them.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God promises blessing if Solomon stays faithful. But he also warns: if the people worship other gods, even this splendid temple will be destroyed.

That really happened later (Chapter 36). For the first readers of Chronicles this was already history. These verses explained to them: God was not too weak. The destruction was the result of unfaithfulness.

But the way back is always open: "If my people will humble themselves, pray, and seek my face ... then I will hear" (verse 14).

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 8

Solomon's buildings and worship

Cities and fortresses VERSES 1–6

1 Solomon spent 20 years building the LORD's house and his own palace.
At the end of these 20 years,
2 Solomon built the cities that Huram had given him.
He let people of Israel live there.
3 Solomon went to Hamath Zobah and defeated it.
4 He built Tadmor in the wilderness.
He also built all the storage cities in Hamath.
5 He built Upper Beth Horon and Lower Beth Horon.
They were strong cities with walls, gates, and bars.
6 He also built Baalath and all the storage cities that Solomon had.
He built all the cities for his chariots and the cities for his horsemen.
He built everything he wanted to build in Jerusalem, in Lebanon, and in all the land he ruled.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the temple and the palace, Solomon builds cities and fortresses in the whole land.

In 1 Kings 9:11–13 it is the other way around: there Solomon gives Huram 20 cities. Maybe Huram gave them back later because he did not like them.

Tadmor is the later famous oasis city of Palmyra in the Syrian desert. 1 Kings 9:18 has "Tamar" in this place. The two names look very similar in Hebrew.

Hamath Zobah was in the north, in the area of today's Syria.

The forced labor VERSES 7–10

7 Some people were still left from the Hittites, the Amorites, the Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites.
They were not from Israel.
8 Their descendants were still in the land,
because the people of Israel had not wiped them out.
Solomon forced these people to work for him.
They still do this work today.
9 But Solomon did not make any of the people of Israel his slaves for his work.
They were his soldiers, the leaders of his officers, and the commanders of his chariots and of his horsemen.
10 King Solomon had 250 chief officers.
They were in charge of the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The descendants of the earlier peoples of Canaan had to do forced labor. For them it was a hard fate. The Bible tells it honestly.

1 Kings 9:23 has 550 officers instead of 250.

Solomon's wife, Pharaoh's daughter VERSE 11

11 Solomon brought Pharaoh's daughter up from the City of David.
He brought her to the palace that he had built for her.
He said,
"My wife must not live in the palace of David, the king of Israel.
The places where the LORD's ark has been are holy."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon had married an Egyptian princess. She was not an Israelite and probably worshiped Egyptian gods. That is why she was not to live near the ark.

Here Chronicles explains why she moved into her own palace. 1 Kings 9:24 tells it without this reason.

For Chronicles, the holiness of the place where God is present is very important.

Regular worship VERSES 12–16

12 Then Solomon offered burnt offerings to the LORD.
He offered them on the LORD's altar, which he had built in front of the porch.
13 He offered what was required for each day,
as Moses had commanded.
He offered sacrifices on the Sabbaths, at the new moons, and at the yearly feasts.
These feasts were three times a year:
the Feast of Unleavened Bread,
the Feast of Weeks,
and the Feast of Booths.
14 Solomon followed the orders of his father David.
He gave the divisions of the priests their work.
He gave the Levites their duties.
They were to praise God and to help the priests,
as each day required.
He also put the gatekeepers in their divisions at every gate.
David, the man of God, had commanded this.
15 The priests and the Levites did not turn away from anything the king commanded them.
This was true for every matter, and also for the treasures.
16 So all of Solomon's work was done,
from the day the foundation of the LORD's house was laid until it was finished.
So the LORD's house was completed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple is not only a building. Now regular worship begins: every day, on the Sabbath, at the new moon and at the three great feasts.

The three great feasts are: the Feast of Unleavened Bread (Passover, in the spring), the Feast of Weeks (Shavuot, in early summer, later "Pentecost") and the Feast of Booths (Tabernacles, in the fall). To this day Jews celebrate these three feasts.

Everything happens as David had ordered. Chronicles stresses that Solomon faithfully carries on the work of his father.

Ships to Ophir VERSES 17–18

17 Then Solomon went to Ezion Geber and to Eloth,
on the coast in the land of Edom.
18 Huram sent him ships through his servants.
He also sent servants who knew the sea well.
They sailed with Solomon's servants to Ophir.
From there they brought 450 talents of gold (about 34,000 pounds)
to King Solomon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezion Geber and Eloth (Elath) are on the Gulf of Aqaba, on the Red Sea.

The sailors from Tyre knew about sailing, Israel did not.

Nobody knows for sure where Ophir was. It was famous for its gold.

A talent is about 75 pounds. 1 Kings 9:28 has 420 talents.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 9

The queen of Sheba and the end of Solomon

The queen of Sheba VERSES 1–12

1 The queen of Sheba heard how famous Solomon was.
So she came to Jerusalem to test Solomon with hard questions.
She came with a very large caravan.
She had camels that carried spices, a lot of gold, and precious stones.
She came to Solomon
and talked with him about everything that was on her mind.
2 Solomon answered all her questions.
Nothing was too hard for Solomon to explain to her.
3 The queen of Sheba saw how wise Solomon was.
She saw the palace he had built.
4 She saw the food on his table and how his officials sat.
She saw how his servants served and what clothes they wore.
She saw his cup bearers and their clothes.
And she saw the way he went up to the LORD's house.
It took her breath away.
5 She said to the king,
"In my own land I heard about the things you have done and about your wisdom.
Everything I heard is true.
6 But I didn't believe it until I came here and saw it with my own eyes.
Now I see that they did not tell me even half of your great wisdom.
You are greater than everything I heard about you!
7 Your men are happy!
These servants of yours are happy!
They always stand before you and hear your wisdom.
8 Praise the LORD your God!
He was pleased with you and set you on his throne to be king for the LORD your God.
Your God loves Israel and wants to make them strong forever.
That is why he made you king over them,
to do justice and righteousness."
Righteousness means: what is right.
9 She gave the king 120 talents of gold (about 9,000 pounds).
She also gave him a great amount of spices and precious stones.
No one had ever brought such spices as the queen of Sheba gave King Solomon.
10 The servants of Huram and the servants of Solomon brought gold from Ophir.
They also brought algum wood and precious stones.

11 The king used the algum wood to make terraces for the
LORD's house and for the king's palace.
He also made harps and stringed instruments for the
singers from it.
No one had ever seen anything like them in the land of
Judah.
12 King Solomon gave the queen of Sheba everything she
wanted.
He gave her whatever she asked for.
He gave her more than she had brought to him.
Then she and her servants went back to her own land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The story is almost the same in 1 Kings 10.

Sheba was probably in the south of Arabia, in today's Yemen.

The queen praises the God of Israel. An important difference from 1 Kings 10:9: here she says to Solomon that God has "set you on his throne to be king for the LORD your God" (2 Chronicles 9:8). For Chronicles, God is the real king.

She understands what power is for: "to do justice and righteousness".

Jesus reminded people of the "Queen of the South", who came from the ends of the earth to hear the wisdom of Solomon (Matthew 12:42).

A talent is about 75 pounds.

"Terraces": the Hebrew word is unclear. Maybe stairs or railings are meant.

Solomon's riches VERSES 13–21

13 Every year Solomon received 666 talents of gold (about
50,000 pounds).
14 Besides that, the traders and merchants brought gold.
And all the kings of Arabia and the governors of the
land brought gold and silver to Solomon.
15 King Solomon made 200 large shields of hammered
gold.
He used 600 shekels of hammered gold (about 15
pounds) for each large shield.
16 He made 300 shields of hammered gold.
He used 300 shekels of gold (about 7½ pounds) for each
shield.
The king put them in the House of the Forest of
Lebanon.
17 The king also made a great throne of ivory.
He covered it with pure gold.
18 The throne had six steps and a footstool of gold.
They were attached to the throne.
On both sides of the seat there were armrests.
Two lions stood beside the armrests.
19 There were 12 lions on the 6 steps,
one on each side of every step.
Nothing like it had ever been made in any other
kingdom.
20 All King Solomon's drinking cups were made of gold.
All the dishes in the House of the Forest of Lebanon
were made of pure gold.
In Solomon's time, silver was not worth much.
21 The king had ships that sailed to Tarshish with Huram's
servants.
Once every three years the ships of Tarshish came
back.
They brought gold, silver, ivory, apes, and peacocks.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon is unbelievably rich. A talent is about 75 pounds. A shekel is about 0.4 ounces. 1 Kings 10:17 has "three minas" instead of 300 shekels.

The shields of gold were not for battle, but for splendor and feasts.

The House of the Forest of Lebanon was a large hall in Solomon's palace, with many pillars of cedar wood.

In Chronicles the fleet goes "to Tarshish". 1 Kings 10:22 only calls them "ships of Tarshish", that is, large ships for long journeys. It is not certain where Tarshish was.

The translation "peacocks" is uncertain. Some translate "baboons".

Solomon's wisdom and power VERSES 22–28

22 So King Solomon was greater than all the kings of the
earth in riches and wisdom.
23 All the kings of the earth wanted to visit Solomon.
They wanted to hear the wisdom that God had put in
his heart.
24 Every year each of them brought him gifts:
things made of silver and gold, clothes, weapons,
spices, horses, and mules.
25 Solomon had 4,000 stalls for horses and chariots,
and 12,000 horsemen.
He kept them in the chariot cities and with him in
Jerusalem.
26 He ruled over all the kings from the River to the land of
the Philistines
and to the border of Egypt.
27 In Jerusalem the king made silver as common as
stones.
He made cedar wood as common as the sycamore trees
in the foothills.
28 People brought horses for Solomon from Egypt and
from all the other lands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's promise from Chapter 1 has come true: Solomon is richer and wiser than all kings. And verse 23 stresses: his wisdom came from God.

"The River" is the Euphrates.

1 Kings 4:26 has 40,000 stalls instead of 4,000.

Chronicles does not tell that Solomon later had many foreign wives and served foreign gods (1 Kings 11). It wants to show Solomon above all as the builder of the temple. It expects the readers to know the other story.

Solomon's death VERSES 29–31

29 Everything else that Solomon did, from first to last, is
written down.
It is in the records of Nathan the prophet,
in the prophecy of Ahijah from Shiloh,
and in the visions of Iddo the seer about Jeroboam, the
son of Nebat.
30 Solomon ruled in Jerusalem over all Israel for 40 years.
31 Then Solomon died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried in the city of his father David.
And his son Rehoboam became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chronicles names books of prophets as sources. Today they are lost.

Ahijah of Shiloh was the prophet who announced to Jeroboam that he would become king over the 10 northern tribes (1 Kings 11:29–39).

Solomon reigned from about 970 to 930 BC.

2 CHRONICLES

Chapter 10

The kingdom is divided

The people ask for relief VERSES 1–5

1 Rehoboam went to Shechem,
for all Israel had come to Shechem to make him king.
2 Jeroboam the son of Nebat heard about it.
He was in Egypt, where he had fled from King Solomon.
So Jeroboam returned out of Egypt.
3 They sent for him and called him.
And Jeroboam and all Israel came and spoke to Rehoboam:
4 "Your father made our yoke hard to bear.
Now make the hard service of your father lighter,
and the heavy yoke that he put on us,
and we will serve you."
5 He said to them,
"Come back to me after three days."
So the people left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is almost the same in 1 Kings 12.

Shechem was in the north. The northern tribes did not want to simply accept Rehoboam as king. They wanted to negotiate.

A "yoke" is a wooden beam that is used to hitch animals to a plow. It is a picture of burden and oppression. The people suffered under Solomon's high taxes and the forced labor.

Chronicles does not tell who Jeroboam was. It expects the readers to know 1 Kings 11: a prophet had announced to Jeroboam that he would become king over the 10 northern tribes.

The advice of the old men and the advice of the young men VERSES 6–15

6 King Rehoboam asked the old men for advice.
They had served Solomon his father while he was still alive.
He said,
"What advice do you give me? How should I answer these people?"
7 They said to him,
"If you are kind to these people, please them, and speak good words to them,
then they will be your servants forever."
8 But he rejected the advice that the old men had given him.
He asked for advice from the young men who had grown up with him
and who served him.
9 He said to them,
"What advice do you give?
How should we answer these people who have said to me,
'Make the yoke that your father put on us lighter'?"
10 The young men who had grown up with him said to him,
"The people said to you,
'Your father made our yoke heavy, but make it lighter for us.'
Tell them this:
'My little finger is thicker than my father's waist.
11 My father put a heavy yoke on you,
but I will add to your yoke.
My father punished you with whips,
but I will punish you with scorpions.'"
12 So Jeroboam and all the people came to Rehoboam on the third day,
as the king had said: "Come to me again on the third day."
13 The king answered them harshly.
King Rehoboam rejected the advice of the old men,
14 and spoke to them as the young men had advised:
"My father made your yoke heavy, but I will add to it.
My father punished you with whips,
but I will punish you with scorpions."
15 So the king didn't listen to the people.
For God brought this about,
so that the LORD might make his word come true,
which he spoke through Ahijah the Shilonite to Jeroboam the son of Nebat.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The old men give wise advice: be kind to the people, then they will serve you. 1 Kings 12:7 says it even more clearly: "If you will be a servant to this people today ..."

The young men grew up in the palace. They do not know the hard life of the people. They advise him to be harsh and to boast.

"Scorpions" were maybe whips with spikes.

Verse 15: God brought this about. That does not mean that Rehoboam was not guilty. He made his choice himself. But God also works through the mistakes of people.

The northern tribes break away VERSES 16–19

16 All Israel saw that the king didn't listen to them.
So the people answered the king,
"What share do we have in David?
We have no inheritance in the son of Jesse!
Every man to your tents, Israel!
Now take care of your own house, David."
So all Israel went away to their tents.
17 But Rehoboam reigned over the people of Israel who lived in the cities of Judah.

18 Then King Rehoboam sent Hadoram, who was over the men who had to do forced labor.
And the people of Israel stoned him to death with stones.
King Rehoboam quickly got up into his chariot to flee to Jerusalem.
19 So Israel rebelled against David's house to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

From now on there are two kingdoms: in the north Israel with 10 tribes, in the south Judah with Jerusalem. That happened around 930 BC.

Of all people, Rehoboam sends the chief of the forced labor to the angry people. That was very unwise. In 1 Kings 12:18 Hadoram is called "Adoram".

After this, Chronicles tells almost only about Judah. The northern kingdom only appears when it has to do with Judah. But for Chronicles the north also remains part of God's people: "Israel".

2 CHRONICLES

Chapter 11

Rehoboam, king of Judah

No war between brothers VERSES 1–4

1 Rehoboam came to Jerusalem.
He called together the people of Judah and Benjamin, 180,000 of the best soldiers.
They were to fight against Israel and win the kingdom back for Rehoboam.
2 But the LORD spoke to Shemaiah, the man of God.
He said,
3 "Speak to Rehoboam, the son of Solomon, the king of Judah.
And speak to all the Israelites in Judah and Benjamin.
Tell them,
4 'This is what the LORD says:
"Do not go up and fight against your brothers!
Every one of you, go back home.
I have made this happen."'"
So they listened to the LORD's words.
They turned back and did not go against Jeroboam.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rehoboam wants to bring back unity by force. But God says through the prophet Shemaiah: do not fight against your brothers!

Rehoboam listens to God. A civil war is prevented. Even though the kingdom is divided, the people remain "brothers".

Fortresses in Judah VERSES 5–12

5 Rehoboam lived in Jerusalem.
He built up cities in Judah to protect the land.
6 He built up Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa,
7 Beth Zur, Soco, Adullam,
8 Gath, Mareshah, Ziph,
9 Adoraim, Lachish, Azekah,
10 Zorah, Aijalon, and Hebron.
These were strong cities in Judah and in Benjamin.
11 He made the fortresses strong.
He put commanders in them.
He stored food, olive oil, and wine there.
12 He put shields and spears in every city.
He made the cities very strong.
So Judah and Benjamin belonged to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rehoboam builds a belt of fortresses around Judah, above all in the south and west, against Egypt and the Philistines.

This list is only in Chronicles. Many of these places, for example Lachish and Azekah, have been dug up by archaeologists.

Priests and Levites come to Judah VERSES 13–17

13 The priests and the Levites from all over Israel came from all their lands and stood on his side.
14 The Levites left their pastures and their property.
They came to Judah and Jerusalem.
Jeroboam and his sons had thrown them out.
They did not let them serve the LORD as priests.
15 Jeroboam chose his own priests for the high places.
They served the goat idols and the calf idols that he had made.
16 After the Levites, people came from all the tribes of Israel.
These were the people who had set their hearts to seek the LORD, the God of Israel.
They came to Jerusalem to sacrifice to the LORD, the God of their ancestors.
17 So they made the kingdom of Judah strong.
For three years they supported Rehoboam, the son of Solomon.
For three years they lived the way David and Solomon had lived.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the north, Jeroboam set up golden calves and appointed his own priests (1 Kings 12:28–31). The true priests and Levites lost their work.

That is why they moved to Judah, and with them many people from the north, the people "who had set their hearts to seek the LORD". They gave up their home in order to stay faithful to God.

Chronicles shows: in the north, too, there were people who sought God. The true Israel are those who seek God, no matter from which tribe.

"Goat idols": literally "goats", probably demons or idols in the shape of goats (compare Leviticus 17:7).

"For three years": this good time did not last long (2 Chronicles 12:1).

Rehoboam's family VERSES 18–23

18 Rehoboam married Mahalath.
She was the daughter of Jerimoth, the son of David.
Her mother was Abihail, the daughter of Eliab, the son of Jesse.
19 Mahalath had sons with him: Jeush, Shemariah, and Zaham.
20 After her, he married Maacah, the granddaughter of Absalom.
She had these children with him: Abijah, Attai, Ziza, and Shelomith.
21 Rehoboam loved Maacah, the granddaughter of Absalom, more than all his other wives and concubines.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
He had 18 wives and 60 concubines.
He had 28 sons and 60 daughters.
22 Rehoboam made Abijah, the son of Maacah, the leader among his brothers.
He wanted to make him king.
23 Rehoboam acted wisely.
He sent some of his sons to all the areas of Judah and Benjamin,
to every fortified city.
He gave them plenty of food.
And he found many wives for them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rehoboam married relatives from David's family. Mahalath and Maacah were both descendants of David or Jesse.

Like his father Solomon, Rehoboam had many wives. The law warned against this (Deuteronomy 17:17).

Here Maacah is called the "granddaughter" of Absalom. The Hebrew says "daughter", which can also mean "granddaughter". In 2 Chronicles 13:2 she is called "Micaiah the daughter of Uriel". Maybe Uriel was her father and Absalom her grandfather.

Rehoboam placed his sons as commanders in the fortresses. That way they had tasks and did not fight over the throne. That was wise.

2 CHRONICLES

Chapter 12

Shishak attacks Jerusalem

Rehoboam leaves God VERSES 1–4

1 Rehoboam's kingdom became firm, and he became strong.
Then he turned away from the LORD's law.
And all Israel turned away with him.
2 In the fifth year that Rehoboam was king,
Shishak, the king of Egypt, attacked Jerusalem.
This happened because the people had been unfaithful to the LORD.
3 Shishak came with 1,200 chariots and 60,000 horsemen.
He brought more soldiers from Egypt than anyone could count:
Lubim, Sukkiim, and Ethiopians.
4 He captured the fortified cities of Judah.
And he came as far as Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A well-known pattern: when things go well for Rehoboam and he is strong, he forgets God. Success can be dangerous.

Shishak is Pharaoh Shoshenq I. His war campaign around 925 BC is also known outside the Bible: in the temple of Karnak in Egypt there is a large inscription with the names of many places that he conquered in Palestine.

The fortresses that Rehoboam had built did not help.

The "Sukkiim" were probably a people from the Libyan desert. The "Ethiopians" came from the area south of Egypt. The Hebrew calls them "Cushites".

The princes humble themselves VERSES 5–8

5 Then the prophet Shemaiah came to Rehoboam and to the leaders of Judah.
They had gathered in Jerusalem because of Shishak.
Shemaiah said to them,
"This is what the LORD says:
'You have abandoned me.
So now I have abandoned you to Shishak.'"
6 Then the leaders of Israel and the king humbled themselves.
They said, "The LORD is in the right."
7 The LORD saw that they humbled themselves.
Then the LORD spoke to Shemaiah.
He said, "They have humbled themselves.
So I will not destroy them.
I will rescue them, at least in part.
I will not pour out my anger on Jerusalem through Shishak.
8 But they will have to serve him.
Then they will learn the difference between serving me
and serving the kings of other lands."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here we see the pattern from 2 Chronicles 7:14: the people humble themselves, and God hears and spares them.

"The LORD is in the right": they admit that they themselves are guilty.

God's answer is remarkable: they are to learn the difference between serving God and serving foreign rulers. Serving God is freedom, serving foreign powers is a burden.

Gold is replaced by bronze VERSES 9–12

9 So Shishak, the king of Egypt, attacked Jerusalem.
He took away the treasures of the LORD's house
and the treasures of the king's palace.
He took everything.
He also took the gold shields that Solomon had made.
10 King Rehoboam made bronze shields to replace them.
He gave them to the commanders of the guard.
They guarded the entrance of the king's palace.

11 Every time the king went into the LORD's house,
the guards came and carried the shields.
Afterward they brought them back to the guardroom.
12 Rehoboam humbled himself.
So the LORD's anger turned away from him,
and the LORD did not destroy him completely.
And there were still some good things in Judah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon's golden shields are gone. Rehoboam replaces them with bronze. From the outside it still looks similar, but the splendor is lost.

"There were still some good things in Judah": even in bad times there were still people who were faithful to God.

The end of Rehoboam VERSES 13–16

13 So King Rehoboam made his rule strong in Jerusalem,
and he ruled as king.
Rehoboam was 41 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 17 years in Jerusalem.
The LORD had chosen this city out of all the tribes of
Israel as the place for his name.
Rehoboam's mother was Naamah, a woman from
Ammon.
14 Rehoboam did what was evil.
He did not set his heart to seek the LORD.
15 Everything Rehoboam did, from first to last, is written
down.
It is in the records of Shemaiah the prophet and of
Iddo the seer,
in the family lists.
Rehoboam and Jeroboam were always at war with
each other.
16 Then Rehoboam died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried in the City of David.
And his son Abijah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14 is the verdict on Rehoboam: "He did not set his heart to seek the LORD." For Chronicles this is the deciding measure. Not one single mistake, but a heart that does not seek God.

Rehoboam reigned from about 930 to 913 BC.

In 1 Kings 15:1 Abijah is called "Abijam".

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 13

Abijah against Jeroboam

Two armies face each other VERSES 1–3

1 In the eighteenth year that Jeroboam was king,
Abijah became king over Judah.
2 He ruled in Jerusalem for three years.
His mother was Micaiah, the daughter of Uriel from
Gibeah.
There was war between Abijah and Jeroboam.
3 Abijah went into battle with an army of brave soldiers,
400,000 of the best men.
Jeroboam lined up his army for battle against him.
He had 800,000 of the best men, strong and brave
soldiers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abijah reigned from about 913 to 910 BC. In 1 Kings 15 he is called "Abijam", and there he is judged briefly and critically: "He committed all the same sins that his father had committed before him." Chronicles, on the other hand, tells a story in which Abijah for once trusts completely in God.

Here his mother is called Micaiah the daughter of Uriel. In 2 Chronicles 11:20 she is called Maacah. Probably it is the same woman with two forms of the name.

The numbers are huge. Many experts think that the Hebrew word for "thousand" can also mean "troop" or "unit" here. What matters is the message: Judah was only half as strong as Israel.

Abijah's speech on the mountain VERSES 4–12

4 Abijah stood on Mount Zemaraim, in the hill country
of Ephraim.
He called out, "Listen to me, Jeroboam and all Israel!
5 Don't you know this?
The LORD, the God of Israel, gave David the rule over
Israel forever.
He gave it to David and to his sons by a covenant of salt.
A covenant of salt is a covenant that lasts forever.
6 But Jeroboam, the son of Nebat, rose up against his
master.
He was only a servant of Solomon, the son of David.
7 Worthless men gathered around him.
These evil men became strong against Rehoboam, the
son of Solomon.
At that time Rehoboam was young and timid.
He could not stand up against them.
8 "And now you plan to stand up against the LORD's
kingdom,
the kingdom that the sons of David rule.
You are a very large army.
And you have the golden calves with you, which
Jeroboam made to be your gods.
9 You drove out the LORD's priests, the sons of Aaron,
and the Levites.
You made your own priests, like the peoples of other
lands.
Anyone who comes to dedicate himself with a young
bull and seven rams
can become a priest of gods that are no gods.
10 "But for us, the LORD is our God.
We have not abandoned him.
Our priests who serve the LORD are the sons of Aaron.
And the Levites help them in their work.
11 Every morning and every evening they burn burnt
offerings and sweet-smelling incense to the LORD.
They set out the show bread in rows on the pure table.

They take care of the gold lampstand and its lamps, so
that it burns every evening.
We keep the commands of the LORD our God.
But you have abandoned him.
12 Look, God himself is with us as our leader.
His priests are here with their trumpets, ready to
sound the battle call against you.
People of Israel, don't fight against the LORD, the God
of your ancestors.
You will not win!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before the fighting, Abijah gives a speech. It is a kind of sermon of Chronicles.

A "covenant of salt" is a covenant that lasts forever. Salt keeps food from going bad (compare Numbers 18:19).

Abijah says: the true kingdom is really the kingdom of God. And the true worship takes place in Jerusalem, with the right priests, the daily offerings, the show bread and the lampstand.

In the north, on the other hand, anyone could become a priest who paid with enough animals. And Abijah calls the golden calves "gods that are no gods".

Important: Abijah calls the people in the north "people of Israel". He asks them: do not fight against God! They are still brothers.

Abijah speaks harshly about Rehoboam as "young and timid". But Rehoboam was 41 years old when he became king (2 Chronicles 12:13). What is probably meant is: without experience and weak.

Judah cries out to God VERSES 13–20

13 But Jeroboam had sent soldiers around to attack Judah
from behind.
So Jeroboam's army was in front of Judah, and the
hidden soldiers were behind them.
14 The men of Judah turned around.
They saw that the enemy was attacking them from the
front and from behind!
Then they cried out to the LORD.
And the priests blew the trumpets.
15 Then the men of Judah gave a battle shout.
When the men of Judah shouted,
God struck Jeroboam and all Israel down in front of
Abijah and Judah.
16 The Israelites ran away from Judah.
And God handed them over to Judah.
17 Abijah and his soldiers killed a great number of them.
500,000 of Israel's best men were killed.
18 So at that time the Israelites were defeated.
And the men of Judah won the battle,
because they trusted in the LORD, the God of their
ancestors.
19 Abijah chased Jeroboam.
He captured these cities from him:
Bethel and its villages,
Jeshanah and its villages,
and Ephron and its villages.
20 As long as Abijah lived, Jeroboam never became strong
again.
The LORD struck him down, and he died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Judah is surrounded. In military terms the situation is hopeless. But they cry out to God. The deciding sentence is in verse 18: "because they trusted in the LORD, the God of their ancestors".

Chronicles wants to give courage with this: whoever trusts in God is not lost, even if he is weaker.

The number of the dead is shockingly high. Here, too: the numbers are probably not meant exactly. Still, it remains sad: brothers fight against brothers. Here the Bible does not celebrate war, but trust in God.

Bethel was one of the two places where Jeroboam had set up a golden calf (1 Kings 12:29).

Jeroboam did not die right away. He lived a few years longer than Abijah (1 Kings 14:20; 15:9). Chronicles only sums up his end here.

Abijah's family and end VERSES 21–22

21 But Abijah became powerful.
He married 14 wives.
He had 22 sons and 16 daughters.
22 Everything else about Abijah is recorded in the
writings of the prophet Iddo:
what he did, how he lived, and what he said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "writings of the prophet Iddo" are a book that no longer exists. Chronicles often names books of prophets as sources.

In the WEB, our English source text, the chapter ends here. In some Bibles the next verse (Abijah's death) is still verse 23 of this chapter.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 14

King Asa trusts in God

Asa removes the idols VERSES 1–5

1 So Abijah died and joined his ancestors.
They buried him in the City of David.
And his son Asa became king in his place.
While Asa was king, the land had peace for 10 years.
2 Asa did what was good and right in the eyes of the
LORD his God.
3 He removed the altars of foreign gods and the high
places.
He broke down the stone pillars.
He cut down the Asherah poles.
4 He commanded the people of Judah to seek the LORD,
the God of their ancestors.
He commanded them to obey the LORD's law and his
commands.

5 He also removed the high places and the sun images
from all the cities of Judah.
And the kingdom had peace while he ruled.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles verse 1 of this chapter is still chapter 13:23. That is why the verses in chapter 14 are shifted by one there: verse 2 here is verse 1 there, and so on.

Asa reigned from about 910 to 869 BC, that is, 41 years.

"Asherah poles" were wooden poles for the goddess Asherah. "Pillars" were holy stones for foreign gods. "Sun images" were probably incense altars, maybe for a sun god.

Asa cleans up. But he does not only take something away. He also calls the people to seek God. That is the heart of it.

Rest and building VERSES 6–8

6 He built fortified cities in Judah,
because the land had peace.
There was no war in those years,
because the LORD had given him rest.
7 Asa said to the people of Judah,
"Let's build up these cities.
Let's put walls around them, with towers, gates, and bars.
The land is still ours,
because we have sought the LORD our God.
We have sought him, and he has given us rest on every side."
So they built, and everything went well for them.
8 Asa had an army of 300,000 men from Judah.
They carried large shields and spears.
He also had 280,000 men from Benjamin.
They carried small shields and shot with bows.
All of them were strong and brave soldiers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Asa uses the time of peace wisely. He builds while there is rest.

He says clearly where the rest comes from: "We have sought him, and he has given us rest on every side."

Judah carried long shields and spears for close combat. Benjamin was known for its archers.

Zerah the Ethiopian attacks VERSES 9–15

9 Zerah the Ethiopian came out to fight against them.
He had an army of a million soldiers and 300 chariots.
He came as far as Mareshah.
10 Asa went out to meet him.
They lined up for battle in the Valley of Zephathah near Mareshah.
11 Asa cried out to the LORD his God.
He said,
"LORD, no one can help like you can,
whether someone is strong or has no strength.
Help us, LORD our God!
We trust in you.
In your name we have come out against this huge army.
LORD, you are our God.
Don't let any human being win against you."
12 So the LORD struck down the Ethiopians in front of Asa and Judah.
And the Ethiopians ran away.
13 Asa and his army chased them as far as Gerar.
So many Ethiopians were killed that they could not recover.
They were crushed before the LORD and his army.
The army of Judah carried away a great amount of goods.
14 They attacked all the cities around Gerar.
The people there were terrified of the LORD.
Judah's army robbed all those cities,
because there were many valuable things in them.
15 They also attacked the tents of the herdsmen.
They took a great number of sheep and camels.
Then they went back to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The WEB, our English source text, says "the Ethiopian". This means a man from Cush, the area south of Egypt. It is not certain who exactly Zerah was. Maybe he was an army commander in the service of Egypt, or he led tribes from the area of Gerar in the south.

Asa's prayer in verse 11 is one of the most beautiful prayers in Chronicles. Asa says: for you, God, it makes no difference whether someone is strong or weak. You can help. And: it is not about us, but about you. Do not let any human being be strong against you.

You can pray this prayer today, too, when you are facing a huge problem.

That the Bible tells about battles and plunder in this way belongs to that old time. It is not an example for violence today. The message is: trust in God, even if you are weak.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 15

The covenant to seek God

The message of the prophet Azariah VERSES 1–7

1 The Spirit of God came on Azariah, the son of Oded.
2 He went out to meet Asa.
He said to him,
"Listen to me, Asa, and all of Judah and Benjamin!
The LORD is with you as long as you are with him.
If you seek him, he will let you find him.
But if you abandon him, he will abandon you.
3 For a long time Israel was without the true God.
They had no priest to teach them,
and they had no law.
4 But when they were in trouble, they turned to the LORD, the God of Israel.
They sought him,
and he let them find him.
5 In those times no one was safe when they went out or came in.

All the people who lived in those lands had great troubles.
6 Nations crushed each other.
One nation fought against another, and one city against another.
God brought every kind of trouble on them.
7 But you must be strong!
Don't give up.
Your work will be rewarded."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Asa has just won a great victory. Now a prophet comes and says: do not forget to whom you owe the victory!

Verse 2 is a key sentence of the whole of Chronicles: "If you seek him, he will let you find him." God does not hide from those who honestly seek him. Later the prophet Jeremiah says something similar (Jeremiah 29:13–14), and Jesus: "Seek, and you will find" (Matthew 7:7).

Verses 3–6 probably recall the time of the judges. Back then there was chaos and violence. But whenever the people cried out to God in their need, he helped.

Verse 7 is an encouragement: do not give up! Your effort is not in vain.

Asa renews the faith VERSES 8–11

8 Asa heard these words and the prophecy of Oded the prophet.
Then he took courage.
He removed the disgusting idols from the whole land of Judah and Benjamin.
He also removed them from the cities he had captured in the hill country of Ephraim.
And he repaired the LORD's altar in front of the porch of the LORD's house.
9 Asa called together all the people of Judah and Benjamin.
He also called the people from Ephraim, Manasseh, and Simeon who lived among them.
Many people from Israel had come over to him.
They had seen that the LORD his God was with him.
10 So they gathered in Jerusalem in the third month of the fifteenth year that Asa was king.
11 On that day they sacrificed to the LORD some of the animals they had taken in the war: 700 cattle and 7,000 sheep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8 says "the prophecy of Oded the prophet". But before, the prophet was called Azariah the son of Oded. Probably the words "Azariah the son of" were lost in copying. Some old translations have "Azariah the son of Oded" here.

The "disgusting idols" are images of idols that God detests.

Again people from the north come to Judah, because they see: God is with Asa. Faith that is really lived draws others.

The third month is the time of the Feast of Weeks (Shavuot, later Pentecost).

The covenant VERSES 12–15

12 They made a covenant to seek the LORD, the God of their ancestors,
with all their heart and with all their soul.
13 Anyone who would not seek the LORD, the God of Israel,
was to be put to death.
This was true for young and old,
for men and women.
14 They made a promise to the LORD with a loud voice.
They shouted and blew trumpets and horns.
15 All the people of Judah were glad about the promise.
They had made it with all their heart.
They had sought the LORD with their whole desire.
And he let them find him.
So the LORD gave them peace on every side.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people solemnly promise to seek God with their whole heart. It is a feast of joy.

Verse 13 is hard: whoever does not seek God is to be killed. This is based on the old law against worshiping idols (Deuteronomy 13 and 17:2–7). At that time worshiping idols counted as betrayal of the whole people.

Today Jews and Christians say clearly: faith must never be forced. Violence in the name of God is wrong. Jesus did not force anyone to follow him. Faith can only grow in freedom. You can also see this in verse 15: what mattered was that they sought "with all their heart" and "with their whole desire". That cannot be forced.

Asa and his mother VERSES 16–19

16 King Asa also removed his mother Maacah from her position as queen mother.
She had made a disgusting image for the goddess Asherah.
Asa cut down her image.
He crushed it into dust
and burned it at the brook Kidron.
17 But the high places were not removed from Israel.
Still, Asa's heart was completely faithful as long as he lived.
18 He brought into God's house the things that he and his father had given to God:
silver, gold, and other objects.
19 There was no more war until the thirty-fifth year that Asa was king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Maacah was really Asa's grandmother (the mother of Abijah, 2 Chronicles 11:20). In Hebrew, "mother" can also mean "grandmother". The "queen mother" had great influence at the court.

Asa acts even against his own family when it is about God. That was brave.

Verse 17 seems to contradict 2 Chronicles 14:5, where Asa removed the high places. One explanation: Asa removed the high places for foreign gods. The high places where people sacrificed to the LORD remained. Or: "Israel" here means the conquered areas in the north.

"Asa's heart was completely faithful": the WEB, our English source text, says "perfect". This does not mean that Asa was without mistakes, but that he was faithful to God with an undivided heart. Chapter 16 shows that Asa did make mistakes later.

Chapter 16

Asa's last years

Asa buys help from the Syrians VERSES 1–6

1 In the thirty-sixth year that Asa was king,
Baasha, the king of Israel, attacked Judah.
He built up the town of Ramah into a fortress.
He wanted to stop anyone from going out to Asa, the king of Judah, or coming in to him.
2 Then Asa took silver and gold
from the treasures of the LORD's house and of the king's palace.
He sent it to Ben Hadad, the king of Syria, who lived in Damascus.
He sent this message:
3 "Let us make a treaty, you and I,
as there was between my father and your father.
Look, I am sending you silver and gold.
Go and break your treaty with Baasha, the king of Israel.
Then he will leave me alone."
4 Ben Hadad agreed with King Asa.
He sent the commanders of his armies against the cities of Israel.
They attacked Ijon, Dan, Abel Maim,
and all the storage cities of Naphtali.
5 When Baasha heard about it,
he stopped building up Ramah.
He gave up his work.
6 Then King Asa brought all the people of Judah.
They carried away the stones and the wood
that Baasha had used to build Ramah.
With them Asa built up Geba and Mizpah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is also told in 1 Kings 15:16–22.

Ramah was only about 5 miles north of Jerusalem. If Baasha fortified Ramah, Jerusalem was cut off from the north.

In Hebrew, Syria is called "Aram". Damascus was its capital.

The number "thirty-sixth year" is difficult. According to 1 Kings 16:8, Baasha was already dead by then. Many experts think that the years here are counted from the division of the kingdom, not the years of Asa. Then it would be about Asa's sixteenth year.

In 1 Kings 15:20 Abel Maim is called "Abel Beth Maacah".

Politically, Asa's plan was a success. But for it he even gave away the temple treasure, and he relied on a foreign king, not on God.

Hanani the seer rebukes Asa VERSES 7–10

7 At that time Hanani the seer came to Asa, the king of Judah.
He said to him,
"You trusted in the king of Syria.
You did not trust in the LORD your God.
That is why the army of the king of Syria has escaped from you.
8 The Ethiopians and the Lubim had a huge army,
with chariots and very many horsemen.
But you trusted in the LORD,
so he handed them over to you.
9 The LORD's eyes look everywhere over the whole earth.
He wants to show his strength to help those whose hearts are completely faithful to him.
You have acted foolishly in this.
From now on you will have wars."
10 Then Asa was angry with the seer.
He was so furious about this that he put him in prison.
At the same time Asa treated some of the people cruelly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hanani reminds Asa of Chapter 14: back then the army was much larger, and Asa trusted God. Now the danger was smaller, but Asa no longer asked God.

Verse 9 is a wonderful sentence: God looks over the whole earth. He looks for people whose hearts are completely faithful to him, so that he can help them. God is not looking for mistakes, but for chances to help.

Asa's reaction is sad. Instead of turning back, he becomes angry and locks up the prophet. And he oppresses people. The king who was once so faithful has become hard in his old age.

"Ethiopians": the Hebrew says "Cushites" (see 2 Chronicles 14:9).

Asa's illness and death VERSES 11–14

11 Everything Asa did, from first to last,
is written in the book of the kings of Judah and Israel.
12 In the thirty-ninth year that Asa was king,
he got a disease in his feet.
His disease was very bad.
But even in his illness he did not seek the LORD.
He only went to the doctors.
13 Then Asa died and joined his ancestors.
He died in the forty-first year that he was king.
14 They buried him in the tomb that he had cut out for himself in the City of David.
They laid him on a bed full of sweet perfumes
and many kinds of spices.
Perfume makers had prepared them with great skill.
And they made a huge fire in his honor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12 does not mean that it is wrong to go to the doctor! The Bible respects doctors (for example Sirach 38; Luke was a doctor, Colossians 4:14). The accusation is: Asa "only" went to the doctors and no longer sought God at all. He had pushed God completely out of his life.

Today Jews and Christians say: go to the doctor, and pray as well. Both belong together.

The "huge fire" was not a burning of the dead body. It was a fire of honor, in which spices were burned in honor of the king (compare Jeremiah 34:5).

In spite of his late mistakes, Asa is honored. All in all he was a good king (2 Chronicles 15:17).

2 CHRONICLES

Chapter 17

Jehoshaphat, a good king

Jehoshaphat seeks God VERSES 1–6

1 Asa's son Jehoshaphat became king in his place.
He made his kingdom strong against Israel.
2 He put troops in all the fortified cities of Judah.
He put soldiers in the land of Judah
and in the cities of Ephraim that his father Asa had captured.
3 The LORD was with Jehoshaphat.
He lived the way his ancestor David had lived in his first years.
He did not seek the Baals.
4 He sought the God of his father.
He obeyed God's commandments.
He did not do what the people of Israel did.
5 So the LORD made the kingdom firm under Jehoshaphat's rule.
All the people of Judah brought gifts to Jehoshaphat.
He had great riches and honor.
6 His heart was full of courage for the LORD's ways.
He also removed the high places and the Asherah poles from Judah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoshaphat reigned from about 872 to 848 BC. Chronicles tells much more about him than the books of Kings.

"The way his ancestor David had lived in his first years": this means David's good years. The WEB, our English source text, calls David his "father", because in Hebrew "father" can also mean "ancestor".

"Baals" are the different forms of the god Baal, who was worshiped in the northern kingdom under Ahab.

"His heart was full of courage": literally it says "his heart was lifted up". Usually this means "to become proud". Here it is meant in a good way: he became full of courage for God's ways.

Teachers go through the land VERSES 7–9

7 In the third year that he was king,
he sent out his officials to teach in the cities of Judah.
They were Ben Hail, Obadiah, Zechariah, Nethanel, and Micaiah.
8 He sent Levites with them:
Shemaiah, Nethaniah, Zebadiah, Asahel,
Shemiramoth, Jehonathan, Adonijah, Tobijah, and Tobadonijah.
And he sent the priests Elishama and Jehoram with them.
9 They taught the people in Judah.
They had the book of the LORD's law with them.
They went to all the cities of Judah
and taught the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is something special: Jehoshaphat sends teachers through the whole land. Princes, Levites and priests go together. They bring the book of the law to the people. Jehoshaphat knew: faith needs knowledge. The people should know God's word themselves.

The name Jehoshaphat means "The LORD judges". In Chapter 19 he appoints judges.

Jehoshaphat becomes mighty VERSES 10–13

10 All the kingdoms in the lands around Judah were terrified of the LORD.
So they did not go to war against Jehoshaphat.
11 Some of the Philistines brought Jehoshaphat gifts and silver as tax.
The Arabs also brought him flocks of animals:
7,700 rams and 7,700 male goats.
12 Jehoshaphat became more and more powerful.
He built fortresses and storage cities in Judah.
13 He carried out many projects in the cities of Judah.
And he kept soldiers in Jerusalem, strong and brave men.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Because the people learned God's word, God gave peace. The neighboring peoples had respect.

The "Arabs" were nomad tribes in the desert south and east of Judah.

Jehoshaphat's army VERSES 14–19

14 Here is the list of them by their families.
From Judah, these were the commanders of thousands:
Adnah was the commander, with 300,000 strong and brave soldiers.
15 Next to him was the commander Jehohanan, with 280,000 men.
16 Next to him was Amasiah, the son of Zichri,
who willingly offered himself to the LORD.
He had 200,000 strong and brave soldiers.
17 From Benjamin:
Eliada, a strong and brave soldier.
He had 200,000 men armed with bows and shields.
18 Next to him was Jehozabad,
with 180,000 men ready for war.
19 These men served the king.
There were also the men the king had put in the fortified cities all over Judah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Together these are more than a million men. That is very many for a small country like Judah. As with the other large numbers, many experts think that "thousand" here means a military unit.

The small remark about Amasiah in verse 16 is beautiful: he "willingly offered himself to the LORD". In the middle of a list of numbers, one person is honored for his devotion.

2 CHRONICLES

Chapter 18

The prophet Micaiah and the death of Ahab

Jehoshaphat makes an alliance with Ahab VERSES 1–3

1 Jehoshaphat had great riches and honor.
And he made an alliance with Ahab.
2 Some years later he went down to Ahab in Samaria.
Ahab killed a great many sheep and cattle for him
and for the people who were with him.
He talked Jehoshaphat into going with him to attack
Ramoth Gilead.
3 Ahab, the king of Israel, asked Jehoshaphat, the king of
Judah,
"Will you go with me to Ramoth Gilead?"
Jehoshaphat answered,
"I am as you are, and my people are as your people.
We will be with you in the war."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is almost the same in 1 Kings 22.

"He made an alliance": what is meant is that Jehoshaphat's son Jehoram married Athaliah, the daughter of Ahab (2 Chronicles 21:6). This marriage later brought great disaster on Judah (Chapters 22–23).

Ahab was the king of the northern kingdom who, together with his wife Jezebel, promoted the worship of Baal.

Jehoshaphat already had riches and honor. Why did he need the alliance with Ahab? Chronicles hints: he did not need it at all.

400 prophets say yes VERSES 4–11

4 Jehoshaphat also said to the king of Israel,
"But first, please ask what the LORD says."
5 So the king of Israel called the prophets together, 400
men.
He asked them,
"Should we go to war against Ramoth Gilead, or
should I not?"
They said,
"Go! God will hand it over to the king."
6 But Jehoshaphat asked,
"Isn't there another prophet of the LORD here?
Then we can ask him too."
7 The king of Israel answered Jehoshaphat,
"There is still one man who can ask the LORD for us.
But I hate him.
He never says anything good about me, only bad
things.
He is Micaiah, the son of Imla."
Jehoshaphat said,
"The king should not say that."
8 So the king of Israel called an officer.
He said, "Bring Micaiah, the son of Imla, quickly."
9 The king of Israel and Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah,
were sitting on their thrones.
They were wearing their royal robes.
They were sitting at an open place at the entrance of
the gate of Samaria.
And all the prophets were prophesying in front of
them.
10 Zedekiah, the son of Chenaanah, had made horns of
iron for himself.
He said,
"This is what the LORD says:
'With these you will gore the Syrians until they are
destroyed.'"
11 All the prophets were saying the same thing:
"Attack Ramoth Gilead, and you will win!
The LORD will hand it over to the king."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoshaphat is careful. He wants to know God's will. But the 400 prophets only say what Ahab wants to hear.

Ahab hates Micaiah because Micaiah tells the truth. This is an old temptation: people want only those around them who agree with them.

Ramoth Gilead was an important border city east of the Jordan. The Syrians (Aram) had occupied it.

This Micaiah is not the prophet Micah, after whom a book of the Bible is named.

Micaiah tells the truth VERSES 12–27

12 The messenger who went to get Micaiah said to him,
"Listen, all the prophets agree. They all say good things
to the king.
So please, say what they say.
Say something good."
13 Micaiah answered,
"As surely as the LORD lives,
I will say what my God says."
14 Micaiah came to the king.
The king asked him,
"Micaiah, should we go to war against Ramoth Gilead,
or should I not?"
Micaiah answered,
"Go and win!
They will be handed over to you."
15 But the king said to him,
"How many times must I make you swear to tell me
only the truth in the LORD's name?"
16 Then Micaiah said,
"I saw all Israel scattered on the mountains,
like sheep without a shepherd.
And the LORD said,
'These people have no master.
Let each of them go home in peace.'"
17 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat,
"Didn't I tell you? He never says anything good about
me, only bad things."
18 Micaiah said,
"Then listen to what the LORD says!
I saw the LORD sitting on his throne.
All the armies of heaven were standing at his right and
at his left.

19 The LORD asked,
'Who will trick Ahab, the king of Israel,
so that he will attack Ramoth Gilead and die there?'
One said this, and another said that.
20 Then a spirit came forward and stood before the LORD.
It said, 'I will trick him.'
"The LORD asked, 'How?'
21 "The spirit answered,
'I will go and be a lying spirit in the mouths of all his prophets.'
"The LORD said,
'You will trick him, and you will succeed.
Go and do it.'
22 "So now you see:
the LORD has put a lying spirit in the mouths of these prophets of yours.
The LORD has announced disaster for you."
23 Then Zedekiah, the son of Chenaanah, came up to Micaiah.
He slapped him in the face and said,
"How did the LORD's Spirit leave me to speak to you?"
24 Micaiah answered,
"You will find out on the day
when you run into an inner room to hide."
25 Then the king of Israel said,
"Take Micaiah and send him back to Amon, the governor of the city,
and to Joash, the king's son.
26 Tell them,
'This is what the king says:
"Put this man in prison.
Give him nothing but the bread and water of suffering
until I come back safely."'"
27 Micaiah said,
"If you ever come back safely,
then the LORD has not spoken through me."
And he said,
"Listen, you people, all of you!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Micaiah is under great pressure: 400 prophets against one. But he stays firm: "I will say what my God says."

First Micaiah mockingly repeats the words of the others. Ahab notices right away that he does not mean it. Then Micaiah tells the truth: Israel will be like sheep without a shepherd. That means: the king, the shepherd of the people, will die.

The vision of the heavenly council around God's throne is hard to understand. Does God really let someone lie? You have to look closely: Micaiah tells Ahab the whole plan! God warns Ahab openly. Ahab has the choice. He wanted to hear the lie, and God leaves him with the lie he has chosen.

"The bread and water of suffering" means: only very little bread and water, just enough to survive.

"Listen, you people, all of you!" is the same sentence as the first sentence in the book of the prophet Micah (Micah 1:2).

The death of Ahab VERSES 28–34

28 So the king of Israel and Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah, went to attack Ramoth Gilead.
29 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat,
"I will disguise myself and go into the battle.
But you wear your royal robes."
So the king of Israel disguised himself,
and they went into the battle.
30 The king of Syria had given an order to the commanders of his chariots.
He said, "Don't fight with anyone, small or great.
Fight only with the king of Israel."
31 The commanders of the chariots saw Jehoshaphat.
They said, "That is the king of Israel!"
So they turned to attack him.
But Jehoshaphat cried out, and the LORD helped him.
And God moved them to go away from him.
32 The commanders of the chariots saw that he was not the king of Israel.
So they stopped chasing him.
33 But a soldier shot an arrow at random.
It hit the king of Israel between the pieces of his armor.
The king said to his chariot driver,
"Turn around and take me out of the battle.
I am badly wounded."
34 The battle grew worse all that day.
The king of Israel held himself up in his chariot, facing the Syrians, until evening.
And at about sunset he died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahab tries to escape the prophecy. He disguises himself and lets Jehoshaphat fight as the only king in royal clothes. That was dangerous and unfair to Jehoshaphat.

But you cannot trick God. An arrow shot "at random" hits Ahab exactly at the weak spot of the armor.

Chronicles adds something that is not in 1 Kings 22: "The LORD helped him. And God moved them to go away from him" (2 Chronicles 18:31). Jehoshaphat cries out to God, and God saves him, even though he had gotten involved with Ahab. God's grace is greater than our mistakes.

Ahab reigned from about 874 to 853 BC.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 19

Jehoshaphat appoints judges

Jehu the seer rebukes Jehoshaphat VERSES 1–3

1 Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah, came back safely to his palace in Jerusalem.
2 Jehu, the son of Hanani the seer, went out to meet him.
He said to King Jehoshaphat,
"Should you help evil people?
Should you love those who hate the LORD?
Because of this, the LORD is angry with you.
3 But there are also good things in you.
You have removed the Asheroth from the land.
And you have set your heart to seek God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoshaphat has just escaped death (Chapter 18). Now the prophet Jehu tells him clearly: your alliance with Ahab was wrong.

Jehu was the son of Hanani, who had rebuked Asa (2 Chronicles 16:7). Father and son were both brave prophets.

Verse 3 is beautiful: God does not only see the mistake. He also sees the good. Jehoshaphat has a heart that seeks God.

"Asheroth" is the plural of Asherah. It means the Asherah poles.

Jehoshaphat leads the people back VERSES 4–7

4 Jehoshaphat lived in Jerusalem.
And he went out again among the people,
from Beersheba to the hill country of Ephraim.
He brought them back to the LORD, the God of their ancestors.
5 He appointed judges in the land,
in all the fortified cities of Judah, in every city.
6 He said to the judges,
"Think carefully about what you do.
You are not judging for people, but for the LORD.
He is with you when you give a judgment.
7 So now, have respect and fear for the LORD.
Be careful in what you do.
The LORD our God is never unfair.
With him there is no favoring of anyone, and no taking of bribes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoshaphat accepts the rebuke. He himself travels through the whole land, from the south (Beersheba) to the north (Ephraim), and calls the people back to God.

Then he makes sure there are fair courts. His words to the judges are still important today:

– A judge does not judge only before people, but before God.

– No "favoring of anyone": rich and poor, powerful and weak must be treated the same.

– No bribes.

Jehoshaphat's name means "The LORD judges". He puts into practice what his name says.

A highest court in Jerusalem VERSES 8–11

8 In Jerusalem, too, Jehoshaphat appointed some Levites, priests,
and heads of the families of Israel.
They were to judge for the LORD and settle quarrels.
They returned to Jerusalem.
9 He gave them this order:
"Do this with respect and fear for the LORD.
Be faithful, and serve with your whole heart.
10 Your brothers who live in their cities will bring cases to you.
It may be a case of blood and blood.
Or it may be a question about the law, a commandment, rules, or laws.
In every case you must warn them,
so that they do not become guilty before the LORD.
Otherwise the LORD's anger will come on you and on your brothers.
Do this, and you will not be guilty.
11 Look, Amariah, the chief priest, will be over you in all matters of the LORD.
Zebadiah, the son of Ishmael, the leader of the tribe of Judah,
will be over you in all the king's matters.
The Levites will serve you as officials.
Be brave and do your work.
May the LORD be with the good!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Jerusalem there is now a highest court for difficult cases (compare Deuteronomy 17:8–13).

Verse 10: "Blood and blood" means a case where someone was killed: was it on purpose or an accident?

It is remarkable that there are two areas. The chief priest is responsible for religious questions, a prince for matters of the state. This is an early form of the separation of powers.

"May the LORD be with the good!": God is on the side of those who judge fairly.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 20

The battle belongs to God

A huge army is coming VERSES 1–4

1 After this, the Moabites and the Ammonites came to fight against Jehoshaphat.
Some of the Meunites came with them.
2 Some people came and told Jehoshaphat,
"A huge army is coming against you from beyond the sea, from Syria.
Look, they are already in Hazazon Tamar."
Hazazon Tamar is En Gedi.
3 Jehoshaphat was afraid.
He decided to seek the LORD.
He announced a time of fasting for all of Judah.
Fasting means: not eating for a time, in order to pray.
4 The people of Judah came together to ask the LORD for help.
They came from all the cities of Judah to seek the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moab and Ammon were east of the Dead Sea. The Meunites were probably a people from the area of Edom (Seir).

"From beyond the sea" means the Dead Sea. "From Syria": the Hebrew says "Aram". Many experts think that "Edom" was meant at first. The two words look very similar in Hebrew. And later in the chapter the text speaks of Mount Seir, that is, Edom.

En Gedi is an oasis on the west shore of the Dead Sea, only about 25 miles from Jerusalem. The enemy was already very close.

Jehoshaphat is afraid. That is human. But he does not let fear freeze him. He turns to God.

Jehoshaphat's prayer VERSES 5–13

5 Jehoshaphat stood up in front of the people of Judah
and Jerusalem.
They were gathered in the LORD's house, in front of
the new courtyard.
6 He said,
"LORD, God of our ancestors,
you are God in heaven!
You rule over all the kingdoms of the nations!
Power and strength are in your hand.
No one can stand against you.
7 Our God, you drove out the people who lived in this
land before your people Israel.
You gave this land forever to the descendants of your
friend Abraham.
8 They have lived in it.
They have built a holy place in it for your name.
They said,
9 'Disaster may come on us:
war, punishment, a deadly disease, or hunger.
Then we will stand in front of this house and before
you,
because your name is in this house.
We will cry out to you in our trouble.
And you will hear us and save us.'
10 Now look at the people of Ammon and Moab and
Mount Seir.
When Israel came out of the land of Egypt, you did not
let Israel invade their lands.
So Israel turned away from them and did not destroy
them.
11 And look how they repay us now!
They are coming to drive us out of your land,
the land you gave us as our own.
12 Our God, won't you judge them?
We have no strength against this huge army that is
attacking us.
We don't know what to do,
but our eyes are on you."
13 All the men of Judah stood before the LORD,
with their little ones, their wives, and their children.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoshaphat's prayer is an example of how to pray in times of need:

– He remembers who God is: the ruler over all peoples.

– He remembers what God has done before.

– He reminds God of his promise when the temple was built (Chapters 6 and 7).

– He says honestly: "We don't know what to do."

– And then: "But our eyes are on you."

This last sentence has helped many people in situations with no way out.

Here Abraham is called God's "friend". Isaiah 41:8 and James 2:23 call him that too.

Verse 10 recalls Deuteronomy 2: God had forbidden Israel to attack Edom, Moab and Ammon.

Verse 13 is moving: whole families stand before God, even the little children.

God's answer through Jahaziel VERSES 14–19

14 Then the LORD's Spirit came on Jahaziel in the middle
of the assembly.
Jahaziel was a Levite from the family of Asaph.
He was the son of Zechariah, the son of Benaiah, the
son of Jeiel, the son of Mattaniah.
15 Jahaziel said,
"Listen, all you people of Judah and Jerusalem, and
you, King Jehoshaphat!
This is what the LORD says to you:
'Don't be afraid. Don't lose courage because of this
huge army.
The battle is not yours, but God's.
16 Tomorrow, go down against them.
Look, they will come up the pass of Ziz.
You will find them at the end of the valley,
in front of the wilderness of Jeruel.
17 You will not need to fight in this battle.
Take your positions and stand still.
Then you will see how the LORD saves you, Judah and
Jerusalem.
Don't be afraid. Don't lose courage.
Go out against them tomorrow.
The LORD is with you.'"
18 Jehoshaphat bowed down with his face to the ground.
And all the people of Judah and Jerusalem fell down
before the LORD
and worshiped him.
19 Then some of the Levites stood up, from the families of
Kohath and of Korah.
They praised the LORD, the God of Israel,
with very loud voices.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers through a Levite, a singer from the family of Asaph. He was not a well-known prophet. God can speak through anyone.

"The battle is not yours, but God's" is one of the best-known sentences of Chronicles. It recalls Moses at the Red Sea: "Stand still and see how the LORD will save you today" (Exodus 14:13).

Even before anything has happened, they worship and praise God. They trust his word.

The Korahites were singers at the temple. Several psalms come from them (for example Psalms 42–49).

The army goes out singing VERSES 20–26

20 Early the next morning they got up
and went out into the wilderness of Tekoa.
As they were leaving, Jehoshaphat stood up and said,
"Listen to me, people of Judah and Jerusalem!
Believe in the LORD your God, and you will stand
firm!
Believe his prophets, and you will succeed."
21 Jehoshaphat talked it over with the people.
Then he chose singers to sing to the LORD.
They were to praise him in holy clothes as they
marched in front of the army.
They sang, "Give thanks to the LORD, for his loving
kindness endures forever."
22 As soon as they began to sing and praise,
the LORD sent an ambush against the people of

Ammon, Moab, and Mount Seir,
who had come to attack Judah.
And they were defeated.
23 The people of Ammon and Moab attacked the people of Mount Seir.
They wanted to kill them and wipe them out completely.
When they had finished with the people of Seir,
they began to destroy each other.
24 The men of Judah came to the place where they could look out over the wilderness.
They looked toward the huge army.
But they saw only dead bodies lying on the ground.
No one had escaped.
25 Jehoshaphat and his people came to take the goods of the dead.
They found a great amount of riches,
and dead bodies with precious jewels on them.
They took these things off the dead for themselves,
more than they could carry.
There was so much that it took them three days to collect it all.
26 On the fourth day they gathered in Beracah Valley.
There they praised the LORD.
That is why this place is still called "Beracah Valley" today.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20 sounds like Isaiah 7:9: "If you will not believe, surely you will not be established." In Hebrew this is a play on words: "believe" and "stand firm" come from the same word (aman; the word "Amen" also comes from it).

This is the most unusual battle order in the Bible: in front go not the soldiers, but the singers. They sing: "Give thanks to the LORD, for his loving kindness endures forever" (like Psalm 136).

Judah does not fight at all. The enemies quarrel with each other and destroy each other. The text does not say exactly who laid the "ambush". What matters is: God brought it about.

"Beracah" means "blessing" or "praise". The WEB, our English source text, says that they "blessed" the LORD there. The valley has this name because they praised God there. To this day there is a place with a similar name south of Bethlehem.

Here, too: the Bible does not rejoice over the dead, but over the rescue. And the rescue did not come through weapons, but through trust and praise.

Joy in Jerusalem VERSES 27–30

27 Then all the men of Judah and Jerusalem went back to Jerusalem with joy.
Jehoshaphat led them.
The LORD had made them glad, because he had saved them from their enemies.
28 They came into Jerusalem and went to the LORD's house.
They played stringed instruments, harps, and trumpets.
29 All the kingdoms of the other lands heard how the LORD had fought against Israel's enemies.
Then they were terrified of God.
30 So Jehoshaphat's kingdom had peace.
His God gave him rest on every side.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

It begins with prayer and fasting. It ends with music and joy in the temple. This is what it looks like when a people trusts God completely.

Summary about Jehoshaphat VERSES 31–37

31 So Jehoshaphat ruled over Judah.
He was 35 years old when he became king.
He ruled in Jerusalem for 25 years.
His mother was Azubah, the daughter of Shilhi.
32 He lived the way his father Asa had lived.
He did not turn away from it.
He did what was right in the LORD's eyes.
33 But the high places were not removed.
The people had still not set their hearts on the God of their ancestors.
34 Everything else Jehoshaphat did, from first to last, is written down.
It is in the records of Jehu, the son of Hanani.
These records are part of the book of the kings of Israel.
35 Later Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah, made an alliance with Ahaziah, the king of Israel.
Ahaziah did very evil things.
36 Jehoshaphat worked together with him to build ships to sail to Tarshish.
They built the ships in Ezion Geber.
37 Then Eliezer, the son of Dodavahu, from Mareshah, spoke as a prophet against Jehoshaphat.
He said,
"You have joined with Ahaziah.
So the LORD has destroyed what you have made."
And the ships were wrecked.
They were never able to sail to Tarshish.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 33 seems to contradict 2 Chronicles 17:6, where Jehoshaphat removed the high places. Maybe he removed them, but the people built them up again. Verse 33 also says: the heart of the people was not yet completely with God. A king can remove altars, but he cannot change hearts.

Jehoshaphat repeats his old mistake: again he makes an alliance with the godless royal house of Ahab. Ahaziah was Ahab's son.

"Ships to sail to Tarshish" were large ships for the open sea, for trade. Ezion Geber was a port on the Red Sea, near today's Eilat.

1 Kings 22:48–49 tells the story a little differently: there Ahaziah wants to take part, and Jehoshaphat says no after the ships were wrecked. Maybe Jehoshaphat learned from the disaster.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 21

Jehoram, a terrible king

Jehoram kills his brothers VERSES 1–7

1 Jehoshaphat died and joined his ancestors.
He was buried with his ancestors in the City of David.
And his son Jehoram became king in his place.
2 Jehoram had brothers, other sons of Jehoshaphat.
They were Azariah, Jehiel, Zechariah, Azariah,
Michael, and Shephatiah.
All of them were sons of Jehoshaphat, the king of
Israel.
3 Their father had given them great gifts of silver, gold,
and valuable things.
He had also given them fortified cities in Judah.
But he gave the kingdom to Jehoram,
because Jehoram was his oldest son.
4 Jehoram took over his father's kingdom
and made his power strong.
Then he killed all his brothers with the sword.
He also killed some of the leaders of Israel.
5 Jehoram was 32 years old when he became king.
He ruled in Jerusalem for eight years.
6 He lived the way the kings of Israel lived,
just like the family of Ahab,
because he had married Ahab's daughter.
He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
7 But the LORD did not want to destroy David's family.
He had made a covenant with David.
He had promised to give him and his descendants a
lamp forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here you can see the results of Jehoshaphat's alliance with Ahab: his son Jehoram has married Athaliah, the daughter of Ahab. And Jehoram becomes like Ahab.

Jehoram murders all six of his brothers. Two of them are called Azariah, probably with slightly different spellings in Hebrew.

Here Jehoshaphat is called "king of Israel". For Chronicles, Judah is the true Israel.

The "lamp" is a picture: as long as a lamp burns in a house, someone still lives there. God promises: David's family will not die out. Even with such a terrible king, God stays faithful. Christians see here a pointer to Jesus, the descendant of David.

Jehoram reigned from about 848 to 841 BC.

Edom and Libnah break away VERSES 8–11

8 While Jehoram was king, Edom rebelled against
Judah's rule.
The Edomites made their own king.
9 So Jehoram went there with his commanders and all
his chariots.
At night he got up and attacked.
He struck down the Edomites who had surrounded
him,
and the commanders of their chariots.
10 But Edom has rebelled against Judah's rule until this
day.
At the same time the city of Libnah also rebelled
against Jehoram's rule.
This happened because Jehoram had abandoned the
LORD, the God of his ancestors.
11 He also built high places in the mountains of Judah.
He led the people of Jerusalem to play the prostitute.
He led Judah away from God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These events are also told in 2 Kings 8:20–22.

Libnah was a city in the west of Judah, on the border with the Philistines.

Chronicles names the reason: Jehoram had abandoned God. Whoever abandons God also loses a firm hold in other things.

"Play the prostitute": this is a picture in the Bible for worshiping idols. The people were joined to God as in a marriage. Whoever serves other gods breaks this marriage.

A letter from Elijah VERSES 12–15

12 Then a letter came to Jehoram from the prophet
Elijah.
It said,
"This is what the LORD, the God of your ancestor
David, says:
'You have not lived the way your father Jehoshaphat
lived.
You have not lived the way Asa, the king of Judah,
lived.
13 Instead, you have lived the way the kings of Israel live.
You have led Judah and the people of Jerusalem to play
the prostitute,
just as Ahab's family did.
You have also killed your own brothers, your father's
sons.
They were better than you.
14 So now the LORD will strike your people with a terrible
disaster.
He will strike your children, your wives, and
everything you own.
15 And you yourself will become very sick with a disease
of your intestines.
Day after day the disease will get worse,
until your intestines come out.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the only time that Chronicles names the prophet Elijah. And it is the only time that Elijah sends something in writing.

This is a difficult passage. According to 2 Kings 2–3, Elijah was already taken up into heaven in the time of Jehoshaphat. There are different explanations: maybe Elijah wrote the letter earlier, because he saw what would come. Or the reigns overlapped, because Jehoram already reigned together with his father while his father was still alive. Or a student of Elijah wrote in his name. Nobody knows for sure.

Elijah had already fought against Ahab. Now he also fights against Ahab's influence in Judah.

The end of Jehoram VERSES 16–20

16 The LORD stirred up the Philistines against Jehoram.
He also stirred up the Arabs who live near the

Ethiopians.
17 They attacked Judah and broke into it.
They carried off everything that was found in the king's palace.
They also took his sons and his wives.
Only one son was left to him, Jehoahaz, his youngest son.
18 After all this, the LORD struck Jehoram with a disease of the intestines.
It could not be healed.
19 After some time, at the end of two years,
his intestines came out because of the disease.
He died in terrible pain.
His people did not make a fire in his honor,
as they had done for his ancestors.
20 Jehoram was 32 years old when he became king.
He ruled in Jerusalem for eight years.
He died, and no one was sad about it.
They buried him in the City of David,
but not in the tombs of the kings.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoram had killed his brothers. Now he himself loses his sons. Only the youngest is left. In 2 Chronicles 22:1 Jehoahaz is called "Ahaziah". Both names mean almost the same: The LORD has taken hold.

"Ethiopians": the Hebrew says "Cushites".

The "fire" is the fire of honor with spices, as for Asa (2 Chronicles 16:14). Jehoram did not receive this honor.

Verse 20 is a sad verdict: "He died, and no one was sad about it." No one mourned for him. A life that was built only on power and violence leaves no love behind.

The Bible does not say here that every illness is a punishment. Jesus clearly rejected that (John 9:1–3). This is about this one king and his judgment.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 22

Ahaziah and Athaliah

Ahaziah, king of Judah VERSES 1–6

1 The people of Jerusalem made Ahaziah, Jehoram's youngest son, king in his place.
A band of raiders had come into the camp with the Arabs.
They had killed all the older sons.
So Ahaziah, the son of Jehoram, became king of Judah.
2 Ahaziah was 42 years old when he became king.
He ruled in Jerusalem for one year.
His mother was Athaliah, the daughter of Omri.
3 Ahaziah also lived the way Ahab's family lived.
His mother gave him advice to do evil.
4 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
just like Ahab's family.
After his father died, they became his advisers.
And that led to his ruin.
5 He followed their advice.
He went with Jehoram, the son of Ahab, the king of Israel,
to fight against Hazael, the king of Syria, at Ramoth Gilead.
There the Syrians wounded Joram.
6 So Joram went back to Jezreel to recover from his wounds.
He had received them at Ramah,
when he fought against Hazael, the king of Syria.
Then Azariah, the son of Jehoram, the king of Judah,
went down to Jezreel to visit Jehoram, the son of Ahab,
because Jehoram was sick.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is told in more detail in 2 Kings 8–9.

Verse 2: here it says "42" years. 2 Kings 8:26 says "22" years. That fits better, for his father Jehoram only lived to be 40 years old (2 Chronicles 21:20). Probably a mistake happened here in copying. Some old translations also have "22" or "20" here.

Athaliah was the daughter of Ahab and the granddaughter of Omri. In Hebrew, "daughter" can also mean "descendant".

Verse 6: here Ahaziah is called "Azariah". This is probably a copying mistake. "Ramah" is a short form of Ramoth Gilead.

The problem of this king: bad advisers. His mother and Ahab's family led him into ruin.

Two kings with the same name: Jehoram (also called Joram) of Israel, the son of Ahab, and Jehoram of Judah, the father of Ahaziah. They were brothers-in-law.

The death of Ahaziah VERSES 7–9

7 God had planned Ahaziah's ruin
through this visit to Joram.
When Ahaziah arrived,
he went out with Jehoram to meet Jehu, the son of Nimshi.
The LORD had anointed Jehu to wipe out Ahab's family.
8 Jehu was carrying out God's judgment on Ahab's family.
There he found the leaders of Judah and the sons of Ahaziah's brothers,
who were serving Ahaziah.
And Jehu killed them.
9 Then Jehu searched for Ahaziah.
Ahaziah was hiding in Samaria, but Jehu's men caught him.
They brought him to Jehu and killed him.
Then they buried him.
They said,
"He is the grandson of Jehoshaphat, who sought the LORD with all his heart."
No one from Ahaziah's family was left who was strong enough to rule the kingdom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehu had the task of punishing Ahab's house (2 Kings 9). Ahaziah was in the wrong place at the wrong time, because he had joined himself to Ahab's family.

In 2 Kings 9:27 Ahaziah's death is told a little differently: he flees and is fatally wounded near Megiddo. Chronicles sums it up more briefly. How exactly the two reports fit together is not quite clear.

Verse 9 is beautiful: Ahaziah is buried with honor because of his grandfather Jehoshaphat. The WEB, our English source text, says "son", because in Hebrew "son" can also mean "grandson". Jehoshaphat's faithfulness to God still has an effect after his death.

Athaliah seizes power VERSES 10–12

10 Athaliah, Ahaziah's mother, saw that her son was dead.
Then she began to kill the whole royal family of Judah.
11 But Jehoshabeath, the king's daughter, took Joash, the son of Ahaziah.
She secretly took him away from the king's sons who were about to be killed.
She hid him and his nurse in a bedroom.
Jehoshabeath was the daughter of King Jehoram and the wife of the priest Jehoiada.
She was also Ahaziah's sister.
She hid Joash from Athaliah, so Athaliah did not kill him.
12 Joash stayed hidden with them in God's house for six years.
During that time Athaliah ruled over the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the darkest moments in the history of Judah. Athaliah wants to kill her own grandchildren in order to rule herself. If she had succeeded, David's family would have died out. And God's promise to David (2 Chronicles 21:7) would have been broken.

But a brave woman saves the child: Jehoshabeath. In 2 Kings 11:2 she is called "Jehosheba". She was the aunt of little Joash and the wife of the priest Jehoiada. That is why she could hide him in the temple.

Christians see a picture here: as God back then kept David's line alive through a little child, so later Jesus came from this line. He, too, was saved as a child from a murderous king (Matthew 2:13–16).

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 23

Joash becomes king

The covenant with the captains VERSES 1–3

1 In the seventh year, Jehoiada found new courage.
He made a covenant with the captains of hundreds.
These were officers who each led 100 men.
Their names were:
Azariah, the son of Jeroham,
Ishmael, the son of Jehohanan,
Azariah, the son of Obed,
Maaseiah, the son of Adaiah,
and Elishaphat, the son of Zichri.
2 They went all around Judah.
They gathered the Levites from all the cities of Judah.
They also gathered the heads of the families of Israel.
Then they came to Jerusalem.
3 The whole assembly made a covenant with the king in God's house.
Jehoiada said to them,
"Look, the king's son must be king.
The LORD promised this about the sons of David.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is also told in 2 Kings 11. But Chronicles tells it with other main points: here the Levites and priests play the main role. In 2 Kings, it is more the bodyguard and the Carites (foreign soldiers).

Jehoiada does not act out of greed for power. He relies on God's promise: a descendant of David is to be king.

The plan VERSES 4–10

4 "This is what you must do:
You priests and Levites who start your duty on the Sabbath:
a third of you will guard the doors.
5 A third of you will be at the king's house.
And a third of you will be at the Foundation Gate.
All the people will stay in the courtyards of the LORD's house.
6 No one may come into the LORD's house
except the priests and the Levites who serve there.
They may come in, because they are holy.
But all the people must obey the LORD's instructions.
7 The Levites must stand all around the king.
Each man must hold his weapons in his hand.
Anyone who comes into the house must be killed.
Stay with the king wherever he goes."
8 The Levites and all Judah did everything Jehoiada the priest commanded.
Each leader took his men.
He took the men who were starting their duty on the Sabbath.
And he took the men who were ending their duty on the Sabbath.
Jehoiada the priest did not send any group home.
9 Jehoiada the priest gave the captains of hundreds the spears and the small and large shields that had belonged to King David.
They were kept in God's house.
10 He put all the people in their places.
Each man held his weapon in his hand.
They stood from the right side of the house to the left side,
near the altar and the house, all around the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoiada uses the Sabbath, because that is when the groups on duty change. The old group and the new group are there

at the same time. So he has twice as many men without anyone noticing.

"The Foundation Gate": nobody knows exactly where it was. In 2 Kings 11:6, it is called "the gate Sur."

Important for Chronicles: only the priests and Levites may go into the temple. Even during this uprising, the holiness of the temple is respected.

David's own weapons are used. That is a sign: here David's rightful descendant comes to the throne.

The crowning VERSE 11

11 Then they brought out the king's son.
They put the crown on him.
They gave him the covenant.
And they made him king.
Jehoiada and his sons anointed him.
They shouted, "Long live the king!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The covenant": the Hebrew says "the testimony." This probably means a scroll with God's law or with the covenant. The king is to rule according to God's word (Deuteronomy 17:18–19).

Joash is only seven years old (2 Chronicles 24:1).

The end of Athaliah VERSES 12–15

12 Athaliah heard the noise of the people.
They were running and cheering for the king.
So she went to the people in the LORD's house.
13 She looked and saw the king.
He was standing by his pillar at the entrance.
The captains and the trumpet players were next to the king.
All the people of the land were full of joy and blew trumpets.
The singers played their instruments
and led the songs of praise.
Then Athaliah tore her clothes and shouted,
"Treason! Treason!"
14 Jehoiada the priest called out the captains of hundreds who led the army.
He said to them,
"Take her out between the rows of soldiers.
Kill anyone who follows her with the sword."
The priest had said,
"Don't kill her in the LORD's house."
15 So they made way for her.
She came to the entrance of the Horse Gate at the king's house.
There they killed her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Athaliah cries "Treason!" But she herself had murdered her grandchildren and stolen the throne.

Again, Jehoiada makes sure that the temple is not made unholy by blood.

The Bible tells of Athaliah's death as the end of a violent rule. She herself had shed a lot of blood.

A new covenant and a new beginning VERSES 16–21

16 Jehoiada made a covenant between himself, all the people, and the king.
They promised to be the LORD's people.
17 Then all the people went to the temple of Baal and tore it down.
They smashed his altars and his idols.
They killed Mattan, the priest of Baal, in front of the altars.
18 Jehoiada put officers in charge of the LORD's house.
They worked under the Levitical priests.
David had divided these priests into groups for the LORD's house.
They were to offer the burnt offerings to the LORD,
as it is written in the Law of Moses.
They were to do it with joy and singing,
as David had ordered.
19 Jehoiada put gatekeepers at the gates of the LORD's house.
So no one who was unclean in any way could go in.
20 He took the captains of hundreds, the nobles, the rulers of the people,
and all the people of the land.
Together they led the king down from the LORD's house.
They went through the Upper Gate to the king's house.
There they set the king on the royal throne.
21 All the people of the land were full of joy.
And the city was calm.
They had killed Athaliah with the sword.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The most important step is the covenant in verse 16: the king and the people promise to be "the LORD's people."

Athaliah had brought the worship of Baal to Jerusalem. Now the temple of Baal is destroyed.

Jehoiada puts the worship in order again, "as David had ordered," with joy and singing.

"The city was calm": after years of fear, peace comes.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 24

Joash – a good beginning and a terrible end

Joash and Jehoiada VERSES 1–3

1 Joash was seven years old when he became king.
He ruled for 40 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Zibiah.
She came from Beersheba.
2 Joash did what was right in the LORD's eyes
all the days of Jehoiada the priest.
3 Jehoiada chose two wives for him.
Joash had sons and daughters.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joash ruled from about 835 to 796 BC.

Verse 2 is important: "all the days of Jehoiada the priest." As long as his teacher and protector lived, Joash was good. This is a warning: faith must not depend only on another person. Everyone needs a relationship with God of their own.

It was important that Jehoiada chose wives for Joash: David's family, which had almost been wiped out, was to grow again.

The repair of the temple VERSES 4–14

4 Some time later, Joash decided to repair the LORD's
house.
5 He called the priests and the Levites together.
He said to them,
"Go out to the cities of Judah.
Collect money from all Israel every year.
Use it to repair the house of your God.
Do this quickly."
But the Levites did not do it right away.
6 So the king called for Jehoiada, the chief priest.
He said to him,
"Why haven't you made the Levites collect the tax
from Judah and Jerusalem?
Moses, the servant of the LORD, and the assembly of
Israel set this tax
for the Tent of the Testimony."
7 Athaliah was a wicked woman.
Her sons had damaged God's house.
They had even given all the holy things of the LORD's
house to the Baals.
8 So the king gave an order.
They made a chest
and put it outside, at the gate of the LORD's house.
9 Then they announced everywhere in Judah and
Jerusalem:
"Bring the tax for the LORD!
Moses, the servant of God, set this tax for Israel in the
wilderness."
10 All the leaders and all the people rejoiced.
They brought their money and threw it into the chest
until it was full.
11 The Levites brought the chest to the king's officials.
Whenever they saw that there was a lot of money in it,
the king's secretary and an official of the chief priest
came.
They emptied the chest
and carried it back to its place.
They did this day after day.
So they collected a lot of money.
12 The king and Jehoiada gave the money to the men who
did the work on the LORD's house.
They hired stonemasons and carpenters to repair the
LORD's house.
They also hired workers in iron and bronze to repair
the LORD's house.
13 So the workers worked,
and the repairs made good progress under them.
They built God's house again the way it was planned.
And they made it strong.
14 When they were finished,
they brought the rest of the money to the king and
Jehoiada.
With it, they made objects for the LORD's house:
objects for the service and for the offerings,
spoons, and objects of gold and silver.
They offered burnt offerings in the LORD's house all
the time,
as long as Jehoiada lived.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is also told in 2 Kings 12.

The temple had fallen into ruin under Athaliah. Her "sons" were probably her followers.

The "Tent of the Testimony" is the tabernacle, the tent in the wilderness. The tax Moses set is the tax for the holy tent from Exodus 30:12–16.

The offering chest was a good idea: everyone could give for themselves. The money was counted openly, by an official of the king and one of the priest together. So no one could steal any of it.

And the people gave gladly: they "rejoiced."

The death of Jehoiada VERSES 15–16

15 Jehoiada grew old.
He had lived a long and full life, and he died.
He was 130 years old when he died.
16 They buried him in David's city with the kings.
They did this because he had done good things in
Israel,
for God and for his house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoiada is the only priest who was buried with the kings. That is a great honor. He had saved David's family.

Joash turns away VERSES 17–19

17 After Jehoiada died,
the leaders of Judah came and bowed down to the
king.
And the king listened to them.
18 They left the house of the LORD, the God of their
ancestors.
They served the Asherah poles and the idols.
Because of this guilt, God's anger came on Judah and
Jerusalem.
19 But the LORD sent prophets to them to bring them
back to him.
The prophets warned them,
but they would not listen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoiada has hardly died when everything changes. The leaders flatter the king, and he listens to them.

Even now, God does not give up. He sends prophets, one after the other. God is patient.

The murder of Zechariah VERSES 20–22

20 Then the Spirit of God came on Zechariah, the son of
Jehoiada the priest.
He stood up in front of the people and said to them,
"God says this:
'Why do you disobey the LORD's commandments?

That is why things do not go well for you.
You have left the LORD.
So he has also left you.'"

21 But they made plans against him.
The king gave the order,
and they threw stones at him until he died.
They did this in the courtyard of the LORD's house.

22 King Joash forgot the kindness
that Jehoiada, Zechariah's father, had shown him.
Instead, he killed Jehoiada's son.
As Zechariah was dying, he said,
"May the LORD look at it, and repay it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a shocking story. Jehoiada had saved Joash's life. And Joash has Jehoiada's son killed, right in the temple, because he tells the truth.

Jesus mentions this murder in Matthew 23:35 and Luke 11:51. In the Hebrew Bible, Chronicles is the last book. That is why Abel is the first and Zechariah the last murder of a righteous person that the Hebrew Bible tells about. Jesus means by this: all the martyrs from the beginning to the end of the Scriptures.

Zechariah's last words: "May the LORD look at it, and repay it." He leaves the punishment to God. Jesus did even more on the cross: he prayed for his murderers (Luke 23:34). Stephen did so too (Acts 7:60).

The end of Joash VERSES 23–27

23 At the end of the year,
the army of the Syrians marched against Joash.
They came to Judah and Jerusalem.
They killed all the leaders of the people.
They sent everything they had captured to the king of Damascus.

24 The army of the Syrians came with only a small group of men.
But the LORD let them defeat a very large army,
because Judah had left the LORD, the God of their ancestors.
So the Syrians carried out God's judgment on Joash.

25 When the Syrians left, Joash was badly wounded.
Then his own servants made plans against him.
They did it because of the blood of the sons of Jehoiada the priest.
They killed him in his bed, and he died.
They buried him in David's city,
but not in the tombs of the kings.

26 These are the men who made plans against him:
Zabad, the son of Shimeath, a woman from Ammon,
and Jehozabad, the son of Shimrith, a woman from Moab.

27 There is more to tell about his sons,
about the many heavy burdens laid on him,
and about the rebuilding of God's house.
It is written in the commentary of the book of the kings.
His son Amaziah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chronicles shows the connection: the leaders who had led Joash into worshiping idols are killed by the Syrians. And Joash himself is murdered by his servants, because of the murder of Zechariah.

Earlier, Judah had been saved from a huge army (Chapters 14 and 20). Now a large army loses against a few men. It does not depend on the number, but on whether you trust God.

Verse 25 says "sons" of Jehoiada in the plural. Maybe more sons were killed, or it is a general way of speaking.

Jehoiada the priest was buried with the kings. Joash the king was not. What counts is not the title, but how you have lived.

"The many heavy burdens laid on him": this may mean the payments he had to make to Syria. But the Hebrew word for "burden" can also mean a heavy message from a prophet. Then the words of the prophets against him would be meant (verse 19).

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 25

Amaziah and the gods of Edom

Amaziah becomes king VERSES 1–4

1 Amaziah was 25 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 29 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Jehoaddan.
She came from Jerusalem.

2 He did what was right in the LORD's eyes,
but not with a perfect heart.

3 When he had firm control of the kingdom,
he killed the servants who had killed his father, the king.

4 But he did not kill their children.
He did what is written in the Law, in the book of Moses.
There the LORD commanded:
"Parents must not die for their children,
and children must not die for their parents.
Each person must die for their own sin."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is also told in 2 Kings 14.

Amaziah ruled from about 796 to 767 BC.

Verse 2 sums up his life: he did what was right, "but not with a perfect heart." He was only half in it. This will show itself in the course of the chapter.

Verse 4 quotes Deuteronomy 24:16. Back then, this was a great step forward: it was usual to kill the whole family of a traitor. God's law says: each person is responsible only for their own guilt (compare Ezekiel 18:20).

The hired soldiers from Israel VERSES 5–10

5 Amaziah called the people of Judah together.
He put them in order by their families.
He put them under captains of thousands and captains

of hundreds.
He did this with all Judah and Benjamin.
He counted the men who were 20 years old or older.
There were 300,000 chosen men.
They were ready to go to war.
They could fight with spear and shield.
6 He also hired 100,000 brave warriors from Israel.
He paid 100 talents of silver (about 7,500 pounds) for them.
7 But a man of God came to him and said,
"King, do not let the army of Israel go with you.
The LORD is not with Israel.
He is not with any of the people of Ephraim.
8 If you go anyway, then fight bravely!
But God will let you fall before the enemy.
God has the power to help and the power to make someone fall."
9 Amaziah said to the man of God,
"But what about the 100 talents that I have given to the army of Israel?"
The man of God answered,
"The LORD can give you much more than this."
10 So Amaziah sent away the army that had come to him from Ephraim.
He sent them back home.
This made them very angry with Judah.
They went home full of rage.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A talent is about 75 pounds.

Amaziah buys soldiers from the northern kingdom. The prophet warns: do not rely on an army that does not serve God. "Ephraim" is another name for the northern kingdom of Israel here.

Amaziah's question in verse 9 is very human: "But what about the 100 talents ...?" The prophet's answer is a lesson in faith: God can give you much more. Sometimes you have to accept a loss in order to do what is right.

Amaziah obeys. That is good. But it has consequences (verse 13).

The war against Edom VERSES 11–13

11 Amaziah found courage.
He led his army out to the Valley of Salt.
There he killed 10,000 of the people of Seir.
12 The men of Judah also captured 10,000 people alive.
They took them to the top of the rock.
They threw them down from the top of the rock,
and all of them were dashed to pieces.
13 Meanwhile, the soldiers Amaziah had sent home so that they would not go with him into battle attacked the cities of Judah, from Samaria to Beth Horon.
They killed 3,000 people there
and took a lot of plunder.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "people of Seir" are the Edomites. Mount Seir was in Edom, southeast of the Dead Sea.

Verse 12 reports a terrible cruelty. The Bible does not praise it. It only tells what happened. Killing prisoners like this is a crime. That was seen as cruel even back then (compare Amos 1–2, where God condemns cruelties in war among many peoples).

In Hebrew, "rock" is "Sela." Maybe the place Sela is meant, which Amaziah conquered according to 2 Kings 14:7.

The angry soldiers from Israel take revenge on Judah. It is hard to say how "Samaria" fits into this description of the place, because Samaria was in Israel. Maybe it means: they came from the direction of Samaria.

Amaziah worships the gods of Edom VERSES 14–16

14 Amaziah came back from killing the Edomites.
He brought the gods of the people of Seir with him.
He set them up as his own gods.
He bowed down to them and burned incense to them.
15 So the LORD became very angry with Amaziah.
He sent a prophet to him.
The prophet said,
"Why have you turned to the gods of this people?
They could not even save their own people from you!"
16 While the prophet was still speaking, the king said to him,
"Have we made you one of the king's advisers?
Stop! Do you want to be killed?"
Then the prophet stopped and said,
"I know that God has decided to destroy you.
You have done this,
and you have not listened to my advice."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is almost unbelievable: Amaziah defeats Edom with God's help. And then he worships the gods of the defeated people! The prophet shows how foolish this is: these gods could not even save their own people.

Earlier, Amaziah had listened to a prophet (verse 10). Now he threatens the prophet. That is the heart that is "not perfect" from verse 2.

A play on words: the king asks mockingly, "Have we made you one of the king's advisers?" The prophet answers: because you have not listened to my advice, God will destroy you.

Amaziah challenges Israel VERSES 17–24

17 Then Amaziah, king of Judah, talked with his advisers.
He sent a message to Joash, king of Israel.
Joash was the son of Jehoahaz, the son of Jehu.
Amaziah said,
"Come! Let's look one another in the face."
18 Joash, king of Israel, sent this answer to Amaziah, king of Judah:
"A thistle in Lebanon sent a message to a cedar in Lebanon.
It said, 'Give your daughter to my son as his wife.'
Then a wild animal in Lebanon came by
and trampled the thistle.
19 You tell yourself, 'I have defeated Edom.'
And now you are proud and boast.
Stay at home!
Why are you looking for trouble?
You will fall, and Judah will fall with you."
20 But Amaziah would not listen.
This came from God.
God wanted to give them into the power of their

enemies,
because they had turned to the gods of Edom.
21 So Joash, king of Israel, marched out.
He and Amaziah, king of Judah, looked one another in the face at Beth Shemesh.
Beth Shemesh belongs to Judah.
22 Israel defeated Judah.
Every man ran away to his home.
23 Joash, king of Israel, captured Amaziah, king of Judah, at Beth Shemesh.
Amaziah was the son of Joash, the son of Jehoahaz.
Joash brought him to Jerusalem.
He tore down the wall of Jerusalem from the Ephraim Gate to the Corner Gate.
That is a stretch of about 600 feet.
24 He took all the gold and silver.
He took all the objects in God's house that were in the care of Obed-Edom.
He took the treasures of the king's house.
He also took hostages.
Then he went back to Samaria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Maybe Amaziah wanted to take revenge on Israel for the raids in verse 13.

"Let's look one another in the face" means: let's fight.

Joash answers with a fable: a small thistle wants to be equal with the great cedar, and it is trampled. He means: you think too much of yourself.

Verse 20 explains from the point of view of Chronicles why Amaziah did not listen: his worship of idols led him into ruin.

The Bible says "400 cubits." A cubit is about 18 inches.

"Obed-Edom": a family of gatekeepers who guarded the treasures in the temple (1 Chronicles 26:15).

Verse 23: the WEB, our English source text, says "the son of Jehoahaz." 2 Kings 14:13 says "the son of Ahaziah." Jehoahaz and Ahaziah are two names for the same king (see 2 Chronicles 21:17 and 22:1).

The end of Amaziah VERSES 25–28

25 Amaziah, the son of Joash, king of Judah,
lived for 15 more years after the death of Joash, the son of Jehoahaz, king of Israel.
26 There is more to tell about Amaziah, from beginning to end.
It is written in the book of the kings of Judah and Israel.
27 Amaziah turned away from following the LORD.
From that time on, people in Jerusalem made plans against him.
He fled to Lachish.
But they sent men after him to Lachish, and they killed him there.
28 They carried his body back on horses.
They buried him with his ancestors in the City of Judah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like his father Joash, Amaziah is murdered too.

Chronicles connects the plot with his turning away from God: from then on, everything went downhill.

The "City of Judah" is Jerusalem, the City of David. 2 Kings 14:20 says "David's city."

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 26

Uzziah – strong and then proud

Uzziah becomes king VERSES 1–5

1 All the people of Judah chose Uzziah.
He was 16 years old.
They made him king in place of his father Amaziah.
2 Uzziah rebuilt Eloth and gave it back to Judah.
After that, the king died and joined his ancestors.
3 Uzziah was 16 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 52 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Jechiliah.
She came from Jerusalem.
4 He did what was right in the LORD's eyes,
just as his father Amaziah had done.
5 He made up his mind to seek God
while Zechariah was alive.
Zechariah understood the vision of God.
As long as he sought the LORD,
God made things go well for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In 2 Kings 14–15, Uzziah is usually called "Azariah." Both names mean almost the same. Uzziah means: The LORD is my strength. Azariah means: The LORD helps.

Uzziah ruled from about 792 to 740 BC, that is, for a very long time. Part of this was probably a shared rule with his father and later with his son.

Eloth (also Elath) is the port on the Red Sea, near today's Eilat. "The king" in verse 2 is probably his father Amaziah. The Hebrew can be understood like this: Uzziah built up Eloth after his father had died.

Zechariah was probably a teacher or prophet who advised Uzziah. He is not the same as the prophet Zechariah, after whom a book of the Bible is named. A "vision" is a message from God. Some old manuscripts have "in the fear of God."

"As long as he sought the LORD": these few words already hint that it will not stay this way.

Uzziah's successes VERSES 6–15

6 Uzziah went to war against the Philistines.
He tore down the walls of Gath, Jabneh, and Ashdod.
He built cities near Ashdod and in other places of the Philistines.
7 God helped him against the Philistines.
He helped him against the Arabians who lived in Gur Baal,
and against the Meunim.

8 The Ammonites paid tribute to Uzziah.
Tribute is money that a defeated people must pay.
Uzziah became famous all the way to the border of Egypt,
because he became very strong.
9 Uzziah also built towers in Jerusalem.
He built them at the Corner Gate, at the Valley Gate, and at the bend in the wall.
And he made them strong.
10 He built towers in the wilderness
and dug many cisterns.
A cistern is a pit for collecting rainwater.
He did this because he had a lot of livestock in the lowlands and in the plains.
He had farmers and vineyard workers in the mountains and in the fertile fields,
because he loved farming.
11 Uzziah also had an army of fighting men.
They went to war in units.
Jeiel the secretary and Maaseiah the officer counted them.
Hananiah, one of the king's commanders, was in charge of them.
12 There were 2,600 heads of families in all.
They were brave warriors.
13 They led an army of 307,500 men.
These men fought with great strength
to help the king against his enemies.
14 Uzziah gave the whole army
shields, spears, helmets, armor, bows, and stones for slings.
15 In Jerusalem, he had machines built.
Skilled men had invented them.
They stood on the towers and on the corners of the walls.
They could shoot arrows and large stones.
Uzziah became famous far and wide,
because he was marvelously helped until he was strong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Under Uzziah, Judah had a time of flourishing. He was successful in war, in building and in farming.

The small remark in verse 10 is beautiful: "He loved farming." A king who has joy in fields and vineyards.

The machines in verse 15 were probably protective structures on the walls, behind which archers and stone throwers could fight safely.

The most important sentence is at the end of verse 15: "He was marvelously helped until he was strong." Uzziah's strength was a gift of God. But he forgot that.

Uzziah's pride VERSES 16–21

16 But when Uzziah was strong,
he became proud.
So he did wrong.
He was unfaithful to the LORD his God.
He went into the LORD's temple
to burn incense on the incense altar.
17 Azariah the priest went in after him.
With him went 80 brave priests of the LORD.
18 They stood up to King Uzziah and said to him,
"Uzziah, it is not your job to burn incense to the LORD.
That is the job of the priests, the sons of Aaron.
They have been set apart to burn incense.
Leave the holy place!
You have been unfaithful.
The LORD God will not honor you for this."
19 Uzziah became angry.
He was holding a censer in his hand to burn incense.
A censer is a pan for burning incense.
While he was angry with the priests,
leprosy broke out on his forehead.
It happened in front of the priests in the LORD's house,
beside the incense altar.
20 Azariah the chief priest and all the other priests looked at him.
He had leprosy on his forehead!
They quickly pushed him out of there.
And he himself hurried to get out,
because the LORD had struck him.
21 King Uzziah had leprosy until the day he died.
He lived in a separate house because of his leprosy.
He was not allowed into the LORD's house anymore.
His son Jotham was in charge of the king's palace.
He ruled over the people of the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Uzziah wants to be everything: king and priest. But the law was clear: only the priests from Aaron's family were allowed to offer incense in the holy place (Numbers 18:7).

The 80 priests are very brave. They stand in the way of a mighty king.

In the Bible, "leprosy" is a name for different serious skin diseases, not only for what is called leprosy today. Whoever had leprosy had to live apart (Leviticus 13:46).

The king who wanted to force his way into the temple may now never go in again. That is the bitter irony of this story.

The message: success can make people proud. "Pride goes before destruction" (Proverbs 16:18). Even great and successful people must respect limits.

The death of Uzziah VERSES 22–23

22 There is more to tell about Uzziah, from beginning to end.
Isaiah the prophet, the son of Amoz, wrote it down.
23 Then Uzziah died and joined his ancestors.
They buried him with his ancestors,
in the burial field that belonged to the kings.
They said, "He has leprosy."
His son Jotham became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The prophet Isaiah lived at this time. In the year that Uzziah died, Isaiah had his great vision in the temple. There he saw the true king: God himself on his throne (Isaiah 6:1–5).

Uzziah was buried beside the royal tombs, but not in them, because of his disease.

In the 20th century, an old stone plaque was found in Jerusalem with the words: "Here were brought the bones of Uzziah, king of Judah. Do not open!" It comes from a much later time, when his bones were moved to a new grave. But it shows that people remembered him for a long time.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 27

Jotham, a faithful king

Jotham's reign VERSES 1–6

1 Jotham was 25 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 16 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Jerushah.
She was the daughter of Zadok.
2 Jotham did what was right in the LORD's eyes,
just as his father Uzziah had done.
But he did not go into the LORD's temple.
The people still did evil things.
3 Jotham built the Upper Gate of the LORD's house.
He also did a lot of building on the wall of Ophel.
4 He built cities in the hill country of Judah.
And in the forests, he built forts and towers.
5 He went to war against the king of the Ammonites
and defeated them.
That year the Ammonites gave him 100 talents of
silver (about 7,500 pounds).
They also gave him about 60,000 bushels of wheat
and about 60,000 bushels of barley.
The Ammonites paid him the same amount in the
second year and in the third year.
6 So Jotham became powerful,
because he set his ways in order before the LORD his
God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jotham ruled from about 750 to 735 BC. For part of this time, he ruled for his sick father (2 Chronicles 26:21).

Verse 2: Jotham was like his father, but he did not make his father's mistake. He did not force his way into the temple to offer incense himself. He had learned from his father's mistake.

"The people still did evil things": a good king alone cannot change the heart of the people. At the same time, the prophets Isaiah and Micah complained about injustice and the worship of idols in Judah.

The Ophel is a hill in Jerusalem between the City of David and the temple.

A talent is about 75 pounds. The Bible says "10,000 cors" of wheat and barley. A cor is about 6 bushels.

Verse 6 is the secret of his success: "He set his ways in order before the LORD his God." He lived consciously before God.

The death of Jotham VERSES 7–9

7 There is more to tell about Jotham, about all his wars
and about the way he lived.
It is written in the book of the kings of Israel and
Judah.
8 He was 25 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 16 years in Jerusalem.
9 Then Jotham died and joined his ancestors.
They buried him in David's city.
His son Ahaz became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jotham is one of the few kings about whom Chronicles says nothing bad.

Verse 8 repeats verse 1. Maybe this is to close a section before a very dark time begins with Ahaz.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 28

Ahaz and the merciful Samaritans

Ahaz serves foreign gods VERSES 1–4

1 Ahaz was 20 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 16 years in Jerusalem.
He did not do what was right in the LORD's eyes,
as his ancestor David had done.
2 Instead, he lived like the kings of Israel.
He even made metal idols for the Baals.
3 He burned incense in the Valley of the Son of Hinnom.
He burned his own children in the fire.
In this way he copied the disgusting customs of the
nations.
The LORD had driven out those nations before the
people of Israel.
4 Ahaz offered sacrifices and burned incense at the high
places.
He did it on the hills and under every green tree.
High places are places of worship on hills.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is also told in 2 Kings 16. Ahaz ruled from about 735 to 715 BC.

Ahaz is one of the worst kings of Judah. He worships foreign gods and does the most terrible thing: he burns his own children as offerings. That is a horrible crime. God's law clearly forbids it (Leviticus 18:21; Deuteronomy 18:10). God does not want human sacrifices. Already with Abraham and Isaac he showed: no child is to be sacrificed (Genesis 22).

The Valley of the Son of Hinnom is south of Jerusalem. Such child sacrifices took place there. Later, the name of the valley ("Gehenna") became a picture for hell.

Defeats against Syria and Israel VERSES 5–8

5 So the LORD his God let the king of Syria defeat him.
The Syrians beat him.
They captured a large crowd of his people
and took them to Damascus.

The LORD also let the king of Israel defeat him.
The king of Israel killed very many of his people.
6 Pekah, the son of Remaliah, killed 120,000 men in
Judah in one day.
All of them were brave men.
This happened because they had left the LORD, the God
of their ancestors.
7 Zichri was a mighty warrior from Ephraim.
He killed Maaseiah, the king's son.
He killed Azrikam, who was in charge of the palace.
And he killed Elkanah, who was second only to the
king.
8 The people of Israel captured 200,000 women, sons, and
daughters.
These were their own relatives from Judah.
They also took a lot of plunder from them
and brought it to Samaria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king of Syria was Rezin, the king of Israel was Pekah. The two joined forces against Judah (the "Syro-Ephraimite War," around 734 BC). At this time, the prophet Isaiah spoke to Ahaz (Isaiah 7).

The numbers are very large again. What matters is: Judah suffered a terrible defeat. And worst of all: brothers lead brothers into slavery.

The prophet Oded and the merciful men from Samaria
VERSES 9–15

9 But a prophet of the LORD was there.
His name was Oded.
He went out to meet the army as it came back to
Samaria.
He said to them,
"The LORD, the God of your ancestors, was angry with
Judah.
That is why he let you defeat them.
But you have killed them with a rage so great that it
reaches up to heaven.
10 And now you want to make the people of Judah and
Jerusalem your slaves,
men and women.
But aren't you guilty of sins against the LORD your
God too?
11 So listen to me now!
Send the prisoners back.
They are your own relatives.
The LORD is very angry with you."
12 Then some of the leaders of Ephraim stood up
against the men who were coming back from the war.
These leaders were:
Azariah, the son of Johanan,
Berechiah, the son of Meshillemoth,
Jehizkiah, the son of Shallum,
and Amasa, the son of Hadlai.
13 They said to the soldiers,
"You must not bring the prisoners here!
What you plan to do would make us guilty before the
LORD.
It would add to our sins and to our guilt.
Our guilt is already great,
and God is very angry with Israel."
14 So the soldiers left the prisoners and the plunder
in front of the leaders and the whole assembly.
15 Then the men who were just named got up and took
care of the prisoners.
Some of the prisoners were naked.
The men used clothes from the plunder to dress them.
They gave them clothes and sandals.
They gave them food and drink.
They rubbed oil on them.
They put all the weak ones on donkeys.
They brought them to their relatives in Jericho, the
city of palm trees.
Then they went back to Samaria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most beautiful stories in Chronicles, in the middle of a dark chapter.

A prophet from the northern kingdom tells his own people the truth: you have no right to make your brothers slaves. You yourselves are guilty before God.

And some leaders listen to him. They do even more than the prophet asks: they give the prisoners clothing, food and drink, rub oil on them and set the weak on donkeys.

Many interpreters see here a model for Jesus' parable of the good Samaritan (Luke 10:30–37): there, too, a man from Samaria helps, pours oil on the wounds, sets the injured man on his animal and brings him to safety on the road near Jericho.

In this way, Chronicles shows: in the northern kingdom, too, there were people who listened to God. Mercy can turn enemies back into brothers.

Ahaz seeks help from Assyria VERSES 16–21

16 At that time, King Ahaz asked the kings of Assyria for
help.
17 The Edomites had come again.
They had attacked Judah and taken prisoners.
18 The Philistines had also attacked the towns in the
lowlands and in the south of Judah.
They had captured Beth Shemesh, Aijalon, and
Gederoth.
They had captured Soco, Timnah, and Gimzo, with
their villages.
And they settled there.
19 The LORD humbled Judah because of Ahaz, king of
Israel.
Ahaz let Judah do whatever it wanted.
And he was very unfaithful to the LORD.
20 Tilgath-pilneser, king of Assyria, came to him.
But he brought him trouble instead of help.
21 Ahaz took things from the LORD's house,
from the king's palace, and from the leaders.
He gave them to the king of Assyria.
But it didn't help him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Instead of asking God for help, Ahaz calls the most powerful ruler in the world: the king of Assyria. The prophet Isaiah had warned him (Isaiah 7:1–17): trust in God, then you will stand firm!

In the WEB, our English source text, he is called "Tilgath-pilneser." This is another spelling of Tiglath-pileser III. He ruled from about 745 to 727 BC. In his own inscriptions, Ahaz is named as one of the kings who paid tribute to him.

According to 2 Kings 16:9, Tiglath-pileser helped for a short time by conquering Damascus. But in the long run, he made Judah dependent and poor. "It didn't help him."
Here Ahaz is called "king of Israel." For Chronicles, Judah is the true Israel.

Ahaz closes the temple VERSES 22–27

22 In the time of his distress,
he was even more unfaithful to the LORD.
That is what King Ahaz did.
23 He offered sacrifices to the gods of Damascus,
the gods of the people who had defeated him.
He said,
"The gods of the kings of Syria helped them.
So I will offer sacrifices to them.
Then they will help me too."
But these gods ruined him and all Israel.
24 Ahaz collected the objects of God's house
and broke them into pieces.
He locked the doors of the LORD's house.
He made altars for himself on every street corner in Jerusalem.
25 In every city of Judah, he made high places
to burn incense to other gods.
So he made the LORD, the God of his ancestors, angry.
26 There is more to tell about Ahaz and all he did, from beginning to end.
It is written in the book of the kings of Judah and Israel.
27 Then Ahaz died and joined his ancestors.
They buried him in the city, in Jerusalem.
But they did not bring him into the tombs of the kings of Israel.
His son Hezekiah became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22 is shocking: "In the time of his distress, he was even more unfaithful to the LORD." Distress can lead people to God, like Manasseh later (Chapter 33). But it can also drive people even further away from God.

Ahaz thinks like a businessman: which god helps most? That one I will worship. But faith is not a trade.

Worst of all: he closes the temple. The lamps go out, no more worship takes place (2 Chronicles 29:7).

Ahaz is not buried in the royal tombs. And his son Hezekiah will do exactly the opposite: he opens the temple again.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 29

Hezekiah opens the temple again

Hezekiah's call to the priests and Levites VERSES 1–11

1 Hezekiah became king when he was 25 years old.
He ruled for 29 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Abijah.
She was the daughter of Zechariah.
2 Hezekiah did what was right in the LORD's eyes,
just as his ancestor David had done.
3 In the first month of his first year as king,
he opened the doors of the LORD's house and repaired them.
4 He brought in the priests and the Levites.
He gathered them in the open square on the east side.
5 He said to them,
"Listen to me, you Levites!
Make yourselves holy now.
And make the house of the LORD, the God of your ancestors, holy.
Carry all the filth out of the holy place.
6 Our ancestors were unfaithful.
They did what was evil in the eyes of the LORD our God.
They left him.
They turned their faces away from the place where the LORD lives.
They turned their backs on him.
7 They even locked the doors of the porch
and put out the lamps.
They stopped burning incense in the holy place for the God of Israel.
They stopped offering burnt offerings there.
8 That is why the LORD became angry with Judah and Jerusalem.
He has let them be tossed back and forth.
People are shocked when they see them, and they hiss at them.
You can see it with your own eyes.
9 Our ancestors have been killed with the sword.
Our sons, our daughters, and our wives have been taken captive because of this.
10 Now I want to make a covenant with the LORD, the God of Israel.
Then his fierce anger will turn away from us.
11 My sons, do not be careless now.
The LORD has chosen you to stand before him and to serve him.
You are to be his servants and burn incense."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hezekiah ruled from about 715 to 686 BC. He is one of the best kings of Judah. In three chapters (29–31), Chronicles tells how he renewed the worship.

He does not wait a single day: right in the first month, he opens the temple that his father had closed.

Hezekiah says honestly: our ancestors were unfaithful. He does not make anything look better than it was. And he explains the distress of the people by their turning away from God.

A "covenant" is a solemn promise. Hezekiah wants to make a completely new start with God.

Lovingly, he calls the Levites "my sons."

The Levites clean the temple VERSES 12–19

12 Then these Levites got to work:
From the Kohathites: Mahath, the son of Amasai, and Joel, the son of Azariah.
From the Merarites: Kish, the son of Abdi, and Azariah, the son of Jehallelel.
From the Gershonites: Joah, the son of Zimmah, and Eden, the son of Joah.
13 From the sons of Elizaphan: Shimri and Jeuel.
From the sons of Asaph: Zechariah and Mattaniah.
14 From the sons of Heman: Jehuel and Shimei.
From the sons of Jeduthun: Shemaiah and Uzziel.
15 They gathered their relatives, and they made themselves holy.
Then they went in to clean the LORD's house.
They did what the king had commanded, following the words of the LORD.
16 The priests went into the inner part of the LORD's house to clean it.
They brought out everything unclean that they found in the LORD's temple.
They brought it into the courtyard of the LORD's house.
From there, the Levites carried it out to the Kidron Valley.
17 They began to make everything holy on the first day of the first month.
On the eighth day of the month, they reached the porch of the LORD's house.
Then they made the LORD's house holy in eight days.
They finished on the sixteenth day of the first month.
18 Then they went in to King Hezekiah in the palace.
They said,
"We have cleaned the whole house of the LORD.
We have cleaned the altar of burnt offering with all its objects.
And we have cleaned the table for the holy bread with all its objects.
19 King Ahaz threw away objects during his rule, when he was unfaithful.
We have prepared all these objects and made them holy.
They are now in front of the LORD's altar."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Representatives of all the Levite families help: the three great families of Kohath, Merari and Gershon, and the singer families of Asaph, Heman and Jeduthun.

Only the priests were allowed into the inner part of the temple. They carried out the filth, and the Levites took it away. Everyone did their part.

The "filth" was probably idols, foreign altars and dirt from the years when the temple was closed.

The cleaning took 16 days. It was a lot of work, but it was done with devotion.

Offerings to make peace with God for the whole people VERSES 20–24

20 Then King Hezekiah got up early.
He gathered the leaders of the city and went up to the LORD's house.
21 They brought seven bulls, seven rams, seven lambs, and seven male goats.
They were a sin offering for the kingdom, for the holy place, and for Judah.
Hezekiah commanded the priests, the sons of Aaron, to offer them on the LORD's altar.
22 So they killed the bulls.
The priests caught the blood and sprinkled it on the altar.
They killed the rams and sprinkled the blood on the altar.
They killed the lambs and sprinkled the blood on the altar.
23 Then they brought the male goats for the sin offering to the king and the assembly.
They laid their hands on the goats.
24 Then the priests killed the goats.
They put their blood on the altar as a sin offering.
This made atonement for all Israel.
Atonement means: the guilt is covered, and there is peace with God again.
The king had commanded that the burnt offering and the sin offering
be made for all Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before normal worship begins again, forgiveness is needed. The sin offerings are to make up for the guilt of the past years.

In the Bible, the number seven stands for completeness.

Laying on hands means: we put our guilt on this animal. It dies in our place (compare Leviticus 4 and 16:21).

Important: "for all Israel." Hezekiah also thinks of the northern kingdom. Christians see in these offerings a pointer to Jesus, who according to the New Testament died once for all for the guilt of all people (Hebrews 10:10–12).

Music and worship VERSES 25–30

25 Hezekiah placed the Levites in the LORD's house.
They had cymbals, stringed instruments, and harps.
This is what David had commanded,
and Gad, the king's seer, and Nathan the prophet.
A seer is a prophet who sees visions from God.
The command came from the LORD through his prophets.
26 The Levites stood ready with David's instruments.
The priests stood ready with the trumpets.
27 Hezekiah gave the order to offer the burnt offering on the altar.
When the burnt offering began,
the song for the LORD began too.
The trumpets and the instruments of David, king of Israel, played along.
28 The whole assembly worshiped.
The singers sang,
and the trumpet players blew their trumpets.
All this went on until the burnt offering was finished.
29 When the offering was finished,
the king and everyone with him bowed down and worshiped.
30 King Hezekiah and the leaders told the Levites to praise the LORD with the words of David and of

Asaph the seer.
So they sang praises with joy.
They bowed their heads and worshiped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The music in the temple was not only David's idea. Verse 25 says: it came from God through prophets.

When the offering begins, the singing begins too. Forgiveness and joy belong together.

"With the words of David and of Asaph": these are psalms. Many psalms carry the name of David or Asaph (for example, Psalms 50 and 73–83 by Asaph).

The people bring offerings willingly VERSES 31–36

31 Then Hezekiah said,
"Now you have given yourselves to the LORD.
Come and bring sacrifices and thank offerings into the LORD's house."
So the assembly brought sacrifices and thank offerings.
Everyone who had a willing heart brought burnt offerings.
32 The assembly brought 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 lambs as burnt offerings.
All of these were burnt offerings for the LORD.
33 The other holy offerings were 600 cattle and 3,000 sheep.
34 But there were not enough priests
to skin all the burnt offerings.
So their relatives, the Levites, helped them until the work was done.
They helped until the priests had made themselves holy.
The Levites had been more careful than the priests to make themselves holy.
35 There were also very many burnt offerings.
And there was the fat of the peace offerings,
and the drink offerings for each burnt offering.
So the service in the LORD's house was set up again.
36 Hezekiah and all the people were full of joy
about what God had prepared for the people.
Everything had happened so quickly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the people themselves come. No one is forced. Those give "who had a willing heart."

An honest remark in verse 34: the Levites were more eager than the priests. Chronicles is not afraid to criticize the priests too.

Verse 36: the joy was great because everything happened so quickly. The people were ready for a new beginning. Chronicles says: God himself had prepared it.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 30

The great Passover

An invitation to all Israel VERSES 1–5

1 Hezekiah sent messages to all Israel and Judah.
He also wrote letters to Ephraim and Manasseh.
He invited them to come to the LORD's house in Jerusalem.
They were to celebrate the Passover for the LORD, the God of Israel.
2 The king had talked with his leaders and the whole assembly in Jerusalem.
They had decided to celebrate the Passover in the second month.
3 They could not celebrate it at the usual time.
Not enough priests had made themselves holy.
And the people had not yet gathered in Jerusalem.
4 The king and the whole assembly thought this plan was right.
5 So they made a decision.
They would send out a message to all Israel,
from Beersheba to Dan.
Everyone was to come to Jerusalem
to celebrate the Passover for the LORD, the God of Israel.
Not many people had celebrated it the way it is written.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Passover recalls the freeing from Egypt. Normally it is celebrated in the first month. But the law allows the Passover to be held in the second month if someone was unclean or far away in the first month (Numbers 9:6–13).

What is special: Hezekiah also invites the northern kingdom, "Ephraim and Manasseh." The northern kingdom had just been conquered by the Assyrians (722 BC). Many had been carried away. Hezekiah invites those who were left.

"From Beersheba to Dan" means: from the far south to the far north. The whole nation, as in the time of David and Solomon.

The king's letter VERSES 6–9

6 So the messengers took the letters from the king and his leaders.
They went through all Israel and Judah,
as the king had commanded.
They said,
"People of Israel,
turn back to the LORD, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel!
Then he will turn back to you who are left,
you who escaped from the kings of Assyria.
7 Don't be like your ancestors and your relatives.
They were unfaithful to the LORD, the God of their ancestors.
So he let them be destroyed, as you can see.
8 Don't be stiff-necked like your ancestors.
Yield yourselves to the LORD.
Come to his holy place, which he has made holy

forever.
Serve the LORD your God.
Then his fierce anger will turn away from you.
9 If you turn back to the LORD,
your relatives and your children will find mercy.
The people who took them captive will be kind to them.
And they will come back to this land.
The LORD your God is gracious and merciful.
He will not turn his face away from you if you come back to him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The letter is an invitation to turn back. The Hebrew word "shuv" (to turn back) appears several times: turn back to God, then God will turn to you, and your prisoners will come back.

"Stiff-necked" means stubborn, like an animal that makes its neck stiff and will not be led.

"Yield yourselves to the LORD": in Hebrew it says literally, "Give the LORD your hand," as a sign of devotion and trust.

Verse 9 is a great promise: God is gracious and merciful (compare Exodus 34:6). He does not turn away from anyone who turns back to him.

Mockery and humility VERSES 10–12

10 So the messengers went from town to town
through the land of Ephraim and Manasseh, as far as Zebulun.
But people laughed at them and made fun of them.
11 Still, some men from Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humbled themselves.
They came to Jerusalem.
12 God's hand was on Judah too.
He made the people of one mind.
So they did what the king and the leaders commanded, as the LORD had said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many people mock the invitation. It is still like that today: not everyone accepts God's invitation. Jesus tells a similar parable about the great banquet (Luke 14:16–24).

But some come. They "humbled themselves." You have to overcome your pride in order to come.

In Judah, God makes the people of one mind. The people agree.

The feast begins VERSES 13–20

13 A huge crowd of people gathered in Jerusalem
in the second month.
They came to celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread.
Unleavened bread is bread made without yeast.
14 They got to work and removed the altars in Jerusalem.
They removed all the incense altars
and threw them into the Kidron Valley.
15 On the fourteenth day of the second month,
they killed the Passover lambs.
The priests and the Levites were ashamed.
They made themselves holy
and brought burnt offerings into the LORD's house.
16 They took their places in the proper order,
as the Law of Moses, the man of God, says.
The Levites handed the blood to the priests,
and the priests sprinkled it on the altar.
17 Many people in the assembly had not made themselves holy.
So the Levites took over the killing of the Passover lambs
for everyone who was not clean.
In this way, they made the lambs holy for the LORD.
18 A large crowd of people had not made themselves clean.
Many of them came from Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun.
Still, they ate the Passover, though not the way it is written.
But Hezekiah had prayed for them.
He said,
"May the good LORD forgive everyone
19 who sets their heart on seeking God,
the LORD, the God of their ancestors.
Forgive them, even if they are not clean
by the rules of the holy place."
20 The LORD listened to Hezekiah.
He healed the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The altars that Ahaz had built everywhere in Jerusalem (2 Chronicles 28:24) are removed.

The priests and Levites "were ashamed": the people were more eager than they were. That spurred them on.

Verses 18–20 are among the most important passages in Chronicles. Many people from the north had not been made clean according to the rules. Actually, they were not allowed to eat the Passover. But Hezekiah prays for them: God, forgive everyone who seeks you with their heart, even if they do not keep all the rules.

And God listens to him. The heart is more important to God than the outward form. Jesus says something similar: God wants mercy (Matthew 9:13; 12:7).

"He healed the people": maybe people feared illness as a result of being unclean. God gives healing instead of punishment.

Joy that lasts two weeks VERSES 21–27

21 The people of Israel who were in Jerusalem
celebrated the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days.
They were full of joy.
Every day the Levites and the priests praised the LORD.
They sang to the LORD with loud instruments.
22 Hezekiah spoke kind and encouraging words to all the Levites.
They understood well how to serve the LORD.
So the people ate the festival meals for all seven days.
They offered peace offerings.
And they confessed their sins to the LORD, the God of their ancestors.
23 Then the whole assembly decided to celebrate for seven more days.
So they joyfully celebrated for another seven days.
24 Hezekiah, king of Judah, gave the assembly 1,000 bulls and 7,000 sheep for offerings.
The leaders gave the assembly 1,000 bulls and 10,000

sheep.
And many priests made themselves holy.
25 The whole assembly of Judah was full of joy.
The priests and the Levites rejoiced with them.
The whole assembly that came from Israel rejoiced too.
So did the foreigners who had come from the land of Israel
and who lived in Judah.
26 There was great joy in Jerusalem.
Since the time of Solomon, the son of David, king of Israel,
there had been nothing like this in Jerusalem.
27 Then the Levitical priests stood up and blessed the people.
God heard their voice.
Their prayer reached his holy home in heaven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The joy is so great that the feast is simply made longer, by another week. That was already the case at the dedication of Solomon's temple (2 Chronicles 7:8–9).

Everyone celebrates together: Judah and Israel, priests and people, and also the foreigners. God's feast is open to all who come.

"Since the time of Solomon": for the first time since the kingdom was divided, the whole nation celebrates together again.

The chapter ends with the blessing and with the certainty: the prayer has arrived in heaven. God has heard.

2 CHRONICLES

Chapter 31

The people give with open hands

The altars of the idols are removed VERSE 1

1 When all this was over,
all the Israelites who were there went out to the cities of Judah.
They smashed the stone pillars.
They cut down the Asherah poles.
They tore down the high places and the altars.
They did this in all Judah and Benjamin, and also in Ephraim and Manasseh.
They did not stop until they had destroyed them all.
Then all the people of Israel went back to their own cities.
Each of them went home to his own land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the Passover, the people themselves clean up. It is not ordered from above, but comes from their own heart. And it also happens in the north, in Ephraim and Manasseh.

Order for the priests and Levites VERSES 2–4

2 Hezekiah divided the priests and the Levites into their groups.
Each man had his own task,
both the priests and the Levites.
They took care of the burnt offerings and the peace offerings.
They served, gave thanks, and praised God at the gates of the LORD's camp.
3 The king also gave a share of his own property for the burnt offerings.
It was for the burnt offerings every morning and every evening.
It was also for the burnt offerings on the Sabbaths, at the new moons, and at the set feasts,
as it is written in the LORD's law.
4 He also commanded the people who lived in Jerusalem to give the priests and the Levites their share.
Then they could give all their time to the LORD's law.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the temple is called "the LORD's camp." This recalls the time in the wilderness, when the tabernacle stood in the middle of the camp.

Hezekiah leads by good example: he himself gives from his property for the offerings.

The priests and Levites should not have to worry about earning a living. They should have time to learn and to teach God's law.

The great heaps VERSES 5–10

5 As soon as the order went out,
the people of Israel gave a great deal.
They gave the first fruits of grain, new wine, olive oil, and honey,
and of everything that grew in the fields.
They brought a tithe of everything, and it was a lot.
A tithe is a tenth.
6 The people of Israel and Judah who lived in the cities of Judah
also brought a tithe of their cattle and sheep.
They brought a tithe of the holy gifts that had been set apart for the LORD their God.
They piled everything up in heaps.
7 They began to pile up the heaps in the third month.
They finished in the seventh month.
8 Hezekiah and the leaders came and saw the heaps.
Then they praised the LORD and blessed his people Israel.
9 Hezekiah asked the priests and the Levites about the heaps.
10 Azariah, the chief priest from the family of Zadok, answered him,
"Since the people began to bring their offerings into the LORD's house,
we have had enough to eat.
And there is still plenty left over.
The LORD has blessed his people.
This great supply is what is left over."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"First fruits" are the first fruits of the harvest. The "tithe" is a tenth of the harvest. People gave both to God, as thanks for the harvest (compare Numbers 18; Deuteronomy 14:22–29).

From the third month (grain harvest) to the seventh month (fruit and grape harvest), the heaps grow. There is more than enough.

Remarkable in verse 8: Hezekiah praises not only God, but also the people. He sees how generous the people are.

Verse 10 shows a principle: whoever gives generously does not become poorer. God blesses. (Compare Malachi 3:10.)

Faithful managers VERSES 11–19

11 Then Hezekiah ordered them to prepare storerooms in the LORD's house.
So they prepared them.
12 They faithfully brought in the offerings, the tithes, and the holy gifts.
Conaniah the Levite was in charge of them.
His brother Shimei was second in charge.
13 Under Conaniah and his brother Shimei there were supervisors:
Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismachiah, Mahath, and Benaiah.
King Hezekiah and Azariah, the leader of God's house, had appointed them.
14 Kore, the son of Imnah, was a Levite.
He was the gatekeeper at the East Gate.
He was in charge of the gifts that people gave to God freely.
He handed out the offerings for the LORD and the most holy gifts.
15 Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah helped him.
They worked in the towns of the priests, in their position of trust.
They gave shares to their relatives by their groups, to the great as well as to the small.
16 They also gave to the males listed in the family records, who were three years old or older.
They gave to everyone who came into the LORD's house
to do their daily work,
the service of their group.
17 They gave to the priests listed in the family records by their families.
And they gave to the Levites who were 20 years old or older,
according to their duties and their groups.
18 They gave to everyone listed in the family records:
to all their little children, their wives, their sons, and their daughters,
in the whole community.
In their position of trust, they kept themselves holy.
19 There were also the priests, the sons of Aaron,
who lived in the pasture lands around their towns.
In every town, men were named
to give shares to all the males among the priests
and to everyone listed in the family records of the Levites.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many goods are involved. That is why honest and faithful managers are needed. Chronicles names them all. The words "faithfully" and "position of trust" appear several times.

The gifts were shared out fairly: "to the great as well as to the small." Even the priests who lived far away in the country received their share. And the families, wives and children were provided for too.

"Three years old or older": even the little boys of the priestly families received a share. Some experts think that it originally said "30 years," as in 1 Chronicles 23:3.

These verses are hard to understand in Hebrew. But the meaning is clear: no one was forgotten.

Hezekiah did everything with all his heart VERSES 20–21

20 Hezekiah did this everywhere in Judah.
He did what was good, right, and faithful before the LORD his God.
21 He started many works in the service of God's house, for the law and for the commandments.
In everything, he wanted to seek his God.
He did it with all his heart, and he succeeded.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the most beautiful praise that Chronicles can give a king: he sought God "with all his heart." And he succeeded.

Compare Amaziah, who did what was right, "but not with a perfect heart" (2 Chronicles 25:2).

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 32

Sennacherib threatens Jerusalem

Hezekiah gets ready VERSES 1–8

1 After these things and this faithfulness,
Sennacherib king of Assyria came and entered Judah.
He set up camp against the fortified cities
and planned to take them for himself.
2 Hezekiah saw that Sennacherib had come,
and that he was planning to fight against Jerusalem.
3 Then he talked with his princes and his mighty men
about stopping up the waters of the springs that were outside the city.
And they helped him.
4 So many people gathered together.
They stopped up all the springs
and the brook that flowed through the middle of the land.
They said,
"Why should the kings of Assyria come and find plenty of water?"
5 He took courage.
He built up all the wall that was broken down

and raised it up to the towers,
with the other wall outside.
He made the Millo in David's city strong,
and he made very many weapons and shields.
6 He set captains of war over the people.
He gathered them to him in the open square at the city gate
and spoke encouraging words to them:
7 "Be strong and brave.
Don't be afraid or lose heart because of the king of Assyria,
or because of all the great crowd that is with him.
For there is a greater one with us than with him.
8 With him is an arm of flesh,
but with us is the LORD our God, to help us and to fight our battles."
The people relied on the words of Hezekiah king of Judah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is told in more detail in 2 Kings 18–19 and Isaiah 36–37. Sennacherib marched against Judah in the year 701 BC. His own inscriptions report this. There he boasts that he shut Hezekiah up in Jerusalem "like a bird in a cage." But he does not report a conquest of Jerusalem.

Verse 1 begins in a surprising way: "After these things and this faithfulness" comes the attack. Faithfulness to God does not protect us from all difficulties. But God is there in the difficulties.

Hezekiah acts wisely: he makes sure that the enemies find no water, and he builds up the walls. Faith and wise action belong together.

The "Millo" was a fortification in the City of David, maybe a terrace built up with earth.

Verses 7–8 are a great sentence of faith: "There is a greater one with us than with him." An "arm of flesh" is human power, which does not last. Compare Jeremiah 17:5–7 and 1 John 4:4.

Sennacherib's mockery VERSES 9–19

9 After this, Sennacherib king of Assyria sent his servants to Jerusalem.
At that time he was attacking Lachish,
and all his forces were with him.
He sent them to Hezekiah king of Judah
and to all Judah who were in Jerusalem, with this message:
10 "Sennacherib king of Assyria says:
In whom do you trust,
that you stay in Jerusalem while it is surrounded?
11 Isn't Hezekiah talking you into letting yourselves die of hunger and thirst,
when he says,
'The LORD our God will save us out of the hand of the king of Assyria'?
12 Hasn't this same Hezekiah taken away his high places and his altars?
Hasn't he commanded Judah and Jerusalem,
'You shall worship before one altar,
and you shall burn incense on it'?
13 Don't you know what I and my ancestors have done to all the peoples of the lands?
Were the gods of the nations of those lands in any way able
to save their land out of my hand?
14 Who among all the gods of those nations that my ancestors completely destroyed
was able to save his people out of my hand?
How then should your God be able to save you out of my hand?
15 So now don't let Hezekiah fool you or talk you into this.
Don't believe him.
For no god of any nation or kingdom was able to save his people
out of my hand and out of the hand of my ancestors.
How much less will your God save you out of my hand!"
16 His servants spoke even more against the LORD God and against his servant Hezekiah.
17 He also wrote letters to insult the LORD, the God of Israel,
and to speak against him:
"The gods of the nations of the lands have not saved their people out of my hand.
In the same way the God of Hezekiah will not save his people out of my hand."
18 They called out with a loud voice in the Jews' language to the people of Jerusalem who were on the wall,
to frighten them and to trouble them,
so that they might take the city.
19 They spoke about the God of Jerusalem
as about the gods of the peoples of the earth,
which are the work of human hands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Lachish was the second most important city of Judah. Sennacherib had the conquest of Lachish shown on large stone pictures in his palace in Nineveh. Today these pictures can be seen in the British Museum in London.

Sennacherib's servants try to make the people unsure:

– They twist Hezekiah's reform: he supposedly destroyed God's altars. But he had removed the altars of idols and gathered the worship in Jerusalem.

– They say: no god has been able to help against us so far. Why should your God be able to?

– They speak "in the Jews' language," that is, in Hebrew, so that everyone on the wall understands it and becomes afraid.

Verse 19 shows their greatest mistake: they think the living God is an idol made by people.

God saves Jerusalem VERSES 20–23

20 Because of this, King Hezekiah and Isaiah the prophet, the son of Amoz,
prayed and cried out to heaven.
21 The LORD sent an angel,
who cut off all the brave warriors, the leaders, and the captains
in the camp of the king of Assyria.
So he went back to his own land in shame.
When he had come into the house of his god,
those who had come out of his own body killed him there with the sword.
22 So the LORD saved Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem

from the hand of Sennacherib the king of Assyria
and from the hand of all others,
and he guided them on every side.
23 Many brought gifts to the LORD in Jerusalem,
and precious things to Hezekiah king of Judah.
So from then on he was honored in the sight of all nations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hezekiah and Isaiah pray. And God steps in. Chronicles tells this very briefly. 2 Kings 19:35 says that in one night 185,000 men died in the camp of the Assyrians.

"Those who had come out of his own body" means: his own sons. Sennacherib was murdered by sons of his about 20 years later, in 681 BC. Babylonian and Assyrian sources report this too. Chronicles sums it up without saying how much time passed in between.

The irony: Sennacherib mocked that no god could save his followers. And then he is killed in the temple of his own god. His god could not protect him.

"He guided them": some manuscripts have "he gave them rest."

Hezekiah's illness and pride VERSES 24–26

24 In those days Hezekiah became sick and was about to die.
He prayed to the LORD,
and the LORD spoke to him and gave him a sign.
25 But Hezekiah did not show thanks for the good that was done for him,
because his heart was lifted up in pride.
So anger came on him, and on Judah and Jerusalem.
26 But Hezekiah humbled himself for the pride of his heart,
he and the people of Jerusalem.
So the LORD's anger didn't come on them in the days of Hezekiah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is told in more detail in 2 Kings 20 and Isaiah 38. God gave Hezekiah 15 more years of life. The sign was that the shadow on the sundial went back.

Even a king as good as Hezekiah becomes proud. No one is safe from this.

But Hezekiah humbles himself. And God spares him. This is the great theme of Chronicles: whoever humbles himself finds grace (2 Chronicles 7:14).

Hezekiah's riches and works VERSES 27–31

27 Hezekiah had very great riches and honor.
He made himself treasuries for silver, for gold, for precious stones,
for spices, for shields, and for all kinds of valuable objects,
28 and also storehouses for the harvest of grain, new wine, and oil,
and stalls for all kinds of animals,
and pens for the flocks.
29 He also built cities for himself,
and he had very many flocks and herds.
For God had given him very great possessions.
30 This same Hezekiah also stopped up the upper spring of the waters of Gihon
and brought the water straight down on the west side of David's city.
Hezekiah succeeded in all his works.
31 But then the ambassadors of the princes of Babylon came.
They had been sent to him to ask about the wonder that had happened in the land.
Then God left him alone to test him,
so that he might know all that was in his heart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 30 describes a great technical achievement: Hezekiah had a tunnel dug through the rock. He led the water of the Gihon spring from outside into the city. So Jerusalem had water during a siege. This "Hezekiah's Tunnel" is more than 1,600 feet long, and people can still walk through it today. In 1880 an old inscription was found in it that describes how the two groups of workers met in the middle.

Verse 31 refers to 2 Kings 20:12–19: Hezekiah proudly showed the ambassadors from Babylon all his treasures. Then the prophet Isaiah said that everything would one day be carried to Babylon.

"God left him alone to test him": God let him decide alone for a time. In this way it was to become visible what was in his heart. Sometimes it is only in a test that it shows how things really stand with us.

"The wonder": probably Hezekiah's healing and the sign with the shadow.

The death of Hezekiah VERSES 32–33

32 The rest of the acts of Hezekiah and his good deeds are written in the vision of Isaiah the prophet, the son of Amoz,
in the book of the kings of Judah and Israel.
33 Hezekiah died and joined his ancestors,
and they buried him on the way up to the tombs of the sons of David.
All Judah and the people of Jerusalem honored him at his death.
And Manasseh his son reigned in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hezekiah was buried with great honor, quite differently from his father Ahaz.

The "vision of Isaiah" is probably the book of the prophet Isaiah, which begins with these words (Isaiah 1:1).

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 33

Manasseh turns back

Manasseh's evil deeds VERSES 1–10

1 Manasseh was 12 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 55 years in Jerusalem.

2 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
He copied the disgusting customs of the nations
that the LORD had driven out before the people of
Israel.
3 He rebuilt the high places that his father Hezekiah had
torn down.
He set up altars for the Baals.
He made Asheroth.
Asheroth are wooden poles for the goddess Asherah.
He bowed down to all the army of the sky and served
them.
4 He built altars in the LORD's house.
But the LORD had said about this house,
"My name will be in Jerusalem forever."
5 In both courtyards of the LORD's house,
he built altars for all the army of the sky.
6 He also made his children pass through the fire
in the Valley of the Son of Hinnom.
He practiced magic, fortune-telling, and witchcraft.
He went to people who called up the spirits of the dead,
and to people who practiced sorcery.
He did much evil in the LORD's eyes
and made him angry.
7 Manasseh had made a carved idol.
He put it in God's house.
But God had said to David and to his son Solomon
about this house,
"I have chosen Jerusalem out of all the tribes of Israel.
In this house and in Jerusalem
I will put my name forever.
8 I will never again make Israel leave the land
that I gave to your ancestors.
But they must carefully do everything I have
commanded them.
They must keep the whole law, all the rules and laws I
gave through Moses."
9 But Manasseh led Judah and the people of Jerusalem
astray.
They did even more evil than the nations
that the LORD had destroyed before the people of
Israel.
10 The LORD spoke to Manasseh and to his people,
but they did not listen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are almost the same in 2 Kings 21. Manasseh ruled from about 697 to 642 BC, longer than any other king of Judah.

Manasseh undoes everything that his father Hezekiah had built up. He does everything that God had forbidden: worship of idols in the temple, worship of the stars ("the army of the sky" is the sun, the moon and the stars), child sacrifices and magic.

"Made his children pass through the fire" very probably means that he burned them as offerings. That is a horrible crime. God does not want human sacrifices (Deuteronomy 18:10).

He even puts an idol in the temple, in the place where God's name is to live.

But verse 10 shows: God still goes on speaking to him. He does not give up.

Manasseh in captivity and his turning back VERSES 11–13

11 So the LORD sent the commanders of the army of the
king of Assyria against them.
They captured Manasseh in chains.
They put him in shackles
and took him to Babylon.
12 Manasseh was in deep trouble.
Then he begged the LORD his God for help.
He humbled himself deeply before the God of his
ancestors.
13 He prayed to God.
And God was moved by his prayer.
He listened to his plea.
He brought him back to Jerusalem, to his kingdom.
Then Manasseh knew that the LORD was God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is only in Chronicles, not in 2 Kings.

"In chains": the Hebrew has a word that can also mean "hooks" or "thorns." The Assyrians sometimes led prisoners away with hooks through the nose or lip. That was cruel and humiliating.

It may be surprising that Manasseh was brought to Babylon, because the capital of Assyria was Nineveh. But at that time, Babylon belonged to the Assyrian empire. In Assyrian inscriptions, Manasseh is named as a vassal king who had to pay tribute.

This is one of the most hopeful stories in the Bible: even the worst king of Judah turns back. And God forgives him. No person is too far away to come back to God.

"Then Manasseh knew that the LORD was God": in his distress, he really came to know God.

There is an old prayer that is called the "Prayer of Manasseh." It is among the Apocrypha in some Bibles. But it was probably written much later.

Manasseh builds up VERSES 14–17

14 After this, Manasseh built an outer wall for David's city.
It ran west of the Gihon Spring in the valley,
as far as the entrance at the Fish Gate.
It went all around Ophel.
He made the wall very high.
He put brave commanders in all the fortified cities of
Judah.
15 He removed the foreign gods and the idol from the
LORD's house.
He also removed all the altars he had built on the hill of
the LORD's house and in Jerusalem.
He threw them all out of the city.
16 He rebuilt the LORD's altar.
On it, he offered peace offerings and thank offerings.
He commanded the people of Judah to serve the
LORD, the God of Israel.
17 Still, the people kept offering sacrifices at the high
places.
But now they offered them only to the LORD their
God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Manasseh's turning back is real. He cleans up what he himself has done. He offers thank offerings: he is thankful to God for saving him.

But verse 17 shows: it is hard to put everything right again. The people go on offering on the high places, even if now to the right God. The damage that Manasseh had done was great.

Turning back is always possible. But the results of earlier deeds do not simply disappear.

The death of Manasseh VERSES 18–20

18 There is more to tell about Manasseh.
There is his prayer to his God.
There are the words of the seers who spoke to him in the name of the LORD, the God of Israel.
All this is written in the records of the kings of Israel.
19 His prayer is written down there too,
and how God listened to his plea.
All his sin and his unfaithfulness are written down.
And so are the places where he built high places and set up Asherah poles and carved idols before he humbled himself.
All this is written in the history of Hozai.
20 Then Manasseh died and joined his ancestors.
They buried him at his own house.
His son Amon became king after him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Hozai": some translate "the seers" instead of a name. The book no longer exists.

2 Kings 21:18 says that he was buried in the garden of his house, in the garden of Uzza.

Amon VERSES 21–25

21 Amon was 22 years old when he became king.
He ruled for two years in Jerusalem.
22 He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes,
just as his father Manasseh had done.
Amon offered sacrifices to all the carved idols that his father Manasseh had made.
And he served them.
23 But he did not humble himself before the LORD,
as his father Manasseh had done.
Instead, Amon became more and more guilty.
24 His servants made plans against him.
They killed him in his own palace.
25 But the people of the land killed all those who had made plans against King Amon.
Then the people of the land made his son Josiah king after him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amon copied the evil deeds of his father, but not his turning back. That is sad: children often learn more from the mistakes of their parents than from their turning back.

Amon ruled from about 642 to 640 BC.

His son Josiah will become one of the best kings of Judah.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 34

Josiah and the book of the law that was found

Josiah seeks God even as a boy VERSES 1–7

1 Josiah was eight years old when he became king.
He ruled for 31 years in Jerusalem.
2 He did what was right in the LORD's eyes.
He lived the way his ancestor David had lived.
He didn't turn away to the right or to the left.
3 In the eighth year of his rule, he was still young.
Then he began to seek the God of his ancestor David.
In the twelfth year, he began to make Judah and Jerusalem clean.
He removed the high places and the Asherah poles, the carved idols and the metal idols.
4 While he watched, the people tore down the altars of the Baals.
He cut down the incense altars that stood above them.
He smashed the Asherah poles, the carved idols, and the metal idols.
He ground them into dust.
He scattered the dust on the graves of the people who had offered sacrifices to them.
5 He burned the bones of the priests on their own altars.
So he made Judah and Jerusalem clean.
6 He did the same in the towns of Manasseh, Ephraim, and Simeon,
all the way to Naphtali,
and in the ruins all around them.
7 He tore down the altars.
He crushed the Asherah poles and the carved idols to powder.
He cut down all the incense altars in the whole land of Israel.
Then he went back to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is also told in 2 Kings 22–23. Josiah ruled from about 640 to 609 BC.

At 16 years old (in the eighth year of his rule), Josiah begins to seek God. At 20 years old (in the twelfth year), he begins to clean the land of idols. His grandfather Manasseh and his father Amon had filled the land with idols.

He "didn't turn away to the right or to the left": he went straight ahead on God's way (compare Deuteronomy 5:32).

Josiah also cleans the area of the former northern kingdom. The Assyrian empire was becoming weaker at that time. So Josiah could act there too.

Burning the bones of the priests of the idols on their altars made these altars unclean forever. So no one could sacrifice there anymore. A prophet had already announced this 300 years before (1 Kings 13:2).

The repair of the temple VERSES 8–13

8 In the eighteenth year of his rule,
Josiah had made the land and the temple clean.
Then he sent three men to repair the house of the LORD his God:

Shaphan, the son of Azaliah,
Maaseiah, the governor of the city,
and Joah, the son of Joahaz, the official who kept the records.

9 They came to Hilkiah, the high priest.
They gave him the money that had been brought into God's house.
The Levites who guarded the doors had collected it.
It came from the people of Manasseh and Ephraim,
from all the rest of Israel,
from all Judah and Benjamin,
and from the people of Jerusalem.

10 They gave the money to the men who were in charge of the work on the LORD's house.
These men paid the workers who repaired and restored the LORD's house.

11 They gave money to the carpenters and the builders.
With it, they bought cut stone and wood for supports and beams.
They used it for the buildings that the kings of Judah had let fall into ruin.

12 The men did the work faithfully.
Their supervisors were Jahath and Obadiah, Levites from the family of Merari.
Zechariah and Meshullam, from the family of Kohath, led the work too.
Other Levites helped as well.
All of them were skilled with musical instruments.

13 They were also in charge of the men who carried the loads.
They directed all the workers in every kind of job.
Some of the Levites were secretaries, officials, and gatekeepers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Josiah is now 26 years old. After he has cleaned the land, he has the temple repaired.

The money also comes from the north, "from all the rest of Israel." Josiah sees the whole people as one.

The detail in verse 12 is beautiful: the supervisors were musicians. Maybe they accompanied the work with music.

The book of the law is found VERSES 14–21

14 They took out the money that had been brought into the LORD's house.
While they did this, Hilkiah the priest found the book of the LORD's law.
The LORD had given it through Moses.

15 Hilkiah said to Shaphan the secretary,
"I have found the book of the law in the LORD's house."
And Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan.

16 Shaphan took the book to the king.
He also gave the king a report:
"Your servants are doing everything you gave them to do.

17 They have emptied out the money that was in the LORD's house.
They have given it to the supervisors and to the workers."

18 Then Shaphan the secretary told the king,
"Hilkiah the priest has given me a book."
And Shaphan read from it to the king.

19 The king heard the words of the law.
Then he tore his clothes.

20 The king gave an order to Hilkiah,
to Ahikam, the son of Shaphan,
to Abdon, the son of Micah,
to Shaphan the secretary,
and to Asaiah, the king's servant.
He said,

21 "Go and ask the LORD for me,
and for those who are left in Israel and in Judah.
Ask him about the words of this book that was found.
The LORD is very angry with us.
His anger has been poured out on us.
Our ancestors have not obeyed the LORD's word.
They have not done everything that is written in this book."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

During the work in the temple, a book is found: the law of Moses. Under Manasseh, it had probably been forgotten or hidden.

Many experts think that it was the book of Deuteronomy, or a large part of it. For Josiah's reforms fit very exactly with what is written there.

Josiah tears his clothes. That is a sign of deep grief and shock. He realizes: we have not kept God's word. He takes God's word seriously.

He also asks for "those who are left in Israel." He thinks of the whole people.

The prophetess Huldah VERSES 22–28

22 So Hilkiah and the men the king had sent went to Huldah the prophetess.
She was the wife of Shallum.
Shallum was the son of Tokhath, the son of Hasrah.
He was in charge of the royal wardrobe.
Huldah lived in Jerusalem, in the second quarter of the city.
They told her what had happened.

23 She said to them,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, says this:
'Tell the man who sent you to me,

24 "The LORD says this:
'I will bring disaster on this place and on the people who live here.
All the curses written in the book will come true,
the book that was read to the king of Judah.

25 They have left me.
They have burned incense to other gods.
With all the idols they have made, they have made me angry.
So my anger is poured out on this place.
And it will not be put out.'"'

26 The king of Judah sent you to ask the LORD.
Tell him this:
'The LORD, the God of Israel, says this
about the words you have heard:

27 "Your heart was tender.
You humbled yourself before God
when you heard what he said against this place and the people who live here.

You humbled yourself before me.
You tore your clothes and cried before me.
So I have heard you too," says the LORD.
28 "I will gather you to your ancestors.
You will be gathered to your grave in peace.
You will not see all the disaster that I will bring on this place
and on the people who live here."'"
The men took this answer back to the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king sends his most important men to a woman: the prophetess Huldah. At that time, she was a respected prophetess. This shows: God also speaks through women. The prophets Jeremiah and Zephaniah lived at the same time.

Huldah says two things: the judgment on Jerusalem will come, because the people have left God for so long. But Josiah will not live to see it, because his heart has become tender and he has humbled himself.

"Gathered to your grave in peace": Josiah later dies in a battle (Chapter 35). What is probably meant: he dies before Jerusalem is destroyed. He does not have to see the downfall.

"The second quarter" was probably a new part of the city in the northwest of Jerusalem.

The covenant VERSES 29–33

29 Then the king sent messengers.
He called together all the elders of Judah and Jerusalem.
30 The king went up to the LORD's house.
All the men of Judah and the people of Jerusalem went with him.
The priests and the Levites went too,
and all the people, both great and small.
The king read aloud to them everything in the book of the covenant.
This book had been found in the LORD's house.
31 The king stood in his place.
He made a covenant before the LORD.
He promised to follow the LORD.
He promised to keep his commandments, his teachings, and his laws
with all his heart and with all his soul.
He promised to do what the covenant in this book said.
32 He made everyone in Jerusalem and Benjamin stand and agree to it.
And the people of Jerusalem kept the covenant of God, the God of their ancestors.
33 Josiah removed all the disgusting idols
from all the lands that belonged to the people of Israel.
He made everyone in Israel serve the LORD their God.
As long as Josiah lived, they did not turn away from following the LORD, the God of their ancestors.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Josiah does not keep the book of the law for himself. He reads it out to the whole people, "both great and small." Everyone is to hear God's word.

Then he solemnly promises to live by God's word, "with all his heart and with all his soul" (verse 31). This recalls the most important commandment (Deuteronomy 6:5).

Although Huldah had said that the judgment would come, Josiah does what is right. He obeys God, not to get a reward, but because it is right.

"He made everyone ... stand": that means they stood up solemnly and agreed to enter the covenant.

"As long as Josiah lived": the people stayed faithful to God for that long. After his death, they fell away again.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 35

Josiah's Passover and his death

Getting ready for the Passover VERSES 1–6

1 Josiah kept a Passover to the LORD in Jerusalem.
They killed the Passover lambs on the fourteenth day of the first month.
2 He set the priests in their duties
and encouraged them in the service of the LORD's house.
3 He said to the Levites who taught all Israel,
who were holy to the LORD,
"Put the holy ark in the house that Solomon the son of David king of Israel built.
It will no longer be a burden on your shoulders.
Now serve the LORD your God and his people Israel.
4 Get yourselves ready by your families and by your divisions,
as David king of Israel wrote down,
and as Solomon his son wrote down.
5 Stand in the holy place by the divisions of the families of your brothers, the people,
For each group of families of the people,
let there be a group from a family of the Levites.
6 Kill the Passover lamb, make yourselves holy,
and prepare it for your brothers,
to do as the LORD commanded through Moses."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is told more briefly in 2 Kings 23:21–23. The Passover took place in Josiah's eighteenth year, in the same year in which the book of the law was found (verse 19).

Verse 3 is a puzzle. The ark had belonged in the temple since Solomon. Maybe it had been removed under Manasseh or Amon and was now brought back. Or Josiah means: you no longer have to carry the ark as in the wilderness. So now you have time for another service: to serve the people.

Here the Levites are called teachers, those "who taught all Israel." That was an important task.

The Bible does not tell what later happened to the ark of the covenant. This is the last time it is mentioned in the history books.

Generous gifts VERSES 7–9

7 Josiah gave to the people animals from the flock,
lambs and young goats, all of them for the Passover offerings,
for all who were there, 30,000 in number,
and 3,000 bulls.
These were from the king's own property.
8 His princes gave a freewill offering to the people, to the priests, and to the Levites.
Hilkiah, Zechariah, and Jehiel, the rulers of God's house,
gave to the priests for the Passover offerings 2,600 small livestock and 300 head of cattle.
9 Conaniah also, and Shemaiah and Nethanel his brothers,
and Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad, the chiefs of the Levites,
gave to the Levites for the Passover offerings 5,000 small livestock and 500 head of cattle.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> The king gives from his own property, so that the poor can celebrate the feast too. The princes and the chiefs follow his example.
>
> "Small livestock" are sheep and goats.

The feast is celebrated VERSES 10–19

10 So the service was prepared.
The priests stood in their place,
and the Levites by their divisions, as the king had commanded.
11 They killed the Passover lambs.
The priests sprinkled the blood that they received from their hands,
and the Levites skinned the animals.
12 They set apart the burnt offerings,
to give them to the divisions of the families of the people,
to offer them to the LORD, as it is written in the book of Moses.
They did the same with the cattle.
13 They roasted the Passover lambs with fire, as the rule says.
They boiled the holy offerings in pots, in kettles, and in pans,
and quickly carried them to all the people.
14 After that they prepared food for themselves and for the priests.
For the priests, the sons of Aaron, were busy offering the burnt offerings and the fat until night.
So the Levites prepared food for themselves and for the priests, the sons of Aaron.
15 The singers, the sons of Asaph, were in their place,
as David, Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun the king's seer had commanded.
And the gatekeepers were at every gate.
They didn't need to leave their service,
because their brothers the Levites prepared food for them.
16 So all the service of the LORD was prepared on the same day,
to keep the Passover and to offer burnt offerings on the LORD's altar,
as King Josiah had commanded.
17 The people of Israel who were there kept the Passover at that time,
and the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days.
18 No Passover like it had been kept in Israel since the days of Samuel the prophet.
And none of the kings of Israel had kept such a Passover as Josiah kept,
with the priests, the Levites, and all Judah and Israel who were there,
and the people of Jerusalem.
19 This Passover was kept in the eighteenth year of Josiah's reign.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> Everything is well organized. Everyone has his task. The Levites make sure that everyone gets their food: the people, the priests, the singers and the gatekeepers. No one is forgotten.
>
> The Passover lamb was roasted, as it says in Exodus 12:8–9. The other offerings were boiled.
>
> Verse 18: no such Passover "since the days of Samuel." Hezekiah's Passover (Chapter 30) was great too, but it took place in the second month, and many were not clean. Josiah's Passover was exactly according to the law.

Josiah's death at Megiddo VERSES 20–27

20 After all this, when Josiah had set the temple in order,
Neco king of Egypt went up to fight at Carchemish by the Euphrates.
And Josiah went out against him.
21 But Neco sent messengers to him and said,
"What have I to do with you, king of Judah?
I am not coming against you today,
but against the house with which I am at war.
God has commanded me to hurry.
Be careful! It is God who is with me.
Don't let him destroy you."
22 But Josiah would not turn his face away from him.
He disguised himself so that he could fight with him.
He didn't listen to the words of Neco, which came from the mouth of God.
And he came to fight in the valley of Megiddo.
23 The archers shot at King Josiah.
And the king said to his servants,
"Take me away, for I am badly wounded!"
24 So his servants took him out of the chariot
and put him in the second chariot that he had,
and they brought him to Jerusalem.
He died and was buried in the tombs of his ancestors.
All Judah and Jerusalem mourned for Josiah.
25 Jeremiah sang a song of mourning for Josiah.
And all the singing men and singing women have spoken of Josiah in their songs of mourning to this day.
They made it a custom in Israel.
They are written in the Lamentations.
26 The rest of the acts of Josiah,
and his good deeds, as it is written in the LORD's law,
27 and his acts, from first to last,
are written in the book of the kings of Israel and

Judah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the year 609 BC, Pharaoh Neco II marched north to help the Assyrians against the Babylonians. Josiah wanted to stop him.

The astonishing thing: this time God spoke through a foreign king. Neco warned Josiah. But Josiah did not listen. He probably did not think it possible that God would speak through an Egyptian.

Like Ahab (2 Chronicles 18:29), Josiah disguises himself. And like Ahab, he is struck by archers. Even such a good king can make a deadly mistake if he does not listen.

The mourning for Josiah was huge. He was the last good king of Judah. The prophet Zechariah, much later, still mentions the great mourning "in the valley of Megiddo" (Zechariah 12:11).

The "Lamentations" in verse 25 are not the same as the biblical book of Lamentations, which mourns the destruction of Jerusalem. This collection no longer exists.

The word "Armageddon" (mountain of Megiddo) in Revelation 16:16 comes from the name Megiddo.

2 CHRONICLES

CHAPTER 36

The fall of Jerusalem and a new beginning

Jehoahaz VERSES 1–4

1 Then the people of the land chose Jehoahaz, the son of Josiah.
They made him king in Jerusalem in place of his father.
2 Joahaz was 23 years old when he became king.
He ruled for three months in Jerusalem.
3 Then the king of Egypt removed him from power in Jerusalem.
He made the land pay 100 talents of silver (about 7,500 pounds)
and a talent of gold (about 75 pounds).
4 The king of Egypt made Eliakim, the brother of Joahaz, king over Judah and Jerusalem.
He changed Eliakim's name to Jehoiakim.
Neco took Joahaz, Eliakim's brother, to Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now things go downhill very fast. Chronicles tells about the last four kings of Judah in only a few verses. It is told in more detail in 2 Kings 23:31–25:30.

The Bible says "100 talents of silver and a talent of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds.

Judah is no longer free. Pharaoh removes kings and puts kings in place as he likes. And he gives them new names. This shows: the king is now his servant.

Jehoiakim VERSES 5–8

5 Jehoiakim was 25 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 11 years in Jerusalem.
He did what was evil in the eyes of the LORD his God.
6 Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, attacked him.
He put him in shackles to take him to Babylon.
7 Nebuchadnezzar also took some of the objects from the LORD's house to Babylon.
He put them in his temple in Babylon.
8 There is more to tell about Jehoiakim,
about the disgusting things he did,
and about what was found against him.
It is written in the book of the kings of Israel and Judah.
His son Jehoiachin became king after him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jehoiakim ruled from about 609 to 598 BC. The prophet Jeremiah criticized him sharply. Jehoiakim even burned a scroll with Jeremiah's words (Jeremiah 36).

Nebuchadnezzar II was the most powerful king of his time. He ruled from about 605 to 562 BC. He had defeated the Egyptians at Carchemish (605 BC).

The text does not say exactly whether Jehoiakim was really taken to Babylon. According to 2 Kings 24:6, he died in Jerusalem. Maybe he was only threatened, or he was set free again.

The objects of the temple come back later (Ezra 1:7–11). They also play a role in the book of Daniel (Daniel 5).

Jehoiachin VERSES 9–10

9 Jehoiachin was eight years old when he became king.
He ruled for 3 months and 10 days in Jerusalem.
He did what was evil in the LORD's eyes.
10 When the new year came,
King Nebuchadnezzar sent for him and had him brought to Babylon.
He also took the valuable objects from the LORD's house.
He made Jehoiachin's brother Zedekiah king over Judah and Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

2 Kings 24:8 says "18 years." That fits better, because he already had wives (2 Kings 24:15). Probably the "ten" was lost here in copying.

Jehoiachin was taken to Babylon in 597 BC. Many people were carried away with him, among them the prophet Ezekiel.

Zedekiah was really his uncle, a son of Josiah (2 Kings 24:17). In Hebrew, "brother" can also mean "relative."

In Babylon, clay tablets were found on which food rations for "Jehoiachin, the king of Judah" and his sons are written down.

Zedekiah and the guilt of the people VERSES 11–16

11 Zedekiah was 21 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 11 years in Jerusalem.
12 He did what was evil in the eyes of the LORD his God.
Jeremiah the prophet spoke to him the words that

came from the LORD's mouth.
But Zedekiah did not humble himself before him.
13 He also rebelled against King Nebuchadnezzar.
Nebuchadnezzar had made him swear an oath by God.
Zedekiah was stubborn.
He made his heart hard and would not turn to the
LORD, the God of Israel.
14 All the leaders of the priests and the people were also
very unfaithful.
They copied all the disgusting customs of the nations.
They made the LORD's house unclean,
the house he had made holy in Jerusalem.
15 The LORD, the God of their ancestors, sent his
messengers to them.
He sent them again and again, from early on,
because he had compassion on his people and on the
place where he lived.
16 But they made fun of God's messengers.
They looked down on his words and laughed at his
prophets.
In the end, the LORD's anger rose up against his
people.
And there was no remedy anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zedekiah ruled from about 597 to 586 BC. He was weak and could not make up his mind. Jeremiah warned him again and again, but he did not listen.

He also broke his oath to Nebuchadnezzar, which he had sworn by God (compare Ezekiel 17:13–19).

Verse 15 is one of the most moving verses of the Bible: God sent his messengers "again and again," "because he had compassion on his people." God did not punish quickly. For hundreds of years, he waited and warned.

But the people mocked the prophets. In the end, there was "no remedy." The judgment was not God's first wish, but the result of the people rejecting every help.

Jesus mourns over Jerusalem in a similar way: "How often I wanted to gather your children together ... But you were not willing!" (Matthew 23:37).

The destruction of Jerusalem VERSES 17–21

17 So God brought the king of the Chaldeans against
them.
He killed their young men with the sword, even in
their holy temple.
He had no pity on young men or young women,
on old people or on the weak.
God gave them all into his power.
18 He took everything to Babylon:
all the objects of God's house, large and small,
the treasures of the LORD's house,
and the treasures of the king and of his leaders.
19 They burned down God's house.
They tore down the wall of Jerusalem.
They burned all its palaces
and destroyed everything of value.
20 The king took the people who had survived the sword to
Babylon.
They had to be servants to him and his sons
until the kingdom of Persia came to power.
21 So the LORD's word through Jeremiah came true.
The land was to enjoy its Sabbath years.
As long as it lay empty, it had its Sabbath rest,
until 70 years were complete.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the year 586 BC, the Babylonians ("Chaldeans") conquered Jerusalem. They burned the temple that Solomon had built. That was the greatest disaster in the history of ancient Israel.

Verse 17 describes terrible suffering: young and old, men and women are killed. The Bible does not keep quiet about the suffering. The book of Lamentations and Psalm 137 show how deep the pain was.

Verse 21 explains the time of the exile in a special way: according to the law, the land was to have a year of rest every seven years, a "Sabbath year" (Leviticus 25:1–7). The people had not kept this. Now the land gets its rest back (compare Leviticus 26:34–35).

Jeremiah had announced 70 years (Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10). The number 70 is a round number for a long time, about one human life.

The decree of Cyrus: a new beginning VERSES 22–23

22 In the first year of Cyrus king of Persia,
so that the LORD's word through Jeremiah's mouth
would come true,
the LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia,
so that he made an announcement throughout all his
kingdom,
and also put it in writing:
23 "Cyrus king of Persia says,
'The LORD, the God of heaven, has given me all the
kingdoms of the earth.
And he has commanded me to build him a house in
Jerusalem, which is in Judah.
Whoever there is among you of all his people,
may the LORD his God be with him.
Let him go up.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the year 539 BC, the Persian king Cyrus conquered Babylon. One year later, he allowed the peoples who had been carried away to return to their homelands and to build their temples again. On the so-called "Cyrus Cylinder," a clay cylinder in the British Museum, Cyrus himself reports about this policy.

The book does not end with the destruction, but with a new beginning. The last words are: "Let him go up." In Hebrew, this is one single word: "veya'al."

In the Hebrew Bible, Chronicles is the last book. So the whole Hebrew Bible ends with this sentence: an invitation to return home and to make a new start with God.

The same words are at the beginning of the book of Ezra (Ezra 1:1–3). The story continues there.

Looking back: What have we read in 2 Chronicles?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Solomon and the temple (Chapters 1–9): Solomon asks God for wisdom and builds the temple. At the dedication, God's glory comes into the house in a cloud. God promises: "If my people will humble themselves, pray, and seek my face ... then I will hear from heaven. I will forgive their sin" (2 Chronicles 7:14). This verse is the key to the whole book.

The divided kingdom (Chapter 10): Because Rehoboam does not listen to the people, the kingdom breaks apart into north and south. From then on Chronicles tells about the kings of Judah in Jerusalem.

Good and bad kings (Chapters 11–36): Again and again the same pattern: whoever seeks God succeeds. Whoever abandons God, God also abandons. But whoever humbles himself finds grace.

– **Good kings** like Asa, Jehoshaphat, Hezekiah and Josiah seek God, pray in their need and renew worship. But they too make mistakes.

– **Bad kings** like Ahaz and Manasseh serve foreign gods. But even Manasseh, the worst of all, may turn back, and God forgives him.

The prophets: God sends messengers again and again: Shemaiah, Azariah, Hanani, Micaiah, Jahaziel, Elijah, Zechariah, Oded, Isaiah, Huldah, Jeremiah and many others. God warns before he punishes, because he "had compassion on his people" (2 Chronicles 36:15).

Prayer and praise: The kings pray in great need, and God helps. Under Jehoshaphat the singers go in front of the army and praise God, and God saves. "The battle is not yours, but God's" (2 Chronicles 20:15).

The end and the new beginning: Because the people mock the prophets, Jerusalem is destroyed. But the book ends with hope: the Persian king Cyrus allows the return and the building of a new temple. The last words are: "Let him go up."

The lesson of the book: God looks at the heart. It does not matter how strong an army is or how rich a king, but whether you seek God "with all your heart." And it is never too late to turn back.

What comes next? The book of Ezra tells how the exiles return to Jerusalem and build the temple again.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 15 OF 66

EZRA

10 CHAPTERS

EZRA

Chapter 1

Cyrus allows the return home

Before we begin: What is the book of Ezra?

The book of Ezra tells how the Jews return to their homeland after the exile in Babylon.

In the year 586 BC the Babylonians had destroyed Jerusalem and the temple. Many people were carried away to Babylon. About 50 years later the Persian king Cyrus conquered Babylon. He allowed the Jews to return home and to build their temple again.

The book has two parts:

– Chapters 1–6: The first group returns, led by Zerubbabel and the priest Jeshua. They build the temple again, in spite of much opposition. In the year 515 BC the new temple is dedicated.

– Chapters 7–10: About 60 years later Ezra comes to Jerusalem. He is a priest and a scribe, a teacher of the law. He teaches the people God's law and calls them to renewal.

The book shows: God keeps his promises. He has not forgotten his people. He can even use foreign kings to help his people.

Part of the book (Ezra 4:8 to 6:18 and 7:12–26) is not written in Hebrew, but in Aramaic. That was the official language of the Persian Empire at that time. That is why the letters and decrees of the kings are copied word for word there.

The book of Ezra and the book of Nehemiah originally belonged together.

The decree of Cyrus VERSES 1–4

1 In the first year of Cyrus king of Persia,
so that the LORD's word through Jeremiah's mouth would come true,
the LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia,
so that he made an announcement throughout all his kingdom,
and also put it in writing:
2 "Cyrus king of Persia says,
'The LORD, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth.
And he has commanded me to build him a house in Jerusalem, which is in Judah.
3 Whoever there is among you of all his people,
may his God be with him.
Let him go up to Jerusalem, which is in Judah,
and build the house of the LORD, the God of Israel, in Jerusalem.
He is God.
4 Whoever is left, in any place where he lives,
let the men of his place help him
with silver, with gold, with goods, and with animals,
in addition to the freewill offering for God's house which is in Jerusalem.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book begins with exactly the words with which Chronicles ends (2 Chronicles 36:22–23). The story continues without a break.

The "first year of Cyrus" is the first year of his rule over Babylon, that is 538 BC.

Jeremiah had announced that the exile would end after about 70 years (Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10). And the prophet Isaiah had even called Cyrus by name (Isaiah 44:28; 45:1).

"The LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus": God also works through a king who does not know him.

Cyrus himself worshiped many gods. On the "Cyrus Cylinder" he thanks the Babylonian god Marduk. In his decree he probably used, for each people, the name of that people's god.

"Whoever is left": this probably means the Jews who stay in Babylon. They and their neighbors are to support those who return home.

Those who return set out VERSES 5–6

5 Then the heads of the families of Judah and Benjamin,
the priests and the Levites,
all whose spirit God had stirred to go up,
rose up to build the LORD's house which is in Jerusalem.
6 All the people around them helped them
with objects of silver, with gold, with goods, with animals, and with precious things,
in addition to all that was given willingly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God stirred up the spirit of Cyrus. And now he also stirs up the spirit of the people who return. Not all Jews return. Many had built a new life in Babylon. It took courage to return to a destroyed land.

The neighbors give them gifts to take along. This recalls the exodus from Egypt, when the Egyptians gave the Israelites silver and gold (Exodus 12:35–36). The return home is like a second exodus.

The temple objects return VERSES 7–11

7 Also Cyrus the king brought out the objects of the LORD's house,
which Nebuchadnezzar had brought out of Jerusalem and had put in the house of his gods.
8 Cyrus king of Persia brought them out through Mithredath the treasurer
and counted them out to Sheshbazzar, the prince of Judah.
9 This is their number:
30 platters of gold, 1,000 platters of silver, 29 knives,
10 30 bowls of gold, 410 silver bowls of a second kind,
and 1,000 other objects.
11 All the objects of gold and of silver were 5,400.
Sheshbazzar brought all these up

when the captives were brought up from Babylon to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The holy objects that Nebuchadnezzar had taken away come back (2 Chronicles 36:7, 18). This is a sign: worship can begin again.

It is not quite clear who Sheshbazzar was. He was the first governor of Judah (Ezra 5:14). Some think he was the same person as Zerubbabel, others think he was an uncle of Zerubbabel.

The numbers in verses 9–10 add up to only 2,499, not 5,400. Maybe only the most important objects were counted one by one. Or numbers were changed in copying. A similar report in another ancient book (1 Esdras 2:13–14) has different numbers.

The careful counting shows: every piece was valuable and was handed over with care.

EZRA

CHAPTER 2

The list of those who returned

The leaders VERSES 1–2

1 These are the people of the province
who came back from captivity.
Nebuchadnezzar the king of Babylon had carried them away to Babylon.
Now they returned to Jerusalem and Judah, each to his own city.
2 They came with Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Nehemiah,
Seraiah, Reelaiah, Mordecai,
Bilshan, Mispar, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah.
The number of the men of the people of Israel:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This long list appears again almost the same in Nehemiah 7. It shows: every single person was important. God knows the names.

"The province" is Judah, now a small province in the great Persian Empire.

Zerubbabel was a grandson of King Jehoiachin, so a descendant of David (1 Chronicles 3:17–19). Jeshua was the high priest. Both lead the return.

The Nehemiah and the Mordecai in this list are probably not the same as the famous men from the books of Nehemiah and Esther. These names were common.

The list names 11 leaders. In Nehemiah 7:7 there are 12, like the 12 tribes of Israel.

The families of the people VERSES 3–20

3 The descendants of Parosh: 2,172.
4 The descendants of Shephatiah: 372.
5 The descendants of Arah: 775.
6 The descendants of Pahathmoab, of the descendants of Jeshua and Joab: 2,812.
7 The descendants of Elam: 1,254.
8 The descendants of Zattu: 945.
9 The descendants of Zaccai: 760.
10 The descendants of Bani: 642.
11 The descendants of Bebai: 623.
12 The descendants of Azgad: 1,222.
13 The descendants of Adonikam: 666.
14 The descendants of Bigvai: 2,056.
15 The descendants of Adin: 454.
16 The descendants of Ater, of Hezekiah: 98.
17 The descendants of Bezai: 323.
18 The descendants of Jorah: 112.
19 The descendants of Hashum: 223.
20 The descendants of Gibbar: 95.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These families are named after their ancestors. "Pahathmoab" means "governor of Moab." Maybe an ancestor once held this office.

The number 666 in verse 13 has no special meaning here. It is simply the number of people in this family.

The people from the towns VERSES 21–35

21 The people of Bethlehem: 123.
22 The men of Netophah: 56.
23 The men of Anathoth: 128.
24 The people of Azmaveth: 42.
25 The people of Kiriath Arim, Chephirah, and Beeroth: 743.
26 The people of Ramah and Geba: 621.
27 The men of Michmas: 122.
28 The men of Bethel and Ai: 223.
29 The people of Nebo: 52.
30 The people of Magbish: 156.
31 The descendants of the other Elam: 1,254.
32 The descendants of Harim: 320.
33 The people of Lod, Hadid, and Ono: 725.
34 The people of Jericho: 345.
35 The descendants of Senaah: 3,630.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the people are listed by their home towns. They return to the towns their families came from.

Bethlehem is the town of David. Anathoth is the home town of the prophet Jeremiah. Before the destruction he had bought a field there, as a sign of hope that people would come back again (Jeremiah 32). Now 128 men from Anathoth return.

Kiriath Arim is probably Kiriath Jearim, where the ark of the covenant stayed for 20 years.

Elam, Harim and maybe also Senaah are probably family names here, not places.

The priests VERSES 36–39

36 The priests:
the descendants of Jedaiah, of the house of Jeshua: 973.

37 The descendants of Immer: 1,052.
38 The descendants of Pashhur: 1,247.
39 The descendants of Harim: 1,017.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

More than 4,000 priests return. That is about one tenth of all who return. Worship was very important to those who returned.

The Levites, singers and gatekeepers VERSES 40–42

40 The Levites:
the descendants of Jeshua and Kadmiel, of the descendants of Hodaviah: 74.
41 The singers:
the descendants of Asaph: 128.
42 The descendants of the gatekeepers:
the descendants of Shallum, the descendants of Ater,
the descendants of Talmon,
the descendants of Akkub, the descendants of Hatita,
the descendants of Shobai,
in all 139.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only a few Levites return, far fewer than priests. Maybe in Babylon they had little reason to hope that they would find a good task in Jerusalem. Later Ezra had to search especially for Levites (Ezra 8:15–20).

The temple servants VERSES 43–54

43 The temple servants:
the descendants of Ziha, the descendants of Hasupha,
the descendants of Tabbaoth,
44 the descendants of Keros, the descendants of Siaha, the descendants of Padon,
45 the descendants of Lebanah, the descendants of Hagabah, the descendants of Akkub,
46 the descendants of Hagab, the descendants of Shamlai,
the descendants of Hanan,
47 the descendants of Giddel, the descendants of Gahar,
the descendants of Reaiah,
48 the descendants of Rezin, the descendants of Nekoda,
the descendants of Gazzam,
49 the descendants of Uzza, the descendants of Paseah, the descendants of Besai,
50 the descendants of Asnah, the descendants of Meunim,
the descendants of Nephisim,
51 the descendants of Bakbuk, the descendants of Hakupha, the descendants of Harhur,
52 the descendants of Bazluth, the descendants of Mehida,
the descendants of Harsha,
53 the descendants of Barkos, the descendants of Sisera,
the descendants of Temah,
54 the descendants of Neziah, the descendants of Hatipha.

The descendants of Solomon's servants VERSES 55–58

55 The descendants of Solomon's servants:
the descendants of Sotai, the descendants of Hassophereth, the descendants of Peruda,
56 the descendants of Jaalah, the descendants of Darkon,
the descendants of Giddel,
57 the descendants of Shephatiah, the descendants of Hattil,
the descendants of Pochereth Hazzebaim, the descendants of Ami.
58 All the temple servants and the descendants of Solomon's servants were 392.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "temple servants" helped with simple work in the temple, for example fetching wood and carrying water. Some of their names do not sound Hebrew. Maybe their ancestors came from other peoples, for example from Gibeon (Joshua 9:27).

The "servants of Solomon" too were probably descendants of workers from foreign peoples (1 Kings 9:20–21).

They too now firmly belong to God's people and return with the others. Every name is mentioned. No one is too small.

The name Sisera in verse 53 is the same as that of the army commander in Judges 4. But here a family of temple servants is meant.

Those without proof VERSES 59–63

59 These were the ones who went up from Tel Melah, Tel Harsha, Cherub, Addan, and Immer.
But they could not prove from their family records that they were from Israel:
60 the descendants of Delaiah, the descendants of Tobiah,
the descendants of Nekoda: 652.
61 Of the descendants of the priests:
the descendants of Habaiah, the descendants of Hakkoz,
and the descendants of Barzillai.
He had married one of the daughters of Barzillai the Gileadite
and was called by their name.
62 These looked for their names among those who were listed in the family records,
but they were not found.
So they were not allowed to serve and were removed from the priesthood.
63 The governor told them that they should not eat of the most holy things
until a priest stood up to serve with Urim and with Thummim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Some could not prove that they belonged to Israel. Their papers had been lost in the exile. Even so they returned with the others. They were not sent away.

With the priests it was stricter: only someone who descended from Aaron was allowed to be a priest. Whoever could not prove this was not allowed to serve for the time being.

Barzillai the Gileadite was a friend of David who had helped him in a hard time (2 Samuel 19:31–39). A priest had married his daughter and taken her family name.

"Urim and Thummim" were lots with which the high priest used to ask for God's will (Exodus 28:30). They had probably been lost. The decision was postponed until God himself would give clarity. That is a wise and fair solution.

The "governor" is probably Zerubbabel or Sheshbazzar. Here a Persian word is used: "Tirshatha."

The total number and the gifts VERSES 64–70

64 The whole assembly together was 42,360,
65 besides their male servants and their female servants,
of whom there were 7,337.
And they had 200 singing men and singing women.
66 Their horses were 736, their mules 245,
67 their camels 435, their donkeys 6,720.
68 Some of the heads of the families,
when they came to the LORD's house which is in Jerusalem,
gave willingly for God's house, to set it up in its place.
69 They gave according to their ability into the treasury for the work:
61,000 darics of gold (more than 1,100 pounds),
5,000 minas of silver (about 6,250 pounds),
and 100 priests' garments.
70 So the priests and the Levites, with some of the people, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants,
lived in their cities,
and all Israel lived in their cities.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

If you add up the single numbers of the list, you get only about 29,800. The total number is 42,360. Maybe the total number also counted women or other groups that do not appear one by one in the list. No one knows exactly.

So in all almost 50,000 people return. That is only a small part of the people. Most stayed in Babylon.

"Darics" were Persian gold coins of about 0.3 ounces. 61,000 darics are more than 1,100 pounds of gold. Silver: the Bible says "5,000 minas." A mina is about 1¼ pounds.

The people gave "according to their ability": each one as much as he could (compare 2 Corinthians 8:12).

The numbers here are a little different from Nehemiah 7:70–72. When such lists were copied, small differences often happened.

EZRA

CHAPTER 3

The altar and the foundation of the temple

The altar is built VERSES 1–6

1 The seventh month came.
The people of Israel were living in their towns.
Then all the people gathered in Jerusalem.
They were united, as if they were one person.
2 Jeshua, the son of Jozadak, and his relatives, the priests, got to work.
Zerubbabel, the son of Shealtiel, and his relatives got to work too.
They built the altar of the God of Israel.
They wanted to offer burnt offerings on it,
as it is written in the Law of Moses, the man of God.
3 They were afraid of the peoples of the lands around them.
But they still set up the altar on its base.
They offered burnt offerings on it to the LORD,
every morning and every evening.
4 They celebrated the Feast of Booths, as it is written.
Every day they offered the right number of burnt offerings,
as the rules say for each day.
5 After that, they offered the regular burnt offerings.
They offered the offerings for the new moons
and for all the holy feasts of the LORD.
They also offered the gifts of everyone who wanted to give the LORD a freewill offering.
A freewill offering is a gift that a person gives because they want to.
6 On the first day of the seventh month,
they began to offer burnt offerings to the LORD.
But the foundation of the LORD's temple had not yet been laid.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The seventh month (September/October) is the month of the great feasts: New Year, the Day of Atonement and the Feast of Booths.

The first thing those who returned build is not a house for themselves, but an altar for God. Before the temple stands, worship already begins.

They are afraid of the neighboring peoples. But they build anyway. The altar and the offerings are a sign for them: God is with us.

Jeshua (also called Joshua) was the high priest, a grandson of the last high priest before the destruction (1 Chronicles 6:14–15).

The Feast of Booths recalls the journey through the wilderness. For those who returned, who had a long journey behind them themselves, this was especially meaningful.

The preparations VERSE 7

7 They gave money to the stonemasons and the carpenters.
They gave food, drink, and olive oil to the people of Sidon and Tyre.
In return, these people were to bring cedar logs from Lebanon by sea to Joppa.
Cyrus, king of Persia, had given them permission for this.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As with the building of the first temple under Solomon, the wood again comes from Lebanon, over the sea to Joppa (2 Chronicles 2:16). The new temple is to continue the old one.

Joppa is today's Jaffa, a part of Tel Aviv.

The foundation is laid VERSES 8–11

8 They had come to God's house in Jerusalem.
In the second month of the second year after that, they began the work.
Zerubbabel, the son of Shealtiel, and Jeshua, the son of Jozadak, began it.
So did the rest of their relatives, the priests and the

Levites.
And so did everyone who had come back to Jerusalem from captivity.
They chose Levites who were 20 years old or older to supervise the work on the LORD's house.
9 Jeshua, his sons, and his relatives,
and Kadmiel and his sons, the sons of Judah,
worked together to supervise the workers in God's house.
The sons of Henadad, with their sons and their relatives, the Levites, helped them.
10 The builders laid the foundation of the LORD's temple.
Then the priests stood there in their robes with trumpets.
The Levites, the sons of Asaph, stood there with cymbals.
They praised the LORD,
as David, king of Israel, had told them to do.
11 They sang to one another.
They praised the LORD and thanked him:
"For he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever toward Israel."
All the people gave a great shout as they praised the LORD,
because the foundation of the LORD's house had been laid.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The second month is the same month in which Solomon began to build the first temple (1 Kings 6:1). Again, there is a link to the old temple.

"The sons of Judah" in verse 9: this probably means "Hodaviah," the Levite family from Ezra 2:40. The two names look alike in Hebrew.

When the foundation is laid, they celebrate. They sing almost the same words as at the dedication of the first temple: "For he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever" (2 Chronicles 5:13; 7:3; Psalm 136).

"To one another": two choirs sing to each other, as was usual with many psalms.

Shouts of joy and weeping VERSES 12–13

12 Many of the priests, Levites, and family leaders were old.
They had seen the first house.
Now they saw the foundation of this house being laid.
Then they wept out loud.
But many others shouted for joy.
13 The people could not tell the shouts of joy
from the sound of weeping.
The people shouted very loudly.
The noise could be heard far away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A moving moment: the young shout for joy, because at last the temple is being built. The old weep, because they still remember the splendid temple of Solomon, which had been destroyed 50 years before.

Maybe they wept because the new temple was much smaller and poorer (compare Haggai 2:3). Maybe they also wept for joy and emotion that they were still allowed to see this.

Joy and sorrow lie close together and sometimes sound the same. Both have their place before God. A new beginning is often both: joy about the new and sorrow about what has been lost.

EZRA

CHAPTER 4

Opposition to the building

"Let us build with you" VERSES 1–5

1 The enemies of Judah and Benjamin heard news.
The people who had come back from captivity were building a temple for the LORD, the God of Israel.
2 So the enemies came to Zerubbabel and to the family leaders.
They said to them,
"Let us build with you.
We worship your God just as you do.
We have been offering sacrifices to him since the time of Esar Haddon, king of Assyria.
He is the one who brought us here."
3 But Zerubbabel, Jeshua, and the other family leaders of Israel answered,
"You have no part with us in building a house for our God.
We alone will build it for the LORD, the God of Israel.
That is what King Cyrus, the king of Persia, commanded us."
4 Then the people of the land tried to discourage the people of Judah.
They made them afraid to build.
5 They paid advisers to work against them and to block their plans.
They did this the whole time Cyrus was king of Persia, and on until Darius became king of Persia.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "enemies" were people who lived in the area of the former northern kingdom. After 722 BC the Assyrians had settled foreign peoples there. These peoples worshiped the LORD, but also their own gods (2 Kings 17:24–41). Later, their descendants were called "Samaritans."

Esar Haddon was king of Assyria from 681 to 669 BC.

Why did Zerubbabel and Jeshua turn down the help? They were afraid that faith in the one God would be mixed with foreign gods. That is exactly what had led to the exile. You can think about whether turning them down was right in every case. Later, in the New Testament, Jesus shows that God loves the Samaritans too (John 4; Luke 10:30–37).

The result: those who were turned down became opponents. They discouraged the builders and made sure that the building stood still for about 16 years (from about 536 to 520 BC).

Later accusations VERSES 6–7

6 Later, Ahasuerus became king.
At the beginning of his rule,
they wrote an accusation against the people of Judah
and Jerusalem.

7 Later still, when Artaxerxes was king,
Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, and the rest of their group
wrote a letter to Artaxerxes, king of Persia.
The letter was written in Syrian script
and in the Syrian language.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the book jumps forward in time. It shows: the opposition went on later too, under the next kings.

Ahasuerus is Xerxes I (486–465 BC). He is also the king from the book of Esther. Artaxerxes is Artaxerxes I (465–424 BC).

These later letters are no longer about the temple, but about building the city wall (verse 12).

"Syrian" here means Aramaic. That was the official language of the Persian Empire. From verse 8 on, the book of Ezra itself is also written in Aramaic, up to Ezra 6:18.

The letter to King Artaxerxes VERSES 8–16

8 Rehum the governor and Shimshai the secretary
wrote a letter against Jerusalem to King Artaxerxes.
It went like this.

9 The letter was from Rehum the governor, Shimshai the secretary,
and the rest of their group:
the Dinaites, the Apharsathchites, the Tarpelites, the Apharsites,
the Archevites, the Babylonians, the Shushanchites,
the Dehaites, the Elamites,

10 and the other nations.
The great and noble Osnappar had brought these nations here.
He had settled them in the city of Samaria
and in the rest of the land beyond the River.
And so on.

11 This is a copy of the letter they sent:
"To King Artaxerxes, from your servants, the people beyond the River.

12 We want the king to know this:
The Jews who came up from you have come to us in Jerusalem.
They are rebuilding that rebellious and evil city.
They have finished the walls and repaired the foundations.

13 The king should also know this:
If this city is rebuilt and its walls are finished,
they will not pay any more taxes, duties, or tolls.
In the end, this will harm the kings.

14 We are loyal to the palace.
It is not right for us to watch the king be dishonored.
So we are sending this message to the king.

15 Please have someone search the records of your ancestors.
In these records you will find
that this city has always rebelled.
It has caused trouble for kings and provinces.
People have started rebellions there in the past.
That is why this city was destroyed.

16 We tell the king:
If this city is rebuilt and its walls are finished,
you will have nothing left beyond the River."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The opponents list many peoples to seem important. Many of these names are uncertain. Some are probably titles of officials, not peoples. Some names point to Erech (Uruk), Babylon, Susa and Elam, cities and regions in the east.

Osnappar is probably the Assyrian king Ashurbanipal (668–627 BC).

"Beyond the River": this means the Euphrates. From the Persian king's point of view, the area west of the Euphrates was "beyond." That was the province Judah belonged to.

"We are loyal to the palace": the English source text says "we eat the salt of the palace." That means: we are in the king's service and are paid by him.

The letter works with fear: if Jerusalem becomes strong, the king loses taxes and power. That is exaggerated. But it works.

The king's answer VERSES 17–24

17 Then the king sent this answer
to Rehum the governor, to Shimshai the secretary,
and to the rest of their group who lived in Samaria
and in the rest of the land beyond the River:
"Peace to you.

18 The letter you sent us has been read to me clearly.

19 I gave an order, and a search was made.
It was found that this city has risen up against kings in the past.
There have been rebellions and revolts there.

20 Powerful kings have also ruled over Jerusalem.
They ruled the whole land beyond the River.
People paid them taxes, duties, and tolls.

21 So now give an order to make these men stop.
This city must not be rebuilt until a decree is made by me.

22 Be careful, and do this quickly.
Why should the damage grow and harm the kings?"

23 A copy of King Artaxerxes' letter was read to Rehum, Shimshai the secretary,
and their group.
Then they hurried to the Jews in Jerusalem.
They made them stop with armed force.

24 So the work on God's house in Jerusalem stopped.
It stayed stopped until the second year that Darius was king of Persia.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king has a search made and finds: Jerusalem really did rise up against Babylon in the past. He also remembers the great kings David and Solomon.

Important in verse 21: "until a decree is made by me." The king leaves a door open. Later the same king allows Nehemiah to build the wall (Nehemiah 2).

Verse 24 returns to the time of the temple building. It continues verse 5: the building of the temple rested until the second year of Darius, that is 520 BC. Verses 6–23 were an insertion that shows how stubborn the opposition was over many decades.

EZRA

CHAPTER 5

The building goes on

The prophets Haggai and Zechariah VERSES 1–2

1 The prophets Haggai and Zechariah, the son of Iddo,
spoke God's message to the Jews in Judah and Jerusalem.
They spoke to them in the name of the God of Israel.
2 Then Zerubbabel, the son of Shealtiel, and Jeshua, the son of Jozadak, got to work.
They began to build God's house in Jerusalem again.
The prophets of God were with them and helped them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For 16 years, the people had not worked on the temple any more. They had settled down and built their own houses. Then God sends two prophets. Their words are in the books of Haggai and Zechariah.

Haggai says: "Is it time for you yourselves to live in your houses with fine wooden walls, while this house lies in ruins?" (Haggai 1:4). And Zechariah says: "Not by might, and not by power, but by my Spirit… says the LORD of Armies" (Zechariah 4:6).

The prophets do not only preach, they also help. God's word and practical help belong together.

The Aramaic says word for word: "in the name of the God of Israel, who was over them." Many understand it like this: God watched over them.

Tattenai asks questions VERSES 3–5

3 At that time, Tattenai came to them.
He was the governor of the land beyond the River.
Shetharbozenai and their officials came with him.
They asked the Jews,
"Who gave you permission to build this house and to finish this wall?"
4 They also asked for the names of the men who were putting up this building.
5 But God was watching over the elders of the Jews.
So the officials did not make them stop.
First the matter had to go to Darius,
and his answer had to come back in a letter.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tattenai was the Persian governor of the whole province west of the Euphrates. His name is also found in a Persian document from this time.

Unlike the opponents in Chapter 4, Tattenai acts fairly: he asks questions, writes to the king, and lets the Jews go on building in the meantime.

"God was watching over the elders": the English source text says, "the eye of their God was on the elders." That is why they were allowed to go on building.

The letter to Darius VERSES 6–17

6 Tattenai, the governor of the land beyond the River,
Shetharbozenai, and his officials, the Apharsachites beyond the River,
sent a letter to King Darius.
Here is a copy of it.
7 This is what they wrote to him:
"To King Darius: We wish you peace in every way.
8 We want the king to know this:
We went to the province of Judah,
to the house of the great God.
It is being built with large stones.
Wooden beams are being set into the walls.
The work is being done with great care.
It is going well for them.
9 We asked the elders there,
'Who gave you permission to build this house and to finish this wall?'
10 We also asked for their names.
We wanted to write down the names of their leaders for you.
11 This is the answer they gave us:
'We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth.
We are rebuilding the house that was built many years ago.
A great king of Israel built it and finished it.
12 But our ancestors made the God of heaven angry.
So he handed them over to Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, the Chaldean.
He destroyed this house
and took the people away to Babylon.
13 But in his first year as king of Babylon,
King Cyrus gave an order to rebuild this house of God.
14 Nebuchadnezzar had taken the gold and silver objects of God's house
out of the temple in Jerusalem.
He had brought them into the temple in Babylon.
King Cyrus took them out of the temple in Babylon again.
He gave them to a man named Sheshbazzar,
whom he had made governor.
15 Cyrus said to him,
"Take these objects.
Go and put them in the temple in Jerusalem.
Let God's house be rebuilt in its old place."
16 So this Sheshbazzar came
and laid the foundations of God's house in Jerusalem.
Since then, people have been building it until now.
But it is still not finished.'
17 Now, if the king agrees,
please have a search made in the royal archives in Babylon.
Find out whether King Cyrus really gave an order to rebuild this house of God in Jerusalem.
Then please let us know what the king decides about this."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The letter is factual and fair. It reports exactly what the Jews said.

The answer of the elders is brave and honest:
– They say openly who they are: servants of the God of heaven and earth.
– They admit that their ancestors were to blame for the destruction.
– They refer to the order of Cyrus.

Cyrus is called "king of Babylon" here, because he had conquered Babylon and also had this title.
A great king of Israel: this means Solomon.
"Apharsachites": probably a Persian title for officials, something like "officers" or "messengers."

EZRA

Chapter 6

The new temple is dedicated

The decree of Cyrus is found VERSES 1–5

1 Then King Darius gave an order.
People searched the archives in Babylon,
where the treasures were kept.
2 A scroll was found in Achmetha,
in the palace in the province of Media.
This was written in it as a record:
3 "In his first year as king, King Cyrus gave an order
about God's house in Jerusalem:
The house must be rebuilt.
It is the place where they offer sacrifices.
Its foundations must be laid firmly.
It must be about 90 feet high and about 90 feet wide.
4 It must have three layers of large stones and one layer
of new wood.
The costs must be paid from the king's treasury.
5 Nebuchadnezzar took the gold and silver objects of
God's house
out of the temple in Jerusalem and brought them to
Babylon.
They must be given back.
They must be brought back to the temple in
Jerusalem,
each one to its place.
You must put them in God's house."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First they search in Babylon and find nothing. Then they find the document in Achmetha. That is Ecbatana, the summer capital of the Persian kings, today Hamadan in Iran. Cyrus had lived there in the summer.

The Bible says "60 cubits." A cubit is about 18 inches. That is bigger than Solomon's temple (2 Chronicles 3:3–4). These are probably the largest measurements the king allowed. In fact, the new temple was probably smaller and more modest (compare Ezra 3:12 and Haggai 2:3).

The decree is copied here in its official form, in Aramaic. It adds to the text in Chapter 1.

Darius commands: Let them build! VERSES 6–12

6 Darius wrote:
"So now, Tattenai, governor of the land beyond the
River,
Shetharbozenai, and your officials, the Apharsachites
beyond the River:
Stay away from there!
7 Do not get in the way of the work on this house of God.
Let the governor of the Jews and the elders of the Jews
rebuild this house of God in its old place.
8 I also give this order about what you must do for these
elders of the Jews,
so that they can build this house of God:
Pay all their costs from the king's money,
from the taxes of the land beyond the River.
Pay them in full and without delay,
so that the work does not have to stop.
9 Give them whatever they need,
every day, without fail.
Give them young bulls, rams, and lambs
for burnt offerings to the God of heaven.
Give them wheat, salt, wine, and olive oil,
as the priests in Jerusalem ask.
10 Then they can offer sacrifices that please the God of
heaven.
And they can pray for the life of the king and his sons.
11 I also give this order:
If anyone changes this order,
a beam must be pulled out of his house.
He must be lifted up and fastened to it.
And his house must be turned into a garbage dump
because of this.
12 God has made his name live in that place.
May he destroy every king and every people
who tries to change this order
or to destroy this house of God in Jerusalem.
I, Darius, have given this order.
It must be carried out carefully."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Darius I reigned from 522 to 486 BC.

The opponents wanted to stop the building. The result is the opposite: the king orders that the building goes on, and he even pays for it out of the taxes of the province! Now the opponents have to pay for the building themselves.

Darius asks that people pray for him and his sons. Later too, Jews prayed for those who ruled (compare Jeremiah 29:7; 1 Timothy 2:1–2).

Verse 11 describes a cruel punishment that was common in the Persian Empire: the guilty person was impaled on a stake. That is how kings threatened people at that time. Here the Bible reports the wording of the royal order. It does not itself call for such violence.

The temple is finished VERSES 13–15

13 King Darius had sent this order.
So Tattenai, the governor of the land beyond the
River,
Shetharbozenai, and their officials carefully did what
it said.

14 The elders of the Jews kept on building, and the work went well.
The prophet Haggai and Zechariah, the son of Iddo, encouraged them with their prophecies.
They finished the building,
as the God of Israel had commanded,
and as Cyrus, Darius, and Artaxerxes, kings of Persia, had ordered.
15 The house was finished on the third day of the month of Adar.
That was in the sixth year that Darius was king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple was finished in the spring of 515 BC, about 70 years after the destruction of the first temple. The month Adar is February/March.

Verse 14 names two reasons for the success: God's command and the orders of the kings. God works through both.

Artaxerxes reigned only later. He is named here because he later supported the temple with gifts (Ezra 7:15–24).

This "second temple" stood for almost 600 years. Later Herod the Great made it much larger and more splendid. That was the temple in which Jesus taught. In AD 70 it was destroyed by the Romans.

The dedication VERSES 16–18

16 Then the people of Israel celebrated the dedication of this house of God with joy.
The priests, the Levites, and the rest of the people who had come back from captivity celebrated with them.
17 For the dedication of this house of God, they offered 100 bulls, 200 rams, and 400 lambs.
As a sin offering for all Israel, they offered 12 male goats,
one for each tribe of Israel.
18 They put the priests into their groups
and the Levites into their teams.
They were to serve God in Jerusalem,
as it is written in the book of Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Compared with the dedication of Solomon's temple (22,000 cattle and 120,000 sheep, 2 Chronicles 7:5), these are few offerings. Those who returned were poor. But the joy is just as great.

The 12 male goats are "for all Israel": although mainly Judah and Benjamin had returned, they think of all 12 tribes. The whole people of God is to belong.

The Aramaic part ends with verse 18. From verse 19 on, the text is in Hebrew again.

The Passover VERSES 19–22

19 The people who had come back from captivity celebrated the Passover
on the fourteenth day of the first month.
20 The priests and the Levites had all made themselves clean together.
All of them were clean.
They killed the Passover lambs for all the people who had come back from captivity,
for their relatives, the priests, and for themselves.
21 The people of Israel who had come back from captivity ate the Passover.
Others ate with them too:
all who had turned away from the unclean ways of the nations in the land
and had joined them to seek the LORD, the God of Israel.
22 With joy, they celebrated the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days.
The LORD had filled them with joy.
He had turned the heart of the king of Assyria toward them.
So the king helped them with the work on the house of God, the God of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One month after the dedication they celebrate the Passover, the feast of freedom from Egypt. Now they celebrate it as people who have been set free a second time, this time from Babylon.

Verse 21 is important: people who had not been in exile were also allowed to celebrate with them, if they turned away from the idols and sought the LORD. The door is open for all who seek God.

"King of Assyria": this means the Persian king Darius. He now ruled over the area of old Assyria. Maybe the title is chosen on purpose: the Assyrians had once scattered the people, now a king on their throne helps with the rebuilding.

EZRA

CHAPTER 7

Ezra comes to Jerusalem

Who was Ezra? VERSES 1–10

1 Some time later, Artaxerxes was king of Persia.
At that time there was a man named Ezra.
Ezra was the son of Seraiah, the son of Azariah, the son of Hilkiah,
2 the son of Shallum, the son of Zadok, the son of Ahitub,
3 the son of Amariah, the son of Azariah, the son of Meraioth,
4 the son of Zerahiah, the son of Uzzi, the son of Bukki,
5 the son of Abishua, the son of Phinehas, the son of Eleazar,
the son of Aaron the chief priest.
6 This Ezra came up from Babylon.
He was a scribe, an expert in the Law of Moses.
The LORD, the God of Israel, had given this law.
The king gave Ezra everything he asked for,
because the hand of the LORD his God was on him.
7 Some of the people of Israel went up to Jerusalem with him.
Among them were priests, Levites, singers,

gatekeepers, and temple servants.
This was in the seventh year that Artaxerxes was king.
8 Ezra came to Jerusalem in the fifth month
of the king's seventh year.
9 He had left Babylon on the first day of the first month.
He arrived in Jerusalem on the first day of the fifth month,
because the good hand of his God was on him.
10 Ezra had made up his mind to study the LORD's law,
to obey it,
and to teach its rules and laws in Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Almost 60 years lie between Chapters 6 and 7. Ezra came to Jerusalem in the seventh year of Artaxerxes (Artaxerxes I), that is, 458 BC. The story of Esther takes place in the time between.

The family tree shows: Ezra descends directly from Aaron, the first high priest. Seraiah was the last high priest before the destruction of Jerusalem (2 Kings 25:18). "Son" here also means "descendant." Some generations are skipped.

Ezra was a "scribe." He knew God's law very well. In Jewish tradition he counts as a second Moses, because he put the law back at the center.

The journey took four months. The way from Babylon to Jerusalem is more than 600 miles long.

Verse 10 is an example: Ezra wanted first to study God's word, second to live by it himself, and third to teach others. In this order.

"The good hand of his God was on him": this sentence comes several times in the book of Ezra. Ezra knew that his success came from God.

The king's letter VERSES 11–26

11 King Artaxerxes gave a letter to Ezra the priest and scribe.
Ezra was an expert in the commandments of the LORD
and in the rules he gave to Israel.
This is a copy of the letter:
12 "From Artaxerxes, king of kings,
to Ezra the priest, the scribe of the law of the perfect God of heaven.
Greetings.
13 I give this order:
Any of the people of Israel in my kingdom may go with you to Jerusalem,
if they want to.
This includes their priests and the Levites.
14 The king and his seven advisers are sending you.
You are to find out how things are in Judah and Jerusalem.
Do this by the law of your God, which you have with you.
15 Take with you the silver and gold
that the king and his advisers have freely given to the God of Israel.
His home is in Jerusalem.
16 Also take all the silver and gold you can get in the whole province of Babylon.
Take the gifts that the people and the priests freely give for the house of their God in Jerusalem.
17 With this money, be careful to buy bulls, rams, and lambs,
with their grain offerings and drink offerings.
Offer them on the altar of the house of your God in Jerusalem.
18 You may do whatever you and your relatives think best with the rest of the silver and gold.
Do it according to the will of your God.
19 You have been given objects for the service in the house of your God.
Bring all of them before the God of Jerusalem.
20 Maybe you will need more for the house of your God.
Then you may take it from the king's treasury.
21 I, King Artaxerxes, give this order to all the treasurers in the land beyond the River:
Ezra the priest is a scribe of the law of the God of heaven.
Whatever he asks of you, do it carefully,
22 up to 100 talents of silver (about 7,500 pounds),
100 cors of wheat (about 600 bushels),
100 baths of wine (about 600 gallons),
100 baths of olive oil (about 600 gallons),
and as much salt as he needs.
23 Whatever the God of heaven commands for his house, do it exactly.
Why should his anger come on the kingdom of the king and his sons?
24 We also tell you this:
You may not make the priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, temple servants,
or other workers of this house of God pay any taxes, duties, or tolls.
25 And you, Ezra, use the wisdom your God has given you.
Appoint officials and judges
to judge all the people in the land beyond the River,
all who know the laws of your God.
And teach those who do not know them.
26 Some people will not obey the law of your God and the law of the king.
Punish them strictly.
They may be put to death,
or sent out of the country,
or lose their property,
or be put in prison."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This letter is again written in Aramaic, the official language of the Persian Empire (verses 12–26).

"King of kings" was the title of the Persian great kings. The "seven advisers" were the king's highest council (compare Esther 1:14).

The Bible says "100 talents of silver," "100 cors of wheat" and "100 baths of wine" and of oil. A talent is about 75 pounds, a cor about 6 bushels, a bath about 6 gallons.

The king is very generous. Why? Verse 23 gives a reason: he does not want the God of Israel to be angry with his kingdom. The Persian kings wanted all the gods in their empire to be content.

Ezra receives a great task: he is to make God's law count in the province and to teach the people.

Verse 26 names harsh punishments. That was the law of the Persian state. It shows the power that the king gave to Ezra. Today Jews and Christians say: faith must not be forced with the power of the state.

Ezra's praise VERSES 27–28

27 Praise the LORD, the God of our ancestors!
He has put it into the king's heart
to make the LORD's house in Jerusalem beautiful.
28 He has shown me his loving kindness
before the king and his advisers
and before all the king's powerful officials.
The hand of the LORD my God was on me,
and that gave me courage.
So I gathered leaders from Israel to go up with me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Ezra begins to tell the story himself, using "I". This goes on until Chapter 9. These parts are called the "Ezra memoir."

Ezra is thankful. He knows: it was not his cleverness that convinced the king, but God put this into the king's heart (compare Proverbs 21:1).

EZRA

CHAPTER 8

The journey to Jerusalem

Who went with Ezra VERSES 1–14

1 These are the heads of their families,
and this is the family list of those who went up with me from Babylon,
in the reign of Artaxerxes the king:
2 Of the descendants of Phinehas, Gershom.
Of the descendants of Ithamar, Daniel.
Of the descendants of David, Hattush.
3 Of the descendants of Shecaniah, of the descendants of Parosh, Zechariah.
With him 150 men were listed in the family list.
4 Of the descendants of Pahathmoab, Eliehoenai the son of Zerahiah,
and with him 200 men.
5 Of the descendants of Shecaniah, the son of Jahaziel,
and with him 300 men.
6 Of the descendants of Adin, Ebed the son of Jonathan,
and with him 50 men.
7 Of the descendants of Elam, Jeshaiah the son of Athaliah,
and with him 70 men.
8 Of the descendants of Shephatiah, Zebadiah the son of Michael,
and with him 80 men.
9 Of the descendants of Joab, Obadiah the son of Jehiel,
and with him 218 men.
10 Of the descendants of Shelomith, the son of Josiphiah,
and with him 160 men.
11 Of the descendants of Bebai, Zechariah the son of Bebai,
and with him 28 men.
12 Of the descendants of Azgad, Johanan the son of Hakkatan,
and with him 110 men.
13 Of the descendants of Adonikam, who were the last,
these are their names: Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah,
and with them 60 men.
14 Of the descendants of Bigvai, Uthai and Zabbud,
and with them 70 men.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Together there are about 1,500 men, and women and children came with them (verse 21).

We already know many of these families from Chapter 2. Part of the family had already returned back then. Now the rest comes. "The last" in verse 13 probably means: the last members of this family now return home.

Hattush was a descendant of David (1 Chronicles 3:22).

In verses 5 and 10 a family name is probably missing in the Hebrew text. Old Greek translations also name the families Zattu and Bani there.

Ezra looks for Levites VERSES 15–20

15 I gathered them together at the river that runs to Ahava,
and there we camped for three days.
Then I looked over the people and the priests,
and found none of the sons of Levi there.
16 Then I sent for Eliezer, Ariel, Shemaiah, Elnathan, Jarib, Elnathan, Nathan, Zechariah, and Meshullam,
who were leading men,
and also for Joiarib and Elnathan, who were teachers.
17 I sent them to Iddo, the leader at the place Casiphia.
I told them what they should say to Iddo and his brothers the temple servants at the place Casiphia,
so that they would bring us servants for the house of our God.
18 Because the good hand of our God was on us,
they brought us a man of good sense,
of the descendants of Mahli, the son of Levi, the son of Israel,
namely Sherebiah, with his sons and his brothers, 18 men,
19 and Hashabiah, and with him Jeshaiah of the descendants of Merari,
his brothers and their sons, 20 men,
20 and of the temple servants, whom David and the princes had given to serve the Levites,
220 temple servants.
All of them were listed by name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again Levites are missing (compare Ezra 2:40). Many had settled down in Babylon and did not want to go back.

Ezra acts wisely: he sends respected men and teachers to convince the Levites. Casiphia was probably a place in Babylonia where many Levites and temple servants lived.

In the end 38 Levites and 220 temple servants come along. Ezra sees God's good hand in this.

Fasting and prayer VERSES 21–23

21 Then I announced a fast there at the river Ahava,
so that we would humble ourselves before our God,
to ask him for a safe journey for us, for our little ones,
and for all our possessions.
22 For I was ashamed to ask the king for a troop of soldiers
and horsemen
to help us against the enemy on the way.
For we had said to the king,
"The hand of our God is on all those who seek him, for good.
But his power and his anger are against all those who abandon him."
23 So we fasted and begged our God for this,
and he answered our prayer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The journey was dangerous. They carried a lot of gold and silver with them, and there were robbers.

Ezra had told the king about God's protection. Now he does not want to ask for soldiers. It would have seemed to him as if he himself did not believe what he had said.

Ezra fasts and prays with everyone. He takes the danger seriously, but he trusts in God.

Later Nehemiah let the king send soldiers with him (Nehemiah 2:9). Both can be right. God can protect through miracles and through human help.

The treasures are entrusted VERSES 24–30

24 Then I set apart 12 of the leaders of the priests,
Sherebiah, Hashabiah, and 10 of their brothers with them.
25 I weighed out to them the silver, the gold, and the objects,
the offering for the house of our God,
which the king, his advisers, his princes, and all Israel who were there had given.
26 I weighed into their hand 650 talents of silver (about 24 tons),
silver objects weighing 100 talents (about 7,500 pounds),
100 talents of gold (about 7,500 pounds),
27 20 bowls of gold weighing 1,000 darics,
and two objects of fine shining bronze, as precious as gold.
28 I said to them,
"You are holy to the LORD, and the objects are holy.
The silver and the gold are a freewill offering to the LORD, the God of your ancestors.
29 Watch over them and keep them
until you weigh them before the leaders of the priests, the Levites,
and the princes of the families of Israel in Jerusalem,
in the rooms of the LORD's house."
30 So the priests and the Levites received the silver, the gold, and the objects by weight,
to bring them to Jerusalem to the house of our God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says "650 talents of silver, 100 talents of silver objects, 100 talents of gold." A talent is about 75 pounds. These are huge amounts. Some experts think that the numbers became larger in copying. What matters is: it was a great treasure.

"1,000 darics": darics were Persian gold coins of about 0.3 ounces.

Ezra weighs everything exactly and hands it over to trustworthy men. In Jerusalem everything is weighed again. Whoever handles money for God should be honest and exact (compare 2 Corinthians 8:20–21).

"You are holy to the LORD, and the objects are holy": the men are set apart for God, just like the treasures.

Arrival in Jerusalem VERSES 31–36

31 Then we left the river Ahava on the twelfth day of the first month,
to go to Jerusalem.
The hand of our God was on us,
and he saved us from the hand of the enemy and the robbers on the way.
32 We came to Jerusalem and stayed there three days.
33 On the fourth day the silver and the gold and the objects were weighed
in the house of our God into the hand of Meremoth the son of Uriah the priest.
With him was Eleazar the son of Phinehas,
and with them were the Levites Jozabad the son of Jeshua and Noadiah the son of Binnui.
34 Everything was counted and weighed,
and the whole weight was written down at that time.
35 The people who had come back from captivity, out of exile,
offered burnt offerings to the God of Israel:
12 bulls for all Israel, 96 rams, 77 lambs,
and 12 male goats as a sin offering.
All this was a burnt offering to the LORD.
36 They handed over the king's orders to the king's local governors
and to the governors beyond the River.
So these supported the people and God's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answered the prayer. They arrive safely, without soldiers.

Again offerings are made "for all Israel": 12 bulls and 12 male goats, for the 12 tribes. 96 is 8 times 12.

Meremoth the son of Uriah later also helps to build the wall (Nehemiah 3:4).

"The king's local governors": here the Hebrew uses a Persian word, "satraps." That was the name for the governors of the large provinces in the Persian Empire.

EZRA

CHAPTER 9

Ezra's prayer of repentance

Shocking news VERSES 1–4

1 When these things were done, the princes came to me
and said,
"The people of Israel, the priests, and the Levites
have not separated themselves from the peoples of the
lands.
They follow their disgusting customs,
the customs of the Canaanites, the Hittites, the
Perizzites, the Jebusites,
the Ammonites, the Moabites, the Egyptians, and the
Amorites.
2 For they have taken some of their daughters as wives
for themselves and for their sons.
So the holy offspring have mixed themselves with the
peoples of the lands.
Yes, the princes and rulers have been the first in this
unfaithfulness."
3 When I heard this,
I tore my clothes and my robe,
pulled out hair from my head and from my beard,
and sat down in shock.
4 Then everyone who trembled at the words of the God of
Israel gathered around me
because of the unfaithfulness of the exiles.
And I sat in shock until the evening offering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter and the next one are among the most difficult parts of the book.

What is it about? Many men, among them priests and leaders, had married women from the surrounding peoples who worshiped other gods. Ezra saw a great danger in this: the small nation could lose its faith, as Solomon once did, whose foreign wives led him to foreign gods (1 Kings 11:1–8). That is exactly what had led to the exile.

It was not about skin color or origin as such, but about faith. Ruth, a woman from Moab, became part of the people because she confessed the God of Israel (Ruth 1:16). She even became the great-grandmother of David.

The list of peoples in verse 1 recalls Deuteronomy 7:1–4. Some of these peoples no longer existed at that time. Ezra uses the old names to say: it is the same danger as before.

"Holy offspring" means: the people that God has set apart for himself.

Ezra reacts with deep grief. Pulling out hair was a sign of the deepest despair.

Ezra's prayer VERSES 5–15

5 At the evening offering I got up from my humbling,
with my clothes and my robe torn.
I fell on my knees and spread out my hands to the
LORD my God.
6 I said,
"My God, I am ashamed and blush to lift up my face to
you, my God.
For our sins have risen higher than our heads,
and our guilt has grown up to the heavens.
7 Since the days of our ancestors we have been very
guilty, until this day.
Because of our sins, we, our kings, and our priests
have been handed over to the kings of the lands,
to the sword, to captivity, to robbery, and to shame,
as it is today.
8 Now for a little while the LORD our God has shown us
grace.
He has left us a remnant that escaped,
and has given us a stake in his holy place,
so that our God may make our eyes shine
and give us a little new life in our slavery.
9 For we are slaves.
Yet our God has not abandoned us in our slavery.
He has shown us loving kindness in the sight of the
kings of Persia,
to give us new life, to set up the house of our God,
to repair its ruins,
and to give us a wall in Judah and in Jerusalem.
10 Now, our God, what shall we say after this?
For we have abandoned your commandments,
11 which you commanded through your servants the
prophets.
You said,
'The land which you are going in to possess is an
unclean land,
through the uncleanness of the peoples of the lands,
through their disgusting customs,
which have filled it from one end to the other with
their filth.
12 So now don't give your daughters to their sons,
and don't take their daughters for your sons.
Never seek their peace or their prosperity,
so that you may be strong and eat the good things of
the land,
and leave it as an inheritance to your children forever.'
13 All this has come on us because of our evil deeds and
our great guilt.
And yet you, our God, have punished us less than our
sins deserve,
and have given us such a remnant.
14 Shall we again break your commandments
and join ourselves by marriage to the peoples who do
these disgusting things?
Wouldn't you be angry with us until you had
destroyed us,
so that there would be no remnant and no one to
escape?
15 LORD, God of Israel, you are righteous,
for we are left as a remnant that has escaped, as it is
today.
Look, we are before you in our guilt.
For no one can stand before you because of this."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezra's prayer is a confession of sin for the whole people. Remarkable: Ezra himself had done nothing wrong. But he says "we" and "our guilt." He stands with his people and takes their side (compare Daniel 9:4–19; Nehemiah 1:6–7).

He sees God's grace: God has not completely destroyed the people. He has left a "remnant". He has given them "a stake" in his holy place. That is a picture of a firm place, like a tent peg that is stuck firmly in the ground.

The "wall" in verse 9 is probably a picture for protection. The real city wall was only built later under Nehemiah.

Verses 11–12 are not a word-for-word quotation, but a summary of several passages from the law (for example

Deuteronomy 7:1–3; 23:6).

In this prayer Ezra does not even ask for forgiveness. He only confesses the guilt and says: "You are righteous." Righteous means: always doing what is right. He leaves everything to God.

Chapter 10 explains how the story goes on and how this story can be understood today.

EZRA

Chapter 10

The decision about the mixed marriages

Shecaniah makes a suggestion VERSES 1–5

1 Ezra was praying and confessing the sins of the people.
He was weeping and lying on the ground in front of God's house.
Meanwhile, a very large crowd from Israel gathered around him.
There were men, women, and children.
The people were weeping bitterly too.

2 Then Shecaniah, the son of Jehiel, from the family of Elam, spoke to Ezra.
He said,
"We have been unfaithful to our God.
We have married foreign women from the peoples of this land.
Yet now there is hope for Israel in this matter.

3 Let's make a covenant with our God now.
We will send away all these wives and their children.
That is what my lord advises,
and those who tremble at the commandment of our God.
Let it be done according to the law.

4 Get up! This is your job.
We are with you.
Be brave and do it."

5 So Ezra got up.
He made the leaders of the priests, the Levites, and all Israel promise with an oath
to do what had been said.
And they made the promise.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezra's prayer and his grief move many people. They come and weep with him.

The suggestion does not come from Ezra, but from Shecaniah, one of the people. He says: "Yet now there is hope for Israel."

Interesting: several men from the family of Elam later appear themselves in the list of those who had married foreign women (verse 26). Maybe even Shecaniah's own father Jehiel was among them.

The assembly in Jerusalem VERSES 6–15

6 Then Ezra left the place in front of God's house.
He went into the room of Jehohanan, the son of Eliashib.
There he did not eat any bread or drink any water.
He was mourning because the people who had come back from exile had been unfaithful.

7 Then a message was sent out everywhere in Judah and Jerusalem.
All the people who had come back from captivity were to gather in Jerusalem.

8 The leaders and the elders had decided:
Anyone who did not come within three days would lose all his property.
And he himself would be shut out of the community of the exiles.

9 So within the three days, all the men of Judah and Benjamin gathered in Jerusalem.
It was the twentieth day of the ninth month.
All the people sat in the open square in front of God's house.
They were trembling because of this matter
and because of the heavy rain.

10 Ezra the priest stood up and said to them,
"You have been unfaithful.
You have married foreign women.
So you have made Israel's guilt even greater.

11 Now confess your sin to the LORD, the God of your ancestors.
Do what he wants.
Separate yourselves from the peoples of the land and from the foreign women."

12 The whole assembly answered with a loud voice,
"Yes! We must do what you have said.

13 But there are many people here.
And it is the rainy season.
We cannot stand outside.
This cannot be done in one or two days,
because many of us have sinned in this matter.

14 Let our leaders act for the whole assembly.
Everyone in our towns who has married a foreign woman
should come at a set time.
The elders and judges of each town should come with them.
We will do this until our God's fierce anger has turned away from us,
until this matter is settled."

15 Only Jonathan, the son of Asahel, and Jahzeiah, the son of Tikvah, were against this.
Meshullam and Shabbethai the Levite supported them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The ninth month is December. It is cold, and it is pouring with rain. The people tremble with cold and with the seriousness of the situation.

The people make a sensible suggestion: each case is to be examined one by one, calmly, with the elders and judges. No quick decision for everyone at once.

Four men are against it. The text does not say whether they were against the separation as such or only against the way it was done. But the Bible names them by name. So there was opposition.

The cases are examined VERSES 16–17

16 The people who had come back from captivity did what had been agreed.
Ezra the priest chose some family leaders,
one from each family.
All of them were named.
On the first day of the tenth month, they sat down to look into each case.
17 By the first day of the first month,
they had finished with all the men who had married foreign women.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The examination took three months. Each case was looked at one by one. Maybe differences were made, for example whether a woman had turned to the God of Israel. But the text does not say this clearly.

The list VERSES 18–44

18 Some of the priests had married foreign women.
These are their names:
From the descendants of Jeshua, the son of Jozadak, and his brothers:
Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah.
19 They shook hands to promise that they would send away their wives.
Because they were guilty, they offered a ram from the flock as a guilt offering.
20 From the descendants of Immer: Hanani and Zebadiah.
21 From the descendants of Harim: Maaseiah, Elijah, Shemaiah, Jehiel, and Uzziah.
22 From the descendants of Pashhur: Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, and Elasah.
23 From the Levites: Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah (also called Kelita), Pethahiah, Judah, and Eliezer.
24 From the singers: Eliashib.
From the gatekeepers: Shallum, Telem, and Uri.
25 From the rest of Israel:
From the descendants of Parosh: Ramiah, Izziah, Malchijah, Mijamin, Eleazar, Malchijah, and Benaiah.
26 From the descendants of Elam: Mattaniah, Zechariah, Jehiel, Abdi, Jeremoth, and Elijah.
27 From the descendants of Zattu: Elioenai, Eliashib, Mattaniah, Jeremoth, Zabad, and Aziza.
28 From the descendants of Bebai: Jehohanan, Hananiah, Zabbai, and Athlai.
29 From the descendants of Bani: Meshullam, Malluch, Adaiah, Jashub, Sheal, and Jeremoth.
30 From the descendants of Pahathmoab: Adna, Chelal, Benaiah, Maaseiah, Mattaniah, Bezalel, Binnui, and Manasseh.
31 From the descendants of Harim: Eliezer, Isshijah, Malchijah, Shemaiah, Shimeon,
32 Benjamin, Malluch, and Shemariah.
33 From the descendants of Hashum: Mattenai, Mattattah, Zabad, Eliphelet, Jeremai, Manasseh, and Shimei.
34 From the descendants of Bani: Maadai, Amram, Uel,
35 Benaiah, Bedeiah, Cheluhi,
36 Vaniah, Meremoth, Eliashib,
37 Mattaniah, Mattenai, Jaasu,
38 Bani, Binnui, Shimei,
39 Shelemiah, Nathan, Adaiah,
40 Machnadebai, Shashai, Sharai,
41 Azarel, Shelemiah, Shemariah,
42 Shallum, Amariah, and Joseph.
43 From the descendants of Nebo: Jeiel, Mattithiah, Zabad, Zebina, Iddo, Joel, and Benaiah.
44 All these men had married foreign women.
Some of them also had children with these wives.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The list names about 110 men. With almost 30,000 who had returned, that is a small part. But many leaders and priests were among them, even from the family of the high priest.

Verse 44 is hard to understand in Hebrew. It ends very briefly with the children. You can feel the pain in this sentence.

How can we understand this chapter today?

This story is very hard for many readers. Women and children were sent away. That meant great suffering.

We have to understand the situation at that time: after the exile, the small nation was in great danger of dissolving and losing its faith in the one God. The leaders saw this as a question of survival.

But the Bible itself also shows other ways:

– Ruth from Moab and Rahab from Canaan became part of God's people because they turned to the LORD.

– The prophet Malachi lived at the same time. He says: "Whoever hates and divorces ... covers his clothes with violence" (Malachi 2:16). That means: God does not want marriages to break.

– In the New Testament, Paul writes: if a Christian is married to a partner who does not believe, he should not separate if the other wants to stay. The children are "holy" (1 Corinthians 7:12–14).

Jews and Christians today do not read this chapter as instructions to separate families. They read it as a serious reminder that faith should shape life. And as a story that shows how hard some decisions were in a particular emergency.

The Bible does not tell what happened to the women and children. We only know that the problem came up again later (Nehemiah 13:23–27).

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Ezra?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The return home (Chapters 1–2): God keeps his promise. The Persian king Cyrus allows the Jews to return to Jerusalem. Almost 50,000 people set out. Every name is written down.

The temple (Chapters 3–6): First they build the altar, then the foundation. The young shout for joy, the old weep. Neighbors bring the building to a standstill for many years. But the prophets Haggai and Zechariah give them courage. In the year 515 BC the new temple is dedicated.

Ezra (Chapters 7–10): Almost 60 years later Ezra comes, a priest and teacher of the law. He wants to study God's word, live by it and teach it. He trusts in God's protection and prays for the people. At the end comes the hard decision about the mixed marriages.

God's hand: One sentence runs through the whole book: "The good hand of our God was on us." God also works through foreign kings. He opens doors where people see none.

What we learn: God gives a new beginning after failure. But a new beginning needs endurance, courage against opposition and a heart that takes God's word seriously.

What comes next? The book of Nehemiah tells how the walls of Jerusalem are built again and how Ezra reads the law to the people.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 16 OF 66

NEHEMIAH

13 CHAPTERS

NEHEMIAH

Chapter 1

Nehemiah hears bad news

Before we begin: What is the book of Nehemiah?

The book of Nehemiah continues the book of Ezra. Originally both were one single book.

Nehemiah was a Jew who lived at the Persian royal court. He was cupbearer to King Artaxerxes (Artaxerxes I). That was a position of trust.

In the year 445 BC Nehemiah hears that the walls of Jerusalem still lie in ruins. He asks the king to let him go to Jerusalem to build them again.

The book tells:

– Chapters 1–7: Nehemiah and the people build the wall again in only 52 days, in spite of mockery, threats and opposition.

– Chapters 8–10: Ezra reads the law to the people. The people confess their guilt and make a covenant with God.

– Chapters 11–13: People settle in Jerusalem again, the wall is dedicated, and Nehemiah puts things in order.

Large parts are written using "I", like a diary. They are called the "Nehemiah memoir."

Nehemiah prays very often, sometimes only very briefly, in the middle of a conversation. He combines prayer and hard work.

The news from Jerusalem VERSES 1–4

1 The words of Nehemiah the son of Hacaliah.
In the month Chislev, in the twentieth year,
I was in the fortress of Susa.
2 Hanani, one of my brothers, came with some men
from Judah.
I asked them about the Jews who had escaped,
who were left from the captivity,
and about Jerusalem.
3 They said to me,
"Those who are left from the captivity there in the province
are in great trouble and shame.
The wall of Jerusalem is broken down,
and its gates are burned with fire."
4 When I heard these words,
I sat down and wept, and mourned for several days.
And I fasted and prayed before the God of heaven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The month Chislev is November/December. The "twentieth year" is the twentieth year of the reign of King Artaxerxes, that is 445 BC (Nehemiah 2:1).

Susa was one of the capitals of the Persian Empire, in today's Iran. The story of Esther also takes place there.

Hanani was maybe really Nehemiah's own brother (compare Nehemiah 7:2).

The wall had already been destroyed by the Babylonians more than 140 years before. Maybe a later attempt to build it again had failed (Ezra 4:23). At that time a city without a wall was without protection and was seen as a disgrace.

Nehemiah lives in wealth at the royal court. But the suffering of his people does not leave him cold. He weeps, fasts and prays.

Nehemiah's prayer VERSES 5–11

5 I said,
"Please, LORD, the God of heaven,
the great and awesome God,
who keeps covenant and loving kindness with those
who love him and keep his commandments:
6 let your ear now listen and your eyes be open,
so that you hear the prayer of your servant,
which I pray before you at this time, day and night,
for the people of Israel your servants.
I confess the sins of the people of Israel,
which we have sinned against you.
Yes, I and my father's house have sinned.
7 We have acted very wickedly against you.
We have not kept the commandments, the rules, and the laws
which you commanded your servant Moses.
8 Please remember the word that you commanded your servant Moses:
'If you are unfaithful, I will scatter you among the peoples.
9 But if you return to me, and keep my commandments and do them,
then even if your scattered people were at the farthest end of the heavens,
I will gather them from there
and bring them to the place that I have chosen,
to make my name live there.'
10 Now these are your servants and your people,
whom you have set free by your great power and by your strong hand.
11 Lord, please let your ear listen now to the prayer of your servant,
and to the prayer of your servants who love to fear your name.
Please give your servant success today,
and let him find mercy in the sight of this man."
At that time I was cupbearer to the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nehemiah's prayer is an example:

– He begins with praise: God is great and faithful.

– He confesses the guilt, his own too: "Yes, I and my father's house have sinned."

– He reminds God of his promises (Deuteronomy 30:1–5).

– He asks for help in concrete terms.

He prays "day and night," for four months (from Chislev to Nisan, Nehemiah 2:1). He waits patiently for the right moment.

"This man" is the king. For God even the most powerful king in the world is only "a man".

A cupbearer handed the king his wine and tested it first to see whether it was poisoned. He was a close confidant of the king and often had great influence.

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 2

Nehemiah goes to Jerusalem

Nehemiah before the king VERSES 1–8

1 It was the month of Nisan,
in the twentieth year that Artaxerxes was king.
Wine was set before the king.
I picked up the wine and gave it to him.
I had never been sad in front of him before.
2 So the king asked me,
"Why do you look so sad?
You are not sick.
This must be sadness of the heart."
Then I was very afraid.
3 I said to the king,
"May the king live forever!
How could I not look sad?
The city where my ancestors are buried lies in ruins.
Its gates have been burned down."
4 The king asked me,
"What do you want?"
Then I prayed to the God of heaven.
5 And I said to the king,
"If it pleases the king,
and if you are happy with me, your servant,
please send me to Judah,
to the city where my ancestors are buried.
Then I can rebuild it."
6 The queen was sitting next to the king.
The king asked me,
"How long will your journey take?
When will you come back?"
The king was willing to send me,
and I gave him a date.
7 I also said to the king,
"If it pleases the king,
please give me letters for the governors of the land beyond the River.
Then they will let me travel through their lands until I reach Judah.
8 Please also give me a letter for Asaph,
who is in charge of the king's forest.
Then he will give me wood for beams.
I need beams for the gates of the fortress next to the temple,
for the city wall,
and for the house where I will live."
The king gave me what I asked for,
because the good hand of my God was on me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The month Nisan is March/April. Nehemiah has prayed and waited for four months.

You were not allowed to look sad before a Persian king. That could count as discontent or treason. That is why Nehemiah becomes afraid.

Nehemiah is wise: he speaks of the city "where my ancestors are buried." Every king understood that you honor the graves of your ancestors. He does not say the name Jerusalem. The king had earlier had the building of this city stopped (Ezra 4:21).

Verse 4 is one of the shortest prayers of the Bible: between the king's question and his answer, Nehemiah prays silently. You can pray at any time, even in the middle of a conversation.

Nehemiah is well prepared. He knows exactly what he needs: letters for the journey and wood for the building. Faith and good planning belong together.

The "king's forest" was maybe in Lebanon, where cedars grew.

Arrival and the first opponents VERSES 9–10

9 Then I came to the governors of the land beyond the River.
I gave them the king's letters.
The king had also sent army officers and horsemen with me.
10 Sanballat the Horonite and Tobiah, the Ammonite servant, heard about it.
They were very upset
that someone had come to help the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Unlike Ezra (Ezra 8:22), Nehemiah travels with soldiers. That is not a contradiction. God can protect in different ways.

Sanballat was the governor of Samaria. His name is also found in a letter that was discovered in Elephantine in Egypt. "Horonite" probably means: he came from Beth Horon.

Tobiah was probably a high official in the area of Ammon, east of the Jordan. "Servant" was maybe a title, like "servant of the king." Or it is meant to belittle him.

These men become Nehemiah's main opponents. They do not want Jerusalem to become strong again.

Nehemiah inspects the wall by night VERSES 11–16

11 So I came to Jerusalem.
I stayed there for three days.
12 Then I got up in the night.
I took a few men with me.
I had not told anyone what my God had put into my heart to do for Jerusalem.
I had no animal with me except the one I was riding.
13 At night, I went out through the Valley Gate.
I went toward the Jackal's Well and then to the Dung Gate.
I looked closely at the walls of Jerusalem.

They were broken down,
and the gates had been burned.
14 Then I went on to the Spring Gate and to the King's Pool.
But there was no room for my animal to get through.
15 So during the night I went up along the brook and looked at the wall.
Then I turned back.
I went in again through the Valley Gate.
That is how I came back.
16 The officials did not know where I had gone or what I had done.
I had not yet told anything to the Jews:
not to the priests, the nobles, the officials,
or the others who would do the work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nehemiah goes about it wisely. First, he looks at everything calmly, secretly at night. Only when he has a plan does he speak with the others.

The rubble lies so thick that in some places his animal cannot get through.

The "brook" is the Kidron Valley east of Jerusalem.

Nehemiah probably goes around the southern part of the city, the old City of David.

"Let's rise up and build!" VERSES 17–20

17 Then I said to them,
"You see the bad situation that we are in.
Jerusalem lies in ruins.
Its gates have been burned.
Come, let's rebuild the wall of Jerusalem!
Then we will no longer be a disgrace."
18 I told them how the hand of my God had been good to me.
I also told them what the king had said to me.
They said, "Let's rise up and build!"
And they got ready for this good work with courage.
19 But Sanballat the Horonite, Tobiah, the Ammonite servant, and Geshem the Arabian heard about it.
They laughed at us and looked down on us.
They said,
"What are you doing?
Are you rebelling against the king?"
20 I answered them,
"The God of heaven will give us success.
We are his servants.
We will start building.
But you have no share in Jerusalem,
no right to it,
and nothing there that people will remember you by."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nehemiah says "we": "the bad situation that we are in." Although he has only just come, he puts himself on the same level as the people.

He gives them courage by telling how God has already helped. The people answer with enthusiasm: "Let's rise up and build!"

At once, mockery and threats come. They accuse them of rebellion against the king. That is the same tactic as in Ezra 4.

Geshem was a powerful Arab ruler. A silver bowl that was found in Egypt probably names the same man: "Geshem, king of Kedar."

Nehemiah does not let himself be frightened. He answers clearly: God will give us success. You have nothing to say here.

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 3

Everyone helps to build

From the Sheep Gate to the Old Gate VERSES 1–5

1 Eliashib the high priest and his relatives, the priests, got to work.
They built the Sheep Gate.
They made it holy and put its doors in place.
They also made the wall holy as far as the Tower of Hammeah
and the Tower of Hananel.
2 The men of Jericho built the next section.
Zaccur, the son of Imri, built the section after that.
3 The sons of Hassenaah built the Fish Gate.
They put in its beams.
They put its doors, bolts, and bars in place.
4 Meremoth, the son of Uriah, the son of Hakkoz, repaired the next section.
Meshullam, the son of Berechiah, the son of Meshezabel, repaired the section after that.
Zadok, the son of Baana, repaired the next one.
5 The people of Tekoa repaired the next section.
But their nobles would not bend their necks to do the Lord's work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is a list: who built which piece of the wall? It begins in the north at the Sheep Gate and goes once around the city, counterclockwise.

The high priest begins. The leaders set a good example.

The Sheep Gate was near the temple. The sheep for the offerings were probably brought in there. Later the pool of Bethesda, where Jesus healed a sick man, was also near the Sheep Gate (John 5:2).

Verse 5 is honest: the nobles of Tekoa thought they were too fine for the work. But the ordinary people of Tekoa even built two sections (verse 27).

"The Lord's work": the Hebrew says "the work of their lords." This means either God or Nehemiah as governor.

From the Old Gate to the Valley Gate VERSES 6–13

6 Joiada, the son of Paseah, and Meshullam, the son of Besodeiah, repaired the Old Gate.
They put in its beams.
They put its doors, bolts, and bars in place.

7 Next to them, Melatiah from Gibeon and Jadon from
Meronoth made repairs.
They were men from Gibeon and Mizpah.
They repaired the residence of the governor of the
land beyond the River.
8 Next to them, Uzziel, the son of Harhaiah, made
repairs.
He was one of the goldsmiths.
Next to him, Hananiah made repairs.
He was one of the perfume makers.
They made Jerusalem strong as far as the Broad Wall.
9 Next to them, Rephaiah, the son of Hur, made repairs.
He was the ruler of half the district of Jerusalem.
10 Next to them, Jedaiah, the son of Harumaph, made
repairs across from his house.
Next to him, Hattush, the son of Hashabneiah, made
repairs.
11 Malchijah, the son of Harim, and Hasshub, the son of
Pahathmoab,
repaired another section and the Tower of the Ovens.
12 Next to them, Shallum, the son of Hallohesh, made
repairs.
He was the ruler of half the district of Jerusalem.
His daughters helped him.
13 Hanun and the people of Zanoah repaired the Valley
Gate.
They built it and put its doors, bolts, and bars in place.
They also repaired about 1,500 feet of the wall,
as far as the Dung Gate.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

People from all trades help to build: goldsmiths, perfume makers, district rulers. Everyone helps, even people who are not builders.

Verse 12 is remarkable: Shallum builds together with his daughters. Women worked on building the wall too.

Many build "across from their house." Each one takes care of the piece that is closest to him. So the work is well divided, and everyone has a reason to be careful.

The Bible says "1,000 cubits." A cubit is about 18 inches. Here the wall was probably less damaged.

From the Dung Gate to the water VERSES 14–16

14 Malchijah, the son of Rechab, repaired the Dung Gate.
He was the ruler of the district of Beth Haccherem.
He built the gate and put its doors, bolts, and bars in
place.
15 Shallun, the son of Colhozeh, repaired the Spring Gate.
He was the ruler of the district of Mizpah.
He built the gate and put a roof over it.
He put its doors, bolts, and bars in place.
He also repaired the wall of the Pool of Shelah, next to
the king's garden.
He repaired it as far as the stairs that go down from
David's city.
16 After him, Nehemiah, the son of Azbuk, made repairs.
He was the ruler of half the district of Beth Zur.
He repaired the wall up to the place across from the
tombs of David,
up to the pool that had been built,
and up to the house of the warriors.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Dung Gate led to the Valley of Hinnom, where the city's garbage was taken.

The pool of Shelah is probably the pool of Siloam. Later Jesus sent a blind man there to wash (John 9:7).

This Nehemiah, the son of Azbuk, is not the same as Nehemiah the governor.

The "tombs of David" were in the old City of David. Today no one knows exactly where.

The Levites and priests VERSES 17–22

17 After him, the Levites made repairs.
Rehum, the son of Bani, made repairs.
Next to him, Hashabiah made repairs for his district.
He was the ruler of half the district of Keilah.
18 After him, their relatives made repairs.
Bavvai, the son of Henadad, the ruler of half the
district of Keilah, made repairs.
19 Next to him, Ezer, the son of Jeshua, the ruler of
Mizpah, repaired another section.
It was across from the way up to the armory, where the
wall turns.
An armory is a building where weapons are kept.
20 After him, Baruch, the son of Zabbai, worked earnestly
and repaired another section.
It went from the place where the wall turns
to the door of the house of Eliashib the high priest.
21 After him, Meremoth, the son of Uriah, the son of
Hakkoz, repaired another section.
It went from the door of Eliashib's house to the end of
Eliashib's house.
22 After him, the priests from the surrounding area made
repairs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Baruch works "earnestly." He is the only one of whom this is said directly. God sees who puts in a special effort.

Meremoth builds two sections (verses 4 and 21). He was the priest to whom Ezra had handed over the treasures (Ezra 8:33).

"Bavvai": some manuscripts have "Binnui," as in verse 24.

As far as the Ophel VERSES 23–27

23 After them, Benjamin and Hasshub made repairs across
from their house.
After them, Azariah, the son of Maaseiah, the son of
Ananiah,
made repairs next to his own house.
24 After him, Binnui, the son of Henadad, repaired
another section.
It went from Azariah's house to the place where the
wall turns, at the corner.
25 Palal, the son of Uzai, made repairs across from the
place where the wall turns.
He also repaired the tower that sticks out from the
upper palace of the king,
next to the courtyard of the guard.
After him, Pedaiah, the son of Parosh, made repairs.
26 (The temple servants lived on the Ophel hill.
They lived as far as the place across from the Water
Gate on the east side,
and as far as the tower that sticks out.)

27 After him, the people of Tekoa repaired another section.
It went from across from the great tower that sticks out
to the wall of the Ophel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Ophel is the hill between the old City of David and the temple mount.

The "Water Gate" was probably called that because the way to the Gihon spring led from there. On the square in front of the Water Gate, Ezra later read the law to the people (Nehemiah 8:1).

The people of Tekoa build a second section, although their nobles did not help (verse 5).

From the Horse Gate back to the Sheep Gate
VERSES 28–32

28 The priests made repairs above the Horse Gate.
Each of them repaired the section across from his own house.
29 After them, Zadok, the son of Immer, made repairs across from his own house.
After him, Shemaiah, the son of Shecaniah, made repairs.
He was the guard of the East Gate.
30 After him, Hananiah, the son of Shelemiah,
and Hanun, the sixth son of Zalaph, repaired another section.
After him, Meshullam, the son of Berechiah, made repairs across from his room.
31 After him, Malchijah made repairs.
He was one of the goldsmiths.
He repaired the wall as far as the house of the temple servants and the merchants,
across from the Gate of Hammiphkad,
and as far as the ascent of the corner.
32 Between the ascent of the corner and the Sheep Gate,
the goldsmiths and the merchants made repairs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The circle closes: the list ends again at the Sheep Gate, where it began.

"Gate of Hammiphkad" means something like "Gate of Inspection." Maybe soldiers were inspected there, or goods were checked.

"Ascent of the corner": the Hebrew word can also mean "upper room," that is, a room up at the corner of the wall.

The message of this chapter: a great work succeeds when everyone lends a hand. Priests and merchants, men and women, people from the city and from the country. Each in his place. And every name is known to God.

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 4

Building with the sword at your side

Mockery and prayer VERSES 1–6

1 Sanballat heard that we were building the wall.
He became angry and very upset.
He made fun of the Jews.
2 He spoke in front of his brothers and the army of Samaria.
He said, "What are these weak Jews doing?
Do they want to make their city strong?
Do they want to offer sacrifices?
Do they think they will finish in one day?
Can they bring the stones back to life out of the piles of rubble?
The stones are burned!"
3 Tobiah the Ammonite was standing next to him.
He said, "Look at what they are building!
If a fox climbed up on it, he would break down their stone wall."
4 "Hear us, our God!
People look down on us.
Let their insults come back on their own heads.
Let them be robbed and taken away as prisoners to a foreign land.
5 Don't cover up their guilt.
Don't wipe out their sin from before you.
They have insulted the builders."
6 So we built the wall.
The whole wall was joined together up to half its height.
The people had a mind to work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles verses 1–6 of this chapter are at the end of Chapter 3 (verses 33–38). That is why the verses of Chapter 4 there are shifted by six: verse 7 here is verse 1 there, and so on.

The opponents first try mockery. Mockery can be very discouraging.

Nehemiah does not answer with mockery of his own. He prays. His prayer is harsh: he asks God to punish the mockers. There are such prayers in the Psalms too. You may tell God honestly how angry and hurt you are. Nehemiah leaves the punishment to God and does not take revenge himself. Jesus goes even further: "Pray for those who treat you badly and persecute you" (Matthew 5:44).

Verse 6: "The people had a mind to work," word for word "a heart for work". In spite of the mockery they go on working with all their heart.

Threats and exhaustion VERSES 7–12

7 Sanballat, Tobiah, the Arabians, the Ammonites, and the people of Ashdod heard the news:
The repair of the walls of Jerusalem was going forward.
The gaps in the wall were starting to be filled.
Then they became very angry.
8 They all made a secret plan together.
They wanted to come and fight against Jerusalem and cause confusion among us.
9 But we prayed to our God.
And because of them we set up guards against them

day and night.
10 The people of Judah said,
"The strength of those who carry the loads is giving out.
There is so much rubble.
We are not able to build the wall."
11 Our enemies said,
"They will not know or see anything
until we come in among them and kill them.
Then we will stop the work."
12 The Jews who lived near the enemies came to us.
They told us 10 times, from all places,
"Wherever you turn, they will attack us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the enemies come from all sides: Samaria in the north, the Arabs in the south, the Ammonites in the east, and Ashdod (the Philistines) in the west. Jerusalem is surrounded.

Verse 9 shows Nehemiah's way: to pray AND to set up guards. Faith and caution belong together.

Then exhaustion comes from inside: "We are not able to build the wall." The rubble seems endless. And the Jews from the towns around spread fear, "10 times," that is, again and again.

Discouragement comes from outside and from inside. Both are dangerous.

Nehemiah encourages the people VERSES 13–15

13 So I set guards in the lowest places behind the wall, in the open places.
I placed the people there by families.
They had their swords, their spears, and their bows.
14 I looked at everything.
Then I stood up and spoke to the nobles, the leaders, and the rest of the people.
I said, "Don't be afraid of them!
Remember the Lord.
He is great and awesome.
Fight for your brothers, your sons, your daughters, your wives, and your houses."
15 Our enemies heard that we knew about their plan.
God had made their plan fail.
Then all of us went back to the wall.
Each one went back to his work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nehemiah sets the people up by families. Everyone defends those he loves.

His words are a strong encouragement: think of God, who is greater than your enemies. And think of your families.

This was about defense, not attack. The people protected their families and their city.

The attack did not happen at all. When the enemies noticed that their plan was known, they gave up.

Building with one hand, keeping watch with the other VERSES 16–23

16 From that day on, half of my servants did the work.
The other half held the spears, the shields, the bows, and the armor.
The leaders stood behind all the people of Judah.
17 The people who built the wall and the people who carried loads worked like this:
With one hand each one did the work.
With the other hand he held his weapon.
18 Each of the builders wore his sword at his side while he built.
The man who blew the trumpet stayed next to me.
19 I said to the nobles, the leaders, and the rest of the people,
"The work is big and spread out over a wide area.
We are spread out along the wall, far from one another.
20 When you hear the sound of the trumpet,
come together to us at that place.
Our God will fight for us."
21 So we did the work.
Half of the people held the spears
from the first light of morning until the stars came out.
22 At that time I also said to the people,
"Each man and his servant should stay overnight inside Jerusalem.
Then they can guard us at night and work during the day."
23 So none of us took off our clothes:
not I, not my brothers, not my servants,
and not the men of the guard who followed me.
Each one took his weapon with him to the water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This picture is famous: building with one hand, holding the weapon with the other. It stands for people who go on working under threat.

Christians have often applied this picture to spiritual life: we build God's kingdom and at the same time stay watchful (compare Ephesians 6:10–18).

Nehemiah has a good plan: a trumpeter is always with him. When there is danger somewhere, everyone comes there. No one stands alone.

"Our God will fight for us": Nehemiah trusts in God, but he also does everything he can himself.

Nehemiah himself sets a good example. He does not even take off his clothes at night.

The end of verse 23 is hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: everyone always had his weapon at hand, even when fetching water.

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 5

Nehemiah fights for the poor

The cry of the poor VERSES 1–5

1 Then there was a great outcry of the people and of their wives
against their brothers the Jews.
2 For some said,
"We, our sons and our daughters, are many.
Let us get grain, so that we may eat and live."
3 Some also said,
"We are pledging our fields, our vineyards, and our houses.
Let us get grain, because of the famine."
4 Some also said,
"We have borrowed money for the king's tribute,
using our fields and our vineyards as security.
5 Yet our flesh is as the flesh of our brothers,
our children as their children.
Look, we are forcing our sons and our daughters into slavery to be servants,
and some of our daughters have already been made slaves.
And we cannot do anything about it,
because other men have our fields and our vineyards."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of building the wall, a problem comes from inside. The poor cry for help.

There was a famine. On top of that came high taxes to the Persian king. The poor had to borrow money and pledge their fields. If they could not pay it back, they lost their land. And in the end they even had to give their children as slaves for their debts.

The worst thing: the rich who exploited them were their own brothers, Jews like them.

"Our flesh is as the flesh of our brothers" means: we are human beings just like them! Our children are worth just as much!

That the wives cry out too shows: whole families suffered.

Nehemiah confronts the rich VERSES 6–13

6 I was very angry when I heard their outcry and these words.
7 Then I thought it over,
and I argued with the nobles and the rulers and said to them,
"You are charging interest, each one from his brother!"
I called a great assembly against them.
8 I said to them,
"As far as we were able, we have bought back our brothers the Jews
who had been sold to the nations.
And would you now sell your brothers,
so that they are sold back to us?"
Then they were silent and found nothing to say.
9 I also said,
"What you are doing is not good.
Shouldn't you walk in the fear of our God,
because of the insults of the nations, our enemies?
10 I too, my brothers and my servants, are lending them money and grain.
Please let us stop this charging of interest.
11 Please give back to them, this very day,
their fields, their vineyards, their olive groves, and their houses,
and also the hundredth part of the money,
and of the grain, the new wine, and the oil,
that you are charging them."
12 Then they said,
"We will give them back and will ask nothing of them.
We will do just as you say."
Then I called the priests
and made them take an oath that they would do as they had promised.
13 I also shook out the fold of my robe and said,
"So may God shake out of his house and from his work every man who doesn't keep this promise.
May he be shaken out and emptied like this."
The whole assembly said, "Amen," and praised the LORD.
And the people did as they had promised.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nehemiah becomes angry, and rightly so. Injustice against the poor makes God angry too.

But he does not act without thinking. He "thought it over" before he acted.

The law forbade taking interest from poor brothers (Exodus 22:25; Leviticus 25:35–37; Deuteronomy 23:19).

Nehemiah's argument is strong: we have spent money to buy our brothers free from slavery among foreign peoples. And you make them slaves again!

"The hundredth part" was probably an interest of one percent a month, that is 12 percent a year.

Nehemiah admits: he and his people have also lent money. He includes himself: "Please let us stop."

Shaking out the robe was a sign: whoever breaks the promise is to lose everything.

This story shows: social justice matters to God. A community cannot be strong when the rich exploit the poor. That is still important today.

Nehemiah as a just governor VERSES 14–19

14 From the time that I was appointed to be their governor in the land of Judah,
from the twentieth year to the thirty-second year of Artaxerxes the king,
that is, 12 years,
I and my brothers have not eaten the food that belonged to the governor.
15 But the earlier governors who were before me were supported by the people.
They took bread and wine from them,
and also 40 shekels of silver (about 1 pound).
Even their servants ruled over the people.
But I didn't do so, because of the fear of God.
16 I also kept on with the work on this wall.
We didn't buy any land.
All my servants were gathered there for the work.
17 At my table there were 150 men of the Jews and the rulers,
besides those who came to us from the nations around us.
18 What was prepared for one day was one ox and six choice sheep.

Birds were also prepared for me,
and once every 10 days a supply of all kinds of wine.
Yet for all this I didn't ask for the governor's pay,
because the burden on this people was heavy.
19 Remember me, my God,
for all the good that I have done for this people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Nehemiah looks back on his whole time in office: 12 years, from 445 to 433 BC.

As governor he would have been allowed to demand payments from the people. But he did not do it, because the people were already suffering enough. He paid for everything out of his own pocket, even the guests at his table.

Verse 15 says "40 shekels of silver". A shekel is about 0.4 ounces.

"We didn't buy any land": he did not use his position to buy land cheaply from poor people in debt.

Verse 19 is a prayer that Nehemiah speaks several times (Nehemiah 13:14, 22, 31). He asks God to remember the good he has done. He does not seek praise from people, but from God.

Nehemiah is an example of leadership: he serves the people, instead of letting them serve him. Jesus later says: "Whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant" (Mark 10:43).

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 6

Traps for Nehemiah – and the wall is finished

The invitation to Ono VERSES 1–4

1 Sanballat, Tobiah, Geshem the Arabian, and the rest of our enemies heard
that I had built the wall,
and that there was no gap left in it.
(But up to that time I had not yet set up the doors in the gates.)
2 Then Sanballat and Geshem sent word to me:
"Come! Let's meet together in the villages in the plain of Ono."
But they planned to harm me.
3 I sent messengers to them and said,
"I am doing a great work, so that I can't come down.
Why should the work stop while I leave it and come down to you?"
4 They sent to me four times like this,
and I answered them the same way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the opponents try a trick. Ono was about 25 miles northwest of Jerusalem, far away from the protection of the city. There they could easily have captured or killed Nehemiah.

Nehemiah's answer is famous: "I am doing a great work, so that I can't come down." He does not let himself be distracted from his task.

He keeps to his answer, even the fourth time. He does not let himself be worn down.

The open letter VERSES 5–9

5 Then Sanballat sent his servant to me in the same way a fifth time,
with an open letter in his hand.
6 In it was written:
"It is reported among the nations, and Gashmu says it,
that you and the Jews plan to rebel.
That is why you are building the wall.
And according to these reports, you want to be their king.
7 You have also appointed prophets to announce about you in Jerusalem:
'There is a king in Judah!'
Now this will be reported to the king, according to these words.
So come now, and let's talk it over together."
8 Then I sent to him and said,
"None of the things you say have happened.
You are making them up out of your own heart."
9 For they all wanted to make us afraid.
They thought,
"Their hands will become too weak for the work, so that it will not be done."
But now, strengthen my hands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An "open letter" was not sealed. Anyone could read it. That way the rumors were meant to spread.

Gashmu is another form of the name Geshem.

The lie is dangerous: whoever rebelled against the Persian king was punished severely.

Nehemiah answers briefly and clearly: this is made up. He does not get into a long defense.

At the end of verse 9 he prays again in the middle of the report: "Strengthen my hands!" A short prayer in need.

The false prophet VERSES 10–14

10 I went to the house of Shemaiah the son of Delaiah, the son of Mehetabel,
who had shut himself in at his home.
He said,
"Let us meet together in God's house, inside the temple,
and let's shut the doors of the temple.
For they will come to kill you.
Yes, in the night they will come to kill you."
11 I said,
"Should a man like me run away?
And who is there like me who would go into the temple to save his life?
I will not go in."
12 I saw clearly that God had not sent him.
He had spoken this prophecy against me
because Tobiah and Sanballat had hired him.

13 He was hired so that I would be afraid, do what he said,
and sin.
Then they would have something for an evil report
about me,
so that they could put me to shame.
14 "My God, remember Tobiah and Sanballat for these
deeds of theirs,
and also the prophetess Noadiah
and the rest of the prophets who wanted to make me
afraid."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the most dangerous trap: a false prophet from his own people. He acts as if he wants to save Nehemiah.

But Nehemiah sees through him for two reasons:

– A leader who runs away would discourage the people.

– Nehemiah was not a priest. He was not allowed to go into the inside of the temple (Numbers 18:7). If he had done it, he would have sinned against God's law.

A true prophet of God would never tell someone to sin. That is how Nehemiah recognizes that Shemaiah had been bought.

A prophetess, Noadiah, also belonged to the opponents. So there were several false prophets.

Nehemiah does not take revenge himself. He leaves his enemies to God.

The wall is finished VERSES 15–16

15 So the wall was finished on the twenty-fifth day of Elul,
in 52 days.
16 When all our enemies heard of it,
all the nations around us were afraid,
and they lost their confidence.
For they saw that this work had been done by our God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only 52 days! In spite of mockery, threats, exhaustion and traps. The month Elul is August/September. So the wall was finished in the fall of 445 BC.

The enemies who wanted to frighten others now become afraid themselves. For they see: this cannot only be the work of people. God has worked here.

The Jewish historian Josephus later writes of two years and four months. Maybe he meant the whole construction with towers and gates.

Tobiah's connections VERSES 17–19

17 Also in those days the nobles of Judah sent many letters
to Tobiah,
and Tobiah's letters came to them.
18 For many in Judah were bound to him by oath,
because he was the son-in-law of Shecaniah the son of
Arah.
And his son Jehohanan had married the daughter of
Meshullam the son of Berechiah.
19 They also spoke of his good deeds before me
and reported my words to him.
And Tobiah sent letters to make me afraid.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Through marriages Tobiah had close connections in Jerusalem. Meshullam the son of Berechiah had even helped build the wall (Nehemiah 3:4, 30).

Some in Jerusalem played a double game: they praised Tobiah to Nehemiah and passed Nehemiah's words on to Tobiah.

Even after the building of the wall the struggle goes on. This time with letters and intimidation.

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 7

Guards for the city and the list of those who returned

Order for Jerusalem VERSES 1–4

1 When the wall was built and I had set up the doors,
and the gatekeepers, the singers, and the Levites had
been appointed,
2 I put my brother Hanani,
and Hananiah the commander of the fortress, in
charge of Jerusalem.
For he was a faithful man and feared God more than
many others.
3 I said to them,
"Don't let the gates of Jerusalem be opened until the
sun is hot.
While the guards are still standing there, let them
shut the doors and bar them.
And appoint watches of the people who live in
Jerusalem,
each one at his post, each one near his own house."
4 The city was wide and large,
but there were few people in it,
and the houses had not been built.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nehemiah appoints faithful men to be in charge. The most important quality: Hananiah "feared God more than many others".

The gates are to be opened only when the sun is high. Then everyone is awake, and no enemy can break in by surprise at dawn.

A new problem: the city is large, but almost empty. A wall alone does not yet make a living city. It needs people. The solution comes in Chapter 11.

The record is found VERSES 5–7

5 My God put it into my heart
to gather together the nobles, the rulers, and the
people,
so that they could be listed by their families.
I found the book of the family records of those who
came up at first,
and I found this written in it:
6 These are the people of the province
who went up out of the captivity of those who had
been carried away,

whom Nebuchadnezzar the king of Babylon had carried away.
They returned to Jerusalem and to Judah, each to his own city.
7 They came with Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Nehemiah, Azariah, Raamiah, Nahamani,
Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispereth, Bigvai, Nehum, and Baanah.
The number of the men of the people of Israel:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nehemiah finds the old list of the first people who returned, almost 100 years old. It appears almost exactly the same in Ezra 2.

The list helps to find out which families belong where. So later it can be decided who is to move to Jerusalem.

Here 12 leaders are named, in Ezra 2:2 only 11. The number 12 recalls the 12 tribes of Israel.

In this chapter some numbers and names are a little different from Ezra 2. When long lists were copied, small differences easily happened.

The families and towns VERSES 8–38

8 The descendants of Parosh: 2,172.
9 The descendants of Shephatiah: 372.
10 The descendants of Arah: 652.
11 The descendants of Pahathmoab, of the descendants of Jeshua and Joab: 2,818.
12 The descendants of Elam: 1,254.
13 The descendants of Zattu: 845.
14 The descendants of Zaccai: 760.
15 The descendants of Binnui: 648.
16 The descendants of Bebai: 628.
17 The descendants of Azgad: 2,322.
18 The descendants of Adonikam: 667.
19 The descendants of Bigvai: 2,067.
20 The descendants of Adin: 655.
21 The descendants of Ater, of Hezekiah: 98.
22 The descendants of Hashum: 328.
23 The descendants of Bezai: 324.
24 The descendants of Hariph: 112.
25 The descendants of Gibeon: 95.
26 The men of Bethlehem and Netophah: 188.
27 The men of Anathoth: 128.
28 The men of Beth Azmaveth: 42.
29 The men of Kiriath Jearim, Chephirah, and Beeroth: 743.
30 The men of Ramah and Geba: 621.
31 The men of Michmas: 122.
32 The men of Bethel and Ai: 123.
33 The men of the other Nebo: 52.
34 The descendants of the other Elam: 1,254.
35 The descendants of Harim: 320.
36 The people of Jericho: 345.
37 The people of Lod, Hadid, and Ono: 721.
38 The descendants of Senaah: 3,930.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many numbers agree with Ezra 2, some do not. For example, Arah has 652 here, but 775 in Ezra 2:5. And Bethel and Ai have 123 here, but 223 in Ezra 2:28.

Jorah (Ezra 2:18) is called Hariph here. Gibbar (Ezra 2:20) is called Gibeon here.

The differences do not change the message: God knows every family, every town.

Priests, Levites, singers and gatekeepers VERSES 39–45

39 The priests:
the descendants of Jedaiah, of the house of Jeshua: 973.
40 The descendants of Immer: 1,052.
41 The descendants of Pashhur: 1,247.
42 The descendants of Harim: 1,017.
43 The Levites:
the descendants of Jeshua, of Kadmiel, of the descendants of Hodevah: 74.
44 The singers:
the descendants of Asaph: 148.
45 The gatekeepers:
the descendants of Shallum, the descendants of Ater,
the descendants of Talmon,
the descendants of Akkub, the descendants of Hatita,
the descendants of Shobai: 138.

The temple servants and the servants of Solomon VERSES 46–60

46 The temple servants:
the descendants of Ziha, the descendants of Hasupha,
the descendants of Tabbaoth,
47 the descendants of Keros, the descendants of Sia, the descendants of Padon,
48 the descendants of Lebana, the descendants of Hagaba,
the descendants of Salmai,
49 the descendants of Hanan, the descendants of Giddel,
the descendants of Gahar,
50 the descendants of Reaiah, the descendants of Rezin,
the descendants of Nekoda,
51 the descendants of Gazzam, the descendants of Uzza,
the descendants of Paseah,
52 the descendants of Besai, the descendants of Meunim,
the descendants of Nephushesim,
53 the descendants of Bakbuk, the descendants of Hakupha, the descendants of Harhur,
54 the descendants of Bazlith, the descendants of Mehida,
the descendants of Harsha,
55 the descendants of Barkos, the descendants of Sisera,
the descendants of Temah,
56 the descendants of Neziah, and the descendants of Hatipha.
57 The descendants of Solomon's servants:
the descendants of Sotai, the descendants of Sophereth, the descendants of Perida,
58 the descendants of Jaala, the descendants of Darkon,
the descendants of Giddel,
59 the descendants of Shephatiah, the descendants of Hattil,

the descendants of Pochereth Hazzebaim, and the descendants of Amon.
60 All the temple servants and the descendants of Solomon's servants were 392.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even the simple servants at the temple are all named by name. With God no one is unimportant.

Those without proof VERSES 61–65

61 These were the ones who went up from Tel Melah, Tel Harsha, Cherub, Addon, and Immer.
But they could not show their families or their ancestry,
whether they were of Israel:
62 the descendants of Delaiah, the descendants of Tobiah, the descendants of Nekoda: 642.
63 Of the priests:
the descendants of Hobaiah, the descendants of Hakkoz,
the descendants of Barzillai.
He had married one of the daughters of Barzillai the Gileadite
and was called by their name.
64 These searched for their family records, but couldn't find them.
So they were not allowed to serve and were removed from the priesthood.
65 The governor told them not to eat of the most holy things
until a priest stood up to serve with Urim and Thummim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As in Ezra 2:59–63: whoever could not prove his ancestry was still allowed to come along. Only the service as priest was postponed until God himself would give clarity.

"Urim and Thummim" were lots with which the high priest asked for God's will.

The total number and the gifts VERSES 66–73

66 The whole assembly together was 42,360,
67 besides their male servants and their female servants, of whom there were 7,337.
They had 245 singing men and singing women.
68 Their horses were 736, their mules 245,
69 their camels 435, their donkeys 6,720.
70 Some of the heads of the families gave to the work.
The governor gave to the treasury 1,000 darics of gold (about 18 pounds),
50 basins, and 530 priests' garments.
71 Some of the heads of the families gave into the treasury for the work
20,000 darics of gold (about 370 pounds),
and 2,200 minas of silver (about 2,750 pounds).
72 What the rest of the people gave was 20,000 darics of gold,
and 2,000 minas of silver (about 2,500 pounds),
and 67 priests' garments.
73 So the priests, the Levites, the gatekeepers, the singers, some of the people, the temple servants, and all Israel lived in their cities.
When the seventh month had come,
the people of Israel were in their cities.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Darics" were Persian gold coins of about 0.3 ounces. Silver: the Bible says "2,200 minas" and "2,000 minas". A mina is about 1¼ pounds.

The list of gifts is more detailed here than in Ezra 2:68–69. The governor gave too. Everyone gave according to his means.

The end of verse 73 is almost exactly the same sentence as Ezra 3:1. It leads over to the great assembly in the seventh month (Chapter 8).

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 8

Ezra reads the law aloud

The great assembly at the Water Gate VERSES 1–8

1 All the people came together as one man.
They gathered in the open square in front of the Water Gate.
They asked Ezra the scribe to bring the book of the law of Moses.
The LORD had given this law to Israel.
2 So Ezra the priest brought the law to the assembly.
Men and women were there, and everyone who could listen and understand.
It was the first day of the seventh month.
3 Ezra read from the book in the open square in front of the Water Gate.
He read from early morning until noon.
The men and the women and everyone who could understand were there.
All the people listened closely to the book of the law.
4 Ezra the scribe stood on a wooden platform.
They had made it for this purpose.
On his right stood Mattithiah, Shema, Anaiah, Uriah, Hilkiah, and Maaseiah.
On his left stood Pedaiah, Mishael, Malchijah, Hashum, Hashbaddanah, Zechariah, and Meshullam.
5 Ezra opened the book where all the people could see it.
He was standing higher than all the people.
When he opened it, all the people stood up.
6 Then Ezra praised the LORD, the great God.
All the people lifted up their hands and answered, "Amen, Amen!"
They bowed their heads.
They worshiped the LORD with their faces to the ground.

7 The Levites helped the people understand the law.
Among them were Jeshua, Bani, Sherebiah, Jamin,
Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah, Maaseiah,
Kelita, Azariah, Jozabad, Hanan, and Pelaiah.
The people stayed in their places.
8 They read clearly from the book, from the law of God.
They explained the meaning.
So the people understood what was read.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important moments in the book of Nehemiah. The people themselves ask Ezra to read the law aloud. They are hungry for God's word.

The first day of the seventh month is a feast day (today: Rosh Hashanah, the Jewish New Year).

Men and women and all the children who can understand listen. God's word is for everyone.

They listen for six hours, from morning until midday.

When Ezra opens the book, the people stand up, out of reverence for God's word. To this day people in synagogues and churches stand up when the Bible is read aloud.

Verse 8 is important: it is not enough only to read God's word aloud. It must also be explained, so that people understand it. Maybe the Hebrew text was also translated into Aramaic, because after the exile many no longer understood Hebrew well. That is exactly what this plain-language Bible is about too.

"The joy of the LORD is your strength" VERSES 9–12

9 Then Nehemiah the governor, Ezra the priest and scribe,
and the Levites who taught the people spoke to all the people.
They said, "Today is a holy day for the LORD your God.
Don't be sad, and don't cry."
They said this because all the people were crying when they heard the words of the law.
10 Then he said to them,
"Go home.
Eat rich food and drink sweet drinks.
Send some of it to people who have nothing ready.
Today is a holy day for our Lord.
Don't be sad.
The joy of the LORD is your strength."
11 The Levites calmed all the people.
They said, "Be quiet, because the day is holy.
Don't be sad."
12 Then all the people went home.
They ate and drank and sent food to others.
They celebrated with great joy.
They had understood the words that were told to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When the people hear the law, they weep. They notice how far they are from God's will.

But Nehemiah and Ezra say: today is a feast day! Today is not a day for weeping, but for celebrating.

"The joy of the LORD is your strength": this is one of the best-known sentences of the Bible. Some Bibles translate it as "joy in the LORD". Both are possible: joy about God gives strength. And God's own joy about his people gives strength. The strength for a life with God does not come from feelings of guilt, but from joy.

Important: "Send some of it to people who have nothing ready." A feast includes not forgetting the poor. No one is to go hungry on a feast day.

Verse 12: they celebrate a great feast of joy. "They had understood the words that were told to them." Understanding leads to joy.

The feast of booths VERSES 13–18

13 On the second day the heads of the families of all the people came together with Ezra the scribe.
The priests and the Levites came too.
They wanted to study the words of the law.
14 In the law they found what the LORD had commanded through Moses:
The people of Israel should live in booths during the feast in the seventh month.
Booths are simple huts made of branches.
15 And they should announce this in all their cities and in Jerusalem:
"Go out to the mountains.
Get olive branches, wild olive branches, myrtle branches, palm branches,
and branches of leafy trees.
Make booths with them, as it is written."
16 So the people went out and brought branches.
They made booths for themselves.
Each one made a booth on the roof of his house,
or in their courtyards, or in the courtyards of God's house,
or in the open square of the Water Gate,
or in the open square of the Gate of Ephraim.
17 The whole assembly of those who had come back from captivity made booths.
They lived in the booths.
The people of Israel had not done this since the days of Joshua the son of Nun.
There was very great joy.
18 He read from the book of the law of God every day, from the first day to the last day.
They kept the feast for seven days.
On the eighth day there was a special holy meeting, as the law commands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The leaders want to learn even more. While reading, they discover the feast of booths (Leviticus 23:33–43).

The feast of booths recalls the 40 years in the wilderness, when the people lived in tents and God provided for them. For those who had returned it had a special meaning: they too had gone through a kind of wilderness and had experienced God's care.

The people of Israel "had not done this since the days of Joshua": the feast had already been celebrated (Ezra 3:4). But not like this, with the whole people in booths. This way of celebrating was completely new.

To this day Jews celebrate the feast of booths (Sukkot) and build huts out of branches.

Reading the Bible is not boring, but leads to "very great joy".

Chapter 9

The great prayer of repentance

A day of confession VERSES 1–5

1 On the twenty-fourth day of this month the people of Israel came together.
They were fasting.
They wore sackcloth and had dirt on their heads.
Sackcloth is rough cloth that people wore when they mourned.
2 The descendants of Israel separated themselves from all foreigners.
They stood and confessed their sins and the sins of their ancestors.
3 They stood up in their places.
For a fourth part of the day they read from the book of the law of the LORD their God.
For another fourth part of the day they confessed their sins and worshiped the LORD their God.
4 Then some Levites stood up on the stairs:
Jeshua, Bani, Kadmiel, Shebaniah, Bunni, Sherebiah, Bani, and Chenani.
They cried out loudly to the LORD their God.
5 Then these Levites spoke:
Jeshua, Kadmiel, Bani, Hashabneiah, Sherebiah, Hodiah, Shebaniah, and Pethahiah.
They said, "Stand up and praise the LORD your God!
He is God from everlasting to everlasting.
May your glorious name be praised!
It is higher than all blessing and praise.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Three weeks after the feast of joy (Chapter 8) comes a day of repentance. Both have their time: joy and honest confession.

Sackcloth and dirt on the head were signs of mourning and regret.

"A fourth part of the day" is about three hours. For three hours they read in God's word, for three hours they confess and pray.

"They separated themselves from all foreigners": this day was a confession of Israel's guilt. That is why the Israelites stayed among themselves.

The prayer that follows is one of the longest prayers of the Bible. It tells the whole history of Israel as a story of God's faithfulness and the people's unfaithfulness.

God the Creator and the God of Abraham VERSES 6–8

6 You alone are the LORD.
You made the heavens, even the highest heavens, with all their army.
You made the earth and everything on it,
the seas and everything in them.
You keep them all alive.
The army of heaven worships you.
7 You are the LORD, the God who chose Abram.
You brought him out of Ur of the Chaldees.
You gave him the name Abraham.
8 You saw that his heart was faithful to you.
You made a covenant with him.
You promised to give his offspring the land of the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Amorite,
the Perizzite, the Jebusite, and the Girgashite.
And you have kept your promise, because you are righteous.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The prayer begins at the very beginning: with creation. God has made everything and keeps everything alive. "The army of heaven" here means the angels.

Verse 8: A covenant is a binding agreement.

Then Abraham: God chose him and promised him a land. And God kept his promise. "You are righteous": God is faithful. Righteous means: always doing what is right.

God saves from Egypt VERSES 9–15

9 "You saw how our ancestors suffered in Egypt.
You heard them cry out at the Red Sea.
10 You did signs and wonders against Pharaoh,
against all his servants, and against all the people of his land.
You knew how proudly they treated our ancestors.
So you made a name for yourself that lasts until today.
11 You divided the sea in front of them.
They went through the middle of the sea on dry land.
But you threw the men who chased them into the deep water,
like a stone into mighty waters.
12 During the day you led them with a pillar of cloud.
At night you led them with a pillar of fire.
It gave them light on the way they should go.
13 "You came down on Mount Sinai.
You spoke with them from heaven.
You gave them right rules and true laws,
good statutes and commandments.
14 You taught them about your holy Sabbath.
Through Moses your servant you gave them commandments, statutes, and a law.
15 When they were hungry, you gave them bread from the sky.
When they were thirsty, you brought water out of the rock for them.
You told them to go in and take the land.
You had promised with an oath to give it to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the story from Exodus is summed up: the misery in Egypt, the wonders, the crossing through the sea, the pillar of cloud and fire, the law at Sinai, the manna and the water from the rock.

God sees, hears, saves, leads, teaches and provides.

"Bread from the sky": later Jesus calls himself "the bread of life" (John 6:35) and "the living bread that came down from heaven" (John 6:51).

Unfaithfulness in the wilderness and God's patience
VERSES 16–21

16 "But they and our ancestors became proud.
They were stubborn
and did not listen to your commandments.
17 They refused to obey.
They did not remember the wonders you had done among them.
They were stubborn.
In their rebellion they chose a leader to take them back to slavery.
But you are a God who is ready to forgive.
You are gracious and merciful.
You are slow to become angry.
Your loving kindness is great.
You did not leave them.
18 They even made a metal statue of a calf for themselves.
They said, 'This is your God who brought you up out of Egypt.'
They spoke terrible words against you.
19 But you have so much mercy.
You did not leave them in the desert.
During the day the pillar of cloud stayed over them and led them on the way.
At night the pillar of fire stayed too.
It gave them light on the way they should go.
20 You gave them your good Spirit to teach them.
You did not stop giving them manna to eat.
You gave them water when they were thirsty.
21 "For 40 years you took care of them in the desert.
They did not lack anything.
Their clothes did not wear out.
Their feet did not swell.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the dark side: the people were ungrateful. They even wanted to go back to slavery in Egypt (Numbers 14:4). They worshiped a golden calf (Exodus 32).

But verse 17 is the heart of the whole prayer: "You are a God who is ready to forgive. You are gracious and merciful. You are slow to become angry. Your loving kindness is great." God himself said these words about himself (Exodus 34:6). They come again and again in the Bible.

In spite of everything God did not abandon them. He went on leading them and gave them his Spirit, food and water. For 40 years.

The good land
VERSES 22–25

22 You gave them kingdoms and peoples.
You gave each group its own share.
So they took the land of Sihon, the king of Heshbon, and the land of Og, the king of Bashan.
23 You made their children as many as the stars in the sky.
You brought them into the land.
You had told their ancestors that they would go in and take it.
24 "So the children went in and took the land.
You defeated the people who lived in the land, the Canaanites, in front of them.
You gave them into their hands,
together with their kings and the peoples of the land.
Your people could do with them whatever they wanted.
25 They captured strong cities and a rich land.
They took over houses full of all kinds of good things.
They took over wells that others had dug, vineyards, olive groves, and many fruit trees.
So they ate until they were full and became fat.
They enjoyed your great goodness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the time of Moses and Joshua is summed up (Numbers 21; Joshua). God fulfilled the promise to Abraham.

The land was rich. They even received houses and vineyards that they had not built themselves (compare Deuteronomy 6:10–11).

The conquest of Canaan is one of the hard subjects of the Bible. The prayer tells it from Israel's point of view, as God's gift. See the explanations in the book of Joshua.

"They ate until they were full and became fat": that sounds good. But it is also a warning. When things went well, the people forgot God (compare Deuteronomy 32:15).

The same cycle again and again
VERSES 26–31

26 "But they did not obey.
They rebelled against you.
They threw your law behind their backs.
Your prophets warned them and wanted to bring them back to you.
But they killed your prophets.
They spoke terrible words against you.
27 So you gave them into the hands of their enemies.
Their enemies made them suffer.
When they were in trouble, they cried out to you.
You heard them from heaven.
You have so much mercy.
So you gave them saviors.
These saviors rescued them from the hands of their enemies.
28 But as soon as they had peace, they did evil before you again.
So you left them in the hands of their enemies.
Their enemies ruled over them.
But when they turned back and cried out to you,
you heard them from heaven.
Many times you rescued them because of your mercy.
29 You warned them to bring them back to your law.
But they were proud.
They did not listen to your commandments.
They sinned against your rules.
Whoever keeps these rules will live by them.
But they turned their backs on you.
They were stubborn and would not listen.
30 For many years you were patient with them.
You warned them by your Spirit through your prophets.
But they would not listen.
So you gave them into the hands of the peoples of the lands.
31 "But you have so much mercy.
You did not destroy them completely.
You did not leave them.
You are a gracious and merciful God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the time of the judges and the kings is summed up. It is always the same cycle:

1. The people turn away from God.
2. Enemies come and oppress them.
3. The people cry to God.
4. God hears and sends saviors.
5. There is rest – and then everything begins all over again.

God saved them "many times". His patience was huge.

Verse 29: "Whoever keeps these rules will live by them." This quotes Leviticus 18:5. God's commandments are not there to make life hard, but to give life.

Verse 31: even the exile was not the end. God did not completely give up his people.

The request VERSES 32–37

32 Now, our God, you are the great, mighty, and awesome God.
You keep your covenant and your loving kindness.
So much hardship has come on us,
on our kings, our princes, our priests, our prophets,
our ancestors, and all your people.
It started in the time of the kings of Assyria, and it goes on until today.
Please don't think that all this hardship is a small thing.
33 You have been fair in everything that has happened to us.
You have been faithful, but we have done evil.
34 Our kings, our princes, our priests, and our ancestors did not keep your law.
They did not pay attention to your commandments.
They did not listen when you warned them.
35 They had their own kingdom.
You gave them great goodness.
You gave them a large and rich land.
But even then they did not serve you.
They did not turn away from their evil deeds.
36 "Look, today we are slaves.
You gave this land to our ancestors so they could eat its fruit and its good things.
But look, we are slaves in it.
37 The land produces a big harvest.
But the harvest goes to the kings you have put over us because of our sins.
They rule over our bodies and over our animals as they please.
We are in great distress.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only now, at the end, comes a request. And it is very careful: "Please don't think that all this hardship is a small thing." They ask God to see their suffering.

They admit: God was just. The guilt lies with us.

Verses 36–37 describe the situation under the Persians honestly: they are back in their own land, but they are not free. The taxes go to the foreign king. That is the bitter reality.

A firm covenant VERSE 38

38 In spite of all this, we are making a firm covenant and writing it down.
Our princes, our Levites, and our priests are sealing it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles this verse is already Nehemiah 10:1. That is why the verses of Chapter 10 there are shifted by one.

After the confession comes the decision: we want to do things differently now. We make a covenant and sign it.

Real turning back does not stop at words. It leads to deeds.

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 10

The people sign the covenant

The priests VERSES 1–8

1 These are the men who put their seal on the covenant:
Nehemiah the governor, the son of Hacaliah, and Zedekiah,
2 Seraiah, Azariah, Jeremiah,
3 Pashhur, Amariah, Malchijah,
4 Hattush, Shebaniah, Malluch,
5 Harim, Meremoth, Obadiah,
6 Daniel, Ginnethon, Baruch,
7 Meshullam, Abijah, Mijamin,
8 Maaziah, Bilgai, and Shemaiah.
These were the priests.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles these verses are 10:2–9. The whole chapter is shifted by one there.

Nehemiah signs first. The leader sets a good example.

The names of the priests are probably names of priestly families, not of single persons. Many of them also appear in Chapter 12.

The Levites VERSES 9–13

9 The Levites:
Jeshua the son of Azaniah, Binnui of the sons of Henadad, Kadmiel,
10 and their brothers Shebaniah, Hodiah, Kelita, Pelaiah, Hanan,
11 Mica, Rehob, Hashabiah,
12 Zaccur, Sherebiah, Shebaniah,
13 Hodiah, Bani, and Beninu.

The heads of the people VERSES 14–27

14 The heads of the people:
Parosh, Pahathmoab, Elam, Zattu, Bani,
15 Bunni, Azgad, Bebai,
16 Adonijah, Bigvai, Adin,

17 Ater, Hezekiah, Azzur,
18 Hodiah, Hashum, Bezai,
19 Hariph, Anathoth, Nobai,
20 Magpiash, Meshullam, Hezir,
21 Meshezabel, Zadok, Jaddua,
22 Pelatiah, Hanan, Anaiah,
23 Hoshea, Hananiah, Hasshub,
24 Hallohesh, Pilha, Shobek,
25 Rehum, Hashabnah, Maaseiah,
26 Ahiah, Hanan, Anan,
27 Malluch, Harim, and Baanah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

We know many of these names from the lists of those who returned (Ezra 2; Nehemiah 7). They are the families who had come back.

In all, 84 men sign: priests, Levites and heads. They stand for the whole people.

The promise VERSES 28–29

28 Then there was the rest of the people:
the priests, the Levites, the gatekeepers, the singers, and the temple servants.
There were also all those who had separated themselves from the peoples of the lands
to follow the law of God.
Their wives, their sons, and their daughters were there too,
everyone who was able to know and understand.
29 They all joined their brothers and their nobles.
They made a promise with an oath.
They called a curse on themselves if they broke it.
They promised to live by God's law.
God gave this law through Moses, the servant of God.
They promised to keep and do all the commandments of the LORD our Lord,
and all his rules and his statutes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Not only the leaders, but everyone takes part: men, women and children who are old enough to understand.

People from other peoples could also belong, if they had separated themselves "to follow the law of God".

An oath with a curse: they promise solemnly. And they say: if we break the promise, may a curse strike us. That is how seriously they mean it.

The individual promises VERSES 30–39

30 We promised not to give our daughters in marriage to the peoples of the land.
And we promised not to take their daughters as wives for our sons.
31 The peoples of the land might bring goods or grain to sell on the Sabbath day.
Then we would not buy from them on the Sabbath or on any other holy day.
Every seventh year we would not harvest the crops.
And in that year we would cancel every debt.
32 We also made rules for ourselves.
Each year every one of us would give a third of a shekel for the service in the house of our God.
33 The money is for the holy bread,
for the daily grain offering and the daily burnt offering,
for the Sabbaths, the new moons, and the set feasts,
for the holy things,
for the sin offerings that make atonement for Israel,
and for all the work in the house of our God.
Atonement means: the guilt is taken away, and people are at peace with God again.
34 We, the priests, the Levites, and the people, cast lots for the wood offering.
In this way we decided which family would bring wood to the house of our God, and when.
Each year at set times they would bring it.
It would be burned on the altar of the LORD our God, as it is written in the law.
35 Each year we would bring the first harvest of our fields to the LORD's house.
We would also bring the first fruit of every kind of tree.
36 We would bring the firstborn of our sons and of our animals,
as it is written in the law.
We would bring the firstborn of our cattle and of our sheep and goats
to the house of our God, to the priests who serve there.
37 We would bring the first of our dough and our wave offerings,
the fruit of every kind of tree, the new wine, and the oil.
We would bring them to the priests, to the storerooms of the house of our God.
And we would bring a tenth of the harvest of our fields to the Levites.
The Levites collect this tenth in all our farming towns.
38 A priest from the family of Aaron will be with the Levites when they collect the tenth.
The Levites will take a tenth of everything they collect and bring it up to the house of our God, to the storerooms of the treasure house.
39 The people of Israel and the descendants of Levi will bring the wave offering of grain, new wine, and oil to the storerooms.
The objects of the holy place are kept there.
The priests who serve, the gatekeepers, and the singers are there too.
We will not abandon the house of our God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The covenant becomes very concrete. It is about everyday life:

– Marriage: no marriages with people who worship foreign gods (see the explanation on Ezra 10).

– Sabbath: not to buy anything on the day of rest, even when the traders come.

– Sabbath year: to let the land rest every seventh year and to cancel debts. That protects the poor (compare Chapter 5).

– Temple: money, wood, first fruits and tithes for worship.

A third of a shekel was a small amount. Everyone could give that.

Someone had to bring the wood for the altar. The fire on the altar was never to go out (Leviticus 6:13). The families took turns.

"The firstborn of our sons": the firstborn sons were dedicated to God and then "bought back" with money (Numbers 18:15–16). It was never about human sacrifice.

The last sentence sums everything up: "We will not abandon the house of our God." Sadly, Chapter 13 shows that they did not keep the promise for long.

NEHEMIAH

Chapter 11

Who lives in Jerusalem

Every tenth person moves to Jerusalem VERSES 1–3

1 The leaders of the people lived in Jerusalem.
The rest of the people cast lots.
In this way they chose one tenth of the people to live in Jerusalem, the holy city.
The other nine tenths stayed in the other cities.
2 Some men offered on their own to live in Jerusalem.
The people blessed all of them.
3 Here are the leaders of the province who lived in Jerusalem.
In the cities of Judah, everyone lived on his own land in their cities.
These were the Israelites, the priests, the Levites, the temple servants,
and the descendants of Solomon's servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the problem from Nehemiah 7:4 is solved: Jerusalem had a wall, but too few people living in it.

One tenth of the people moves to Jerusalem, like a "tithe" for God.

Why didn't everyone want to live in Jerusalem? The city was still in ruins and dangerous. The people in the country had their fields and houses. Moving to Jerusalem meant making sacrifices.

That is why the volunteers are blessed. The people honor those who put themselves out for the community.

From Judah and Benjamin VERSES 4–9

4 Some of the descendants of Judah and of Benjamin lived in Jerusalem.
Of the descendants of Judah:
Athaiah the son of Uzziah, the son of Zechariah, the son of Amariah,
the son of Shephatiah, the son of Mahalalel, of the descendants of Perez,
5 and Maaseiah the son of Baruch, the son of Colhozeh, the son of Hazaiah,
the son of Adaiah, the son of Joiarib, the son of Zechariah, the son of the Shilonite.
6 All the descendants of Perez who lived in Jerusalem were 468 brave men.
7 These are the descendants of Benjamin:
Sallu the son of Meshullam, the son of Joed, the son of Pedaiah,
the son of Kolaiah, the son of Maaseiah, the son of Ithiel, the son of Jeshaiah.
8 After him came Gabbai and Sallai.
There were 928 men.
9 Joel the son of Zichri was in charge of them.
Judah the son of Hassenuah was second in command over the city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Perez was a son of Judah (Genesis 38:29). David also descended from him (Ruth 4:18–22).

"The Shilonite" here probably means a descendant of Shelah, another son of Judah.

This list is similar to 1 Chronicles 9, but it is not quite the same.

The priests VERSES 10–14

10 Of the priests:
Jedaiah the son of Joiarib, Jachin,
11 Seraiah the son of Hilkiah, the son of Meshullam, the son of Zadok,
the son of Meraioth, the son of Ahitub, the leader of God's house.
12 Their brothers did the work in the temple.
There were 822 of them.
Then there was Adaiah the son of Jeroham, the son of Pelaliah, the son of Amzi,
the son of Zechariah, the son of Pashhur, the son of Malchijah,
13 and his brothers, who were heads of families.
There were 242 of them.
Then there was Amashsai the son of Azarel, the son of Ahzai,
the son of Meshillemoth, the son of Immer,
14 and their brothers, who were brave, strong men.
There were 128 of them.
Zabdiel, the son of Haggedolim, was in charge of them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

More than 1,100 priests lived in Jerusalem, near the temple.

"Haggedolim" means "the great ones". Maybe it is not a name, but a title: Zabdiel, from one of the great families.

The Levites, singers and gatekeepers VERSES 15–21

15 Of the Levites:
Shemaiah the son of Hasshub, the son of Azrikam, the son of Hashabiah, the son of Bunni.
16 There were also Shabbethai and Jozabad, two of the leaders of the Levites.
They were in charge of the outside work of God's house.
17 There was Mattaniah the son of Mica, the son of Zabdi, the son of Asaph.
He was the leader who started the prayer of thanks.
There was Bakbukiah, who was second among his brothers.
And there was Abda the son of Shammua, the son of Galal, the son of Jeduthun.
18 There were 284 Levites in all in the holy city.

19 The gatekeepers were Akkub, Talmon, and their brothers.
They kept watch at the gates.
There were 172 of them.
20 The rest of the Israelites, the priests, and the Levites lived in all the cities of Judah.
Each one lived on the land his family had received.
21 The temple servants lived on the Ophel hill.
Ziha and Gishpa were in charge of the temple servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mattaniah began the song of praise at prayer. He was a leading singer, like a cantor today.

The "outside work" was probably tasks outside the actual temple service, for example managing the gifts.

Other people in charge VERSES 22–24

22 Uzzi was in charge of the Levites in Jerusalem.
He was the son of Bani, the son of Hashabiah, the son of Mattaniah, the son of Mica.
He was one of the descendants of Asaph.
They were the singers who were responsible for the service in God's house.
23 The king had given an order about them.
The singers received a fixed supply of what they needed each day.
24 Pethahiah the son of Meshezabel was a descendant of Zerah, the son of Judah.
He was the king's helper in all matters that had to do with the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Persian king even provided for the singers in the temple. He supported worship in Jerusalem (compare Ezra 7:24).

Pethahiah was probably a representative of the Jews at the Persian court, a kind of ambassador.

In the villages of Judah and Benjamin VERSES 25–36

25 Now about the villages and their fields:
Some of the descendants of Judah lived in Kiriath Arba and its towns,
in Dibon and its towns, in Jekabzeel and its villages,
26 in Jeshua, in Moladah, in Beth Pelet,
27 in Hazar Shual, in Beersheba and its towns,
28 in Ziklag, in Meconah and its towns,
29 in En Rimmon, in Zorah, in Jarmuth,
30 in Zanoah, Adullam, and their villages,
in Lachish and its fields, and in Azekah and its towns.
So they lived everywhere from Beersheba to the valley of Hinnom.
31 The descendants of Benjamin lived from Geba onward, at Michmash and Aija, and at Bethel and its towns,
32 at Anathoth, Nob, Ananiah,
33 Hazor, Ramah, Gittaim,
34 Hadid, Zeboim, Neballat,
35 Lod, and Ono, the valley of craftsmen.
36 Some groups of the Levites from Judah settled in the land of Benjamin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Kiriath Arba is the old name of Hebron (Joshua 14:15).

"Its towns": the Hebrew says "its daughters". These are smaller places that belonged to a larger city.

"From Beersheba to the valley of Hinnom": from the south right up to Jerusalem.

We know many of these places from earlier books of the Bible. Those who returned live again in the places of their ancestors. God's promise to bring them back has been fulfilled.

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 12

The dedication of the wall

The priests and Levites of the first return VERSES 1–9

1 Here are the priests and the Levites who came up to Jerusalem
with Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel and with Jeshua:
Seraiah, Jeremiah, Ezra,
2 Amariah, Malluch, Hattush,
3 Shecaniah, Rehum, Meremoth,
4 Iddo, Ginnethoi, Abijah,
5 Mijamin, Maadiah, Bilgah,
6 Shemaiah, Joiarib, Jedaiah,
7 Sallu, Amok, Hilkiah, and Jedaiah.
In the days of Jeshua, these were the leaders of the priests and of their brothers.
8 The Levites were Jeshua, Binnui, Kadmiel, Sherebiah, Judah, and Mattaniah.
Mattaniah and his brothers were in charge of the songs of thanks.
9 Their brothers Bakbukiah and Unno stood close to them during the service.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the book jumps back to the first return, almost 100 years earlier (Ezra 2).

The Ezra in verse 1 is not the Ezra from Ezra 7. He is a priest with the same name.

"Close to them": the Hebrew says "opposite them". The singers probably stood opposite each other in two choirs and sang in turns.

The high priests VERSES 10–11

10 Jeshua became the father of Joiakim,
Joiakim became the father of Eliashib,
Eliashib became the father of Joiada,
11 Joiada became the father of Jonathan,
and Jonathan became the father of Jaddua.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the list of the high priests over six generations, from about 538 to after 400 BC.

Eliashib was high priest in the time of Nehemiah (Nehemiah 3:1; 13:4). "Jonathan" is called "Johanan" in verse 22. His name is also found in a letter from Elephantine in Egypt.

The priestly families under Joiakim VERSES 12–21

12 In the days of Joiakim, these priests were the heads of the families:
for Seraiah: Meraiah; for Jeremiah: Hananiah;
13 for Ezra: Meshullam; for Amariah: Jehohanan;
14 for Malluchi: Jonathan; for Shebaniah: Joseph;
15 for Harim: Adna; for Meraioth: Helkai;
16 for Iddo: Zechariah; for Ginnethon: Meshullam;
17 for Abijah: Zichri; for Miniamin; for Moadiah: Piltai;
18 for Bilgah: Shammua; for Shemaiah: Jehonathan;
19 for Joiarib: Mattenai; for Jedaiah: Uzzi;
20 for Sallai: Kallai; for Amok: Eber;
21 for Hilkiah: Hashabiah; for Jedaiah: Nethanel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the next generation each priestly family had a new head. The list shows: the service went on, from generation to generation.

With "Miniamin" the name of the head is missing in the Hebrew text.

The records and the Levites VERSES 22–26

22 In the days of Eliashib, Joiada, Johanan, and Jaddua,
the heads of the Levite families were written down.
The heads of the priest families were written down too,
during the rule of Darius the Persian.
23 The heads of the families of the descendants of Levi
were written in the book of the chronicles.
The list goes until the days of Johanan the son of Eliashib.
24 The leaders of the Levites were Hashabiah, Sherebiah,
and Jeshua the son of Kadmiel.
Their brothers stood close to them.
They praised God and gave thanks,
as David, the man of God, had commanded.
One group answered the other group, section next to section.
25 Mattaniah, Bakbukiah, Obadiah, Meshullam, Talmon,
and Akkub were gatekeepers.
They kept watch at the storerooms by the gates.
26 All these served in the days of Joiakim the son of Jeshua, the son of Jozadak.
They also served in the days of Nehemiah the governor
and of Ezra the priest and scribe.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Darius the Persian" is probably Darius II (423–404 BC). So this note was added somewhat later.

"Section next to section": the choirs stood next to each other or opposite each other and sang in turns, as David had ordered (1 Chronicles 25).

Getting ready for the dedication VERSES 27–30

27 Then the wall of Jerusalem was dedicated to God.
For this they looked for the Levites in all the places where they lived.
They brought them to Jerusalem to celebrate the dedication with joy.
They gave thanks and sang songs
with cymbals, stringed instruments, and harps.
28 The singers came together
from the area around Jerusalem
and from the villages of the Netophathites.
29 They also came from Beth Gilgal and from the fields of Geba and Azmaveth.
The singers had built villages for themselves around Jerusalem.
30 The priests and the Levites made themselves pure for God.
Then they made the people, the gates, and the wall pure.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wall is not only a building. It is dedicated to God. That is why there is a cleansing: first the priests themselves, then the people, then the gates and the wall.

Two choirs on the wall VERSES 31–42

31 Then I brought the leaders of Judah up onto the wall.
I set up two large choirs.
They gave thanks and walked in a procession.
The first choir went to the right on the wall, toward the Dung Gate.
32 Behind them walked Hoshaiah with half of the leaders of Judah,
33 and Azariah, Ezra, and Meshullam,
34 Judah, Benjamin, Shemaiah, Jeremiah,
35 and some of the priests' sons with trumpets:
Zechariah the son of Jonathan, the son of Shemaiah,
the son of Mattaniah,
the son of Micaiah, the son of Zaccur, the son of Asaph,
36 and his brothers Shemaiah, Azarel, Milalai, Gilalai,
Maai, Nethanel, Judah, and Hanani.
They had the musical instruments of David, the man of God.
Ezra the scribe walked in front of them.
37 At the Spring Gate they went straight up the stairs of the City of David,
where the wall goes up.
They went above David's palace, as far as the Water Gate in the east.
38 The other choir of those who gave thanks went the opposite way.
I followed them with half of the people.
We walked on the wall above the Tower of the Ovens,
as far as the Broad Wall,
39 and above the Gate of Ephraim, by the Old Gate, by the Fish Gate,
by the tower of Hananel and the tower of Hammeah,
as far as the Sheep Gate.
They stopped at the Gate of the Guard.
40 Then both choirs of those who gave thanks took their places in God's house.

I did the same, and so did half of the leaders who were with me.
41 The priests Eliakim, Maaseiah, Miniamin, Micaiah,
Elioenai, Zechariah, and Hananiah were there with trumpets,
42 and also Maaseiah, Shemaiah, Eleazar, Uzzi,
Jehohanan, Malchijah, Elam, and Ezer.
The singers sang loudly.
Jezrahiah was their leader.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What a picture: two great choirs walk on the wall around the city in opposite directions. One is led by Ezra, the other by Nehemiah. They meet at the temple.

The wall Tobiah mocked, saying "a fox ... would break down their stone wall" (Nehemiah 4:3), now carries a whole procession.

The way of the choirs follows the list in Chapter 3, only in the opposite direction.

Great joy VERSE 43

43 On that day they offered many sacrifices.
They were full of joy,
because God had given them great joy.
The women and the children were full of joy too.
The joy in Jerusalem could be heard far away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The word "joy" comes five times in this verse (in Hebrew). It is the high point of the book.

Everyone rejoices: men, women and children. And the joy is so loud that it is heard far away (compare Ezra 3:13).

Providing for the temple service VERSES 44–47

44 On that day men were put in charge of the storerooms.
The treasures, the wave offerings, the first fruits, and the tithes were kept there.
A tithe is a tenth of the harvest.
The law set a share for the priests and the Levites.
The men were to gather these shares from the fields around the cities and bring them into the storerooms.
The people of Judah were glad about the priests and about the Levites who served.
45 The priests and Levites did the work their God had given them.
They took care of the cleansing.
The singers and the gatekeepers did their work too.
They did everything as David and his son Solomon had commanded.
46 Long ago, in the days of David and Asaph,
there was a leader of the singers.
There were songs of praise and songs of thanks to God.
47 In the days of Zerubbabel and in the days of Nehemiah,
all Israel gave the singers and the gatekeepers their shares,
as they needed them each day.
They set apart a share for the Levites.
And the Levites set apart a share for the descendants of Aaron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people gladly provide for those who serve in the temple. "The people of Judah were glad about the priests and about the Levites."

The order of worship continues what David and Solomon began. The old heritage lives on.

NEHEMIAH

CHAPTER 13

Nehemiah's second term in office

The law about Ammonites and Moabites VERSES 1–3

1 On that day they read in the book of Moses so that the people could hear.
And it was found written in it
that an Ammonite and a Moabite should never come into the assembly of God,
2 because they didn't meet the people of Israel with bread and with water,
but hired Balaam against them to curse them.
However, our God turned the curse into a blessing.
3 When they had heard the law,
they separated all the mixed crowd from Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The law is in Deuteronomy 23:3–5. The story of Balaam is in Numbers 22–24.

"God turned the curse into a blessing": Balaam was supposed to curse Israel, but he had to bless it. God can turn even evil into good.

How does this law fit with Ruth the Moabite, who became David's great-grandmother? Jewish interpretation later said: the law applies to men from Moab and Ammon, not to women. Others say: whoever turns completely to the God of Israel, like Ruth, belongs. The Bible itself keeps both side by side.

The prophet Isaiah says later: even foreigners who hold on to the LORD are welcome in God's house, "for my house will be called a house of prayer for all peoples" (Isaiah 56:3–7).

Tobiah in the temple VERSES 4–9

4 Before this, Eliashib the priest,
who was appointed over the rooms of the house of our God,
and who was related to Tobiah,
5 had prepared a great room for him.
Before that, they had stored there the grain offerings, the frankincense, the objects,
and the tithes of the grain, the new wine, and the oil, which were given by command to the Levites, the singers, and the gatekeepers,
and the wave offerings for the priests.
6 But during all this I was not in Jerusalem.
For in the thirty-second year of Artaxerxes king of Babylon
I had gone to the king.

After some time I asked the king for permission to leave,
7 and I came to Jerusalem.
Then I understood the evil that Eliashib had done for Tobiah,
by preparing a room for him in the courts of God's house.
8 It upset me very much.
So I threw all of Tobiah's household goods out of the room.
9 Then I gave orders, and they cleansed the rooms.
And I brought back into them the objects of God's house,
with the grain offerings and the frankincense.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After 12 years (433 BC) Nehemiah had gone back to the king. Later he came to Jerusalem a second time.

While he was away, a lot had gone wrong. The worst thing: the high priest Eliashib had given Nehemiah's enemy Tobiah a place to live in the temple!

Nehemiah acts firmly: he throws Tobiah's furniture out. That recalls Jesus, who drove the traders out of the temple (John 2:13–17).

Artaxerxes is called "king of Babylon" here, because he also ruled over Babylon.

The Levites are provided for again VERSES 10–14

10 I also found out that the portions of the Levites had not been given to them.
So the Levites and the singers, who did the work,
had each run away to his own field.
11 Then I argued with the rulers and said,
"Why is God's house forsaken?"
I gathered the Levites together and put them back in their places.
12 Then all Judah brought the tithe of the grain, the new wine, and the oil
to the storerooms.
13 I made treasurers over the storerooms:
Shelemiah the priest, Zadok the scribe, and of the Levites, Pedaiah.
Next to them was Hanan the son of Zaccur, the son of Mattaniah.
For they were considered faithful,
and their task was to hand out the portions to their brothers.
14 Remember me, my God, for this.
Don't wipe out the good deeds that I have done
for the house of my God and for its services.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people had promised: "We will not abandon the house of our God" (Nehemiah 10:39). But they had stopped giving the tithe. The Levites had to go back to their fields to survive.

Nehemiah's question is still important today: "Why is God's house forsaken?"

He again appoints faithful men. Faithfulness is the most important thing when you handle what belongs to others.

The Sabbath VERSES 15–22

15 In those days I saw men in Judah treading winepresses on the Sabbath,
bringing in sheaves, and loading donkeys
with wine, grapes, figs, and all kinds of loads,
which they brought into Jerusalem on the Sabbath day.
I warned them on the day they sold food.
16 Some men of Tyre also lived there.
They brought in fish and all kinds of goods
and sold them on the Sabbath to the people of Judah,
and in Jerusalem.
17 Then I argued with the nobles of Judah and said to them,
"What is this evil thing that you are doing?
You are making the Sabbath day unholy!
18 Didn't your ancestors do the same?
And didn't our God bring all this disaster on us and on this city?
Yet you are bringing more anger on Israel by making the Sabbath unholy."
19 When it began to get dark at the gates of Jerusalem before the Sabbath,
I commanded that the doors should be shut,
and that they should not be opened until after the Sabbath.
I set some of my servants over the gates,
so that no load would be brought in on the Sabbath day.
20 So the traders and sellers of all kinds of goods
camped outside Jerusalem once or twice.
21 Then I warned them and said to them,
"Why are you staying around the wall?
If you do it again, I will lay hands on you."
From that time on they didn't come on the Sabbath any more.
22 I commanded the Levites to make themselves clean
and to come and guard the gates,
to keep the Sabbath day holy.
Remember me for this also, my God,
and spare me according to the greatness of your loving kindness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The promise about the Sabbath (Nehemiah 10:31) had also been broken. On the day of rest people worked and traded as on any other day.

The Sabbath is a gift of God: a day of rest for everyone, also for servants, foreigners and animals (Deuteronomy 5:12–15). When trade decides everything, this rest is lost.

The Sabbath begins on Friday evening, when it gets dark. That is why Nehemiah shuts the gates when darkness falls.

At the end Nehemiah does not only pray "Remember me", but also: "Spare me." He knows that he himself needs God's grace.

The mixed marriages VERSES 23–29

23 In those days I also saw Jews who had married women of Ashdod, of Ammon, and of Moab.
24 Their children spoke half in the language of Ashdod,
and could not speak the Jews' language,
but only the language of one people or another.

25 I argued with them, cursed them,
struck some of them, and pulled out their hair.
And I made them swear by God:
"You shall not give your daughters to their sons,
nor take their daughters for your sons or for
yourselves.
26 Didn't Solomon king of Israel sin because of such
things?
Among many nations there was no king like him.
He was loved by his God,
and God made him king over all Israel.
Yet foreign women made even him sin.
27 Shall we then listen to you and do all this great evil,
to be unfaithful to our God by marrying foreign
women?"
28 One of the sons of Joiada, the son of Eliashib the high
priest,
was son-in-law to Sanballat the Horonite.
So I chased him away from me.
29 Remember them, my God,
because they have made the priesthood unclean,
and the covenant of the priesthood and of the Levites.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The third promise from Chapter 10 had also been broken.

Nehemiah's concern: the children could no longer speak Hebrew. So they could no longer understand God's word either. Faith was in danger of being lost within one generation.

He reminds them of Solomon: even the wisest king was led into idol worship by foreign wives (1 Kings 11:1–8).

Nehemiah reacts very violently. He hits people and pulls out their hair. The Bible reports this honestly, without praising it directly. Today Jews and Christians say: violence is no way to force faith. Nehemiah too was a human being with faults.

A grandson of the high priest had married the daughter of Nehemiah's archenemy Sanballat. That was especially bad, because by law the high priest was only allowed to marry a woman from Israel (Leviticus 21:14).

On the question of mixed marriages, see also the detailed explanation on Ezra 10.

Nehemiah's last prayer VERSES 30–31

30 So I cleansed them from all foreigners,
and I set the duties for the priests and for the Levites,
each one in his work,
31 and for the wood offering at set times, and for the first
fruits.
Remember me, my God, for good.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book ends with a short prayer: "Remember me, my God, for good!" Nehemiah has done a lot for God and the people. But at the end he does not trust in what he has achieved, but in God remembering him.

The end is not triumphant. The people have broken their promises. Nehemiah had to clean up again. That shows: people alone cannot keep the covenant with God for good. That is why the prophets speak of a "new covenant", in which God writes his law on the heart (Jeremiah 31:31–34). Christians see this new covenant fulfilled in Jesus.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Nehemiah?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A man who prays and acts: Nehemiah, the cupbearer of the Persian king, hears about the misery of Jerusalem. He weeps, fasts and prays. Then he bravely asks the king and goes to Jerusalem.

The wall (Chapters 1–7): Everyone helps to build: priests and goldsmiths, men and women. In spite of mockery, threats, exhaustion and traps, the wall is finished in only 52 days. "Each one did the work with one of his hands and held his weapon with the other."

Justice (Chapter 5): Nehemiah fights for the poor, who are exploited by their rich brothers. He himself gives up his privileges.

God's word (Chapters 8–10): Ezra reads the law aloud. The people weep, then they celebrate: "The joy of the LORD is your strength." A great prayer of repentance tells the whole story of God's faithfulness. The people sign a covenant.

The dedication (Chapters 11–12): People live in Jerusalem again. Two choirs walk along the wall. The joy is heard far away.

The failure (Chapter 13): When Nehemiah is away, the people break their promises. Nehemiah has to clean up again.

What we learn: Praying and working belong together. God helps with great tasks. But walls and promises alone do not change hearts. That needs God's grace.

Short prayers: Nehemiah often prays very briefly, in the middle of everyday life: "Strengthen my hands!" "Remember me, my God, for good!" We can pray like that today too.

What comes next? The book of Esther tells a story from the same time, but not in Jerusalem. It takes place at the court of the Persian king in Susa.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 17 OF 66

ESTHER

10 CHAPTERS

ESTHER

Chapter 1

Queen Vashti says no

Before we begin: What is the book of Esther?

The book of Esther tells an exciting story at the court of the Persian king in Susa.

It takes place around 480 BC, between the dedication of the temple (Ezra 6) and Ezra's arrival in Jerusalem (Ezra 7). At that time many Jews did not live in Jerusalem, but scattered over the whole Persian Empire.

The main characters:

– Esther, a young Jewish woman who becomes queen.

– Mordecai, her cousin, who brought her up.

– Haman, a powerful official who wants to kill all the Jews.

– King Ahasuerus (Xerxes I).

What is special: in the Hebrew book of Esther the name of God does not appear a single time. And yet you notice that God guides everything in the background. Many "coincidences" lead to the rescue of the people.

There is also a Greek version of the book with additional parts, in which people pray and God is named. These additions are in Catholic Bibles, and in Protestant Bibles among the Apocrypha. This edition follows the Hebrew text.

The book explains the origin of the Jewish feast of Purim, which is still celebrated joyfully today.

Some parts of the story are told in an exaggerated way, almost like a satire. The mighty king often appears vain and easy to influence. That is part of the style of the book.

A huge feast VERSES 1–9

1 This happened in the days of Ahasuerus.
This is the Ahasuerus who reigned from India to Ethiopia,
over 127 provinces.
2 In those days King Ahasuerus sat on the throne of his kingdom
in the fortress of Susa.
3 In the third year of his reign
he gave a feast for all his princes and his servants.
The army of Persia and Media, the nobles and the princes of the provinces were before him.
4 He showed the riches of his glorious kingdom
and the honor of his splendid majesty for many days,
180 days.
5 When these days were over,
the king gave a feast of seven days for all the people who were present in the fortress of Susa,
both great and small,
in the court of the garden of the king's palace.
6 There were hangings of white and blue material,
fastened with cords of fine linen and purple to silver rings and marble pillars.
The couches were of gold and silver,
on a floor of red, white, yellow, and black marble.
7 They served drinks in golden cups of different kinds,
and royal wine in great amounts, as the king could well afford.
8 According to the law, no one was forced to drink.
For the king had told all the officials of his house
to let each man do as he pleased.
9 Queen Vashti also gave a feast for the women
in the royal house which belonged to King Ahasuerus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahasuerus is the Hebrew name for the Persian king Xerxes I (486–465 BC). His empire was huge: from India in the east to Cush (south of Egypt) in the west.

The text says "Ethiopia". In Hebrew it is "Cush", which means the area of Cush.

The "third year" is about 483 BC. Maybe at this feast the king was planning the great war against Greece, which he then lost.

A feast of 180 days! And then another week for the whole city. The king wants to show how rich and powerful he is.

The description of the palace is very detailed. Archaeologists have dug up the palace in Susa. It really was very splendid.

"No one was forced to drink": no one had to drink more than he wanted. At Persian feasts it was sometimes the custom that everyone had to drink along when the king drank.

Vashti refuses VERSES 10–12

10 On the seventh day, when the king was merry with wine,
he commanded Mehuman, Biztha, Harbona, Bigtha, Abagtha, Zethar, and Carcass,
the seven eunuchs who served King Ahasuerus,
11 to bring Queen Vashti before the king wearing the royal crown,
to show the people and the princes her beauty,
for she was beautiful.
12 But Queen Vashti refused to come at the king's command
which the eunuchs brought.
So the king was very angry,
and his anger burned in him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After seven days of celebrating, the king is drunk. He wants to show off his wife like a treasure, in front of a crowd of drunken men.

Vashti says no. The text does not say why. Maybe she wanted to keep her dignity. Many readers admire her courage. She does not let herself be treated like an object.

The most powerful man in the world cannot force his own wife. That is told in an almost comic way.

"Eunuchs": a eunuch was a man who had been castrated. Such men often served in the women's quarters of palaces.

But the Hebrew word can also mean a court official in general.

The advice of the wise men VERSES 13–22

13 Then the king spoke to the wise men, who knew the times.
For it was the king's custom to ask those who knew law and justice.
14 Next to him were Carshena, Shethar, Admatha, Tarshish, Meres, Marsena, and Memucan,
the seven princes of Persia and Media,
who saw the king's face and sat first in the kingdom.
He asked them,
15 "According to the law, what shall we do to Queen Vashti,
because she has not obeyed the command of King Ahasuerus
which the eunuchs brought?"
16 Memucan answered before the king and the princes,
"Vashti the queen has not done wrong only to the king,
but also to all the princes,
and to all the peoples in all the provinces of King Ahasuerus.
17 For this deed of the queen will become known to all women.
It will make them look down on their husbands, when it is said:
'King Ahasuerus commanded Queen Vashti to be brought in before him,
but she didn't come.'
18 Today the princesses of Persia and Media
who have heard of the queen's deed
will tell it to all the king's princes.
This will cause much contempt and anger.
19 If it pleases the king,
let a royal command go out from him,
and let it be written among the laws of the Persians and the Medes,
so that it cannot be changed,
that Vashti may never again come before King Ahasuerus.
And let the king give her royal position to another woman who is better than she.
20 When the king's decree is announced throughout all his kingdom,
for it is great,
all the wives will give honor to their husbands, both great and small."
21 This advice pleased the king and the princes,
and the king did as Memucan had said.
22 He sent letters into all the king's provinces,
into every province in its own writing,
and to every people in their own language,
that every man should rule his own house
and speak in the language of his own people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king does not know what to do. He asks his advisers. A family quarrel becomes an affair of state.

Memucan exaggerates wildly: if the queen does not obey, all the women in the empire will look down on their husbands!

The "laws of the Persians and the Medes" could not be changed. That becomes very important later in the story (Esther 8:8; compare Daniel 6:8).

The result is ridiculous: a law for the whole world empire that "every man should rule his own house". As if you could order respect by law! The Bible tells this with gentle humor. It does not praise this law.

In other places the Bible teaches that husband and wife should respect and love each other (for example Genesis 2:24; Ephesians 5:21–33).

Through Vashti's removal the place becomes free for Esther. That is how God's hidden plan begins.

ESTHER

CHAPTER 2

Esther becomes queen

The search for a new queen VERSES 1–4

1 Some time later King Ahasuerus was no longer angry.
Then he remembered Vashti.
He remembered what she had done
and what had been decided against her.
2 The king's servants who served him said,
"Let people look for beautiful young virgins for the king.
3 The king should choose officers in all the provinces of his kingdom.
They should gather all the beautiful young virgins
and bring them to the fortress of Susa, to the women's house.
There Hegai will take care of them.
He is the king's eunuch who is in charge of the women.
The young women should receive beauty treatments.
4 Then the young woman who pleases the king the most should become queen instead of Vashti."
The king liked this idea, and he did it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king's anger has calmed down. Maybe he even misses Vashti. But the law cannot be changed (Esther 1:19).

The servants suggest a kind of "beauty contest". For the young women this was no game. They were taken from their families and had no choice. They came into the king's harem. Most of them saw the king only once and afterward lived shut away in the women's house.

The Bible describes these conditions without approving of them.

Mordecai and Esther VERSES 5–7

5 In the fortress of Susa there was a Jew named Mordecai.
He was the son of Jair, the son of Shimei, the son of

Kish.
He was from the tribe of Benjamin.
6 He had been taken away from Jerusalem as a prisoner.
He was among the prisoners who were taken away with Jeconiah, the king of Judah.
Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, had taken them away.
7 Mordecai had raised Hadassah, that is, Esther.
She was the daughter of his uncle.
She had no father and no mother.
The young woman had a lovely figure and was beautiful.
When her father and mother died,
Mordecai took her as his own daughter.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mordecai comes from the tribe of Benjamin, like King Saul, whose father was also called Kish. That becomes important later (Esther 3:1).

Verse 6 probably means: his family (maybe his great-grandfather Kish) had been carried away in 597 BC with King Jeconiah (Jehoiachin). Otherwise Mordecai himself would have been more than 100 years old.

Esther has two names: Hadassah is Hebrew and means "myrtle". Esther is Persian and probably means "star".

Esther is an orphan. Her cousin Mordecai has brought her up like a daughter. He is a loving foster father.

Esther in the women's house VERSES 8–11

8 The king's command and his order were made known.
Many young women were brought to the fortress of Susa.
Hegai took care of them.
Esther was also taken into the king's palace.
Hegai, who was in charge of the women, took care of her.
9 Hegai liked the young woman, and she won his kindness.
He quickly gave her the beauty treatments and her special food.
He gave her seven young women who were chosen for her from the king's palace.
He moved her and her young women to the best place in the women's house.
10 Esther had not told anyone who her people and her relatives were.
Mordecai had told her not to tell anyone.
11 Every day Mordecai walked back and forth in front of the courtyard of the women's house.
He wanted to find out how Esther was doing and what would happen to her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Esther "was taken". She had no choice.

Esther wins the favor of Hegai. The book says this again and again: Esther finds favor with everyone. That recalls Joseph, who also found favor in a foreign land (Genesis 39:4, 21).

Why was Esther to keep it secret that she was Jewish? Maybe there were already prejudices against Jews back then. Mordecai wanted to protect her.

Mordecai worries every day about his foster daughter. He cannot see her, but he comes every day to ask about her.

A year of preparation VERSES 12–14

12 Each young woman had to go through 12 months of beauty treatment.
Then her turn came to go in to King Ahasuerus.
The treatment took this long:
6 months with oil of myrrh,
and 6 months with sweet perfumes and other beauty treatments for women.
13 Then the young woman went to the king.
She was given whatever she asked for
to take with her from the women's house to the king's palace.
14 She went in the evening.
The next morning she came back to the second women's house.
There Shaashgaz took care of her.
He was the king's eunuch who was in charge of the concubines.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
She did not go to the king again,
unless the king liked her very much and called for her by name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A whole year of beauty treatment for one single night. After that each woman became a "concubine" of the king and had to live in the second women's house. A concubine is a wife of lower rank. If the king did not call her again, she never saw him again.

That was a sad fate for many young women. The Bible tells it soberly. It shows the power and the arbitrariness of a king who treats people like property.

Esther becomes queen VERSES 15–18

15 Then Esther's turn came to go in to the king.
Esther was the daughter of Abihail, Mordecai's uncle.
Mordecai had taken her as his daughter.
She did not ask for anything except what Hegai suggested.
Hegai was the king's eunuch who was in charge of the women.
Everyone who saw Esther liked her.
16 So Esther was taken to King Ahasuerus in his royal palace.
It was in the tenth month, the month Tebeth,
in the seventh year of his rule.
17 The king loved Esther more than all the other women.
She won his favor and kindness more than all the other virgins.
So he put the royal crown on her head.
He made her queen instead of Vashti.
18 Then the king gave a great feast for all his princes and his servants.
It was Esther's feast.
He declared a holiday in the provinces.
He gave gifts, as generously as a king can.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Esther is modest. She asks for nothing special, but listens to Hegai's advice.

The month Tebeth is December/January. The seventh year of the king is about 479 BC. So four years lay between

Chapter 1 and Chapter 2. In this time Xerxes fought his war against Greece.

Esther becomes queen. A Jewish orphan now sits on the throne of the greatest empire in the world. No one knows yet why this is so important.

"Holiday": the Hebrew word can also mean "tax relief". It means a release from work or from taxes.

Mordecai saves the king VERSES 19–23

19 The virgins were gathered together a second time.
At that time Mordecai was sitting in the king's gate.
20 Esther still had not told anyone who her relatives and her people were.
Mordecai had commanded her not to.
Esther obeyed Mordecai,
just as she had when he was raising her.
21 In those days Mordecai was sitting in the king's gate.
Two of the king's eunuchs, Bigthan and Teresh, were angry.
They guarded the door.
They tried to attack King Ahasuerus.
22 Mordecai found out about it.
He told Queen Esther.
Esther told the king and said that the news came from Mordecai.
23 The matter was investigated.
It was true.
So both men were hanged on a gallows.
All this was written in the book of the chronicles while the king watched.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Sitting in the king's gate" probably means: Mordecai had an office at court. The gate was the place where officials worked and where justice was done.

Esther is queen now, but she still listens to her foster father. She is faithful to him.

Mordecai saves the king's life. But he gets no reward. The matter is only written in a book and seems forgotten. But in Chapter 6 exactly this book will play a big role. In the story of Esther nothing happens by chance.

"Gallows": word for word it says "wood" or "stake". Among the Persians, condemned people were often impaled on a stake or hanged on it.

Xerxes really was murdered later, in the year 465 BC, by court officials.

ESTHER

CHAPTER 3

Haman wants to kill all the Jews

Mordecai does not bow VERSES 1–6

1 Some time later King Ahasuerus gave Haman a higher rank.
Haman was the son of Hammedatha the Agagite.
The king made him more important
and gave him a seat above all the other princes who were with him.
2 All the king's servants at the king's gate bowed down to Haman and honored him.
The king had commanded them to do this.
But Mordecai did not bow down to him or honor him.
3 Then the king's servants at the king's gate asked Mordecai,
"Why do you disobey the king's command?"
4 They talked to him day after day, but he did not listen to them.
So they told Haman about it.
They wanted to see if Mordecai's reason would be accepted.
Mordecai had told them that he was a Jew.
5 Haman saw that Mordecai did not bow down to him or honor him.
Then Haman was filled with anger.
6 But he thought it was not enough to attack only Mordecai.
People had told him which people Mordecai belonged to.
So Haman wanted to destroy all the Jews in the whole kingdom of Ahasuerus.
They were Mordecai's people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Haman becomes the second most powerful man in the empire.

"Agagite" is an important hint: Agag was a king of the Amalekites, an old enemy of Israel. King Saul, a Benjamite, had fought against him (1 Samuel 15). Now again a Benjamite (Mordecai) and an Agagite (Haman) face each other. The old conflict comes back to life.

Why does Mordecai not bow? The text only says: he had told them "that he was a Jew". Otherwise Jews did bow before kings (for example 2 Samuel 14:4). Maybe Haman was honored like a god. Or Mordecai did not want to bow before an Amalekite.

Haman's reaction is beyond all measure: because of one single man he wants to wipe out a whole people. That is hatred against a whole group of people.

The lot is cast VERSE 7

7 It was the first month, the month Nisan,
in the twelfth year of King Ahasuerus.
They cast Pur in front of Haman.
Pur means the lot.
They cast it for one day after another and for one month after another.
The lot fell on the twelfth month, the month Adar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Pur" is an old word for "lot". Haman has the lot cast to find a "lucky" day for the destruction. The name of the feast of Purim comes from the word "Pur" (plural "Purim") (Esther 9:26).

The lot falls on a day 11 months later. So Haman has to wait a long time. This time will be decisive for the rescue. The

Bible says: "The lot is thrown into the lap, but every decision comes from the LORD" (Proverbs 16:33).

The twelfth year of the king is about 474 BC. Esther has already been queen for five years.

Haman persuades the king VERSES 8–11

8 Then Haman said to King Ahasuerus,
"There is a certain people.
They are scattered and spread out among the other peoples
in all the provinces of your kingdom.
Their laws are different from the laws of all other peoples.
They do not keep the king's laws.
So it is not good for the king to let them stay.
9 If it pleases the king,
let an order be written to destroy them.
Then I will pay 10,000 talents of silver (about 750,000 pounds)
to the men who are in charge of the king's business.
They can put it into the king's treasury."
10 The king took his signet ring off his hand.
He gave it to Haman, the son of Hammedatha the Agagite, the enemy of the Jews.
11 The king said to Haman,
"The silver is given to you, and the people too.
Do with them whatever you think is good."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Haman's speech is a pattern for hatred of Jews, as it runs through history:

– He does not call the people by name.

– He says: they are different from us.

– He mixes truth and lies: the Jews did have their own laws, yes. But that they did not keep the king's laws was a lie. Mordecai had even saved the king's life!

– He turns it into a danger for the state.

Such lies have again and again led to persecution and murder in history, up to the Holocaust, in which 6 million Jews were murdered. The book of Esther warns: this is how it begins.

The Bible says "10,000 talents of silver". A talent is about 75 pounds. That was a huge amount, maybe two thirds of the yearly tax income of the whole empire. Haman probably wanted to take the money from the property of the murdered Jews.

The king does not even ask which people is meant. He gives Haman his signet ring, that is, full power. Indifference can be just as dangerous as hatred.

"The silver is given to you" was probably a polite phrase. Later Esther says that her people has been "sold" (Esther 7:4).

The order to murder VERSES 12–15

12 On the thirteenth day of the first month the king's scribes were called.
They wrote down everything Haman commanded.
They wrote to the king's local governors,
to the governors of every province,
and to the princes of every people.
They wrote to every province in its own writing
and to every people in its own language.
The letter was written in the name of King Ahasuerus.
It was sealed with the king's ring.
13 Messengers took the letters to all the king's provinces.
The letters said:
Destroy, kill, and wipe out all Jews,
young and old, little children and women,
all on one day.
That day is the thirteenth day of the twelfth month,
the month Adar.
Take everything they own.
14 A copy of the letter was made public to all the peoples.
The order was to be given out as law in every province.
So everyone would be ready for that day.
15 The king commanded the messengers to hurry, and they went out.
The order was also given out in the fortress of Susa.
The king and Haman sat down to drink.
But the city of Susa was confused and upset.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The order is written on the thirteenth day of Nisan, one day before the Passover. At Passover the Jews celebrate their freedom from Egypt. Now they are threatened with destruction.

"The king's local governors": here the Hebrew has the Persian word "satraps", the governors of the large provinces.

The order is a call to genocide: all Jews are to be killed, children and women too. Whoever takes part may rob their property.

Verse 15 shows a terrible contrast: the king and Haman drink comfortably, while a whole people is condemned to death. But the city of Susa is upset. Not all people agree with the hatred.

ESTHER

CHAPTER 4

"For a time like this"

Mourning and weeping VERSES 1–3

1 Mordecai found out about everything that had been done.
He tore his clothes.
He put on sackcloth and put ashes on himself.
Sackcloth is rough cloth that people wore when they mourned.
He went out into the middle of the city.
He cried out loudly and bitterly.
2 He went as far as the king's gate, but no farther.
No one was allowed to go through the king's gate dressed in sackcloth.
3 The king's command and his order reached every province.
Wherever it came, the Jews mourned deeply.

They fasted, cried, and wailed.
Many of them lay in sackcloth and ashes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mordecai mourns in public. Sackcloth and ashes were signs of the deepest mourning and repentance.

No one was allowed to appear sad before the king (compare Nehemiah 2:2). That is why Mordecai stays in front of the gate.

In the whole empire the Jews fast and weep. In the Bible fasting was always connected with prayer. Even if God's name is not mentioned: the people turn to God.

Esther finds out VERSES 4–9

4 Esther's young women and her eunuchs came and told
her about it.
The queen was very upset.
She sent clothes to Mordecai for him to wear instead of
his sackcloth.
But he did not accept them.
5 Then Esther called Hathach.
He was one of the king's eunuchs.
The king had chosen him to serve her.
She ordered him to go to Mordecai.
He was to find out what was wrong and why.
6 So Hathach went out to Mordecai.
Mordecai was in the city square in front of the king's
gate.
7 Mordecai told him everything that had happened to
him.
He told him the exact amount of money that Haman
had promised to pay into the king's treasury
for destroying the Jews.
8 He also gave Hathach a copy of the written order.
It had been given out in Susa, and it said to destroy the
Jews.
Hathach was to show it to Esther and explain it to her.
Mordecai told him to urge her to go to the king.
She should beg the king for mercy
and plead with him for her people.
9 Hathach came back and told Esther what Mordecai had
said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Esther did not yet know anything about the order. In the palace she was cut off from the outside world.

At first she only wants to comfort Mordecai, with new clothes. But Mordecai does not want comfort. He wants her to act.

Mordecai gives her the proof: the copy of the decree. And he asks her: go to the king and plead for your people!

Esther's fear VERSES 10–12

10 Then Esther spoke to Hathach.
She gave him a message for Mordecai:
11 "All the king's servants and the people in the king's
provinces know this:
There is one law for every man or woman
who goes to the king in the inner courtyard without
being called.
That person must be put to death.
Only if the king holds out his golden scepter to that
person will he live.
But the king has not called me to come to him for 30
days now."
12 Esther's words were told to Mordecai.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Esther is afraid, and rightly so. Going to the king without being called could mean death.

The king has not called her for 30 days. Maybe he has lost interest in her. That makes the situation even more dangerous.

Mordecai's famous answer VERSES 13–14

13 Then Mordecai sent this answer back to Esther:
"Don't think that you will escape just because you are
in the king's palace.
You will not be safer than all the other Jews.
14 If you stay silent now,
help and rescue will come to the Jews from another
place.
But you and your father's family will die.
Who knows? Maybe you have become queen for a time
like this."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mordecai's answer is one of the best-known sentences of the Bible.

He says three things:

– Even in the palace you are not safe. You are Jewish too.

– If you stay silent, rescue will come "from another place". Many interpreters see this as a hidden hint at God. Mordecai is sure: God will not let his people perish.

– "Who knows? Maybe you have become queen for a time like this." Maybe everything Esther has gone through had a meaning. Maybe she is in this place exactly for this.

This sentence still encourages people today: where you stand right now, you can do something good. Maybe that is exactly why you are there.

Esther's decision VERSES 15–17

15 Then Esther sent this answer to Mordecai:
16 "Go and gather all the Jews who are in Susa.
Fast for me.
Don't eat or drink anything for three days, night or
day.
My young women and I will fast in the same way.
Then I will go to the king, even though it is against the
law.
And if I die, I die."
17 So Mordecai went away.
He did everything Esther had commanded him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Esther makes her decision. The quiet young woman who always listened to others becomes a brave leader. Now she gives Mordecai instructions.

She asks everyone to fast for her. In the Bible fasting always means asking God for help. Even though God is not named, it is clear: Esther seeks God's help.

"If I die, I die." Esther risks her life for her people. That is true courage: you are afraid and still do what is right.

CHAPTER 5

Esther goes to the king

The golden scepter VERSES 1–4

1 On the third day Esther put on her royal clothes.
She stood in the inner courtyard of the king's palace,
next to the king's hall.
The king sat on his royal throne in the royal hall,
next to the entrance.
2 The king saw Queen Esther standing in the courtyard.
He was pleased with her.
He held out to Esther the golden scepter that was in his hand.
So Esther came closer and touched the top of the scepter.
3 Then the king asked her,
"What do you want, Queen Esther? What do you ask for?
I will give it to you, even up to half of the kingdom."
4 Esther said,
"If the king agrees,
let the king and Haman come today
to the banquet that I have prepared for the king."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After three days of fasting Esther takes the step. She puts on her royal clothes and comes before the king, without being called, risking her life.

The king holds out the scepter to her. She may live! The fasting and praying have been answered. Here too God is not named, but the reader feels who is behind it.

"Even up to half of the kingdom" was a common saying. It means: I am very well disposed toward you (compare Mark 6:23).

Esther is wise. She does not say her real request at once. First she invites them to a banquet.

The first banquet VERSES 5–8

5 Then the king said,
"Bring Haman quickly.
Then we can do what Esther has asked."
So the king and Haman went to the banquet that Esther had prepared.
6 While they were drinking wine at the banquet, the king said to Esther,
"What do you wish for? I will give it to you.
What do you ask for? I will do it, even up to half of the kingdom."
7 Esther answered,
"This is my wish and my request:
8 Maybe the king is pleased with me.
Maybe the king is willing to give me what I wish and to do what I ask.
If so, then let the king and Haman come to another banquet that I will prepare for them.
Tomorrow I will do what the king has said."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Esther puts off her request once again. Why? Maybe she is waiting for the right moment. Maybe she wants to make the king curious.

This delay is decisive. For in the night in between something unexpected happens (Chapter 6). What looks like hesitating is part of a greater plan.

Haman's pride and hatred VERSES 9–14

9 That day Haman went out happy and in a good mood.
But then Haman saw Mordecai in the king's gate.
Mordecai did not stand up for him.
He did not even move.
Then Haman was filled with anger against Mordecai.
10 But Haman controlled himself and went home.
There he called his friends and his wife Zeresh.
11 Haman bragged to them about his great riches
and about his many sons.
He told them about all the ways the king had honored him.
He told them how the king had raised him above the other princes and servants of the king.
12 Haman also said,
"And that is not all.
Queen Esther invited no one except me to come with the king to the banquet she had prepared.
And tomorrow she has invited me again, together with the king.
13 But all this means nothing to me
as long as I see Mordecai the Jew sitting at the king's gate."
14 Then his wife Zeresh and all his friends said to him,
"Have a gallows built, about 75 feet high.
In the morning, ask the king to have Mordecai hanged on it.
Then go happily with the king to the banquet."
Haman liked this idea, so he had the gallows built.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Haman has everything: wealth, many sons, power, honor. But one single man who does not bow before him spoils everything for him. That is the nature of pride and hatred: they never let a person be content.

"Pride goes before destruction" (Proverbs 16:18). Haman is at the peak of his pride. Soon he will fall.

The Hebrew text says 50 cubits. A cubit is about 18 inches, so that is about 75 feet. That is as high as a house with seven floors. The whole city was to see how Mordecai is punished. Maybe the number is also exaggerated in the telling, to show Haman's boundless hatred.

CHAPTER 6

A sleepless night

The king cannot sleep VERSES 1–3

1 That night the king could not sleep.
So he ordered his servants to bring the book of records, the chronicles.
They read from it to the king.
2 There they found a report about Mordecai.
Mordecai had told about Bigthana and Teresh, two of the king's eunuchs who guarded the door.
These two had tried to attack King Ahasuerus.
3 The king asked,
"How has Mordecai been honored and rewarded for this?"
The king's servants who served him answered,
"Nothing has been done for him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the turning point of the whole story. And it begins with something very small: the king cannot sleep.

Why exactly on this night? Why does he have exactly this book read to him? Why exactly this passage? The Bible does not say. But the reader notices: this is no coincidence. Here God is guiding things in secret.

Jewish interpreters say: it was not only the king who could not sleep, but "the King of the world", that is God, who "will not doze and will not sleep" (Psalm 121:4).

Mordecai's good deed from Chapter 2 seemed forgotten. Now, at exactly the right moment, it comes to light.

Haman honors Mordecai VERSES 4–11

4 The king asked, "Who is in the courtyard?"
At that moment Haman had just come into the outer courtyard of the king's palace.
He wanted to ask the king to hang Mordecai on the gallows that he had set up for him.
5 The king's servants said to him,
"Look, Haman is standing in the courtyard."
The king said, "Let him come in."
6 So Haman came in.
The king asked him,
"What should be done for the man the king wants to honor?"
Haman thought to himself,
"Whom would the king want to honor more than me?"
7 So Haman said to the king,
"This is what should be done for the man the king wants to honor:
8 Let servants bring royal clothes that the king has worn.
Let them bring a horse that the king rides,
with a royal crown on its head.
9 Let them give the clothes and the horse to one of the king's most important princes.
He should dress the man the king wants to honor.
He should lead him on the horse through the city square.
And he should call out in front of him,
'This is what is done for the man the king wants to honor!'"
10 Then the king said to Haman,
"Hurry! Take the clothes and the horse, as you have said.
Do all this for Mordecai the Jew, who sits at the king's gate.
Don't leave out anything you have said."
11 So Haman took the clothes and the horse.
He dressed Mordecai.
He led him on the horse through the city square.
And he called out in front of him,
"This is what is done for the man the king wants to honor!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most wonderful scenes of the Bible, full of irony.

Haman comes in the middle of the night or early in the morning, to demand Mordecai's death. The king asks him how someone should be honored. Haman thinks that he himself is meant, and thinks up the greatest honor.

Then the shock: he himself has to show this honor to his archenemy! He has to lead Mordecai through the city and call out: "This is what is done for the man the king wants to honor!"

Here we see what Jesus says later: "Everyone who lifts himself up will be humbled. And whoever humbles himself will be lifted up" (Luke 14:11).

Haman's fall begins VERSES 12–14

12 Then Mordecai went back to the king's gate.
But Haman hurried home.
He was full of grief and had covered his head.
13 Haman told his wife Zeresh and all his friends everything that had happened to him.
Then his wise men and his wife Zeresh said to him,
"You have begun to fall before Mordecai.
If he is a Jew, you will not win against him.
You will surely fall before him."
14 While they were still talking with him,
the king's eunuchs arrived.
They quickly took Haman to the banquet that Esther had prepared.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mordecai goes back quietly to his work. He does not let himself be blinded by the honor.

Haman, on the other hand, goes home like a mourner.

Astonishing: even Haman's wife and his advisers now see that you cannot win against the Jewish people. They sense that a higher power is at work.

Haman has no time to collect himself. He is fetched to the banquet at once.

ESTHER

CHAPTER 7

Haman is exposed

Esther's request VERSES 1–4

1 So the king and Haman came to the banquet with
Queen Esther.
2 On the second day, while they were drinking wine at
the banquet,
the king said again to Esther,
"What do you wish, Queen Esther? It shall be given
you.
What do you ask for? Even up to half of the kingdom,
it shall be done."
3 Then Queen Esther answered,
"If I have found favor in your sight, O king,
and if it pleases the king,
let my life be given me as my wish,
and my people as my request.
4 For we have been sold, I and my people,
to be destroyed, to be slain, and to perish.
If we had only been sold as male and female slaves,
I would have kept quiet,
although the enemy could never have made up for the
king's loss."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At last Esther speaks. And she speaks very wisely:

– First she asks for her own life. The king loves her. That touches him personally.

– Then she asks for her people. For the first time she makes known that she is Jewish.

– She uses the words "to be destroyed, to be slain, and to perish", exactly the words of the order to murder (Esther 3:13).

– "We have been sold": she reminds him of the money that Haman had offered.

The last sentence is hard to understand. It probably means: slavery would have been bad, but I would not have bothered the king for that. But here it is about life and death.

"This wicked Haman!" VERSES 5–6

5 Then King Ahasuerus said to Queen Esther,
"Who is he, and where is he,
who has dared in his heart to do such a thing?"
6 Esther said,
"An enemy and a foe:
this wicked Haman!"
Then Haman was terrified before the king and the
queen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king had sealed the order himself, but he had not even asked which people was meant (Esther 3:10–11). Now he learns: it is the people of his own queen!

Esther points to Haman. The mighty man is suddenly exposed.

Haman's end VERSES 7–10

7 The king got up in his anger from the banquet of wine
and went into the palace garden.
Haman stayed to beg Queen Esther for his life,
for he saw that the king had decided evil against him.
8 Then the king returned from the palace garden into the
room of the banquet of wine.
Haman had fallen on the couch where Esther was.
Then the king said,
"Will he even attack the queen in front of me, in my
own house?"
As soon as the word left the king's mouth,
they covered Haman's face.
9 Then Harbonah, one of the eunuchs who were with the
king, said,
"Look, the gallows about 75 feet high,
which Haman has made for Mordecai,
who spoke up for the good of the king,
is standing at Haman's house."
The king said, "Hang him on it!"
10 So they hanged Haman on the gallows that he had
prepared for Mordecai.
Then the king's anger calmed down.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king goes out. Maybe he has to think. After all, he gave the order himself.

Haman falls down before Esther and begs for mercy. At that time people lay on couches while eating. When the king comes back, he misreads the scene, or he wants to misread it. That gives him a reason to condemn Haman.

"They covered Haman's face": this was probably a sign that someone had been condemned to death.

The eunuch Harbonah points to the gallows (he was already named in Esther 1:10). The Hebrew text says the gallows was 50 cubits high (about 75 feet).

The great irony: Haman dies on the gallows that he had built for Mordecai. "Whoever digs a pit will fall into it" (Proverbs 26:27; Psalm 7:15).

But the danger is not over yet. The order to destroy the Jews is still valid. And a Persian law cannot be taken back (Chapter 8).

ESTHER

CHAPTER 8

The counter-decree

Mordecai receives the ring VERSES 1–2

1 On that same day King Ahasuerus gave Queen Esther
the house of Haman, the enemy of the Jews.
Esther had told the king how Mordecai was related to
her.
So Mordecai came before the king.
2 The king had taken back his signet ring from Haman.
Now he took it off and gave it to Mordecai.
Esther put Mordecai in charge of Haman's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the king learns that Mordecai is Esther's foster father.

The signet ring with which Haman had sealed the order to murder now belongs to Mordecai. And all of Haman's

property goes to Esther. Everything has been turned around.

Esther pleads a second time VERSES 3–8

3 Then Esther spoke to the king once more.
She fell down at his feet.
She cried and begged him to stop the evil plan of Haman the Agagite.
Haman had made this plan against the Jews.
4 The king held out the golden scepter to Esther.
So Esther got up and stood in front of the king.
5 She said,
"If it pleases the king,
and if he is pleased with me,
and if the king thinks it is right,
and if he likes me,
then let an order be written.
It should cancel the letters that Haman thought up.
Haman, the son of Hammedatha the Agagite, wrote them
to destroy the Jews in all the king's provinces.
6 How can I stand to watch the disaster that would come on my people?
How can I stand to watch my relatives be destroyed?"
7 Then King Ahasuerus said to Queen Esther and to Mordecai the Jew,
"Look, I have given Esther the house of Haman.
And Haman was hanged on the gallows,
because he attacked the Jews.
8 Now you may also write to the Jews, as you think best.
Write it in the king's name.
Seal it with the king's ring.
No one can cancel a letter that is written in the king's name
and sealed with the king's ring."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Haman is dead, but his order is still valid. On the thirteenth day of Adar all enemies may attack the Jews.

Esther goes to the king once more, risking her life. She weeps and pleads. She does not only think of herself, but of her whole people.

The problem: a Persian law cannot be taken back (Esther 1:19; Daniel 6:8). Even the king cannot cancel his own order.

The solution: a new order that works against the old one.

The new decree VERSES 9–14

9 So the king's scribes were called at once.
It was the twenty-third day of the third month, the month Sivan.
They wrote down everything that Mordecai commanded.
They wrote to the Jews, to the local governors, and to the governors and princes of the provinces.
There were 127 provinces, from India to Ethiopia.
They wrote to every province in its own writing
and to every people in its own language.
They also wrote to the Jews in their own writing and their own language.
10 He wrote the letters in the name of King Ahasuerus.
He sealed them with the king's ring.
He sent them with messengers on horseback.
They rode fast royal horses that were bred from the best horses.
11 In these letters the king gave the Jews in every city the right
to gather together and to defend their lives.
They were allowed to destroy, kill, and wipe out every army of any people or province
that would attack them,
together with their little ones and women.
And they were allowed to take what their enemies owned.
12 All this was to happen on one day in all the provinces of King Ahasuerus:
on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month, the month Adar.
13 A copy of the letter was made public to all the peoples.
The order was to be given out as law in every province.
So the Jews would be ready on that day
to take revenge on their enemies.
14 The king commanded the messengers to hurry.
So they rode out quickly on the royal horses.
The order was also given out in the fortress of Susa.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The new decree comes two months after the first one. There are still nine months until the thirteenth day of Adar.

The new decree is almost word for word the same as Haman's order to murder (Esther 3:12–14), only the other way around. Now the Jews may defend themselves.

Important: this is about defense. The Jews may only act against those "that would attack them".

The words "their little ones and women" are hard to read. They repeat Haman's words from Esther 3:13. Chapter 9 does not say whether this was really carried out. There only killed men are mentioned. And the Jews took no plunder (Esther 9:10, 15, 16), although it was allowed.

"To take revenge" here means: to defend themselves against the attackers and to get justice.

Joy instead of mourning VERSES 15–17

15 Mordecai left the king.
He wore royal clothes of blue and white.
He wore a large golden crown
and a robe of fine linen and purple.
The city of Susa shouted for joy and celebrated.
16 For the Jews it was a time of light, gladness, joy, and honor.
17 The king's command and his order reached every province and every city.
Wherever it came, the Jews were glad and full of joy.
They had a feast and a holiday.
Many people from the other peoples of the land became Jews.
They had become afraid of the Jews.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What a contrast to Chapter 4: there Mordecai wore sackcloth and ashes. Now he wears royal clothes. There was mourning in all the provinces. Now there is joy everywhere.

"Light, gladness, joy, and honor": to this day this verse is spoken in Jewish families at the end of the Sabbath.

At the end of Chapter 3 the city of Susa was upset. Now it shouts for joy. So many people in Susa were glad that the

Jews were saved.
"Many ... became Jews": some joined the Jewish people. The text does not say exactly whether out of fear or out of conviction.

ESTHER

CHAPTER 9

The thirteenth of Adar and the feast of Purim

The day of decision VERSES 1–4

1 Then came the thirteenth day of the twelfth month,
the month Adar.
On that day the king's command and his order were to be carried out.
On that day the enemies of the Jews had hoped to defeat them.
But it turned out that the opposite happened:
The Jews defeated those who hated them.
2 The Jews gathered together in their cities
in all the provinces of King Ahasuerus.
They wanted to attack those who wanted to harm them.
No one could stand against them.
All the peoples had become afraid of them.
3 All the princes of the provinces, the local governors, the governors,
and the king's officials helped the Jews.
They had become afraid of Mordecai.
4 Mordecai was powerful in the king's palace.
People in all the provinces heard about him.
Mordecai became more and more powerful.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The day comes. The day on which the Jews were to be destroyed. But "it turned out that the opposite happened". That is the key word of the whole book: everything turns into its opposite.

Important: the Jews only attack "those who wanted to harm them". It was about self-defense against people who wanted to kill them. For Haman's order was still valid.

The fighting in Susa VERSES 5–15

5 The Jews struck down all their enemies with the sword.
They killed and destroyed them.
They did what they wanted with those who hated them.
6 In the fortress of Susa the Jews killed and destroyed 500 men.
7 They killed Parshandatha, Dalphon, Aspatha,
8 Poratha, Adalia, Aridatha,
9 Parmashta, Arisai, Aridai, and Vaizatha.
10 They were the 10 sons of Haman, the son of Hammedatha, the enemy of the Jews.
But they did not touch the plunder.
11 On that day the king was told how many people had been killed in the fortress of Susa.
12 The king said to Queen Esther,
"The Jews have killed and destroyed 500 men in the fortress of Susa,
and also the 10 sons of Haman.
What must they have done in the rest of the king's provinces!
Now what do you wish for? I will give it to you.
What else do you ask for? It will be done."
13 Esther said,
"If it pleases the king,
let the Jews in Susa do the same tomorrow.
Let them act by today's order again.
And let Haman's 10 sons be hanged on the gallows."
14 The king commanded that this be done.
An order was given out in Susa.
And Haman's 10 sons were hanged.
15 The Jews in Susa gathered together again
on the fourteenth day of the month Adar.
They killed 300 men in Susa.
But they did not touch the plunder.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are hard to read. Many people die.

We have to see the context: there were still many enemies who wanted to carry out the first order and kill the Jews. The Jews defend their lives.

Three times it is stressed: "They did not touch the plunder." That was allowed to them (Esther 8:11). But they wanted to show: it was not about getting rich, but about surviving. That recalls Saul, who took plunder from the Amalekites back then and was rebuked for it (1 Samuel 15).

The 10 sons of Haman were probably already dead (verse 10). They were hanged up in public as a warning.

Why does Esther ask for a second day in Susa? The text does not say. Maybe there were especially many enemies left in the capital. This passage is hard to understand, and many readers still find it hard today.

Jews and Christians do not read this story as a call to revenge or violence. They read it as the story of a rescue from a planned genocide.

In the provinces VERSES 16–19

16 The other Jews in the king's provinces also gathered together.
They defended their lives
and got rest from their enemies.
They killed 75,000 of those who hated them.
But they did not touch the plunder.
17 This happened on the thirteenth day of the month Adar.
On the fourteenth day of that month they rested.
They made it a day of feasting and joy.
18 But the Jews in Susa gathered together
on the thirteenth and the fourteenth day of the month.
On the fifteenth day of that month they rested.
They made it a day of feasting and joy.

19 That is why the Jews in the villages, who live in towns without walls,
celebrate the fourteenth day of the month Adar.
It is a day of joy and feasting, a holiday.
On this day they send gifts of food to one another.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The number 75,000 is very high. The Greek version of the book has 15,000. As with many large numbers in the Bible, it is uncertain how exactly it is meant.

"They defended their lives": again it is stressed that it was about self-defense.

Because there was fighting in Susa for two days, the Jews in walled cities celebrate Purim one day later. To this day Jews in Jerusalem celebrate Purim on the fifteenth of Adar ("Shushan Purim") and in other places on the fourteenth of Adar.

Mordecai establishes the feast of Purim VERSES 20–28

20 Mordecai wrote down these things.
He sent letters to all the Jews in all the provinces of King Ahasuerus,
both near and far.
21 He told them to celebrate the fourteenth and fifteenth days of the month Adar every year.
22 On these days the Jews had gotten rest from their enemies.
In this month their sorrow had been turned into joy, and their mourning into a holiday.
They should make them days of feasting and joy.
They should send gifts of food to one another and give gifts to the poor.
23 The Jews had already begun to celebrate.
They accepted it as a custom, as Mordecai had written to them.
24 Haman, the son of Hammedatha the Agagite, the enemy of all the Jews,
had made plans against the Jews to destroy them.
He had cast "Pur", that is, the lot,
to crush them and to destroy them.
25 But when the king learned about it,
he gave orders in letters:
The evil plan that Haman had made against the Jews should fall back on his own head.
He and his sons should be hanged on the gallows.
26 That is why these days were called "Purim", after the word "Pur."
This letter said all these things.
And the Jews had seen these things themselves and had lived through them.
27 So the Jews made a rule for themselves,
for their descendants, and for everyone who would join them:
Every year, without fail, they would celebrate these two days,
as it was written and at the set time.
28 These days should be remembered and celebrated in every generation, in every family, in every province, and in every city.
These days of Purim should never stop among the Jews.
Their descendants should never forget them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is how the feast of Purim began. "Purim" is the plural of "Pur", lot. Haman had cast the lot to find a day for the destruction. Now this day is a day of joy.

How is Purim celebrated? To this day just as it is written here:

– with a feast and much joy,

– people send each other food ("Mishloach Manot"),

– people give gifts to the poor ("Matanot la-Evyonim").

In addition, the book of Esther is read aloud in the synagogue. Every time the name Haman is said, the children make noise with rattles, to drown out his name. Many people dress up in costumes.

Important: thinking of the poor is part of the feast. Whoever has been saved should give gifts to others.

Purim does not celebrate the death of the enemies. It celebrates the rescue, the rest and the turning of sorrow into joy.

The second letter of Purim VERSES 29–32

29 Then Queen Esther, the daughter of Abihail, and Mordecai the Jew
wrote with full authority.
They wanted to confirm this second letter about Purim.
30 He sent letters to all the Jews in the 127 provinces of the kingdom of Ahasuerus.
They had words of peace and truth.
31 The letters confirmed these days of Purim at their set times.
Mordecai the Jew and Queen Esther had ordered it.
The Jews had made it a rule for themselves and for their descendants,
together with the times of fasting and mourning.
32 Esther's command confirmed these rules about Purim.
It was written in the book.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Esther herself confirms the feast with her royal authority. She is no longer only the young orphan who does what she is told. She is a leader of her people.

"Words of peace and truth": the feast is meant to bring peace.

"The times of fasting and mourning": to this day Jews fast on the day before Purim, in memory of Esther's fasting (the "Fast of Esther", Esther 4:16).

ESTHER

CHAPTER 10

The greatness of Mordecai

Mordecai seeks the good of his people VERSES 1–3

1 King Ahasuerus made the land and the islands of the sea
pay taxes.
2 All his powerful and mighty deeds are written in the
book of the chronicles of the kings of Media and Persia.
The full story of Mordecai's greatness is written there
too.
The king had made Mordecai great.
3 Mordecai the Jew was second in rank after King
Ahasuerus.
He was great among the Jews.
Most of his fellow Jews respected him.
He worked for the good of his people.
He spoke words of peace to all his descendants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book ends briefly. Mordecai is now the second most powerful man in the empire, exactly where Haman stood before.

But Mordecai is completely different from Haman. Haman sought his own honor and the death of others. Mordecai "worked for the good of his people" and "spoke words of peace".

That recalls Joseph in Egypt, who also, as a foreigner, became the second man after the king and saved his people (Genesis 41:40).

It says: "Most of his fellow Jews respected him." Word for word: "the majority of his brothers". An honest hint: not everyone agreed with him. Even a good leader cannot please everyone.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Esther?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The story: A Jewish orphan, Esther, becomes queen of Persia. Haman, the most powerful official, plans to kill all the Jews. Esther risks her life to save her people. Haman is exposed and falls into the pit he dug himself. The Jews are saved.

The hidden God: In the Hebrew book of Esther, God is not named a single time. And yet he is everywhere: in the "coincidences", in the timing of the sleepless night, in the delay of the banquet, in the lot that falls on a day 11 months later. The book shows: even when we do not see God, he is at work.

Everything turns around: That is the great theme: sorrow becomes joy, fasting becomes feasting, the gallows strikes the one who built it, the enemy is brought low, the despised one is honored.

Courage: Esther is an example of courage. She is afraid, but she acts: "If I die, I die." And Mordecai's question still applies to every person today: Who knows? Maybe you are in your place for a time like this.

A warning against hatred: The book shows how hatred of Jews arises: from wounded pride, from lies and from the indifference of the powerful. Sadly this warning has stayed important through all of history until today.

Purim: The book explains why Jews still celebrate Purim today, with joy, gifts for friends and gifts for the poor.

Hard passages: The fighting in Chapter 9 is hard to read. It is told as self-defense against a planned genocide. It is no permission for revenge.

What comes next? With the book of Esther the history books of the Old Testament end. Next come the books of wisdom and poetry. The first is the book of Job, which asks the question: why do good people have to suffer?

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 18 OF 66

JOB

42 CHAPTERS

JOB

Chapter 1

Job loses everything

Before we begin: What is the book of Job?

The book of Job asks one of the hardest questions people have ever asked:

Why do good people have to suffer?

Job is a good man who loves God. Even so, he loses everything: his possessions, his children, his health.

The book has three parts:

– At the beginning (Chapters 1–2) and at the end (Job 42:7–17) there is a story. It is told in simple language, almost like a fairy tale. It begins with the words "There was a man" (Job 1:1).

– In the middle (Chapter 3 to Job 42:6) there are long speeches in the form of poems. Job argues with his friends. The friends say: You must have sinned, or you would not suffer. Job says: I am innocent! And he accuses God.

– Near the end (Chapters 38–41) God himself answers out of a storm.

The book gives no easy answer to the question of suffering. But it shows: You may lament before God, cry out to him, and ask him questions. God can bear it. And the simple formula "Whoever suffers is to blame" is wrong.

Job probably lived outside Israel, in the land of Uz. We do not know exactly when the book was written.

The speeches are great poetry. Some verses are very hard to understand in Hebrew. This edition follows the WEB, our English source text, and explains difficult passages.

The book of Job can help people who are suffering themselves. It shows: You are not alone with your questions.

Job, a man who loved God VERSES 1–5

1 There was a man in the land of Uz.
His name was Job.
This man was blameless and honest.
He feared God and turned away from evil.
2 Seven sons and three daughters were born to him.
3 He owned 7,000 sheep, 3,000 camels,
500 pairs of oxen, 500 female donkeys,
and he had very many servants.
So this man was the greatest of all the people of the East.
4 His sons used to hold a feast,
each one in his own house on his day.
They sent for their three sisters
and invited them to eat and drink with them.
5 When the days of the feast were over,
Job sent for them and made them holy.
He got up early in the morning
and offered burnt offerings, one for each of them.
For Job said,
"Maybe my sons have sinned
and turned away from God in their hearts."
Job always did this.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job is described as a completely good person. This is important for the whole story: He does not suffer because of his own guilt.

We do not know exactly where the land of Uz was. Maybe in the area of Edom, southeast of Israel. So Job was probably not an Israelite.

Seven sons and three daughters, 7,000 sheep and 3,000 camels: In the Bible, the numbers 7, 3, and 10 stand for completeness. Job's happiness was complete.

"On his day": Probably on their birthdays. The brothers and sisters got along well and celebrated together.

Job loves God so much that he even brings offerings for sins his children might have committed. He cares about their relationship with God.

In heaven: Satan asks a question VERSES 6–12

6 One day the sons of God came
to stand before the LORD.
Satan also came among them.
7 The LORD said to Satan,
"Where have you come from?"
Satan answered the LORD,
"From roaming back and forth on the earth,
and from walking up and down on it."
8 The LORD said to Satan,
"Have you noticed my servant Job?
There is no one like him on the earth.
He is a blameless and honest man.
He fears God and turns away from evil."
9 Then Satan answered the LORD,
"Does Job fear God for nothing?
10 Haven't you put a fence around him,
around his house, and around everything he has, on every side?
You have blessed the work of his hands.
His wealth has grown in the land.
11 But now stretch out your hand
and touch everything he has.
Then he will turn away from you to your face!"
12 The LORD said to Satan,
"All right. Everything he has is in your power.
Only do not stretch out your hand against him himself."
Then Satan went away from the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the scene changes to heaven. God holds a kind of council meeting with the "sons of God," that is, angels (compare 1 Kings 22:19).

In Hebrew, "the Satan" means "the accuser" or "the opponent." Here he is like an accuser in the court of heaven. In the New Testament, Satan is described as the enemy of God and of people.

Satan's question is the big question of the book: "Does Job fear God for nothing?" Does Job love God only because things are going well for him? Is faith only a business deal?
Important: God remains the Lord. Satan may only go as far as God allows.
This scene is hard to understand. Why does God allow this? The book gives no easy answer. Job himself never learns anything about this scene in heaven. Many interpreters think: This story is not meant as an exact report. It is meant as a picture that asks the big question: Is there faith that is not just after a reward?

Four terrible messages VERSES 13–19

13 One day
Job's sons and daughters were eating and drinking
wine in the house of their oldest brother.
14 Then a messenger came to Job and said,
"The oxen were plowing,
and the donkeys were grazing beside them.
15 Then the Sabeans attacked and took them away.
They killed the servants with the sword.
Only I escaped to tell you."
16 While he was still speaking, another man came and said,
"The fire of God fell from the sky.
It burned up the sheep and the servants and destroyed them.
Only I escaped to tell you."
17 While he was still speaking, another man came and said,
"The Chaldeans formed three groups.
They swept down on the camels and took them away.
And they killed the servants with the sword.
Only I escaped to tell you."
18 While he was still speaking, yet another man came and said,
"Your sons and your daughters were eating and drinking wine
in the house of their oldest brother.
19 Suddenly a great wind came from the desert.
It struck the four corners of the house.
The house fell on the young people,
and they are dead.
Only I escaped to tell you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The messages come one after the other. Each time: "While he was still speaking …" Job has no time to catch his breath.
The disaster comes from people (Sabeans, Chaldeans) and from nature (fire from the sky, probably lightning, and a storm). From all sides.
The worst comes last: All 10 children are dead.
"The fire of God" is an old expression for lightning.
Anyone who has lost a child or a loved one can find their own pain in these verses. The Bible does not keep quiet about such suffering.

Job's answer VERSES 20–22

20 Then Job stood up.
He tore his robe,
shaved his head,
fell down on the ground,
and worshiped.
21 He said,
"Naked I came out of my mother's womb,
and naked I will return there.
The LORD gave,
and the LORD has taken away.
May the name of the LORD be praised."
22 In all this, Job did not sin.
He did not accuse God of doing wrong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job grieves, and he does it openly: He tears his clothes and shaves his head. Back then, these were signs of deep grief. Grief is allowed and important.
And yet he worships. His words are among the best-known words in the Bible: "The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away. May the name of the LORD be praised." Many people say these words at funerals.
"Naked I will return there": This means the earth, from which people were taken (compare Genesis 3:19). We bring nothing into the world, and we can take nothing out of it (1 Timothy 6:7).
Satan had said: Job will turn away from God. But Job holds on to God.
Important: Later the book also shows a very different Job, who laments and cries out. Both belong to faith: trust and lament.

Anyone who has lost a child or a loved one today is not alone in their grief. Help is available, for example: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

JOB

CHAPTER 2

Job becomes sick – and his friends come

The second test VERSES 1–6

1 Again, one day the sons of God came
to stand before the LORD.
Satan also came among them
to stand before the LORD.
2 The LORD said to Satan,
"Where have you come from?"
Satan answered the LORD,
"From roaming back and forth on the earth,
and from walking up and down on it."
3 The LORD said to Satan,
"Have you noticed my servant Job?
There is no one like him on the earth.
He is a blameless and honest man.
He fears God and turns away from evil.

He still holds on to his integrity,
even though you stirred me up against him
to ruin him without any reason."
Integrity means: being honest and faithful through and through.
4 Satan answered the LORD,
"Skin for skin!
Yes, a man will give everything he has for his life.
5 But now stretch out your hand
and touch his bones and his flesh.
Then he will turn away from you to your face!"
6 The LORD said to Satan,
"All right. He is in your hand.
Only spare his life."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God himself says: Job suffers "without any reason." This is the key to the whole book. Later Job's friends will claim that Job must have sinned. But the reader knows better: Job is innocent.

"Skin for skin" was probably a saying. It means: A person will give everything to save his own skin. As long as it does not hit Job himself, he will stay faithful to God.

Again God sets a limit: "Only spare his life."

Job becomes sick VERSES 7–10

7 So Satan went away from the LORD.
He struck Job with painful sores,
from the soles of his feet to the top of his head.
8 Job took a piece of broken pottery to scratch himself with.
And he sat among the ashes.
9 Then his wife said to him,
"Are you still holding on to your integrity?
Turn away from God and die!"
10 But he said to her,
"You are talking like a foolish woman.
Should we accept good things from God,
and not accept bad things?"
In all this, Job did not sin with his lips.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job becomes very sick. His whole body is covered with painful sores. He sits in the ashes, probably on the ash heap outside the town, where garbage was burned. That is where the outcasts sat.

Job's wife is often judged harshly. But we must remember: She too has lost all 10 of her children. She too suffers endlessly. Maybe she means: Make an end of it, then you will have no more pain. Her words come from deep despair.

Job answers: We cannot accept only the good things from God. He keeps holding on to God.

"He did not sin with his lips": Jewish interpreters have noticed: Here it says "with his lips," but in Job 1:22 it does not. Maybe doubt was already starting in his heart. From Chapter 3 on, he will speak it out loud.

Three friends come VERSES 11–13

11 Job had three friends.
They heard about all the trouble that had come on him.
So they came, each one from his own home:
Eliphaz the Temanite,
Bildad the Shuhite,
and Zophar the Naamathite.
They agreed to meet
and come together to share his grief and to comfort him.
12 They looked up from far away,
but they did not recognize him.
Then they cried out loud and wept.
Each of them tore his robe.
They threw dust into the air over their heads.
13 Then they sat with him on the ground
for seven days and seven nights.
No one said a word to him,
because they saw that his pain was very great.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job's friends are good friends. They come from far away. They agree to meet so that they can comfort him together.

Job looks so changed that they do not recognize him.

The best thing they do: They sit with him in silence for seven days. They say nothing. They are simply there. That is often the best comfort for someone who is grieving. In the Jewish tradition there is still the "Shiva" today: seven days of mourning, when friends visit the mourners.

Sadly, later they start to talk. And then they make everything worse.

Teman was in Edom. We do not know exactly where Bildad and Zophar came from.

JOB

CHAPTER 3

Job curses the day he was born

Job breaks his silence VERSES 1–10

1 After this, Job opened his mouth
and cursed the day he was born.
2 Job said,
3 "Let the day I was born be wiped out,
and the night that said, 'A boy has been conceived!'
4 Let that day be darkness.
Let God above not look for it.
Let no light shine on it.
5 Let darkness and the shadow of death claim it for themselves.
Let a cloud settle over it.
Let everything that makes the day black terrify it.
6 Let thick darkness grab that night.
Let it not be happy among the days of the year.
Let it not be counted among the months.
7 Let that night be barren.
Let no joyful shout come into it.

8 Let those who curse days curse it,
those who are ready to wake up Leviathan.
9 Let the stars of its dawn be dark.
Let it hope for light but get none.
Let it not see the eyelids of the morning.
10 For it did not shut the doors of my mother's womb.
It did not hide trouble from my eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After seven days of silence, it all bursts out of Job. Now the part in the form of poems begins.

Job does not curse God. He curses the day he was born. He wishes he had never been born. The prophet Jeremiah lamented in a similar way (Jeremiah 20:14–18).

On the first day of creation, God had said, "Let there be light" (Genesis 1:3). Job says the opposite: "Let that day be darkness" (3:4). He wishes that creation would be undone for him.

"Leviathan" is a sea monster from old stories. It stands for chaos. Some people believed that sorcerers could wake it up to curse a day.

"The eyelids of the morning" is a beautiful picture for the first rays of the sun.

Why didn't I die? VERSES 11–19

11 "Why didn't I die at birth?
Why didn't I breathe my last when my mother gave birth to me?
12 Why were there knees to receive me?
Or why were there breasts for me to nurse?
13 For then I would be lying down and quiet now.
I would be asleep. Then I would be at rest,
14 with kings and counselors of the earth,
who built up ruins for themselves,
15 or with princes who had gold,
who filled their houses with silver.
16 Or I would not exist, like a baby born dead and hidden away,
like babies who never saw the light.
17 There the wicked stop causing trouble.
There the tired are at rest.
18 There the prisoners are at peace together.
They do not hear the voice of the slave driver.
19 The small and the great are there.
The servant is free from his master.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job asks again and again: Why? Why did I have to live?

"Knees to receive me": At a birth, the father or the grandparents took the child on their knees. That was a sign that they accepted the child.

Job imagines death as a place of rest. There everyone is equal: kings and servants, rich and poor. There is no more pain there.

We must understand these words as the cry of a person in unbearable pain. The Bible takes this cry seriously. It does not cross it out.

Why does God give life to those who suffer? VERSES 20–26

20 "Why is light given to someone in misery,
and life to those who are bitter in their soul,
21 who long for death, but it does not come,
who dig for it more than for hidden treasure,
22 who would be very happy and full of joy
if they could find the grave?
23 Why is light given to a man whose way is hidden,
a man whom God has fenced in?
24 For my sighing comes before I eat.
My groaning pours out like water.
25 For the thing I fear comes on me.
What I am afraid of happens to me.
26 I have no peace. I have no quiet.
I have no rest.
Only trouble comes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job no longer asks only about himself. He asks about all who suffer: Why does God let people live who suffer so much?

Verse 23 is bitter: Satan had said that God had put a protecting fence around Job (Job 1:10). Now Job feels fenced in by God, as if he were in a prison. The same fence, but felt in a completely different way.

"My sighing comes before I eat": He cannot even eat without groaning.

Important: Job wishes he were dead, but he does not take his own life. He brings his pain to God, even when he laments and cries out. He keeps talking with God. The book shows: You may tell God everything, even your darkest thoughts.

If you yourself are thinking, "I don't want to live anymore": You are not alone. Please talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

JOB

CHAPTER 4

Eliphaz: "Who ever died while he was innocent?"

Eliphaz begins kindly VERSES 1–6

1 Then Eliphaz the Temanite answered,
2 "If someone tries to talk with you, will it upset you?
But who can keep from speaking?
3 You have taught many people.
You have made weak hands strong.
4 Your words have helped up those who were stumbling.
You have made shaky knees firm.
5 But now it has come to you, and you lose heart.
It touches you, and you are terrified.
6 Isn't your reverence for God your confidence?
Isn't your honest way of life your hope?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz is the oldest and probably the most respected of the three friends. He begins politely and carefully.

He reminds Job how often Job himself has comforted other people. But then comes a jab: Now that it hits you yourself, you lose heart.

Eliphaz means well: You love God, so you have reason to hope. But he does not understand how deep Job's pain is.

What Eliphaz teaches VERSES 7–11

7 "Remember this:
Who ever died while he was innocent?
Where were honest people ever wiped out?
8 This is what I have seen:
Those who plow wrongdoing and sow trouble
harvest the same.
9 They die by the breath of God.
They are destroyed by the blast of his anger.
10 The roaring of the lion, the voice of the fierce lion,
and the teeth of the young lions are broken.
11 The old lion dies because it has no prey.
The cubs of the lioness are scattered.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is the teaching that all three friends hold: Things go well for those who are good. Things go badly for those who are evil. "You harvest what you sow."

For Job, this means, without it being said out loud: If things are going so badly for you, you must have done something evil.

There is some truth in this teaching. Wrongdoing often has bad results. But it is not always true. The reader knows from Chapters 1–2: Job is innocent. God himself said so.

Later Jesus clearly rejected this simple formula (John 9:1–3; Luke 13:1–5).

The lions are a picture of powerful, violent people. In the end they too are broken.

A frightening vision in the night VERSES 12–21

12 "A message was brought to me in secret.
My ear caught a whisper of it.
13 It came in troubled thoughts from visions in the night,
when deep sleep falls on people.
14 Fear came over me, and trembling.
It made all my bones shake.
15 Then a spirit passed in front of my face.
The hair on my body stood up.
16 It stood still, but I could not make out what it looked like.
A shape was in front of my eyes.
There was silence. Then I heard a voice say,
17 'Can a mortal human be more right than God?
Can a man be more pure than his Maker?
18 He does not trust even his servants.
He blames his angels for mistakes.
19 How much more those who live in houses of clay,
whose foundation is in the dust,
who are crushed like a moth!
20 Between morning and evening they are destroyed.
They die forever, and no one pays attention.
21 Isn't their tent cord pulled up inside them?
They die, and they die without wisdom.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz points to a mysterious appearance in the night. The voice said: No human being is truly right before God.

That is true in itself. No human being is perfect (compare Romans 3:23). But Eliphaz uses this truth in the wrong way: He wants to say that Job deserves his suffering.

"Houses of clay" is a picture for the human body. People are made from the earth (Genesis 2:7) and are as fragile as a moth.

"The tent cord pulled up": Life is like a tent. When the cord is pulled out, the tent falls down. Paul uses a similar picture (2 Corinthians 5:1).

At the end of the book, God will say that Eliphaz and his friends did not speak rightly about him (Job 42:7).

JOB

CHAPTER 5

Eliphaz: "Turn to God"

The fool and his trouble VERSES 1–7

1 "Call out if you want! Is there anyone who will answer you?
To which of the holy ones will you turn?
2 For anger kills the foolish man,
and jealousy kills the simple one.
3 I have seen the fool putting down roots.
But suddenly I cursed his home.
4 His children are far from safety.
They are crushed in the town gate.
There is no one to rescue them.
5 The hungry eat up his harvest.
They take it even from among the thorns.
The trap opens wide to catch their wealth.
6 For trouble does not come out of the dust.
Hardship does not grow out of the ground.
7 But a human being is born to hardship,
as surely as sparks fly upward.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The holy ones" are angels. Eliphaz means: No angel will help you if you rebel against God.

Eliphaz warns Job: Whoever gets angry and furious harms himself.

Verse 4 is cruel when you think of Job: Eliphaz speaks of a fool whose children die. Job's children have just died! Eliphaz does not notice how much he hurts Job.

"The town gate" was the place where court was held. Without anyone to protect them, the children were treated unfairly there.

Verse 7 is a well-known sentence: "A human being is born to hardship, as surely as sparks fly upward." Suffering is part of being human. It is as natural as sparks rising.

If I were you, I would seek God VERSES 8–16

8 "But as for me, I would seek God.
I would put my case in God's hands.
9 He does great things that no one can understand,
wonders that cannot be counted.
10 He gives rain to the earth
and sends water on the fields.
11 So he sets the lowly up high,
and those who mourn are lifted up to safety.
12 He spoils the plans of the crafty,
so that their hands cannot carry out what they planned.
13 He catches the wise in their own craftiness.
The plans of the cunning are swept away.
14 They run into darkness in the daytime.
At noon they feel their way as if it were night.
15 But he saves the needy from the sword of their mouth,
and from the hand of the mighty.
16 So the poor have hope,
and injustice shuts its mouth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz says many true things about God: He is great, he does wonders, he helps the lowly and the poor.

Paul quotes verse 13 in the New Testament: "He has caught the wise in their own tricks" (1 Corinthians 3:19). So the words are not wrong.

The problem is not what Eliphaz says, but how he applies it to Job. He gives wise advice without really listening.

"If I were you, I would …": People often say this to those who suffer. But no one is ever really in someone else's place.

Happy is the one whom God corrects VERSES 17–27

17 "Happy is the person whom God corrects.
So do not reject the discipline of the Almighty!
18 For he wounds, and he bandages.
He injures, and his hands heal.
19 He will rescue you in six troubles.
Yes, in seven troubles no harm will touch you.
20 In famine he will save you from death,
and in war from the power of the sword.
21 You will be hidden from the whip of the tongue.
You will not be afraid of destruction when it comes.
22 You will laugh at destruction and famine.
You will not be afraid of the wild animals.
23 For you will be in league with the stones of the field.
The wild animals will be at peace with you.
24 You will know that your tent is safe.
You will check your sheep pen and find nothing missing.
25 You will also know that you will have many children,
and your descendants will be like the grass of the earth.
26 You will come to your grave at a ripe old age,
like a bundle of grain that is brought in at harvest time.
27 We have looked into this. It is true.
Listen to it, and take it to heart for your own good."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz says: Your suffering is a discipline from God. If you accept it, everything will be good again. God will bless you.

This is also said in other places in the Bible (Proverbs 3:11–12; Hebrews 12:5–11). Suffering can make a person grow.

But for Job this is no comfort. God has said that Job suffers "without any reason" (Job 2:3). It is not discipline.

Verse 25 is especially painful: Eliphaz promises Job many children. But Job has just lost all his children. New children cannot replace the ones he lost.

Verse 27 shows Eliphaz's attitude: "We have looked into this. It is true." He is completely sure. He leaves no room for questions. That is the problem with people who have an answer for everything.

JOB

CHAPTER 6

Job: "My friends are like a dried-up stream"

My pain is heavier than sand VERSES 1–7

1 Then Job answered,
2 "Oh, if only my pain could be weighed,
and all my misery put on the scales!
3 For now it would be heavier than the sand of the seas.
That is why my words have been rash.
4 For the arrows of the Almighty are stuck in me.
My spirit drinks their poison.
God's terrors line up against me.
5 Does a wild donkey bray when it has grass?
Does an ox bellow over its feed?
6 Can food without flavor be eaten without salt?
Is there any taste in the white of an egg?
7 I refuse to touch it.
It is like disgusting food to me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job answers Eliphaz. He says: If only you knew how heavy my pain is! Heavier than all the sand of the sea!

He even apologizes a little: That is why I spoke so rashly (in Chapter 3).

Job feels attacked by God, as if by poisoned arrows.

Verse 5: An animal only cries out when it lacks something. Job means: I am not crying out for no reason!

Verses 6–7: The words of Eliphaz taste to him like bland food without salt. They disgust him. What Eliphaz says does not help him at all.

I can't go on VERSES 8–13

8 "Oh, if only my request would be granted,
and God would give me what I long for:
9 that it would please God to crush me,
that he would let his hand go and cut me off!
10 Then I would still have this comfort.
Yes, I would jump for joy in pain that does not let up:
I have not denied the words of the Holy One.
11 What strength do I have, that I should keep waiting?
What end is ahead of me, that I should be patient?
12 Is my strength the strength of stones?
Is my body made of bronze?
13 Isn't it true that I have no help inside me,
and that wisdom has been driven away from me?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job wishes again that he were dead. But he asks God for it. He does not take his life into his own hands.

His only comfort: "I have not denied the words of the Holy One." He has stayed faithful to God, in spite of everything.

Verses 11–12 are very honest: I have no strength left. I am not made of stone or metal. I am a human being, and I can't go on.

The Bible takes such feelings seriously. It does not condemn Job for them.

If you yourself are thinking, "I have no strength left, I don't want to live anymore": You are not alone. Please talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Friends who let him down VERSES 14–23

14 "Someone who is about to collapse should receive
kindness from his friend,
even if he gives up the fear of the Almighty.
15 My brothers have been as unreliable as a stream,
like the bed of streams that dry up.
16 They are dark because of the ice,
and the snow hides in them.
17 In the dry season they disappear.
When it is hot, they vanish from their place.
18 The caravans that travel along them turn aside.
They go up into the empty desert and die.
19 The caravans of Tema looked for water.
The travelers of Sheba waited for it.
20 They were let down because they had been sure.
They came there and were put to shame.
21 Now you too have become nothing.
You see something terrible, and you are afraid.
22 Did I ever say, 'Give me something'?
Or, 'Pay a gift for me out of your wealth'?
23 Or, 'Rescue me from the enemy's hand'?
Or, 'Buy me free from the hand of the oppressors'?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14 is an important sentence: A true friend stands by you, even when you are in despair, even when you doubt God.

Job compares his friends to a desert stream (a wadi). In winter, when no one needs water, it is full. In summer, when people badly need water, it is dried up. The caravans that hoped for water die of thirst.

His friends are like that: In good times they were there. Now, when he really needs them, they fail him.

"You see something terrible, and you are afraid": Maybe the friends are afraid that such a disaster could hit them too. That is why they look for the guilt in Job. Then they themselves feel safe.

Job has asked nothing of them, no money, no help. Only compassion.

Tema and Sheba were places in Arabia from which trade caravans came.

Show me my mistake! VERSES 24–30

24 "Teach me, and I will be quiet.
Help me understand where I went wrong.
25 How powerful honest words are!
But what does your criticism prove?
26 Do you want to criticize words,
when the speeches of a desperate person are like wind?
27 Yes, you would even throw lots for an orphan,
and you would sell your friend.
28 Now please look at me.
I will surely not lie to your face.
29 Please turn back. Let there be no injustice.
Yes, turn back. My cause is right.
30 Is there anything wrong on my tongue?
Can't my sense of taste tell what is harmful?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job challenges his friends: If I have sinned, then show me where! Say it plainly!

Verse 26 is very human: The words of a desperate person are "like wind." You should not weigh every word. A person in deep trouble sometimes says harsh things. A friend should understand that.

"Now please look at me": Job asks his friends to really look at him, as a person, not as a case for their theory.

This is an important lesson for everyone who stands by people who suffer: First listen, first look, before giving advice.

JOB

CHAPTER 7

"What is a human being?"

Life is a breath VERSES 1–10

1 "Isn't a human being forced to do hard labor on earth?
Aren't his days like the days of a hired worker?
2 Like a slave who longs for the shade,
like a hired worker who waits for his pay,
3 so I have been given months of misery.
Exhausting nights have been handed to me.

4 When I lie down, I say,
'When can I get up? When will the night be over?'
I toss and turn until the dawn.
5 My body is covered with worms and clumps of dirt.
My skin closes up and then breaks open again.
6 My days go by faster than a weaver's shuttle.
They come to an end without hope.
7 Oh, remember that my life is only a breath.
My eyes will never again see anything good.
8 The eyes of those who see me now will see me no more.
Your eyes will look for me, but I will be gone.
9 As a cloud fades and disappears,
so whoever goes down to Sheol, the world of the dead,
will not come up again.
10 He will never come back to his house.
His home will not know him anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job no longer speaks to his friends now, but to God. "Oh, remember ..."

He describes his misery: He cannot sleep. His skin is full of wounds that do not heal. Time passes quickly, but without hope.

A weaver's "shuttle" flies quickly back and forth during weaving. That is how fast the days go by.

In Hebrew, the world of the dead is called "Sheol." People imagined it as a dark place under the earth, where the dead are. Job sees no hope of coming back from there. Only later in the Bible does the hope of a resurrection grow.

Verse 8 is bitter: God will look for Job, but Job will no longer be there.

Why do you guard me? VERSES 11–16

11 "So I will not keep quiet.
I will speak in the anguish of my spirit.
I will complain in the bitterness of my soul.
12 Am I the sea, or a sea monster,
that you put a guard over me?
13 When I say, 'My bed will comfort me,
my couch will ease my complaint,'
14 then you frighten me with dreams
and terrify me with visions.
15 So I would rather be strangled.
I would rather die than live on in these bones.
16 I hate my life. I don't want to live forever.
Leave me alone, for my days are only a breath.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"I will not keep quiet": Job decides to lament honestly. He does not swallow his pain.

In old stories, the sea and the sea monster were pictures for the chaos that God had to tame. Job asks: Am I so dangerous that you guard me so strictly?

He does not find rest even in his sleep. Nightmares torment him.

Verses 15–16 are very dark words. Job does not want to live anymore. But he says this to God. He keeps talking with him. This is important: Even in the deepest despair, you can talk with God.

If you yourself feel this way and don't want to live anymore: You are not alone. Please talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

What is a human being? VERSES 17–21

17 "What is a human being, that you make so much of him,
that you pay so much attention to him,
18 that you check on him every morning
and test him every moment?
19 How long will you keep staring at me?
Won't you leave me alone
even long enough to swallow my spit?
20 If I have sinned, what harm does that do to you,
you who watch over people?
Why have you made me your target,
so that I have become a burden to myself?
21 Why don't you forgive my wrongdoing
and take away my guilt?
For soon I will lie down in the dust.
You will search hard for me, but I will be gone."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17 reminds us of Psalm 8:4: "What is a human being, that you think of him?" In the psalm, this is praise full of wonder: God cares about small human beings! Job turns it around: Why don't you leave me alone? Your attention is torture for me.

"Long enough to swallow my spit": God does not leave him alone for even a moment.

Job does not say that he has sinned. He says: Even if I had sinned, why don't you simply forgive me?

The last sentence is amazing: "You will search hard for me." Deep in his heart, Job knows that God will miss him. He still believes that God loves him, even if he cannot feel it right now.

JOB

CHAPTER 8

Bildad: "God does not twist justice"

Your children must have sinned VERSES 1–7

1 Then Bildad the Shuhite answered,
2 "How long will you keep saying these things?
Will the words of your mouth be a mighty wind?
3 Does God twist justice?
Does the Almighty twist what is right?
4 If your children sinned against him,
he handed them over to the power of their wrongdoing.

5 If you will seek God with all your heart
and plead with the Almighty,
6 if you are pure and honest,
then surely he will now wake up for you.
He will give you back the home you deserve as a
righteous man, and make it prosper.
7 Even if your beginning was small,
your future will be very great.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bildad is less polite than Eliphaz. He calls Job's words "a mighty wind," that is, empty talk.

His question in verse 3 is right: God does not twist justice. But his conclusion is cruel:

Verse 4: "If your children sinned against him, he handed them over to the power of their wrongdoing." That means: God punished them. Bildad tells a father who has just lost all his children: It is probably their own fault that they died. This is one of the harshest statements in the whole book.

No one may say something like this to a grieving person. Bildad thinks he is defending God. But he deeply hurts a human being.

Verse 7 is ironic: At the end of the book Job will really receive more than before (Job 42:12). But not because Bildad was right.

Ask the generations of the past VERSES 8–10

8 "Please ask the generations of the past.
Find out what their ancestors learned.
9 (For we were only born yesterday, and we know
nothing.
Our days on earth are a shadow.)
10 Won't they teach you and tell you?
Won't they speak words from their hearts?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz pointed to a vision. Bildad points to tradition, to the wisdom of the ancestors.

Tradition is valuable. But Bildad uses it so that he does not have to think for himself. He does not listen to what Job really experiences.

The plant without water VERSES 11–19

11 "Can papyrus grow without a swamp?
Can reeds grow without water?
12 While it is still green and not yet cut,
it dries up faster than any other plant.
13 That is how it goes for all who forget God.
The hope of the godless will die.
14 What he relies on breaks apart.
What he trusts is a spider's web.
15 He leans on his house, but it will not stand.
He holds on to it, but it will not last.
16 He is green in the sun.
His shoots spread out over his garden.
17 His roots wrap around the pile of rocks.
He looks at the place of stones.
18 But if he is torn out of his place,
then the place will deny him and say, 'I have never seen
you.'
19 That is the joy of his way!
Others will spring up out of the ground.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bildad uses pictures from nature. Papyrus and reeds need water. Without water they dry up quickly. It is the same with people who forget God.

"What he trusts is a spider's web": It looks strong, but it cannot hold anything.

The second plant (verses 16–19) grows strongly, even on stones. But when it is torn out, it is as if it had never been there. The place itself "denies" it.

Bildad means: That is what happens to the godless. And without saying it out loud: Maybe to you too, Job.

God does not reject a blameless man VERSES 20–22

20 "God will not reject a blameless man.
He will not support evildoers.
21 He will yet fill your mouth with laughter,
and your lips with shouts of joy.
22 Those who hate you will be clothed with shame.
The tent of the wicked will be gone."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bildad ends with a hope: If you are blameless, God will make you glad again.

The irony: God himself called Job "blameless" (Job 1:8). But by Bildad's logic, that cannot be true, because Job is suffering.

The friends have a ready-made theory. And because reality does not fit their theory, Job must be to blame.

JOB

CHAPTER 9

"How can a human being be right before God?"

God's overwhelming power VERSES 1–13

1 Then Job answered,
2 "Yes, I know that this is true.
But how can a human being be right before God?
3 If someone wanted to argue with him,
he could not answer him even once in 1,000 times.
4 God is wise in heart and mighty in strength.
Who has ever stood up against him and come out well?
5 He moves mountains, and they do not know it,
when he turns them over in his anger.
6 He shakes the earth out of its place.
Its pillars tremble.
7 He gives an order to the sun, and it does not rise.
He seals up the stars.
8 He alone stretches out the heavens.
He walks on the waves of the sea.

9 He makes the Bear, Orion, and the Pleiades,
and the rooms of the south.
10 He does great things that no one can understand,
yes, wonders that cannot be counted.
11 He goes past me, and I do not see him.
He moves on, but I do not notice him.
12 He snatches things away. Who can stop him?
Who will say to him, 'What are you doing?'
13 "God does not hold back his anger.
The helpers of Rahab bow down under him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job agrees with his friends: Yes, God is just and mighty. But that is exactly his problem: How can a small human being get justice against such a mighty God?

"Be right" is meant here as in a court of law. Job would like to take God to court. But God is too great.

Job describes God's power in powerful pictures: He moves mountains, shakes the earth, gives orders to the sun, and made the groups of stars.

"He walks on the waves of the sea": Christians think here of Jesus, who walked on the water (Mark 6:48–50).

"He goes past me, and I do not see him": God is there, but hidden. Job cannot grasp him.

"Rahab" here is not the woman from Jericho. It is a sea monster from old stories, a picture for chaos (compare Isaiah 51:9).

I cannot stand up to him VERSES 14–21

14 "How much less could I answer him,
and choose my words to argue with him!
15 Even if I were in the right, I could not answer him.
I would have to beg my judge for mercy.
16 If I called and he answered me,
I would still not believe that he was listening to my voice.
17 For he crushes me with a storm
and gives me more and more wounds without any reason.
18 He does not let me catch my breath.
He fills me with bitterness.
19 If it is a matter of strength, he is mighty!
If it is a matter of justice, he says, 'Who can call me to court?'
20 Even if I am in the right, my own mouth would condemn me.
Even if I am blameless, it would prove me guilty.
21 I am blameless.
I don't care about myself.
I hate my life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job feels completely helpless. Even if he were right, he could not stand before God. God is both judge and opponent.

Verse 17: "He crushes me with a storm and gives me more and more wounds without any reason." God himself had used exactly this word in heaven: "without any reason" (Job 2:3). Job knows nothing about that, but he is right.

Verse 21: "I am blameless." Job holds on to his innocence, even though everyone else tells him the opposite.

God makes no difference VERSES 22–24

22 "It is all the same. That is why I say:
He destroys both the blameless and the wicked.
23 When a disaster suddenly kills,
he mocks the despair of the innocent.
24 The earth has been handed over to the wicked.
He covers the faces of its judges.
If it is not he, then who is it?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These are Job's harshest words so far. He says: God makes no difference between the good and the evil. He destroys both.

He even accuses God of mocking the suffering of the innocent.

"He covers the faces of its judges": The judges on earth are blind to justice.

"If it is not he, then who is it?" Job believes that everything comes from God. So God must also be responsible for injustice.

These words are very bitter. But the Bible does not cross them out. It shows how a person can think and speak in the deepest suffering. At the end, God will say that Job spoke rightly about him, unlike his friends (Job 42:7). God prefers honest lament to pious lies.

If only there were a referee! VERSES 25–35

25 "My days go by faster than a runner.
They run away and see nothing good.
26 They have glided past like fast ships,
like an eagle that swoops down on its prey.
27 If I say, 'I will forget my complaint.
I will stop looking sad and cheer up,'
28 then I am afraid of all my pain.
I know that you will not declare me innocent.
29 I will be found guilty.
So why should I struggle for nothing?
30 Even if I washed myself with snow
and cleaned my hands with lye soap,
31 you would still dip me in a ditch,
and my own clothes would be disgusted by me.
32 For he is not a human being like me, so that I could answer him,
so that we could go to court together.
33 There is no referee between us
who could put his hand on both of us.
34 Let him take his rod away from me.
Let his terror not frighten me.
35 Then I would speak and not be afraid of him.
For that is not how I am inside."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job tries to think positively: "I will cheer up." But it does not work. The pain is too great. A person who suffers cannot simply "be in a good mood."

Verses 30–31: No matter how much he cleans himself, God would make him dirty again. He feels powerless.

Verse 33 is one of the most important verses in the book: Job wishes for a "referee," a go-between between God and human beings, who could "put his hand on both of us." Someone who understands God and human beings and brings them together.

Christians see in this wish a hint of Jesus: "For there is one God and one mediator between God and people: the man Christ Jesus" (1 Timothy 2:5). Jesus is both God and human. Job will develop this thought further later (Job 16:19–21; 19:25).

"That is not how I am inside": This probably means: There is nothing in me that I would have to be afraid of. I know of no guilt in myself.

JOB

Chapter 10

"Your hands made me"

Why do you fight against me? VERSES 1–7

1 "I am sick of my life.
I will let my complaint pour out freely.
I will speak in the bitterness of my soul.
2 I will say to God,
'Do not condemn me!
Show me why you are fighting against me.
3 Do you think it is good to oppress me,
to reject the work of your own hands,
and to smile on the plans of the wicked?
4 Do you have human eyes?
Do you see things the way a human being sees them?
5 Are your days like the days of a mortal,
or your years like the years of a man,
6 that you search for my guilt
and hunt for my sin?
7 You know that I am not wicked.
And there is no one who can rescue anyone from your hand.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job wants to bring his complaint before God. He would at least like to know why he is suffering.

"The work of your own hands": Job reminds God that God himself created him. How can God destroy his own work?

Verses 4–6: Job asks: Are you like a human being who looks for mistakes because he does not know everything? You know everything! You know that I am not wicked!

This is great trust in the middle of a lament: God knows that I am innocent.

You made me with such love VERSES 8–12

8 "'Your hands shaped me and formed me completely,
and yet you are destroying me.
9 Please remember that you shaped me like clay.
Will you turn me back into dust?
10 Didn't you pour me out like milk
and let me thicken like cheese?
11 You clothed me with skin and flesh.
You wove me together with bones and sinews.
12 You gave me life and loving kindness.
Your care has kept my spirit alive.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a wonderful picture of how God forms a human being in the mother's womb. Like a potter, he shapes the clay. Like a weaver, he weaves bones and sinews together (compare Psalm 139:13–16).

"Pour me out like milk and let me thicken like cheese": Back then, people imagined that this is how a child comes into being in the womb.

Job knows: God made me with love. He gave me life and kindness. That is exactly why he does not understand why God is destroying him now.

These verses show: Every human being is lovingly formed by God.

You hid it in your heart VERSES 13–17

13 "'Yet you hid these things in your heart.
I know that this is what you had in mind:
14 If I sin, you watch me closely.
You will not declare me free from my guilt.
15 If I am wicked, how terrible for me!
And if I am in the right, I still cannot lift up my head.
I am full of shame, and I see my misery.
16 If I hold my head high, you hunt me like a lion.
Again you show your mighty power against me.
17 You keep bringing new witnesses against me.
Your anger against me keeps growing.
Wave after wave of attack comes against me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job suspects: From the beginning God had in mind to torment him. This is a terrible thought that comes from his pain.

Whatever he does, he feels lost: If he sins, he is punished. If he is in the right, he is still put to shame.

"New witnesses": His illnesses and losses are like witnesses in a trial, who speak against him.

Why did you let me be born? VERSES 18–22

18 "'Why then did you bring me out of the womb?
I wish I had died, and no eye had seen me!
19 Then I would be as if I had never been.
I would have been carried from the womb straight to the grave.
20 Aren't my days few? Stop!
Leave me alone, so that I can find a little comfort,
21 before I go to the place from which I will not come back,
to the land of darkness and of the shadow of death,
22 the land as dark as midnight,
of the shadow of death, without any order,
where even the light is like midnight.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job returns to his lament from Chapter 3: Why did I have to be born?

He asks God for only one thing: Leave me alone a little, so that I can find some comfort before I die.

He describes the world of the dead as a dark land without order. Even the light there is dark.

If you yourself feel this way: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

JOB

Chapter 11

Zophar: "God asks less of you than you deserve"

Zophar attacks Job VERSES 1–6

1 Then Zophar the Naamathite answered,
2 "Shouldn't all these words get an answer?
Should a man who talks so much be proved right?
3 Should your bragging make people keep quiet?
When you mock, will no one put you to shame?
4 For you say, 'My teaching is pure.
I am clean in your eyes.'
5 Oh, if only God would speak,
and open his lips against you,
6 and show you the secrets of wisdom!
For true wisdom has two sides.
So know this: God asks less of you
than your guilt deserves.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zophar is the harshest of the three friends. He calls Job a big talker and a bragger.

He wishes that God would speak, to put Job in his place. The irony: At the end God really does speak. But he does not correct Job. He corrects the friends (Job 42:7)!

Verse 6 is cruel: "So know this: God asks less of you than your guilt deserves." Zophar tells a man who has lost all his children and his health: Really you deserved even more.

Zophar does not know Job's life at all. He judges without knowing.

God's wisdom cannot be fathomed VERSES 7–12

7 "Can you find out the deep secrets of God?
Can you discover the limits of the Almighty?
8 They are as high as heaven. What can you do?
They are deeper than Sheol (the world of the dead).
What can you know?
9 They are longer than the earth
and wider than the sea.
10 If he passes by, or locks someone up, or calls a court together,
who can stop him?
11 For he knows who is false.
He sees wrongdoing too, even when he does not seem to pay attention to it.
12 An empty-headed man will become wise
when a human being is born as a wild donkey's colt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zophar says something true: God's wisdom is endlessly great. No human being can fully understand it (compare Romans 11:33).

But he uses this truth against Job. If God's ways are so far beyond understanding, then Zophar could not understand them either. And yet he acts as if he knew exactly why Job is suffering.

Verse 12 is a mocking proverb: A fool will become wise just as soon as a human being is born as a wild donkey's colt. So never. Zophar means Job.

Turn back, and everything will be fine VERSES 13–20

13 "If you set your heart right
and stretch out your hands to him,
14 if there is wrongdoing in your hand, put it far away.
Do not let injustice live in your tents.
15 Then surely you will lift up your face without any stain.
Yes, you will stand firm and not be afraid.
16 For you will forget your misery.
You will remember it like water that has flowed past.
17 Your life will be brighter than noon.
Even if there is darkness, it will be like the morning.
18 You will feel safe, because there is hope.
Yes, you will look around and rest in safety.
19 You will lie down, and no one will frighten you.
Yes, many will try to win your favor.
20 But the eyes of the wicked will fail.
They will have no place to escape to.
Their only hope will be to breathe their last."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like Eliphaz and Bildad, Zophar also ends with a beautiful promise: If you turn back, everything will be fine.

That sounds good. And much of it is true. God can turn misery into joy.

But it takes for granted that Job has sinned. That is the problem. The friends say: Admit that you are guilty, then everything will be fine. But Job is not guilty. He cannot admit something that is not true.

The last verse is a warning: If you do not turn back, you are like the wicked. Their only hope is death.

JOB

Chapter 12

"You are the people, and wisdom will die with you!"

Job mocks them VERSES 1–6

1 Then Job answered,

2 "No doubt you are the people that matter,
and wisdom will die with you!
3 But I have understanding as well as you.
I am not less than you.
Yes, who doesn't know such things?
4 I have become a joke to my neighbor,
I, who called on God, and he answered me.
The righteous, blameless man has become a joke.
5 A person who lives at ease looks down on misfortune.
It is waiting for those whose feet slip.
6 The tents of robbers do well.
Those who provoke God are safe,
those who carry their god in their hands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job answers with biting mockery: "You are the only wise people! When you die, there will be no more wisdom in the world!"

He says: What you are telling me, I know too. These are not new insights.

Verse 5 is a wise observation: A person who lives at ease easily looks down on those who are doing badly. People who have never suffered often do not understand those who suffer.

Verse 6: In reality, robbers often do well. The friends' simple formula is not true.

"Those who carry their god in their hands": Maybe this means idols. Or: Their god is their own hand, their violence.

Ask the animals! VERSES 7–12

7 "But ask the animals, and they will teach you.
Ask the birds of the sky, and they will tell you.
8 Or speak to the earth, and it will teach you.
The fish of the sea will explain it to you.
9 Which of all these does not know
that the hand of the LORD has done this?
10 In his hand is the life of every living thing,
and the breath of all people.
11 Doesn't the ear test words,
just as the tongue tastes food?
12 Old people have wisdom.
A long life brings understanding.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job says: Every animal knows that God is mighty! You don't need clever friends for that.

Verse 9 is remarkable: It is the only place in the speeches (Chapters 3–37) where God's name "the LORD" (Yahweh) appears. Otherwise Job and his friends say "God" or "the Almighty."

Verse 10 is a beautiful sentence: In God's hand is the life of all living things and the breath of all people.

Verse 11: Just as you test food with your tongue, you should test words with your ear. Not everything that is said is true.

Verse 12 may be meant ironically: "Old people have wisdom," people say. But Job's old friends are showing no wisdom at all.

God's power over everyone VERSES 13–25

13 "God has wisdom and strength.
He has good advice and understanding.
14 When he tears something down, it cannot be built again.
When he locks a man up, no one can set him free.
15 When he holds back the water, it dries up.
When he lets it go, it floods the earth.
16 He has strength and wisdom.
Both the one who is fooled and the one who fools others belong to him.
17 He leads counselors away stripped bare.
He makes judges into fools.
18 He loosens the bonds of kings.
He ties a belt around their waists.
19 He leads priests away stripped bare.
He overthrows the mighty.
20 He takes away the speech of those who are trusted.
He takes away the good sense of the elders.
21 He pours shame on princes.
He loosens the belt of the strong.
22 He uncovers deep things hidden in the darkness.
He brings the shadow of death into the light.
23 He makes nations grow, and he destroys them.
He makes nations spread out, and he leads them away as captives.
24 He takes away the understanding of the leaders of the peoples of the earth.
He makes them wander in a wilderness where there is no path.
25 They feel their way in the dark without light.
He makes them stagger like a drunk.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job shows that he knows God's power better than his friends do. But he sees it differently: God's power cannot always be explained. God overthrows kings, judges, priests, and whole nations. No one is safe.

"He loosens the bonds of kings. He ties a belt around their waists": Kings are taken prisoner and must wear a belt like slaves.

Verse 16: "Both the one who is fooled and the one who fools others belong to him." God stands above everything, even above good and evil among people.

With this, Job says: You cannot squeeze God's actions into your simple formula. God is greater than your theories.

Remarkable: These words about kings who are overthrown and mighty people who are brought low remind us of Hannah's song of praise (1 Samuel 2:6–8) and Mary's song of praise (Luke 1:52).

JOB

CHAPTER 13

"You are doctors who are worth nothing"

You defend God with lies VERSES 1–12

1 "Look, my eyes have seen all this.
My ears have heard it and understood it.
2 What you know, I know too.
I am not less than you.
3 "But I want to speak to the Almighty.
I want to argue my case with God.
4 But you make up lies.
You are all doctors who are worth nothing.
5 Oh, if only you would be completely silent!
Then you would be wise.
6 Now listen to my argument.
Pay attention to the case my lips are making.
7 Will you say what is wrong to defend God?
Will you tell lies for him?
8 Will you take his side?
Will you argue God's case for him?
9 Would it go well for you if he examined you?
Or will you fool him, the way you fool a human being?
10 He will surely correct you
if you secretly take sides.
11 Won't his majesty frighten you?
Won't the terror of him fall on you?
12 Your wise sayings are proverbs made of ashes.
Your defenses are defenses made of clay.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job no longer wants to talk with his friends. He wants to talk directly with God.

He calls his friends people who "make up lies" and "doctors who are worth nothing." They wanted to heal him, but their medicine makes everything worse.

Verse 5 is famous: "Oh, if only you would be completely silent! Then you would be wise." At the beginning, they had been silent for seven days (Job 2:13). That was the best thing they did.

Verses 7–8 are sharp criticism: The friends want to defend God by saying untrue things about Job. Job says: God does not need lies to defend him. God wants the truth.

At the end of the book, God will confirm exactly this (Job 42:7).

"Proverbs made of ashes": Their clever sentences are worthless. They fall apart when you touch them.

I will defend my ways before God VERSES 13–19

13 "Be quiet! Leave me alone, so that I can speak.
Let whatever may happen to me come.
14 Why should I take my flesh in my teeth
and put my life in my hand?
15 He will kill me. I have no hope.
Even so, I will defend my ways before him.
16 This too will be my rescue:
A godless person would not dare to come before him.
17 Listen carefully to what I say.
Let my words fill your ears.
18 Look, I have prepared my case.
I know that I am in the right.
19 Who is there who will argue against me?
If someone could, I would be quiet and die.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job is ready to risk everything. He wants to come before God, even if it costs him his life.

"Take my flesh in my teeth" and "put my life in my hand" are sayings. They mean: I am risking everything.

Verse 15 is very well known, but it is hard to understand in Hebrew. The WEB, our English source text, follows the written Hebrew text: "He will kill me. I have no hope." At this place, the Jewish tradition reads one word differently. Then it says: "Even if he kills me, I will hope in him." That is how many Bibles have it. Both readings show: Job does not give up on God. He wants to face him.

Verse 16: Job is sure that a godless person would not dare to come before God. That he dares to do it shows that he is innocent.

Job speaks to God VERSES 20–28

20 "Only do not do two things to me.
Then I will not hide from your face:
21 Take your hand far away from me,
and do not let your terror frighten me.
22 Then call, and I will answer.
Or let me speak, and you answer me.
23 How many wrongs and sins have I done?
Show me my wrongdoing and my sin!
24 Why do you hide your face
and think of me as your enemy?
25 Will you chase a leaf blown by the wind?
Will you hunt down dry straw?
26 For you write bitter charges against me.
You make me pay for the sins of my youth.
27 You also lock my feet in the stocks.
You watch every path I take.
You draw a line around the soles of my feet,
28 though I am rotting away like something decayed,
like a piece of clothing eaten by moths.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Job speaks directly to God. He asks for only two things: Take the pain away, and do not let me be afraid of you. Then he will speak.

Verse 23: Job wants to know what he did wrong. He is ready to see his guilt if God shows it to him.

Verse 24 is the deepest pain: "Why do you hide your face?" The worst thing for Job is not the illness. It is that God is silent and seems far away (compare Psalm 13:1; 22:1).

"A leaf blown by the wind": Job feels so weak and small. Why does the almighty God fight against something so small?

"The sins of my youth": Maybe he is thinking of small mistakes from his younger years. Should they be the reason for so much suffering?

"The stocks" were a wooden beam in which the feet of prisoners were locked.

JOB

CHAPTER 14

"If a man dies, will he live again?"

A human life is short VERSES 1–6

1 "A human being, born of a woman,
lives only a few days, and they are full of trouble.
2 He grows up like a flower, and then he is cut down.
He slips away like a shadow and does not last.
3 Do you really keep your eyes open on someone like that?
Do you bring me into court with you?
4 Who can bring something clean out of something unclean?
No one.
5 His days are already set.
The number of his months is decided by you.
You have set limits for him that he cannot pass.
6 So look away from him, so that he can rest,
until he finishes his day like a hired worker.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses about the shortness of life are very well known. They are often read at funerals.

Life is like a flower: beautiful, but quickly wilted (compare Psalm 90:5–6; 103:15–16; Isaiah 40:6–8).

Job asks God: If life is so short, then at least leave a person alone, so that he can live his short time in peace.

Verse 4: No human being is completely pure. Job admits that he is not perfect. But he asks: Why is he of all people treated so harshly?

Hope for a tree, but for a human being? VERSES 7–12

7 "For there is hope for a tree:
If it is cut down, it will sprout again.
Its new shoots will not stop growing.
8 Its root may grow old in the earth,
and its stump may die in the ground.
9 Yet at the mere smell of water it will bud
and put out branches like a young plant.
10 But a human being dies and lies there.
Yes, he breathes his last. And where is he?
11 As water disappears from the sea,
and a river runs low and dries up,
12 so a human being lies down and does not rise.
Until the heavens are no more, people will not wake up.
They will not be woken from their sleep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A beautiful and sad picture: A tree that has been cut down can sprout again. Even the smell of water makes it grow again.

But a human being? When he dies, he is gone. Like a dried-up river.

"Until the heavens are no more": Job probably means: never. But later parts of the Bible speak of exactly this: God creates a new heaven and raises the dead (Isaiah 65:17; Daniel 12:2; Revelation 21:1).

Later, Isaiah uses the picture of a tree stump as a picture of hope: "A shoot will come out of the stump of Jesse" (Isaiah 11:1).

A quiet hope VERSES 13–17

13 "Oh, if only you would hide me in Sheol (the world of the dead)
and keep me hidden until your anger is over!
If only you would set a time for me and then remember me!
14 If a man dies, will he live again?
I would wait all the days of my hard service,
until my relief came.
15 You would call, and I would answer you.
You would long for the work of your hands.
16 But now you count my steps.
Don't you keep watch over my sin?
17 My wrongdoing is sealed up in a bag.
You tie up my guilt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a quiet hope shines through. Job imagines: Maybe God will hide him in the world of the dead, only for a while, until his anger is over. And then God will remember him.

Verse 14 asks the big question: "If a man dies, will he live again?" Job does not know the answer. But he dares to ask the question.

Verse 15 is very beautiful: "You would long for the work of your hands." Deep inside, Job believes that God loves him and misses him.

Christians see in this question a hint of the resurrection that Jesus speaks about: "I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me will live, even if he dies" (John 11:25).

"Sealed up in a bag": God collects Job's guilt as if in a closed bag. Some also understand it this way: God closes up the guilt and does not look at it anymore.

But the hope melts away VERSES 18–22

18 "But a mountain that falls crumbles away.
A rock is moved from its place.
19 Water wears away stones.
Its floods wash away the soil of the earth.
In the same way you destroy a human being's hope.
20 You overpower him forever, and he passes away.
You change his face and send him away.
21 His sons are honored, and he does not know it.
They are brought low, but he does not notice it.
22 But he feels the pain in his own body.
His soul inside him mourns."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The hope lasted only a short time. Now it grows dark again.

As water slowly wears away stones, God slowly destroys a person's hope.

Verse 21 is especially painful for Job: A dead person no longer finds out how his children are doing. Job has no children anymore.

Job swings back and forth between hope and despair. That is very human. Many people who are grieving know this back and forth.

JOB

Chapter 15

Eliphaz's second speech: "Your own mouth condemns you"

You speak against God VERSES 1–6

1 Then Eliphaz the Temanite answered,
2 "Should a wise man answer with empty knowledge
and fill his belly with the east wind?
3 Should he argue with useless talk,
or with speeches that do no good?
4 Yes, you are doing away with the fear of God.
You are standing in the way of devotion to God.
5 For your guilt teaches your mouth what to say.
You choose the language of the crafty.
6 Your own mouth condemns you, not I.
Yes, your own lips speak against you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the second round of speeches begins. Eliphaz is no longer as polite as the first time.

"The east wind" is the hot desert wind that brings only heat and dust. Eliphaz means: Your words are hot air.

He accuses Job: With your complaints you are destroying faith. Because of you, others could lose their respect for God.

Verses 5–6: Eliphaz says: Your words prove that you are guilty. Only a guilty person talks like that.

Do you think you are wiser than everyone? VERSES 7–16

7 "Were you the first human being ever born?
Were you brought into being before the hills?
8 Have you listened in on God's secret council?
Do you keep wisdom all to yourself?
9 What do you know that we don't know?
What do you understand that we don't understand
too?
10 We have gray-haired men among us, and very old men,
much older than your father.
11 Are God's comforts too small for you,
even the words that treat you gently?
12 Why does your heart carry you away?
Why do your eyes flash,
13 so that you turn your spirit against God
and let such words come out of your mouth?
14 What is a human being, that he could be clean?
What is someone born of a woman, that he could be
righteous?
15 God does not even trust his holy ones.
Even the heavens are not clean in his eyes.
16 How much less someone disgusting and corrupt,
a man who drinks wrongdoing like water!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz mocks: Are you the first human being who ever lived? Were you there when God made the world? Do you think you are wiser than everyone?

The irony: Later God will ask Job similar questions (Job 38:4). But not to condemn him.

Verse 10: Eliphaz points to the wisdom of the old.

Verse 11: Eliphaz thinks his own words are "God's comforts" and gentle words. He does not notice how much he hurts Job.

Verses 14–16 repeat the thought from Job 4:17–19.

But now it is sharper: Verse 16 speaks of a man "who drinks wrongdoing like water." Eliphaz probably means Job too.

What happens to the wicked VERSES 17–35

17 "I will show you. Listen to me.
I will tell you what I have seen.
18 Wise men have told it, as they learned it from their
ancestors.
They have not hidden it.
19 The land was given to those ancestors alone.
No foreigner moved among them.
20 The wicked man twists in pain all his days,
all the years that are stored up for the oppressor.
21 Terrifying sounds are in his ears.
When things are going well, the destroyer will come
on him.
22 He does not believe that he will come back out of the
darkness.
The sword is waiting for him.
23 He wanders around looking for bread and says, 'Where
is it?'
He knows that the day of darkness is close at hand.
24 Distress and anguish frighten him.
They overpower him, like a king ready for battle.
25 For he has stretched out his hand against God.
He has acted proudly against the Almighty.
26 He charges at him stubbornly,
with his thick, heavy shields.
27 For he has covered his face with his fat
and put on fat around his hips.
28 He has lived in ruined cities,
in houses where no one lived,
houses that were about to become heaps of rubble.
29 He will not stay rich.
His wealth will not last.
Their possessions will not spread over the earth.
30 He will not escape the darkness.
The flame will dry up his branches.
He will be carried away by the breath of God's mouth.
31 Let him not trust in what is empty and so fool himself,
for emptiness will be his reward.
32 It will happen before his time.
His branch will not be green.
33 He will shake off his unripe grapes like a vine.
He will drop his blossoms like an olive tree.
34 For the company of the godless will be barren.
Fire will burn up the tents of those who take bribes.
35 They become pregnant with trouble and give birth to
wrongdoing.
Their hearts prepare deceit."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz describes in detail what happens to the wicked: He lives in constant fear, loses everything, and dies early.

He does not say it directly, but everyone understands: This is a picture of Job. Job is afraid, and he has lost everything. So he must be a wicked man.

In the Bible, "fat" was often a picture for wealth and self-satisfaction.

Some of this is true: People who do evil often live in fear. But Eliphaz makes it into a rule that is supposed to be true always. And he applies it to an innocent man.

Verse 35 is a strong picture: The wicked "become pregnant with trouble." Evil grows inside them like a child until it is born.

JOB

CHAPTER 16

"My witness is in heaven"

You are miserable comforters VERSES 1–5

1 Then Job answered,
2 "I have heard many things like this.
You are all miserable comforters!
3 Will your empty words ever end?
What is bothering you, that you keep answering?
4 I could also speak the way you do,
if you were in my place.
I could string words together against you
and shake my head at you.
5 But I would make you strong with my words.
The comfort of my lips would ease your pain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Miserable comforters": This expression has become a saying. It describes people who want to comfort, but make everything worse with their words.

Job says: If you were in my place, I could also talk the way you do. But I would not do it. I would comfort you and make you strong.

This is an important thought: How would I feel if I were in the place of the one who is suffering? This question helps us to comfort in the right way (compare Matthew 7:12).

God has attacked me VERSES 6–17

6 "If I speak, my pain does not get better.
If I keep quiet, does any of it go away?
7 But now, God, you have truly worn me out.
You have destroyed my whole family.
8 You have made me shrivel up. That is a witness against me.
My thin body rises up against me.
It testifies against me to my face.
9 He has torn me apart in his anger and hunted me down.
He has ground his teeth at me.
My enemy looks at me with sharp eyes.
10 People have opened their mouths wide against me.
They have slapped my cheek to shame me.
They gang up together against me.
11 God hands me over to the ungodly.
He throws me into the hands of the wicked.
12 I was living in peace, and he broke me apart.
Yes, he has grabbed me by the neck and smashed me to pieces.
He has also set me up as his target.
13 His archers surround me.
He splits my kidneys open and does not spare me.
He pours out my bile on the ground.
14 He breaks through me, again and again, like a wall.
He charges at me like a warrior.
15 I have sewn rough sackcloth over my skin.
I have pushed my horn into the dust.
16 My face is red from crying.
Deep darkness lies on my eyelids,
17 even though there is no violence in my hands,
and my prayer is pure.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job describes his suffering in strong pictures: God is like a wild animal that tears him apart. Like a warrior who attacks him. Like an archer who uses him as a target. Like an army that breaks through a city wall.

People also mock him and slap him on the cheek.

"Pushed my horn into the dust": The horn is a picture for strength and honor. Job has lost all his dignity.

Verse 17 is the heart of it: Job suffers "even though there is no violence in my hands, and my prayer is pure." He insists: I am innocent.

Some words in verse 10 remind Christians of the suffering of Jesus, who was also mocked and struck, even though he was innocent (Matthew 26:67).

My witness is in heaven VERSES 18–22

18 "Earth, do not cover my blood!
Let my cry find no place to rest!
19 Even now, look, my witness is in heaven.
The one who speaks up for me is on high.
20 My friends mock me.
My eyes pour out tears to God.
21 I want him to defend a man's case before God,
and a person's case with his neighbor!
22 For in only a few years
I will go on the road from which I will not come back.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Earth, do not cover my blood": Innocent blood that has been shed cries out to heaven (compare Abel in Genesis 4:10). Job wants his cry not to fall silent, even if he dies.

Verse 19 is a great statement of faith: "Even now, look, my witness is in heaven." In the middle of the deepest despair, Job believes: There is someone in heaven who stands up for me. In Job 9:33 he had wished for a referee. Now he says: There is one!

Who is this witness? Maybe God himself. Then Job would be appealing to God against God: to the God who is just, against the God who seems to torment him.

Verse 21: He is to defend "a man's case before God," like a lawyer.

Christians see here a hint of Jesus, who "speaks up for us" before God (Romans 8:34; Hebrews 7:25; 1 John 2:1).

JOB

Chapter 17

"Where then is my hope?"

You be my guarantee! VERSES 1–5

1 "My spirit is used up.
My days are burned out.
The grave is ready for me.
2 There are mockers all around me.
My eyes have to look at their insults.
3 "Now give a pledge for me. Be my guarantee before yourself.
Who else will shake hands on it with me?
4 For you have closed their hearts to understanding.
That is why you will not let them win.
5 Whoever turns in his friends to get a share of the loot,
even the eyes of his children will fail.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job feels that death is near.

Verse 3 is amazing: Job asks God himself to stand guarantee for him, before God! He has no one else to stand up for him. His friends do not help him. So he turns to God himself.

"Shake hands on it" was a gesture to seal a guarantee.

Verse 5 is probably a proverb: Whoever betrays his friends to gain something for himself will be punished. Job probably means his friends.

A joke to everyone VERSES 6–10

6 "But he has made me a byword among the people,
a name they use to mock.
They spit in my face.
7 My eyes have grown dim with grief.
My whole body is like a shadow.
8 Honest people will be shocked by this.
The innocent will rise up against the godless.
9 Yet the righteous will hold on to his way.
Whoever has clean hands will grow stronger and stronger.
10 But as for all of you, come back again!
I will not find a wise man among you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job has become so thin that he is only a shadow of himself. People spit in his face.

Verse 9 is a ray of light: "Yet the righteous will hold on to his way. Whoever has clean hands will grow stronger and stronger." This is a confession that applies to Job himself too. He does not give up.

Verse 10: Job challenges his friends: Come on, keep talking, but you have no wisdom.

Where is my hope? VERSES 11–16

11 "My days are over.
My plans are torn apart,
and so are the wishes of my heart.
12 They turn night into day.
'The light is near,' they say, when it is dark.
13 If I look to Sheol (the world of the dead) as my home,
if I have made my bed in the darkness,
14 if I have said to decay, 'You are my father,'
and to the worm, 'My mother' and 'My sister,'
15 where then is my hope?
And my hope – who will see it?
16 Will it go down with me to the gates of Sheol?
Will we go down into the dust together?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: The friends want to talk Job into believing that everything will soon be fine. "The light is near!" But Job sees only darkness. False optimism does not help people who are suffering.

Verses 13–14 are very dark: The grave is his home, decay is his father, the worm is his mother and sister. He has no other family anymore.

Verse 15: "Where then is my hope?" That is the question of the whole book. Will his hope go into the grave with him?

The chapter ends without an answer. But that is exactly what is honest about it. Sometimes we have no answer. And still Job asks the question, and he asks it to God.

If you yourself are in such despair: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

JOB

Chapter 18

Bildad's second speech: The end of the wicked

Stop hunting for words VERSES 1–4

1 Then Bildad the Shuhite answered,
2 "How long will you keep hunting for words?
Think about it, and then we will talk.

3 Why are we treated like animals?
Why are we unclean in your eyes?
4 You tear yourself apart in your anger.
Should the earth be abandoned because of you?
Should the rock be moved from its place?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bildad is offended. Job had said that there was no wise man among them. Bildad asks: Do you think we are stupid animals?

Verse 4 is mocking: Do you think the whole order of the world will change because of you? The rule is: Whoever suffers is guilty. This rule is as firm as a rock. It will not be overturned because of you.

The traps of the wicked VERSES 5–10

5 "Yes, the light of the wicked will be put out.
The spark of his fire will not shine.
6 The light in his tent will grow dark.
His lamp above him will go out.
7 His strong steps will become short.
His own plans will bring him down.
8 For his own feet lead him into a net.
He walks right into its mesh.
9 A snare grabs him by the heel.
A trap holds him tight.
10 A rope is hidden for him in the ground.
A trap is set for him on the path.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bildad describes what happens to the wicked. His light goes out, and he falls into traps.

Six different words for traps and nets: The wicked is surrounded on all sides by dangers that he has set up himself.

This is well-known wisdom: Whoever plans evil often falls into it himself (compare Psalm 7:16; Proverbs 26:27). But Bildad applies it to Job again.

The king of terrors VERSES 11–21

11 "Terrors will frighten him on every side.
They will follow at his heels.
12 His strength will starve.
Disaster stands ready at his side.
13 The parts of his body will be eaten away.
The firstborn of death will eat up his limbs.
14 He will be torn out of the safety of his tent.
He will be brought to the king of terrors.
15 Things that are not his will live in his tent.
Sulfur will be scattered over his home.
16 His roots will dry up below.
His branch will be cut off above.
17 The memory of him will disappear from the earth.
No one will speak his name in the street.
18 He will be driven out of the light into the darkness,
and chased out of the world.
19 He will have no son or grandson among his people.
No one will be left where he lived.
20 Those who come after him will be shocked at what happened to him,
just as those who came before were filled with fear.
21 Surely this is what happens to the homes of the unrighteous.
This is the place of the one who does not know God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bildad's speech is cruel when you think of Job:

– "The parts of his body will be eaten away": That is exactly what Job is going through with his illness.

– "He will have no son or grandson": Job has lost all his children.

– "Sulfur will be scattered over his home": Like with Job, when "the fire of God fell from the sky" (Job 1:16).

Bildad does not say it directly, but every sentence is aimed at Job. At the end he concludes: This is what happens to "the one who does not know God." That is a monstrous accusation against a man whom God himself called blameless.

"The firstborn of death" is probably a deadly disease. "The king of terrors" is death itself.

This speech shows how dangerous it is to apply a right teaching in the wrong way. Bildad talks about God and at the same time deeply hurts a human being.

JOB

CHAPTER 19

"I know that my Redeemer lives"

How long will you torment me? VERSES 1–6

1 Then Job answered,
2 "How long will you torment me
and crush me with words?
3 You have insulted me 10 times now.
You are not ashamed to attack me.
4 If it is true that I have gone wrong,
my mistake stays with me.
5 If you really want to make yourselves bigger than me,
and use my shame as proof against me,
6 then know this: God has done me wrong.
He has surrounded me with his net.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"10 times" means: again and again. Job is worn out by the constant accusations.

Verse 4: Even if I have made a mistake, it is none of your business. It is a matter between me and God.

Verse 6: Bildad had said that the wicked man walks into his own net (Job 18:8). Job answers: No, God has put the net around me. I am not to blame.

Abandoned by God and by everyone VERSES 7–22

7 "Look, I cry out, 'Violence!' but I get no answer.
I call for help, but there is no justice.
8 He has walled up my road so that I cannot get through.
He has put darkness on my paths.

9 He has stripped my honor from me.
He has taken the crown from my head.
10 He has torn me down on every side, and I am finished.
He has pulled up my hope like a tree.
11 He has also let his anger burn against me.
He counts me as one of his enemies.
12 His troops come together.
They build a ramp to attack me,
and they camp all around my tent.
13 "He has put my brothers far away from me.
The people I know have become complete strangers to me.
14 My relatives have gone away.
My close friends have forgotten me.
15 The people who live in my house and my female servants treat me like a stranger.
I am a foreigner in their eyes.
16 I call my servant, and he does not answer me.
I have to beg him with my own mouth.
17 My breath disgusts my wife.
I am disgusting to my own brothers and sisters.
18 Even little children look down on me.
When I get up, they talk against me.
19 All my close friends hate me.
The people I loved have turned against me.
20 My bones stick to my skin and my flesh.
I have escaped by the skin of my teeth.
21 "Have pity on me, have pity on me, you my friends,
for the hand of God has struck me!
22 Why do you hunt me down as God does?
Why are you never satisfied with my flesh?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job describes how completely alone he is. Not only does God seem to be against him, but all people too: brothers, friends, relatives, male and female servants, his wife, even little children.

He was once a respected man. Now he is a stranger in his own house. Illness and suffering often make people lonely. Many sick people still experience this today.

"By the skin of my teeth" is a saying that is still known in many languages today. It means: just barely, with almost nothing. After all, teeth have no skin.

Verse 21 is a heartbreaking cry for help: "Have pity on me!" Job does not ask for explanations. He asks for compassion.

Verse 22: "Why do you hunt me down as God does?" The friends make themselves judges, as if they were God.

I know that my Redeemer lives VERSES 23–29

23 "Oh, if only my words were written down!
Oh, if only they were written in a book!
24 If only they were carved into the rock forever
with an iron pen and lead!
25 But as for me, I know that my Redeemer lives.
In the end he will stand on the earth.
26 After my skin has been destroyed,
I will still see God in my flesh.
27 I myself will see him, and he will be on my side.
My own eyes will see him, and not as a stranger.
My heart grows faint inside me.
28 If you say, 'How we will hunt him down!'
because the root of the problem is found in me,
29 then be afraid of the sword!
For anger brings the punishment of the sword,
so that you will know there is a judgment."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job wishes that his words would be kept forever, carved in stone. Then later generations would know that he was innocent. His wish came true: His words are in the Bible and have been read for thousands of years.

Verses 25–27 are among the most famous verses in the whole Bible: "But as for me, I know that my Redeemer lives."

In Israel, a "redeemer" (in Hebrew "go'el") was a close relative who stood up for a person in need. He bought him free from slavery, bought back his land, or made sure he got justice (compare Leviticus 25:25; Ruth 4).

Job has been abandoned by everyone. But he believes: There is someone who stands up for me. He lives. And in the end he will appear.

"See God in my flesh": Job hopes to see God himself, not as a stranger, but on his side. Whether he means before or after his death is not completely clear in Hebrew.

Very early, Christians related these words to Jesus, the living Redeemer, and to the hope of the resurrection. George Frideric Handel set them to music in his "Messiah," in a famous aria.

At the end of the book Job really does see God. He says to God: Now my eye sees you (Job 42:5).

Verses 28–29: Job warns his friends. If they keep hunting him down, they themselves will stand before God's judgment.

JOB

CHAPTER 20

Zophar's second speech: The short happiness of the wicked

The joy of the wicked is short VERSES 1–11

1 Then Zophar the Naamathite answered,
2 "That is why my thoughts give me an answer,
because I am so stirred up inside.
3 I have heard a warning that puts me to shame.
But my understanding gives me an answer.
4 Don't you know this from long ago,
ever since human beings were put on the earth:
5 The cheering of the wicked is short.
The joy of the godless lasts only a moment.
6 His pride may rise up to the heavens,
and his head may reach the clouds.
7 Yet he will be gone forever, like his own dung.
Those who have seen him will say, 'Where is he?'
8 He will fly away like a dream and not be found.
Yes, he will be chased away like a vision in the night.

9 The eye that saw him will not see him again.
His place will not see him anymore.
10 His children will have to beg the poor for help.
His hands will have to give back his wealth.
11 His bones are full of the strength of youth,
but it will lie down with him in the dust.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zophar is offended. Job had warned the friends (Job 19:29). Zophar feels put to shame and answers in an agitated way.

He paid no attention at all to Job's great confession, "I know that my Redeemer lives." He just keeps talking about his theory.

His teaching: The wicked are happy only for a short time. Even if they rise up to the heavens, they soon fall.

The crude picture "like his own dung" shows how much Zophar looks down on the wicked.

Verse 10: The children of the wicked even have to ask the poor for help. And he has to give back everything he stole.

Evil tastes sweet, but turns into poison VERSES 12–19

12 "Evil may taste sweet in his mouth.
He may hide it under his tongue.
13 He may hold on to it and not let it go,
but keep it in his mouth.
14 Yet his food turns sour in his stomach.
It becomes cobra venom inside him.
15 He has swallowed riches, and he will vomit them up again.
God will throw them out of his belly.
16 He will suck cobra venom.
The viper's tongue will kill him.
17 He will not enjoy the rivers,
the flowing streams of honey and butter.
18 He will have to give back what he worked for.
He will not be able to swallow it.
He will not enjoy the wealth he has gained.
19 For he has oppressed the poor and left them helpless.
He has taken a house by force,
and he will not build it up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A strong picture: At first evil tastes sweet, like a candy you keep in your mouth. But in the stomach it becomes poison.

This is an important truth: Doing wrong can feel good at first. But it destroys the one who does it.

Verse 19 names the sin: He has oppressed the poor and taken their houses away from them.

"Streams of honey and butter": a picture of wealth and plenty.

Is Zophar accusing Job of oppressing the poor? He does not say it directly. But in Chapter 22, Eliphaz will claim exactly this. And in Chapters 29 and 31, Job will show that he always helped the poor.

God's anger strikes him VERSES 20–29

20 "Because he never knew peace inside himself,
he will not save anything he enjoys.
21 There was nothing left that he did not gobble up.
That is why his wealth will not last.
22 When he has more than enough, trouble will catch up with him.
Everyone who is in misery will raise a hand against him.
23 Just when he is about to fill his belly,
God will throw his burning anger at him.
It will rain down on him while he is eating.
24 He will run away from the iron weapon,
but the bronze arrow will pierce him.
25 He pulls it out, and it comes out of his body.
Yes, the shining point comes out of his liver.
Terrors come over him.
26 Total darkness is waiting for his treasures.
A fire that no one fanned will burn him up.
It will burn up whatever is left in his tent.
27 The heavens will reveal his guilt.
The earth will rise up against him.
28 The wealth of his house will be carried off.
It will flow away on the day of God's anger.
29 This is what God gives to a wicked man.
This is the inheritance God has set for him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zophar describes God's punishment of the wicked in harsh, vivid pictures: God's anger rains down on him, arrows pierce him, fire burns him up.

"A fire that no one fanned": A fire from God, maybe lightning. This reminds us of Job 1:16, when "the fire of God" burned up Job's sheep. Zophar is aiming at Job again.

Verse 27: Heaven and earth come forward as witnesses against him. Job had said, "Even now, look, my witness is in heaven" (Job 16:19). Zophar answers: Heaven will be a witness against you!

This is Zophar's last speech. In the third round, he will not speak anymore. Maybe he ran out of things to say.

JOB

CHAPTER 21

"Why do the wicked live?"

Please listen to me! VERSES 1–6

1 Then Job answered,
2 "Listen carefully to what I say.
Let that be the comfort you give me.
3 Let me speak.
After I have spoken, go on mocking.
4 As for me, is my complaint against a human being?
Why shouldn't I be impatient?
5 Look at me and be shocked.
Put your hand over your mouth.
6 When I think about it, I am troubled.
My body shakes with horror.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2 is bitter: The only comfort you can give me is to listen to me.

"Put your hand over your mouth": a sign that you are speechless and keep quiet.

Job says: My complaint is aimed at God, not at people. So I may be impatient.

The wicked are doing well VERSES 7–16

7 "Why do the wicked go on living?
Why do they grow old and become very powerful?
8 Their children are settled around them.
They see their descendants grow up before their eyes.
9 Their houses are safe, with nothing to fear.
God's rod does not strike them.
10 Their bulls breed and never fail.
Their cows give birth and never lose a calf.
11 They send out their little ones like a flock.
Their children dance.
12 They sing to the tambourine and the harp.
They have fun at the sound of the flute.
13 They spend their days in good times.
Then in an instant they go down to Sheol (the world of the dead).
14 They say to God, 'Go away from us!
We don't want to know your ways.
15 Who is the Almighty, that we should serve him?
What would we gain if we prayed to him?'
16 Yet their good fortune is not in their own hands.
The plans of the wicked are far from me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Job attacks the friends' teaching directly. They have said: Things go badly for the wicked. Job says: Just look at reality! Things often go very well for the wicked!

They grow old, have many children, their houses are safe, their animals thrive, their children dance and sing. And they die peacefully, "in an instant," without long suffering.

And this even though they look down on God: "What would we gain if we prayed to him?"

Other parts of the Bible ask this question too (Psalm 73; Jeremiah 12:1). Why do evil people do well?

Verse 16: Job clearly separates himself from them. He does not want to live like the wicked, even if they are doing well.

How often are the wicked really punished? VERSES 17–21

17 "How often is the lamp of the wicked put out?
How often does disaster come on them?
How often does God hand out pain in his anger?
18 How often are they like straw in the wind,
like chaff that the storm carries away?
19 You say, 'God stores up a man's guilt for his children.'
Let God pay back the man himself, so that he feels it!
20 Let his own eyes see his ruin.
Let him drink the anger of the Almighty.
21 For what does he care about his family after him,
when the number of his months has run out?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bildad had said, "Yes, the light of the wicked will be put out" (Job 18:5). Job asks: How often does that really happen? Rarely!

The friends say: If the wicked man himself is not punished, then his children will be punished. Job thinks this is unfair: The one who did wrong should feel the results himself, not his children. After his death, he does not care anyway what happens to his children.

This fits with what the prophet Ezekiel later says: Everyone is responsible for his own guilt (Ezekiel 18:20).

In death everyone is equal VERSES 22–26

22 "Can anyone teach God knowledge,
since he judges even those who are high up?
23 One man dies in his full strength,
completely at ease and quiet.
24 His buckets are full of milk.
The marrow of his bones is still moist.
25 Another man dies with a bitter soul.
He never tasted anything good.
26 They lie down together in the dust.
The worms cover them both.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job says: You cannot tell who is good and who is evil if you only look at their lives. One dies happy, the other unhappy. And in the end both lie in the grave.

The Preacher in Ecclesiastes says something similar (Ecclesiastes 9:2–3).

Verse 22: No one can teach God. But that is exactly what the friends are trying to do with their theory.

Your comfort is lies VERSES 27–34

27 "Look, I know your thoughts,
the plans you have to do me wrong.
28 For you say, 'Where is the house of the prince now?
Where is the tent where the wicked lived?'
29 Haven't you asked people who travel?
Don't you know what they report?
30 They say that the evil man is kept for the day of disaster,
that such people are led out to the day of anger.
31 Who will tell him to his face what he has done?
Who will pay him back for it?
32 Yet he is carried to the grave,
and people keep watch over his tomb.
33 The soil of the valley is sweet to him.
All people will follow after him,
just as countless people went before him.
34 So how can you comfort me with nonsense?
Nothing is left of your answers but lies."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job sees through his friends: When you ask, "Where is the house of the prince now?" you mean my destroyed house.

He says: Just ask the travelers who have seen much of the world. They know: The evil man often even gets a beautiful funeral with an honored grave. Many follow in his funeral procession. No one holds his deeds against him while he is alive.

Verse 30 is not completely clear in Hebrew. The WEB, our English source text, understands it this way: The evil man is kept for the day of disaster. Then this would be the friends' opinion, which Job repeats here. But many other Bibles translate it the way the context suggests: The evil man is spared on the day of disaster.

Verse 34 is Job's verdict on the whole second round: Your answers are lies. They do not fit reality.

Job does not deny that God is just. But he refuses to accept an easy explanation that is not true. That is honest faith.

JOB

CHAPTER 22

Eliphaz's third speech: an open accusation

Does God gain anything if you are righteous? VERSES 1–4

1 Then Eliphaz the Temanite answered,
2 "Can a person be useful to God?
No, a wise person is only useful to himself.
3 Does it give the Almighty any joy that you are righteous?
Does he gain anything if you make your ways perfect?
4 Is it because you fear him that he corrects you?
Is that why he takes you to court?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz says: God is so great that he needs nothing from us. Whether you are good or bad changes nothing for God.

Verse 4 is ironic: God surely does not punish you because you are devout! So there must be another reason.

The irony for the reader: That is exactly what happened! God praised Job before Satan precisely because Job was devout (Job 1:8). And that is why Job was tested. Eliphaz has no idea how right he is without meaning to be.

And: God does take joy in a righteous person. The whole Bible shows this.

The concrete accusations VERSES 5–11

5 "Isn't your evil great?
Your guilt has no end.
6 For you took things from your brothers as security for a debt, for no reason.
You took the clothes off people and left them naked.
7 You did not give water to the tired to drink.
You held back bread from the hungry.
8 But the powerful man owned the land,
and the honored man lived in it.
9 You sent widows away with empty hands.
The arms of the orphans were broken.
10 That is why traps are all around you,
and sudden fear troubles you,
11 or darkness, so that you cannot see,
and floods of water cover you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Eliphaz gets concrete. He accuses Job of serious sins: Job supposedly took advantage of poor people, gave no bread to the hungry and left widows and orphans alone.

But Eliphaz has no proof. He makes up these accusations because his theory needs them. He thinks: Job suffers badly, so he must have sinned badly. And since a rich man like Job could most easily sin against the poor, Eliphaz accuses him of that.

That is slander. In Chapters 29 and 31, Job will show that he did exactly the opposite: He was a father to the poor and helped widows and orphans.

Here you can see where a false theory can lead: People accuse the innocent so that the theory will be right.

God sees everything VERSES 12–20

12 "Isn't God high up in heaven?
Look how high the stars are!
13 And you say, 'What does God know?
Can he judge through the thick darkness?
14 Thick clouds cover him, so that he does not see.
He walks on the dome of the sky.'
15 Will you keep to the old path
that evil people walked on?
16 They were snatched away before their time.
Their foundation was washed away like a river.
17 They said to God, 'Go away from us!'
and, 'What can the Almighty do for us?'
18 Yet he filled their houses with good things.
But the plans of the wicked are far from me.
19 The righteous see it and are glad.
The innocent make fun of them.
20 They say, 'Surely those who rose up against us are destroyed.
The fire has burned up what was left of them.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliphaz puts words into Job's mouth that Job never said: What does God know? He doesn't see anything. On the contrary, Job always said that God sees everything.

"The old path that evil people walked on": Maybe Eliphaz is thinking of the people at the time of the Flood, who were washed away by floods of water.

Verses 17–18 repeat Job's words from Job 21:14–16 almost word for word. Eliphaz turns them against Job.

Turn back to the Almighty! VERSES 21–30

21 "Get to know him now, and be at peace.
That way good things will come to you.
22 Please accept teaching from his mouth.
Keep his words in your heart.
23 If you return to the Almighty, you will be built up again,
if you put wrongdoing far away from your tents.
24 Throw your treasure into the dust,
the gold of Ophir among the stones of the streams.
25 Then the Almighty will be your treasure,
and precious silver to you.
26 For then you will find joy in the Almighty,
and you will lift up your face to God.
27 You will pray to him, and he will hear you.
You will keep your promises to him.
28 You will also decide on something, and it will happen for you.
Light will shine on your ways.
29 When people are brought down, you will say, 'Be lifted up.'

He will save the humble person.
30 He will even rescue the one who is not innocent.
Yes, that person will be rescued because your hands are clean."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, Eliphaz becomes friendly again. He invites Job to turn back. Many of these words are beautiful: "Then the Almighty will be your treasure." "You will pray to him, and he will hear you."

God himself is the greatest treasure. That is a true and deep insight.

Ophir was a land that was famous for its fine gold.

Verse 30 is amazing: Eliphaz says that even guilty people can be rescued when a righteous person prays for them. That is exactly what will happen at the end, but the other way around: Job will pray for Eliphaz, and God will forgive Eliphaz for Job's sake (Job 42:8). Without knowing it, Eliphaz is predicting his own future here.

JOB

CHAPTER 23

"Oh, if only I knew where I could find him!"

I am looking for God VERSES 1–7

1 Then Job answered,
2 "Even today my complaint is rebellious.
His hand is heavy on me, even though I groan.
3 Oh, if only I knew where I could find him!
If only I could come to his throne!
4 I would lay out my case before him.
I would fill my mouth with arguments.
5 I would learn the words he would answer me.
I would understand what he would tell me.
6 Would he fight with me with all his great power?
No, he would listen to me.
7 There an honest person could argue his case with him.
So I would be set free from my judge forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job no longer answers Eliphaz's accusations. He has had enough of his friends. He turns to God again.

Verse 3 is one of the most moving sentences in the book: "Oh, if only I knew where I could find him!" Job longs for God. He does not want to get rid of God. He wants to find him.

Verse 6 shows Job's deep trust: God would not strike me down with his power. He would listen to me. Job believes in a just God, even though he does not understand him right now.

I cannot find him – but he knows my way VERSES 8–12

8 "If I go east, he is not there.
If I go west, I cannot find him.
9 He works in the north, but I cannot see him.
He turns to the south, but I cannot catch sight of him.
10 But he knows the way I take.
When he has tested me, I will come out like gold.
11 My feet have stayed close to his steps.
I have kept to his way and have not turned aside.
12 I have not turned back from the commands of his lips.
I have treasured the words of his mouth more than the food I need.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job looks for God in every direction and does not find him. Many people know this feeling: God seems to be absent.

But then comes verse 10, a wonderful sentence of trust: "But he knows the way I take. When he has tested me, I will come out like gold."

Gold is made pure in fire. Job senses: Maybe my suffering is a test. And in the end I will not be destroyed but made pure. The reader knows from Chapters 1–2 that it really is a test.

Even when I cannot find God, he finds me. He knows my way (compare Psalm 139; 1 Peter 1:7).

Verse 12: God's words were more important to Job than food. Jesus says something similar: "People do not live by bread alone. They live by every word that comes out of God's mouth" (Matthew 4:4).

God does what he wants VERSES 13–17

13 "But he is the only one, and who can stand against him?
Whatever he desires, he does.
14 For he carries out what he has planned for me.
He has many more plans like this.
15 That is why I am terrified in front of him.
When I think about it, I am afraid of him.
16 For God has made my heart weak.
The Almighty has terrified me,
17 because I was not destroyed before the darkness came,
and he did not hide the thick darkness from my face.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job swings back and forth again: A moment ago he was full of trust. Now he is afraid. God is so powerful that no one can stop him.

That is honest. Faith is not always equally strong. Trust and fear take turns.

Verse 17 is hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: God has led me into darkness and did not keep it away from me.

JOB

CHAPTER 24

The suffering of the poor

Why does God not step in? VERSES 1–4

1 "Why does the Almighty not set times for judgment?
Why do those who know him not see his days?
2 There are people who move the boundary stones.
They take flocks by force and let them graze as their own.
3 They drive away the donkey of the orphans.
They take the widow's ox as security for a debt.
4 They push the needy off the road.
The poor of the land all have to hide.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job asks: Why does God not hold a day of judgment? Why do the faithful not see God step in?

Then he describes what happens in the world: The strong take advantage of the weak.

"Move the boundary stones" means: stealing land by secretly moving the border. The law strictly forbade this (Deuteronomy 19:14; 27:17).

The orphan's donkey and the widow's ox were often all they owned. Without them they could not survive.

How the poor live VERSES 5–12

5 "Look, like wild donkeys in the desert,
they go out to their work.
They search hard for food.
The wilderness gives them bread for their children.
6 They cut their food in the field.
They gather what is left in the vineyard of the wicked.
7 They lie naked all night without clothes.
They have no cover in the cold.
8 They are wet from the rain in the mountains.
They hug the rocks because they have no shelter.
9 There are people who tear the orphan from the mother's breast.
They take things from the poor as security for a debt,
10 so that the poor go around naked without clothes.
They are hungry while they carry the bundles of grain.
11 They make olive oil inside the walls of these men.
They tread the grapes in the winepresses, but they suffer thirst.
12 In the crowded city, people groan.
The wounded cry out.
Yet God pays no attention to the wrong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job describes the misery of the poor very exactly and with much compassion:

– They search the desert for food like wild animals.

– They have no clothes and are cold at night.

– They look for shelter under rocks.

– Their children are taken from them as security for debts.

– They are hungry while they carry the grain of the rich. They are thirsty while they press the wine.

This is one of the most powerful descriptions of poverty in the Bible. Sadly, such conditions still exist today.

Verse 12 is a bitter accusation: "Yet God pays no attention to the wrong." Job does not understand why God does not step in.

Job does not only see his own suffering. He sees the suffering of many people. His pain has made him compassionate.

The people who hate the light VERSES 13–17

13 "These are the ones who rebel against the light.
They do not know its ways.
They do not stay on its paths.
14 The murderer gets up when it gets light.
He kills the poor and the needy.
At night he is like a thief.
15 The eye of the man who cheats on his wife also waits for the evening.
He says, 'No eye will see me.'
He covers his face.
16 In the dark they break into houses.
In the daytime they lock themselves in.
They do not know the light.
17 For all of them, the morning is like thick darkness,
because they know the terrors of thick darkness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job describes criminals who work in the dark: murderers, men who cheat on their wives, burglars. They love the night because no one sees them.

"For all of them, the morning is like thick darkness": The light is their enemy, because it shows what they do.

Jesus says something similar: "Everyone who does evil hates the light. He doesn't come to the light, because he doesn't want his deeds to be seen" (John 3:20).

What happens to the wicked VERSES 18–25

18 "They are foam on the surface of the water.
Their share of the land is cursed.
They no longer turn onto the road to the vineyards.
19 Drought and heat dry up the water from the snow.
In the same way, Sheol (the world of the dead) takes those who have sinned.
20 The mother's womb will forget him.
The worm will feed on him with pleasure.
No one will remember him anymore.
Wrongdoing will be broken like a tree.
21 He robs the woman who cannot have children.
He does no kindness to the widow.
22 Yet God keeps the mighty alive by his power.
He gets up again, even when he is not sure he will live.
23 God gives them safety, and they rely on it.
His eyes are on their ways.
24 They are raised up high, but in a little while they are gone.
Yes, they are brought low.
They are taken away like everyone else.
They are cut off like the tops of the heads of grain.
25 If it is not so, who will prove that I am lying?
Who will show that my words are worth nothing?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This section is very hard to understand in Hebrew. The translations differ greatly.

Some verses (18–20) sound like the speeches of the friends: The wicked quickly pass away. Maybe Job is quoting his friends' opinion here. Or he is saying: Yes, in the end the

wicked die too, but often only after a long, good life (verses 22–24).

Verses 22–23: God even seems to protect the mighty and give them safety.

Verse 24: In the end they die "like everyone else." Death makes no difference. But Job does not see any special punishment for them.

Verse 25 is a challenge: If I am not right, then prove it to me!

Some scholars think that the order of the speeches in Chapters 24–27 got mixed up when the text was copied. For in the third round, Bildad's speech is very short, and Zophar does not speak at all anymore. This rendering follows the text as it has been handed down.

JOB

CHAPTER 25

Bildad's last speech: a human being is a worm

How can a human being be righteous? VERSES 1–6

1 Then Bildad the Shuhite answered,
2 "Power to rule and fear belong to him.
He makes peace in his high places.
3 Can anyone count his armies?
On whom does his light not rise?
4 So how can a human being be righteous before God?
How can someone born of a woman be clean?
5 Look, even the moon has no brightness,
and the stars are not pure in his eyes.
6 How much less a human being, who is a worm,
a son of man, who is a worm!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the shortest speech in the whole book, only five verses. The friends are running out of arguments.

Bildad praises God's greatness: God rules over everything. He makes peace in heaven. His armies of angels cannot be counted.

Then he repeats what Eliphaz already said (Job 4:17; 15:14): No human being is clean before God.

His last word is harsh: A human being is "a worm." In Hebrew there are two different words here, something like "maggot" and "worm." That is Bildad's picture of a human being: small, dirty, worthless.

In other places, the Bible sees this differently: A human being is small before God, but is made in God's image (Genesis 1:27). God made human beings only a little lower than the heavenly beings (Psalm 8:5; in some Bibles 8:6). God loves people.

Zophar does not speak at all in this third round. The friends have nothing more to say.

JOB

CHAPTER 26

"These are only the edges of his ways"

How well you have helped! VERSES 1–4

1 Then Job answered,
2 "How well you have helped the one who has no power!
How well you have saved the arm that has no strength!
3 How well you have advised the one who has no wisdom!
How much sound knowledge you have shared!
4 To whom have you spoken these words?
Whose spirit came out of you?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job answers with biting mockery: How wonderfully you have helped me! How wise your advice was!

Verse 4: "Whose spirit came out of you?" Job asks: Where did you get this from? It is surely not from God. You only repeat what others have said.

God's greatness is beyond understanding VERSES 5–14

5 "The spirits of the dead tremble,
those beneath the waters and all who live there.
6 Sheol (the world of the dead) lies naked before God.
Abaddon has no cover.
7 He stretches out the north over empty space.
He hangs the earth on nothing.
8 He wraps up the waters in his thick clouds,
and the clouds do not burst under their weight.
9 He covers the sight of his throne
and spreads his cloud over it.
10 He has drawn a boundary on the surface of the waters,
out to where light and darkness meet.
11 The pillars of heaven tremble.
They are shocked when he speaks sharply.
12 He stirs up the sea with his power.
With his understanding he strikes down Rahab.
13 By his Spirit the heavens are made beautiful.
His hand has pierced the fleeing serpent.
14 Look, these are only the edges of his ways!
How quiet is the whisper we hear of him!
But the thunder of his power – who can understand it?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job shows that he knows God's greatness much better than Bildad. His description is magnificent:

– Even Sheol is open before God. Nothing is hidden from him.

– "He hangs the earth on nothing": an amazing sentence. Many ancient peoples believed that the earth rested on

pillars or on the back of an animal. Job says: The earth hangs freely in space.

– God wraps up water in the clouds, and they do not burst.

– The horizon is the boundary between light and darkness.

"Abaddon" is another Hebrew name for the world of the dead (compare Revelation 9:11).

"Rahab" and "the fleeing serpent" are pictures from ancient stories for chaos. God defeats all the powers of chaos.

Verse 14 is one of the most beautiful verses of the book: Everything we see of God is "only the edges of his ways." We hear only a quiet whisper of him. His full power, the "thunder," we cannot understand at all.

That is true humility: We know only a little about God. So no one should act as if they had fully understood him, as the friends do.

JOB

Chapter 27

"I hold on to my righteousness"

Job's oath VERSES 1–6

1 Job went on with his speech and said,
2 "As surely as God lives, who has taken away my right,
the Almighty, who has made my soul bitter
3 (for as long as there is still life in me,
and the breath of God is in my nose),
4 my lips will surely not speak what is wrong.
My tongue will not say anything false.
5 I would never say that you are right!
Until I die, I will not give up my integrity.
6 I hold on to my righteousness and will not let it go.
My heart will not blame me as long as I live.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job swears by God, the God who has taken away his right. That is a contradiction: He accuses God and at the same time swears by him. Job holds on to God, even though he does not understand him.

"The breath of God is in my nose": God breathed the breath of life into human beings (Genesis 2:7).

Verses 5–6: Job will not lie just to satisfy his friends. He will not admit he is guilty when he is not. "My heart will not blame me as long as I live." He has a clear conscience.

"Integrity" is the same word God used in heaven: "He still holds on to his integrity" (Job 2:3). And that is exactly what Satan wanted to destroy. He did not succeed.

What hope does the godless person have? VERSES 7–12

7 "Let my enemy be like the wicked.
Let the one who rises up against me be like the unrighteous.
8 For what hope does the godless person have
when he is cut off,
when God takes away his life?
9 Will God hear his cry
when trouble comes on him?
10 Will he find joy in the Almighty?
Will he call on God at all times?
11 I will teach you about the hand of God.
I will not hide what the Almighty has in mind.
12 Look, all of you have seen it yourselves.
So why have you become so completely foolish?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job clearly sets himself apart from the godless person: The godless person has no hope. He cannot find joy in God. He does not call on God.

Job, on the other hand, calls on God all the time, even when he complains. That very fact shows that he is not godless.

Verse 9: Does God hear the cry of the godless? Job knows: God hears his own cry too, even though he has not yet received an answer.

The end of the wicked VERSES 13–23

13 "This is what God gives a wicked person as his share.
This is what the cruel receive from the Almighty as their inheritance:
14 If his children become many, it is for the sword.
His descendants will not have enough bread to eat.
15 Those of his family who are left will be buried by death.
His widows will not mourn.
16 He may pile up silver like dust
and get clothes ready like heaps of clay.
17 He may get them ready, but the righteous will wear them.
The innocent will divide up the silver.
18 He builds his house like a moth,
like a hut that a watchman makes.
19 He lies down rich, but he will not do it again.
He opens his eyes, and he is gone.
20 Terrors overtake him like a flood.
A storm carries him off in the night.
21 The east wind carries him away, and he is gone.
It sweeps him away from his place.
22 For it hurls itself at him without mercy,
while he tries to flee from its power.
23 People will clap their hands at him.
They will hiss him out of his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses sound surprisingly like the speeches of the friends: The wicked person loses everything. His children die. His wealth goes to the righteous.

How does this fit with Job, who has just said that the wicked often do well (Chapter 21)?

There are different explanations:

– Maybe Job is saying: I also know that in the end God will judge the wicked. I do not deny that. But that does not mean that everyone who suffers is wicked.

– Maybe Job is mockingly quoting what the friends always say.

– Many scholars think that these verses originally belonged to Zophar's third speech, which is otherwise completely

missing. The order may have gotten mixed up when the text was copied.

This rendering follows the text as it has been handed down. Here the text is given to Job.

"Buried by death": The Hebrew word for "death" can also mean "plague" here.

"A hut that a watchman makes": a simple hut made of branches in the vineyard. It soon falls apart again.

"People will clap their hands ... they will hiss": signs of mockery and contempt.

JOB

CHAPTER 28

The song of wisdom

People find treasures deep down VERSES 1–11

1 "Surely there is a mine for silver,
and a place for gold that people make pure.
2 Iron is taken out of the earth.
Copper is melted out of the rock.
3 People put an end to darkness.
They search to the farthest limit
for the stones in the dark and thick darkness.
4 They open a shaft far away from where people live.
Feet that walk by forget them.
They hang far away from other people.
They swing back and forth.
5 Bread comes out of the earth,
but underneath, the earth is turned up as if by fire.
6 Sapphires come from its rocks.
It has dust of gold.
7 No bird of prey knows that path.
The falcon's eye has not seen it.
8 The proud wild animals have not walked on it.
The fierce lion has not passed by there.
9 A person puts his hand on the hard rock.
He turns the mountains over from their roots.
10 He cuts tunnels through the rocks.
His eye sees every precious thing.
11 He dams up the streams so that they do not trickle.
He brings what is hidden out into the light.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is a poem about wisdom. It interrupts the argument between Job and his friends. It is calmer, like a pause for breath. Many scholars think that it does not belong directly to Job's speech, but is a separate song that was put in here.

First the poem describes mining. Even in ancient times, people dug deep shafts into the earth to find silver, gold, iron and copper. They hung on ropes in the shafts.

Human beings are amazingly clever and brave. They get to places that no bird and no lion has ever seen. They find the most hidden treasures.

But where is wisdom? VERSES 12–22

12 "But where can wisdom be found?
Where is the place of understanding?
13 People do not know what it is worth.
It is not found in the land of the living.
14 The deep waters say, 'It is not in me.'
The sea says, 'It is not with me.'
15 You cannot get it for gold.
Silver cannot be weighed out as its price.
16 It cannot be valued with the gold of Ophir,
with precious onyx or sapphire.
17 Gold and glass cannot equal it.
It cannot be traded for jewels of fine gold.
18 Coral and crystal are not even worth mentioning.
Yes, the price of wisdom is higher than rubies.
19 The topaz of Ethiopia cannot equal it.
It cannot be valued with pure gold.
20 So where does wisdom come from?
Where is the place of understanding?
21 For it is hidden from the eyes of all living things.
It is kept hidden from the birds of the sky.
22 Destruction and Death say,
'We have heard a rumor of it with our ears.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the big question: People find gold deep in the earth. But where do they find wisdom?

The answer: nowhere on earth. Not in the deep, not in the sea. And no one can buy it, not with gold, not with precious stones.

Wisdom is worth more than all the treasures in the world (compare Proverbs 3:13–15; 8:11).

Human beings are very gifted at technology. But they cannot dig up the deepest truth about life.

"Destruction and Death": Even they have only heard a rumor of wisdom.

The WEB says "topaz of Ethiopia." This means the land of Cush.

God knows the way to wisdom VERSES 23–28

23 "God understands the way to it.
He knows its place.
24 For he looks to the ends of the earth.
He sees everything under the whole sky.
25 He sets the force of the wind.
Yes, he measures out the waters by measure.
26 When he made a law for the rain
and a path for the lightning and thunder,
27 then he saw wisdom and made it known.
He set it in place, yes, and searched it out.
28 And to human beings he said,
'Look, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom.
To turn away from evil is understanding.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only God knows where wisdom is. He already saw it when he created the world, when he put wind, water, rain and lightning in order.

Verse 28 is the high point of the chapter and maybe of the whole book: "The fear of the Lord, that is wisdom. To turn away from evil is understanding."

"Fear of the Lord" does not mean being scared of God. It means awe, respect and trust: taking God seriously. That is the beginning of all wisdom (Proverbs 1:7; 9:10; Psalm 111:10).

What is special: This is exactly how Job was described at the beginning: He "feared God and turned away from evil" (Job 1:1). Job already has this wisdom. He does not understand why he suffers. But he lives the wisdom that matters.

People cannot understand everything. But they can trust God and do what is good.

JOB

CHAPTER 29

Remembering the good old days

When God was my friend VERSES 1–6

1 Job went on with his speech and said,
2 "Oh, if only I were as I was in the months long ago,
as in the days when God watched over me,
3 when his lamp shone over my head,
and by his light I walked through the darkness,
4 as I was in the best years of my life,
when God's friendship was over my tent,
5 when the Almighty was still with me,
and my children were all around me,
6 when my steps were bathed in butter,
and the rock poured out streams of olive oil for me!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapters 29–31, Job gives his closing speech. He looks back on his former life (Chapter 29), describes his misery now (Chapter 30), and insists one last time that he is innocent (Chapter 31).

What Job misses most is not his wealth but being close to God: "when God watched over me," "when God's friendship was over my tent."

And he misses his children: "when my children were all around me." This short sentence is full of pain.

"Steps bathed in butter" and "streams of olive oil": pictures of plenty and wealth.

Respected by everyone VERSES 7–11

7 "When I went out to the city gate,
when I set up my seat in the public square,
8 the young men saw me and stepped back out of sight.
The old men stood up and stayed standing.
9 The leaders stopped talking
and put their hands over their mouths.
10 The voices of the nobles went quiet.
Their tongues stuck to the roof of their mouths.
11 For when an ear heard me, it called me blessed.
When an eye saw me, it spoke well of me,

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The city gate was the place where the elders judged cases and talked about important matters. Job had a place of honor there.

Everyone respected him: The young made room, the old stood up, and even the leaders went quiet when he came.

A father to the poor VERSES 12–17

12 because I rescued the poor who cried for help,
and the orphan who had no one to help him.
13 The blessing of the one who was about to die came on me.
I made the widow's heart sing for joy.
14 I put on righteousness, and it clothed me.
My justice was like a robe and a crown.
15 I was eyes for the blind
and feet for the lame.
16 I was a father to the needy.
I looked into the case of the stranger I did not know.
17 I broke the jaws of the unrighteous
and pulled the prey out of his teeth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here you can see why Job was respected: not because of his wealth but because of his goodness.

Eliphaz had accused him of leaving widows and orphans alone (Job 22:9). Here Job says the opposite: I rescued the poor, protected the orphan and made the widow's heart glad.

Verse 15 is a beautiful picture: "I was eyes for the blind and feet for the lame." Job was there for others where they could not help themselves.

Verse 16: He even stood up for strangers he did not know. He looked carefully into their case, so that they would get justice.

Verse 17: He stood against the unrighteous and set their victims free.

According to the Bible, this is how a righteous person should live (compare Isaiah 1:17; James 1:27).

I thought it would always stay this way VERSES 18–20

18 "Then I said, 'I will die in my own house.
My days will be as many as the grains of sand.
19 My roots reach out to the water.
The dew lies all night on my branches.
20 My honor stays fresh in me.
My bow stays new in my hand.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job thought his happiness would last forever. He would grow old and die in peace in his own house.

"In my own house": The Hebrew literally says "by my nest."

He saw himself as a tree that stands by the water and always stays green (compare Psalm 1:3).

Many people think like this when things go well for them. But life can suddenly change.

A king who comforts those who mourn VERSES 21–25

21 "People listened to me and waited.
They kept quiet to hear my advice.
22 After I had spoken, no one spoke again.
My words fell on them.
23 They waited for me as people wait for the rain.
They opened their mouths as if to drink the spring rain.
24 I smiled at them when they had lost their confidence.
They did not turn away from the light of my face.
25 I chose their way for them and sat as their chief.
I lived like a king among his troops,
like someone who comforts those who mourn.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job's advice was like rain on dry land. People waited for it.

Verse 24 is touching: When others had lost heart, Job smiled at them and gave them courage.

Verse 25: He was like a king, but a king "like someone who comforts those who mourn."

The bitter irony: Job himself used to comfort those who mourned. Now he needs comfort himself, and his friends cannot comfort him.

JOB

CHAPTER 30

"But now ..."

Now the despised make fun of me VERSES 1–8

1 "But now those who are younger than I am laugh at me.
I would not have thought their fathers good enough to put with the dogs that guard my sheep.
2 What use would the strength of their hands be to me?
They are men whose strength is gone.
3 They are thin from need and hunger.
They gnaw on the dry ground,
in the gloom of waste and ruin.
4 They pick salty plants among the bushes.
The roots of the broom bush are their food.
5 They are driven out from among people.
People shout after them as if after a thief,
6 so that they have to live in frightening valleys,
in holes in the ground and in the rocks.
7 They bray like donkeys among the bushes.
They huddle together under the thorny weeds.
8 They are children of fools, yes, children of wicked men.
They were whipped out of the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"But now": With these words the contrast to Chapter 29 begins. Job used to be honored. Now he is mocked.

And by the poorest of the poor: by outcasts who live in caves and eat roots.

These verses are hard to read, because Job speaks very scornfully about these people. We need to remember: Job is bitter and hurt. And now the very people who themselves live on the edge are kicking him.

In Chapter 24, Job spoke about the poor with great compassion. Here we hear the pain of a man who has been humiliated. The Bible shows Job honestly, with all his feelings, even the ugly ones.

"Children of wicked men": The Hebrew literally says "children without a name." That means people without respect and without a family that counts for anything.

I have become a mocking song VERSES 9–15

9 "And now I have become their mocking song.
Yes, I have become a saying people use against me.
10 They hate me. They keep away from me.
They do not hold back from spitting in my face.
11 For he has loosened his bowstring and brought me low.
So they have thrown off all self-control in front of me.
12 On my right side the mob rises up.
They push my feet away.
They build up their roads of destruction against me.
13 They break up my path.
They push for my downfall, and no one has to help them.
14 They come in as through a wide gap in a wall.
They roll in among the ruins.
15 Terrors have turned against me.
They chase away my honor like the wind.
My well-being has passed by like a cloud.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job is mocked, spat on and attacked. He feels like a city whose wall has been broken through, so that the enemies come pouring in.

"He has loosened his bowstring": God has unstrung Job's bow. That means he has taken away Job's strength. When God brought Job low, people lost all respect for him.

Something similar happened to Jesus: He was mocked and spat on (Mark 14:65; 15:19).

God does not answer me VERSES 16–23

16 "And now my soul is poured out inside me.
Days of misery have taken hold of me.
17 At night my bones are pierced inside me.
The gnawing pains never rest.
18 My clothing is twisted out of shape by great force.
It is tight around me like the collar of my shirt.
19 He has thrown me into the mud.
I have become like dust and ashes.
20 I cry out to you, and you do not answer me.
I stand up, and you just stare at me.
21 You have become cruel to me.
With the strength of your hand you hunt me down.
22 You lift me up into the wind and let it drive me away.
You make me melt away in the storm.

23 For I know that you will bring me to death,
to the house that is set for all the living.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job describes his physical pain: At night it bores into his bones. His clothes stick to his sick body.

"Dust and ashes": Job feels very small and worthless. At the end of the book he will use the same words, but in a completely different sense (Job 42:6).

Verse 20 is the deepest pain: "I cry out to you, and you do not answer me." God's silence is worse than any illness. Many people know this feeling (compare Psalm 22:2; in some Bibles 22:3).

Verse 21: Job even calls God "cruel." Those are hard words. But he says them to God, not about God. He keeps talking with God.

I hoped for good, but evil came VERSES 24–31

24 "But doesn't someone stretch out his hand when he falls?
Doesn't he cry for help in his disaster?
25 Didn't I weep for the one who was in trouble?
Wasn't my soul sad for the needy?
26 When I hoped for good, evil came.
When I waited for light, darkness came.
27 My insides are churning and cannot rest.
Days of misery have come on me.
28 I go around mourning, without the sun.
I stand up in the assembly and cry for help.
29 I have become a brother to jackals
and a companion to ostriches.
30 My skin turns black and peels off me.
My bones burn with fever.
31 That is why my harp has turned to mourning,
and my flute to the sound of those who weep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: Job himself suffered along with others. He wept when others were having a hard time. Why does no one feel sorry for him now?

Verse 26 describes a bitter experience: "When I hoped for good, evil came. When I waited for light, darkness came."

Jackals and ostriches live in the desert and make mournful sounds at night. Job feels like them: alone in the desert, crying out.

Verse 31 is a sad picture: The instruments that used to play happy music now play only songs of mourning.

JOB

CHAPTER 31

Job's oath of innocence

A covenant with my eyes VERSES 1–4

1 "I made a covenant with my eyes.
So how could I look at a young woman with desire?
2 For what would my share from God above be then?
What would I inherit from the Almighty on high?
3 Isn't it disaster for the unrighteous,
and ruin for those who do wrong?
4 Doesn't he see my ways
and count all my steps?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In this chapter, Job takes a solemn oath. He goes through many possible sins and says each time: If I have done this, let a curse strike me. In those days, this was how people declared their innocence in court.

Job does not begin with deeds, but with thoughts. "A covenant with my eyes": A covenant is a binding agreement. Job has committed himself not even to look at a woman with desire.

This shows how seriously Job takes God's will. Later Jesus says something similar: Even a look of desire is adultery in the heart (Matthew 5:28).

Verse 4: Job knows that God sees all his ways. So he lives honestly, even when no one is watching.

Honesty VERSES 5–8

5 "If I have gone along with lies,
if my feet have hurried to cheat
6 (let God weigh me on honest scales,
so that he may know my integrity),
7 if my steps have turned off the way,
if my heart has followed my eyes,
if any stain has stuck to my hands,
8 then let me sow, and let someone else eat.
Yes, let the crops of my field be pulled up by the roots.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job asks: Let God weigh me on honest scales. Then he will see that I am honest.

"My heart has followed my eyes": if I wanted to have everything I saw.

The punishment Job wishes on himself: What he has sown, someone else should harvest.

Faithful in marriage VERSES 9–12

9 "If my heart has been lured by a woman,
and I have lain in wait at my neighbor's door,
10 then let my wife grind grain for another man,
and let other men sleep with her.
11 For that would be a terrible crime.
Yes, it would be a sin that the judges must punish.
12 For it is a fire that burns everything up to destruction.
It would pull up by the roots all that I have gained.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job was faithful to his wife. He never seduced another man's wife.

Verse 10 is hard for today's readers: As a punishment, Job wishes that his wife would have to serve another man. In the ancient world, this was seen as the worst shame for a man. Today we see: The wife would be punished for her husband's guilt. That is unjust. Here the Bible reports Job's

words and the way people thought in his time. It does not make a law out of it.

Verse 12: Adultery is like a fire that destroys everything: family, trust and property (compare Proverbs 6:27–29).

Fairness to male and female servants VERSES 13–15

13 "Suppose I had not respected the rights of my male servant or my female servant
when they had a complaint against me.
14 What would I do then when God rises up?
When he comes to look into it, what would I answer him?
15 Didn't the one who made me in the womb make him too?
Didn't the same God form us both in the womb?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is an amazing section for that time. Job treated his male and female servants as people of equal worth. When they complained to him, he listened to them.

His reason in verse 15 is wonderful: The same God made me and my servant in the womb. Before God we are equal.

Here we see an idea that later became very important: All people have the same dignity, because God created them all (compare Malachi 2:10; Galatians 3:28).

Caring for the poor VERSES 16–23

16 "If I have kept back from the poor what they wished for,
or have let the widow's eyes grow tired from waiting,
17 or if I have eaten my bit of food alone,
and the orphan has not eaten any of it
18 (no, from my youth the orphan grew up with me as with a father,
and from my mother's womb I have guided the widow);
19 if I have seen anyone dying because he had no clothes,
or a needy person with no cover;
20 if his heart has not blessed me,
if he has not been warmed with the wool of my sheep;
21 if I have raised my hand against the orphan,
because I saw that I had support at the city gate;
22 then let my shoulder fall from my shoulder blade.
Let my arm be broken off at the bone.
23 For disaster from God terrifies me.
Because of his majesty I can do nothing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job shared his food with orphans. He gave clothes to the poor. He never used his power in court ("at the city gate") against the weak.

This is the answer to Eliphaz's accusations in Chapter 22. Job did exactly the opposite.

"Eaten my bit of food alone": Job never ate without thinking of the hungry.

The punishment he wishes on himself: The arm that would have been raised against the orphan should be broken.

No trust in money and no other gods VERSES 24–28

24 "If I have made gold my hope,
and have said to fine gold, 'You are what I trust in,'
25 if I have been glad because my wealth was great,
and because my hand had gained so much,
26 if I have looked at the sun when it was shining,
or at the moon moving along in its splendor,
27 and my heart has been secretly lured,
so that my hand threw them a kiss from my mouth,
28 then this too would be a sin that the judges must punish,
for I would have denied the God who is above.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job was very rich, but he did not put his trust in money. Money was not his god (compare Matthew 6:24).

In those days, many peoples worshiped the sun and the moon. People threw them a kiss with their hand as a sign of worship. Job never did that. He worshiped only the one God.

Greed for money and worshiping idols belong together: Both mean putting something other than God in first place.

No joy at others' misfortune, open doors VERSES 29–34

29 "If I have been glad when the one who hated me was destroyed,
or felt proud when evil came on him
30 (no, I have not let my mouth sin
by calling down a curse on his life);
31 if the men of my household have not said,
'Who can find anyone who has not had his fill of Job's meat?'
32 (the foreigner did not have to spend the night in the street,
but I opened my doors to the traveler);
33 if, like Adam, I have covered up my wrongdoings
by hiding my guilt in my heart,
34 because I was afraid of the great crowd,
and the contempt of families terrified me,
so that I kept silent and did not go out of my door –

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job was not glad when things went badly for his enemies. He did not even curse them. That goes very far. Later Jesus teaches: "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44).

He was very welcoming to guests: Everyone got food at his house. No stranger had to sleep in the street.

Verse 33: "Like Adam" (or: "as people do"): Adam hid after his sin (Genesis 3:8–10). Job did not hide anything. He admitted his mistakes, even when he was afraid of what people would think.

Here is my signature! VERSES 35–37

35 "Oh, if only I had someone to hear me!
Look, here is my signature!
Let the Almighty answer me!
Let my accuser write down the charges against me!
36 I would surely carry them on my shoulder.
I would tie them on like a crown.
37 I would tell him the number of my steps.
I would come near to him like a prince.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the high point of Job's speeches. He has taken his oath. Now he "signs" it, the way people sign a statement in court.

And he challenges God: Answer me! Write down your charges!

Job is so sure that he is innocent that he would wear the list of charges proudly, like a crown. He would come before God "like a prince," not like a criminal.

Now only God can answer. And God will answer, but differently from what Job expects (Chapter 38).

The land does not accuse me VERSES 38–40

38 "If my land cries out against me,
and its furrows weep together,
39 if I have eaten its crops without paying,
or have caused its owners to lose their lives,
40 then let thorns grow instead of wheat,
and stinking weeds instead of barley."
The words of Job are ended.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Finally, one last point: Job did not get his land unjustly. He paid the workers and did not drive anyone away.

"My land cries out": Just as Abel's blood cried out from the ground (Genesis 4:10), the soil would also cry out against injustice.

"The words of Job are ended": Job has said everything. He will only speak again after God has spoken (Job 40:3–5; 42:1–6).

JOB

CHAPTER 32

A young man speaks up: Elihu

Elihu is angry VERSES 1–5

1 So these three men stopped answering Job,
because he was righteous in his own eyes.
2 Then Elihu became very angry.
He was the son of Barachel the Buzite,
from the family of Ram.
He was angry with Job,
because Job made himself out to be right rather than God.
3 He was also angry with Job's three friends,
because they had found no answer,
and yet they had condemned Job.
4 Elihu had waited before speaking to Job,
because they were older than he was.
5 When Elihu saw that these three men had no answer left,
he became very angry.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Surprisingly, a new speaker appears: Elihu. He was never mentioned before. He is younger than the others and has been listening the whole time.

Elihu is angry with both sides:

– with Job, because Job made himself out to be more righteous than God,

– with the friends, because they condemned Job without having a convincing answer.

Elihu is the only speaker in the book with a Hebrew name. It means: "He is my God."

Elihu speaks from Chapter 32 to Chapter 37. After that, God himself answers. Interesting: At the end of the book, God neither praises nor blames Elihu. Scholars do not agree on how his speeches should be understood.

Wisdom does not come only with age VERSES 6–10

6 Elihu the son of Barachel the Buzite answered,
"I am young, and you are very old.
That is why I held back.
I did not dare to tell you what I think.
7 I said, 'Age should speak.
Many years should teach wisdom.'
8 But there is a spirit in people,
and the Spirit of the Almighty gives them understanding.
9 It is not the great who are wise.
It is not the old who understand what is right.
10 That is why I said, 'Listen to me!
I too will tell you what I think.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu is polite: He waited because the others are older. That was the custom in those days.

But then he says something important: Wisdom does not come automatically with age. It comes from the Spirit of God. A young person can also be wise when God's Spirit gives him understanding (compare 1 Timothy 4:12).

This is a criticism of the friends, who always appealed to age and tradition (Job 8:8; 15:10).

You did not convince Job VERSES 11–17

11 "Look, I waited for your words.
I listened to your reasons,
while you were searching for what to say.
12 Yes, I paid close attention to you.
But none of you proved Job wrong.
None of you answered his words.
13 Be careful not to say, 'We have found wisdom.
God may prove him wrong, not a human being.'
14 For he has not aimed his words at me.
And I will not answer him with your speeches.
15 They are shocked. They do not answer anymore.
They have nothing left to say.
16 Should I wait because they do not speak,
because they just stand there and answer no more?
17 I too will give my answer.
I too will tell you what I think.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu listened carefully. His verdict: The friends did not convince Job. They gave no answer to his questions.

Verse 13: Elihu warns the friends not to make excuses with: "God may prove him wrong, not a human being."

Verse 14: Elihu wants to bring new arguments, not repeat the old ones.

I am full of words VERSES 18–22

18 "For I am full of words.
The spirit inside me pushes me.
19 Look, my insides are like wine that has no opening.
Like new wineskins, they are about to burst.
20 I will speak, so that I may feel better.
I will open my lips and answer.
21 Please, let me not take sides with anyone.
I will not flatter anyone.
22 For I do not know how to flatter.
If I did, my Maker would soon take me away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu cannot stay silent any longer. He is like a wineskin in which the fermenting wine builds up so much pressure that it is about to burst.

Some readers find Elihu a bit arrogant: He talks for a very long time about the fact that he is now going to talk. Others see in him a young man with real zeal for God.

Verses 21–22: Elihu wants to be honest and fair to all. He does not want to flatter anyone, neither Job nor the friends.

JOB

CHAPTER 33

Elihu: God speaks in many ways

Listen to me, Job VERSES 1–7

1 "But now, Job, please hear what I say.
Listen to all my words.
2 Look, I have opened my mouth.
My tongue is speaking in my mouth.
3 My words come from an honest heart.
My lips will speak sincerely what they know.
4 The Spirit of God has made me.
The breath of the Almighty gives me life.
5 If you can, answer me!
Set your words in order before me and stand up!
6 Look, before God I am just like you.
I too was formed out of clay.
7 Look, you do not need to be afraid of me.
I will not press down heavily on you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu speaks to Job directly by name. The three friends never did that.

He says: I am a human being like you, made of clay. You do not need to be afraid of me.

This is an answer to Job's wish: Job wanted someone to talk with who was not overpowering (Job 9:34; 13:21). Elihu says: I am someone like that. You can talk with me.

What you have said VERSES 8–13

8 "Surely you have spoken where I could hear.
I have heard the sound of your words:
9 'I am clean, without wrongdoing.
I am innocent. There is no guilt in me.
10 Look, he looks for reasons to attack me.
He thinks of me as his enemy.
11 He puts my feet in the stocks.
He watches all my paths.'
12 "Look, I will answer you.
In this you are not right,
for God is greater than any human being.
13 Why do you fight against him
because he does not explain anything he does?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu sums up what Job has said. He quotes Job quite closely (compare Job 13:24, 27).

Elihu does not accuse Job of having sinned, as the friends did. He criticizes something else: Job has accused God of being his enemy. And he has complained that God does not answer.

Elihu's answer: God is greater than human beings. He does not have to justify himself to us.

God speaks through dreams VERSES 14–18

14 "For God speaks once, yes, twice,
but people do not pay attention.
15 In a dream, in a vision at night,
when deep sleep falls on people,
while they are sleeping in bed,
16 then he opens people's ears
and seals the warning he gives them,
17 to turn a person away from what he planned to do,
and to keep pride away from him.
18 He keeps his soul from the pit,
and his life from dying by the sword.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job had complained that God does not answer. Elihu says: God does speak, just in a different way than you think.

The first way: dreams and visions at night. God can warn people in a dream, so that they do not run into ruin.

God's goal is not punishment but rescue: He wants to keep people "from the pit," that is, from death.

God speaks through suffering VERSES 19–22

19 "A person is also corrected with pain in his bed,
with constant aching in his bones,
20 so that he cannot stand to eat bread,
and he hates even his favorite food.
21 His flesh wastes away until it can no longer be seen.
His bones, which could not be seen before, stick out.
22 Yes, his soul comes near to the pit,
and his life to those who bring death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The second way God speaks: through illness and pain.

This is a new idea. The friends said: Suffering is punishment for sin. Elihu says: Suffering can also be a warning or a way of teaching. Through it, God wants to bring a person back before it is too late.

Many people have found that during a serious illness they thought about their lives and came closer to God. But we must not make this a rule that we hold up to every sick person.

An angel who speaks up for him VERSES 23–30

23 "Suppose there is an angel at his side,
someone who speaks for him,
one out of 1,000,
to show the person what is right for him.
24 Then God is gracious to him and says,
'Rescue him from going down to the pit!
I have found a ransom.'
25 His flesh becomes fresher than a child's.
He goes back to the days of his youth.
26 He prays to God, and God is pleased with him,
so that he sees God's face with joy.
God gives him back his righteousness.
27 He sings in front of people and says,
'I have sinned and twisted what was right,
and it did me no good.
28 He has saved my soul from going into the pit.
My life will see the light.'
29 "Look, God does all these things with a person
twice, yes, three times,
30 to bring back his soul from the pit,
so that the light of life may shine on him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Elihu comes back to Job's wish for a judge between him and God, a witness and a redeemer (Job 9:33; 16:19; 19:25).

He says: There may be an angel, someone "who speaks for him," who stands up for the person. Then God says: "I have found a ransom." The person is rescued.

A "ransom" is a price that is paid to set someone free. Christians see here a hint of Jesus, who says that he came "to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45).

The result: The person gets well, prays to God, sees God's face with joy and sings about being rescued. He honestly admits his guilt.

Verses 29–30: God does this again and again, "twice, yes, three times." He does not give up. He wants to bring the person back into the light.

I want to declare you righteous VERSES 31–33

31 "Pay attention, Job, and listen to me.
Be quiet, and I will speak.
32 If you have anything to say, answer me.
Speak, for I want to declare you righteous.
33 If not, listen to me.
Be quiet, and I will teach you wisdom."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 32 is remarkable: "I want to declare you righteous." Elihu does not want to condemn Job like the friends did. He wants to help him.

Job does not answer. Maybe he is listening. Maybe he is exhausted. The Bible does not say.

JOB

CHAPTER 34

Elihu's second speech: God does no wrong

Test my words VERSES 1–4

1 Elihu went on and said,
2 "Hear my words, you wise men!
Listen to me, you who have knowledge!
3 For the ear tests words,
just as the mouth tastes food.
4 Let us choose for ourselves what is right.
Let us find out together what is good.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Elihu speaks to the wise, that is, to the three friends and to everyone who is listening.

Verse 3: Just as you taste with your mouth whether food is good, you should test with your ear whether words are true. Elihu invites them to test together what is right. Job himself had already used the same picture (Job 12:11).

What Job has said VERSES 5–9

5 "For Job has said, 'I am righteous,
but God has taken away my right.
6 Even though I am right, I am treated as a liar.
My wound cannot be healed, even though I have not disobeyed.'
7 What man is like Job?
He drinks mockery like water.
8 He keeps company with those who do evil.
He walks with wicked men.
9 For he has said, 'It does a person no good
to find his joy in God.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu quotes Job (compare Job 27:2; 9:22).

Then he becomes sharp: Job "drinks mockery like water." That means: He speaks scornfully about God as easily as people drink water.

Verse 8 is a harsh accusation: Job supposedly talks like the wicked. Elihu probably does not mean that Job spends time with criminals, but that his words sound like theirs.

Verse 9: Job had said that the wicked often do well (Chapter 21). Elihu understands this to mean: Job thinks it does not pay to serve God. Here Elihu is too harsh: Job never stopped holding on to God.

God does no wrong VERSES 10–15

10 "So listen to me, you men of understanding:
God would never do evil!
The Almighty would never do wrong!

11 For he pays a person back for what he has done.
He lets everyone receive what his ways deserve.
12 Yes, surely God does not do evil.
The Almighty does not twist justice.
13 Who put him in charge of the earth?
Who gave him the whole world to rule?
14 If he thought only of himself,
if he took his spirit and his breath back to himself,
15 all living things would die together,
and people would turn back into dust.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is Elihu's main idea: God cannot be unjust. That would go against who he is.

Verse 13: No one handed the world over to God. It belongs to him because he created it. He does not owe anyone an explanation.

Verses 14–15: All life depends on God's breath. If God thought only of himself and took back his breath, all life would be dead at once (compare Psalm 104:29; Genesis 2:7; 3:19). The fact that we are alive shows that God takes care of what he has made.

God does not take sides VERSES 16–20

16 "If you have understanding, hear this!
Listen to the sound of my words!
17 Could someone who hates justice rule?
Will you condemn the one who is righteous and mighty,
18 who says to a king, 'You are worthless!'
or to nobles, 'You are wicked!'?
19 He does not favor princes.
He does not value the rich more than the poor,
for they are all the work of his hands.
20 They die in a moment, even at midnight.
The people are shaken and pass away.
The mighty are taken away, and no human hand does it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu asks: Can someone who hates justice rule the world? No. God rules the world, so he must be just.

God is not afraid of the powerful. He can tell even a king the truth. To him, rich and poor are the same, because he made them all (compare Job 31:15).

Verse 20: Even the most powerful can suddenly die without any human laying a hand on them. God does not need an army.

God sees everything VERSES 21–30

21 "For his eyes are on the ways of every person.
He sees every step he takes.
22 There is no darkness and no deep gloom
where those who do evil can hide.
23 For he does not need to look at a person any longer
before that person comes before God for judgment.
24 He breaks the mighty into pieces in ways no one can figure out.
He puts others in their place.
25 He knows what they do.
He overthrows them in the night, so that they are destroyed.
26 He strikes them down for being wicked
where everyone can see it,
27 because they turned away from following him.
They did not pay attention to any of his ways.
28 So they caused the cry of the poor to come to him.
He heard the cry of those who suffer.
29 When he keeps quiet, who can condemn him?
When he hides his face, who can see him?
He rules over a nation and over a single person alike,
30 so that the godless person may not rule,
and there is no one to trap the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God sees everything. No one can hide from him (compare Psalm 139:11–12).

Verse 23: God does not need a long trial as people do. He already knows everything. Job had wished for a court date with God. Elihu says: That is not necessary.

Verse 28: God hears the cry of the poor. When the powerful oppress the poor, God steps in (compare Exodus 3:7).

Verse 29: Sometimes God is silent. It says: "When he hides his face, who can see him?" But even then he rules. He makes sure that the godless do not rule forever.

Job speaks without understanding VERSES 31–37

31 "For has anyone ever said to God,
'I am guilty, but I will not do wrong anymore.
32 Teach me what I cannot see.
If I have done wrong, I will not do it again'?
33 Should God pay you back the way you want, since you refuse what he does?
For you must choose, not I.
So tell us what you know.
34 People of understanding will tell me,
yes, every wise man who hears me:
35 'Job speaks without knowledge.
His words have no wisdom.'
36 I wish that Job would be tested to the very end,
because he answers like wicked men.
37 For he adds rebellion to his sin.
He claps his hands among us in mockery.
He piles up his words against God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 31–32 suggest the right way to speak with God: "Teach me what I cannot see." That is a humble prayer. Elihu means: This is how Job should pray, instead of accusing God.

Verse 33 is hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: God does not follow your wishes, Job. If you know better, say so.

Verses 36–37 are very harsh. Elihu wishes that Job would be "tested to the very end." He says that Job adds rebellion to his sin. Here Elihu sounds almost like the three friends again.

At the end of the book, God himself says that Job has "spoken of me what is right" (Job 42:7). So Elihu's sharp verdict is not the last word.

Chapter 35

Elihu's third speech: God is far above us

What does our behavior do for God? VERSES 1–8

1 Elihu went on and said,
2 "Do you think this is your right?
Do you say, 'My righteousness is greater than God's'?
3 For you ask, 'What good will it do you?
What do I gain, more than if I had sinned?'
4 I will answer you,
and your friends with you.
5 Look up at the skies and see!
See the skies, which are higher than you!
6 If you have sinned, what harm do you do to him?
If your wrongdoings are many, what do you do to him?
7 If you are righteous, what do you give him?
What does he receive from your hand?
8 Your evil may hurt a person like yourself.
Your righteousness may help another human being.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job had asked: What good does it do me not to sin? (compare Job 7:20; 10:14–15). Elihu answers by looking up: The sky is so high above you. God is much higher still.

God does not depend on us. Our sin cannot harm him. Our righteousness does not make him richer.

But verse 8 is important: What we do affects other people. Evil hurts people. Good helps them. That is why it matters how we live.

Why God sometimes does not answer VERSES 9–16

9 "People cry out because there is so much oppression.
They cry for help because of the power of the mighty.
10 But no one says, 'Where is God my Maker,
who gives songs in the night,
11 who teaches us more than the animals of the earth,
and makes us wiser than the birds of the sky?'
12 There they cry out, but no one answers,
because of the pride of evil people.
13 Surely God will not listen to an empty cry.
The Almighty will not pay attention to it.
14 How much less when you say that you do not see him!
Your case is before him, and you are waiting for him!
15 But now, because he has not punished in his anger,
and he does not pay much attention to arrogance,
16 Job opens his mouth with empty talk.
He piles up words without knowledge."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu says: Many people cry out in their need. But they cry out only because of their pain, not for God himself. They do not ask: "Where is God my Maker?"

"Who gives songs in the night" is a beautiful picture: Even in the middle of dark times, God can give comfort and even joy (compare Psalm 42:8; Acts 16:25).

Verse 14 can also be read as a comfort: "Your case is before him, and you are waiting for him!" God has not forgotten Job's case.

Verses 15–16: Elihu thinks that God has not yet punished Job in anger. That is why Job talks so much. Here too Elihu is very strict. Many people in need did not just give "an empty cry." They really searched for God, just as Job did.

Chapter 36

Elihu's fourth speech: God teaches through suffering

I speak for God VERSES 1–4

1 Elihu went on and said,
2 "Be patient with me a little longer, and I will show you.
For I still have something to say for God.
3 I will bring my knowledge from far away.
I will show that my Maker is righteous.
4 For truly, my words are not false.
One who is perfect in knowledge is with you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu's fourth and last speech begins. He wants to speak "for God" and show that God is just.

Verse 4: "One who is perfect in knowledge": Some understand this as Elihu praising himself. Others think he is already speaking about God here (the same phrase is used for God in Job 37:16). Both are possible.

God despises no one VERSES 5–12

5 "Look, God is mighty, and he despises no one.
He is mighty in the strength of his understanding.
6 He does not keep the wicked alive,
but he gives justice to those who suffer.
7 He does not take his eyes off the righteous.
He seats them with kings on the throne forever,
and they are raised up high.
8 If they are bound in chains
and caught in the ropes of misery,
9 then he shows them what they have done.
He shows them their wrongdoings, that they have acted proudly.
10 He also opens their ears to his teaching.
He commands them to turn back from wrongdoing.
11 If they listen and serve him,
they will spend their days in good times,

and their years in pleasure.
12 But if they do not listen, they will die by the sword.
They will die without knowledge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is mighty, but he despises no one. His power goes together with understanding and care.

Elihu explains his main idea once more: When righteous people get into suffering ("bound in chains"), God wants to show them something. Maybe there is pride in their lives that they do not see. God opens their ears.

Whoever listens finds happiness again. Whoever does not listen is destroyed.

The Bible knows this idea in other places too (compare Hebrews 12:5–11). But it does not explain every kind of suffering. According to Chapters 1–2, Job's suffering had a different reason.

God rescues through suffering VERSES 13–16

13 "But those who are godless in their hearts store up anger.
They do not cry for help when he binds them.
14 They die while they are young.
Their life ends among the unclean.
15 He rescues those who suffer through their suffering.
He opens their ears through their trouble.
16 Yes, he would have drawn you out of distress
into a wide place, where nothing holds you in.
What was set on your table would be full of rich food.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "Among the unclean": The Hebrew has a word for men who served in the temples of foreign gods. It means a shameful end.

Verse 15 is Elihu's key sentence: God rescues the one who suffers "through" the suffering. Suffering can be a way in which God speaks to a person.

Verse 16: God wanted to lead Job out of the tight place into a wide open space. "What was set on your table would be full of rich food." That means: rich, good food, a picture of blessing (compare Psalm 23:5).

A warning to Job VERSES 17–21

17 "But you are full of judgment on the wicked.
Judgment and justice have taken hold of you.
18 Do not let riches lure you into anger.
Do not let a large bribe turn you aside.
19 Would your wealth keep you going in distress,
or all the might of your strength?
20 Do not long for the night,
when peoples are taken away from their place.
21 Be careful! Do not turn to wrongdoing,
for you have chosen this rather than suffering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are very hard to understand in Hebrew. The translations differ greatly from each other.

It probably means: Job, you are completely caught up in arguing about justice and judgment. Be careful that this does not make you bitter.

Verse 20: "Do not long for the night": Job had often wished he were dead (Chapter 3). Elihu warns him against this.

If you yourself see no meaning in life right now: Talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Who is a teacher like God? VERSES 22–26

22 "Look, God is lifted high in his power.
Who is a teacher like him?
23 Who has told him which way to go?
Who can say to him, 'You have done wrong'?
24 Remember to praise his work,
which people have sung about.
25 All people have looked at it.
People see it from far away.
26 Look, God is great, and we do not know him.
The number of his years cannot be found out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Elihu changes his tone. He no longer argues. He praises God.

God is the best teacher. No one can tell him what to do.

Instead of accusing God, Job should praise God's works, as people have always done in songs.

Verse 26: "God is great, and we do not know him." Our minds are not big enough to understand God fully. He is eternal.

God in the rain and the thunderstorm VERSES 27–33

27 "For he draws up the drops of water,
which fall as rain from his mist.
28 The clouds pour it down.
It falls on people in plenty.
29 Can anyone really understand how the clouds spread out,
and the thunder from his tent?
30 Look, he spreads his light around him.
He covers the bottom of the sea.
31 For by these he judges the peoples.
He gives food in plenty.
32 He covers his hands with the lightning.
He commands it to strike its target.
33 Its crashing tells about him.
The livestock also tell that a storm is coming.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu describes the water cycle: God draws the water up as mist, and it falls down again as rain. People were amazed by this even back then.

The clouds are like God's "tent," and the thunder is his sound. God holds lightning in his hands.

Verse 31: With the weather God can punish (storms, drought) or bless (rain, a good harvest).

Verse 33: Even the livestock sense when a thunderstorm is coming.

It seems as if a thunderstorm is coming up while Elihu is speaking. This prepares for Chapter 38: There God answers "out of the whirlwind."

Chapter 37

Elihu: God's greatness in the thunderstorm

Hear God's voice in the thunder VERSES 1–5

1 "Yes, my heart trembles at this.
It jumps out of its place.
2 Listen, oh, listen to the roar of his voice,
the sound that comes out of his mouth!
3 He sends it out under the whole sky.
He sends his lightning to the ends of the earth.
4 After it, a voice roars.
He thunders with his majestic voice.
He holds nothing back when his voice is heard.
5 God thunders wonderfully with his voice.
He does great things that we cannot understand.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu keeps on speaking. A thunderstorm is coming up, and Elihu is deeply impressed. His heart trembles.

In the thunder he hears God's voice. This is an old picture in the Bible (compare Psalm 29, which says that the voice of the LORD is over the waters).

Verse 5: "He does great things that we cannot understand." That is the heart of Elihu's conclusion: God is greater than our minds.

Snow, rain, ice VERSES 6–13

6 "For he says to the snow, 'Fall on the earth!'
He says the same to the rain shower,
and to the showers of his heavy rain.
7 He seals up the hand of every person,
so that all the people he has made may know it.
8 Then the animals take cover.
They stay in their dens.
9 The storm comes out of its room,
and cold comes out of the north.
10 By the breath of God, ice is made.
The wide waters freeze over.
11 Yes, he loads the thick cloud with moisture.
He spreads out the cloud of his lightning.
12 It turns around and around as he guides it,
so that the clouds do whatever he commands them
on the face of the inhabited world.
13 He makes it come,
whether to correct people, or for his land, or out of
loving kindness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God commands the weather, and it obeys him.

Verse 7: "He seals up the hand of every person": In snow and heavy rain, people cannot work in the fields. Their hands rest. Then they notice that God is above them.

Verse 13: God sends the weather for different purposes: to warn, to water the land, or simply out of love and goodness.

The Hebrew word for loving kindness is "chesed." It means God's faithful, loving care.

Job, stand still and be amazed VERSES 14–20

14 "Listen to this, Job!
Stand still and think about God's wonderful works!
15 Do you know how God controls them,
and makes the lightning of his cloud flash?
16 Do you know how the clouds float,
the wonderful works of the one who is perfect in
knowledge?
17 Your clothes are hot
when the earth is still because of the south wind.
18 Can you, together with him, spread out the sky,
which is as hard as a mirror made of cast metal?
19 Teach us what we should say to him,
for we cannot set out our case because of the darkness.
20 Should he be told that I want to speak?
Or would anyone wish to be swallowed up?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elihu calls on Job: Stop arguing. Stand still and be amazed.

He asks Job questions: Do you know how the clouds float? Can you spread out the sky? These are questions that God himself will soon ask in Chapter 38.

Verse 17: The hot south wind (from the desert) makes everything still and muggy. People can only sweat. They cannot change the weather.

Verse 18: In those days, people pictured the sky as a solid, shining dome. Mirrors back then were made of polished metal, not glass.

Verses 19–20: Elihu means: We human beings are groping in the dark. Who would want to argue with God then? Whoever tries such a thing will be "swallowed up."

Golden splendor from the north VERSES 21–24

21 "Right now people cannot see the light that is bright in
the skies.
But the wind passes by and clears the clouds away.
22 Golden splendor comes out of the north.
God has awesome majesty.
23 We cannot reach the Almighty.
He is lifted high in power.
In justice and great righteousness he will not oppress
anyone.
24 That is why people have deep respect for him.
He pays no attention to anyone who is wise in his own
heart."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the storm, the sun comes out again. The wind has blown the clouds away.

"Golden splendor comes out of the north": In the ancient Near East, people often pictured God's home in the north. God's glory shines brightly like gold.

Verse 23 sums up Elihu's message: God is so great that no one can reach him. But he is just and oppresses no one.

Verse 24: Whoever thinks he is wise does not impress God. Deep respect for God is the beginning of wisdom (compare Job 28:28).

These are Elihu's last words. From now on, God himself speaks.

JOB

CHAPTER 38

God answers out of the whirlwind

God speaks VERSES 1–3

1 Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind.
He said,
2 "Who is this who makes my plan dark
with words without knowledge?
3 Get ready like a man!
I will ask you questions, and you will answer me!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At last God answers! Job has been waiting for this through the whole book.

Important: Here God's name "the LORD" appears again (in Hebrew: YHWH). In the speeches before, God was mostly called only "God" or "the Almighty." Now Job meets the God of Israel in person.

God comes "out of the whirlwind." This is a reminder of other meetings with God: at Mount Sinai (Exodus 19) or with Elijah (1 Kings 19).

God accuses Job of having spoken "without knowledge." But: God does not say that Job has sinned. He does not repeat the friends' accusations.

"Get ready like a man": Word for word, the Hebrew says: Tie up your clothing around your waist like a man. In those days, people tied up their long robes before they worked or fought. It means: Get ready! Job wanted to ask God questions. Now God asks Job questions.

Where were you when I laid the foundations of the earth? VERSES 4–7

4 "Where were you when I laid the foundations of the
earth?
Tell me, if you have understanding!
5 Who decided how big it would be? Surely you know!
Who stretched the measuring line over it?
6 What were its foundations set on?
Who laid its cornerstone,
7 when the morning stars sang together,
and all the sons of God shouted for joy?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God describes the creation of the world like building a house: deciding the size, stretching the measuring line, laying the foundations, setting the cornerstone.

And Job was not there. He does not know the plan by which the world was built.

Verse 7: a beautiful picture. When the world was finished, the stars and the angels ("sons of God," compare Job 1:6) rejoiced. Creation was a reason for joy.

The sea has its boundary VERSES 8–11

8 "Or who shut up the sea behind doors,
when it burst out of the womb,
9 when I made the clouds its clothing,
and wrapped it in thick darkness like a baby's cloth,
10 when I set my boundary for it,
and put bars and doors in place,
11 and said, 'You may come this far, but no farther.
Your proud waves must stop here'?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For people in those days, the sea was dangerous and frightening. It stood for chaos and threat.

But God describes the sea like a newborn baby: It comes out of the womb, and God wraps it in clouds as in baby cloths.

God is stronger than the sea. He has set it a boundary: "You may come this far, but no farther." Chaos does not go on without limits. God has it under control.

Have you given orders to the morning? VERSES 12–15

12 "Have you ever in your life given orders to the
morning?
Have you shown the dawn its place,
13 so that it takes hold of the ends of the earth,
and shakes the wicked out of it?
14 The earth changes like clay under a seal.
It stands out like a piece of clothing.
15 The wicked are kept from their light.
The arm raised to strike is broken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Every morning the sun rises. Who ordered that? Not Job.

The morning light grabs the earth like a blanket by its corners and shakes the criminals out. For many crimes happen at night (compare Job 24:13–17).

Verse 14: When the light comes, things get their shape and color again, just as soft clay gets a picture from a seal stamp.

This is an answer to Job's question about justice: God has already built it into the order of the world that evil is limited.

Do you know the depths and the light? VERSES 16–21

16 "Have you gone down to the springs of the sea?
Have you walked through the hidden places of the
deep?
17 Have the gates of death been shown to you?
Have you seen the gates of the shadow of death?
18 Have you understood how wide the earth is?
Tell me, if you know all this!
19 "What is the way to the home of light?
And darkness, where does it live,
20 so that you could take it to its border,
and know the paths to its house?
21 Surely you know, for you were born back then,
and you have lived so many days!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God asks about the deepest depths of the sea, about the world of the dead and about the size of the earth. Job knows

nothing about any of it.

Verse 21 is meant ironically: "Surely you know, for you were born back then, and you have lived so many days!" Of course Job was not there at creation.

God is not angry or hurtful, but he makes it clear: Job sees only a small part of the whole.

Snow, hail, rain and ice VERSES 22–30

22 "Have you gone into the storerooms of the snow?
Have you seen the storerooms of the hail,
23 which I have kept for the time of trouble,
for the day of battle and war?
24 By what way is the lightning spread out?
How is the east wind scattered over the earth?
25 Who has cut a channel for the floodwaters,
or a path for the thunderstorm,
26 to make it rain on a land where no one lives,
on the wilderness, where there are no people,
27 to water the empty, ruined ground,
and to make the tender grass grow?
28 Does the rain have a father?
Who is the father of the drops of dew?
29 Whose womb did the ice come out of?
Who gave birth to the gray frost of the sky?
30 The waters become hard like stone,
when the surface of the deep is frozen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: "Lightning": The Hebrew word literally means "light." That is why many Bibles translate "the light" here.

Verses 26–27 are especially beautiful: God makes it rain even where no one lives. He takes care of the desert and the little grass, even when no human being gets anything out of it.

That means: The world does not turn only around human beings. God takes joy in all of his creation. This view is new for Job.

Verses 28–29: Rain, dew, ice and frost have no human parents. God alone brings them about.

The stars VERSES 31–33

31 "Can you tie together the cluster of the Pleiades?
Can you loosen the ropes of Orion?
32 Can you lead out the constellations in their season?
Can you guide the Bear with her cubs?
33 Do you know the laws of the heavens?
Can you set up their rule over the earth?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Pleiades (the Seven Sisters), Orion and the Great Bear (the Big Dipper) are well-known groups of stars. You can still see them in the night sky today.

God has given them their paths. They follow fixed "laws of the heavens." No human being can move them.

Job himself had already spoken about these constellations (Job 9:9). Now God asks him: Can you guide them?

Clouds, lightning and wisdom VERSES 34–38

34 "Can you lift up your voice to the clouds,
so that plenty of water covers you?
35 Can you send out lightning, so that it goes?
Does it report to you, 'Here we are'?
36 Who has put wisdom deep inside people?
Who has given understanding to the mind?
37 Who is wise enough to count the clouds?
Who can tip over the water jars of the sky,
38 when the dust runs together into a mass,
and the clods of earth stick together?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Can Job order rain? Do the lightning bolts obey him like soldiers who report: "Here we are!"? No.

Verse 36: Human wisdom also comes from God. What Job knows, he has received from God.

Verses 37–38: The clouds are like jars from which God pours water. After that, the dry dust turns into moist clods of earth.

Food for lions and ravens VERSES 39–41

39 "Can you hunt prey for the lioness?
Can you satisfy the hunger of the young lions,
40 when they crouch in their dens,
and lie in wait in the thick bushes?
41 Who provides food for the raven,
when its young ones cry to God,
and wander around because they have no food?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now God moves from lifeless nature to the animals. This goes on in Chapter 39.

God takes care of the wild animals: the strong lions as well as the young ravens that cry for food.

Jesus later takes this up: "Consider the ravens ... And God feeds them" (Luke 12:24). If God even takes care of the ravens, he takes care of you too.

JOB

CHAPTER 39

God and the wild animals

Mountain goats and deer VERSES 1–4

1 "Do you know the time when the mountain goats give birth?
Do you watch when the doe has her fawns?
2 Can you count the months until they are ready?
Do you know the time when they give birth?
3 They bend down. They give birth to their young.
Their labor pains are over.
4 Their young ones grow strong.
They grow up in the open field.
They go away and do not come back.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God keeps asking Job questions, now about wild animals. They are animals that people have not tamed and do not control.

The mountain goats live high up in the mountains. No human being is there when they have their young. But God sees it and takes care of it.

The young grow up and become independent. Life goes on, completely without human beings.

The wild donkey VERSES 5–8

5 "Who has set the wild donkey free?
Who has untied the ropes of the swift donkey?
6 I have made the wilderness his home,
and the salty land the place where he lives.
7 He laughs at the noise of the city.
He does not hear the shouting of a driver.
8 The mountains are his pasture.
He searches for anything green.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wild donkey is free. He does not have to carry loads, and no driver shouts at him.

God gave him freedom and the desert as his home. What is harsh for human beings is just right for the wild donkey.

God has given every creature its own place.

The wild ox VERSES 9–12

9 "Will the wild ox be willing to serve you?
Will he stay by your feeding trough?
10 Can you keep the wild ox in the furrow with a harness?
Will he plow the valleys behind you?
11 Will you trust him because his strength is great?
Will you leave your work to him?
12 Will you rely on him
to bring home your grain,
and gather it from your threshing floor?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wild ox (the aurochs) was a huge, very strong kind of cattle. It has died out today. People could not tame it.

God asks: Can you hitch the wild ox to your plow like a farm ox? No. He is too wild and too strong.

People cannot control everything. There are forces in creation that only God holds in his hand.

The ostrich VERSES 13–18

13 "The wings of the ostrich flap proudly,
but are they the feathers and plumage of love?
14 For she leaves her eggs on the ground.
She lets them warm in the dust.
15 She forgets that a foot may crush them,
or that a wild animal may trample them.
16 She is harsh with her young, as if they were not hers.
She is not afraid that her work may be for nothing,
17 because God has not given her wisdom.
He has not given her a share of understanding.
18 But when she rises up to run,
she laughs at the horse and its rider.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The ostrich is a strange bird: It has wings, but it cannot fly. It lays its eggs in the sand, and it looks as if it does not care about them.

"Feathers and plumage of love": Plumage means a bird's feathers. In Hebrew this is a play on words. The word for stork means "the faithful one" or "the loving one." The ostrich, on the other hand, seems not to care.

But then: When the ostrich starts running, it is faster than a horse with its rider.

God has also made strange creatures that seem "foolish." And yet they have their own strength. God's creation is full of surprises and humor.

The war horse VERSES 19–25

19 "Have you given the horse his strength?
Have you clothed his neck with a flowing mane?
20 Have you made him leap like a locust?
His proud snorting is terrifying.
21 He paws the ground in the valley and enjoys his strength.
He charges out to meet the armed men.
22 He laughs at fear and is not afraid.
He does not turn back from the sword.
23 The quiver of arrows rattles against him,
along with the flashing spear and the javelin.
24 He eats up the ground with fierce rage.
He cannot stand still at the sound of the trumpet.
25 Whenever the trumpet sounds, he snorts, 'Aha!'
He smells the battle from far away,
the thunder of the commanders, and the shouting.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The horse in war is brave and strong. It is not afraid of weapons or noise.

"He eats up the ground": He gallops so fast that he seems to swallow up the road.

"Aha!" (in Hebrew "He'ach!"): The horse neighs with impatience when it hears the signal to attack.

This strength and this courage also come from God, not from human beings. The Bible does not praise war here. It is amazed at the animal God has made.

Hawk and eagle VERSES 26–30

26 "Is it by your wisdom that the hawk soars,
and spreads her wings toward the south?
27 Is it at your command that the eagle flies upward,
and builds his nest up high?
28 He lives on the cliff and makes his home there,
on the tip of the cliff, in a safe stronghold.
29 From there he looks out for prey.
His eyes see it from far away.
30 His young ones also suck up blood.
Where the dead bodies are, there he is."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 26: In the fall, the hawk flies south. Who taught it that? Not Job. God has given the migrating birds their knowledge.

The eagle builds his nest high up in the rocks. He sees his prey from a great distance.

Verse 30 also shows the hard side of nature: Animals eat other animals. God does not keep quiet about this. That too belongs to his creation, which human beings do not fully understand.

Jesus takes up this picture: "For wherever the dead body is, that is where the vultures gather" (Matthew 24:28).

JOB

Chapter 40

Job falls silent – God's second speech: behemoth

Job puts his hand over his mouth VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD went on and answered Job,
2 "Will the one who argues fight with the Almighty?
Whoever argues with God, let him answer!"
3 Then Job answered the LORD,
4 "Look, I am too small.
What can I answer you?
I put my hand over my mouth.
5 I have spoken once, and I will not answer again.
Yes, I have spoken twice, but I will not say anything more."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God calls on Job: You wanted to argue with me. Now answer!

And Job, who has talked so much, falls silent. "I put my hand over my mouth" is a gesture. It means: I am silent. I have nothing more to say.

Job does not say: I have sinned. He says: I am too small. He has seen how great God is.

But this is not the end yet. God speaks a second time.

Will you set aside my justice? VERSES 6–14

6 Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind,
7 "Now get ready like a man!
I will ask you questions, and you will answer me.
8 Will you even set aside my judgment?
Will you condemn me, so that you can be in the right?
9 Do you have an arm like God's?
Can you thunder with a voice like his?
10 "Then dress yourself in greatness and dignity!
Clothe yourself with honor and majesty!
11 Pour out your burning anger!
Look at everyone who is proud, and bring him down!
12 Look at everyone who is proud, and humble him!
Crush the wicked where they stand!
13 Hide them all together in the dust!
Tie up their faces in the hidden place!
14 Then I too will admit to you
that your own right hand can save you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8 is the heart of God's second speech: Job, to show that you are in the right, you have called me unjust. That goes too far.

God does not say that Job has sinned and is suffering because of it. But he rebukes Job for accusing God.

Then God makes an offer, with irony: Go ahead, sit on my throne! You make the world just! Bring down all the proud and the wicked!

Job had complained that God does not punish the wicked. God says: You try it. Ruling the world is harder than you think.

Behemoth VERSES 15–24

15 "Look now at behemoth,
which I made just as I made you.
He eats grass like an ox.
16 Look now, his strength is in his hips.
His power is in the muscles of his belly.
17 He swings his tail like a cedar tree.
The sinews of his thighs are tightly woven together.
18 His bones are like pipes of bronze.
His legs are like bars of iron.
19 He is the first among the works of God.
The one who made him gives him his sword.
20 Surely the mountains produce food for him,
where all the wild animals play.
21 He lies under the lotus plants,
hidden in the reeds and the marsh.
22 The lotus plants cover him with their shade.
The willows by the stream surround him.
23 Look, if a river floods, he does not tremble.
He is calm, even if the Jordan rises up to his mouth.
24 Can anyone catch him while he is watching?
Can anyone pierce his nose with a trap?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Behemoth" is a Hebrew word. It is the plural of "animal," so something like "the animal of all animals," "the giant beast."

Which animal is meant? Many think of the hippopotamus: It eats grass, lies in the marsh under plants and is not afraid of floods. Others think of the elephant. Still others see in it a mythical creature from the beginning, a picture of the wild, untamed forces of the world.

Verse 15 is important: "which I made just as I made you." Behemoth is a creature of God, just like Job. Even the strongest, wildest animal is in God's hand.

Verse 19: "The first among the works of God": a masterpiece of God's creation.

A note on verse numbers: In some Bibles (following the Hebrew), Chapter 40 has 32 verses in all. Verses 25–32 there are Job 41:1–8 here.

JOB

Chapter 41

Leviathan

Can you catch Leviathan? VERSES 1–11

1 "Can you pull out Leviathan with a fishhook?
Can you press down his tongue with a cord?
2 Can you put a rope through his nose?
Can you pierce his jaw with a hook?
3 Will he beg you over and over for mercy?
Will he speak gentle words to you?
4 Will he make a covenant with you,
so that you can take him as your servant forever?
5 Will you play with him as with a pet bird?
Will you put him on a leash for your girls?
6 Will traders bargain over him?
Will they divide him up among the merchants?
7 Can you fill his skin with harpoons,
or his head with fishing spears?
8 Lay your hand on him.
Remember the fight, and you will never do it again!
9 Look, any hope of beating him is useless.
Won't a person be knocked down just by the sight of him?
10 No one is so fierce that he dares to stir him up.
So who is the one who can stand before me?
11 Who has given me anything first, so that I would have to pay him back?
Everything under the heavens is mine.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Leviathan is a huge sea monster. Many think of the crocodile (compare the armor of scales in verses 15–17). But in ancient stories of the Near East, Leviathan also stands for chaos, for evil and for the powers that threaten human beings (compare Job 3:8; Psalm 74:14; Isaiah 27:1).

God asks with humor: Can you catch Leviathan on a hook like a fish? Will he beg you for mercy? Can you put him on a leash as a pet for your daughters? Of course not!

Verse 8: Whoever attacks him once never does it again.

Verses 10–11 are the conclusion: If no one can stand before Leviathan, who can stand before God, his Creator? God owes nobody anything. Everything belongs to him. Paul quotes this thought in Romans 11:35.

A note on verse numbers: In some Bibles, verses 1–8 of this chapter are Job 40:25–32. After that, the verse numbers there are 8 lower (verse 9 here is 41:1 there).

His body VERSES 12–17

12 "I will not keep quiet about his limbs,
or his mighty strength, or his fine build.
13 Who can strip off his outer coat?
Who can get between his jaws?
14 Who can open the doors of his face?
All around his teeth is terror.
15 His strong scales are his pride.
They are shut tight together like a seal.
16 They lie so close to one another
that no air can get between them.
17 They are joined to one another.
They stick together, so that they cannot be pulled apart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is proud of his creature. He describes Leviathan the way an artist describes his masterpiece.

"His outer coat" is his skin, his armor. "The doors of his face" are his huge mouth.

The scales lie so close together that nothing gets through, neither air nor any weapon.

Fire and smoke VERSES 18–24

18 "When he sneezes, light flashes out.
His eyes are like the eyelids of the dawn.
19 Burning torches come out of his mouth.
Sparks of fire leap out.
20 Smoke comes out of his nostrils,
like a boiling pot over a fire of reeds.
21 His breath sets coals on fire.
A flame comes out of his mouth.
22 There is strength in his neck.
Terror dances in front of him.
23 The folds of his flesh are joined together.
They are firm on him. They cannot be moved.
24 His heart is as hard as a stone,
yes, as hard as the lower millstone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the description becomes more and more powerful: fire from the mouth, smoke from the nose. This is poetic language that wants to show how frightening he is. It makes you think of a dragon.

Verse 18: When a crocodile snorts in the sunlight, the water sparkles. Its eyes come up out of the water with a reddish glow, like the dawn.

Verse 24: His heart is as hard as stone. He knows no fear and no pity.

No weapon helps VERSES 25–34

25 "When he rises up, the mighty are afraid.
They back away from his thrashing.
26 If someone attacks him with the sword, it does nothing.
Neither does the spear, the dart or the pointed shaft.
27 He thinks of iron as straw,
and of bronze as rotten wood.
28 An arrow cannot make him run away.
Stones from a sling are like the dry husks of grain to him.
29 He thinks of clubs as straw.
He laughs at the rushing sound of the javelin.
30 His underside is like sharp pieces of broken pottery.
He leaves a trail in the mud like a threshing sledge.
31 He makes the deep boil like a pot.
He makes the sea like a pot of ointment.
32 He leaves a shining path behind him.
You would think the deep had white hair.
33 On earth there is nothing equal to him.
He was made without fear.
34 He looks at everything that is high.
He is king over all the sons of pride."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

All human weapons are useless against Leviathan: sword, spear, arrow, sling, club.

Verses 31–32: When he swims through the sea, the water foams up. Behind him there is a white trail of foam, as if the sea had gotten white hair.

Verse 34: Leviathan is "king over all the sons of pride." That means: over all the proud. This is the key: In Job 40:11–12, God challenged Job to bring down the proud. Job cannot even defeat Leviathan. But God created him and holds him in his hand.

The message of God's two speeches: The world is full of wild and dangerous forces that people do not control. But God controls them. Job does not have to understand everything. He can trust God.

God has not answered Job's question "Why?" He has not told him anything about the conversation in heaven (Chapters 1–2). But God has shown himself to Job. And that is enough for Job, as the next chapter shows.

JOB

CHAPTER 42

Job's answer and God's blessing

Now my eye sees you VERSES 1–6

1 Then Job answered the LORD:
2 "I know that you can do all things.
No plan of yours can be stopped.
3 You asked, 'Who is this who hides my plan without knowledge?'
So I have spoken about things I did not understand,
things too wonderful for me, which I did not know.
4 You said, 'Listen now, and I will speak.
I will ask you questions, and you will answer me.'
5 I had heard of you with my ears,
but now my eye sees you.
6 That is why I hate myself,
and I am sorry, in dust and ashes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is Job's last answer. He sees: God can do everything. God's plans go far beyond what I understand.

In verses 3 and 4, Job quotes God's own words (Job 38:2–3). He admits: I have talked about things that were too big for me.

Verse 5 is one of the most important sentences in the whole book: "I had heard of you with my ears, but now my eye sees you." Before, Job knew God from what others said. Now he has met God himself. That changes everything.

Verse 6 can be understood in different ways in Hebrew:

– "I hate myself" (as the WEB, our English source text, says), or

– "I take back (my words)," or

– "I give up my complaint and let myself be comforted, even though I am in dust and ashes."

What is clear: Job does not confess that he suffered because of a sin. He takes back his accusations against God. And he finds peace without knowing the answer to the question "Why?"

God's anger at the friends VERSES 7–9

7 After the LORD had spoken these words to Job,
the LORD said to Eliphaz the Temanite,
"I am angry with you and with your two friends.
For you have not spoken of me what is right,
as my servant Job has.
8 So now take seven bulls and seven rams for yourselves.
Go to my servant Job,
and offer up a burnt offering for yourselves.
My servant Job will pray for you,
for I will accept him.
Then I will not deal with you as your foolishness deserves.
For you have not spoken of me what is right,
as my servant Job has."
9 So Eliphaz the Temanite, Bildad the Shuhite and Zophar the Naamathite went
and did what the LORD had commanded them.
And the LORD accepted Job.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the big surprise at the end: God is angry with the friends, not with Job!

The friends seemed to defend God. They said: God is just, so Job must have sinned. But that was wrong. They did not speak of God what is right.

Job complained, argued and accused God. But he spoke honestly. He turned toward God and not away from him. Twice God calls him "my servant Job," as at the beginning (Job 1:8).

That means: God would rather have honest complaints than pious lies. We may tell God our pain.

And Job is to pray for the friends who hurt him so much. He speaks up for them before God. That is reconciliation.

Elihu is not mentioned here. He is neither praised nor blamed.

Job's happiness is restored VERSES 10–11

10 The LORD turned things around for Job when he prayed for his friends.
The LORD gave Job twice as much as he had before.
11 Then all his brothers, all his sisters
and all who had known him before came to him.
They ate a meal with him in his house.
They comforted him and showed him sympathy
for all the trouble that the LORD had brought on him.
Each of them gave him a piece of money
and a gold ring.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The turning point comes "when he prayed for his friends." When Job forgave, he himself was healed.

Job gets everything back twice over.

His family and friends finally come. Before, they had left him alone (Job 19:13–19). Now they eat with him and comfort him.

"A piece of money": The Hebrew says "kesitah," an old unit of weight for silver. Otherwise it is mentioned only in the stories about Jacob (Genesis 33:19). Its exact value is unknown.

The Bible honestly says: The trouble came from the LORD (compare Job 2:10). It does not try to explain this away.

A new beginning VERSES 12–17

12 So the LORD blessed the last part of Job's life more than the first.
He had 14,000 sheep, 6,000 camels,
1,000 pairs of oxen and 1,000 female donkeys.
13 He also had seven sons and three daughters.
14 He named the first daughter Jemimah,
the second Keziah,
and the third Keren Happuch.
15 In all the land there were no women as beautiful as Job's daughters.
Their father gave them an inheritance along with their brothers.
16 After this, Job lived 140 years.
He saw his sons and his grandsons,
four generations.
17 Then Job died, old and full of days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Job's animals are exactly doubled (compare Job 1:3).

He again has seven sons and three daughters. The children are not "doubled." Many scholars say: The children who died cannot be replaced. They are still Job's children, even after their death. A new child does not undo the pain over a child who was lost.

If you have lost a child yourself and need help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The daughters are named, but the sons are not. The names are beautiful: Jemimah means "little dove," Keziah "cinnamon blossom," Keren Happuch "little makeup box" (a container for precious eye makeup).

Verse 15: Job gives his daughters an inheritance like his sons. That was unusual in those days. Normally only sons inherited (compare Numbers 27:1–8).

"Old and full of days": The same is said about Abraham, Isaac and David. Job dies in peace after a full life.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Job?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The question: The book of Job asks one of the hardest questions of humankind: Why do good people have to suffer? Job is devout and righteous, and yet he loses everything: his possessions, his children, his health.

The wrong answer: The three friends say: Whoever suffers must have sinned. At the end, God says clearly: That is wrong. Suffering is not always punishment. We must not blame people who suffer by saying it is their own fault. Jesus later says this too (John 9:1–3; Luke 13:1–5).

Honest complaint: Job does not curse God, but he complains and cries out. He argues with God. And God says that Job has "spoken of me what is right." The book allows us to tell God our pain and our questions honestly.

The hope: In the middle of his despair, Job has great moments of faith: He says that he knows his Redeemer lives (Job 19:25). He longs for a judge between him and God, a witness in heaven, someone who speaks up for him. Christians see in this a hint of Jesus Christ.

Elihu: The young Elihu brings a new idea: Suffering can also be a way of teaching or warning, through which God speaks. That is sometimes true, but not always.

God's answer: God does not explain to Job why he suffered. He shows him the greatness and beauty of creation, from the morning stars to Leviathan. The message: The world is bigger than you understand. But I hold it in my hand. You can trust me.

Meeting God: The most important thing for Job is not the answer but the meeting: "But now my eye sees you."

What we do not know: The reader knows more than Job: The reader knows the scene in heaven (Chapters 1–2). This shows: Behind our suffering too, there may be connections that we do not see.

The end: Job prays for his friends, is restored and dies "old and full of days." But the good ending does not undo the suffering. Not all suffering ends well in this life. The book of Job does not promise that either. But it shows: God does not leave those who suffer alone.

What comes next? Next comes the book of Psalms, 150 songs and prayers. Many of them sound like Job: complaint, questions, trust and praise.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 19 OF 66

PSALMS

150 PSALMS

PSALMS

Psalm 1

Two ways

Before we begin: What is the book of Psalms?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Psalms is the prayer book and songbook of the Bible. It has 150 psalms. The word "psalm" comes from Greek. It means "a song that is played with string instruments." In Hebrew, the book is called "Tehillim." That means "songs of praise."

Who wrote them? Many psalms are linked with David, the king of Israel (about 1000 BC). Others come from Asaph, the sons of Korah, Solomon, Moses and others. Many have no name. The psalms were written over many centuries.

Five books: The psalms are divided into five parts, like the five books of Moses: Psalms 1–41, 42–72, 73–89, 90–106 and 107–150. Each part ends with praise to God.

What is in them? Everything people bring to God: praise and thanks, complaint and despair, asking for help, confessing guilt, trust, anger about injustice, joy about God's creation. The psalms show: You may talk with God about everything.

Headings: Many psalms have a heading, for example "A psalm by David" or "For the music director." In the WEB, our English source text, the heading belongs to verse 1. Some Bibles count the heading as a verse of its own. That is why the verse numbers there are often 1 or 2 higher.

"Selah": This word often stands at the end of a section. No one knows exactly what it means. It is probably a sign for the music, perhaps for a pause or an interlude.

Poetry: The psalms are poems. A typical feature is "parallelism": The second line repeats a thought in other words, or takes it further. That is why we keep the form of short lines.

Until today: Jews and Christians have prayed the psalms for thousands of years. Jesus prayed them, even on the cross (Psalms 22 and 31). The New Testament quotes no book as often as the Psalms.

Happy is the one who loves God's teaching VERSES 1–3

1 Blessed is the person
who does not follow the advice of the wicked,
who does not stand on the path of sinners,
and who does not sit with people who mock.
2 Instead, he takes delight in the LORD's law.
He thinks about his law day and night.
3 He will be like a tree planted by streams of water.
It bears its fruit at the right time.
Its leaves do not dry up.
Whatever he does will go well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 1 is the entrance gate to the whole book. It shows two ways. Every person can choose between them.

"Blessed" (often also translated as "happy"): This is about a life that goes well and is full.

Verse 1 shows a step-by-step movement: walking, standing, sitting. Someone who comes close to evil is first carried along. Then he stops and stays. In the end, he sits down with them and belongs to them.

"Law" (in Hebrew "Torah") does not mean only rules. It means everything God shows us about how we can live well.

"Thinks about" means in Hebrew, more exactly, "murmurs": People said the words quietly to themselves to learn them by heart.

The picture of the tree by the water: Even in times of drought, it stays green, because its roots reach the water (compare Jeremiah 17:7–8).

The way of the wicked VERSES 4–6

4 The wicked are not like that.
They are like chaff that the wind blows away.
5 That is why the wicked will not stand firm in the judgment.
And sinners will not stand in the gathering of the righteous.
6 For the LORD knows the way of the righteous,
but the way of the wicked will come to nothing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chaff is the empty husks that come off when grain is threshed. People threw everything into the air, and the wind carried the light chaff away. The heavy grain stayed behind.

The tree has roots and bears fruit. The chaff has no weight and nothing to hold it.

Righteous means: living right before God.

Verse 6: "The LORD knows the way of the righteous." In the Bible, "to know" means more than to have information. It means: to go along with, to take care of, to be close to.

The psalm describes how God meant things to be. Job showed that life does not always look this simple. But in the end, the psalm says, only the way with God lasts.

PSALMS

Psalm 2

The king whom God has chosen

The nations rebel VERSES 1–3

1 Why are the nations in an uproar?
Why do the peoples make plans that will come to nothing?

2 The kings of the earth get ready to fight.
The rulers meet together to make plans
against the LORD and against his Anointed One.
They say,
3 "Let's tear off their chains.
Let's throw off the ropes they tied on us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 2 belongs together with Psalm 1. Together, they form the entrance to the book of Psalms.

Powerful kings want to rebel against God and his king. To them, God's rule feels like chains.

"Anointed One" is "Mashiach" in Hebrew (Messiah), and "Christos" in Greek. At first, this meant the king of Israel. When he became king, oil was poured on his head (compare 1 Samuel 16:13).

God laughs at them VERSES 4–6

4 The one who sits in heaven laughs.
The Lord makes fun of them.
5 Then he speaks to them in his anger.
He fills them with terror in his fury:
6 "But I have placed my King
on Zion, my holy hill."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is not worried. The plans of the powerful are laughably small to him.

Zion is the hill in Jerusalem where the temple stood. There God has placed his king.

You are my son VERSES 7–9

7 I will tell about what the LORD has decided.
The LORD said to me, "You are my son.
Today I have become your father.
8 Ask me, and I will give you the nations as your
inheritance.
The farthest ends of the earth will belong to you.
9 You will break them with an iron rod.
You will smash them to pieces like clay pots."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the king himself speaks. He tells what God said when he made him king: "You are my son."

In ancient Israel, this was a kind of adoption formula. On the day he was crowned, the king became God's "son" (compare 2 Samuel 7:14).

Jews understand the psalm as speaking about the king from the family of David and about the Messiah who is coming.

Christians see a pointer to Jesus here. When Jesus was baptized, a voice from heaven called him God's Son, whom God loves (Mark 1:11). The New Testament quotes verse 7 several times (Acts 13:33; Hebrews 1:5).

Verse 9 is a picture of complete power. It is a picture from the language of kings in those days. It is not a call to violence. The New Testament links it with the final victory over evil (Revelation 19:15).

A warning to the powerful VERSES 10–12

10 So now, you kings, be wise!
Let yourselves be warned, you judges of the earth!
11 Serve the LORD with fear.
Rejoice with trembling.
12 Give sincere honor to the Son,
so that he does not become angry and you are
destroyed on your way.
For his anger can flare up quickly.
Blessed are all who take refuge in him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The powerful are warned, but they are also invited: Be wise! Serve God!

Verse 12 is hard to translate from Hebrew. It probably says, word for word, "Kiss the Son." Kissing was a sign of respect before a king. Others translate it as "Kiss his feet" or "Accept correction."

The psalm ends with "Blessed," just as Psalm 1 began with it. This joins the two psalms together like a frame.

"Take refuge in him": Whoever trusts himself to God is safe.

PSALMS

PSALM 3

A morning prayer in danger

So many enemies VERSES 1–2

1 A psalm by David, when he ran away from his son
Absalom.
LORD, how many enemies I have now!
Many people rise up against me.
2 Many say about me,
"God will not help him."
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The heading names the situation: David has to run away from his own son Absalom. Absalom wants to take the throne away from him (2 Samuel 15–18). This is one of the most painful moments in David's life.

The worst thing is not only the many enemies, but their mocking: God does not help him anymore. Job knew this, too.

"Selah": probably a sign for a pause in the music (see Psalm 1).

Note: In some Bibles, the heading is verse 1. That is why every verse there is 1 higher.

But you, LORD VERSES 3–6

3 But you, LORD, are a shield all around me.
You are my glory.
You are the one who lifts up my head.
4 I cry out loud to the LORD.
He answers me from his holy hill.
Selah.
5 I lay down and slept.
I woke up, because the LORD holds me up.

6 I will not be afraid of tens of thousands of people
who have lined up against me on every side.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With "But you" comes the turning point. David no longer looks at the enemies. He looks at God.

God is like a shield that protects him all around. "The one who lifts up my head": When David fled, he walked with his head covered, and he wept (2 Samuel 15:30). God lifts him up again.

Verse 5: In the middle of danger, David can sleep. This is a sign of great trust. That is why Psalm 3 is seen as a morning prayer: I have woken up. God has kept me safe.

Get up, LORD! VERSES 7–8

7 Get up, LORD! Save me, my God!
For you have struck all my enemies on the cheek.
You have broken the teeth of the wicked.
8 Rescue comes from the LORD.
May your blessing be on your people.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Get up, LORD!" was the call when the ark of the covenant went out into battle (Numbers 10:35).

The enemies are compared with wild animals. When their teeth are broken, they cannot bite anymore. This is a picture: God takes away the enemies' power to do harm. David does not strike them himself. He leaves it to God.

Verse 8: At the end, David does not think only of himself. He blesses the whole people, even those who have just turned away from him.

PSALMS

PSALM 4

An evening prayer

Answer me when I call VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. On string instruments. A psalm by David.
Answer me when I call, God of my righteousness!
That means: God who makes things right for me.
Give me relief from my trouble.
Be kind to me and hear my prayer.
2 You people, how long will you turn my honor into shame?
Will you love what is worthless and look for lies?
Selah.
3 But know this: The LORD has set apart for himself the one who is faithful to him.
The LORD will hear when I call to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"For the music director": This note stands above many psalms. It shows that the psalms were sung in worship.

"God of my righteousness": God is the one who makes sure I receive justice.

People are spreading lies about David. They love "what is worthless" and "lies." Some think of false gods here, others of false rumors.

Be still VERSES 4–5

4 Stand in awe, and do not sin.
Search your own heart on your bed, and be still.
Selah.
5 Bring the right sacrifices.
Put your trust in the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Good advice for the evening: Before you sleep, think about your day. Search your heart. Become still.

Verse 4 can also be translated in another way. Paul quotes it like this in Ephesians 4:26: Be angry, but do not sin. And Paul adds: Do not let your anger last until the sun goes down.

"The right sacrifices" (in the WEB: "the sacrifices of righteousness"): sacrifices brought with an honest heart, not only on the outside.

Peace in the night VERSES 6–8

6 Many say, "Who will let us see anything good?"
LORD, let the light of your face shine on us.
7 You have filled my heart with joy,
more than people have when they have lots of grain and new wine.
8 In peace I will lie down and sleep,
for you alone, LORD, let me live in safety.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many people are unhappy and ask: Where is the good?

David answers with a prayer from the blessing of Aaron: The LORD make his face shine on you (Numbers 6:25).

Verse 7: The joy that comes from God is greater than the joy about a rich harvest.

Verse 8 is one of the most beautiful sentences for the evening: "In peace I will lie down and sleep." Psalm 3 was a morning prayer. Psalm 4 is an evening prayer.

PSALMS

PSALM 5

A prayer in the morning

In the morning you hear my voice VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. With flutes. A psalm by David.
Listen to my words, LORD.

Pay attention to my quiet thoughts.
2 Listen to the sound of my cry for help, my King and my God,
for I pray to you.
3 LORD, in the morning you will hear my voice.
In the morning I will lay my requests before you,
and I will watch and wait for your answer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David begins the day with prayer. He brings his requests to God and waits eagerly for God's answer.

"My King": David is a king himself, but he knows: The true King is God.

"I will watch and wait": like a guard who waits for the morning.

God takes no pleasure in evil VERSES 4–6

4 For you are not a God who takes pleasure in wickedness.
Evil cannot live with you.
5 Proud people will not stand before your eyes.
You hate all who do wrong.
6 You will destroy those who tell lies.
The LORD hates people who are violent and who deceive others.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is holy. He cannot put up with evil.

"You hate all who do wrong": This is a strong statement. In the language of the Bible, "to hate" often means: to firmly reject, not to want something near you. The Bible also says that God does not want the sinner to die. He wants the sinner to turn back and live (Ezekiel 18:23).

I will come into your house VERSES 7–8

7 But as for me, because your loving kindness is so great,
I will come into your house.
I will bow down toward your holy temple with deep respect for you.
8 LORD, lead me in your righteousness because of my enemies.
Make your way straight in front of me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David knows: I may come to God. This is not because I am so good. It is "because your loving kindness is so great." The Hebrew word is "chesed": God's faithful love.

"Toward your holy temple": Jews still pray facing Jerusalem today.

David asks: Show me the right way, and make it straight and smooth, with nothing to trip over.

The enemies, and those who take refuge VERSES 9–12

9 For nothing they say can be trusted.
Their heart is full of destruction.
Their throat is an open grave.
They flatter with their tongue.
10 God, declare them guilty.
Let them fall because of their own plans.
Drive them out because of all their many sins,
for they have rebelled against you.
11 But let all who take refuge in you be glad.
Let them always shout for joy, because you protect them.
Let those who love your name also be joyful in you.
12 For you will bless the righteous.
LORD, you will surround him with your kindness like a shield.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: The words of the enemies are deadly, like an open grave. Paul quotes this in Romans 3:13 to show that all people need God's grace.

Verse 10 asks for justice. David asks God to let the wicked fail because of their own plans. He does not take revenge himself. He leaves the judgment to God. Such prayers are called "cursing psalms" or "psalms of revenge." They honestly show the pain of people who suffer injustice. Later, Jesus teaches us to pray even for our enemies (Matthew 5:44).

Verses 11–12: The psalm ends with joy. God protects all who take refuge in him, as if with a large shield.

PSALMS

PSALM 6

A prayer in deep trouble

LORD, how long? VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. On string instruments, on the eight-stringed lyre. A psalm by David.
LORD, do not correct me in your anger.
Do not punish me in your fury.
2 Be kind to me, LORD, for I am weak.
LORD, heal me, for my bones are shaking.
3 My soul is also in deep distress.
But you, LORD—how long?
4 Come back, LORD. Rescue my soul.
Save me because of your loving kindness.
5 For in death, no one remembers you.
Who will thank you in Sheol (the world of the dead)?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 6 is the first of the seven "psalms of repentance" (6, 32, 38, 51, 102, 130, 143). Christians pray them especially when they ask God for forgiveness.

The person praying is sick in body and soul. "My bones are shaking": The whole body is suffering.

"How long?": The sentence breaks off. The person praying has no more words. We hear this question often in the psalms.

"Because of your loving kindness": The person praying does not point to his own good deeds. He points to God's faithful love.

Verse 5: In the Old Testament, people imagined the world of the dead ("Sheol") as a quiet, dark place. The hope of rising from the dead became clearer only later (compare Daniel 12:2).

I am worn out from groaning VERSES 6–7

6 I am worn out from my groaning.
Every night I flood my bed.
I soak my couch with my tears.
7 My eyes grow weak because of grief.
They grow old because of all my enemies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A very honest picture: The person praying cries so much every night that his bed is wet. He is exhausted.

The Bible does not hide such feelings. You may cry in front of God.

If you feel like this right now and do not know how to go on: You are not alone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. If you are thinking about hurting yourself: In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

The LORD has heard my weeping VERSES 8–10

8 Go away from me, all you who do evil,
for the LORD has heard the sound of my weeping.
9 The LORD has heard my plea for help.
The LORD accepts my prayer.
10 May all my enemies be put to shame and filled with terror.
They will turn back. Suddenly they will be put to shame.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Suddenly the turning point comes. The person praying is sure: God has heard my weeping!

Three times he says: The LORD has heard, the LORD has heard, the LORD accepts. It is as if he says it to himself again and again, so that he can fully believe it.

Many psalms of complaint have this turning point: At the beginning there is trouble, at the end there is trust. This is not because the situation has already changed. It is because the person praying knows: God has heard me.

PSALMS

PSALM 7

God is a righteous judge

Save me from those who chase me VERSES 1–2

1 A meditation by David. He sang it to the LORD because of the words of Cush, the Benjamite.
LORD, my God, I take refuge in you.
Save me from all who chase me, and rescue me.
2 Otherwise they will tear my soul apart like a lion.
They will rip it to pieces, and no one will be there to rescue me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Meditation": In Hebrew, it says "Shiggaion." No one knows exactly what it means. It may be a special kind of song, or a stirred-up, passionate song.

We do not know who Cush from the tribe of Benjamin was. He is not mentioned anywhere else. Saul came from the tribe of Benjamin. Perhaps Cush was one of Saul's men who told lies about David.

If I have done wrong VERSES 3–5

3 LORD, my God, if I have done this,
if there is guilt on my hands,
4 if I have paid back evil to someone who was at peace with me
(yes, I have robbed the one who was my enemy for no reason),
5 then let the enemy chase my soul and catch it.
Yes, let him trample my life into the ground,
and lay my honor in the dust.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David swears an oath, much like Job (Chapter 31): If I am guilty, let disaster strike me.

Verse 4: The words in parentheses are hard to understand. The WEB, our English source text, translates: "I have robbed the one who was my enemy for no reason." But some Bibles understand the Hebrew word as "to set free" or "to spare." Then it means: Yes, I have even rescued the one who was my enemy for no reason. That would fit David, who spared Saul's life two times (1 Samuel 24 and 26). Both readings are possible.

Get up, LORD, and judge! VERSES 6–10

6 Get up, LORD, in your anger!
Rise up against the rage of my enemies!
Wake up for me! You have ordered that judgment must happen.
7 Let the gathering of the peoples stand around you.
Rule over them from on high.
8 The LORD judges the peoples.
Judge me, LORD, by my righteousness,
and by the honesty that is in me.
9 Oh, let the wickedness of the wicked come to an end.
But make the righteous stand firm.
The righteous God tests their minds and hearts.
10 My shield is with God.
He saves those whose hearts are honest.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David asks God to step in as judge. He does not want to take revenge himself. He leaves the judgment to God.

Verse 9: God tests "minds and hearts." Word for word, it says "kidneys and heart." Back then, people thought of the kidneys as the place of feelings and the heart as the place of thoughts. So God sees into the deepest part of a person.

Whoever digs a pit VERSES 11–17

11 God is a righteous judge.
Yes, he is a God who is angry every day.
12 If a person does not turn back, he will sharpen his sword.
He has bent his bow and strung it.

13 He has also gotten deadly weapons ready for himself.
He prepares his flaming arrows.
14 Look! He is in labor with evil.
Yes, he has become pregnant with trouble and given birth to lies.
15 He has dug a hole,
and he has fallen into the pit that he made.
16 The trouble he causes will come back on his own head.
His violence will come down on the top of his own head.
17 I will thank the LORD for his righteousness.
I will sing praise to the name of the LORD Most High.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God "is angry every day": God does not shrug at evil. Injustice touches him.

Verses 12–13: Who is "he"? It can mean God: God stands ready if the wicked person does not turn back. Or it can mean the wicked person: He prepares weapons against others. Both are possible.

Verse 14: A picture from giving birth: The wicked person "becomes pregnant" with evil plans and "gives birth" to lies.

Verses 15–16: Many people know this as a saying: Whoever digs a pit for others falls into it himself. The saying comes from the Bible. Proverbs 26:27 says: "Whoever digs a pit will fall into it." Evil falls back on the one who does it.

The psalm ends with thanks and praise.

PSALMS

Psalm 8

What is a human being?

How majestic is your name VERSES 1–2

1 For the music director. On an instrument from Gath. A psalm by David.
LORD, our Lord,
how majestic is your name in all the earth!
You have placed your glory above the heavens!
2 From the lips of babies and little children you have built up strength,
because of your enemies,
to silence the enemy and the one who seeks revenge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 8 is a psalm of praise about creation and about human beings.

"An instrument from Gath" (in Hebrew: "Gittith"): Gath was a city of the Philistines. Perhaps it means an instrument or a tune from Gath. No one knows for sure.

Verse 2: A surprising thought: God does not need strong warriors. Even the babbling and laughing of little children is praise to God that puts the enemies to shame. Jesus quotes this verse when children praise him in the temple (Matthew 21:16).

What is a human being? VERSES 3–8

3 When I look at your heavens, the work of your fingers,
the moon and the stars, which you have set in place,
4 what is a human being, that you think of him?
What is a son of man, that you care for him?
A son of man means: a human being.
5 For you have made him only a little lower than the angels.
You have crowned him with glory and honor.
6 You make him ruler over the works of your hands.
You have put all things under his feet:
7 all sheep and cattle,
yes, and the wild animals of the field,
8 the birds of the sky, the fish of the sea,
and everything that swims along the paths of the seas.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At night, David looks up at the starry sky. He feels tiny. And yet he is amazed: The great God thinks of small human beings and takes care of them!

Verse 5: "Only a little lower than the angels": In Hebrew, it says "Elohim." This can mean "God" or "heavenly beings." Some Bibles translate it here as "God." Human beings have a high dignity.

Verses 6–8: God has given human beings responsibility for the animals and the earth (compare Genesis 1:26–28). "To rule" here does not mean to exploit. It means to take care of things responsibly, like a good king.

Job had asked the same question in bitterness: What is a human being, that you make so much of him and keep testing him? (Job 7:17). Psalm 8 asks it full of wonder.

The New Testament relates these verses to Jesus, the "Son of Man," to whom everything is made subject (Hebrews 2:6–9).

How majestic is your name VERSE 9

9 LORD, our Lord,
how majestic is your name in all the earth!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm ends with the same words it began with. Like a frame, the praise of God surrounds what is said about human beings.

This shows: Human beings are great, but God is greater. Human dignity comes from God.

PSALMS

Psalm 9

God judges fairly

I will thank you VERSES 1–6

1 For the music director. To the tune of "The Death of the
Son." A psalm by David.
I will thank the LORD with my whole heart.
I will tell about all the wonderful things you have
done.
2 I will be glad and full of joy because of you.
I will sing praise to your name, Most High.
3 When my enemies turn back,
they stumble and die in front of you.
4 For you have stood up for my rights and my cause.
You sit on the throne and judge fairly.
5 You have scolded the nations.
You have destroyed the wicked.
You have wiped out their name forever and ever.
6 The enemy is caught in endless ruin.
Even the memory of the cities that you have torn
down is gone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"To the tune of 'The Death of the Son'": This is probably the name of a well-known tune that the psalm was sung to. No one knows it today.

Psalms 9 and 10 belong together. In Hebrew, together they form a poem based on the alphabet (an "acrostic"): Every second verse begins with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet. In the old Greek and Latin Bibles, they are one single psalm. That is why, from here on, the psalm number in older Catholic and in Orthodox Bibles is often 1 lower (up to Psalm 147).

David thanks God with his whole heart, because God has helped him against his enemies.

The LORD reigns forever VERSES 7–12

7 But the LORD reigns forever.
He has set up his throne for judgment.
8 He will judge the world with righteousness.
He will judge the peoples honestly.
9 The LORD will also be a high tower for those who are
oppressed,
a high tower in times of trouble.
10 Those who know your name will put their trust in you,
for you, LORD, have not abandoned those who look
for you.
11 Sing praises to the LORD, who lives in Zion.
Tell the peoples what he has done.
12 For the one who punishes murder remembers them.
He does not forget the cry of those who suffer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mighty empires come and go. But God reigns forever.

God is like a "high tower" for those who are oppressed: a safe place where they find protection.

Verse 12: "The one who punishes murder": God makes sure that murder and violence are not forgotten. He does not forget the victims.

Be kind to me VERSES 13–16

13 Be kind to me, LORD.
See how I suffer because of those who hate me.
Lift me up from the gates of death,
14 so that I can tell of all your praise.
I will rejoice in your rescue in the gates of the
daughter of Zion.
15 The nations have sunk down into the pit that they
made.
Their own foot is caught in the net that they hid.
16 The LORD has made himself known.
He has carried out judgment.
The wicked is trapped by the work of his own hands.
Meditation. Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Gates of death" and "gates of the daughter of Zion" stand opposite each other: God brings me back from the edge of death, so that I can sing his praise in Jerusalem (Zion).

"Daughter of Zion" is a poetic name for Jerusalem and the people who live there.

Verses 15–16: Again the same thought: The wicked are caught in their own trap (compare Psalm 7:15–16).

"Meditation" (in Hebrew "Higgaion"): probably a sign for the music, perhaps quiet playing for thinking things over.

The poor will not be forgotten VERSES 17–20

17 The wicked will be sent back to Sheol (the world of the
dead),
all the nations that forget God.
18 For the needy will not always be forgotten.
The hope of the poor will not be lost forever.
19 Get up, LORD! Do not let human beings win.
Let the nations be judged in front of you.
20 Fill them with fear, LORD.
Let the nations know that they are only human.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18 is a great promise: The poor will not be forgotten forever. Their hope will not be disappointed.

Verse 20: Mighty nations often forget that they are "only human." They think of themselves as gods. The psalm asks God to show them their limits.

PSALMS

Psalm 10

Why are you so far away, LORD?

Why do you hide? VERSES 1–2

1 Why do you stand so far away, LORD?
Why do you hide yourself in times of trouble?
2 In their pride, the wicked hunt down the weak.
They are caught in the evil plans they think up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 10 has no heading. It continues Psalm 9 (see there).

The psalm begins with an honest, painful question: Why is God so far away when people need him most? People still ask this question today.

The second half of verse 2: "They are caught in the evil plans they think up." This can also be read as a request to God: May God catch them in their own plans.

This is how the wicked think VERSES 3–11

3 For the wicked person boasts about what his heart craves.
He praises the greedy and speaks against the LORD.
4 The wicked person is so proud
that there is no room for God in his thoughts.
5 Everything always goes well for him.
He is arrogant, and your laws are far away from his eyes.
He sneers at all his enemies.
6 He says to himself, "Nothing will shake me.
For generations, I will have no trouble."
7 His mouth is full of cursing, lies and threats.
Under his tongue are trouble and evil.
8 He lies in wait near the villages.
From his hiding places he murders innocent people.
His eyes secretly watch for the helpless.
9 He hides in secret like a lion in its hiding place.
He lies in wait to catch the helpless.
He catches the helpless when he drags them into his net.
10 The helpless are crushed. They collapse.
They fall under his strength.
11 He says to himself, "God has forgotten.
He hides his face. He will never see it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here we see exactly how a wicked person thinks and acts:

– He is proud, and there is "no room for God in his thoughts."

– He is successful and feels safe: Nothing can happen to me.

– He lies and cheats.

– He lies in wait for the weak like a wild animal hunting its prey.

– He thinks: God does not see this.

Paul quotes verse 7 in Romans 3:14.

This describes oppression as it has existed at all times: The strong take advantage of the weak, and it seems as if no one steps in.

Get up, LORD! VERSES 12–15

12 Get up, LORD! God, lift up your hand!
Do not forget the helpless.
13 Why does the wicked person speak against God?
Why does he say to himself, "God will not make me answer for it"?
14 But you do see trouble and grief.
You look at it closely, to take it into your hand.
You help the victim and the child without a father.
15 Break the arm of the wicked.
As for the evil person, search out his wickedness until you find no more.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wicked person says: God does not see it. The person praying disagrees: Yes, you do see it! God sees the trouble and takes it into his hand.

"Break the arm" is a picture: Take away his power to harm others.

The second half of verse 15: God should search for evil until no more evil can be found. The goal is a world without injustice.

The LORD is King VERSES 16–18

16 The LORD is King forever and ever!
The nations will disappear from his land.
17 LORD, you have heard what the humble long for.
You will make their hearts strong.
You will listen closely
18 to bring justice to the child without a father and to the oppressed,
so that people who are made from the earth will not spread terror anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end there is trust: The LORD is King, not the violent people.

God hears the humble, the children without fathers and the oppressed.

"People who are made from the earth": Even the mightiest oppressor is only a human being made from dust. His power has an end.

Psalms 9 and 10 together show: Faith in God's justice and the honest complaint "Why do you stand so far away, LORD?" (Psalm 10:1) belong together.

PSALMS

PSALM 11

I find refuge with the LORD

Fly away like a bird? VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. By David.
I take refuge in the LORD.
How can you say to me,
"Fly away like a bird to your mountain"?
2 For look, the wicked bend their bows.
They put their arrows on the strings,
to shoot in the dark at those whose hearts are honest.
3 If the foundations are destroyed,
what can the righteous do?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Friends advise David: Run away! Get to safety! The situation is hopeless.

Verse 3 is their reason: If the foundations of society are destroyed, if law and order no longer count, what can one

single righteous person still do?

But David answers: I do not need to flee to the mountains. My refuge is God.

The LORD is on his throne VERSES 4–7

4 The LORD is in his holy temple.
The LORD's throne is in heaven.
His eyes watch.
His eyes examine all people.
5 The LORD examines the righteous,
but he hates the wicked and those who love violence with all his soul.
6 He will rain burning coals on the wicked.
Fire, sulfur and a scorching wind will be what fills their cup.
7 For the LORD is righteous.
He loves what is right.
Those who are honest will see his face.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David's answer to the question "What can the righteous do?": He looks up. Even when everything on earth is shaking, God is still sitting on his throne. He sees everything.

Verse 5: It says about God: "He hates the wicked and those who love violence with all his soul." God cannot stand violence.

Verse 6: "Fire, sulfur" reminds us of Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19:24). "Cup" is a picture of the fate that someone receives.

Verse 7: The goal of those who are honest is to see God's face, which means to be very close to God (compare Matthew 5:8: "Blessed are those whose hearts are pure, for they will see God").

PSALMS

PSALM 12

God's words are pure

Everyone lies VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. On an eight-stringed lyre. A psalm by David.
Help, LORD, for there are no more people who are faithful to you.
Those who can be trusted are disappearing from among people.
2 Everyone lies to his neighbor.
They speak with flattering lips
and with a double heart.
3 May the LORD cut off all flattering lips
and the tongue that boasts.
4 They have said, "With our tongue we will win.
Our lips belong to us. Who is lord over us?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying feels alone. There seem to be no more faithful, honest people.

"With a double heart": They say one thing and mean something else.

Verse 4: The liars are proud of the power of their words. They think: We can say whatever we want. No one can touch us.

Today, too, we see how much harm lies, rumors and hate speech can do, especially on the internet.

God gets up VERSES 5–8

5 "Because the weak are oppressed,
and because the needy groan,
I will now get up," says the LORD.
"I will bring him to safety, away from those who tell lies about him."
6 The LORD's words are pure words,
like silver refined in a clay furnace,
purified seven times.
7 You will keep them, LORD.
You will protect them from this generation forever.
8 The wicked walk around freely on every side,
when what is shameful is praised among people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In verse 5, God himself speaks. He has heard the groaning of the poor, and he gets up to help them.

Verse 6: People's words are full of lies. But God's words are pure like silver that has been melted and purified seven times. Seven is the number of perfection. You can fully rely on God's word.

Verse 8: An honest ending: The wicked are still everywhere. When what is shameful is celebrated, they have an easy time. But God's promise in verse 5 still stands.

PSALMS

PSALM 13

How much longer, LORD?

How long? VERSES 1–2

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
How long, LORD? Will you forget me forever?
How long will you hide your face from me?
2 How long must I struggle with my thoughts,
with sorrow in my heart every day?
How long will my enemy win over me?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Four times: "How long?" The person praying feels that God has forgotten him. It has been like this for so long.

Psalm 13 is short, but it is a pattern for many psalms of complaint: complaint – request – trust.

It shows three sides of the trouble: God seems far away (verse 1). I myself am full of worry (the first half of verse 2). And others win over me (the second half of verse 2).

Look and answer me VERSES 3–4

3 Look at me and answer me, LORD, my God.
Give light to my eyes,
so that I do not fall asleep in death,
4 so that my enemy does not say, "I have beaten him,"
so that my enemies do not rejoice when I fall.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The complaint turns into a request. "Give light to my eyes": When someone is very sick or exhausted, the eyes grow dull. The person praying asks for new strength to live.

If you feel as if God has forgotten you, and you see no way out: Get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

But I trust VERSES 5–6

5 But I trust in your loving kindness.
My heart is full of joy because you save me.
6 I will sing to the LORD,
because he has been good to me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"But I": In the middle of the trouble, the person praying decides to trust God.

He is already glad about the rescue, even though it has not come yet.

Verse 6: He remembers: God has been good to me before. That gives hope for the future.

PSALMS

Psalm 14

The fool says: There is no God

No one does good VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. By David.
The fool has said in his heart, "There is no God."
They are rotten. They have done disgusting things.
There is no one who does good.
2 The LORD looked down from heaven on all people,
to see if there was anyone who understood,
anyone who looked for God.
3 They have all turned away.
All of them together have become rotten.
There is no one who does good, no, not one.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, "the fool" is not simply a person who is not smart. It is someone who lives as if there is no God. He does not necessarily think about it like a philosopher. He simply lives as if he did not have to answer to anyone.

God looks down from heaven to see if he can find anyone who looks for him. And he finds no one.

Paul quotes verses 1–3 in Romans 3:10–12: "There is no one righteous; no, not one." With this, he shows that all people need God's grace.

Psalm 14 appears again, almost exactly the same, as Psalm 53.

God is with the righteous VERSES 4–7

4 Do all who do evil have no understanding?
They eat up my people the way people eat bread,
and they do not call on the LORD.
5 There they were, full of terror,
for God is with the generation of the righteous.
6 You ruin the plans of the poor,
because the LORD is his refuge.
7 Oh, that the salvation of Israel would come out of Zion!
When the LORD turns things around for his people,
then Jacob will be full of joy, and Israel will be glad.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: The wicked "eat up" God's people as easily as people eat bread. They take advantage of the weak without thinking.

But then they become afraid, because God is on the side of the righteous and the poor.

Verse 6: The powerful can ruin the plans of the poor, but God is their refuge.

Verse 7: A deep longing: May God come and rescue his people. "Jacob" and "Israel" are two names for the same people.

PSALMS

Psalm 15

Who may live with God?

The question VERSE 1

1 A psalm by David.
LORD, who may live in your sanctuary?
Who may live on your holy hill?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

People who came to the temple on Mount Zion may have asked this at the entrance: Who may go in here? Who may be close to God?

The answer in the following verses is surprising: It is not about sacrifices or rituals. It is about how we treat other people.

The answer VERSES 2–5

2 The one who lives without blame and does what is right,
and who speaks the truth in his heart.
3 The one who does not tell lies about others with his tongue,
who does not do evil to his friend,
and who does not insult his neighbor.
4 The one who looks down on a wicked person,
but who honors those who fear the LORD.
The one who keeps his promise even when it hurts him,
and does not change it.
5 The one who does not lend his money to make a profit from others,
and does not take a bribe against an innocent person.
Whoever does these things will never be shaken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm names about 10 qualities, like the Ten Commandments:
– to live honestly and do what is right,
– to tell the truth, also in your heart,
– not to speak badly about others,
– not to do evil to friends,
– not to admire evil, but to honor those who honor God,
– to keep promises, even when it costs you something,
– not to charge high interest (people in Israel were supposed to help each other in need without charging interest, compare Exodus 22:25),
– not to take bribes.

"Speaks the truth in his heart": Honesty begins on the inside, not only with words.

The ending is a promise: Whoever lives like this stands firm.

PSALMS

PSALM 16

You show me the path to life

You are my Lord VERSES 1–4

1 A poem by David.
Keep me safe, God, for I take refuge in you.
2 My soul, you have said to the LORD,
"You are my Lord.
Apart from you, I have nothing good."
3 As for God's holy people who are on the earth,
they are the wonderful ones. All my joy is in them.
4 Those who bring gifts to another god will have more and more pain.
I will not pour out their drink offerings of blood.
I will not even speak their names.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Poem": In Hebrew, it says "Miktam." No one knows exactly what it means. Some think of "golden song" or "inscription."

Verse 2 is a strong confession: God is the greatest good. Without him, everything else is worth nothing.

Verse 3: The person praying is glad to be together with other people who love God.

Verse 4: He wants nothing to do with foreign gods. He will not even say their names.

My good inheritance VERSES 5–8

5 The LORD has given me my share and my cup.
You have made what I received secure.
6 The measuring lines have marked out pleasant places for me.
Yes, I have a good inheritance.
7 I will praise the LORD, who has given me advice.
Yes, my heart teaches me in the night.
8 I have always kept the LORD in front of me.
Because he is at my right side, nothing will shake me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When Israel came into the land, the land was divided with measuring lines and by drawing lots. Only the priests and Levites received no land. God himself was their inheritance (Numbers 18:20).

The person praying says: God is my share. That is the best inheritance there is.

Verse 8: "I have always kept the LORD in front of me." Whoever thinks of God finds a firm hold. God is at my right side, like a protector.

You will not leave me in death VERSES 9–11

9 That is why my heart is glad, and my tongue rejoices.
My body will also live in safety.
10 For you will not leave my soul in Sheol (the world of the dead).
You will not let your holy one see decay.
11 You will show me the path of life.
When I am with you, my joy is full.
At your right hand there is delight forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here we hear a great trust that reaches beyond death: God will not leave me in the place of the dead. Being close to God is stronger than death.

Verse 11 is one of the most beautiful verses in the Bible: With God, "my joy is full," and there is "delight forever."

In the New Testament, verses 8–11 are related to the resurrection of Jesus. Peter quotes them in his sermon at Pentecost (Acts 2:25–31). Paul quotes them in Acts 13:35. They say: David died, and his body decayed. But Jesus rose from the dead. He is "your holy one," who did not see decay.

Jewish teachers understand the psalm as an expression of trust that God protects the faithful person from death and gives him life.

PSALMS

Psalm 17

Protect me like the apple of your eye

Hear my just request VERSES 1–5

1 A prayer by David.
Hear, LORD, my just request.
Listen to my prayer. It does not come from lying lips.
2 Let my verdict come from you.
Let your eyes see what is fair.
3 You have tested my heart.
You have visited me in the night.
You have examined me and found nothing.
I have decided that my mouth will not disobey.
4 As for what people do:
because of the word of your lips,
I have kept myself away from the ways of violent people.
5 My steps have stayed on your paths.
My feet have not slipped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is being accused unfairly. He asks God to decide as judge.

He is sure: God has tested me, even at night, when people are completely honest with themselves. And God has found nothing evil.

This is not pride. David does not say that he has never sinned. He says: In this matter, I am innocent.

Verse 4: God's word has kept him from using violence.

In the shadow of your wings VERSES 6–12

6 I have called to you, for you will answer me, God.
Turn your ear to me. Hear what I say.
7 Show your wonderful loving kindness,
you who save those who take refuge at your right hand from their enemies.
8 Protect me like the apple of your eye.
Hide me in the shadow of your wings,
9 away from the wicked who oppress me,
from my deadly enemies who surround me.
10 They close their hard hearts.
With their mouths they speak proudly.
11 Now they have surrounded us wherever we step.
They are watching for a chance to throw us to the ground.
12 He is like a lion that is hungry for its prey,
like a young lion lying in wait in its hiding place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8 has two beautiful pictures:

– "The apple of your eye": This means the pupil of the eye. It is the most sensitive part of the body. People protect it at once with the eyelid. That is how God protects those he loves (compare Deuteronomy 32:10).

– "The shadow of your wings": As a bird takes its chicks under its wings, God protects (compare Ruth 2:12; Matthew 23:37).

"Hard hearts": Word for word, it says "fat." Their heart is closed up as if by fat. They feel no pity.

I will see your face VERSES 13–15

13 Get up, LORD, face him! Throw him down!
Rescue my soul from the wicked with your sword,
14 from people, by your hand, LORD,
from people of this world, whose share is in this life.
You fill the stomachs of those you love.
Your sons have plenty,
and they save up riches for their children.
15 But as for me, I will see your face in righteousness.
When I wake up, I will be satisfied with seeing what you look like.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14 is hard to understand in Hebrew. It can be explained in different ways. The WEB, our English source text, understands it like this: God provides richly for those he loves. Others translate: God fills the stomachs of the wicked with punishment.

"People of this world, whose share is in this life": people for whom only the here and now counts.

Verse 15 is the high point: The person praying does not only want a full stomach. He wants to see God. That is what truly satisfies him.

"When I wake up": Perhaps the next morning. Many teachers, Jewish and Christian, also see a hope beyond death here: waking up to eternal life with God.

PSALMS

Psalm 18

David's song of thanks for being rescued

I love you, LORD VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. By David, the servant of the LORD.
He spoke the words of this song to the LORD on the day when the LORD rescued him from the power of all his enemies and from the power of Saul.
He said:
I love you, LORD, my strength.
2 The LORD is my rock, my fortress and my rescuer.
My God is my rock. I take refuge in him.
He is my shield and the horn of my salvation. He is my high tower.

3 I call to the LORD, who deserves to be praised,
and I am saved from my enemies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 18 is one of the longest songs of thanks. It also appears, almost word for word, in 2 Samuel 22. David sang it at the end of his life, when he looked back on all the times he had been rescued.

It begins with a confession of love: "I love you, LORD." The Hebrew word is very deep and tender. It is used only here with God as the one who is loved.

Then come many pictures for God: rock, fortress, shield, high tower. All of them are pictures of protection and safety.

"Horn" is a picture of strength, like the horns of a bull.

In my trouble I called VERSES 4–6

4 The ropes of death wrapped around me.
Floods of wickedness frightened me.
5 The ropes of Sheol (the world of the dead) were all around me.
The traps of death came upon me.
6 In my trouble I called on the LORD.
I cried out to my God.
He heard my voice from his temple.
My cry to him reached his ears.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David describes deadly danger: as if he were caught in ropes, as if floods were washing over him.

But he called to God, and God heard him. From his "temple" in heaven, God heard the cry of one single person.

God comes to the rescue VERSES 7–15

7 Then the earth shook and trembled.
The foundations of the mountains also shook and moved,
because he was angry.
8 Smoke came out of his nostrils.
A fire that burns everything up came out of his mouth.
It set coals on fire.
9 He also bent the heavens down and came down.
Thick darkness was under his feet.
10 He rode on a cherub and flew.
Yes, he soared on the wings of the wind.
11 He made darkness his hiding place,
his tent all around him:
dark waters, thick clouds in the sky.
12 Out of the brightness in front of him, his thick clouds passed by,
with hailstones and burning coals.
13 The LORD also thundered in the sky.
The Most High let his voice be heard:
hailstones and burning coals.
14 He shot his arrows and scattered them.
He drove them away with great flashes of lightning.
15 Then the beds of the waters could be seen.
The foundations of the world were uncovered
when you scolded them, LORD,
at the blast of the breath from your nostrils.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now David describes how God comes to help him, in powerful poetic pictures: earthquake, fire, thunderstorm, hail, lightning.

This is a "theophany": a description of how God appears. It reminds us of how God appeared on Mount Sinai (Exodus 19:16–18) and of the crossing through the Red Sea (verse 15).

"Cherub": a heavenly being. In the Bible, cherubim often carry God's throne (compare Ezekiel 1 and 10).

David wants to say: When God rescued me, it was as if all of heaven stepped in. That is how great God's help was.

He pulled me out of deep waters VERSES 16–19

16 He reached down from on high. He took hold of me.
He pulled me out of many waters.
17 He rescued me from my strong enemy,
from those who hated me,
for they were too strong for me.
18 They attacked me on the day of my disaster,
but the LORD held me up.
19 He also brought me out into a wide-open place.
He rescued me, because he took delight in me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After all the thunder comes something very personal: God reaches down and pulls David out of the water, the way someone saves a person who is drowning.

"He brought me out into a wide-open place": out of the tight spot of trouble into freedom.

Verse 19: The reason for the rescue: "He took delight in me." God loves David.

God has rewarded me VERSES 20–24

20 The LORD has rewarded me because I did what is right.
Because my hands are clean, he has paid me back.
21 For I have kept the ways of the LORD.
I have not done evil by turning away from my God.
22 For all his rules were in front of me.
I did not push his laws away from me.
23 I was also without blame before him.
I kept myself from my sin.
24 That is why the LORD has rewarded me because I did what is right,
because my hands were clean in his eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At first this sounds strange: David committed adultery with Bathsheba and had Uriah killed (2 Samuel 11). Does he call himself "without blame"?

It probably means: In his struggle against Saul and his enemies, David kept to what was right. He did not kill Saul, even though he could have done it (1 Samuel 24 and 26).

Also: In the Bible, "without blame" does not mean "without sin." It means "on God's side with your whole heart." David confessed his guilt and received forgiveness (Psalm 51).

With the faithful you are faithful VERSES 25–30

25 With those who show mercy, you show yourself merciful.
With the person who is blameless, you show yourself blameless.

26 With the pure, you show yourself pure.
With the crooked, you show yourself clever.
27 For you save people who are suffering,
but you bring down proud eyes.
28 For you light my lamp, LORD.
My God lights up my darkness.
29 For with you I can charge against a troop of soldiers.
With my God I can leap over a wall.
30 As for God, his way is perfect.
The LORD's word has been tested.
He is a shield to all who take refuge in him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 25–26: God meets each person the way that person is. Whoever shows mercy experiences God's mercy. Whoever cheats others finds out that God is cleverer (compare Matthew 5:7).

Verse 28: "My God lights up my darkness": a sentence that people hold on to in dark times.

Verse 29: With God's help, the impossible becomes possible, even leaping over walls.

Verse 30: God's word is like metal that has been tested: genuine and reliable.

God gives me strength VERSES 31–36

31 For who is God, except the LORD?
Who is a rock, except our God?
32 He is the God who gives me strength like armor
and makes my way perfect.
33 He makes my feet like the feet of a deer.
He sets me on my high places.
34 He trains my hands for battle,
so that my arms can bend a bow of bronze.
35 You have also given me the shield of your salvation.
Your right hand holds me up.
Your gentleness has made me great.
36 You have given me plenty of room for my steps.
My feet have not slipped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: There is no other God, no other firm rock.

Verse 33: Deer and mountain goats climb safely over steep rocks. That is how safely God lets David walk.

Verse 35: "Your gentleness has made me great": a beautiful sentence. It was not God's power alone that made David great, but God's kindness and care. Others translate it as "your humility" or "your help."

Victory over the enemies VERSES 37–45

37 I will chase my enemies and catch up with them.
I will not turn back until they are destroyed.
38 I will strike them down, so that they cannot get up.
They will fall under my feet.
39 For you have given me strength for the battle.
You have made those who rose up against me bow down under me.
40 You have also made my enemies turn their backs to me,
so that I could destroy those who hate me.
41 They cried for help, but there was no one to save them.
They even cried to the LORD, but he did not answer them.
42 Then I ground them as fine as dust in the wind.
I threw them out like mud in the streets.
43 You have rescued me from the fights of the people.
You have made me the head of the nations.
A people I did not know will serve me.
44 As soon as they hear of me, they will obey me.
Foreigners will bow down to me.
45 Foreigners will lose heart.
They will come trembling out of their strongholds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here David describes his wars and victories. This is the language of a king at a time when wars were common.

For readers today, this is hard. It helps to know: David fought against enemies who attacked Israel and wanted to destroy it. The psalm celebrates God's rescue, not violence itself.

These verses are not a command for wars or violence today. Jesus teaches: "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44). Christians often read these verses as a picture of the fight against evil.

The LORD lives! VERSES 46–50

46 The LORD lives! Praise be to my rock!
May the God who saves me be honored above all.
47 He is the God who pays back my enemies for me,
and who makes peoples bow down under me.
48 He rescues me from my enemies.
Yes, you lift me up above those who rise up against me.
You rescue me from the violent man.
49 That is why I will thank you, LORD, among the nations.
I will sing praises to your name.
50 He gives his king great victories.
He shows loving kindness to his anointed one,
to David and to his descendants forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The LORD lives!": a shout of joy. God is not a dead idol. He is alive and acts.

Verse 47: David does not take revenge himself. God makes sure he receives justice.

Verse 49: David wants to praise God "among the nations." Paul quotes this in Romans 15:9: The nations should praise God, too.

Verse 50: God's faithfulness is not only for David, but for his descendants "forever." This is the promise to the family of David (2 Samuel 7). Jews are waiting for the Messiah from David's family. Christians believe that Jesus, the descendant of David, fulfills this promise.

PSALMS

Psalm 19

The heavens tell of God's glory

The language of creation VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
The heavens tell of the glory of God.
The sky shows the work of his hands.
2 Day after day, they pour out speech.
Night after night, they show knowledge.
3 There is no speech and no language
where their voice is not heard.
4 Their voice has gone out through all the earth,
their words to the end of the world.
In the heavens, God has set up a tent for the sun.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 19 is one of the most beautiful psalms. It has two parts: God speaks through creation (verses 1–6) and through his word (verses 7–14).

The sky is like a preacher without words. Every day and every night, it tells of God's greatness.

Verse 3 can be read in two ways: In every language of the world, people understand this message. Or: It is a speech without words, and yet it is heard everywhere.

Verse 4: Paul quotes this verse in Romans 10:18.

The sun VERSES 5–6

5 The sun is like a bridegroom coming out of his room.
It is like a strong man who is happy to run his race.
6 It rises at one end of the heavens
and travels around to the other end.
Nothing is hidden from its heat.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many peoples back then worshiped the sun as a goddess. The psalm says: The sun is something God created. God has built a "tent" for it.

The sun rises every morning like a shining bridegroom on his wedding day, or like a runner who starts his race full of joy.

Verse 6: Nothing is hidden from the sun. This leads into the second part: Nothing stays hidden from God's word either.

God's teaching is perfect VERSES 7–11

7 The LORD's law is perfect.
It gives new life to the soul.
The LORD's covenant can be trusted.
It makes simple people wise.
8 The LORD's instructions are right.
They make the heart glad.
The LORD's command is pure.
It gives light to the eyes.
9 The fear of the LORD is clean.
It lasts forever.
The LORD's rulings are true.
All of them are right.
10 They are worth more than gold,
yes, more than much pure gold.
They are sweeter than honey,
sweeter than honey dripping from the honeycomb.
11 Also, your servant is warned by them.
Whoever keeps them receives a great reward.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the psalm changes from "God" to "the LORD," from creation to God's word. Through creation, people can see that God exists. Through his word, people learn who he is and how they can live with him.

Six names for God's word: law, covenant (word for word, "testimony"), instructions, command, fear, rulings. And each time, the psalm says what it does: It gives new life, makes wise, makes glad, gives light.

God's commandments are not a burden but a gift: worth more than gold, sweeter than honey.

Forgive me my hidden faults VERSES 12–14

12 Who can see all his own mistakes?
Forgive me for the faults that are hidden from me.
13 Also keep your servant from sins that are done on purpose.
Do not let them rule over me.
Then I will be honest.
I will be without blame and free from great wrongdoing.
14 Let the words of my mouth and the thoughts of my heart
be pleasing to you, LORD, my rock and my redeemer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever reads God's word notices: I have faults that I do not even see myself. That is why the person praying asks for forgiveness also for the "hidden" faults.

"Sins that are done on purpose": sins that people commit knowingly and intentionally. The person praying asks God to keep him from them.

Verse 14 is a well-known prayer. Many preachers say it before the sermon, and Jews pray it at the end of their main prayer: "Let the words of my mouth and the thoughts of my heart be pleasing to you."

"My redeemer": In Hebrew, "Goel," as in Job (Job 19:25). God is the one who buys me free and stands up for me.

PSALMS

PSALM 20

A blessing for the king

May the LORD answer you VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
May the LORD answer you on the day of trouble.
May the name of the God of Jacob keep you safe up high.
2 May he send you help from the sanctuary.
May he give you support from Zion.
3 May he remember all your offerings
and accept your burnt offering.
Selah.

4 May he give you what your heart desires.
May he make all your plans come true.
5 We will shout for joy when you win the victory.
In the name of our God we will raise our flags.
May the LORD give you everything you ask for.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 20 is a prayer of blessing for the king before he goes into a hard battle. The people pray for him in the temple.

"The name of God": God's name stands for who God is and for his presence. Whoever calls on God's name calls on God himself.

Today, too, many people pray this psalm for others, for example before an operation, an exam or a hard road ahead.

Some trust in chariots VERSES 6–9

6 Now I know that the LORD saves his anointed one.
He will answer him from his holy heaven
with the saving strength of his right hand.
7 Some trust in chariots, and some in horses,
but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.
8 They have bowed down and fallen,
but we rise up and stand tall.
9 Save us, LORD!
Let the King answer us when we call!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Suddenly one single person speaks, perhaps a priest or a prophet: "Now I know." He is sure that God will help.

Verse 7 is famous: Chariots and horses were the strongest weapons back then, like tanks today. But Israel does not trust in weapons. It trusts in God.

Verse 9: "The King" can be the human king, or God himself, the true King. Some translations read: LORD, save the king! Answer us when we call!

PSALMS

PSALM 21

Thanks for the king's victory

The king rejoices VERSES 1–7

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
The king rejoices in your strength, LORD!
How greatly he rejoices that you save him!
2 You have given him what his heart desires.
You have not refused what his lips asked for.
Selah.
3 For you come to meet him with rich blessings.
You put a crown of pure gold on his head.
4 He asked you for life, and you gave it to him,
a long life, forever and ever.
5 He has great glory because you saved him.
You give him honor and majesty.
6 For you make him blessed forever.
You fill him with joy in your presence.
7 For the king trusts in the LORD.
Because of the loving kindness of the Most High,
nothing will shake him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 21 belongs together with Psalm 20. In Psalm 20, the people prayed for the king. In Psalm 21, they give thanks, because God has answered the prayer.

Verse 2: "You have given him what his heart desires." This is the direct answer to Psalm 20:4. There it said: "May he give you what your heart desires."

Verse 7 is the center of the psalm: The king is strong because he trusts in God, not in himself.

Jews have also related the psalm to the Messiah, and Christians to Jesus, the King who has life "forever and ever."

God's power against the enemies VERSES 8–13

8 Your hand will find all your enemies.
Your right hand will find those who hate you.
9 When the time of your anger comes, you will make
them like a blazing furnace.
The LORD will swallow them up in his fury.
The fire will burn them up.
10 You will wipe out their descendants from the earth,
their children from among the people.
11 For they planned evil against you.
They came up with an evil plan against you, but it
cannot succeed.
12 For you will make them turn their backs and run,
when you aim your bows at their faces.
13 Be honored above all, LORD, in your strength.
Then we will sing and praise your power.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the psalm is about the enemies who plan evil against God and the king.

The pictures are very harsh: fire, destruction, even the descendants. This is the language of war in the ancient Near East.

Important: The king and the people are not the ones who take revenge here. The judgment is left to God. And it falls on those who "planned evil against you," that is, against God.

For readers today: These verses do not give anyone permission to persecute enemies or their children. Children are not responsible for what their parents did (Ezekiel 18:20). Jesus teaches us to love our enemies.

The psalm does not end with the enemies, but with the praise of God.

PSALMS

PSALM 22

My God, why have you abandoned me?

Why have you abandoned me? VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. To the tune of "The Doe of the
Morning." A psalm by David.
My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?
Why are you so far from helping me,
so far from the words of my groaning?
2 My God, I cry out during the day, but you do not
answer.
I cry out at night, and I do not keep silent.
3 But you are holy.
You are enthroned on the praises of Israel.
4 Our ancestors trusted in you.
They trusted, and you rescued them.
5 They cried out to you, and they were rescued.
They trusted in you, and they were not disappointed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 22 is one of the most important psalms in the whole Bible. It begins with the most desperate cry there is: "My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?"

Jesus prayed this sentence on the cross, in Aramaic: "Eli, Eli, lima sabachthani?" (Matthew 27:46; Mark 15:34).

The person praying feels completely abandoned by God. But he still speaks to God: "My God." He holds on to God, even when he cannot feel him.

Verse 2: "I do not keep silent": I do not stop calling out, day and night. Some Bibles translate: and I find no rest.

Verses 4–5: He remembers: In the past, God helped our ancestors. Why not me?

I am a worm VERSES 6–11

6 But I am a worm, and not a man.
People insult me, and the people look down on me.
7 Everyone who sees me makes fun of me.
They insult me with their lips.
They shake their heads and say,
8 "He trusts in the LORD. Let the LORD rescue him.
Let the LORD save him, since he takes delight in him."
9 But you brought me out of my mother's womb.
You made me trust you while I was still nursing at my
mother's breasts.
10 I was placed in your care from the time I was born.
You have been my God since my mother gave birth to
me.
11 Do not be far from me, for trouble is near,
and there is no one to help.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying feels worthless, "a worm" that gets stepped on. People make fun of him and his faith.

Verses 7–8: The Gospels report that people under the cross mocked Jesus in exactly this way: "He trusts in God. Let God rescue him now" (Matthew 27:39–43).

Verses 9–10: Again the person praying holds on to God: You have known me since I was born. You have always been my God.

Surrounded VERSES 12–18

12 Many bulls have surrounded me.
Strong bulls of Bashan have closed in around me.
13 They open their mouths wide against me,
like lions that roar and tear their prey.
14 I am poured out like water.
All my bones are out of joint.
My heart is like wax.
It has melted inside me.
15 My strength is dried up like a broken piece of clay pot.
My tongue sticks to the roof of my mouth.
You have brought me into the dust of death.
16 For dogs have surrounded me.
A gang of evil people has closed in on me.
They have pierced my hands and feet.
17 I can count all my bones.
They look at me and stare.
18 They divide my clothes among themselves.
They cast lots for my clothing.
That means: They let chance decide who gets it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The enemies are compared with wild animals: bulls, lions, dogs. Bashan was a region with especially strong, well-fed cattle.

The person praying describes terrible pain in his body: bones out of joint, thirst, weakness, being close to death.

Verse 16: "They have pierced my hands and feet." This is what the WEB, our English source text, says, and the old Greek translation. In today's Hebrew text, there is a word that can also be read as: like a lion (they are at) my hands and feet. Jewish translations mostly follow this reading. Among the Dead Sea Scrolls, there is one manuscript that seems to read a verb here.

Verse 18: The Gospels report that the soldiers under the cross divided up Jesus' clothes and cast lots for his tunic (John 19:23–24).

That is why, for Christians, Psalm 22 is an amazing look ahead to the suffering of Jesus. For Jews, it is the prayer of a righteous person who suffers, and even of the whole suffering people of Israel. Both readings take the pain of the person praying seriously.

Hurry to help me! VERSES 19–21

19 But you, LORD, do not be far away.
You are my help. Hurry to help me!
20 Rescue my soul from the sword,
my precious life from the power of the dog.
21 Save me from the lion's mouth!
Yes, you have rescued me from the horns of the wild
oxen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One last, urgent cry for help.

And then, at the end of verse 21, quite suddenly: "You have rescued me." In Hebrew, this is only one single word. It means: You have answered me! This is the turning point of the whole psalm.

Praise in the great assembly VERSES 22–26

22 I will tell my brothers about your name.
In the middle of the assembly I will praise you.
23 You who fear the LORD, praise him!
All you descendants of Jacob, give him glory!
Stand in awe of him, all you descendants of Israel!

24 For he has not looked down on the suffering of the one who suffers.
He has not turned away from it in disgust.
He has not hidden his face from him.
When he cried out to him, he heard.
25 My praise of you comes in the great assembly.
I will keep my promises in front of those who fear him.
26 The humble will eat and be satisfied.
Those who look for the LORD will praise him.
May your hearts live forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now everything is different. The complaint turns into praise. The person who felt abandoned now tells everyone: God has heard me!

Verse 24 is the answer to verse 1: God has not hidden his face. He has heard.

In the New Testament, verse 22 is related to Jesus, who calls people his "brothers" (Hebrews 2:11–12).

Verse 26: When someone brought a thank offering, there was a feast. The poor were invited and could eat until they were full.

All nations will worship the LORD VERSES 27–31

27 All the ends of the earth will remember and turn to the LORD.
All the families of the nations will worship before you.
28 For the kingdom belongs to the LORD.
He is the ruler over the nations.
29 All the rich people of the earth will eat and worship.
All who go down to the dust will bow down before him,
even the one who cannot keep himself alive.
30 Their descendants will serve him.
Future generations will be told about the Lord.
31 They will come and tell about his righteousness
to a people that is not yet born,
for he has done it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The praise grows bigger and bigger: first the brothers, then all of Israel, then all the nations of the earth, then even the dead and those who are not yet born.

The rescue of one single person becomes a message for the whole world.

The last sentence: "He has done it." Some teachers connect this with Jesus' last words on the cross: "It is finished" (John 19:30).

Psalm 22 shows: You may ask God, "Why have you abandoned me?" And the way can lead from the deepest loneliness to praise.

If you feel abandoned by God and by everyone right now: Talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

PSALMS

PSALM 23

The LORD is my shepherd

The good shepherd VERSES 1–3

1 A psalm by David.
The LORD is my shepherd.
I will not lack anything.
2 He lets me lie down in green pastures.
He leads me beside still waters.
3 He restores my soul.
He guides me on paths of righteousness.
That means: on paths that are right.
He does this for the sake of his name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 23 is the best-known psalm in the Bible. Many people know it by heart. It is prayed at baptisms, weddings and funerals.

David was a shepherd himself before he became king (1 Samuel 16:11). He knew what a good shepherd does for his sheep.

A shepherd takes care of everything: He finds fresh grass and calm water that the sheep can drink from. He leads them on safe paths.

"I will not lack anything": This does not mean that I get everything I want. It means that I have everything I really need.

"He restores my soul": He gives me new strength and new courage.

"For the sake of his name": God leads me well because he is faithful. His good name depends on it.

Later, Jesus says that he is the good shepherd, and that the good shepherd gives his life for the sheep (John 10:11).

In the dark valley VERSE 4

4 Even when I walk through the valley of the shadow of death,
I will fear no evil, for you are with me.
Your rod and your staff comfort me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Life is not only green pastures. There are also dark valleys: sickness, grief, fear, being close to death.

But the shepherd goes along. That is why: "I will fear no evil, for you are with me."

Worth noticing: Until now, David has spoken about God ("he"). Now, in the dark valley, he speaks directly to God: "You are with me." In times of need, the relationship becomes personal.

The rod was a club to fight off wild animals. The staff was a long shepherd's staff to guide the sheep and bring them back. Both show: The shepherd protects and leads.

The table that is set VERSES 5–6

5 You prepare a table for me in front of my enemies.
You anoint my head with oil.

That means: You pour oil on my head.
My cup overflows.
6 Surely goodness and loving kindness will follow me all the days of my life.
And I will live in the LORD's house forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the picture changes: God is no longer only the shepherd. He is also a generous host.

"In front of my enemies": The enemies are still there, but they cannot do anything. I am God's guest, and I am safe.

"You anoint my head with oil": This is how people honored a guest back then. The oil smelled good and refreshed the guest.

"My cup overflows": God gives more than enough.

Verse 6: "Goodness and loving kindness will follow me": In Hebrew, it says more exactly: "they will chase after me." It is not my enemies who chase me, but God's goodness.

"I will live in the LORD's house forever": For David, this was the temple. Christians and many Jews also understand it as hope for a life with God beyond death.

PSALMS

PSALM 24

The King of glory comes in

The earth belongs to the LORD VERSES 1–2

1 A psalm by David.
The earth belongs to the LORD, and everything in it,
the world and all who live in it.
2 For he has built it on the seas
and made it stand firm on the floods.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Everything belongs to God: the earth, everything on it, and all people. We are not the owners of the world. We are guests and caretakers.

Back then, people imagined that the earth was built as if on water. God has set it on a firm foundation. The chaos of the water cannot wash it away.

Paul quotes verse 1 in 1 Corinthians 10:26.

Who may go up God's hill? VERSES 3–6

3 Who may go up the LORD's hill?
Who may stand in his holy place?
4 The one who has clean hands and a pure heart,
who has not set his heart on lies,
and has not sworn falsely.
5 He will receive a blessing from the LORD,
and righteousness from the God who saves him.
6 This is the generation of those who look for him,
who look for your face—Jacob.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The same question as in Psalm 15: Who may come close to God?

The answer: "Clean hands" (good deeds) and "a pure heart" (good intentions). The outside and the inside belong together.

Verse 6: In Hebrew, the end is hard to understand. Some Bibles add the word "God" here. Then it means: They look for your face, God of Jacob.

Jesus says: "Blessed are those whose hearts are pure, for they will see God" (Matthew 5:8).

Open the gates wide! VERSES 7–10

7 Lift up your heads, you gates!
Be lifted up, you ancient doors,
and the King of glory will come in!
8 Who is the King of glory?
The LORD, strong and mighty,
the LORD, mighty in battle.
9 Lift up your heads, you gates!
Yes, lift them up, you ancient doors,
and the King of glory will come in!
10 Who is this King of glory?
The LORD of Armies is the King of glory!
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here we hear a festive procession to the temple. Perhaps the psalm was sung when the ark of the covenant was brought to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6).

A choir calls out to the gates: Open up! Lift yourselves up! The gatekeepers ask in return: Who is this King? And the choir answers: The LORD!

The gates are so small for such a great King that they should "lift up their heads," which means they should become bigger.

"The LORD of Armies": God is the Lord over all powers in heaven and on earth, over angels and stars.

The well-known Advent hymn "Lift Up Your Heads, Ye Mighty Gates" was inspired by this psalm. It comes from Germany. Christians sing it in the time before Christmas, when they look forward to the coming of Jesus.

PSALMS

PSALM 25

Show me your ways

To you I lift up my soul VERSES 1–3

1 By David.
To you, LORD, I lift up my soul.
2 My God, I have trusted in you.
Do not let me be put to shame.

Do not let my enemies win over me.
3 Yes, no one who waits for you will be put to shame.
Those who are unfaithful for no reason will be put to shame.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Hebrew, Psalm 25 is an alphabet poem: Each verse begins with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet. This made it easier to learn by heart.

"I lift up my soul to you": I turn my whole self toward you, the way people lift up their hands to pray.

"Be put to shame": to stand there embarrassed and disappointed. Whoever waits for God will not be disappointed.

Teach me VERSES 4–7

4 Show me your ways, LORD.
Teach me your paths.
5 Guide me in your truth, and teach me,
for you are the God who saves me.
I wait for you all day long.
6 LORD, remember your tender mercy and your loving kindness,
for they have been there since ancient times.
7 Do not remember the sins of my youth or the wrong things I have done.
Remember me in your loving kindness,
because you are good, LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying wants to learn from God how to live the right way.

Verses 6–7 are a beautiful play on words: God should "remember" his loving kindness, but "not remember" my sins. God's memory should be full of love, not full of blame.

"The sins of my youth": mistakes that someone made as a young person, which still weigh on them later.

The LORD is good VERSES 8–11

8 The LORD is good and honest.
That is why he shows sinners the way.
9 He guides the humble in what is right.
He teaches the humble his way.
10 All the paths of the LORD are loving kindness and truth
for those who keep his covenant and his commands.
11 For the sake of your name, LORD,
forgive my guilt, for it is great.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Because God is good, he does not give up on sinners. He shows them the way back.

God teaches "the humble," who admit that they do not know everything.

Verse 11: The person praying asks for forgiveness. This is not because he has earned it. It is "for the sake of your name": because God is merciful.

The friendship of the LORD VERSES 12–15

12 Who is the person who fears the LORD?
The LORD will teach him the way he should choose.
13 He will live a good and peaceful life.
His descendants will inherit the land.
14 The friendship of the LORD is with those who fear him.
He will show them his covenant.
15 My eyes are always on the LORD,
for he will pull my feet out of the net.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14 is beautiful: God is a friend to those who honor him. The Hebrew word means a close, trusted circle in which people share secrets.

Jesus says: "I don't call you servants anymore. ... But I have called you friends" (John 15:15).

Verse 15: Like an animal caught in a net, the person praying needs God's help to get free.

Turn to me VERSES 16–22

16 Turn to me, and be kind to me,
for I am lonely and suffering.
17 The troubles of my heart have grown great.
Oh, bring me out of my distress.
18 Look at how I suffer and how hard things are for me.
Forgive all my sins.
19 Look at my enemies, for there are many of them.
They hate me with a cruel hatred.
20 Oh, guard my soul and rescue me.
Do not let me be disappointed, for I take refuge in you.
21 Let honesty and doing what is right protect me,
for I wait for you.
22 God, set Israel free from all its troubles.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Lonely and suffering": The person praying feels left alone. He asks God to turn toward him.

He brings everything to God: his fears, his struggles, his sins, his enemies.

Verse 22: At the end, the prayer widens to the whole people. This verse stands outside the alphabet, like an afterword. The individual does not pray only for himself, but for everyone.

PSALMS

PSALM 26

I go my way with integrity

Test me, LORD VERSES 1–5

1 By David.
Judge me, LORD, for I have lived with integrity.
That means: I have lived honestly, with my whole heart.
I have also trusted in the LORD without doubting.
2 Examine me, LORD, and test me.
Look closely at my heart and my mind.

3 For your loving kindness is in front of my eyes.
I have lived by your truth.
4 I have not sat with liars,
and I will not go along with hypocrites.
5 I hate the gathering of evil people.
I will not sit with the wicked.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying is being accused unfairly. He asks God to test him. He has nothing to hide.

This is not pride. He does not say: I am without sin. He says: I have honestly tried to live with you.

Verses 4–5 remind us of Psalm 1: He does not sit with those who plan evil.

"I hate the gathering of evil people": He firmly rejects evil. This does not mean hatred of people. It means a clear no to their evil plans.

I wash my hands in innocence VERSES 6–8

6 I will wash my hands in innocence.
Then I will go around your altar, LORD,
7 so that I can let my voice of thanks be heard,
and tell about all the wonderful things you have done.
8 LORD, I love the house where you live,
the place where your glory lives.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Wash my hands in innocence": Before the priests went to the altar, they washed their hands (Exodus 30:19–21). The person praying says: I come with a clean conscience.

We still know the saying "to wash your hands of something" today. Pilate washed his hands when he condemned Jesus (Matthew 27:24). But for him, it was an excuse.

Verse 8: The person praying loves the temple, because God's glory lives there.

Do not sweep me away with the sinners VERSES 9–12

9 Do not sweep my soul away together with sinners,
or my life together with violent men.
10 Their hands are full of evil.
Their right hands are full of bribes.
11 But as for me, I will live with integrity.
Set me free, and be kind to me.
12 My foot stands on level ground.
In the gatherings I will praise the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying asks: Do not let me share the same fate as the violent people and those who take bribes.

Verse 11: Even though he lives honestly, he still asks for mercy. He knows: In the end, I depend on God's mercy.

Verse 12: "Level ground": He stands safe and firm. He will not stumble.

PSALMS

Psalm 27

The LORD is my light

Whom should I fear? VERSES 1–3

1 By David.
The LORD is my light and my salvation.
Whom should I fear?
The LORD is the strength of my life.
Of whom should I be afraid?
2 When evil people came at me to eat up my flesh,
my enemies and my foes,
they stumbled and fell.
3 Even if an army sets up camp against me,
my heart will not be afraid.
Even if war breaks out against me,
even then I will be confident.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 27 begins with great trust: God is my light in the dark, my rescue in danger, the strength of my life.

Whoever has God at his side does not need to be afraid, not even of a whole army.

"To eat up my flesh": The enemies are like wild animals hunting their prey.

I ask for only one thing VERSES 4–6

4 I have asked the LORD for one thing. That is what I will look for:
that I may live in the LORD's house all the days of my life,
to see the LORD's beauty,
and to think and ask in his temple.
5 For on the day of trouble, he will keep me hidden in his shelter.
In the secret place of his tent, he will hide me.
He will lift me up on a rock.
6 Now my head will be lifted up above my enemies all around me.
I will bring sacrifices of joy in his tent.
I will sing, yes, I will sing praises to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4 is the heart of the psalm. The person praying has only one wish: to be with God and see his beauty.

"The LORD's beauty": God is not only mighty and just. He is also beautiful, lovable and kind.

Verse 5: God's house is like a hiding place in danger. Back then, a person who was being hunted could look for protection in the sanctuary.

Do not abandon me VERSES 7–12

7 Hear me, LORD, when I cry out with my voice.
Be kind to me, and answer me.
8 When you said, "Seek my face,"
my heart said to you, "I will seek your face, LORD."
9 Do not hide your face from me.
Do not push your servant away in anger.
You have been my help.

Do not leave me, and do not abandon me,
God who saves me.
10 Even if my father and my mother abandon me,
the LORD will take me in.
11 Teach me your way, LORD.
Lead me on a straight path, because of my enemies.
12 Do not hand me over to what my enemies want,
for false witnesses have risen up against me,
people who breathe out cruelty.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the tone changes. Trust turns into a request. The person praying is afraid that God might turn away.

Verse 8: God himself invites: "Seek my face." The person praying answers: Yes, I want to do that!

Verse 10 is a great comfort: Even if your own parents let you down, God takes you in. For people who have been rejected by their family, this is a very important sentence.

Verse 12: False witnesses speak against him. He needs God's protection in court.

Wait for the LORD VERSES 13–14

13 I am still confident of this:
I will see the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living.
14 Wait for the LORD.
Be strong, and let your heart take courage.
Yes, wait for the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"In the land of the living": The person praying will experience God's goodness not only after death, but here and now.

Verse 14: At the end, the person praying speaks to himself or to others: Wait for God! Be brave!

"Waiting" here does not mean sitting around and doing nothing. It means holding on full of hope and trusting God.

PSALMS

PSALM 28

The LORD is my strength and my shield

Do not be silent, my rock VERSES 1–5

1 By David.
To you, LORD, I call.
My rock, do not close your ears to me.
For if you stay silent toward me,
I will become like those who go down into the pit.
2 Hear my voice when I beg you for help,
when I cry out to you,
when I lift up my hands toward your Most Holy Place.
3 Do not drag me away with the wicked,
with those who do evil.
They speak of peace with their neighbors,
but there is evil in their hearts.
4 Pay them back for what they have done,
for the evil of their deeds.
Pay them back for the work of their hands.
Bring back on them what they deserve.
5 They do not pay attention to the works of the LORD,
or to what his hands have done.
That is why he will tear them down and not build them up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The worst thing for the person praying is when God is silent. Then he feels as if he were already dead ("in the pit").

"Lift up my hands toward your Most Holy Place": This is how people prayed back then, with their hands raised toward the temple.

Verse 3: Hypocrites speak in a friendly way, but they plan evil.

Verse 4 asks for justice: God should give them what their own deeds deserve. The person praying does not take revenge himself.

Praise the LORD VERSES 6–9

6 Praise be to the LORD,
because he has heard my voice when I begged for help.
7 The LORD is my strength and my shield.
My heart trusted in him, and I was helped.
That is why my heart is full of joy.
With my song I will thank him.
8 The LORD is their strength.
He is a fortress that saves his anointed one.
9 Save your people, and bless your inheritance.
Be their shepherd, too, and carry them forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again the sudden turning point: God has heard! The person praying rejoices.

Verse 9 is a beautiful prayer for the whole people: God should be like a shepherd who carries his sheep (compare Psalm 23; Isaiah 40:11).

Christians still pray verse 9 in worship today, for example in the old hymn of praise called the "Te Deum." There they ask the Lord to save his people and bless his inheritance.

PSALMS

PSALM 29

The voice of the LORD in the storm

Give glory to the LORD VERSES 1–2

1 A psalm by David.
Give to the LORD, you sons of the mighty,

give to the LORD glory and strength.
2 Give to the LORD the glory that his name deserves.
Worship the LORD in holy clothing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Sons of the mighty": This probably means heavenly beings, angels. Even they should give glory to God.

"In holy clothing": in festive clothes, like the priests in the temple. Others translate: in the splendor of his holiness.

The voice of the LORD VERSES 3–9

3 The LORD's voice is over the waters.
The God of glory thunders.
The LORD thunders over many waters.
4 The LORD's voice is powerful.
The LORD's voice is full of majesty.
5 The LORD's voice breaks the cedars.
Yes, the LORD smashes the cedars of Lebanon.
6 He makes them jump like a calf,
and Lebanon and Sirion like a young wild ox.
7 The LORD's voice strikes with flashes of lightning.
8 The LORD's voice shakes the wilderness.
The LORD shakes the wilderness of Kadesh.
9 The LORD's voice makes the deer give birth,
and it strips the forests bare.
In his temple, everyone says, "Glory!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Seven times it says: "The LORD's voice." You can hear the thunder rolling.

A thunderstorm moves across the land: from the sea (verse 3), over the mountains of Lebanon in the north (verses 5–6), to the wilderness of Kadesh in the south (verse 8).

"Sirion" is another name for Mount Hermon.

Israel's neighbors believed that the god Baal sent thunder and rain. This psalm says clearly: Not Baal, but the LORD is the Lord over the storm.

Verse 9: While the storm is raging outside, everyone in the temple calls out, "Glory!" They see God's greatness in the storm.

The LORD is King VERSES 10–11

10 The LORD sat on his throne above the Flood.
Yes, the LORD sits as King forever.
11 The LORD will give strength to his people.
The LORD will bless his people with peace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The Flood": The same word is used here as for the great flood in the time of Noah (Genesis 6–9). God was already King over the greatest flood. He remains King forever.

The psalm begins with God's mighty voice in the storm and ends with a quiet word: "peace." The mighty God gives his people rest and peace (in Hebrew, "shalom").

PSALMS

PSALM 30

You have turned my mourning into dancing

You have healed me VERSES 1–3

1 A psalm. A song for the dedication of the temple. By David.
I will praise you highly, LORD, for you have lifted me up.
You have not let my enemies rejoice over me.
2 LORD my God, I cried out to you,
and you have healed me.
3 LORD, you have brought my soul up from Sheol (the world of the dead).
You have kept me alive,
so that I did not go down into the pit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The heading speaks of the "dedication of the temple." In Hebrew, it simply says "of the house." It can mean the temple or David's palace. To this day, Jews pray this psalm at the festival of lights, Hanukkah. Hanukkah remembers how the temple was dedicated again.

The person praying was very sick and close to death. God has healed him. "Lifted me up": the way someone pulls a bucket up out of a deep well.

Weeping at night, joy in the morning VERSES 4–5

4 Sing praise to the LORD, you who are faithful to him!
Give thanks to his holy name!
5 For his anger lasts only a moment.
His kindness lasts a lifetime.
Weeping may stay for the night,
but joy comes in the morning.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5 is one of the most comforting verses in the Bible. Suffering and grief are like a night. They are hard, but they do not last forever. The morning comes.

God's anger is short. His love is long.

This does not mean that every grief is over after one night. But it does mean: Weeping does not have the last word.

I thought I was safe VERSES 6–10

6 As for me, when things were going well, I said,
"Nothing will ever shake me."
7 LORD, when you were kind to me,
you made my mountain stand strong.
But when you hid your face,
I was terrified.
8 I cried out to you, LORD.
I begged the Lord for help:
9 "What good is it to you if I am destroyed,
if I go down into the pit?
Will the dust praise you?
Will it tell about your faithfulness?
10 Hear me, LORD, and be kind to me.
LORD, be my helper."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying tells honestly: When things were going well for me, I became proud. I thought nothing could shake me, by my own strength.

Then God hid himself, and suddenly everything was different. He noticed: My safety came from God, not from me.

Verse 9: A bold argument in prayer: God, what good is it to you if I die? The dead cannot praise you anymore. Let me live, so that I can praise you!

Mourning turns into dancing VERSES 11–12

11 You have turned my mourning into dancing.
You have taken off my sackcloth
and dressed me with joy.
Sackcloth is rough clothing that people wore when they were grieving.
12 So my heart will sing praise to you and not be silent.
LORD my God, I will thank you forever!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A beautiful picture: God takes off the rough clothing of grief (sackcloth) from the one who is mourning. He dresses him in festive clothes of joy. Mourning turns into dancing.

The psalm ends with a promise: I will not be silent. I will thank God forever.

PSALMS

PSALM 31

Into your hand I commit my spirit

Be a strong rock for me VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
LORD, I come to you for safety.
Never let me be put to shame.
Rescue me, because you are righteous.
2 Turn your ear to me.
Rescue me quickly.
Be a strong rock for me,
a strong house that keeps me safe.
3 For you are my rock and my fortress.
So lead me and guide me
for the sake of your name.
4 Pull me out of the net
that they have secretly set for me,
for you are my stronghold.
5 Into your hand I commit my spirit.
You set me free, LORD, God of truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5 is very well known: "Into your hand I commit my spirit." "Commit" here means: to entrust, to hand over.

Jesus prayed these words on the cross as his last words: "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit!" (Luke 23:46). Stephen prayed something similar when he died (Acts 7:59).

Jews traditionally pray this verse before going to sleep. Many Christians pray it in the evening and in the hour of death.

You have seen my trouble VERSES 6–8

6 I hate those who hold on to worthless idols.
But I trust in the LORD.
7 I will be glad and full of joy
because of your loving kindness.
For you have seen my suffering.
You have known my soul in times of trouble.
8 You have not handed me over to my enemy.
You have set my feet in a wide, open place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Worthless idols": gods who cannot do anything. The one who prays rejects them firmly.

Verse 7: "You have known my soul in times of trouble": God knows exactly how I am doing. He knows my pain.

I am like broken pottery VERSES 9–13

9 Have mercy on me, LORD, for I am in trouble.
My eyes, my soul and my body
are wearing away with grief.
10 For my life is used up in sorrow,
and my years in sighing.
My strength fails because of my guilt.
My bones are wasting away.
11 Because of all my enemies,
my neighbors look down on me completely.
I have become a horror to the people I know.
Those who saw me on the street ran away from me.
12 They have forgotten me like a dead man.
I am like broken pottery.
13 For I have heard many people speaking evil about me.
There is terror on every side.
They plot together against me.
They make plans to take my life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one who prays is sick, pushed out and forgotten. People avoid him on the street.

"Like broken pottery": worthless, thrown away. That is how he feels.

"Terror on every side": This phrase often appears in the book of the prophet Jeremiah (for example Jeremiah 20:10).

Many people know this feeling of being forgotten and written off. God still sees them.

My times are in your hand VERSES 14–18

14 But I trust in you, LORD.
I said, "You are my God."
15 My times are in your hand.
Rescue me from the hand of my enemies
and from those who hunt me down.

16 Let your face shine on your servant.
Save me, because of your loving kindness.
17 LORD, do not let me be put to shame,
for I have called to you.
Let the wicked be put to shame.
Let them be silent in Sheol (the world of the dead).
18 Let the lying lips be silenced
that speak against the righteous
in a rude way, with pride and scorn.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–15: "But I": Once again the turn toward trust.

"My times are in your hand": My whole life, good times and bad times, beginning and end, is with God. Many people hold on to this sentence in hard hours.

A well-known German Christian song takes up this verse.

How great is your goodness! VERSES 19–24

19 Oh, how great is your goodness!
You have stored it up for those who fear you.
You have shown it to those who come to you for safety,
in front of all people.
20 In the shelter of your presence
you hide them from the plots of people.
You keep them hidden in a shelter,
away from the quarrels of tongues.
21 Praise the LORD!
For he has shown me his wonderful loving kindness
in a strong city.
22 As for me, I said in my panic,
"I am cut off from your sight."
But you heard my voice when I begged you for help,
when I cried out to you.
23 Oh, love the LORD, all you who belong to him!
The LORD protects those who are faithful.
And he pays back in full
the one who acts proudly.
24 Be strong, and let your heart take courage,
all you who hope in the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: God has a great store of goodness for those who trust him.

Verse 20: The "quarrels of tongues" means: rumors, lies about others, evil talk. God protects from this.

Verse 22 is very honest: In his panic, the one who prayed had thought that God had forgotten him. But God did hear him. Even when we doubt, God stays faithful.

Verse 24: An encouragement for everyone: Be strong and take courage!

If you feel forgotten and written off right now: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

PSALMS

PSALM 32

The freedom of forgiveness

Happy is the one who is forgiven VERSES 1–2

1 By David. A contemplative psalm.
Blessed is the one whose wrongdoing is forgiven,
whose sin is covered.
Blessed means: truly happy.
2 Blessed is the man
whose guilt the LORD does not count against him,
and whose spirit has no deceit in it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 32 is one of the seven psalms of repentance. It is about the happiness of being forgiven.

"Contemplative psalm": The Hebrew word is "Maskil." It may mean "a song that gives insight" or "a skillful song."

Three words for guilt: wrongdoing (crossing a line on purpose), sin (missing the target), guilt (what is wrong and crooked). And three words for forgiveness: forgive (take away), cover, not count against. God forgives completely.

Paul quotes verses 1–2 in Romans 4:7–8: Forgiveness is a gift, not a reward for good deeds.

When I kept silent VERSES 3–5

3 When I kept silent,
my bones wasted away
because of my groaning all day long.
4 For day and night your hand was heavy on me.
My strength dried up as in the heat of summer.
Selah.
5 I admitted my sin to you.
I did not hide my guilt.
I said, "I will confess my wrongs to the LORD."
And you forgave the guilt of my sin.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David tells about his own experience: As long as he kept quiet about his guilt, he felt bad, even in his body. His bad conscience ate away at him.

Many people think of the time after David's adultery with Bathsheba (2 Samuel 11–12).

Verse 5: When he finally admitted his guilt, he was set free. God forgave him right away.

This is still true today: Whoever honestly admits their guilt finds forgiveness with God (compare 1 John 1:9).

You are my hiding place VERSES 6–7

6 So let everyone who is faithful to God pray to you
at a time when you can be found.
When the great waters flood over,
they will surely not reach him.
7 You are my hiding place.
You will protect me from trouble.
You will surround me with songs of rescue.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David invites everyone: Do not wait too long! Pray while God can be found.

God is a safe hiding place. When the floods of trouble come, you are safe with him.

"Songs of rescue": All around, songs of joy are heard, because God has rescued.

I will teach you VERSES 8–11

8 I will teach you and show you the way you should go.
I will give you advice, and my eye is on you.
9 Do not be like the horse or the mule,
which have no understanding.
They must be controlled with bit and bridle,
or else they will not come near to you.
10 The wicked have many sorrows.
But loving kindness will surround
the one who trusts in the LORD.
11 Be glad in the LORD, and be full of joy, you righteous people!
Shout for joy, all of you whose hearts are honest!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In verse 8, God himself speaks: I will lead you. I keep my eye on you, like a good teacher.

Verse 9: God does not want to force us like an animal with a bridle. He wants us to come to him freely and with understanding.

Verses 10–11: Whoever trusts God is surrounded by goodness. The psalm ends with joy.

PSALMS

PSALM 33

Sing a new song to the LORD

A new song VERSES 1–5

1 Be full of joy in the LORD, you righteous people!
It is fitting for honest people to praise him.
2 Give thanks to the LORD with the lyre.
Sing praises to him with the harp of 10 strings.
3 Sing a new song to him.
Play well, with shouts of joy!
4 For the LORD's word is right.
All his work is done in faithfulness.
5 He loves what is right and fair.
The earth is full of the LORD's loving kindness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 33 is a great song of praise. It has no heading.

"A new song": God's goodness is new every day, so our praise should also be new and fresh again and again. This phrase appears often in the Bible (compare Psalm 96:1; Revelation 5:9).

"The earth is full of the LORD's loving kindness": You can discover God's love everywhere in the world.

He spoke, and it was done VERSES 6–9

6 The heavens were made by the LORD's word,
and all their army by the breath of his mouth.
7 He gathers the waters of the sea together like a heap.
He puts the deep waters in storerooms.
8 Let all the earth fear the LORD.
Let all the people of the world stand in awe of him.
9 For he spoke, and it was done.
He gave the command, and it stood firm.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God created the world through his word (compare Genesis 1:3: "God said, 'Let there be light.'").

"All their army": the stars.

Verse 9 sums it up very briefly: God only needs to speak, and it happens. That is how powerful his word is.

God's plan stands firm VERSES 10–15

10 The LORD brings the plans of the nations to nothing.
He makes the ideas of the peoples useless.
11 The LORD's plan stands firm forever,
the thoughts of his heart for all generations.
12 Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD,
the people he has chosen as his own.
13 The LORD looks down from heaven.
He sees all people.
14 From the place where he lives,
he looks out on everyone who lives on the earth.
15 He is the one who forms all their hearts,
and he pays attention to everything they do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

People and nations make big plans. But in the end, what God plans is what happens.

God sees all people, not only Israel. He has formed every heart and knows it exactly.

A horse does not help VERSES 16–22

16 No king is saved by a large army.
A strong warrior is not rescued by great strength.
17 A horse is useless for safety.
It does not rescue anyone with its great power.
18 Look, the LORD's eye is on those who fear him,
on those who hope in his loving kindness.
19 He rescues their soul from death
and keeps them alive in times of hunger.
20 Our soul has waited for the LORD.
He is our help and our shield.
21 For our heart is full of joy in him,
because we have trusted in his holy name.
22 LORD, let your loving kindness be on us,
since we have put our hope in you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Neither large armies nor strong war horses can really save. True safety comes from God (compare Psalm 20:7).

God's eye rests with love on those who trust him.

Verse 22 is a beautiful closing prayer. It is also prayed at the end of the ancient song of praise called the "Te Deum."

PSALMS

PSALM 34

Taste and see that the LORD is good

I will praise the LORD at all times VERSES 1–7

1 By David, when he pretended to be insane in front of Abimelech,
who drove him away, and he left.
I will praise the LORD at all times.
His praise will always be in my mouth.
2 My soul will boast about the LORD.
The humble will hear it and be glad.
3 Oh, praise the greatness of the LORD with me.
Let's honor his name together.
4 I looked for the LORD, and he answered me.
He rescued me from all my fears.
5 Those who looked to him were glowing with joy.
Their faces will never be covered with shame.
6 This poor man cried out, and the LORD heard him.
He saved him from all his troubles.
7 The LORD's angel sets up camp around those who fear him,
and he rescues them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The heading reminds us of a story: David fled from Saul to the Philistine king in Gath. Out of fear, he pretended to be insane so that they would let him go (1 Samuel 21:10–15). There the king is called Achish. "Abimelech" was probably a title of the Philistine kings, like "Pharaoh" in Egypt.

Psalm 34 is an alphabet poem.

Verse 5: "Those who looked to him were glowing with joy": Whoever looks to God has a face that shines with joy.

Verse 7: God's angel camps like an army all around those who trust him, and protects them.

Taste and see VERSES 8–10

8 Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good.
Blessed is the man who comes to him for safety.
Blessed means: truly happy.
9 Oh, fear the LORD, you who belong to him,
for those who fear him do not lack anything.
10 The young lions lack food and go hungry.
But those who seek the LORD
will not lack any good thing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8 is an invitation: Try it out! Just as you taste good food, you can experience God's goodness. You have to experience it yourself.

Christians often sing this verse at Holy Communion. 1 Peter 2:3 also takes it up.

Verse 10: Even strong young lions sometimes have to go hungry. But whoever seeks God does not lack anything that is really good.

Whoever loves life VERSES 11–16

11 Come, children, listen to me.
I will teach you the fear of the LORD.
12 Who wants to live?
Who loves to have many days to see good things?
13 Then keep your tongue from evil,
and keep your lips from telling lies.
14 Turn away from evil, and do good.
Seek peace, and go after it.
15 The LORD's eyes are on the righteous.
His ears listen to their cry.
16 The LORD's face is against those who do evil.
He will wipe out the memory of them from the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David becomes a teacher. He gives practical advice for a good life:

– Watch your words, do not lie.

– Leave evil behind and do what is good.

– "Seek peace, and go after it": Peace does not come by itself. You have to work for it actively.

Peter quotes verses 12–16 in his letter (1 Peter 3:10–12).

Near to those with a broken heart VERSES 17–22

17 The righteous cry out, and the LORD hears.
He rescues them from all their troubles.
18 The LORD is near to those who have a broken heart.
He saves those whose spirit is crushed.
19 The righteous have many troubles,
but the LORD rescues him from all of them.
20 He protects all his bones.
Not one of them is broken.
21 Evil will kill the wicked.
Those who hate the righteous will be condemned.
22 The LORD sets free the soul of his servants.
None of those who come to him for safety will be condemned.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18 is one of the most comforting verses in the Bible: God is especially near to those whose heart is broken. Whoever is sad, hurt or in despair is not far from God. God is especially close to them.

Verse 19 is honest: The righteous also have "many troubles." Faith does not protect us from suffering. But God rescues us out of it.

Verse 20: John relates this verse to Jesus: On the cross, his legs were not broken, unlike the legs of the others who were crucified (John 19:36).

Verse 21: Evil comes back on the one who does it.

If your heart is broken right now and you need help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

PSALMS

PSALM 35

LORD, fight for me

Fight against those who fight against me VERSES 1–8

1 By David.
LORD, argue against those who argue against me.
Fight against those who fight against me.
2 Take hold of your small shield and your large shield.
Stand up and help me.
3 Raise the spear
and block the way of those who chase me.
Say to my soul, "I am your salvation."
Salvation means: rescue.
4 Let those who want to take my life
be put to shame and disgraced.
Let those who plan to ruin me
be turned back and confused.
5 Let them be like chaff in the wind,
with the LORD's angel driving them away.
Chaff is the dry husk around the grain.
6 Let their way be dark and slippery,
with the LORD's angel chasing them.
7 For they had no reason
to hide their net in a pit for me.
They had no reason
to dig a pit for my soul.
8 Let disaster come on him by surprise.
Let the net that he has hidden catch him himself.
Let him fall into that disaster.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one who prays is being hunted for no reason. He asks God to stand up for him like a warrior, or like a lawyer in court. The Hebrew word for "argue" also means "to bring a case to court."

Verse 3: What he wants most is a word from God: "I am your salvation."

Verses 4–8 are prayers against the enemies. The one who prays does not want to strike back himself. He asks God to let the wicked fall into their own trap.

Who is like you? VERSES 9–10

9 My soul will be full of joy in the LORD.
It will be glad because he rescues me.
10 All my bones will say,
"LORD, who is like you?
You rescue the poor from the one who is too strong for him.
Yes, you rescue the poor and needy from the one who robs him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A short moment of trust. "All my bones": with my whole body, with everything I am.

God stands on the side of the weak against the strong who rob them.

They pay back good with evil VERSES 11–18

11 Witnesses who are not honest stand up.
They ask me about things I know nothing about.
12 They pay me back evil for good.
My soul is left all alone.
13 But as for me, when they were sick,
I wore sackcloth.
Sackcloth was rough clothing that people wore when they were sad.
I made my soul suffer by fasting.
Fasting means: not eating, to pray more seriously.
My prayer came back into my own lap.
14 I acted as if it were my friend or my brother.
I bowed down in sorrow,
like someone who mourns for his mother.
15 But when I was in trouble,
they were glad and gathered together.
The attackers gathered together against me,
and I did not know it.
They tore at me and did not stop.
16 Like godless people who make fun of others at feasts,
they ground their teeth at me.
17 Lord, how long will you just watch?
Rescue my soul from their attacks.
Rescue my precious life from the lions.
18 I will thank you in the great gathering.
I will praise you among many people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This hurts most of all: The people for whom the one who prays had prayed and fasted when they were sick now turn against him. They are glad about his trouble.

Verse 13: "My prayer came back into my own lap": This is hard to understand. Maybe: I prayed with my head bowed down to my chest. Or: My prayer did not help them; it came back to me. Or: I now pray the same prayer for myself.

Verse 17: "How long will you just watch?": An honest, desperate question to God.

They hate me without a cause VERSES 19–26

19 Do not let those who are my enemies for no good reason
be glad about me.
Do not let those who hate me without a cause
wink their eyes at me.
20 For they do not speak of peace.
Instead they make up lies
against those who live quietly in the land.
21 Yes, they open their mouths wide against me.
They say, "Aha! Aha! We have seen it with our own eyes!"
22 You have seen it, LORD. Do not stay silent.
Lord, do not be far from me.
23 Wake up! Rise up to defend me, my God!
My Lord, argue my case!

24 LORD my God, take my side,
because you are righteous.
Do not let them be glad about my trouble.
25 Do not let them say in their heart,
"Aha! That is just how we wanted it!"
Do not let them say, "We have swallowed him up!"
26 Let all those who are glad about my disaster
be put to shame and confused together.
Let those who make themselves big against me
be dressed in shame and disgrace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: "Those who hate me without a cause": Jesus uses these words about himself (John 15:25).

"Those who live quietly in the land": peaceful, ordinary people who do not harm anyone. They are the very ones who become the target of lies.

Verse 21: "Aha! Aha! We have seen it with our own eyes!": The enemies laugh with glee, as if they had caught the one who prays doing something wrong.

Verse 22: The answer: "You have seen it, LORD." The enemies see something, but God sees everything.

May the LORD be great VERSES 27–28

27 Let those who support my just cause
shout for joy and be glad.
Yes, let them always say,
"May the LORD be praised as great!
He is pleased when his servant is doing well."
28 My tongue will talk about your righteousness
and about your praise all day long.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, it is no longer about the enemies, but about the friends and about God.

"Doing well": The Hebrew word here is "shalom," peace. God is glad when his children are doing well.

Psalm 35 is a prayer for people who are bullied, lied about or treated unfairly. It allows us to tell God all of our pain and to hand the matter over to him, instead of taking revenge ourselves.

PSALMS

PSALM 36

With you is the spring of life

The wicked person VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. By David, the servant of the LORD.
God has shown my heart something
about the wrongdoing of the wicked:
He does not fear God at all.
2 For he flatters himself in his own eyes.
He thinks so highly of himself
that he cannot find his sin and hate it.
3 The words of his mouth are evil and full of lies.
He has stopped being wise and doing good.
4 He makes evil plans on his bed.
He sets out on a way that is not good.
He does not hate evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm describes how a wicked person thinks: He has no respect for God. He thinks he is so great that he does not see his own faults.

Paul quotes verse 1 in Romans 3:18.

Verse 4: Even at night in bed, he thinks up evil things. He no longer holds back from evil.

Verse 1 is hard to translate from the Hebrew. Word for word, it says something like: A saying of wrongdoing to the wicked in my heart.

Your loving kindness reaches to the heavens VERSES 5–9

5 LORD, your loving kindness reaches to the heavens.
Your faithfulness reaches to the skies.
6 Your righteousness is like the mountains of God.
Your judgments are like the great deep sea.
LORD, you protect both people and animals.
7 How precious is your loving kindness, God!
People come for safety
under the shadow of your wings.
8 They will eat their fill of the rich food in your house.
You will let them drink from the river of your delights.
9 For with you is the spring of life.
In your light we will see light.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes a strong contrast: After the dark picture of the wicked person comes shining praise of God's goodness.

God's goodness is as great as the heavens. His righteousness is as firm as the highest mountains. His judgments are as deep as the sea.

"You protect both people and animals": God cares for all of creation.

Verse 9 is one of the most beautiful verses in the Bible: "For with you is the spring of life. In your light we will see light." All life comes from God. And only in his light can we really see and understand.

Jesus says, "I am the light of the world" (John 8:12), and he speaks of "living water" (John 4:10–14).

Keep me safe VERSES 10–12

10 Oh, keep showing your loving kindness to those who know you,
and your righteousness to those whose hearts are honest.
11 Do not let the foot of proud people step on me.
Do not let the hand of the wicked drive me away.
12 There the evildoers have fallen.
They are pushed down and will not be able to get up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one who prays asks: Let me stay in your goodness. Keep me safe from proud and evil people.

Verse 12: The one who prays already sees the end of the evildoers: They fall and do not get up again.

PSALMS

Psalm 37

Commit your way to the LORD

Do not be upset about evil people VERSES 1–2

1 By David.
Do not be upset because of evildoers.
Do not be jealous of those who do wrong.
2 For they will soon be cut down like the grass.
They will dry up like green plants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 37 is a psalm of wisdom and an alphabet poem. It sounds like the advice of an old, experienced person to a young one (compare verse 25).

The big question: Why do evil people often do so well? The answer: Do not be upset! Their success is like grass that soon dries up.

Trust in the LORD VERSES 3–8

3 Trust in the LORD, and do good.
Live in the land, and enjoy safe pasture.
4 Also find your joy in the LORD,
and he will give you what your heart wants.
5 Commit your way to the LORD.
That means: Put your way into the LORD's hands.
Trust in him too, and he will do this:
6 He will make your righteousness shine out like light,
and your justice like the sun at noon.
7 Be still before the LORD, and wait patiently for him.
Do not be upset because of the one who succeeds on his way,
because of the man who carries out evil plans.
8 Stop being angry, and let go of your rage.
Do not be upset. It only leads to doing evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "Also find your joy in the LORD": When God is my greatest joy, then my wishes also become the kind that God is glad to fulfill.

Verse 5 is very well known: "Commit your way to the LORD." The Hebrew has a strong picture: You roll your way onto the LORD, the way you roll a heavy load onto someone else. Paul Gerhardt's famous German hymn "Befiehl du deine Wege" is based on this verse.

Verses 7–8: Anger and jealousy eat you up inside and can lead you to do evil yourself. It is better to become still and trust God.

The humble will inherit the land VERSES 9–15

9 For evildoers will be cut off.
But those who wait for the LORD will inherit the land.
10 In just a little while, the wicked will be gone.
Yes, even if you look for his place, he is not there.
11 But the humble will inherit the land.
They will enjoy great peace.
12 The wicked makes plans against the righteous
and grinds his teeth at him.
13 The Lord laughs at him,
for he sees that his day is coming.
14 The wicked have pulled out the sword
and have bent their bow.
They want to bring down the poor and needy.
They want to kill those who live honestly.
15 Their sword will go into their own heart.
Their bows will be broken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: "The humble will inherit the land": Jesus takes this up in the Sermon on the Mount: "Blessed are the gentle, for they will inherit the earth" (Matthew 5:5).

The violence of the wicked turns against them in the end (verse 15).

Better a little with God VERSES 16–22

16 The little that a righteous person has
is better than the riches of many wicked people.
17 For the arms of the wicked will be broken,
but the LORD holds up the righteous.
18 The LORD knows the days of those who are blameless.
What they receive from him will last forever.
19 They will not be put to shame in evil times.
In times of hunger they will have enough to eat.
20 But the wicked will die.
The enemies of the LORD will be like the beauty of the fields.
They will disappear, disappear like smoke.
21 The wicked borrow and do not pay back,
but the righteous give generously.
22 For those whom he blesses will inherit the land.
Those whom he curses will be cut off.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Owning little with a clear conscience is better than great riches gained by doing wrong (compare Proverbs 15:16).

Verse 20: The splendor of the wicked is like flowers in a meadow: beautiful, but soon faded. Like smoke that blows away.

Verse 21: One difference between the wicked and the righteous: The one takes and does not give back. The other gives generously.

Though he stumbles, he will not fall VERSES 23–29

23 The LORD makes a man's steps firm.
He is pleased with his way.
24 Even if he stumbles, he will not fall down,
for the LORD holds him up with his hand.
25 I have been young, and now I am old.
Yet I have not seen the righteous left alone,

or his children begging for bread.
26 All day long he is kind and lends to others.
His children are blessed.
27 Turn away from evil, and do good.
Then you will live safely forever.
28 For the LORD loves justice.
He does not leave those who are faithful to him.
They are kept safe forever,
but the children of the wicked will be cut off.
29 The righteous will inherit the land
and live in it forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: Even a righteous person sometimes stumbles, makes mistakes and has setbacks. But God holds him by the hand so that he does not fall all the way down.

Verse 25: The old speaker tells about his experience of life. He means it honestly, but it is not a promise for every single case. There are also righteous people who are poor and suffer (like Job). The verse is meant to encourage. It is not meant to blame poor people.

Verse 28: "The children of the wicked": This means those who go on along the evil way of their parents. The Bible also says: Each person is responsible for their own guilt (Ezekiel 18:20).

God's law in the heart VERSES 30–34

30 The mouth of the righteous speaks wisdom.
His tongue says what is right.
31 The law of his God is in his heart.
None of his steps will slip.
32 The wicked lie in wait for the righteous
and try to kill him.
33 The LORD will not leave him in his power.
He will not let him be condemned when he is judged.
34 Wait for the LORD, and stay on his way.
He will lift you up so that you inherit the land.
When the wicked are cut off, you will see it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: God's teaching is not only a law on the outside. It is in the heart. Whoever loves God's will walks safely.

Verse 33: Even if a righteous person is condemned in a human court, God stays on his side.

A man of peace has a future VERSES 35–40

35 I have seen the wicked in great power,
spreading out like a green tree in the soil where it grew up.
36 But he passed away, and he was gone.
Yes, I looked for him, but he could not be found.
37 Pay attention to the blameless man, and look at the honest one,
for there is a future for the man of peace.
38 But those who break God's law will all be destroyed together.
The future of the wicked will be cut off.
39 But the salvation of the righteous comes from the LORD.
He is their stronghold in times of trouble.
40 The LORD helps them and rescues them.
He rescues them from the wicked and saves them,
because they have come to him for safety.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 35–36: The old speaker has seen powerful tyrants come and go. They seemed like big trees, but suddenly they were gone.

Verse 37: "There is a future for the man of peace": Whoever makes peace has a future. This is a great encouragement.

The psalm ends with trust: God is a stronghold in times of trouble.

PSALMS

PSALM 38

A sick man confesses his guilt

Your arrows have struck me VERSES 1–8

1 A psalm by David, for a memorial.
LORD, do not correct me in your anger.
Do not punish me in your burning rage.
2 For your arrows have pierced me.
Your hand presses hard on me.
3 Nothing in my body is healthy
because of your anger.
Nothing in my bones is well
because of my sin.
4 For my guilt has gone over my head.
It is like a heavy load, too heavy for me.
5 My wounds stink and are full of pus
because of my foolishness.
6 I am in pain and bent over low.
I go around mourning all day long.
7 For my waist is full of burning pain.
Nothing in my body is healthy.
8 I am weak and badly crushed.
I groan because my heart is in anguish.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 38 is one of the seven psalms of repentance. "For a memorial": Maybe it was sung at the "memorial offering," or it is meant to remind God of the one who prays.

The one who prays is very sick. He understands his sickness as a result of his guilt.

Important: The Bible does not say that every sickness is a punishment for sin. The book of Job showed this clearly, and Jesus says it too (John 9:1–3). But this man experiences it that way for himself, and he brings it honestly before God.

Verse 4: "My guilt has gone over my head": like water that rises over your head. Many people who feel guilty know this feeling.

My friends keep their distance VERSES 9–14

9 Lord, everything I long for is in front of you.
My groaning is not hidden from you.
10 My heart is pounding. My strength leaves me.
Even the light of my eyes has left me.
11 My loved ones and my friends stay away from me
because of my sickness.
My relatives stand far away.
12 Those who want to take my life set traps for me.
Those who want to hurt me speak of ruin.
They think up lies all day long.
13 But I am like a deaf man. I do not hear.
I am like a man who cannot speak,
who does not open his mouth.
14 Yes, I am like a man who does not hear,
who has no answer in his mouth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: A comfort: God knows everything, even what I cannot put into words.

Verse 11: This is very painful: Just when he is sick, his friends and his family keep their distance. Maybe they are afraid of catching it. Maybe they think it is his own fault.

Verses 13–14: The one who prays does not defend himself against the attacks. He stays silent. This reminds us of the suffering servant of God in Isaiah 53:7, and of Jesus, who stayed silent before those who accused him.

I hope in you VERSES 15–22

15 For I hope in you, LORD.
You will answer, Lord my God.
16 For I said, "Do not let them be glad about my trouble,
or make themselves big over me when my foot slips."
17 For I am about to fall.
My pain is always in front of me.
18 For I will confess my guilt.
I am sorry for my sin.
19 But my enemies are strong and many.
There are many who hate me for no reason.
20 Those who pay back evil for good are also against me,
because I follow what is good.
21 Do not leave me, LORD.
My God, do not be far from me.
22 Hurry to help me, Lord, my salvation.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: He is silent before people, but he talks with God. He expects an answer from God.

Verse 18: He honestly confesses his guilt. That is the first step toward healing.

The psalm does not end with an answer, but with an urgent cry for help. Not every prayer ends with a solution. Sometimes all that is left is the cry: "Do not leave me, LORD."

PSALMS

PSALM 39

How short a person's life is

I wanted to stay silent VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. For Jeduthun. A psalm by David.
I said, "I will watch my ways,
so that I do not sin with my tongue.
I will keep my mouth closed, as with a bridle,
while the wicked are in front of me."
2 I was silent and said nothing.
I kept quiet, even about good things.
And my pain was stirred up.
3 My heart grew hot inside me.
While I was thinking, the fire burned.
Then I spoke with my tongue:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeduthun was one of the leaders of the temple music in David's time (1 Chronicles 16:41).

The one who prays wanted to stay silent so that he would not say anything wrong about God in front of wicked people.

But the silence made it worse. The pain burned in him like fire. Finally he had to speak, but he does not speak to people. He speaks to God.

Let me know how short my life is VERSES 4–6

4 "LORD, show me my end,
and how many my days will be.
Let me know how weak and passing I am.
5 Look, you have made my days only a few hand widths long.
My lifetime is like nothing before you.
Surely every person is only a breath."
Selah.
6 "Surely every person walks around like a shadow.
Surely they keep busy for nothing.
A person piles up riches
and does not know who will gather them in.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one who prays thinks about how short life is. Compared to God, a human life is only "hand widths," as short as the width of a hand.

"A breath": The Hebrew word is "hevel." The same word appears often in the book of Ecclesiastes. There it says that everything is a breath, that everything passes away.

Verse 6: People gather riches, but they do not know who will get them after they die (compare Luke 12:20).

Thinking about death like this is not hopeless. It helps us tell what is important from what is not important (compare Psalm 90:12).

My hope is in you VERSES 7–11

7 And now, Lord, what am I waiting for?
My hope is in you.
8 Rescue me from all my wrongs.
Do not let foolish people make fun of me.

9 I was silent. I did not open my mouth,
because you are the one who did it.
10 Take your blows away from me.
I am worn out by the blows of your hand.
11 When you correct a person
and punish him for his guilt,
you eat away his riches like a moth.
Surely every person is only a breath."
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7 is the turning point: If everything passes away, what should I hope for? The answer: God. He alone remains.

Verse 11: "His riches": Some Bibles translate "his beauty" or "what he loves." Just as a moth slowly eats a garment, so everything a person has passes away.

I am a guest with you VERSES 12–13

12 "Hear my prayer, LORD,
and listen to my cry.
Do not be silent when you see my tears.
For I am a stranger with you,
a foreigner, as all my ancestors were.
13 Oh, spare me, so that I can get my strength back,
before I go away and am no more."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: "I am a stranger with you": A person is only a guest on earth. He lives here only for a time, like Abraham, who lived as a stranger in the land. The earth belongs to God (Psalm 24:1).

Verse 13: A shocking ending. In Hebrew, he asks word for word that God would look away from him. The one who prays feels God's gaze like a burden that makes him suffer. He asks for a pause to catch his breath.

Psalm 39 is one of the darkest psalms. It shows: Even prayers like this have a place in the Bible.

If you feel right now as if you have no strength left and do not want to be here anymore: Talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

PSALMS

PSALM 40

He pulled me out of the pit

I waited patiently VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
I waited patiently for the LORD.
He turned to me and heard my cry.
2 He also brought me up out of a terrible pit,
out of the muddy clay.
He set my feet on a rock
and gave me a firm place to stand.
3 He has put a new song in my mouth,
a song of praise to our God.
Many will see it and be filled with awe.
They will trust in the LORD.
4 Blessed is the man who puts his trust in the LORD.
Blessed means: truly happy.
He does not look up to proud people,
or to those who turn aside to lies.
5 LORD, my God, you have done many wonderful things.
You have many thoughts for us.
No one can list them all for you.
If I wanted to tell about them and speak of them,
there would be more than anyone can count.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one who prays tells about how he was rescued. He was trapped as if in a deep pit full of mud, where you cannot get out by yourself. Back then, people sometimes used empty cisterns as prisons (compare Jeremiah 38:6). A cistern is a pit dug in the ground to collect rainwater.

God pulled him out and set him on firm rock.

The song "40" by the Irish band U2 is based on this psalm.

Verse 5: God's good deeds are so many that no one can list them all.

I am glad to do your will VERSES 6–10

6 You did not want sacrifices and offerings.
You have opened my ears.
You did not ask for burnt offerings and sin offerings.
7 Then I said, "Look, I have come.
It is written about me in the book, in the scroll.
8 I am glad to do your will, my God.
Yes, your law is in my heart."
9 I have told the good news of your righteousness
in the great gathering.
Look, I will not close my lips.
LORD, you know it.
10 I have not hidden your righteousness in my heart.
I have told about your faithfulness and your salvation.
I have not kept your loving kindness and your truth
hidden from the great gathering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–8: God does not first of all want animal sacrifices. He wants a heart that listens to him and is glad to do his will (compare 1 Samuel 15:22; Hosea 6:6).

"You have opened my ears": Word for word: "dug." God has given him ears that hear and obey. The ancient Greek translation says here: "You prepared a body for me."

The letter to the Hebrews quotes verses 6–8 from the Greek translation and relates them to Jesus: Jesus came to do God's will and to offer himself as a sacrifice (Hebrews 10:5–10).

Verses 9–10: Whoever has experienced God's help should not stay silent, but tell others about it.

I am poor and needy VERSES 11–17

11 LORD, do not hold back your tender mercy from me.
Let your loving kindness and your truth always
protect me.

12 For more troubles than I can count have surrounded me.
My sins have caught up with me,
so that I cannot look up.
They are more than the hairs on my head.
My heart has failed me.
13 LORD, please be willing to rescue me.
Hurry to help me, LORD.
14 Let all those who want to take my life and destroy it
be put to shame and confused together.
Let those who are glad when I am hurt
be turned back and disgraced.
15 Let those who say to me, "Aha! Aha!"
be stunned because of their shame.
16 Let all those who seek you
be full of joy and glad in you.
Let those who love your salvation always say,
"Let the LORD be praised as great!"
17 But I am poor and needy.
May the Lord think about me.
You are my help and the one who rescues me.
Do not wait any longer, my God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the thanks comes a new trouble. This is honest: Life is not made up of just one rescue. New difficulties come again and again.

Verse 12: The one who prays sees his own guilt. It is "more than the hairs on my head."

Verses 13–17 appear again almost exactly as Psalm 70.

Verse 17: "But I am poor and needy. May the Lord think about me." Even if I am small, God does not forget me.

PSALMS

Psalm 41

Happy is the one who thinks of the weak

Whoever thinks of the poor VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
Blessed is the one who thinks of the poor.
Blessed means: truly happy.
The LORD will rescue him on the day of trouble.
2 The LORD will protect him and keep him alive.
He will be called blessed on the earth.
The LORD will not hand him over to what his enemies want.
3 The LORD will support him on his sickbed.
He will make him well again from his bed of illness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever takes care of the poor and weak will be taken care of by God when he himself gets into trouble.

Verse 3: God is like a nurse who makes the sick person's bed and helps him get up again.

Jesus says, "Blessed are those who show mercy, for they will receive mercy" (Matthew 5:7).

My enemies wait for me to die VERSES 4–9

4 I said, "LORD, have mercy on me!
Heal me, for I have sinned against you."
5 My enemies say evil things about me:
"When will he die? When will his name be forgotten?"
6 When someone comes to visit me, he says things that are not true.
His heart collects evil.
When he goes outside, he tells it to others.
7 All who hate me whisper together against me.
They imagine the worst for me.
8 "A terrible disease has struck him," they say.
"Now that he is lying down, he will never get up again."
9 Yes, even my close friend whom I trusted,
who ate bread with me,
has lifted up his heel against me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one who prays is very sick. The people who visit him act as if they feel sorry for him. But outside, they speak badly about him and wait for him to die.

Verse 9 is especially painful: Even his best friend has betrayed him. "Lifted up his heel": like a horse that kicks, or like someone who kicks another person.

Jesus quotes this verse at the Last Supper about Judas, who will betray him (John 13:18).

Raise me up VERSES 10–12

10 But you, LORD, have mercy on me, and raise me up, so that I can pay them back.
11 This is how I know that you are pleased with me:
my enemy does not win over me.
12 As for me, you hold me up because I am honest.
You set me in your presence forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: "So that I can pay them back": This sounds like revenge. If the one who prays is a king, it can also mean: so that I, as king, can make sure justice is done. Later, the Bible clearly teaches not to pay back evil with evil (Romans 12:17–21).

Verse 12: The most important thing is to be in God's presence forever, close to him.

Praise at the end of the first book VERSE 13

13 Praise the LORD, the God of Israel,
from everlasting to everlasting!
Amen and amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This verse is no longer part of Psalm 41 itself. It is the ending of the first book of the Psalms (Psalms 1–41).

Each of the five books of the Psalms ends with praise like this (compare Psalm 72:18–19; 89:52; 106:48; 150).

"Amen" means: "That is how it is! Let it be so!" It is a word of agreement and trust.

PSALMS

PSALM 42

As the deer longs for fresh water

The second book of the Psalms

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Psalm 42, the second book of the Psalms begins (Psalms 42–72).

In this part, God is usually called "God" (Hebrew "Elohim"), and less often "LORD" (YHWH). That is why Psalms 42–83 are also called the "Elohistic Psalter."

Many psalms in this part come from the "sons of Korah." They were Levites who served in the temple as singers and gatekeepers (1 Chronicles 9:19; 2 Chronicles 20:19).

My soul thirsts for God VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. A contemplation by the sons of Korah.
As the deer pants for streams of water,
so my soul pants for you, God.
2 My soul thirsts for God, for the living God.
When can I come and stand before God?
3 My tears have been my food day and night,
while people keep asking me, "Where is your God?"
4 I remember these things,
and I pour out my soul inside me:
how I used to go with the crowd
and lead them to God's house,
with shouts of joy and praise,
a great crowd celebrating a holy day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 42 and Psalm 43 belong together. They have the same refrain (42:5; 42:11; 43:5).

Verse 1 is a well-known picture: A deer in the dry season searches desperately for water. That is how the one who prays longs for God.

He is far away from the temple in Jerusalem, maybe in exile or in captivity. He can no longer go to the feasts.

Verse 3: He cries day and night. And people mock him: "Where is your God?"

Verse 4: He remembers the past, when he joyfully went to the temple with the crowd. This memory hurts.

Why are you so downcast, my soul? VERSE 5

5 Why are you in such despair, my soul?
Why are you so troubled inside me?
Hope in God!
For I will still praise him
for the help and rescue of his presence.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the refrain. The one who prays talks to himself, to his own soul. He asks: Why are you so downcast?

And then he encourages himself: Hope in God! A time will come when I can praise again.

This is an important help in sadness: Do not only listen to your feelings. Speak to yourself and remember God's faithfulness.

All your waves have swept over me VERSES 6–10

6 My God, my soul is in despair inside me.
So I remember you from the land of the Jordan,
from the heights of Hermon, from the hill Mizar.
7 One deep sea calls to another
at the roar of your waterfalls.
All your waves and breakers have swept over me.
8 In the daytime the LORD will send his loving kindness.
In the night his song will be with me:
a prayer to the God of my life.
9 I will say to God, my rock,
"Why have you forgotten me?
Why do I go around mourning,
because the enemy oppresses me?"
10 My enemies mock me.
It feels like a sword in my bones.
They keep asking me, "Where is your God?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: The one who prays is in the north of the land, at the springs of the Jordan near Mount Hermon. There are many waterfalls there. The hill Mizar is unknown.

Verse 7: The roar of the waterfalls becomes a picture of his trouble: Like waves, his worries crash over him. He feels as if he is drowning.

Verse 8: In the middle of it, a ray of light: God gives loving kindness in the day and a song in the night.

Verse 9: Again the honest question: "Why have you forgotten me?"

Once more: Hope in God VERSE 11

11 Why are you in such despair, my soul?
Why are you so troubled inside me?
Hope in God!
For I will still praise him,
the one who helps and rescues me, and my God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The refrain comes again. The one who prays struggles with his sadness again and again. It is not a victory won once and for all. It is a struggle.

Psalm 42 helps many people who suffer from depression or deep sadness. It shows: People of faith also know times like this. You may tell God about them.

If you feel like this and see no way out: Get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. A doctor can also help. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

PSALMS

PSALM 43

Send out your light and your truth

God, take my side VERSES 1–2

1 God, prove that I am in the right.
Argue my case against an ungodly nation.
Oh, rescue me from lying and wicked people.
2 For you are the God who gives me strength.
Why have you rejected me?
Why do I go around mourning,
because the enemy oppresses me?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 43 continues Psalm 42. It has no heading of its own. In many old manuscripts, both psalms are one single psalm.

The one who prays is being oppressed by an "ungodly nation," maybe in a foreign land.

Verse 2 repeats Psalm 42:9 almost exactly.

Send out your light VERSES 3–4

3 Oh, send out your light and your truth.
Let them lead me.
Let them bring me to your holy hill,
to the places where you live.
4 Then I will go to the altar of God,
to God, my overflowing joy.
I will praise you on the harp, God, my God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes a new request: God should send his light and his truth, like two companions who take the one who prays by the hand and lead him home to the temple.

Verse 4: "To God, my overflowing joy": This is the goal of his longing. Not only the temple, but God himself is the greatest joy.

Hope in God VERSE 5

5 Why are you in such despair, my soul?
Why are you so troubled inside me?
Hope in God!
For I will still praise him:
my Savior, my helper and my God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The refrain comes for the third time. Psalms 42 and 43 do not end with a solution to the trouble, but with hope.

The sadness is still there. But the hope has grown stronger. At the beginning, there was only longing. Now there is firm trust: I will still praise him.

PSALMS

Psalm 44

Why do you sleep, Lord?

What you did in the past VERSES 1–8

1 For the music director. By the sons of Korah. A contemplative psalm.
God, we have heard it with our ears.
Our ancestors have told us
what you did in their days,
in the days long ago.
2 With your hand you drove out the nations,
but you planted our ancestors in the land.
You brought trouble on the peoples,
but you let our ancestors spread out.
3 For they did not take the land with their own sword.
Their own arm did not save them.
It was your right hand, your arm,
and the light of your face,
because you were kind to them.
4 God, you are my King.
Give the order for victories for Jacob!
5 With your help, we will push our enemies down.
In your name, we will trample those who rise up against us.
6 For I will not trust in my bow.
My sword will not save me.
7 But you have saved us from our enemies.
You have put to shame those who hate us.
8 We have boasted about God all day long.
We will thank your name forever.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 44 is a lament of the whole people after a terrible defeat.

It begins by remembering: In the past, God helped Israel. He gave them the land, not through their own strength, but through his grace.

Verse 6: The people do not trust in weapons, but in God.

The phrase "you drove out the nations" describes the taking of the land from Israel's point of view. It is not a command for today to drive out other peoples.

But now you have rejected us VERSES 9–16

9 But now you have rejected us and brought us to disgrace.
You no longer go out with our armies.
10 You make us turn back and run from the enemy.
Those who hate us take our goods for themselves.
11 You have made us like sheep that are eaten.
You have scattered us among the nations.
12 You sell your people for nothing.
You have gained nothing from selling them.
13 You make our neighbors insult us.
The people around us mock us and laugh at us.
14 The nations use our name as a saying of scorn.
The peoples shake their heads at us.
15 All day long my disgrace is in front of me.
Shame covers my face,

16 because of the voice of the one who mocks and insults me,
because of the enemy who wants revenge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Suddenly the turn: "But now." God seems to have left his people. They have suffered a terrible defeat. Many have been killed or taken away.

The complaints to God are very direct: You have sold us like goods, and not even for a good price!

The Bible allows such honest words to God, even words that accuse him.

We have not forgotten you VERSES 17–22

17 All this has happened to us,
yet we have not forgotten you.
We have not been unfaithful to your covenant.
A covenant is a binding agreement.
18 Our heart has not turned back.
Our steps have not left your path.
19 Yet you have crushed us in the place where jackals live.
You have covered us with the shadow of death.
20 If we had forgotten the name of our God,
or stretched out our hands to a foreign god,
21 wouldn't God find this out?
For he knows the secrets of the heart.
22 Yes, for your sake we are killed all day long.
We are thought of as sheep to be slaughtered.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is what is special about Psalm 44: The people say, We are innocent. We have not sinned. And still we suffer. It is like Job, but for a whole people.

Verse 22: "For your sake we are killed all day long": They suffer precisely because they belong to God.

Paul quotes verse 22 in Romans 8:36. Then he answers: Nothing "will be able to separate us from God's love which is in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:39).

Many Jews have prayed this verse in times of persecution, up to the Shoah (the Holocaust).

Wake up, Lord! VERSES 23–26

23 Wake up! Why are you sleeping, Lord?
Get up! Do not reject us forever.
24 Why do you hide your face?
Why do you forget our suffering and how we are oppressed?
25 For our soul is bowed down to the dust.
Our body lies flat on the ground.
26 Rise up and help us.
Set us free because of your loving kindness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Why are you sleeping?": A bold cry. Of course the one who prays knows that God does not sleep (Psalm 121:4). But that is how it feels.

The psalm ends without an answer, only with the request: Help us, "because of your loving kindness." Not because we have earned it, but because you are good.

PSALMS

PSALM 45

A song for the king's wedding

Praise of the king VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. Set to "The Lilies." A contemplation by the sons of Korah. A wedding song.
My heart overflows with a beautiful theme.
I recite my verses for the king.
My tongue is like the pen of a skilled writer.
2 You are the most excellent of all people.
Grace has been poured on your lips.
So God has blessed you forever.
3 Strap your sword on your side, mighty one,
in your splendor and your majesty.
4 In your majesty, ride out to victory
for truth, humility and righteousness.
Let your right hand show awesome deeds.
5 Your arrows are sharp.
The nations fall under you.
Your arrows are in the heart of the king's enemies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 45 is unique: a song for the wedding of a king. The WEB, our English source text, calls it a "wedding song." Word for word, it says "song of love."

The poet is full of excitement. He describes the king: handsome, good with words, blessed by God.

Verse 4: The king does not fight for power, but "for truth, humility and righteousness." That is the ideal of a good ruler.

Your throne, God, lasts forever VERSES 6–9

6 Your throne, God, lasts forever and ever.
The scepter of your kingdom is a scepter of fairness.
A scepter is a royal staff, a sign of a king's power.
7 You have loved righteousness and hated wickedness.
That is why God, your God, has anointed you
with the oil of joy, more than your companions.
8 All your clothes smell of myrrh, aloes and cassia.
From palaces decorated with ivory,
the music of stringed instruments has made you glad.
9 Kings' daughters are among the women you honor.
At your right hand stands the queen in gold of Ophir.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6 is astonishing: The king is addressed directly as "God." In the ancient Near East, kings were sometimes praised in very lofty words. The verse can also be translated: Your throne is like God's throne. Or: Your divine throne.

The letter to the Hebrews quotes verses 6–7 and relates them to Jesus, the Son of God (Hebrews 1:8–9).

Verse 8: Myrrh, aloes and cassia are precious perfumes. Ivory palaces were palaces decorated with ivory, a sign of great wealth.
Ophir was a land that was famous for its fine gold (1 Kings 9:28).

To the bride VERSES 10–15

10 Listen, daughter, think about this, and turn your ear.
Forget your own people and your father's house.
11 Then the king will desire your beauty.
Honor him, for he is your lord.
12 The daughter of Tyre comes with a gift.
The rich among the people try to win your favor.
13 The princess inside the palace is all glorious.
Her clothing is woven with gold.
14 She will be led to the king in embroidered clothes.
The young women, her companions who follow her, will be brought to you.
15 They will be led in with gladness and joy.
They will enter the king's palace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the poet turns to the bride. She probably comes from a foreign land and is now to find a new home.

"Forget your own people": Back then, this was a big step for a young woman. She left her family forever.
"He is your lord": That is how people spoke about marriage back then. But in other places, the Bible also says that husband and wife should love and honor each other (compare Genesis 2:24; Ephesians 5:21–33).
"The daughter of Tyre": the rich trading city of Tyre, which sends gifts.
Jews have also related the psalm to the Messiah and Israel. Christians relate it to Christ and the church as his bride.

Your sons VERSES 16–17

16 Your sons will take the place of your ancestors.
You will make them princes in all the earth.
17 I will make your name remembered in all generations.
So the peoples will thank you forever and ever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end there is a blessing for the future: The king will have sons who will rule after him.
The poet promises: Your name will never be forgotten.

PSALMS

Psalm 46

A mighty fortress is our God

God is our refuge VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. By the sons of Korah.
According to Alamoth.
God is our refuge and strength.
A refuge is a safe place.
He is always there to help in times of trouble.
2 So we will not be afraid, even if the earth changes,
even if the mountains are shaken into the middle of the seas,
3 even if its waters roar and foam,
even if the mountains tremble when the sea rises.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"According to Alamoth": probably a note about the music, maybe for high voices (women's or boys' voices).
Psalm 46 inspired Martin Luther to write his famous hymn about the mighty fortress. The hymn says: God is like a mighty fortress. With him we are safe.
Even if the whole world falls apart, if the mountains fall into the sea, if an earthquake or a flood destroys everything: Whoever looks for safety with God does not need to be afraid.

The city of God VERSES 4–7

4 There is a river.
Its streams make the city of God glad,
the holy place where the Most High lives.
5 God is in the middle of her. She will not be shaken.
God will help her when morning comes.
6 The nations were in an uproar. The kingdoms were shaken.
He raised his voice, and the earth melted.
7 The LORD of Armies is with us.
The God of Jacob is our refuge.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Outside, the sea is roaring (verse 3). But in the city of God, a calm river flows that brings joy. Jerusalem actually had no big river, only a spring. The river is a picture of God's blessing (compare Ezekiel 47; Revelation 22:1).
Verse 5: God lives in the middle of the city. That is why it is safe. "When morning comes": The night of fear passes.
Verse 7 is a refrain: "The LORD of Armies is with us." This reminds us of the name "Immanuel," which means "God with us" (Isaiah 7:14).

Be still and know VERSES 8–11

8 Come, see the works of the LORD,
the destruction he has brought on the earth.
9 He makes wars stop all over the world.
He breaks the bow and smashes the spear.
He burns the chariots in the fire.
10 "Be still, and know that I am God.
I will be honored among the nations.
I will be honored on the earth."
11 The LORD of Armies is with us.
The God of Jacob is our refuge.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9 is a great vision of peace: God ends all wars and destroys all weapons (compare Isaiah 2:4: swords are beaten into plowshares).

Verse 10: God himself speaks: "Be still." That means: Stop fighting. Stop your panic and restlessness. Know that I am God.

For many people, this verse is a place of rest in the middle of the noise and rush of life.

PSALMS

PSALM 47

God is King over all the earth

Clap your hands, all you nations! VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. A psalm by the sons of Korah.
Oh, clap your hands, all you nations!
Shout to God with loud cries of joy!
2 For the LORD Most High is awesome.
He is a great King over all the earth.
3 He puts nations under us,
and peoples under our feet.
4 He chooses our land for us to own,
the pride of Jacob, whom he loved.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A joyful psalm. All nations, not only Israel, are called to clap their hands and shout for joy to God.

God is not only the God of one people. He is King over all the earth.

Verse 3 speaks in the language of that time about victory over other peoples. But the whole psalm invites all nations to praise God (verses 1 and 9).

"The pride of Jacob": the land that God gave to Israel.

God has gone up VERSES 5–9

5 God has gone up with shouts of joy,
the LORD with the sound of a trumpet.
6 Sing praises to God! Sing praises!
Sing praises to our King! Sing praises!
7 For God is the King of all the earth.
Sing praises with understanding.
8 God rules over the nations.
God sits on his holy throne.
9 The leaders of the peoples have gathered together
as the people of the God of Abraham.
For the shields of the earth belong to God.
He is highly honored!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: "God has gone up": like a king who goes up to his throne with shouts of joy and the sound of trumpets. Maybe the ark of the covenant was carried up to the temple in a procession.

Christians read this psalm on Ascension Day, because Jesus also went up to God.

Verse 9 is astonishing: The leaders of all peoples gather as "the people of the God of Abraham." God had promised Abraham: "Through you, all the families of the earth will be blessed" (Genesis 12:3). Here it becomes reality.

"The shields of the earth": the powerful people and rulers of the world. They too belong to God.

PSALMS

PSALM 48

The city of God

The LORD is great VERSES 1–3

1 A song. A psalm by the sons of Korah.
The LORD is great, and he is worthy of great praise
in the city of our God, on his holy mountain.
2 Mount Zion is beautiful and high.
It is the joy of the whole earth.
It lies on the sides of the north.
It is the city of the great King.
3 God has shown himself in her strongholds
as a safe refuge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 48 is a "song of Zion," a song about Jerusalem and the temple mountain, Zion.

"On the sides of the north": In old stories of the neighboring peoples, the gods lived on a mountain in the north. The psalm says: The true mountain of God is Zion.

"The city of the great King": Jesus calls Jerusalem this (Matthew 5:35).

The city is not safe because of its walls, but because God is its refuge.

The kings ran away VERSES 4–8

4 For look, the kings gathered together.
They marched past together.
5 They saw it, and they were amazed.
They were terrified. They hurried away.
6 Trembling took hold of them there,
pain like a woman giving birth.
7 With the east wind
you break the ships of Tarshish.
8 What we have heard, we have now seen
in the city of the LORD of Armies,
in the city of our God.

God will make it firm forever.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Enemy kings marched against Jerusalem. But when they saw the city, they became afraid and ran away. People think of the Assyrians under Sennacherib, who had to withdraw (2 Kings 19:35–36).

Verse 7: "Ships of Tarshish" were large trading ships for long voyages. The hot east wind from the desert could destroy them. That is how quickly God can break human power.

Verse 8: "What we have heard, we have now seen": What our ancestors told us, we have now experienced ourselves.

Walk around Zion VERSES 9–14

9 God, we have thought about your loving kindness
in the middle of your temple.
10 God, your name is known to the ends of the earth,
and so is your praise.
Your right hand is full of righteousness.
11 Let Mount Zion be glad!
Let the daughters of Judah be full of joy
because of your judgments.
12 Walk around Zion. Go all the way around her.
Count her towers.
13 Look closely at her walls.
Look at her palaces,
so that you can tell about it to the next generation.
14 For this God is our God forever and ever.
He will guide us even until death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: In the temple, the people think about God's goodness.

"The daughters of Judah": the towns and villages in the land of Judah.

Verses 12–13: A walk around the city. People should look at everything carefully and tell their children about it. Faith is passed on from generation to generation.

Verse 14: "He will guide us even until death": God goes with us our whole life long. In Hebrew, the end of the verse is hard to read. Some translate it "forever" or "beyond death."

PSALMS

Psalm 49

Riches do not save from death

Listen, all you peoples VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. A psalm by the sons of Korah.
Hear this, all you peoples.
Listen, all you who live in the world,
2 both ordinary people and important people,
rich and poor together.
3 My mouth will speak words of wisdom.
My heart will speak with understanding.
4 I will turn my ear to a wise saying.
I will explain my riddle with the harp.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 49 is a psalm of wisdom. It speaks to all people, whether poor or rich, high or low.

Its topic concerns everyone: What do riches mean in the face of death?

No one can buy his way free VERSES 5–12

5 Why should I be afraid in evil days,
when the evil of those who follow at my heels
surrounds me?
6 They trust in their wealth.
They boast about how rich they are.
7 But none of them can in any way set his brother free.
None of them can pay God a ransom for him.
A ransom is a price paid to set someone free.
8 For setting a life free costs too much.
No payment is ever enough
9 for someone to live on forever
and never see decay in the grave.
10 For he sees that wise people die.
In the same way, the foolish and the senseless die.
They leave their wealth to others.
11 Deep inside, they think that their houses will last
forever,
and the places where they live will stay for all
generations.
They name their lands after themselves.
12 But a person does not last, even with all his riches.
He is like the animals that die.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rich people think they can buy anything. But there is one thing they cannot buy: life. No money in the world can stop death.

Verse 10: Death comes to everyone, the wise and the foolish. And the riches are left behind for others.

Verse 11: Some people name lands, buildings or companies after themselves to live on forever. But they also die.

Jesus tells a parable about this: the parable of the rich farmer (Luke 12:16–21).

Death is their shepherd VERSES 13–15

13 This is what happens to foolish people,
and to those who agree with what they say.
Selah.
14 Like a flock of sheep, they are headed for Sheol (the
world of the dead).
Death will be their shepherd.
In the morning, the honest will rule over them.
Their beauty will rot away in Sheol,
far from their great house.
15 But God will set my soul free
from the power of Sheol,
for he will receive me.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14 is a frightening picture: Death is like a shepherd who drives his flock into the place of the dead. This is the opposite of Psalm 23, where God is the good shepherd.

Verse 15 is the high point of the psalm: No one can buy his way free. But God can! "He will receive me": The Hebrew word is the same as for Enoch, whom God had "taken" (Genesis 5:24). Here we see a hope beyond death.

He takes nothing with him VERSES 16–20

16 Do not be afraid when someone becomes rich,
when the splendor of his house grows.
17 For when he dies, he will take nothing with him.
His splendor will not go down into the grave after him.
18 While he lived, he called himself happy.
And people praise you when you do well for yourself.
19 But he will go to the generation of his ancestors.
They will never see the light.
20 A person who has riches but no understanding
is like the animals that die.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A German saying goes: "The last shirt has no pockets." The psalm says the same thing: When we die, we take nothing with us (compare 1 Timothy 6:7).

Verse 20 repeats verse 12, but with one important difference: "no understanding." Riches are not bad in themselves. What is bad is riches without understanding, when people forget that they will die and that they need God.

PSALMS

PSALM 50

God judges his people

God is coming VERSES 1–6

1 A psalm by Asaph.
The Mighty One, God, the LORD, speaks.
He calls the earth from where the sun rises to where it sets.
2 Out of Zion, the most beautiful place of all,
God shines out.
3 Our God is coming, and he will not stay silent.
A fire burns up everything in front of him.
A great storm rages around him.
4 He calls to the heavens above and to the earth,
so that he can judge his people:
5 "Gather to me those who are faithful to me,
those who have made a covenant with me by sacrifice."
A covenant is a binding agreement.
6 The heavens will announce his righteousness,
for God himself is judge.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Asaph was a musician and singer in David's time (1 Chronicles 16:4–7). His name is on 12 psalms (Psalm 50 and Psalms 73–83).

God appears as if at a great trial in court. Heaven and earth are the witnesses.

It is not about the other nations, but about God's own people. God tests whether they take the covenant seriously.

I do not need your sacrifices VERSES 7–15

7 "Listen, my people, and I will speak.
Israel, I will speak as a witness against you.
I am God, your God.
8 I do not blame you for your sacrifices.
Your burnt offerings are always in front of me.
9 I do not need a bull from your barn,
or male goats from your pens.
10 For every animal of the forest is mine,
and the cattle on 1,000 hills.
11 I know all the birds of the mountains.
The wild animals of the field are mine.
12 If I were hungry, I would not tell you,
for the world is mine, and everything in it.
13 Do I eat the meat of bulls,
or drink the blood of goats?
14 Bring thanks to God as your sacrifice.
Keep the promises you have made to the Most High.
15 Call on me in the day of trouble.
I will rescue you, and you will honor me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God does not blame his people for not bringing sacrifices. They bring enough. But they think about the sacrifices in the wrong way: as if God needed them, as if they had to feed him.

God does not need anything. The whole world belongs to him anyway.

What God really wants: thankfulness, keeping your promises and trust in times of trouble.

Verse 15 is a well-known promise: "Call on me in the day of trouble. I will rescue you."

A word to the hypocrites VERSES 16–21

16 But to the wicked God says,
"What right do you have to list my laws
and to talk about my covenant?
17 For you hate correction,
and you throw my words behind you.
18 When you saw a thief, you went along with him.
You joined in with people who commit adultery.
19 "You let your mouth speak evil.
Your tongue makes up lies.
20 You sit and speak against your brother.
You tell lies about your own mother's son.
21 You have done these things, and I stayed silent.
You thought that I was just like you.
But I will correct you,
and I will lay out the charges right in front of your eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now God speaks to the hypocrites: They talk about God's commandments, but they do not live by them. They steal, commit adultery, lie and speak badly about their own brothers and sisters.

Verse 21: Because God stayed silent, they thought he was like them: that he did not care about evil. But that is a mistake. God's patience does not mean that he does not care (compare 2 Peter 3:9).

Whoever gives thanks honors me VERSES 22–23

22 "Now think about this, you who forget God,
or I will tear you to pieces,
and there will be no one to rescue you.
23 Whoever brings thanks as a sacrifice honors me.
He prepares the way
on which I will show him God's salvation."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A serious warning, but also an invitation to turn back.

The psalm ends with a promise: Whoever thanks God and walks on the right way will experience God's rescue.

PSALMS

PSALM 51

Create in me a clean heart, O God

Have mercy on me VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. A psalm by David,
when Nathan the prophet came to him,
after David had slept with Bathsheba.
Have mercy on me, God,
because of your loving kindness.
Because your mercy is so great,
wipe out my wrongs.
2 Wash all my guilt away from me.
Make me clean from my sin.
3 For I know my wrongs.
My sin is always in front of me.
4 Against you, and you only, I have sinned.
I have done what is evil in your eyes.
So you are right when you speak,
and you are fair when you judge.
5 Look, I was born in guilt.
My mother became pregnant with me in sin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 51 is the best-known psalm of repentance. The superscription reminds us of the worst moment in David's life: He had committed adultery with Bathsheba and had her husband Uriah killed. The prophet Nathan confronted him with his guilt (2 Samuel 11–12).

Note: In some Bibles, the superscription takes up two verses. That is why every verse there is 2 higher (for example, verse 10 here = verse 12 there).

David makes no excuses. He only asks for grace. He does not deserve it. He asks because of God's goodness and mercy.

Verse 4: "Against you, and you only, I have sinned": Of course David also did great wrong to Bathsheba and Uriah. But he understands: In the end, every sin is also a sin against God.

Verse 5: This does not mean that sex or birth is sinful. David says: From the very beginning, I have been a person who tends to sin. Christians speak here of "original sin." Jewish interpreters understand the verse rather as a strong expression of deep regret.

Wash me, and I will be whiter than snow VERSES 6–9

6 Look, you want truth deep inside a person.
In the hidden places of my heart, you teach me wisdom.
7 Make me pure with hyssop, and I will be clean.
Wash me, and I will be whiter than snow.
8 Let me hear joy and gladness,
so that the bones you have broken may be full of joy.
9 Turn your face away from my sins.
Wipe out all my guilt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God wants honesty deep inside. You cannot fool him.

Hyssop is a small plant. Priests used a bundle of hyssop to sprinkle water or blood, to make people clean for worship (for example Leviticus 14:4–7; Numbers 19:18).

"Whiter than snow": That is how completely God can forgive (compare Isaiah 1:18).

Verse 8: The guilt has broken David inside. He asks: Let me feel joy again.

A clean heart VERSES 10–13

10 Create in me a clean heart, O God.
Make my spirit new and right again.
11 Do not throw me away from your presence.
Do not take your Holy Spirit from me.
12 Give me back the joy of your salvation.
Hold me up with a willing spirit.
13 Then I will teach those who do wrong your ways.
Sinners will turn back to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10 is one of the best-known verses in the Bible. Many people sing it as a song: "Create in me a clean heart, O God."

"Create": The Hebrew has the same word as in Genesis 1:1 ("God created"). Only God can create a new heart. A person cannot make himself new.

Verse 11: David had seen how God's Spirit left Saul (1 Samuel 16:14). He is afraid that the same thing will happen to him.

Verse 13: Whoever has experienced forgiveness can show others the way to God.

A broken heart VERSES 14–17

14 God, rescue me from the guilt of killing someone.
You are the God who saves me.

My tongue will sing out loud about your
righteousness.
15 Lord, open my lips.
And my mouth will tell your praise.
16 For you do not want sacrifices,
or I would bring them.
You take no pleasure in burnt offerings.
17 The sacrifices God wants are a broken spirit.
God, you will not turn away
a heart that is broken and sorry for its sin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "The guilt of killing someone": David is guilty of Uriah's death. He asks God to free him from this heavy guilt.

Verse 15: "Lord, open my lips": To this day, many Christians and Jews begin their prayer with this sentence.

Verses 16–17: For murder and adultery, the law had no sacrifice that could make up for the guilt. David can only bring himself: a broken heart that is sorry. And God does not turn it away.

Build the walls of Jerusalem VERSES 18–19

18 Be good to Zion, as it pleases you.
Build the walls of Jerusalem.
19 Then you will be pleased with the right sacrifices,
with burnt offerings and whole burnt offerings.
Then people will offer bulls on your altar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These last verses were probably added later, when Jerusalem had been destroyed (after 586 BC). The community took David's prayer as their own prayer for forgiveness and a new beginning.

Verse 19 does not contradict verse 16: When the heart is right, then God is also pleased with the sacrifices again.

Psalm 51 shows: Even after the worst guilt, there is a way back to God. Not through excuses, but through honest confession and trust in God's mercy.

PSALMS

PSALM 52

Like a green olive tree

Why do you boast about evil? VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. A contemplation by David,
when Doeg the Edomite came and told Saul,
"David has come to Ahimelech's house."
Why do you boast about the evil you do, you mighty man?
God's loving kindness lasts all the time.
2 Your tongue plans ruin.
It is like a sharp razor, and it works with lies.
3 You love evil more than good.
You love lying more than speaking the truth.
Selah.
4 You love all words that destroy,
you lying tongue.
5 So God will also destroy you forever.
He will grab you and pull you out of your tent.
He will pull you up by the roots
from the land of the living.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The superscription reminds us of a terrible story: David was fleeing from Saul. The priest Ahimelech gave him bread. Doeg, a man from Edom, told Saul about it. Then Saul had 85 priests killed, and Doeg carried out the murder (1 Samuel 21–22).

Doeg is an example of a person who causes harm with his tongue. His words are like a sharp razor.

Verse 1: In the middle of this accusation there is a strong sentence: "God's loving kindness lasts all the time." Evil is powerful, but God's goodness is stronger and lasts longer.

Like a green olive tree VERSES 6–9

6 The righteous will also see it and be filled with awe.
They will laugh at him and say,
7 "Look, this is the man who did not make God his strength.
He trusted in his great riches
and made himself strong by his evil."
8 But as for me, I am like a green olive tree in God's house.
I trust in God's loving kindness forever and ever.
9 I will thank you forever, because you have done it.
I will hope in your name, for it is good,
in front of those who are faithful to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The evil man will be pulled up "by the roots" (verse 5). But the righteous person is like an olive tree that is firmly rooted in the ground and stays green.

Olive trees grow very old, some more than 1,000 years. They are a picture of lasting strength and blessing.

"In God's house": Trees may have grown in the temple area. Whoever lives close to God stays alive and bears fruit (compare Psalm 1:3).

PSALMS

PSALM 53

The fool says: There is no God

No one does good VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. To the tune of "Mahalath." A
contemplation by David.
The fool has said in his heart, "There is no God."
They are rotten. They have done disgusting evil.
There is no one who does good.
2 God looks down from heaven on all people,
to see if there is anyone who understands,
anyone who looks for God.
3 Every one of them has turned away.
They have all become filthy together.
There is no one who does good, no, not one.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 53 is almost the same as Psalm 14 (see there). The difference: Here it always says "God" (Elohim). In Psalm 14 it mostly says "LORD." This fits the second book of the Psalms, which mostly says "God."

The fact that the same psalm appears twice shows: The book of Psalms grew together from several older collections.

"Mahalath": maybe a tune or an instrument. The meaning is uncertain. Some think of "sickness" or "round dance."

They were afraid where there was nothing to fear VERSES 4–6

4 Do those who do evil have no understanding?
They eat up my people the way people eat bread.
They do not call on God.
5 There they were filled with great fear,
where there was nothing to fear.
For God has scattered the bones
of the one who set up camp against you.
You have put them to shame,
because God has rejected them.
6 Oh, that the salvation of Israel would come out of Zion!
When God brings his people back from captivity,
then Jacob will be full of joy, and Israel will be glad.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5 is different from Psalm 14:5–6. Here it is about an enemy army that surrounds Jerusalem. Suddenly the enemies become afraid, even though there is no reason to be seen. God has made them run away. Their bones lie scattered on the field.

Verse 6: The WEB says here "brings his people back from captivity." The Hebrew word can also mean that God "turns things around for his people" (compare Psalm 14:7).

PSALMS

PSALM 54

God is my helper

Save me, God VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. On stringed instruments. A
contemplation by David,
when the Ziphites came and said to Saul,
"Isn't David hiding among us?"
Save me, God, by your name.
Prove that I am in the right by your power.
2 Hear my prayer, God.
Listen to the words of my mouth.
3 For strangers have risen up against me.
Violent men want to take my life.
They do not care about God.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The superscription reminds us how the people of the town of Ziph betrayed David to Saul when he was hiding among them (1 Samuel 23:19; 26:1).

David is betrayed, surrounded and in danger of his life. He has only one hope left: God.

"By your name": God's name stands for God himself, for his power and faithfulness.

God is my helper VERSES 4–7

4 Look, God is my helper.
The Lord is the one who keeps my soul alive.
5 He will pay back my enemies for their evil.
Destroy them, because you are faithful.
6 I will bring you a sacrifice
that I give freely.
I will thank your name, LORD, for it is good.
7 For he has rescued me from all trouble.
My eyes have seen my enemies defeated.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4 is the turning point: "Look, God is my helper." In the middle of the danger, David realizes: I am not alone.

Verse 5: David asks that the evil of his enemies may fall back on them. He does not take revenge himself. In fact, David later spared Saul's life twice (1 Samuel 24 and 26).

Verse 6: An offering given freely is a thank offering that people bring out of joy, not out of duty.

PSALMS

PSALM 55

Betrayed by a friend

If only I had wings like a dove VERSES 1–8

1 For the music director. On stringed instruments. A
contemplation by David.
Listen to my prayer, God.
Do not hide from me when I beg you for help.

2 Pay attention to me, and answer me.
I am restless in my complaint, and I groan
3 because of the voice of the enemy,
because the wicked oppress me.
For they bring suffering on me.
In their anger they hold a grudge against me.
4 My heart is in great pain inside me.
The terrors of death have fallen on me.
5 Fear and trembling have come over me.
Horror has overwhelmed me.
6 I said, "Oh, if only I had wings like a dove!
Then I would fly away and be at rest.
7 Look, then I would wander far away.
I would stay in the wilderness."
Selah.
8 "I would hurry to a shelter
from the stormy wind and the storm."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one who prays is in fear of death. He is so worn out that all he wants is to get away.

Verse 6: "If only I had wings like a dove!": Just fly away, leave everything behind and find rest. Many people know this wish in hard times.

The composer Felix Mendelssohn set this verse to music: "O for the wings of a dove."

If this wish turns into a longing not to be here at all anymore: Talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Violence in the city VERSES 9–11

9 Confuse them, Lord, and mix up their language,
for I have seen violence and fighting in the city.
10 Day and night they prowl around on its walls.
Evil and abuse are also inside the city.
11 Forces of destruction are inside it.
Threats and lies never leave its streets.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The city, which should be a place of safety, is full of violence, injustice and lies.

Verse 9: "Mix up their language": This reminds us of the tower of Babel (Genesis 11). When evil people can no longer understand each other, they cannot carry out their plans.

It was my friend VERSES 12–15

12 For it was not an enemy who insulted me.
I could have put up with that.
It was not someone who hated me who rose up against me.
I could have hidden from him.
13 But it was you, a man like me,
my companion and my close friend.
14 We enjoyed sweet friendship together.
We walked with the crowd in God's house.
15 Let death come on them suddenly.
Let them go down alive into Sheol (the world of the dead).
For evil is among them, in their homes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the deepest pain in this psalm: The betrayal does not come from an enemy, but from a close friend. Someone with whom he had prayed and worshiped God.

Some think of Ahithophel, David's advisor, who went over to Absalom's side (2 Samuel 15:12, 31). Christians also think of Judas, who betrayed Jesus.

Verse 15 is a curse that comes from deep pain. It reminds us of Korah and his followers, who were swallowed alive by the earth (Numbers 16:30–33). The one who prays tells God about his anger instead of taking revenge himself. Later, Jesus shows another way: He prays for his enemies (Luke 23:34).

Evening, morning and noon VERSES 16–21

16 As for me, I will call to God,
and the LORD will save me.
17 In the evening, in the morning and at noon,
I will cry out in my trouble,
and he will hear my voice.
18 He has set my soul free and brought me peace
from the battle that was against me,
even though many are against me.
19 God, who has ruled on his throne forever,
will hear and answer them.
Selah.
They never change, and they do not fear God.
20 He raises his hands against his friends.
He has broken his covenant.
21 His mouth was as smooth as butter,
but his heart was set on war.
His words were softer than oil,
yet they were swords ready to strike.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Praying three times a day: in the evening, in the morning and at noon. Later, Daniel also prayed like this (Daniel 6:10). Jews still pray three times a day today. In the Jewish calendar, the day begins in the evening.

Verse 21: A fitting picture of a false friend: His words are soft as butter, but a sword is hidden behind them.

Cast your burden on the LORD VERSES 22–23

22 Cast your burden on the LORD, and he will take care of you.
He will never let the righteous be shaken.
23 But you, God, will bring them down
into the pit of destruction.
Violent and lying people
will not live out half their days.
But I will trust in you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22 is one of the best-known verses of comfort in the Bible: "Cast your burden on the LORD." Peter takes it up: "Cast all your worries on him, because he cares for you" (1 Peter 5:7).

The psalm ends with a simple sentence: "But I will trust in you." Despite betrayal and violence, the one who prays holds on to God.

PSALM 56

When I am afraid, I trust in you

When I am afraid VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. To the tune of "Silent Dove in
Distant Lands."
A poem by David, when the Philistines caught him in
Gath.
Be merciful to me, God, for people want to swallow me
up.
All day long they attack me and oppress me.
2 My enemies want to swallow me up all day long,
for there are many who proudly fight against me.
3 When I am afraid,
I will put my trust in you.
4 In God, I praise his word.
In God, I put my trust. I will not be afraid.
What can mere human beings do to me?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The superscription reminds us of David's flight to the Philistines in Gath (1 Samuel 21:10–15; compare Psalm 34).

"Silent Dove in Distant Lands": the name of a tune. It fits David: far away from home, without protection, like a dove.

Verse 3 is very simple and honest: "When I am afraid, I will put my trust in you." Faith does not mean never being afraid. Faith means going to God with your fear.

Verse 4: "What can mere human beings do to me?" People can do a lot of harm, but they do not have the last word.

You collect my tears VERSES 5–9

5 All day long they twist my words.
All their thoughts are against me, to do me harm.
6 They plot together and lie in wait.
They watch my steps.
They are eager to take my life.
7 Will they get away with their evil?
God, in your anger, bring down the peoples.
8 You count the places where I have wandered.
You put my tears into your bottle.
Aren't they written in your book?
9 Then my enemies will turn back
on the day that I call.
I know this: God is for me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8 is one of the most tender pictures in the Bible: God collects every tear in a bottle. He writes them in his book. No tear is forgotten. God knows exactly how often and how much we have suffered.

Verse 9: "God is for me." Later Paul says, "If God is for us, who can be against us?" (Romans 8:31).

What can people do to me? VERSES 10–13

10 In God, I will praise his word.
In the LORD, I will praise his word.
11 I have put my trust in God. I will not be afraid.
What can people do to me?
12 God, I am bound by the promises I made to you.
I will bring you offerings of thanks.
13 For you have rescued my soul from death.
You have kept my feet from falling,
so that I may walk before God
in the light of the living.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11 repeat the refrain of verse 4.

Verse 12: David had made a promise to God when he was in trouble. Now he wants to keep his promise and thank God.

"In the light of the living": God has kept David from death, so that he can live and serve God.

PSALMS

PSALM 57

In the shadow of your wings

Until the disaster has passed VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. To the tune of "Do Not
Destroy."
A poem by David, when he fled from Saul into the
cave.
Be merciful to me, God, be merciful to me,
for my soul comes to you for safety.
Yes, I will find safety in the shadow of your wings
until the disaster has passed.
2 I cry out to God Most High,
to God who does for me what I ask.
3 He will send help from heaven and save me.
He scolds the one who is chasing me.
Selah.
God will send out his loving kindness and his truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The superscription reminds us of David's flight from Saul. David hid in a cave, and Saul came into that very cave. David could have killed him, but he spared his life (1 Samuel 24; compare 1 Samuel 22:1).

"Do Not Destroy": the name of a tune. It fits David, who did not want to destroy Saul.

"In the shadow of your wings": In the dark cave, David feels like a chick under its mother's wings. He waits "until the disaster has passed."

Among lions VERSES 4–6

4 My soul is among lions.
I lie among people who breathe out fire,
people whose teeth are spears and arrows,
and whose tongue is a sharp sword.

5 Be lifted up, God, above the heavens!
Let your glory be over all the earth!
6 They have set a net for my steps.
My soul is bowed down.
They dig a pit in front of me.
But they fall into the middle of it themselves.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The enemies are like wild animals. Their words are like weapons.

Verse 5 is a refrain. In the middle of danger, David praises God. He looks away from the enemies and toward God's greatness.

Verse 6: Again the picture of the pit: The enemies fall into their own trap.

I will wake up the dawn VERSES 7–11

7 My heart is steady, God. My heart is steady.
I will sing. Yes, I will sing praises.
8 Wake up, my soul!
Wake up, lute and harp!
I will wake up the dawn.
9 I will thank you, Lord, among the peoples.
I will sing praises to you among the nations.
10 For your great loving kindness reaches to the heavens,
and your truth reaches to the skies.
11 Be lifted up, God, above the heavens!
Let your glory be over all the earth!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: "My heart is steady": The fear has given way to firm trust.

Verse 8: A beautiful picture: David wants to sing so early that he wakes up the dawn. He does not wait until it gets light. His praise comes before the light.

Verses 7–11 appear again almost exactly in Psalm 108:1–5.

PSALMS

PSALM 58

There is a God who judges

Unjust judges VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. To the tune of "Do Not Destroy." A poem by David.
Do you really speak what is right, you silent ones?
Do you judge fairly, you human beings?
2 No, in your heart you plan injustice.
On the earth you hand out the violence of your hands.
3 The wicked go the wrong way from the womb.
They go astray from the day they are born, and they tell lies.
4 Their poison is like the poison of a snake,
like a deaf cobra that closes its ear.
5 It does not listen to the voice of the snake charmers,
no matter how skilled the charmer may be.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 58 accuses unjust judges and rulers. They should make sure that justice is done. But they stay silent about injustice and use violence themselves.

Verse 1: "You silent ones": The Hebrew word is uncertain. Others translate "you gods" or "you mighty ones." It means those who have power over others.

Verses 4–5: They are like a poisonous snake that acts as if it were deaf. No advice, however good, reaches them.

Break their teeth VERSES 6–9

6 God, break the teeth in their mouths.
LORD, break out the big teeth of the young lions.
7 Let them disappear like water that flows away.
When they pull back the bow,
let their arrows have no point.
8 Let them be like a snail that melts away and is gone,
like a baby born dead, who has never seen the sun.
9 Before your pots can feel the heat of the burning thorns,
he will sweep away both the green and the burning wood.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the harshest psalms. The one who prays asks God to break the power of the unjust rulers. "Break their teeth": take away their ability to "tear others apart."

The pictures are drastic: The wicked should disappear like water in the sand, like a snail in the sun (back then, people believed that snails melted in the heat).

Verse 8: The picture of the baby born dead is very painful for readers today. It is not a judgment about children who were not able to live, or about their parents. It is a poetic picture of something that passes away before it can have any effect. If you have lost a child yourself: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 9 is very hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: God's judgment comes as fast as a storm, before the fire under the cooking pot is really burning.

There is a God who judges VERSES 10–11

10 The righteous will be glad when he sees the punishment.
He will wash his feet in the blood of the wicked.
11 Then people will say,
"Surely there is a reward for the righteous.
Surely there is a God who judges the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10 is very hard to bear. The picture of washing feet in blood comes from the language of war in the ancient Near East. It shows the wish that injustice will be defeated once and for all.

What matters is this: The one who prays does not take revenge himself. He leaves the judgment to God. And the goal is verse 11: Everyone should see that there is justice, that injustice does not have the last word.

For people who suffer under brutal injustice, this psalm is a cry for justice.

But: This psalm does not give permission to be glad about the suffering or death of other people, or to use violence.

The Bible also says, "Don't be glad when your enemy falls!" (Proverbs 24:17). Jesus teaches: "Love your enemies ... And pray for those who treat you badly and persecute you" (Matthew 5:44).

PSALMS

Psalm 59

God is my fortress

Rescue me from my enemies VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. To the tune of "Do Not Destroy."
A poem by David, when Saul sent men,
and they watched the house to kill him.
Rescue me from my enemies, my God.
Put me in a high, safe place,
away from those who rise up against me.
2 Rescue me from those who do evil.
Save me from violent men.
3 For look, they lie in wait for my life.
The powerful gather together against me.
It is not because I disobeyed, and not because of my sin, LORD.
4 I have done nothing wrong,
yet they are ready to attack me.
Rise up, look, and help me!
5 You, LORD God of Armies, the God of Israel,
wake up to punish the nations.
Show no mercy to the wicked traitors.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The superscription reminds us of a night when Saul's men surrounded David's house. His wife Michal helped him escape through a window (1 Samuel 19:11–17).

David is innocent. He has done nothing, and still he is hunted.

"The nations": The psalm looks beyond David's personal enemies to all who fight against God's people.

Like dogs in the night VERSES 6–10

6 They come back in the evening,
howling like dogs,
and they prowl around the city.
7 Look, they spit out words with their mouths.
Swords are on their lips.
"For," they say, "who hears us?"
8 But you, LORD, laugh at them.
You make fun of all the nations.
9 Oh, my Strength, I watch for you,
for God is my high tower.
10 My God will come to meet me with his loving kindness.
God will let me look down on my enemies in victory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people hunting David are like stray dogs that roam the streets at night, howling. Back then, street dogs were dangerous and despised.

They think: "Who hears us?" They believe that no one sees the wrong they do. But God hears and sees everything.

Verse 9: Like a watchman in the night, David waits for God.

Do not kill them VERSES 11–13

11 Do not kill them, or my people may forget.
Scatter them by your power, and bring them down,
Lord, our shield.
12 Because of the sin of their mouths
and the words of their lips,
let them be caught in their pride,
because of the curses and lies that they speak.
13 Destroy them in your anger.
Destroy them, so that they are no more.
Let them know that God rules in Jacob,
to the ends of the earth.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11 is surprising: "Do not kill them." David does not want God to destroy the enemies right away. They should remain as a warning, so that the people do not forget how God rescues.

Verse 13 then does sound harsh. But the goal is: Everyone should know that God rules. It probably means: God should destroy their power, not necessarily their lives.

In the morning I will sing VERSES 14–17

14 Let them come back in the evening.
Let them howl like a dog
and prowl around the city.
15 They will wander around looking for food.
They will wait all night if they do not get enough.
16 But I will sing about your strength.
Yes, in the morning I will sing out loud about your loving kindness.
For you have been my high tower,
a safe place on the day of my trouble.
17 To you, my Strength, I will sing praises.
For God is my high tower,
the God who shows me mercy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The enemies howl in the night, hungry and dissatisfied.

David, on the other hand, sings in the morning. The night of fear is over.

Verse 17: "The God who shows me mercy": word for word, "my God of loving kindness." God is not only strong, but also loving.

Psalm 60

With God we will do brave deeds

You have rejected us VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. To the tune of "The Lily of the Covenant." A teaching poem by David,
when he fought against Aram Naharaim and Aram Zobah,
and Joab returned and killed 12,000 men of Edom in the Valley of Salt.
God, you have rejected us.
You have broken us down. You have been angry.
Make us whole again.
2 You have made the land shake. You have torn it open.
Heal its cracks, for it is shaking.
3 You have made your people see hard things.
You have made us drink wine that makes us stagger.
4 You have given a banner to those who fear you,
so that they can raise it because of the truth.
Selah.
5 Save us with your right hand and answer us,
so that the people you love may be rescued.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The superscription reminds us of David's wars against the Arameans and the Edomites (2 Samuel 8; 1 Chronicles 18). 2 Samuel 8:13 and 1 Chronicles 18:12 speak of 18,000 dead. The numbers in old traditions sometimes differ from each other.

Note: In some Bibles, the superscription takes up two verses. That is why every verse there is 2 higher.

In the middle of the war, Israel has suffered a terrible defeat. It feels like an earthquake that tears the land apart.

"Wine that makes us stagger": wine that makes you drunk, so that you sway back and forth. A picture of confusion and helplessness.

God has spoken VERSES 6–8

6 God has spoken from his holy place:
"I will win the victory.
I will divide up Shechem
and measure out the valley of Succoth.
7 Gilead is mine, and Manasseh is mine.
Ephraim is the helmet that protects my head.
Judah is my scepter.
8 Moab is my washbasin.
I will throw my sandal on Edom.
I shout in triumph over Philistia."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers with a promise: The whole land belongs to me.

Shechem, Succoth, Gilead, Manasseh, Ephraim and Judah: These are areas of Israel. They are like God's equipment: Ephraim is his helmet, Judah is his ruler's staff.

Verse 7: A scepter is a royal staff, a sign of a king's power.

The neighboring peoples are compared with household objects: Moab is the "washbasin" in which you wash your feet. "Throwing a sandal on Edom" was a sign of claiming ownership (compare Ruth 4:7).

This is the picture language of that time. It means: God is the Lord over all peoples.

Human help is worth nothing VERSES 9–12

9 Who will bring me into the strong city?
Who has led me to Edom?
10 God, haven't you rejected us?
You do not go out with our armies, God.
11 Give us help against the enemy,
for human help is worth nothing.
12 With God we will do brave deeds,
for he is the one who will trample our enemies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The strong city": probably Petra or Bozrah, the strongly fortified capital of Edom.

Verse 11: "Human help is worth nothing": Without God, even the best army does not help.

Verse 12: With God, courage is possible. Verses 5–12 appear again almost exactly in Psalm 108:6–13.

PSALMS

Psalm 61

Lead me to the rock

I call from the end of the earth VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. For a stringed instrument. By David.
Hear my cry, God!
Listen to my prayer!
2 From the end of the earth I call to you
when my heart is overwhelmed.
Lead me to the rock that is higher than I am.
3 For you have been a safe place for me,
a strong tower against the enemy.
4 I will live in your tent forever.
I will find safety in the shelter of your wings.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying is far away, "at the end of the earth." He feels far from God and worn out.

"Lead me to the rock that is higher than I am": He cannot climb up to the safe place by himself. God must lead him.

"Live in your tent": to be close to God, like a guest who finds protection with God.

For the king VERSES 5–8

5 For you, God, have heard my vows.
You have given me the inheritance of those who fear your name.
6 You will make the king's life long.
His years will last for generations.
7 He will sit on his throne in God's presence forever.
Appoint your loving kindness and truth to guard him.
8 So I will sing praise to your name forever,
so that I keep my vows every day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: A prayer for the king. God should give him a long life.

"For generations" and "forever": This goes beyond a single human life. Jews and Christians have understood this as being about the Messiah, the eternal king from David's family.

"Loving kindness and truth" are like two bodyguards who protect the king.

PSALMS

PSALM 62

My soul is quiet before God

God alone VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. For Jeduthun. A psalm by David.
My soul finds rest in God alone.
My rescue comes from him.
2 He alone is my rock, my rescue and my fortress.
I will never be badly shaken.
3 How long will you attack a man?
Do all of you want to throw him down
like a leaning wall, like a shaky fence?
4 They fully plan to push him down from his high place.
They love lies.
With their mouths they bless,
but inside they curse.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 62 is a psalm of deep trust. In Hebrew, the word "alone" (or "only") appears six times. Only with God does the one praying find rest.

"My soul finds rest": Literally, it says "is silence." The restlessness inside stops when a person relies on God completely.

Verse 3: The enemies want to knock him over like a wall that is already leaning. But he stands firm, because God is his rock.

Verse 4: Hypocrites: friendly words, evil thoughts.

Pour out your heart before him VERSES 5–8

5 My soul, wait quietly for God alone,
for my hope comes from him.
6 He alone is my rock and my rescue, my fortress.
I will not be shaken.
7 My rescue and my honor are with God.
The rock of my strength and my refuge are in God.
8 Trust in him at all times, you people!
Pour out your heart before him!
God is a refuge for us.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6 repeat verses 1–2, but with a small difference: In verse 2 it said "never be badly shaken," now it says "not be shaken." The trust has grown.

Verse 8 is a beautiful invitation to everyone: "Pour out your heart before him!" You may tell God everything that moves you, just as you empty a jug completely.

Power belongs to God VERSES 9–12

9 Surely ordinary people are only a breath,
and important people are a lie.
On the scales they go up.
All together they are lighter than a breath.
10 Don't trust in oppressing others!
Don't put empty hope in robbery!
If your riches grow, don't set your heart on them!
11 God has spoken once.
Twice I have heard this:
that power belongs to God.
12 Lord, loving kindness also belongs to you,
for you pay back each person according to what he has done.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: All people, poor or rich, are only a "breath" before God. On a scale, they would be lighter than air.

Verse 10: A warning: Do not trust in violence and riches. "If your riches grow, don't set your heart on them!" That is still true today.

Verses 11–12: Two things belong to God: power and loving kindness. God is strong, but also loving. Both together make him worthy of trust.

Paul quotes verse 12 in Romans 2:6.

PSALMS

PSALM 63

My soul thirsts for you

In a dry land VERSES 1–4

1 A psalm by David, when he was in the desert of Judah.
God, you are my God. I will seek you with all my heart.
My soul thirsts for you.
My body longs for you
in a dry and tired land, where there is no water.
2 So I have looked at you in the sanctuary,
to see your power and your glory.
The sanctuary is the holy place of God.
3 For your loving kindness is better than life.
My lips will praise you.
4 So I will bless you as long as I live.
I will lift up my hands in your name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is in the desert of Judah, perhaps running away from Saul or from Absalom. It is hot and dry.

Just as a person in the desert thirsts for water, David longs for God, with body and soul.

Verse 3 is a deep sentence: "Your loving kindness is better than life." God's love is the most precious thing there is, more precious than life itself.

In the early church, Psalm 63 was prayed every morning.

In the shadow of your wings VERSES 5–8

5 My soul will be satisfied, as if with the richest food.
My mouth will praise you with joyful lips,
6 when I remember you on my bed
and think about you during the watches of the night.
7 For you have been my help.
I will shout for joy in the shadow of your wings.
8 My soul stays close to you.
Your right hand holds me up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the desert, David is satisfied, not by food, but by God.

Verse 6: Even at night, when he cannot sleep, he thinks about God. "Watches of the night": The night was divided into three watches.

Verse 8: A beautiful picture of our relationship with God: "My soul stays close to you. Your right hand holds me up." A person holds on to God, and God holds on to him.

The king rejoices VERSES 9–11

9 But those who want to take my life and destroy it
will go down into the depths of the earth.
10 They will be handed over to the power of the sword.
They will become food for jackals.
11 But the king will rejoice in God.
Everyone who swears by him will praise him,
for the mouths of those who tell lies will be shut.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The enemies who want to kill David will die themselves. Back then, this was a terrible fate: not to be buried.

The one praying does not take revenge himself. He trusts that God will make sure that justice is done.

Verse 11: In the end, the king rejoices in God, and the liars must be silent.

PSALMS

PSALM 64

Against the arrows of evil words

Their tongue is like a sword VERSES 1–6

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
Hear my voice, God, when I complain to you!
Keep my life safe from fear of the enemy!
2 Hide me from the secret plans of the wicked,
from the noisy crowd of those who do evil.
3 They sharpen their tongues like swords.
They aim their arrows, deadly words,
4 to shoot at innocent people from hiding places.
They shoot at him suddenly and without fear.
5 They encourage each other in evil plans.
They talk about setting traps in secret.
They say, "Who will see them?"
6 They plan injustice and say, "We have made a perfect plan!"
Surely the mind and heart of a person are full of tricks.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is about attacks with words: slander, lies, rumors, secret schemes. Words can kill like arrows.

We know this today too, for example through bullying or hate on the internet.

The attackers feel safe: "Who will see them?" They think their plan is perfect.

God shoots back VERSES 7–10

7 But God will shoot at them.
Suddenly they will be struck down by an arrow.
8 Their own tongues will ruin them.
All who see them will shake their heads.
9 All people will be afraid.
They will tell about the work of God
and wisely think about what he has done.
10 The righteous will be glad in the LORD
and will find safety in him.
All whose hearts are honest will praise him!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The turning point: The attackers shot "suddenly" (verse 4), but now they themselves are "suddenly" struck (verse 7). Their own words ruin them.

God makes sure that evil falls back on the one who does it. The one praying does not have to strike back himself.

In the end, all people see that God is just.

PSALMS

Psalm 65

You crown the year with your blessing

God hears prayer and forgives VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. A psalm by David. A song.
Praise waits for you, God, in Zion.
People will keep the vows they made to you.
2 You who hear prayer,
all people will come to you.
3 My sins were too much for me,
but you made atonement for our wrongdoings.
That means: You took away our guilt.
4 Happy is the one whom you choose and let come near,
so that he may live in your courts.
We will be filled with the good things of your house,
your holy temple.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 65 is a song of thanks, perhaps for the harvest festival.

"Praise waits for you": In the temple, praise is already waiting, ready for God. Others translate: "Silence and praise are fitting for you."

"You who hear prayer": That is a beautiful name for God.

Verse 3: God forgives sins that are too much for a person. That is the foundation for everything else.

The hope of all the ends of the earth VERSES 5–8

5 With awesome deeds of righteousness you answer us,
God who saves us.
You are the hope of all the ends of the earth
and of those who are far away on the sea.
6 By your power you form the mountains.
You have put on strength like a belt.
7 You calm the roaring of the seas,
the roaring of their waves,
and the uproar of the nations.
8 Even those who live in faraway places are afraid of your wonders.
You make the dawn of the morning and the evening
sing with joy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is not only the God of Israel. He is "the hope of all the ends of the earth."

He made the mountains, and he calms the raging sea. He also brings the raging nations to rest. Later, Jesus calmed the storm on the lake (Mark 4:39).

Verse 8: From the sunrise in the east to the sunset in the west, the whole world shouts for joy.

You crown the year VERSES 9–13

9 You take care of the earth and water it.
You make it very rich.
The river of God is full of water.
You give people grain, for that is what you have decided.
10 You soak its furrows.
You level its ridges.
You soften it with rain showers.
You bless its crops.
11 You crown the year with your good gifts.
Your carts overflow with plenty.
12 The grasslands of the wilderness overflow.
The hills are dressed in gladness.
13 The pastures are covered with flocks.
The valleys are dressed in grain.
They shout for joy! They also sing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A wonderful picture of spring and the harvest. God is like a farmer who takes care of his fields: He waters the ground, levels it, softens it and blesses the seed.

Verse 11: "You crown the year with your good gifts": The harvest is like a crown for the whole year.

"Your carts overflow with plenty": Wherever God drives along with his cart, everything grows. In Hebrew, it literally says "your tracks" or "your cart tracks drip with fat."

At the end, all of nature sings: The hills, pastures and valleys shout for joy. Creation praises its Creator.

PSALMS

Psalm 66

Come and see the works of God

Shout to God, all the earth! VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. A song. A psalm.
Shout to God with joy, all the earth!
2 Sing about the glory of his name!
Give him glory and praise!
3 Say to God: "How awesome your deeds are!
Your power is so great that your enemies bow down before you.
4 All the earth will worship you and sing to you.
They will sing to your name."
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A joyful psalm of praise. The whole world is invited to praise God.

He turned the sea into dry land VERSES 5–7

5 Come and see what God has done!
His work for the people of the earth is awesome.
6 He turned the sea into dry land.
They walked through the river on foot.

There we rejoiced in him.
7 He rules by his power forever.
His eyes watch the nations.
Do not let the rebellious rise up against him!
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6 reminds us of two great rescues: crossing the Red Sea (Exodus 14) and crossing the Jordan (Joshua 3).

"There we rejoiced in him": Even though it was long ago, the psalm says "we." Whoever believes today is part of this story.

Through fire and water VERSES 8–12

8 Praise our God, you peoples!
Let the sound of his praise be heard!
9 He keeps us alive
and does not let our feet slip.
10 For you, God, have tested us.
You have made us pure, the way silver is made pure in fire.
11 You brought us into prison.
You put a heavy load on our backs.
12 You let people ride over our heads.
We went through fire and through water,
but you brought us out to a place of plenty.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people have lived through hard times: captivity, oppression, humiliation.

Verse 10: These times were like the fire in which silver is made pure. The suffering made the people pure.

Verse 12: "Through fire and through water": through every danger. But in the end, God leads them into plenty (compare Isaiah 43:2).

I will keep my vows VERSES 13–15

13 I will come into your temple with burnt offerings.
I will keep my vows to you,
14 the vows that my lips promised
and that my mouth spoke when I was in trouble.
15 I will offer you burnt offerings of fat animals,
together with the offering of rams.
I will offer bulls and goats.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now a single person speaks. When he was in trouble, he promised God something. Now he wants to keep his promise.

He brings big, expensive sacrifices to show how thankful he is.

God has heard my prayer VERSES 16–20

16 Come and listen, all you who fear God!
I will tell what he has done for my soul.
17 I cried out to him with my mouth,
and my tongue praised him highly.
18 If I had held on to sin in my heart,
the Lord would not have listened.
19 But God has truly listened.
He has paid attention to the voice of my prayer.
20 Praise be to God!
He has not turned away my prayer,
and he has not turned his loving kindness away from me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever has experienced God's help wants to tell others about it.

Verse 18: If someone holds on to a sin on purpose and does not want to let go of it, his prayer is not honest. This does not mean that only perfect people may pray. It means: We should be honest before God.

Verse 20: The psalm ends with thanks: God has not turned away my prayer.

PSALMS

PSALM 67

Let all the peoples praise you

May God be merciful to us VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. With stringed instruments. A psalm. A song.
May God be merciful to us and bless us!
May he make his face shine on us.
Selah.
2 Then your way will be known on earth,
and your saving power among all nations.
3 Let the peoples praise you, God.
Let all the peoples praise you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1 takes up the blessing that the priests spoke over Israel: "The LORD bless you … The LORD make his face shine on you" (Numbers 6:24–26).

But the psalm goes further: Israel is not blessed only for its own sake, but so that all nations come to know God. The blessing is meant to be passed on (compare Genesis 12:2–3).

Let the nations be glad VERSES 4–5

4 Oh, let the nations be glad and sing for joy,
for you judge the peoples fairly
and guide the nations on earth.
Selah.
5 Let the peoples praise you, God.
Let all the peoples praise you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is a just judge and a good shepherd for all nations. That is a reason for the whole world to be glad.

Verse 5 repeats verse 3 as a refrain.

The earth gives its harvest VERSES 6–7

6 The earth has given its harvest.
God, our own God, will bless us.
7 God will bless us.
All the ends of the earth will fear him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 67 is a song of thanks for the harvest. The harvest is a visible sign of God's blessing.

At the end, the whole world is there again: "All the ends of the earth" are to honor God.

In many worship services, this short psalm is spoken as a prayer of blessing.

PSALMS

PSALM 68

God enters his sanctuary

God rises up VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. A psalm by David. A song.
Let God rise up! Let his enemies be scattered!
Let those who hate him run away before him.
2 As smoke is blown away, so blow them away.
As wax melts before the fire,
so let the wicked die before God.
3 But let the righteous be glad.
Let them rejoice before God.
Yes, let them be full of joy and gladness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 68 is one of the most difficult psalms. Many verses are hard to understand in Hebrew. The translations often differ from one another.

It describes a great festive procession: God marches from Sinai through the desert to his sanctuary in Jerusalem.

Verse 1 takes up the call with which the ark of the covenant set out: "Rise up, LORD! Let your enemies be scattered" (Numbers 10:35).

Father of orphans VERSES 4–6

4 Sing to God! Sing praises to his name!
Praise highly the one who rides on the clouds.
His name is Yah! Rejoice before him!
5 A father of orphans and a defender of widows:
that is God in his holy home.
6 God gives lonely people a family to live in.
He leads the prisoners out with singing.
But the rebellious live in a land burned by the sun.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The one who rides on the clouds": The neighboring nations called their god Baal this. The psalm says: Not Baal, but our God rides on the clouds.

"Yah" is a short form of God's name YHWH. People know it from the word "Hallelujah" (which means "Praise Yah").

Verses 5–6 are a wonderful picture: The great God cares especially for the weakest: orphans, widows, lonely people, prisoners. He is their father and their defender.

"God gives lonely people a family": Literally, it says "he lets them live in a house." God gives them a home.

Verse 6: "With singing": Some Bibles translate this as "into happiness" or "into freedom."

When you marched through the wilderness VERSES 7–10

7 God, when you went out ahead of your people,
when you marched through the wilderness…
Selah.
8 … the earth shook.
The sky also poured down rain before the God of Sinai,
before God, the God of Israel.
9 You, God, sent plenty of rain.
You made your inheritance strong again when it was worn out.
10 Your community lived there.
In your goodness, God, you provided for the poor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm remembers Israel's journey through the desert after they left Egypt. It also remembers how God appeared at Mount Sinai, when the earth shook (Exodus 19:18).

Verses 9–10: In the promised land, God gave rain and took care of the poor.

Kings run away VERSES 11–14

11 The Lord gave the word.
Those who announced it were a great crowd.
12 "Kings with their armies run away! They run away!"
And the woman who stays at home divides the plunder,
13 while you sleep among the campfires:
the wings of a dove covered with silver,
her feathers with shining gold.
14 When the Almighty scattered kings there,
it snowed on Zalmon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are especially hard to understand.

Verse 11: "Those who announced it": In Hebrew, the word is in a female form here. It probably means women who spread the news of victory, like Miriam (Exodus 15:20) or Deborah (Judges 5).

Verses 12–13: The enemies run away. The women at home divide the plunder. Verse 13 speaks of a dove: "the wings of a dove covered with silver." It may be a precious piece of plunder, or a picture for Israel.

Verse 13: "Among the campfires": The Hebrew word is uncertain. Others translate "among the sheepfolds" or "in the stalls" (compare Judges 5:16).

Verse 14: Zalmon is a mountain. Maybe the weapons of the fallen lay on the mountain, white like snow. Or it is about real snowy weather that confused the enemies.

The mountain that God has chosen VERSES 15–18

15 The mountains of Bashan are mighty mountains.
The mountains of Bashan have rugged peaks.

16 Why do you look with envy, you rugged mountains,
at the mountain where God chooses to rule?
Yes, the LORD will live there forever.
17 The chariots of God are tens of thousands and
thousands of thousands.
The Lord is among them, from Sinai into the
sanctuary.
18 You have gone up on high.
You have led away captives.
You have received gifts among people,
yes, even among the rebellious,
so that Yah God may live there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bashan is a high, impressive mountain range in the northeast (with Mount Hermon). Mount Zion in Jerusalem is much smaller. But God has chosen little Zion. The big mountains "look with envy." God often chooses what is small (compare 1 Corinthians 1:27).

Verse 17: God comes from Sinai into his sanctuary with a huge heavenly army.

Verse 18: Like a king who has won a victory, God goes up to his throne, with captives and gifts.

Paul quotes verse 18 in Ephesians 4:8 and applies it to Jesus going up into heaven. But there he says "gave gifts to people" instead of "received gifts." Old Jewish translations also understood it this way.

He carries our burdens VERSES 19–23

19 Praise be to the Lord, who carries our burdens every
day,
the God who saves us.
Selah.
20 For us, God is a God who rescues.
Escape from death belongs to the LORD, the Lord.
21 But God will crush the heads of his enemies,
the hairy scalp of anyone who keeps on living in his
guilt.
22 The Lord said, "I will bring you back from Bashan.
I will bring you back from the depths of the sea,
23 so that you may crush them and dip your foot in blood,
and so that the tongues of your dogs may have their
share of your enemies."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19 is one of the most beautiful verses of the psalm: "Praise be to the Lord, who carries our burdens every day." God helps us every day.

Verse 20: God can even rescue from death.

Verses 21–23 are very harsh. They are about enemies who will not let go of their guilt. God says: They cannot hide anywhere, not in the mountains and not in the sea (compare Amos 9:2–3).

The pictures of blood and dogs are the war language of that time. They are not permission for violence. They mean that in the end, evil will be completely defeated. The judgment belongs to God.

The festive procession VERSES 24–27

24 They have seen your processions, God,
the processions of my God, my King, into the
sanctuary.
25 The singers went in front, the musicians followed,
among the women playing tambourines:
26 "Bless God in the congregations!
Bless the Lord in the assembly of Israel!"
27 There is little Benjamin, their ruler,
the princes of Judah, their council,
the princes of Zebulun, and the princes of Naphtali.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now we can picture the procession: the singers in front, the musicians behind, and in between women with tambourines (hand drums).

The tribes of Israel march along: the smallest tribe, Benjamin, at the front, then Judah from the south, Zebulun and Naphtali from the north. All Israel is united.

Kings bring gifts VERSES 28–31

28 Your God has commanded your strength.
God, make strong what you have done for us!
29 Because of your temple at Jerusalem,
kings will bring gifts to you.
30 Speak sharply to the wild animal of the reeds,
to the herd of bulls with the calves of the peoples.
Trample the bars of silver under your feet.
Scatter the nations who love war!
31 Princes will come out of Egypt.
Ethiopia will hurry to stretch out her hands to God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 30: "The wild animal of the reeds": probably a picture for Egypt (a crocodile or a hippopotamus in the reeds of the Nile). The "bulls" are the powerful rulers.

"Scatter the nations who love war!": God is against those who stir up war.

Verse 31: "Ethiopia": In Hebrew, the name here is Cush. Cush is the land south of Egypt (today roughly Sudan). Even the most distant nations will come to God.

Sing to God, you kingdoms of the earth! VERSES 32–35

32 Sing to God, you kingdoms of the earth!
Sing praises to the Lord!
Selah.
33 Sing to him who rides on the highest heavens, which
have been there from long ago.
Listen! He speaks with his voice, a mighty voice.
34 Say that strength belongs to God!
His majesty is over Israel,
and his strength is in the skies.
35 You are awesome, God, in your sanctuaries.
The God of Israel gives strength and power to his
people.
Praise be to God!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, all the kingdoms of the earth are invited to praise God.

God is mighty in heaven, but he passes his strength on to his people.

The psalm ends with simple praise: "Praise be to God!"

PSALM 69

The water is up to my neck

I am sinking VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. To the tune of "Lilies." By
David.
Save me, God,
for the waters have come up to my neck!
2 I am sinking in deep mud,
where there is nothing to stand on.
I have come into deep waters,
and the floods are washing over me.
3 I am tired from crying out.
My throat is dry.
My eyes grow weak while I look for my God.
4 Those who hate me without a cause
are more than the hairs on my head.
Those who want to destroy me are powerful.
They are my enemies without any reason.
I have to give back what I did not take.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The waters have come up to my neck": Even today, people use this picture as a saying. The one praying feels as if he is drowning. He cannot find anything to hold on to.

He has cried out until his voice gave out. He has waited until his eyes grew tired.

Verse 4: He is hated without a cause. He is supposed to give back something he never stole. Jesus quotes: "They hated me for no reason" (John 15:25).

If the water is up to your neck right now and you see no way out: Get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

I am insulted because of you VERSES 5–12

5 God, you know my foolishness.
My sins are not hidden from you.
6 Lord GOD of Armies,
don't let those who wait for you be put to shame
because of me.
God of Israel,
don't let those who seek you be disgraced because of
me.
7 For I have been insulted because of you.
Shame has covered my face.
8 I have become a stranger to my brothers,
a foreigner to my mother's children.
9 For my zeal for your house eats me up.
The insults of those who insult you have fallen on me.
10 When I cried and fasted,
people insulted me for it.
11 When I wore rough sackcloth as a sign of grief,
they made jokes about me.
12 Those who sit in the city gate talk about me.
Drunkards make up songs about me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: The one praying is honest: I am not without faults. But that is not the reason for the hatred.

Verses 7–9: He suffers because he is faithful to God. Even his own family turns away from him.

Verse 9: "My zeal for your house eats me up": The disciples remembered this verse when Jesus drove the traders out of the temple (John 2:17). Paul quotes the second part in Romans 15:3.

Verse 12: "Those who sit in the city gate": the respected people of the town. Even the drunkards make up mocking songs about him.

Pull me out of the mud VERSES 13–18

13 But as for me, I pray to you, LORD, at a time of your
favor.
God, because your loving kindness is so great,
answer me with your faithful help!
14 Pull me out of the mud, and don't let me sink!
Let me be rescued from those who hate me
and out of the deep waters!
15 Don't let the flood waters wash over me.
Don't let the deep swallow me up.
Don't let the pit shut its mouth over me.
16 Answer me, LORD, for your loving kindness is good.
Turn to me in your great and tender mercy!
17 Don't hide your face from your servant,
for I am in trouble. Answer me quickly!
18 Come near to my soul and set it free!
Pay the price to set me free, because of my enemies!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying turns to God completely. He asks again and again: Answer me! Rescue me! Don't hide!

"Don't let the pit shut its mouth": like a well that is covered up, so that no one can ever get out again.

I looked for comforters and found none VERSES 19–21

19 You know how I am insulted, my shame, and my
disgrace.
All my enemies are in front of you.
20 The insults have broken my heart,
and I am full of sadness.
I looked for someone to feel sorry for me, but there
was no one.
I looked for comforters, but I found none.
21 They also gave me poison for my food.
When I was thirsty, they gave me vinegar to drink.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: The worst part is the loneliness: No one has pity, no one comforts.

Verse 21: Instead of help, he gets poison and vinegar. The word for "poison" probably means a bitter herb.

The Gospels report that Jesus was given vinegar to drink on the cross (Matthew 27:34, 48; John 19:28–29). Together with

Psalm 22, Psalm 69 is one of the psalms that the New Testament most often relates to the suffering of Jesus.

A curse on the enemies VERSES 22–28

22 Let their table in front of them become a snare.
Let it become a punishment and a trap.
23 Let their eyes be darkened, so that they cannot see.
Let their backs always be bent.
24 Pour out your anger on them!
Let your burning anger catch up with them.
25 Let their home be empty and ruined.
Let no one live in their tents.
26 For they hunt down the one you have struck.
They talk about the pain of those you have wounded.
27 Count their crimes against them, one crime after another!
Don't let them come into your righteousness!
28 Let them be erased from the book of life,
and let them not be written down with the righteous.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the harshest curses in the Psalms. The one praying is so hurt that he asks God to punish his enemies.

Verse 26 shows how cruel the enemies are: Instead of having pity on the one who suffers, they kick him when he is already down.

Paul quotes verses 22–23 in Romans 11:9–10. Peter applies verse 25 to Judas (Acts 1:20).

Important: The one praying tells God about his anger. He does not take revenge himself. The Bible allows us to speak honestly about our anger and pain before God. But Jesus, who applied many verses of this psalm to himself, prayed for his enemies on the cross: "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34).

"The book of life": a picture for the list of those who belong to God and live (compare Exodus 32:32; Revelation 20:12).

Praise is better than a bull VERSES 29–36

29 But I am in pain and trouble.
God, let your saving help protect me.
30 I will praise the name of God with a song.
I will honor him greatly with thanks.
31 That will please the LORD more than an ox,
or a bull with horns and hoofs.
32 The humble have seen it, and they are glad.
You who seek God, let your heart live!
33 For the LORD hears the needy.
He does not look down on his people who are prisoners.
34 Let heaven and earth praise him,
the seas and everything that moves in them!
35 For God will save Zion
and build the cities of Judah.
They will live there and own it.
36 The children of his servants will also inherit it.
Those who love his name will live there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end comes the turning point: The cry becomes praise.

Verse 31: A song of thanks pleases God more than the most expensive animal sacrifice (compare Psalm 50:14; 51:16–17).

Verse 33: "The LORD hears the needy." That is the hope of all the poor and all prisoners.

Verses 35–36: The view widens to the whole people. Perhaps the psalm was prayed in exile, when Jerusalem was destroyed, with the hope that it would be rebuilt.

PSALMS

PSALM 70

Hurry to help me

Come quickly, God VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. By David. As a reminder.
Hurry, God, to rescue me!
Come quickly to help me, LORD!
2 Let those who are after my life
be disappointed and confused.
Let those who want to see me ruined
be turned back in disgrace.
3 Let those who say, "Aha! Aha!"
turn back because of their shame.
4 Let all those who seek you
be full of joy and glad in you.
Let those who love your salvation always say,
"Let God be praised as great!"
5 But I am poor and needy.
Come to me quickly, God!
You are my help and my rescuer.
LORD, don't wait!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 70 is almost exactly the same text as Psalm 40:13–17. It was handed down as a separate, short prayer.

"As a reminder": Perhaps the psalm was sung at a certain sacrifice. Or it is meant to "remind" God of the one praying.

It is a short, urgent cry for help: "Come quickly!" It begins and ends with the request that God would hurry.

For many centuries, monks have prayed the first verse at the beginning of their times of prayer: "O God, come to my help! Lord, hurry to help me!"

PSALMS

PSALM 71

Do not abandon me when I am old

You have been my hope since I was young VERSES 1–8

1 In you, LORD, I find safety.
Never let me be put to shame!
2 Rescue me because you are righteous, and set me free!
Turn your ear to me and save me!
3 Be a rock of safety for me, where I can always go!
Give the command to save me,
for you are my rock and my fortress.
4 My God, rescue me from the hand of the wicked,
from the hand of the unjust and cruel man!
5 For you are my hope, Lord GOD.
I have trusted you since I was young.
6 I have relied on you since before I was born.
You are the one who brought me out of my mother's womb.
I will always praise you.
7 To many people I am like a wonder,
but you are my strong place of safety.
8 My mouth will be full of your praise
and of your honor all day long.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 71 is the prayer of an old person. He looks back on his whole life: Already as a baby, already as a young person, he trusted God.

Verses 1–3 remind us of Psalm 31:1–3.

Verse 7: "To many people I am like a wonder": People are amazed at him, perhaps because he has been through so much. The word can also mean "a warning example." But he knows: God is my place of safety.

Do not abandon me when my strength fails VERSES 9–13

9 Don't throw me away when I am old!
Don't abandon me when my strength fails!
10 For my enemies talk about me.
Those who lie in wait for my life make plans together.
11 They say, "God has abandoned him.
Chase him and grab him, for no one will rescue him."
12 God, don't be far from me!
My God, hurry to help me!
13 Let my accusers be put to shame and destroyed.
Let those who want to harm me
be covered with disgrace and contempt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9 is a moving prayer for old people: "Don't abandon me when my strength fails!" In old age, people become weaker and need more help.

The enemies think: He is old and weak. God has abandoned him. Now we can take everything from him.

The Bible says: Old people have a special dignity (Leviticus 19:32). God does not abandon them (Isaiah 46:4: "Even into your old age I am he, and even when your hair is gray I will carry you").

I will always hope VERSES 14–18

14 But I will always hope.
I will praise you more and more.
15 My mouth will tell about your righteousness
and about your saving help all day long,
even though I cannot measure it all.
16 I will come with the mighty deeds of the Lord GOD.
I will speak about your righteousness, yours alone.
17 God, you have taught me since I was young.
Until now I have told about your wonderful deeds.
18 Yes, even when I am old and have gray hair, God, don't abandon me,
until I have told the next generation about your strength,
and everyone who is still to come about your power.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: God's good deeds are so many that no one can count them all.

Verse 18: The old person still has a task: He wants to tell the young generation what God has done. Old people are important, because they can pass on what they have experienced.

You will bring me up again VERSES 19–24

19 God, your righteousness also reaches up to the heavens.
You have done great things.
God, who is like you?
20 You have let us see many bitter troubles,
but you will make me live again.
You will bring us up again from the depths of the earth.
21 Make my honor greater,
and comfort me again!
22 I will also praise you with the harp for your faithfulness, my God.
I sing praises to you with the lyre, Holy One of Israel.
23 My lips will shout for joy!
My soul, which you have set free, sings praises to you!
24 My tongue will also talk about your righteousness all day long,
for those who want to harm me
are put to shame and confused.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: The one praying has lived through many hard things. But he trusts that God will lift him up again, even "from the depths of the earth." Many see in this a hope beyond death.

"Holy One of Israel": This name for God appears especially often in the book of Isaiah.

The psalm ends with joy and singing: An old person who has trusted God all his life still praises him now.

PSALMS

PSALM 72

A prayer for the king

Give the king your justice VERSES 1–7

1 By Solomon.
God, give the king your justice.
Give your righteousness to the king's son.
2 He will judge your people with righteousness,
and your poor people with justice.
3 The mountains will bring well-being to the people.
The hills will bring the fruit of righteousness.
4 He will judge fairly for the poor among the people.
He will save the children of the needy.
He will break the oppressor in pieces.
5 They will fear you as long as the sun lasts,
and as long as the moon shines, through all
generations.
6 He will come down like rain on grass that has been cut,
like showers that water the earth.
7 In his days the righteous will flourish.
There will be plenty of peace, until the moon is no
more.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 72 is a prayer for the king, perhaps for the day he was crowned. The heading names Solomon, the son of David.

What is a good king? He makes sure there is justice, especially for the poor and the weak. He protects them from those who oppress them.

"Well-being" (verse 3) and "peace" (verse 7): In Hebrew, both times the word is "shalom." That means more than "no war": It means well-being, justice, and wholeness for everyone.

Verse 6: A good king is like rain after the harvest: He brings new life.

From sea to sea VERSES 8–11

8 He will also rule from sea to sea,
from the River to the ends of the earth.
9 Those who live in the wilderness will bow before him.
His enemies will lick the dust.
10 The kings of Tarshish and of the islands will bring
tribute.
Tribute is money or goods that people pay to a ruler.
The kings of Sheba and Seba will offer gifts.
11 Yes, all kings will fall down before him.
All nations will serve him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm wishes that the king would rule over the whole world. "The River" is the Euphrates.

Tarshish was far in the west (perhaps Spain). Sheba and Seba were in the south (Arabia and Africa). The queen of Sheba visited Solomon (1 Kings 10).

This went far beyond what any king in Israel really achieved. That is why Jews and Christians have understood the psalm as being about the Messiah.

In verses 10–11, Christians think of the wise men from the East, who brought gifts to the child Jesus (Matthew 2:11).

He rescues the poor VERSES 12–14

12 For he will rescue the needy person when he cries out,
and the poor person who has no one to help him.
13 He will have pity on the poor and needy.
He will save the lives of the needy.
14 He will set them free from oppression and violence.
Their blood will be precious in his eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

That is the real reason why this king is great: not his power, but his care for the poor.

Verse 14: "Their blood will be precious in his eyes": For a good ruler, the life of every poor person is valuable. No one is too unimportant.

That is a standard for everyone who has power, to this day.

His name lasts forever VERSES 15–17

15 He will live, and gold from Sheba will be given to him.
People will pray for him all the time.
They will bless him all day long.
16 There will be plenty of grain in the land.
Its fruit sways like Lebanon.
Let it flourish and grow like the grass of the field.
17 His name lasts forever.
His name continues as long as the sun.
People will be blessed through him.
All nations will call him blessed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Under a just king, everything thrives: the harvest, the people, the land.

"Like Lebanon": The heads of grain sway in the wind like the great cedar forests of Lebanon.

Verse 17 reminds us of the promise to Abraham: "Through you, all the families of the earth will be blessed" (Genesis 12:3).

The end of the second book of Psalms VERSES 18–20

18 Praise be to the LORD God, the God of Israel,
who alone does wonderful deeds!
19 Praise be to his glorious name forever!
Let the whole earth be filled with his glory!
Amen and amen.
20 This is the end of the prayers by David, the son of Jesse.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18–19 are the praise at the end of the second book of Psalms (Psalms 42–72), just as Psalm 41:13 closes the first book.

Verse 20: "This is the end of the prayers by David": This was probably once the end of an older collection of David's psalms. Later, more psalms by David were added (for example, Psalms 86, 101, 103, 108–110, 138–145).

Jesse was David's father.

With Psalm 73, the third book of Psalms begins.

PSALMS

PSALM 73

Yet I am always with you

The third book of Psalms

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Psalm 73, the third book of Psalms begins (Psalms 73–89).

The first 11 psalms of this book (73–83) come from Asaph or from his group of singers. Asaph was a musician whom David had appointed to serve at the temple (1 Chronicles 16:4–7). Psalm 50 also comes from him.

Many psalms in this book are dark: They lament the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple, and they ask why God allowed it.

I was jealous of the wicked VERSES 1–3

1 A psalm by Asaph.
Surely God is good to Israel,
to those who have a pure heart.
2 But as for me, my feet almost stumbled.
My steps had nearly slipped.
3 For I was jealous of proud people
when I saw how well things go for the wicked.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 73 is one of the most important psalms about this question: Why do things go well for evil people and badly for good people? It is the same question as in the book of Job.

The one praying begins with a statement of faith: God is good. But then he admits honestly: I almost lost my faith.

How well things go for the wicked VERSES 4–12

4 For they have no struggles in their death.
Their strength stays firm.
5 They are free from the burdens that other people carry.
They are not struck by trouble like other people.
6 That is why pride is like a chain around their neck.
Violence covers them like clothing.
7 Their eyes bulge with fat.
Their minds overflow with proud ideas.
8 They mock and speak with evil intent.
In their pride they threaten to crush others.
9 They have set their mouths in the heavens.
Their tongues walk through the earth.
10 That is why their people turn back to them,
and they drink up water in plenty.
11 They say, "How would God know?
Does the Most High know anything?"
12 Look, these are the wicked.
They are always at ease, and they keep getting richer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying describes the wicked: They are healthy, rich, and strong. They have no worries. They wear their pride like a necklace.

Verse 9: They talk as if they could rule over heaven and earth.

Verse 10: Many people run after them and admire them. This verse is hard to understand in Hebrew.

Verse 11: They think: God doesn't notice anything anyway.

Was it all for nothing? VERSES 13–16

13 Surely I have kept my heart pure for nothing,
and I have washed my hands in innocence for nothing.
14 For all day long I have been struck with trouble,
and I am punished every morning.
15 If I had said, "I will talk like that,"
I would have betrayed the generation of your children.
16 When I tried to understand this,
it was too painful for me—

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying is bitter: Was it worth it at all to live an honest life? Things go badly for me, even though I did everything right.

Verse 15: But he does not say these doubts out loud. He does not want to shake the faith of other believers.

Verse 16: He gets nowhere with his thinking. It only hurts.

Until I went into the sanctuary VERSES 17–20

17 until I went into God's sanctuary
and saw what their end will be.
18 Surely you put them on slippery ground.
You throw them down to destruction.
19 How suddenly they are destroyed!
Terrors sweep them away completely.
20 As a dream disappears when someone wakes up,
so you, Lord, when you wake up, will despise their empty dreams.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17 is the turning point of the whole psalm: "until I went into God's sanctuary." Close to God, the one praying sees things differently.

He realizes: The success of the wicked does not last. They stand on slippery ground. Their happiness is like a dream that disappears when you wake up.

Sometimes we do not understand life by thinking alone, but only when we meet God.

I was like a dumb animal VERSES 21–22

21 For my soul was bitter.
My heart was hurt.
22 I was so foolish, and I did not understand.
I was like a dumb animal before you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying is ashamed of his bitterness. He says honestly: I was as foolish as an animal that only looks at what it can see.

Yet I am always with you VERSES 23–28

23 Yet I am always with you.
You have held my right hand.
24 You will guide me with your advice,
and afterward you will take me into glory.
25 Whom do I have in heaven?
There is no one on earth I long for besides you.
26 My body and my heart fail,
but God is the strength of my heart,
and he is my share forever.

27 For look, those who are far from you will die.
You have destroyed all those who are unfaithful to you.
28 But for me, it is good to come close to God.
I have made the Lord GOD my refuge,
so that I may tell about all your works.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23 is one of the most beautiful sayings in the Bible: "Yet I am always with you." In spite of all the doubts, in spite of the bitterness: God has held me by the hand the whole time.

Verse 24: "And afterward you will take me into glory": Here the hope for a life with God after death shines through.

Verses 25–26: This is the answer to the question of the psalm. The wicked have riches. I have God. And that is worth more than anything else. Even if my body and my heart fail, God remains.

Verse 28: "But for me, it is good to come close to God." This is what the one praying has come to understand at the end.

PSALMS

Psalm 74

A lament over the destroyed temple

Why have you rejected us? VERSES 1–3

1 A contemplation by Asaph.
God, why have you rejected us forever?
Why does your anger smoke against the sheep of your pasture?
2 Remember your community, which you bought long ago,
which you set free to be the tribe that belongs to you:
Mount Zion, where you have lived.
3 Lift up your feet and come to the endless ruins,
to all the evil the enemy has done in the sanctuary.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 74 laments the destruction of the temple in Jerusalem. It probably means the destruction by the Babylonians in the year 586 BC (2 Kings 25:8–9).

The people feel like a flock whose shepherd has left them.

"Lift up your feet": Come here and look at the ruins!

They have burned your sanctuary VERSES 4–11

4 Your enemies have roared in the middle of your meeting place.
They have set up their own flags as signs.
5 They acted like men swinging axes,
cutting through a thicket of trees.
6 Now they smash all its carved woodwork
with hatchets and hammers.
7 They have burned your sanctuary to the ground.
They have made the home of your Name unholy.
8 They said in their hearts, "We will crush them completely."
They have burned all the places in the land where God was worshiped.
9 We see no miraculous signs.
There is no prophet anymore,
and none of us knows how long this will last.
10 How long, God, will the enemy insult you?
Will the enemy speak against your name forever?
11 Why do you hold back your hand, your right hand?
Take it out from your chest and destroy them!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the destruction is described in detail: The enemies roar in the temple, set up their flags, smash the beautiful wood carvings with axes, and burn everything down.

Verse 9: This is especially bad: There are no more signs from God, and no prophet who says how long it will last. God is silent.

Verse 11: God keeps his hand hidden at his chest, inside his robe, as if he did not want to do anything. The one praying asks: Take your hand out and step in!

Yet you have been my King since long ago VERSES 12–17

12 Yet God has been my King since long ago.
He brings rescue all over the earth.
13 You divided the sea by your strength.
You broke the heads of the sea monsters in the waters.
14 You crushed the heads of Leviathan.
You gave him as food to the people and creatures of the desert.
15 You made springs and streams break open.
You dried up mighty rivers.
16 The day is yours, and the night is yours too.
You made the light and the sun.
17 You have set all the borders of the earth.
You have made summer and winter.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the lament, the one praying remembers: God is still the King who created the world and rescued Israel.

Verses 13–14: Dividing the sea reminds us of the way out of Egypt. The "sea monsters" and "Leviathan" are pictures for the powers of chaos (compare Job 41). Some interpreters also think of Egypt, which was like a monster.

Verse 14: The Hebrew word is uncertain. It can mean people who live in the desert, or wild animals of the desert. Here it says: "as food to the people and creatures of the desert."

Verses 16–17: Day and night, summer and winter: God created the order of the world. That is why he can create order again now.

Don't forget your poor VERSES 18–23

18 Remember this, LORD: the enemy has mocked you.
Foolish people have insulted your name.
19 Don't hand over the soul of your dove to wild animals!
Don't forget the life of your poor people forever!
20 Keep your covenant in mind,
for the dark places of the earth are full of places of violence.

21 Don't let the oppressed go back in shame!
Let the poor and needy praise your name!
22 Rise up, God! Defend your own cause!
Remember how the foolish man mocks you all day long.
23 Don't forget the voices of your enemies.
The noise of those who rise up against you goes up all the time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: The people of Israel are like a helpless dove among wild animals.

Verse 20: "Keep your covenant in mind": A covenant is a binding agreement. God has bound himself to his people. The one praying reminds God of his promise.

Verse 22: "Defend your own cause": It is not only about Israel, but about God's honor. The enemies mock God himself.

The psalm ends without an answer. It leaves the lament open. To this day, Jews pray this psalm in memory of the destruction of the temple.

PSALMS

PSALM 75

God is the judge

We thank you VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. To the tune of "Do Not Destroy." A psalm by Asaph. A song.
We give thanks to you, God.
We give thanks, for your Name is near.
People tell about your wonderful deeds.
2 When I choose the right time,
I will judge fairly.
3 The earth and all who live on it shake.
I hold its pillars firmly.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the lament in Psalm 74, an answer comes here: God will judge, but at his own time.

In verses 2–3, God himself speaks: I decide when the time has come. Even if everything shakes, I hold the world firm, like a house whose pillars I support.

Don't brag! VERSES 4–8

4 I said to the proud, "Don't brag!"
I said to the wicked, "Don't lift up your horn.
5 Don't lift up your horn so high.
Don't speak with a stiff neck."
6 For honor does not come from the east,
or from the west, or from the south.
7 But God is the judge.
He brings one person down, and he lifts another up.
8 For in the LORD's hand there is a cup,
full of foaming wine mixed with spices.
He pours it out.
Yes, the wicked of the earth drink and drink it, down to the very last drop.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Lift up your horn": like a bull that raises its head, proud and ready to attack. A picture for pride and power.

"Speak with a stiff neck": to be stubborn and proud.

Verses 6–7: Success and honor do not come from any direction of the sky, but from God. He removes the powerful and lifts up the lowly (compare 1 Samuel 2:7; Luke 1:52).

Verse 8: The cup is a picture for God's judgment. The wicked must drink it down to the very last drop.

I will sing VERSES 9–10

9 But as for me, I will tell about this forever.
I will sing praises to the God of Jacob.
10 I will cut off all the horns of the wicked,
but the horns of the righteous will be lifted up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying promises to praise God forever.

Verse 10: The one speaking here is probably God himself again, or the king acting for him. The power of the wicked is broken, and the power of the righteous is made strong.

PSALMS

PSALM 76

God breaks the weapons

God is known in Judah VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. On stringed instruments. A psalm by Asaph. A song.
In Judah, God is known.
His name is great in Israel.
2 His tent is also in Salem.
His home is in Zion.
3 There he broke the flaming arrows of the bow,
the shield, the sword, and the weapons of war.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Salem" is an old name for Jerusalem (compare Genesis 14:18). It sounds like the word "shalom," which means peace.

In the city of peace, God breaks the weapons. That is a picture that gives hope today too.

When they read this psalm, many people think of the rescue of Jerusalem from the Assyrians (2 Kings 19:35).

The warriors are asleep VERSES 4–6

4 You are glorious and wonderful,
more than mountains full of prey.
5 The brave men have been robbed.
They have fallen into their last sleep.
None of the warriors can lift their hands.
6 When you scold them, God of Jacob,
both chariot and horse fall into a deep sleep like death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The enemies who marched against Jerusalem are defeated. They lie there like sleepers who will never wake up again.

God needs no weapons. One word from him is enough.

God rises up to judge VERSES 7–10

7 You, yes you, are to be feared.
Who can stand before you when you are angry?
8 You announced judgment from heaven.
The earth was afraid and became silent
9 when God rose up to judge,
to save all the suffering people of the earth.
Selah.
10 Surely even human anger will praise you.
Those who escape your anger are held back.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9 shows the goal of God's judgment: "to save all the suffering people of the earth." God does not judge because he likes to punish, but to protect the weak.

Verse 10 is hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: In the end, even the anger of the enemies serves to show God's greatness.

Bring him gifts VERSES 11–12

11 Make vows to the LORD your God, and keep them!
Let all the people around him bring gifts to him, the one who is to be feared.
12 He will cut off the spirit of princes.
The kings of the earth fear him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever has experienced God's help should thank him and keep his promises.

"He will cut off the spirit of princes": This means: He breaks the pride of rulers. Even the most powerful people in the world must answer to God.

PSALMS

Psalm 77

I think about the days of old

A night without comfort VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. For Jeduthun. A psalm by Asaph.
My cry goes up to God!
Yes, I cry to God for help, so that he will listen to me.
2 On the day of my trouble I looked for the Lord.
At night my hand was stretched out, and it did not get tired.
My soul refused to be comforted.
3 I remember God, and I groan.
I complain, and my spirit grows weak.
Selah.
4 You hold my eyelids open.
I am so troubled that I cannot speak.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying is in deep trouble. He prays all night with his hands stretched out. He cannot sleep.

"My soul refused to be comforted": Sometimes the pain is so great that no comfort helps. The Bible takes this seriously.

Verse 3: Even thinking of God hurts, because God seems so far away.

If you know nights like this: You are not alone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. Help is there day and night.

Has God forgotten to be gracious? VERSES 5–9

5 I have thought about the days of long ago,
the years of ancient times.
6 I remember my song in the night.
I think deeply in my heart,
and my spirit searches hard:
7 "Will the Lord reject us forever?
Will he never be kind to us again?
8 Is his loving kindness gone forever?
Has his promise come to an end for all generations?
9 Has God forgotten to be gracious?
Has he, in his anger, shut away his compassion?"
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying remembers earlier times, when he still sang songs to God at night. Back then, everything was good.

Then he asks six hard questions: Has God left us forever? Is his love gone? Has he forgotten to be gracious?

These are questions that many people ask in times of crisis. The Bible allows these questions.

I will remember your wonders VERSES 10–15

10 Then I thought, "I will appeal to this:
the years of the right hand of the Most High."
11 I will remember the deeds of Yah.
Yes, I will remember your wonders of long ago.
12 I will also think about all your work
and consider what you have done.

13 God, your way is in the sanctuary.
What god is as great as God?
14 You are the God who does wonders.
You have made your strength known among the peoples.
15 With your arm you have set your people free,
the descendants of Jacob and Joseph.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10 is the turning point. The one praying stops going around in circles about himself and his pain. He makes a choice to remember what God did in the past.

Verse 10 is hard to translate from Hebrew. Others understand it as a lament: It hurts me that the Most High no longer acts as he did before. The WEB, our English source text, understands it as a turn toward trust.

"Yah" is a short form of God's name.

Remembering God's deeds gives strength for the present.

Your way went through the sea VERSES 16–20

16 The waters saw you, God.
The waters saw you, and they twisted in pain.
The depths also shook.
17 The clouds poured out water.
The skies roared with thunder.
Your arrows also flashed all around.
18 The voice of your thunder was in the whirlwind.
The lightning lit up the world.
The earth trembled and shook.
19 Your way went through the sea,
your paths through the great waters.
No one could see your footprints.
20 You led your people like a flock,
by the hand of Moses and Aaron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying remembers the greatest rescue: crossing the Red Sea (Exodus 14–15).

Verse 19 is a deep thought: "No one could see your footprints." God led his people through the sea, but no one saw his tracks. Today too, God's way is often hidden. We do not see it, but he still leads.

Verse 20: The psalm ends quietly and with comfort: God leads his people like a shepherd leads his flock.

PSALMS

PSALM 78

Tell it to your children

Passing on the story VERSES 1–8

1 A contemplation by Asaph.
Listen to my teaching, my people!
Turn your ears to the words of my mouth!
2 I will open my mouth and speak in a parable.
I will speak riddles from long ago,
3 things we have heard and known,
things our ancestors have told us.
4 We will not hide them from their children.
We will tell the next generation
about the praises of the LORD, about his strength,
and about the wonderful deeds he has done.
5 For he set up a covenant in Jacob
and gave a teaching in Israel.
He commanded our ancestors
to make these things known to their children,
6 so that the next generation would know them,
the children who would still be born.
Then they would rise up and tell their own children,
7 so that they would put their hope in God
and not forget God's deeds,
but keep his commandments,
8 and so that they would not be like their ancestors:
a stubborn and rebellious generation,
a generation whose hearts were not loyal,
whose spirit did not stay faithful to God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 78 is the second-longest psalm (after Psalm 119). It tells the story of Israel from the way out of Egypt up to King David.

The goal is stated at the beginning: The story is to be passed on to the children, so that they learn from the mistakes of their ancestors and trust God.

Verse 2: Matthew quotes this verse and applies it to the parables of Jesus (Matthew 13:35).

The psalm is honest: It tells not only about God's wonders, but also about how unfaithful the people were. We can learn from both.

They forgot his deeds VERSES 9–16

9 The people of Ephraim had weapons and carried bows,
but they turned back on the day of battle.
10 They did not keep God's covenant.
They refused to live by his law.
11 They forgot what he had done,
the wonderful deeds he had shown them.
12 He did amazing things before the eyes of their ancestors,
in the land of Egypt, in the region of Zoan.
13 He split the sea and led them through it.
He made the waters stand up like a heap.
14 During the day he led them with a cloud,
and all night long with a light of fire.
15 He split rocks in the wilderness
and gave them plenty to drink, as if from the deep.
16 He also brought streams out of the rock
and made water run down like rivers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ephraim was the largest tribe in the north of Israel. The psalm does not say exactly when the people of Ephraim ran away in battle. Here, Ephraim stands for the northern kingdom, which became unfaithful to God.

Zoan (in Greek, Tanis) was a city in the Nile Delta in Egypt.

Verses 13–16 tell about the wonders when Israel left Egypt: the divided sea (Exodus 14), the pillar of cloud and fire (Exodus 13:21), and the water from the rock (Exodus 17; Numbers 20).

Verse 13: "Like a heap": The water piled up and stood like a wall (compare Exodus 15:8).

Can God set a table in the wilderness? VERSES 17–22

17 But they kept on sinning against him.
They rebelled against the Most High in the desert.
18 In their hearts they put God to the test
by demanding the food they craved.
19 Yes, they spoke against God.
They said, "Can God set a table in the wilderness?
20 Look, he struck the rock, and water gushed out,
and streams overflowed.
But can he give bread too?
Will he provide meat for his people?"
21 So the LORD heard it, and he was angry.
A fire was lit against Jacob,
and anger also rose up against Israel,
22 because they did not believe in God,
and they did not trust in his saving help.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even though God had done so many wonders, the people doubted again and again. They asked mockingly: "Can God set a table in the wilderness?"

The real problem was not hunger, but unbelief: "They did not trust in his saving help."

The bread of angels VERSES 23–31

23 Yet he gave orders to the skies above
and opened the doors of heaven.
24 He rained down manna on them to eat.
He gave them food from the sky.
25 People ate the bread of angels.
He sent them as much food as they wanted.
26 He made the east wind blow in the sky.
By his power he led the south wind.
27 He also rained meat on them like dust,
birds like the sand of the seas.
28 He let them fall in the middle of their camp,
all around their tents.
29 So they ate, and they were completely full.
He gave them what they craved.
30 But they did not turn away from their cravings.
Their food was still in their mouths
31 when God's anger rose up against them.
He killed some of their strongest men
and struck down the young men of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In spite of their unbelief, God gave them food: manna, the "bread from heaven" (Exodus 16), and quail (Numbers 11).

"The bread of angels": bread that comes from heaven. Later, Jesus calls himself "the true bread from heaven" (John 6:31–35).

Verses 30–31 remind us of the story in Numbers 11:33–34: The greed of the people was punished. Afterward, the place was called Kibroth Hattaavah, which means "graves of craving."

They looked for God only in times of trouble VERSES 32–39

32 In spite of all this, they kept on sinning.
They did not believe in his wonderful deeds.
33 So he let their days pass away for nothing,
and their years in terror.
34 When he killed some of them, the others asked about him.
They turned back and looked hard for God.
35 They remembered that God was their rock,
that God Most High was the one who set them free.
36 But they flattered him with their mouths
and lied to him with their tongues.
37 For their hearts were not loyal to him.
They were not faithful to his covenant.
38 But he was merciful. He forgave their guilt
and did not destroy them.
Yes, many times he turned his anger away
and did not stir up all his fury.
39 He remembered that they were only flesh,
a wind that passes by and does not come back.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A pattern repeats itself: When things went badly, they looked for God. When things went well again, they forgot him. Their sorrow was often just talk. They did not mean it honestly.

Verses 38–39 are the heart of the psalm: In spite of all their unfaithfulness, God stayed merciful. He forgave again and again. He knew how weak people are: "only flesh, a wind that passes by."

The signs in Egypt VERSES 40–51

40 How often they rebelled against him in the wilderness
and made him sad in the desert!
41 Again and again they put God to the test
and provoked the Holy One of Israel.
42 They did not remember his hand,
or the day when he set them free from the enemy,
43 when he did his signs in Egypt,
his wonders in the region of Zoan.
44 He turned their rivers into blood,
and their streams too, so that they could not drink.
45 He sent swarms of flies among them, which ate them up,
and frogs, which ruined them.
46 He gave their crops to the caterpillar,
and the fruit of their work to the locust.
47 He destroyed their vines with hail
and their sycamore fig trees with frost.
48 He also handed over their cattle to the hail,
and their flocks to burning bolts of lightning.
49 He threw on them his burning anger,
his fury, his rage, and trouble,
a band of angels who bring disaster.
50 He made a path for his anger.
He did not spare their lives from death,
but handed them over to the plague.

51 He struck down all the firstborn in Egypt,
the first sons of their strength in the tents of Ham.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm remembers the plagues in Egypt (Exodus 7–12): blood, frogs, flies, locusts, hail, the plague on the animals, and last, the death of the firstborn.

"Angels who bring disaster": angels who carry out God's judgment.

"The tents of Ham": Egypt. According to Genesis 10:6, Egypt (Mizraim) came from Ham, a son of Noah.

This story is hard for readers today, especially the death of the children. The Bible tells it as a judgment on Pharaoh, who would not let Israel go and who himself had the people of Israel killed (Exodus 1:22).

He led them like sheep VERSES 52–55

52 But he led his own people out like sheep.
He guided them in the wilderness like a flock.
53 He led them safely, so that they were not afraid,
but the sea covered their enemies.
54 He brought them to the border of his holy land,
to this mountain, which his right hand had won.
55 He also drove out the nations in front of them.
He measured out the land for them as their inheritance,
and he let the tribes of Israel live in their tents.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like a good shepherd, God led his people through the desert into the promised land.

Verse 55: The taking of the land is told from Israel's point of view. It is not a command for today to drive out peoples.

He left the tent at Shiloh VERSES 56–64

56 Yet they put God Most High to the test and rebelled against him.
They did not keep his laws.
57 They turned away and were unfaithful like their ancestors.
They were as twisted as a bow that cannot be trusted.
58 For they made him angry with their high places,
and they made him jealous with their carved idols.
59 When God heard this, he was angry,
and he completely rejected Israel.
60 So he left the tent at Shiloh,
the tent he had set up among people.
61 He let his strength be taken away as a captive,
and his glory into the enemy's hand.
62 He also handed his people over to the sword.
He was angry with his inheritance.
63 Fire ate up their young men.
Their young women had no wedding song.
64 Their priests were killed by the sword,
and their widows could not weep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Once they had arrived in the land, the people became unfaithful again. They worshiped other gods at the "high places."

"A bow that cannot be trusted": a bow that fails when you shoot. That is how unreliable the people were.

Verses 60–64 remind us of the disaster in 1 Samuel 4: The Philistines defeated Israel, captured the ark of the covenant ("his strength," "his glory"), and killed the priests Hophni and Phinehas. After that, the sanctuary at Shiloh was probably destroyed (compare Jeremiah 7:12).

"Their widows could not weep": There were so many dead that there was no time for the usual mourning.

God chose David VERSES 65–72

65 Then the Lord woke up as if from sleep,
like a mighty warrior who shouts because of wine.
66 He beat his enemies back.
He put them to shame forever.
67 He also rejected the tent of Joseph
and did not choose the tribe of Ephraim.
68 But he chose the tribe of Judah,
Mount Zion, which he loves.
69 He built his sanctuary like the heights,
like the earth, which he has set firm forever.
70 He also chose David, his servant,
and took him from the sheep pens.
71 He brought him from following the mother sheep with their lambs,
to be the shepherd of Jacob, his people,
and of Israel, his inheritance.
72 So David was their shepherd with an honest heart.
He guided them with skillful hands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 65: A very bold picture: God "wakes up" like a warrior and steps in again. Of course God does not sleep (Psalm 121:4). But to the people, it looked that way.

Verses 67–68: God did not choose Ephraim in the north, but Judah in the south. Jerusalem on Mount Zion became the place of the temple.

Verses 70–72: At the end stands David. God took him away from the sheep and made him the shepherd of his people. The long story of unfaithfulness ends with a sign of grace: a king who leads "with an honest heart."

The psalm shows: The story of the people is full of failure. But God's faithfulness is greater.

PSALMS

PSALM 79

Jerusalem lies in ruins

The nations have broken into your inheritance VERSES 1–4

1 A psalm by Asaph.
God, the nations have come into your inheritance.
They have made your holy temple unclean.
They have turned Jerusalem into piles of ruins.
2 They have given the dead bodies of your servants
as food to the birds of the sky.

They have given the flesh of your faithful people to the animals of the earth.
3 They have poured out their blood like water all around Jerusalem.
There was no one to bury them.
4 We have become a joke to our neighbors.
The people around us mock us and laugh at us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like Psalm 74, Psalm 79 is a lament over the destruction of Jerusalem, probably by the Babylonians in 586 BC.

The description is shocking: The temple has been made unclean, the city lies in ruins, the dead lie unburied in the streets. For the people back then, that was the most terrible thing of all.

To this day, laments like this are a prayer for people who live through war and destruction.

How long, LORD? VERSES 5–7

5 How long, LORD?
Will you be angry forever?
Will your jealousy burn like fire?
6 Pour out your anger on the nations that do not know you,
on the kingdoms that do not call on your name.
7 For they have eaten up Jacob
and destroyed his homeland.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying knows: The destruction also has to do with the guilt of his own people. That is why he asks: How much longer will you be angry?

Verses 6–7 ask God to punish those who destroyed the city. Jeremiah 10:25 has almost the same words.

Forgive us for the sake of your name VERSES 8–10

8 Don't hold the sins of our ancestors against us!
Let your tender mercy come quickly to meet us,
for we are in great need.
9 Help us, God who saves us, for the glory of your name!
Rescue us, and forgive our sins for the sake of your name!
10 Why should the nations say, "Where is their God?"
Let the nations know, while we watch,
that you pay back those who poured out the blood of your servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–9: The people confess their guilt and ask for forgiveness. They do not point to anything good they have done, but to God's name and honor.

Verse 10: The nations mock: "Where is their God?" It is about God's reputation in the world.

"You pay back those who poured out the blood": The one praying leaves justice to God. He does not take revenge himself.

Hear the groaning of the prisoners VERSES 11–13

11 Let the groaning of the prisoners come before you!
By your great power, keep alive those who have been sentenced to death!
12 Lord, pay back our neighbors seven times over, right into their laps,
for the insults with which they have insulted you!
13 Then we, your people and the sheep of your pasture,
will thank you forever.
We will tell of your praise to all generations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: A prayer for the prisoners and for those who were taken away, who have been sentenced to death.

Verse 12: "Seven times over, right into their laps": completely, fully. The mocking was not aimed only at Israel, but at God himself.

Verse 13: In spite of everything, the psalm ends with a promise: We will praise you, also for the generations to come.

PSALMS

PSALM 80

Make your face shine

Shepherd of Israel, hear us! VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. To the tune of "The Lilies of the Covenant." A psalm by Asaph.
Hear us, Shepherd of Israel,
you who lead Joseph like a flock!
You who sit on your throne above the cherubim, shine out!
2 Before Ephraim, Benjamin, and Manasseh,
wake up your power! Come and save us!
3 Bring us back, God!
Make your face shine on us, and we will be saved.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 80 is a prayer for the northern kingdom of Israel (Joseph, Ephraim, Manasseh, Benjamin), perhaps after the Assyrians conquered it in 722 BC.

"You who sit on your throne above the cherubim": On the ark of the covenant there were two cherubim (figures of angels). People pictured God as a king sitting on his throne above them.

Verse 3 is a refrain. It appears three times (verses 3, 7, and 19), and it gets stronger each time: God, God of Armies, LORD God of Armies.

"Make your face shine": a request from the priestly blessing (Numbers 6:25). When God looks at us kindly, we are saved.

The bread of tears VERSES 4–7

4 LORD God of Armies,
how long will you be angry at the prayers of your people?
5 You have fed them with the bread of tears.
You have given them tears to drink in large amounts.

6 You make us something our neighbors fight over.
Our enemies laugh at us among themselves.
7 Bring us back, God of Armies!
Make your face shine on us, and we will be saved.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: A strong picture: Tears have become the daily bread of the people.

The people pray, but they feel as if God is even angry about their prayers.

The vine from Egypt VERSES 8–13

8 You brought a vine out of Egypt.
You drove out the nations and planted it.
9 You cleared the ground for it.
It put down deep roots and filled the land.
10 The mountains were covered with its shade.
Its branches were like God's cedars.
11 It sent out its branches as far as the sea,
and its shoots as far as the River.
12 Why have you broken down its walls,
so that all who pass by pick its fruit?
13 The wild boar from the forest tears it up.
The wild animals of the field feed on it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel is compared to a vine. God brought it out of Egypt, planted it, and took care of it. It grew and became large, from the Mediterranean Sea to the Euphrates.

But now the protecting wall has been torn down. Anyone can come and steal the grapes. Wild animals destroy the vineyard.

This picture appears often in the Bible (Isaiah 5:1–7; Hosea 10:1). Later, Jesus says: "I am the true vine" (John 15:1).

Look after this vine VERSES 14–19

14 Please come back, God of Armies!
Look down from heaven and see!
Take care of this vine,
15 the plant that your right hand planted,
the branch that you made strong for yourself.
16 It is burned with fire. It is cut down.
They die when you scold them.
17 Let your hand be on the man of your right hand,
on the son of man whom you made strong for yourself.
18 Then we will not turn away from you.
Give us new life, and we will call on your name.
19 Bring us back, LORD God of Armies!
Make your face shine on us, and we will be saved.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying asks God: Look after your vine! You planted it yourself.

Verse 17: "The man of your right hand" and "the son of man": This probably means the king, or perhaps the whole people. By the way, the name "Benjamin" (verse 2) means: son of the right hand. Christians have also thought of Jesus here, who calls himself the "Son of Man" and sits at the right hand of God.

Verse 18: The people promise: If you give us new life, we will stay faithful to you.

The psalm ends with the refrain in its strongest form: "LORD God of Armies."

PSALMS

Psalm 81

If only my people would listen to me

A festival song VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. On an instrument from Gath.
By Asaph.
Sing out loud to God, our strength!
Shout for joy to the God of Jacob!
2 Start a song, and bring the tambourine,
the lovely lyre, and the harp!
3 Blow the trumpet at the New Moon,
at the full moon, on our feast day!
4 For this is a rule for Israel,
a law of the God of Jacob.
5 He set it up as a covenant in Joseph
when he went out over the land of Egypt.
I heard a language that I did not know:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 81 begins as a joyful festival song. People celebrate with music and singing.

Verse 3: Festivals were celebrated at the New Moon and the full moon. This probably means the Festival of Booths in the fall, which begins at the full moon (Leviticus 23:34).

"Trumpet": In Hebrew, the word is "shofar." That is a ram's horn that people blow like a trumpet. Jews still blow it today on the High Holy Days.

Verse 5: "A language that I did not know": Suddenly the singer hears a voice he does not know. It is God's voice, which now speaks.

I set you free VERSES 6–10

6 "I took the load off his shoulder.
His hands were set free from the basket.
7 You called out in trouble, and I rescued you.
I answered you from the hidden place of thunder.
I tested you at the waters of Meribah."
Selah.
8 "Listen, my people, and I will warn you.
Israel, if only you would listen to me!
9 There must be no strange god among you.
You must not worship any foreign god.
10 I am the LORD, your God,
who brought you up out of the land of Egypt.
Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God reminds them of how he set them free from Egypt. There the Israelites had to carry heavy baskets with clay and bricks as slaves (Exodus 1:14).

"Meribah" means "quarreling." There the people quarreled with God because they had no water (Exodus 17:7).

Verses 9–10 remind us of the beginning of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:2–3).

"Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it": like a young bird that opens its beak wide and is fed by its mother. God wants to give generously.

But my people did not listen VERSES 11–16

11 But my people did not listen to my voice.
Israel wanted nothing to do with me.
12 So I let them follow their own stubborn hearts,
so that they would live by their own plans.
13 Oh, if only my people would listen to me!
If only Israel would walk in my ways!
14 I would soon bring their enemies down
and turn my hand against their attackers.
15 Those who hate the LORD would cower before him,
and their punishment would last forever.
16 But I would feed Israel with the finest wheat.
I will satisfy you with honey from the rock."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is disappointed: My people did not want to listen to me.

Verse 12: God forces no one. He lets people go their own ways, even when those ways lead to disaster (compare Romans 1:24).

Verse 13 is a longing sigh from God: "Oh, if only my people would listen to me!" God is not a cold judge. He longs for his people.

Verse 16: God would give them the very best. "Honey from the rock": Wild bees built their honeycombs in cracks in the rocks. It is a picture for surprising plenty.

PSALMS

PSALM 82

God judges the judges

God leads the assembly VERSES 1–4

1 A psalm by Asaph.
God leads the great assembly.
He judges among the gods.
2 "How long will you judge unfairly
and take the side of the wicked?"
Selah.
3 "Defend the weak, the poor, and the orphans!
Protect the rights of the poor and the oppressed!
4 Rescue the weak and needy!
Set them free from the hand of the wicked!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 82 shows a court scene in heaven. God stands in the middle of an assembly of "gods."

Who are these "gods"? There are different explanations:

– heavenly powers or angels who have been put in charge of the nations,

– the gods of the other nations,

– human judges and rulers who were supposed to judge in God's name (compare Exodus 21:6, where "God" can also mean "the judges").

What God demands of them is clear: Protect the weak, the poor, the orphans! That is the standard for everyone who has power.

You will die like men VERSES 5–8

5 They know nothing, and they understand nothing.
They walk around in darkness.
All the foundations of the earth are shaken.
6 I said, "You are gods.
All of you are sons of the Most High.
7 But you will die like men,
and you will fall like any one of the rulers."
8 Rise up, God, judge the earth,
for all the nations belong to you as your inheritance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: Because the powerful are unjust, the whole world shakes. Injustice destroys the foundations of life together.

Verses 6–7: They were highly honored, "sons of the Most High." But because they did not do their job, they lose their position. They will die like ordinary people.

Jesus quotes verse 6 in John 10:34–36, when people accuse him of making himself God.

Verse 8: The one praying calls on God himself as judge, because the human judges have failed. In the end, God will make sure that justice is done.

PSALMS

PSALM 83

God, do not keep silent!

They make secret plans against your people VERSES 1–8

1 A song. A psalm by Asaph.
God, don't keep silent!
Don't keep silent, and don't be still, God!
2 For look, your enemies are in an uproar.
Those who hate you have raised their heads.
3 They make clever plans against your people.
They plot against those you love.
4 "Come," they say, "let's destroy them as a nation,
so that no one remembers the name of Israel
anymore!"
5 For they have made their plans together with one
mind.

They make an alliance against you:
6 the tents of Edom and the Ishmaelites,
Moab and the Hagrites,
7 Gebal, Ammon, and Amalek,
Philistia with the people who live in Tyre.
8 Assyria has also joined them.
They have helped the descendants of Lot.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 83 is the last of the psalms of Asaph. Many nations join together against Israel. Their goal is to wipe out the whole people.

The nations surround Israel on all sides: Edom, Moab, and Ammon in the east (Moab and Ammon are the "descendants of Lot," Genesis 19:36–38), Philistia and Tyre in the west, Assyria in the north.

Gebal is probably a region south of the Dead Sea. The Hagrites were a people of the desert.

Sadly, verse 4 is still relevant today: Again and again in history, people have tried to destroy the Jewish people. The psalm is a cry for help against such hatred.

Do to them as you did to Midian VERSES 9–12

9 Do to them what you did to Midian,
what you did to Sisera and to Jabin at the Kishon River.
10 They were destroyed at Endor.
They became like manure for the ground.
11 Make their nobles like Oreb and Zeeb,
yes, all their princes like Zebah and Zalmunna,
12 who said, "Let's take God's pastures for ourselves."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying remembers earlier rescues from the time of the judges:

– Gideon defeated the Midianites and their leaders Oreb, Zeeb, Zebah, and Zalmunna (Judges 7–8).

– Deborah and Barak defeated Sisera, the army commander of King Jabin, at the Kishon River (Judges 4–5).

Just as God helped back then, he should help now too.

So that they seek your name VERSES 13–18

13 My God, make them like tumbleweed,
like chaff blown by the wind.
14 Like the fire that burns the forest,
like the flame that sets the mountains on fire,
15 chase them with your storm
and terrify them with your wild winds.
16 Fill their faces with shame,
so that they seek your name, LORD.
17 Let them be put to shame and terrified forever.
Yes, let them be confused and die,
18 so that they know that you alone, whose name is the LORD,
are the Most High over all the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Tumbleweed": dry plants that break off from their stems and are rolled across the land by the wind.

The request against the enemies is harsh. But verse 16 shows another goal: "so that they seek your name." The enemies are not only to be defeated, but to come to know God.

Verse 18: In the end, the whole world is to know that the LORD alone is God.

As with other harsh psalms: The judgment is left to God. It is not permission for violence or hatred against other nations.

PSALMS

Psalm 84

How lovely are your dwellings

My soul longs VERSES 1–4

1 For the music director. On an instrument from Gath. A psalm by the sons of Korah.
How lovely are your dwellings, LORD of Armies!
2 My soul longs, yes, it grows weak with longing for the courts of the LORD.
My heart and my body cry out for the living God.
3 Yes, even the sparrow has found a home,
and the swallow a nest for herself,
where she can raise her young,
near your altars, LORD of Armies,
my King and my God.
4 Happy are those who live in your house.
They are always praising you.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 84 is a pilgrim song. A person longs to travel to the temple in Jerusalem.

"How lovely": how beautiful, how dearly loved.

Verse 3 is a tender picture: Even the little birds have found a home at the temple. They build their nests close to God's altar. The one praying almost envies them.

Jesus says: Not one sparrow falls to the ground without your Father, and you are worth more than many sparrows (Matthew 10:29–31).

Johannes Brahms set verses 1–2 to music in his "German Requiem."

Through the valley of Weeping VERSES 5–7

5 Happy are those whose strength is in you,
who have set their hearts on the pilgrim road.
6 When they pass through the valley of Weeping,
they make it a place of springs.
Yes, the autumn rain covers it with blessings.
7 They go from strength to strength.
Every one of them appears before God in Zion.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Who have set their hearts on the pilgrim road": In their hearts, they are already on their way to God.

Verse 6: The "valley of Weeping" (in Hebrew, "Baca") may have been a dry valley on the way to Jerusalem. But for anyone who is on the way to God, even the valley of tears becomes a place full of springs.

That is a beautiful picture for life: Even through hard times, God can give strength and blessing.

Verse 7: "From strength to strength": The closer they come to the goal, the stronger they become.

A day in your courts VERSES 8–12

8 LORD God of Armies, hear my prayer!
Listen, God of Jacob!
Selah.
9 Look, God, our shield!
Look at the face of your anointed one!
10 For one day in your courts is better than 1,000.
I would rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God
than live in the tents of the wicked.
11 For the LORD God is a sun and a shield.
The LORD gives grace and glory.
He does not hold back any good thing
from those who live without blame.
12 LORD of Armies,
happy is the person who trusts in you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: A prayer for the king, the "anointed one."

Verse 10 is a well-known sentence: A single day with God is better than 1,000 days anywhere else. It is better to be a simple doorkeeper with God than a rich man among the wicked.

The "sons of Korah" were doorkeepers at the temple themselves (1 Chronicles 9:19). They knew what they were singing about.

Verse 11: God is "a sun and a shield": He gives light and warmth, and he protects.

PSALMS

PSALM 85

Righteousness and peace kiss each other

You were kind VERSES 1–3

1 For the music director. A psalm by the sons of Korah.
LORD, you have been kind to your land.
You have turned things around for Jacob.
2 You have forgiven the guilt of your people.
You have covered all their sin.
Selah.
3 You have taken away all your fury.
You have turned away from your burning anger.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm begins by looking back: In the past, God forgave and restored his people. This may mean the return from exile in Babylon (around 538 BC).

"Covered all their sin": God no longer looks at the guilt. It is forgiven.

Give us new life again VERSES 4–7

4 Bring us back, God who saves us,
and stop being angry with us!
5 Will you be angry with us forever?
Will your anger go on through all generations?
6 Won't you give us new life again,
so that your people may rejoice in you?
7 Show us your loving kindness, LORD.
Give us your saving help.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even after the return, things are difficult. The land is poor, and life is hard. The people ask: Give us new life again!

"So that your people may rejoice in you": The goal of the rescue is joy in God.

Righteousness and peace kiss each other VERSES 8–13

8 I will listen to what God, the LORD, will say,
for he will promise peace to his people, his faithful ones.
But they must not go back to foolishness.
9 Surely his saving help is near those who fear him,
so that glory may live in our land.
10 Mercy and truth meet each other.
Righteousness and peace have kissed each other.
11 Truth springs up out of the earth.
Righteousness looks down from heaven.
12 Yes, the LORD will give what is good.
Our land will give its harvest.
13 Righteousness goes ahead of him
and prepares the way for his steps.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: The one praying becomes quiet and listens to God. And God speaks of peace.

Verses 10–11 are wonderful pictures: God's qualities are described like people who meet and hug each other.

"Righteousness and peace have kissed each other": There is no real peace without justice, and justice leads to peace.

Verse 11: From below, truth grows out of the earth. From above, righteousness looks down from heaven. Heaven and earth come together.

"Truth" (verses 10 and 11): The Hebrew word "emet" means both: truth and faithfulness, being reliable. That is why many Bibles translate it here as "faithfulness."

Christians often read this psalm during Advent: God is coming, and righteousness goes ahead of him.

PSALMS

PSALM 86

Teach me your way

I am poor and needy VERSES 1–7

1 A prayer by David.
Hear me, LORD, and answer me,
for I am poor and needy.
2 Keep my soul safe, for I am faithful to you.
You are my God. Save your servant who trusts in you.
3 Be merciful to me, Lord,
for I call to you all day long.
4 Fill the soul of your servant with joy,
for to you, Lord, I lift up my soul.
5 For you, Lord, are good and ready to forgive.
You are rich in loving kindness to all who call on you.
6 LORD, hear my prayer!
Listen to my voice when I beg you for help!
7 On the day of my trouble I will call on you,
for you will answer me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 86 is the only psalm by David in the third book of Psalms.

It is put together from many sentences of other psalms and Bible passages, like a prayer woven from well-known words.

Verse 5: "For you, Lord, are good and ready to forgive": That is why the one praying trusts God.

No one is like you VERSES 8–10

8 Among the gods there is no one like you, Lord.
No deeds are like your deeds.
9 All the nations you have made
will come and worship before you, Lord.
They will honor your name.
10 For you are great, and you do wonderful things.
You alone are God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: God made all nations, and one day they will all come to him (compare Revelation 15:4).

Verse 10: "You alone are God": a clear statement of faith in the one God.

Give me an undivided heart VERSES 11–13

11 Teach me your way, LORD!
I will walk in your truth.
Give me an undivided heart, so that I fear your name.
12 I will praise you, Lord my God, with my whole heart.
I will honor your name forever.
13 For your loving kindness to me is great.
You have rescued my soul from the deepest part of Sheol (the world of the dead).

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11 is a beautiful prayer: "Give me an undivided heart." A divided heart wants two things at once: God and something else. The one praying asks for a heart that belongs completely to God.

Verse 13: God has rescued him from deadly danger.

Merciful and gracious VERSES 14–17

14 God, proud people have risen up against me.
A gang of violent men is out to take my life.
They do not care about you.
15 But you, Lord, are a God who is merciful and gracious,
slow to anger, and rich in loving kindness and truth.
16 Turn to me, and have mercy on me!
Give your strength to your servant!
Save the son of your servant!
17 Show me a sign of your goodness,
so that those who hate me see it and are put to shame,
because you, LORD, have helped me and comforted me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15 quotes one of the most important statements about God in the whole Bible. God himself said it to Moses: "A God who is full of mercy and kindness, slow to become angry, and rich in loving kindness and faithfulness" (Exodus 34:6).

Verse 16: "The son of your servant": In Hebrew, it says "the son of your female servant." It means: I belong to you completely, from birth on, like a child who was born in the house of a master.

Verse 17: The one praying asks for a visible sign that God is on his side.

PSALMS

PSALM 87

Zion, the mother of all nations

Glorious things are spoken about you VERSES 1–3

1 A psalm by the sons of Korah. A song.
His foundation is on the holy mountains.
2 The LORD loves the gates of Zion
more than all the homes of Jacob.
3 Glorious things are spoken about you,
city of God.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 87 is a short song about Jerusalem (Zion). God founded this city, and he loves it in a special way.

Verse 3 is famous: "Glorious things are spoken about you, city of God." A well-known English hymn ("Glorious Things of Thee Are Spoken") is based on it. It is sung to a melody by Joseph Haydn.

This one was born there VERSES 4–7

4 I will list Rahab and Babylon among those who know me.
Look, Philistia, Tyre, and also Ethiopia:
"This one was born there."
5 Yes, about Zion people will say,
"This one and that one were born in her."
The Most High himself will make her strong.

6 When the LORD writes down the peoples, he will count them:
"This one was born there."
Selah.
7 Those who sing and those who dance will say,
"All my springs are in you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is an amazing psalm! The enemies of Israel are listed: "Rahab" (a poetic name for Egypt), Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, and Ethiopia (in Hebrew, "Cush": the land south of Egypt).

And God says about them: "This one was born there," in Zion. God writes people from all nations into his book, as if they were citizens of Jerusalem.

In this way, Zion becomes the mother of all nations. That is a great vision: All people can belong to God, no matter where they come from (compare Isaiah 2:2–4; Galatians 4:26).

Verse 7: Everyone sings and dances: "All my springs are in you." God is the source of life for everyone.

PSALMS

Psalm 88

The darkest prayer

My life is close to death VERSES 1–9

1 A song. A psalm by the sons of Korah. For the music director.
To the tune of "The Suffering of Affliction." A contemplation by Heman, the Ezrahite.
LORD, God who saves me,
I have cried out before you day and night.
2 Let my prayer come before you!
Turn your ear to my cry!
3 For my soul is full of troubles.
My life is coming close to Sheol (the world of the dead).
4 I am counted among those who go down into the pit.
I am like a man who has no help,
5 set apart among the dead,
like those who were killed and lie in the grave,
whom you remember no more.
They are cut off from your hand.
6 You have put me in the lowest pit,
in the darkest depths.
7 Your anger lies heavily on me.
You have struck me with all your waves.
Selah.
8 You have taken my friends away from me.
You have made me disgusting to them.
I am shut in, and I cannot get out.
9 My eyes are dim from grief.
I have called on you every day, LORD.
I have stretched out my hands to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 88 is the darkest psalm in the Bible. It has no turn toward the light, and no praise at the end.

Heman was a singer and a wise man in the time of David and Solomon (1 Kings 4:31; 1 Chronicles 15:19).

The one praying is seriously ill, perhaps since he was young (verse 15). He feels as if he has been buried alive. His friends avoid him, perhaps because his sickness is contagious or repulsive (like leprosy).

And the worst part: He experiences his suffering as something that comes from God.

Do you do wonders for the dead? VERSES 10–12

10 Do you show wonders to the dead?
Do the spirits of the dead rise up and praise you?
Selah.
11 Is your loving kindness told about in the grave,
or your faithfulness in Destruction?
12 Are your wonders made known in the dark,
or your righteousness in the land where everything is forgotten?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The one praying asks God questions: If I die, what good is that to you? The dead cannot praise you.

In the Old Testament, people thought of the world of the dead as a dark place where everything is forgotten. "Destruction": In Hebrew, the word is "Abaddon," the place of destruction.

Christians believe: In Jesus, God did his greatest wonder for a dead man: the resurrection. That is an answer to these questions which the one praying did not yet know back then.

Why do you hide your face? VERSES 13–18

13 But I cry out to you, LORD.
In the morning, my prayer comes before you.
14 LORD, why do you reject my soul?
Why do you hide your face from me?
15 I have suffered and been close to death since I was young.
While I suffer your terrors, I do not know what to do.
16 Your burning anger has swept over me.
Your terrors have destroyed me.
17 They surrounded me like water all day long.
They closed in on me completely.
18 You have taken my loved ones and my friends far away from me.
You have put my friends into darkness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm ends with the word "darkness." In Hebrew, it really is the last word. There is no comfort and no answer.

Why is a psalm like this in the Bible? Because there are times when people see nothing but darkness. Psalm 88 shows: Even then, you may pray. Even then, you belong to God.

And: The one praying is still praying. In verse 1, he calls God "God who saves me." He does not give up talking with God. That alone is already a sign of faith.

If you feel like the one praying: Please don't stay alone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at

findahelpline.com. These lines are free and open day and night. If your life is in danger right now, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK). Doctors, pastors, and counseling centers can also help.

PSALMS

Psalm 89

God's covenant with David

I will sing of the LORD's loving kindness VERSES 1–4

1 A contemplation by Ethan, the Ezrahite.
I will sing of the loving kindness of the LORD forever.
With my mouth I will make your faithfulness known
to all generations.
2 I say, "Love stands firm forever.
You set up the heavens. Your faithfulness is in them."
3 "I have made a covenant with my chosen one.
I have made a promise with an oath to David, my
servant:
4 'I will make your descendants firm forever,
and I will build up your throne for all generations.'"
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like Heman, Ethan was a well-known wise man (1 Kings 4:31).

Psalm 89 remembers God's promise to David: His family would sit on the throne forever (2 Samuel 7:12–16).

Two words come up again and again in this psalm: "loving kindness" (or love) and "faithfulness," seven times each. God's loving kindness and faithfulness are the foundation for everything.

But at the end of the psalm, a hard question is asked: What has become of this promise?

Who is like the LORD? VERSES 5–18

5 The heavens will praise your wonders, LORD,
and your faithfulness in the assembly of the holy ones.
6 For who in the skies can be compared to the LORD?
Who among the heavenly beings is like the LORD,
7 a very awesome God in the council of the holy ones,
to be feared more than all who are around him?
8 LORD God of Armies, who is mighty like you?
Yah, your faithfulness is all around you.
9 You rule over the proud sea.
When its waves rise up, you calm them.
10 You have crushed Rahab like someone who has been
killed.
With your mighty arm you have scattered your
enemies.
11 The heavens are yours. The earth is yours too,
the world and everything in it. You have founded
them.
12 You created the north and the south.
Tabor and Hermon shout for joy at your name.
13 You have a mighty arm.
Your hand is strong, and your right hand is lifted high.
14 Righteousness and justice are the foundation of your
throne.
Loving kindness and truth go ahead of you.
15 Happy are the people who learn to cheer for you.
They walk in the light of your presence, LORD.
16 They rejoice in your name all day long.
They are lifted up by your righteousness.
17 For you are the glory of their strength.
By your kindness our horn will be lifted up.
18 For our shield belongs to the LORD,
and our king to the Holy One of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A great song of praise to God's power. In heaven there is no one who is equal to him.

Verse 10: Here "Rahab" is a sea monster, a picture for chaos (compare Job 26:12). Sometimes Rahab also stands for Egypt (Psalm 87:4).

Verse 12: Tabor and Hermon are two well-known mountains in the north of Israel.

Verse 14: God's rule rests on righteousness and justice. Loving kindness and truth go ahead of him like servants in front of a king.

Verse 18: The king of Israel belongs to God. He is God's "shield," the one who protects the people on God's behalf.

I have found David VERSES 19–29

19 Then you spoke in a vision to your faithful ones and
said,
"I have given strength to a warrior.
I have lifted up a young man from the people.
20 I have found David, my servant.
I have anointed him with my holy oil.
21 My hand will stay firmly with him.
My arm will also make him strong.
22 No enemy will demand tribute from him.
No wicked man will oppress him.
23 I will beat down his enemies in front of him
and strike those who hate him.
24 But my faithfulness and my loving kindness will be
with him.
In my name his horn will be lifted up.
25 I will also put his hand on the sea,
and his right hand on the rivers.
26 He will call to me, 'You are my Father,
my God, and the rock who saves me!'
27 I will also make him my firstborn,
the highest of the kings of the earth.
28 I will keep my loving kindness for him forever.
My covenant with him will stand firm.
29 I will also make his descendants last forever,
and his throne as long as the days of heaven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here God's promise to David is repeated in detail. The "vision" is probably the message of the prophet Nathan (2

Samuel 7).

God "found" David, a simple young man, and anointed him as king.

Verses 26–27: David may call God "Father," and God makes him the "firstborn," the most important king in the world.

Christians see in these words a pointer to Jesus, the Son of David, the "firstborn" (Colossians 1:15; Revelation 1:5).

Even if they become unfaithful VERSES 30–37

30 If his children leave my law
and do not live by my rules,
31 if they break my laws
and do not keep my commandments,
32 then I will punish their sin with the rod,
and their guilt with beatings.
33 But I will not completely take my loving kindness away from him.
I will not let my faithfulness fail.
34 I will not break my covenant.
I will not change what my lips have spoken.
35 Once and for all I have sworn by my holiness:
I will not lie to David.
36 His descendants will last forever,
and his throne will be like the sun before me.
37 It will stand firm forever like the moon,
the faithful witness in the sky."
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God promises: Even if David's descendants disobey, he will punish them, but he will not cancel his covenant.

"The rod" and "beatings": That is the language of raising children back then. Today we know that violence against children is wrong. What is meant here is: God will not overlook the guilt, but he will not reject his people.

Verse 37: The moon, which is in the sky every night, is like a witness to God's faithfulness.

But now you have rejected him VERSES 38–45

38 But you have rejected him and pushed him away.
You have been angry with your anointed one.
39 You have turned your back on the covenant with your servant.
You have thrown his crown into the dust and made it unclean.
40 You have broken down all his walls.
You have turned his fortresses into ruins.
41 All who pass by rob him.
He has become a joke to his neighbors.
42 You have lifted up the right hand of his enemies.
You have made all his enemies rejoice.
43 Yes, you turn back the edge of his sword,
and you have not helped him in battle.
44 You have put an end to his splendor
and thrown his throne down to the ground.
45 You have cut short the days of his youth.
You have covered him with shame.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the great break: "But you have rejected him!" The king from David's family is defeated, his crown lies in the dust, Jerusalem is destroyed.

This probably means the end of the kingdom of Judah, when the Babylonians conquered Jerusalem in 586 BC and took King Jehoiachin or King Zedekiah prisoner (2 Kings 24–25).

The one praying openly accuses God: You have broken your covenant! That sounds harsh, but it shows how seriously he takes God's promise.

Where is your loving kindness from before? VERSES 46–51

46 How long, LORD? Will you hide yourself forever?
Will your anger burn like fire?
47 Remember how short my time is!
How short and empty you have made the lives of all people!
48 What man can live and never see death?
Who can save his soul from the power of Sheol (the world of the dead)?
Selah.
49 Lord, where is your loving kindness from before,
which you swore to David in your faithfulness?
50 Lord, remember how your servants are insulted,
how I carry in my heart the mocking of all the mighty peoples,
51 the mocking with which your enemies have mocked, LORD,
with which they have mocked every step of your anointed one.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 49 is the great question of the psalm: "Lord, where is your loving kindness from before, which you swore to David in your faithfulness?"

That is a question the Jewish people asked themselves for a long time after the exile. There was no longer a king from David's family.

The Bible's answer is the hope for the Messiah, the coming king from David's family. Jews are still waiting for him today. Christians believe that Jesus, the "Son of David," is this king (Luke 1:32–33).

The end of the third book of Psalms VERSE 52

52 Praise be to the LORD forever.
Amen and amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This verse closes the third book of Psalms (Psalms 73–89).

It is remarkable: After all the lament and the open questions, the book still ends with praise. Faith holds on to God, even when the answers are missing.

With Psalm 90, the fourth book of Psalms begins.

PSALMS

PSALM 90

Teach us to count our days

The fourth book of Psalms

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Psalm 90, the fourth book of Psalms begins (Psalms 90–106).

After the end of the kingdom (Psalm 89), this book turns its eyes again to God himself as King. Many psalms call out: "The LORD reigns!" (Psalm 93; 96–99).

The book begins with the only psalm that is linked to Moses. That reminds us of the time before the kings, when God led his people through the desert.

From everlasting to everlasting you are God VERSES 1–6

1 A prayer by Moses, the man of God.
Lord, you have been our home
for all generations.
2 Before the mountains were born,
before you formed the earth and the world,
from everlasting to everlasting, you are God.
3 You turn people back to dust
and say, "Return, you children of men."
4 For in your eyes 1,000 years
are like yesterday when it is past,
like one watch in the night.
5 You sweep people away as they sleep.
In the morning they sprout like new grass.
6 In the morning it sprouts and grows.
By evening it is withered and dry.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is eternal. He was already there before the mountains came to be. For people, he is like a "home" where they are safe.

Verse 3: "Back to dust": The Hebrew word means something crushed, like dust. People return to the dust they were made from (Genesis 3:19).

Verse 4: For God, 1,000 years are like a day. Peter quotes this in 2 Peter 3:8.

Verses 5–6: Human life is like grass: fresh in the morning, withered in the evening.

Our life is like a sigh VERSES 7–11

7 For we are used up by your anger.
We are terrified by your fury.
8 You have put our sins in front of you,
our secret sins in the light of your presence.
9 For all our days have passed away under your anger.
We bring our years to an end like a sigh.
10 The days of our years are 70,
or 80 if we are strong.
But even their best is only hard work and sorrow,
for it soon passes, and we fly away.
11 Who knows the power of your anger,
your fury, as great as the fear that you deserve?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm is honest: Life is short, and it is often full of hard work. Human guilt adds to this.

Verse 10 is very well known: A human life lasts about 70 or 80 years. Even the best years are full of work and worry. And then it is over quickly.

This psalm is often read at funerals.

Teach us to count our days VERSE 12

12 So teach us to count our days,
so that we may gain a wise heart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the key verse of the psalm. Whoever knows that life is short lives more mindfully and more wisely.

"To count our days" means: to remember that our life has an end.

It is not about being afraid of death. It is about using well the time we have, and telling the important things apart from the unimportant things.

Make the work of our hands last VERSES 13–17

13 Turn back, LORD! How long?
Have compassion on your servants!
14 Satisfy us in the morning with your loving kindness,
so that we may shout for joy and be glad all our days!
15 Make us glad for as many days as you have made us suffer,
for as many years as we have seen trouble!
16 Let your servants see your work,
and let their children see your glory!
17 Let the kindness of the Lord our God be on us!
Make the work of our hands last for us.
Yes, make the work of our hands last!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After thinking about how short life is, the request comes: God, give us joy anyway! Let us enjoy the days we have.

Verse 15: A bold request: Give us as many good days as we had bad ones.

Verse 17: Life is short, but what we do should not be for nothing. God is to make our work last. A beautiful prayer before any work.

PSALMS

PSALM 91

Under the protection of the Most High

Whoever lives in the shelter of the Most High VERSES 1–4

1 Whoever lives in the secret place of the Most High
will rest in the shadow of the Almighty.
2 I will say about the LORD:
"He is my safe place and my fortress.
He is my God, and I trust in him."
3 For he will rescue you from the trap of the bird catcher,
and from the deadly plague.

4 He will cover you with his feathers.
Under his wings you will find shelter.
His faithfulness is your shield and your wall.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 91 is one of the best-known psalms of protection. Many people pray it in danger, before a journey or when they are sick. Soldiers have carried it with them in wars.

"In the secret place of the Most High": It means a hiding place. With God, you are safe, like in a secret hiding place.

Verse 3: A bird catcher set up nets and traps. God sets people free from traps.

Verse 4: Here again is the tender picture of a mother bird who takes her chicks under her wings.

You do not need to be afraid VERSES 5–8

5 You do not need to be afraid of the terror at night,
or of the arrow that flies by day,
6 or of the plague that moves around in the dark,
or of the destruction that ruins at noon.
7 1,000 may fall at your side,
and 10,000 at your right hand,
but it will not come near you.
8 You will only look with your eyes.
You will see how the wicked are paid back.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

There are dangers at every time of day: at night, by day, in the dark, at noon. With God, you are always safe.

Verse 7: A strong picture: Many people fall all around you, but you yourself are kept safe.

Important: This is not a promise that believers will never get sick or never die. Many faithful people have died of plagues. The psalm says: Nothing can separate us from God's protection, not even death (compare Romans 8:38–39).

He will put his angels in charge of you VERSES 9–13

9 For you have made the LORD your safe place,
and the Most High your home.
10 No evil will happen to you.
No plague will come near your home.
11 For he will put his angels in charge of you,
to guard you in all your ways.
12 They will carry you in their hands,
so that you do not hit your foot against a stone.
13 You will step on the lion and the cobra.
You will trample the young lion and the snake under your feet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12 are very well known: God sends angels who protect us. This is where the idea of a "guardian angel" comes from.

These verses appear when Jesus is tempted: The devil quotes them and tells Jesus to throw himself down from the temple. Jesus answers: "Do not test the Lord your God" (Matthew 4:5–7). That means: We should not put God to the test.

This shows: We must not misuse God's promises by putting ourselves in danger on purpose.

I will rescue him VERSES 14–16

14 "Because he has set his love on me,
I will rescue him.
I will put him in a high, safe place,
because he knows my name.
15 He will call to me, and I will answer him.
I will be with him in trouble.
I will rescue him and honor him.
16 I will fill him with a long life,
and I will show him my salvation."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, God himself speaks. He gives seven promises: to rescue, to put in a safe place, to answer, to be with him, to set free, to honor, to fill with life.

Verse 15 is especially comforting: "I will be with him in trouble." God does not promise that there will be no trouble. But he promises to be there in the trouble.

PSALMS

PSALM 92

A song for the Sabbath

It is good to give thanks to the LORD VERSES 1–5

1 A psalm. A song for the Sabbath day.
It is a good thing to give thanks to the LORD,
and to sing praises to your name, Most High,
2 to tell about your loving kindness in the morning,
and about your faithfulness every night,
3 with the ten-stringed lute, with the harp,
and with the music of the lyre.
4 For you, LORD, have made me glad through what you have done.
I will shout for joy about the works of your hands.
5 How great are your works, LORD!
Your thoughts are very deep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 92 is the only psalm that is clearly meant for the Sabbath. The Sabbath is the seventh day of the week, the day of rest (Exodus 20:8–11). Jewish people still pray this psalm on the Sabbath today.

On the day of rest, there is time to thank God: in the morning for his kindness, in the evening for his faithfulness.

Verse 5: God's thoughts are so deep that we can never understand them completely.

The wicked grow like grass VERSES 6–9

6 A person without sense does not know this,
and a fool does not understand it:
7 Even if the wicked spring up like grass,
and all who do evil flourish,
they will be destroyed forever.

8 But you, LORD, are high above forever.
9 For look, your enemies, LORD,
look, your enemies will die.
All who do evil will be scattered.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is the question again: Why do evil people do well? The answer: Their success is like grass. It grows quickly, but it also dries up quickly.

Verse 8 stands exactly in the middle of the psalm: "But you, LORD, are high above forever." This is the center.

Like a palm tree VERSES 10–15

10 But you have lifted up my horn like the horn of a wild ox.
That means: You have made me strong.
I am anointed with fresh oil.
11 My eyes have also seen my enemies.
My ears have heard about the wicked enemies who rise up against me.
12 The righteous person will flourish like a palm tree.
He will grow like a cedar in Lebanon.
13 They are planted in the LORD's house.
They will flourish in the courtyards of our God.
14 They will still bear fruit when they are old.
They will be full of sap and green,
15 to show that the LORD is upright.
He is my rock, and there is nothing wrong in him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wicked are like grass (verse 7). The righteous are like palm trees and cedars (verse 12). Grass dries up quickly. Palm trees and cedars live very long and stay green.

Verse 14 is a beautiful promise for old people: They can still bear fruit when they are old and be full of life. Old age is not an end. It can be a fruitful time.

PSALMS

PSALM 93

The LORD is King

The LORD is King VERSES 1–2

1 The LORD reigns!
That means: The LORD is King!
He is dressed in majesty!
The LORD is armed with strength.
The world also stands firm.
It cannot be moved.
2 Your throne has stood firm from long ago.
You have always been there, from everlasting.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 93 is the first of the so-called "kingship psalms" (Psalm 93; 95–99). They call out: "The LORD reigns!" That means: The LORD is King!

After the end of the kings in Israel (Psalm 89), hope turns to God himself as the true King.

God is dressed like a king: with majesty and strength instead of purple and gold.

Mightier than the roar of the sea VERSES 3–5

3 The floods have risen up, LORD.
The floods have raised their voice.
The floods lift up their waves.
4 Mightier than the roar of many waters,
mightier than the powerful breaking waves of the sea,
is the LORD on high.
5 Your laws stand firm.
Holiness makes your house beautiful, LORD, forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For people back then, the sea with its roaring waves was a picture of chaos and danger. You can hear the waves roll in three times: "The floods …"

But God is mightier than the raging sea. Even the most threatening powers in the world are smaller than he is.

Verse 5: God's laws can be trusted, and his house is holy.

PSALMS

PSALM 94

God of vengeance, shine out!

How long? VERSES 1–7

1 LORD, you God to whom vengeance belongs,
you God to whom vengeance belongs, shine out!
2 Rise up, you judge of the earth!
Pay back the proud people what they deserve!
3 LORD, how long will the wicked,
how long will the wicked celebrate their victory?
4 They pour out proud words.
All who do evil brag.
5 They crush your people, LORD,
and they oppress the people who belong to you.
6 They kill the widow and the foreigner,
and they murder the orphans.
7 They say: "Yah does not see it.
The God of Jacob does not notice it."
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"God to whom vengeance belongs": This sounds harsh. It means: God makes sure that there is justice. He does not let wrong go unpunished. Because vengeance belongs to God,

people do not have to take revenge themselves (compare Deuteronomy 32:35; Romans 12:19).

The wicked do the worst things: They kill the weakest people in society, widows, foreigners and orphans. These are exactly the people God especially wants to protect.

They think: God does not see anything.

Should he not see? VERSES 8–11

8 Pay attention, you people without sense!
You fools, when will you become wise?
9 He made the ear. Will he not hear?
He formed the eye. Will he not see?
10 He disciplines the nations. Will he not punish?
He teaches people. He knows.
11 The LORD knows people's thoughts.
He knows that they are worthless.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A clever argument: God gave people ears and eyes. How could he himself be blind and deaf? Of course he sees and hears everything.

Verse 11: Paul quotes this verse in 1 Corinthians 3:20.

Happy is the one you discipline VERSES 12–15

12 Happy is the person whom you discipline, Yah,
and whom you teach from your law.
13 Then you give him rest from the bad days,
until the pit is dug for the wicked.
14 For the LORD will not reject his people.
He will not leave the people who belong to him.
15 For justice will become right again.
All whose hearts are upright will follow it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's discipline is a sign of his love. Whoever knows God's teaching finds peace inside, even in bad times.

Verse 14 is a great promise: God does not reject his people.

Verse 15: One day, justice will be fair again. Now it is often twisted, but it will not stay that way.

When my foot was slipping VERSES 16–19

16 Who will stand up for me against the wicked?
Who will stand up for me against those who do evil?
17 If the LORD had not helped me,
my soul would soon have lived in silence.
18 When I said, "My foot is slipping!"
your loving kindness, LORD, held me up.
19 When there were many worried thoughts inside me,
your comfort made my soul glad.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying tells about what happened to him: No one helped him. Without God, he would have died. ("Lived in silence" means: in the world of the dead.)

Verse 18: A beautiful picture: Just when he thought he would slip and fall, God's loving kindness held him tight.

Verse 19: When worries go round and round in your head, God's comfort can make the soul glad. This is a verse for sleepless nights full of worrying.

The LORD is my fortress VERSES 20–23

20 Can a throne of evil be your partner,
a throne that causes harm through its laws?
21 They gather together against the life of the righteous person.
They condemn innocent people to death.
22 But the LORD has become my high tower.
My God is the rock where I am safe.
23 He has brought their own sin back on them.
He will destroy them in their own evil.
The LORD, our God, will destroy them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: A frightening thought: Evil rulers can even make wrong legal through laws. Sadly, this has often happened in history. But God has nothing to do with it.

Verse 21: Innocent people are condemned by courts.

Verses 22–23: But God is the safe fortress. Evil falls back on those who do it.

PSALMS

PSALM 95

Come, let us shout for joy!

Let us sing to the LORD VERSES 1–5

1 Come, let us sing to the LORD!
Let us shout out loud to the rock who saves us!
2 Let us come before him with thanks!
Let us praise him with songs!
3 For the LORD is a great God,
a great King above all gods.
4 The deep places of the earth are in his hand.
The tops of the mountains also belong to him.
5 The sea belongs to him, because he made it.
His hands formed the dry land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 95 is an invitation to worship. In many churches, it is prayed at the beginning of morning prayer. (In Latin, it is called "Venite," which means "Come.")

God is King over everything: the depths and the heights, the sea and the land.

Let us kneel down VERSES 6–7

6 Come, let us worship and bow down!
Let us kneel before the LORD, who made us!
7 For he is our God.
We are the people of his pasture, and the sheep in his care.
Today, oh, if only you would listen to his voice!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First there was loud shouting for joy (verses 1–2). Now comes quiet worship: kneeling down before the one who made us.

"The sheep in his care": God takes care of us like a shepherd. In Hebrew, it says: "the sheep of his hand."

"Today": The call is urgent. Not someday, but today we should listen to God.

Do not make your hearts hard VERSES 8–11

8 Do not make your hearts hard, as at Meribah,
as on the day at Massah in the wilderness.
9 There your ancestors tempted me.
They tested me, even though they had seen what I did.
10 For 40 long years, I was grieved with that generation.
I said: "They are a people whose hearts go the wrong way.
They have not known my ways."
11 That is why I swore in my anger:
"They will not enter my rest."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now God himself speaks. He reminds them of the time in the wilderness: At Meribah ("quarrel") and Massah ("testing"), the people complained against God because they had no water (Exodus 17:1–7).

For 40 years, the people disobeyed in the wilderness. That is why this generation was not allowed to enter the promised land, God's "rest" (Numbers 14).

The letter to the Hebrews quotes verses 7–11 at length and calls its readers: "Today, if you hear his voice, don't harden your hearts!" (Hebrews 3:7–4:11).

PSALMS

PSALM 96

Sing a new song to the LORD

All the earth, sing to the LORD! VERSES 1–6

1 Sing a new song to the LORD!
Sing to the LORD, all the earth!
2 Sing to the LORD! Praise his name!
Tell about how he saves, day after day!
3 Tell the nations about his glory.
Tell all the peoples about his wonderful works!
4 For the LORD is great, and he deserves great praise!
He is to be feared more than all gods.
5 For all the gods of the peoples are idols,
but the LORD made the heavens.
6 Honor and majesty are before him.
Strength and beauty are in his holy place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 96 is a mission song: All nations should learn about God and praise him.

Verse 5: The gods of the other nations are "idols." In Hebrew, the word means "nothings." They cannot do anything. But the LORD made the heavens.

This psalm also appears almost word for word in 1 Chronicles 16:23–33. There it is sung when the ark of the covenant is brought to Jerusalem.

Give honor to the LORD VERSES 7–10

7 You families of the nations, give to the LORD,
give to the LORD glory and strength!
8 Give to the LORD the glory his name deserves!
Bring an offering, and come into his courtyards!
9 Worship the LORD in holy clothing!
Tremble before him, all the earth!
10 Say among the nations: "The LORD reigns!"
That means: The LORD is King!
The world also stands firm. It cannot be moved.
He will judge the peoples fairly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–9 remind us of Psalm 29:1–2. But there it was the heavenly beings. Here it is the families of the nations, that is, all people.

Verse 10: The good news for the world: "The LORD reigns!" That means: The LORD is King! He will judge fairly.

All creation shouts for joy VERSES 11–13

11 Let the heavens be glad, and let the earth rejoice!
Let the sea roar, and everything that fills it!
12 Let the field and everything in it celebrate!
Then all the trees of the forest will sing for joy
13 before the LORD, for he comes,
for he comes to judge the earth.
He will judge the world with righteousness,
and the peoples with his truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Not only people, but all creation shouts for joy: heaven, earth, sea, fields and trees.

Why? Because God comes to judge the world fairly. For people who are oppressed, this is good news: At last, justice is coming!

"He comes": Christians read this psalm in Advent and at Christmas.

PSALMS

PSALM 97

The LORD is King, let the earth rejoice

Clouds and darkness around him VERSES 1–6

1 The LORD reigns! Let the earth rejoice!
Let the many islands be glad!
2 Clouds and darkness are all around him.
Righteousness and justice are the foundation of his

throne.
3 A fire goes ahead of him.
It burns up his enemies all around.
4 His lightning lights up the world.
The earth sees it and trembles.
5 The mountains melt like wax before the LORD,
before the Lord of the whole earth.
6 The heavens tell about his righteousness.
All the peoples have seen his glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God appears like he did at Mount Sinai: with clouds, darkness, fire and lightning (Exodus 19:16–18).

"The islands": These are the faraway lands by the sea. It means the whole world.

Verse 2: God is full of mystery ("clouds and darkness"). But one thing is certain: His rule is built on righteousness.

Let those who serve idols be put to shame VERSES 7–9

7 Let all who serve carved images be put to shame,
all who brag about their idols.
Worship him, all you gods!
8 Zion heard it and was glad.
The daughters of Judah rejoiced because of your judgments, LORD.
9 For you, LORD, are the Most High over all the earth.
You are lifted high above all gods.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever worships images of gods that people have made will be disappointed.

"Worship him, all you gods!": All the powers that people honor must bow down before the true God. The letter to the Hebrews applies a similar statement to the angels (Hebrews 1:6).

Light is sown for the righteous VERSES 10–12

10 You who love the LORD, hate evil!
He protects the lives of his holy people.
He rescues them from the hand of the wicked.
11 Light is sown for the righteous,
and joy for those whose hearts are upright.
12 Be glad in the LORD, you righteous people!
Give thanks to his holy name!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Whoever loves God turns away from evil. Love for God and hatred of evil belong together.

Verse 11 is a beautiful picture: Light is "sown" like seed. It grows slowly, but it will come up. This is true even if you cannot see it yet.

PSALMS

PSALM 98

Let the rivers clap their hands

He has done wonderful things VERSES 1–3

1 A psalm.
Sing a new song to the LORD,
for he has done wonderful things!
His right hand and his holy arm have won salvation for him.
2 The LORD has made known how he saves.
He has shown his righteousness openly, in front of the nations.
3 He has remembered his loving kindness and his faithfulness
toward the people of Israel.
All the ends of the earth have seen how our God saves.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 98 is like Psalm 96. It celebrates how God saves, and the whole world has seen it.

God has stayed faithful to his people Israel. And all the nations see it.

Mary takes up thoughts from this psalm in her song of praise (the "Magnificat") (Luke 1:54).

Shout for joy to the King VERSES 4–6

4 Shout for joy to the LORD, all the earth!
Burst out and sing for joy! Yes, sing praises!
5 Sing praises to the LORD with the harp,
with the harp and the sound of singing!
6 With trumpets and the sound of the ram's horn,
shout for joy before the King, the LORD!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A big, loud celebration: singing, harps, trumpets and rams' horns (in Hebrew: shofar).

God is celebrated like a king when he is crowned.

All creation shouts for joy VERSES 7–9

7 Let the sea roar, and everything that fills it,
the world, and those who live in it.
8 Let the rivers clap their hands.
Let the mountains sing for joy together
9 before the LORD, for he comes to judge the earth.
He will judge the world with righteousness,
and the peoples fairly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A happy picture: The rivers clap their hands, the mountains sing. All of nature celebrates God.

The well-known Christmas song "Joy to the World" is based on this psalm.

Like Psalm 96, this psalm also ends with hope: God comes and brings justice for everyone.

PSALMS

PSALM 99

He is holy!

The LORD is King in Zion VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD reigns! Let the peoples tremble.
He sits on his throne above the cherubim.
Cherubim are heavenly beings.
Let the earth shake.
2 The LORD is great in Zion.
He is high above all the peoples.
3 Let them praise your great and awesome name.
He is holy!
4 The King is strong, and he loves justice.
You have set up what is fair.
You do what is just and right in Jacob.
5 Lift up the LORD our God with praise!
Worship at his footstool!
He is holy!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 99 is the last of the kingship psalms (93–99). Three times we hear the call: "He is holy!" (verses 3, 5 and 9). This reminds us of the angels in Isaiah 6:3: "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of Armies!"

"Holy" means: completely different, pure, high above everything.

"His footstool": This means the ark of the covenant in the temple. People imagined that God sat invisibly on his throne above the cherubim and rested his feet on the ark.

Verse 4: God's strength is not random or cruel. It loves justice.

Moses, Aaron and Samuel VERSES 6–9

6 Moses and Aaron were among his priests.
Samuel was among those who called on his name.
They called to the LORD, and he answered them.
7 He spoke to them from the pillar of cloud.
They kept his rules and the law that he gave them.
8 You answered them, LORD our God.
You were a God who forgave them,
even though you punished them for what they did.
9 Lift up the LORD our God with praise!
Worship at his holy hill,
for the LORD our God is holy!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Three great people of prayer are named: Moses, Aaron and Samuel. They prayed for the people, and God answered (compare Exodus 32:11–14; 1 Samuel 7:9).

Verse 8: God is holy. That is why he takes sin seriously and punishes it. But he also forgives. Both belong together: justice and grace.

PSALMS

PSALM 100

Shout for joy to the LORD, all you lands!

Serve the LORD with gladness VERSES 1–3

1 A psalm of thanksgiving.
Shout for joy to the LORD, all you lands!
2 Serve the LORD with gladness!
Come before him with singing!
3 Know that the LORD is God!
He made us, and we belong to him.
We are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 100 is one of the best-known psalms of praise. It was probably sung when people came to the temple with a thank offering.

"Serve the LORD with gladness": Worship is not a sad duty. It is a celebration.

Verse 3: Three reasons for joy: The LORD is God. He made us. We belong to him, like sheep belong to their shepherd.

In Hebrew, verse 3 can also be read in a different way. Then it says: He made us, and we did not make ourselves. The WEB, our English source text, reads "and we are his."

Go through his gates with thanks VERSES 4–5

4 Go through his gates with thanks,
and into his courtyards with praise!
Give thanks to him, and praise his name!
5 For the LORD is good.
His loving kindness lasts forever,
and his faithfulness lasts through all generations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The pilgrims walk through the gates into the temple, with songs of thanks on their lips.

Verse 5: The reason for all thanks: "The LORD is good. His loving kindness lasts forever." This sentence appears very often in the Bible (for example, Psalm 106:1; 107:1; 136).

Many people know this psalm as a hymn, for example "All People That on Earth Do Dwell."

PSALMS

PSALM 101

A king's promise

I will live a blameless life VERSES 1–4

1 A psalm by David.
I will sing about loving kindness and justice.
To you, LORD, I will sing praises.
2 I will be careful to live a blameless life.
Blameless means: no one can accuse me of doing wrong.
When will you come to me?
I will live in my house with an honest heart.
3 I will not put anything vile in front of my eyes.
I hate what unfaithful people do.
It will not stick to me.
4 A twisted heart will be far from me.
I will have nothing to do with evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 101 is like a king's plan for how he will govern. He promises to rule justly, and he begins with his own life.

"In my house": Honesty begins at home, not only in public.

Verse 3: "I will not put anything vile in front of my eyes": He does not want to be influenced by bad things. This is true today too, for example in what we choose to watch.

"When will you come to me?": The king longs for God to be near.

Who may live with me VERSES 5–8

5 Whoever secretly tells lies about his neighbor, I will silence.
Whoever is arrogant and proud, I will not put up with.
6 My eyes will look for the faithful people of the land, so that they may live with me.
Whoever lives a blameless life will serve me.
7 Whoever cheats others will not live in my house.
Whoever tells lies will not stand before my eyes.
8 Morning after morning, I will destroy all the wicked people of the land.
I will remove all who do evil from the LORD's city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king does not want people who spread lies, liars or cheaters in his government. He looks for faithful and honest servants.

Verse 8: "Morning after morning": Back then, kings held court in the morning. The king promises to make sure every day that there is justice and that crimes are punished.

This is the task of a ruler with lawful authority to judge, under just laws. It does not allow any person to use violence against others on their own.

PSALMS

PSALM 102

The prayer of a suffering person

My days vanish like smoke VERSES 1–11

1 A prayer of a suffering person, when he is overwhelmed and pours out his complaint before the LORD.
Hear my prayer, LORD!
Let my cry come to you!
2 Do not hide your face from me on the day of my trouble!
Turn your ear to me!
Answer me quickly on the day when I call!
3 For my days vanish like smoke.
My bones burn like a torch.
4 My heart is struck down like grass, and dried up, for I forget to eat my bread.
5 Because of my loud groaning, my bones stick to my skin.
6 I am like a pelican in the wilderness.
I have become like an owl in the ruins.
7 I lie awake.
I have become like a sparrow that is alone on the roof.
8 My enemies insult me all day long.
Those who are angry with me use my name as a curse.
9 For I have eaten ashes like bread, and I have mixed my drink with tears,
10 because of your fury and your anger.
For you have picked me up and thrown me away.
11 My days are like a long shadow in the evening.
I have dried up like grass.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 102 has a special heading: It is for every person who is "suffering" and "overwhelmed." Anyone may use it as his or her own prayer.

It is one of the seven psalms of repentance.

The person praying describes deep loneliness and sickness: He forgets to eat. He is only skin and bones. He cannot sleep.

Verses 6–7: Three pictures for loneliness: a bird in the wilderness, an owl in the ruins, a sparrow alone on the roof.

If you feel this lonely and desperate: Please talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

But you remain VERSES 12–17

12 But you, LORD, will remain forever.
People will remember you in all generations.
13 You will rise up and have mercy on Zion, for it is time to be kind to her.
Yes, the time you have set has come.
14 For your servants love her stones, and they feel sorry for her dust.
15 Then the nations will fear the name of the LORD, and all the kings of the earth will fear your glory.
16 For the LORD has built up Zion.
He has appeared in his glory.
17 He has answered the prayer of the poor and helpless.
He has not looked down on their prayer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12 is the turning point: "But you, LORD, will remain forever." People pass away, but God remains.

Now the person praying thinks of Jerusalem (Zion), which lies in ruins. The people even love the stones and the dust of the destroyed city.

Verse 17: God hears the prayer of those who are poor and left alone. He does not look down on it.

For the generation to come VERSES 18–22

18 This will be written down for the generation to come.
A people who will be created later will praise Yah.
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
19 For he has looked down from his high, holy place.
From heaven, the LORD looked at the earth,
20 to hear the groaning of the prisoners,
and to set free those who are sentenced to death.
21 Then people will tell about the name of the LORD in Zion,
and about his praise in Jerusalem,
22 when the peoples and the kingdoms gather together
to serve the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

How God saves should be written down, so that later generations can learn about it. This is one reason why the Bible was written.

God looks down from heaven at the prisoners and at those sentenced to death.

In the end, all nations gather to serve God.

You stay the same VERSES 23–28

23 He has weakened my strength along the way.
He has shortened my days.
24 I said: "My God, do not take me away in the middle of my life!
Your years go on through all generations.
25 Long ago, you laid the foundation of the earth.
The heavens are the work of your hands.
26 They will pass away, but you will remain.
Yes, all of them will wear out like a piece of clothing.
You will change them like a coat, and they will be changed.
27 But you stay the same.
Your years will never end.
28 The children of your servants will live on.
Their descendants will stand firm before you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying asks: Do not let me die in the middle of my life!

Verses 25–27: Even heaven and earth will wear out like a piece of clothing, and one day they will be replaced. Only God always stays the same.

The letter to the Hebrews quotes verses 25–27 and applies them to Jesus (Hebrews 1:10–12).

Verse 28: The psalm ends with hope for the generations to come.

PSALMS

PSALM 103

Praise the LORD, my soul

Do not forget the good he has done for you VERSES 1–5

1 By David.
Praise the LORD, my soul!
Everything inside me, praise his holy name!
2 Praise the LORD, my soul,
and do not forget all the good he has done for you.
3 He forgives all your sins.
He heals all your diseases.
4 He saves your life from the grave.
He crowns you with loving kindness and tender mercy.
5 He fills your life with good things,
so that you become young again, like the eagle.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 103 is one of the most beautiful psalms of praise in the Bible. The person praying speaks to his own soul and tells it to praise God.

"Do not forget": It is easy to forget how much good we have received. The psalm reminds us.

Five good gifts: forgiveness, healing, rescue, a crown of love, and being filled with good things.

Verse 5: The eagle sheds its old feathers and gets new ones. Then it looks young and strong again. In the same way, God renews our strength (compare Isaiah 40:31).

The well-known hymn "Praise to the Lord, the Almighty, the King of creation" was inspired by this psalm.

The LORD is merciful and gracious VERSES 6–12

6 The LORD does what is right.
He brings justice for all who are oppressed.
7 He showed Moses his ways.
He showed the people of Israel what he does.
8 The LORD is merciful and gracious.
He is slow to become angry, and he is full of loving kindness.
9 He will not always accuse us.
He will not stay angry forever.
10 He has not treated us as our sins deserve.
He has not paid us back for our wrongs.
11 For as high as the heavens are above the earth,
so great is his loving kindness toward those who fear him.
12 As far as the east is from the west,
so far has he removed our sins from us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8 again quotes how God describes himself in Exodus 34:6.

Verse 10: God does not give us what we deserve. He is more gracious than we deserve.

Verses 11–12: Two wonderful pictures for God's love and forgiveness:

– His loving kindness is as high as the heavens.

– As far as the east is from the west, that is how far God throws away our sins. East and west never meet. Sin that is forgiven never comes back.

As a father has compassion on his children VERSES 13–18

13 As a father has compassion on his children,
so the LORD has compassion on those who fear him.
14 For he knows how we are made.
He remembers that we are dust.
15 As for people, their days are like grass.
They bloom like a flower in the field.
16 Then the wind blows over it, and it is gone.
Its place does not remember it anymore.
17 But the LORD's loving kindness lasts from everlasting
to everlasting
for those who fear him.
His righteousness reaches to their grandchildren,
18 to those who keep his covenant,
and to those who remember to obey his commands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: God is like a loving father. He feels for his children.

Verse 14: God knows how weak we are. He knows that we are made of dust. That is why he does not ask the impossible of us.

Verses 15–16: Human life is short, like the life of a flower.

Verse 17: But God's love lasts forever. It reaches to the grandchildren and great-grandchildren.

Praise the LORD, you angels! VERSES 19–22

19 The LORD has set up his throne in heaven.
His kingdom rules over everything.
20 Praise the LORD, you angels of his,
you mighty and strong ones who carry out his word
and obey the voice of his word!
21 Praise the LORD, all his armies,
you servants of his who do what he wants!
22 Praise the LORD, all his works,
in all the places where he rules!
Praise the LORD, my soul!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, the praise grows wider and wider: from one's own soul to the angels, to all the armies of heaven, to all creatures everywhere.

And then the psalm returns to the beginning: "Praise the LORD, my soul!" The great praise of the whole universe begins and ends in one's own heart.

PSALMS

Psalm 104

How many are your works!

Wrapped in light VERSES 1–4

1 Praise the LORD, my soul!
LORD, my God, you are very great.
You are dressed in honor and majesty.
2 He wraps himself in light as in a robe.
He stretches out the heavens like a curtain.
3 He lays the beams of his rooms on the waters.
He makes the clouds his chariot.
He walks on the wings of the wind.
4 He makes the winds his messengers,
and flames of fire his servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 104 is a great psalm about creation. It tells in pictures how God created the world and keeps it going, much like Genesis 1.

It begins and ends like Psalm 103: "Praise the LORD, my soul!" Psalm 103 praises God for his forgiveness. Psalm 104 praises him for his creation.

God is dressed in light. He stretches out the sky like the cloth of a tent. Clouds and wind are like his vehicle and his servants.

The letter to the Hebrews quotes verse 4 and applies it to the angels (Hebrews 1:7).

The waters and the mountains VERSES 5–9

5 He set the earth on its foundations,
so that it will never be moved.
6 You covered it with the deep waters like a coat.
The waters stood above the mountains.
7 When you scolded them, they ran away.
At the sound of your thunder, they hurried away.
8 The mountains rose up, and the valleys sank down,
to the place you had chosen for them.
9 You have set a border that the waters may not cross,
so that they never cover the earth again.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the beginning, everything was covered with water (compare Genesis 1:2, 9). At God's command, the waters pulled back, and the land and the mountains appeared.

Verse 9: God has set a border for the sea (compare Job 38:8–11).

Springs for all the animals VERSES 10–18

10 He sends springs into the valleys.
They flow between the mountains.
11 They give water to every animal of the field.
The wild donkeys satisfy their thirst.
12 The birds of the sky build their nests beside them.
They sing among the branches.
13 He waters the mountains from his rooms above.
The earth is filled with the fruit of your works.
14 He makes the grass grow for the cattle,
and plants for people to grow,
so that they can bring food out of the earth:

15 wine that makes people's hearts glad,
oil that makes their faces shine,
and bread that gives strength to their hearts.
16 The LORD's trees get plenty of water,
the cedars of Lebanon, which he planted.
17 There the birds build their nests.
The stork makes its home in the cypress trees.
18 The high mountains are for the wild goats.
The rocks are a safe place for the rock badgers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A wonderful picture: God takes care of all living things. Each one has its place: the wild donkeys at the springs, the birds in the branches, the stork in the trees, the wild goats on the mountains.

Rock badgers are small animals that live in cracks in the rocks. They are about as big as rabbits.

Verse 15: God does not give only what is most necessary. He also gives joy: wine for the heart, oil for beauty, bread for strength.

Day and night VERSES 19–23

19 He made the moon to mark the seasons.
The sun knows when to go down.
20 You make darkness, and it is night.
Then all the animals of the forest move around.
21 The young lions roar for their prey.
They ask God for their food.
22 The sun rises, and they slip away.
They lie down in their dens.
23 People go out to their work,
to their labor until the evening.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The moon sets the calendar (months and festivals). The sun sets day and night.

A beautiful rhythm: At night the lions hunt. By day people work. Each has its own time.

Even the roaring of the lions is like a prayer: "They ask God for their food."

How many are your works! VERSES 24–30

24 LORD, how many are your works!
You made them all with wisdom.
The earth is full of your riches.
25 There is the sea, great and wide.
It is full of living things that no one can count,
both small and large animals.
26 The ships sail there,
and so does Leviathan, which you formed to play
there.
27 They all wait for you
to give them their food at the right time.
28 You give it to them, and they gather it.
You open your hand, and they are filled with good
things.
29 When you hide your face, they are frightened.
When you take away their breath, they die and turn
back into dust.
30 When you send out your Spirit, they are created.
You make the face of the ground new.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24 is the high point: "LORD, how many are your works! You made them all with wisdom." The great variety of creation shows God's wisdom.

Verse 26: Leviathan is usually a picture of threatening chaos (Job 41). Here it is like a pet that God made for playing. Some people think of a whale.

Verses 27–30: All life depends on God. When he gives his breath, the creatures live. When he takes it away, they die.

Verse 30 is prayed at Pentecost: "When you send out your Spirit, they are created. You make the face of the ground new."

I will sing to the LORD as long as I live VERSES 31–35

31 Let the glory of the LORD last forever!
Let the LORD be glad about his works!
32 He looks at the earth, and it trembles.
He touches the mountains, and they smoke.
33 I will sing to the LORD as long as I live.
I will sing praise to my God as long as I exist.
34 May my thoughts please him.
I will be glad in the LORD.
35 Let sinners disappear from the earth.
Let the wicked be no more.
Praise the LORD, my soul!
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: God himself is glad about his creation (compare Genesis 1:31: "It was very good").

Verse 35: A surprising wish at the end: The sinners should disappear, because they spoil God's good creation. It means: Evil should disappear from this beautiful world.

"Praise Yah!": In Hebrew, this is "Hallelujah!" Here this word appears for the first time in the book of Psalms. (Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.)

Psalm 104 is an invitation to look at nature with open eyes and to discover God's wisdom and love in it. It also shows: Creation belongs to God. We should respect it and take care of it.

PSALMS

PSALM 105

God keeps his covenant with Abraham

Remember his wonderful works VERSES 1–6

1 Give thanks to the LORD! Call on his name!
Tell the peoples what he has done!
2 Sing to him, sing praises to him!
Tell about all his wonderful works!
3 Be proud of his holy name!
Let the hearts of those who seek the LORD be glad.

4 Seek the LORD and his strength!
Seek his face always!
5 Remember the wonderful works he has done,
his wonders, and the judgments he has spoken,
6 you descendants of Abraham, his servant,
you children of Jacob, his chosen ones!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 105 tells the story of Israel from Abraham up to the time when the people entered the promised land. Unlike Psalm 78 and Psalm 106, it tells only about God's faithfulness, not about the unfaithfulness of the people.

Verses 1–15 also appear almost word for word in 1 Chronicles 16:8–22.

"Seek his face always": The relationship with God should never stop.

The everlasting covenant VERSES 7–15

7 He is the LORD, our God.
His judgments are in all the earth.
8 He has remembered his covenant forever,
the word he commanded for 1,000 generations.
9 It is the covenant he made with Abraham,
and the promise he swore to Isaac.
10 He confirmed it to Jacob as a law,
to Israel as a covenant that lasts forever.
11 He said: "I will give you the land of Canaan.
It will be your share and your inheritance."
12 At that time, they were only a few people,
yes, very few, and they were foreigners in the land.
13 They moved around from nation to nation,
from one kingdom to another people.
14 He did not allow anyone to harm them.
Yes, he warned kings because of them:
15 "Do not touch my anointed ones!
Do not harm my prophets!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God promised Abraham, Isaac and Jacob that he would give the land of Canaan to their descendants (Genesis 12:7; 26:3; 28:13).

When the family was still small and moved around as foreigners, God protected them. He even warned kings, for example Pharaoh and Abimelech (Genesis 12:17; 20:3).

"My anointed ones" and "my prophets": This means Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. In Genesis 20:7, Abraham is called a "prophet."

Joseph in Egypt VERSES 16–22

16 He called for a famine on the land.
He destroyed all their supplies of food.
17 He sent a man ahead of them:
Joseph was sold as a slave.
18 They hurt his feet with chains.
His neck was locked in iron,
19 until the time came when what he had said happened,
and the word of the LORD proved him right.
20 The king sent for him and set him free.
The ruler of peoples let him go free.
21 He made him lord over his house,
and ruler over everything he owned.
22 Joseph could give orders to his princes as he wanted,
and he taught his elders wisdom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the story of Joseph is told in a few words (Genesis 37–45). His brothers sold him as a slave, and he ended up in prison.

But God had a plan: Joseph became the second most powerful man in Egypt, and he saved his family from hunger.

Verse 19: "Until the time came when what he had said happened": Joseph had explained dreams. When they came true, he was set free.

Israel in Egypt VERSES 23–36

23 Israel also came to Egypt.
Jacob lived as a foreigner in the land of Ham.
24 The LORD made his people grow very large in number.
He made them stronger than their enemies.
25 He turned the hearts of the Egyptians to hate his people,
and to make secret plans against his servants.
26 He sent Moses, his servant,
and Aaron, whom he had chosen.
27 They did his miraculous signs among them,
and wonders in the land of Ham.
28 He sent darkness and made it dark.
They did not rebel against his words.
29 He turned their waters into blood,
and he killed their fish.
30 Their land swarmed with frogs,
even in the rooms of their kings.
31 He spoke, and swarms of flies came,
and lice in all their land.
32 He gave them hail instead of rain,
with lightning in their land.
33 He struck their grapevines and their fig trees.
He broke the trees of their country.
34 He spoke, and the locusts came,
and grasshoppers without number.
35 They ate up every plant in their land.
They ate up the fruit of their ground.
36 He also struck down all the firstborn in their land,
the first sons of all their strength.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob's family (Israel) moved to Egypt and became a large nation there. Then the Egyptians oppressed them (Exodus 1).

"The land of Ham": This means Egypt (compare Psalm 78:51).

Verse 25: "He turned the hearts of the Egyptians": The Bible sees God's plan even behind the hatred of the Egyptians. But this does not free the Egyptians from their own responsibility.

Verses 28–36: The plagues are listed, but not in exactly the same order as in Exodus 7–12. Here the darkness comes first.

Verse 28: "They did not rebel against his words": This probably means Moses and Aaron, who faithfully carried out God's commands.

He brought them out with joy VERSES 37–45

37 He brought them out with silver and gold.
Among his tribes, no one was weak.
38 Egypt was glad when they left,
because the Egyptians had become afraid of them.
39 He spread out a cloud as a covering,
and a fire to give light at night.
40 They asked, and he brought quails.
He filled them with bread from the sky.
41 He opened the rock, and water gushed out.
It flowed like a river through the dry places.
42 For he remembered his holy promise,
and Abraham, his servant.
43 He brought his people out with joy,
his chosen ones with singing.
44 He gave them the lands of the nations.
They took over what other peoples had worked for,
45 so that they would keep his rules
and obey his laws.
Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Leaving Egypt is described as a happy celebration. When the people of Israel left, they even received silver and gold from the Egyptians (Exodus 12:35–36).

In the wilderness, God provided everything: the cloud and the fire, quails, manna and water from the rock.

Verse 42: The reason for everything: God did not forget his promise to Abraham.

Verse 45: The goal: The people should live in the land God gave them and follow his teaching. The land is a gift that comes with responsibility.

The taking of the land is told from Israel's point of view. It is not a command for today to drive other peoples out.

PSALMS

Psalm 106

We have sinned, but God stayed faithful

His loving kindness lasts forever VERSES 1–5

1 Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
2 Who can put into words the mighty acts of the LORD?
Who can tell all the praise he deserves?
3 Happy are those who hold on to justice.
Happy is the one who does what is right at all times.
4 Remember me, LORD, with the kindness you show to your people.
Come to me and save me,
5 so that I may see the good things your chosen ones receive,
so that I may share the joy of your nation,
so that I may celebrate with the people who belong to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 106 is the counterpart to Psalm 105. Psalm 105 tells about God's faithfulness. Psalm 106 honestly tells about the unfaithfulness of the people, and how God stayed faithful anyway.

Verse 1: "For he is good, for his loving kindness lasts forever": This is one of the most common calls of praise in the Bible.

At the Red Sea VERSES 6–12

6 We have sinned, just like our ancestors.
We have done wrong. We have acted wickedly.
7 Our ancestors in Egypt did not understand your wonders.
They did not remember how much loving kindness you had shown them.
Instead, they rebelled at the sea, at the Red Sea.
8 But he saved them anyway, for the sake of his name,
to make his mighty power known.
9 He scolded the Red Sea, and it dried up.
He led them through the deep waters as if through a desert.
10 He saved them from the hand of the one who hated them.
He rescued them from the hand of the enemy.
11 The waters covered their enemies.
Not one of them was left.
12 Then they believed his words.
They sang his praise.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6 is an honest confession: "We have sinned, just like our ancestors." The present generation stands in line with their ancestors and admits: We are no better.

Already at the Red Sea, shortly after they left Egypt, the people doubted (Exodus 14:11–12). Even so, God saved them.

Verse 12: After they were saved, they believed and sang the song of Moses (Exodus 15).

Greed and envy in the wilderness VERSES 13–18

13 They soon forgot what he had done.
They did not wait for his advice.
14 Instead, they gave in to their greedy cravings in the wilderness.
They tested God in the dry land.
15 He gave them what they asked for,
but he sent emptiness into their souls.
16 In the camp, they also became jealous of Moses,
and of Aaron, the LORD's holy one.
17 The earth opened up and swallowed Dathan.
It covered the group of Abiram.
18 A fire broke out in their group.
The flames burned up the wicked.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: God gave them meat, as they demanded (Numbers 11). But their souls became "lean" and empty. Whoever

lives only for his own wishes becomes poor inside.

Verses 16–18: Dathan, Abiram and Korah rebelled against Moses and Aaron (Numbers 16).

The golden calf VERSES 19–23

19 They made a calf at Horeb.
They worshiped an image made of melted metal.
20 So they traded their glory
for the image of a bull that eats grass.
21 They forgot God, their Savior,
who had done great things in Egypt,
22 wonderful works in the land of Ham,
and awesome things at the Red Sea.
23 So he said that he would destroy them.
But Moses, his chosen one, stood before him in the gap in the wall,
to turn his anger away, so that he would not destroy them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At Mount Horeb (Sinai), they made the golden calf (Exodus 32).

Verse 20: How foolish: They traded the living God, their "glory," for the image of an animal that eats grass!

Verse 23: Moses stood up for the people, like a soldier who stands in a gap in the wall. It is a picture for praying for others (Exodus 32:11–14).

They rejected the beautiful land VERSES 24–31

24 Yes, they rejected the pleasant land.
They did not believe his promise.
25 Instead, they complained in their tents,
and they did not listen to the voice of the LORD.
26 So he swore to them that he would strike them down in the wilderness,
27 that he would strike down their descendants among the nations,
and scatter them in other lands.
28 They also joined themselves to Baal Peor,
and they ate the sacrifices offered to the dead.
29 So they made him angry with what they did.
The plague broke out among them.
30 Then Phinehas stood up and carried out judgment,
and the plague was stopped.
31 That was counted to him as righteousness,
for all generations to come.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 24–27: The people refused to go into the promised land because they were afraid (Numbers 13–14). That is why they had to stay in the wilderness for 40 years.

Verse 28: The people of Israel "ate the sacrifices offered to the dead." This means sacrifices to dead idols, or sacrifices in rituals for the dead. This happened at Baal Peor. There, people of Israel worshiped a foreign god (Numbers 25).

Verses 30–31: Phinehas, a priest, stepped in with violence at that time (Numbers 25:7–13). The Bible tells this as a judgment in the time of Moses. It does not allow anyone today to use violence in the name of God. Jesus clearly rejected violence in the name of God (Luke 9:54–55; Matthew 26:52).

At Meribah VERSES 32–33

32 They also made him angry at the waters of Meribah,
so that things went badly for Moses because of them.
33 For they rebelled against his Spirit,
and Moses spoke without thinking.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At Meribah, even Moses lost his patience. He angrily struck the rock instead of speaking to it, as God had commanded. That is why Moses was not allowed to enter the promised land (Numbers 20:1–13).

In the land: idols and child sacrifice VERSES 34–39

34 They did not destroy the peoples,
as the LORD had commanded them.
35 Instead, they mixed with the nations
and learned to do what they did.
36 They served their idols,
and the idols became a trap for them.
37 Yes, they sacrificed their sons and their daughters to demons.
38 They shed innocent blood,
the blood of their sons and their daughters,
whom they sacrificed to the idols of Canaan.
The land was made unclean with blood.
39 So they made themselves unclean by what they did.
They were unfaithful in their actions, like a prostitute.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the land of Canaan, the people of Israel took over the religious customs of the nations around them. The most terrible thing: They even sacrificed their own children (compare 2 Kings 16:3; Jeremiah 7:31).

The Bible condemns this in the strongest way. God does not want children to be sacrificed (compare Genesis 22).

Verse 34: The command to destroy the peoples belongs to the account of how the land was taken in ancient times. It does not apply today. Back then, its main goal was to protect Israel from these cruel religions.

"Unfaithful, like a prostitute": The Bible often compares worshiping idols with being unfaithful in marriage to God.

He remembered his covenant VERSES 40–46

40 Then the LORD's anger burned against his people.
He hated the people who belonged to him.
41 He handed them over to the nations.
Those who hated them ruled over them.
42 Their enemies also oppressed them.
They were forced to bow under their power.
43 Many times he rescued them,
but they kept rebelling in their plans,
and their sin brought them down.
44 But he saw their trouble
when he heard their cry.
45 He remembered his covenant for them.
He changed his mind, because his loving kindness is so great.
46 He also made all those who had taken them captive
feel sorry for them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the time of the judges and the kings is summed up in a few words: Again and again the people turned away, were oppressed, cried to God and were rescued (compare Judges 2:11–19).

Verses 44–45: In spite of everything, God heard their cry and remembered his covenant. His loving kindness was greater than their guilt.

Verse 46: Even when they were captives (in exile), God made others feel sorry for them.

Gather us from among the nations VERSES 47–48

47 Save us, LORD our God,
and gather us from among the nations,
so that we may give thanks to your holy name
and celebrate as we praise you!
48 Praise the LORD, the God of Israel,
from everlasting to everlasting!
Let all the people say, "Amen."
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 47: A prayer from the exile: Gather us again! Bring us home!

Verse 48 is the end of the fourth book of Psalms (Psalms 90–106). Here all the people are called to answer with "Amen."

With Psalm 107, the fifth and last book of Psalms begins.

PSALMS

PSALM 107

Give thanks to the LORD, he rescues from every trouble

The fifth book of Psalms

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Psalm 107, the fifth and last book of Psalms begins (Psalms 107–150).

It contains many songs of praise and thanks, the pilgrim songs (Psalms 120–134), the long Psalm 119 about God's word, and at the end the great Hallelujah psalms (146–150).

Psalm 107 connects to the end of Psalm 106. There the people asked: "Gather us from among the nations." Here they give thanks: God has gathered us.

Let those whom the LORD has rescued say so VERSES 1–3

1 Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
2 Let those whom the LORD has rescued say so,
those he has rescued from the hand of the enemy,
3 and gathered from the lands,
from the east and from the west,
from the north and from the south.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm invites everyone who has experienced God's rescue to tell about it.

God has brought his people back from every direction, back from the exile.

Lost in the wilderness VERSES 4–9

4 They wandered in the wilderness, on a desert road.
They found no city to live in.
5 They were hungry and thirsty.
Their souls grew weak inside them.
6 Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble,
and he rescued them from their distress.
7 He led them on a straight road,
so that they came to a city to live in.
8 Let them praise the LORD for his loving kindness,
for the wonderful things he does for people!
9 For he satisfies the longing soul.
He fills the hungry soul with good things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm tells about four groups of people in trouble. Each story has the same pattern: trouble – crying out to God – rescue – thanks.

The first group: people who got lost in the wilderness. They are hungry and thirsty and cannot find the way. God leads them on a straight road.

The refrain (verses 6 and 8) comes four times.

In chains and darkness VERSES 10–16

10 Some sat in darkness and in the shadow of death.
They were prisoners in misery and in iron chains,
11 because they had rebelled against the words of God,
and they had rejected the advice of the Most High.
12 So he humbled their hearts with hard work.
They fell down, and no one helped them.
13 Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble,
and he saved them from their distress.
14 He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death.
He broke their chains apart.
15 Let them praise the LORD for his loving kindness,
for the wonderful things he does for people!
16 For he has broken the gates of bronze,
and cut through the bars of iron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The second group: prisoners in a dungeon. They got there through their own fault.

But God helps them too when they cry to him. Even iron prison doors cannot stop God.

This shows: Even someone who gets into trouble through his own mistakes may call to God.

Sick because of sin VERSES 17–22

17 Fools suffered because of their disobedience
and because of their sins.
18 They could not stand any kind of food.
They came close to the gates of death.
19 Then they cry to the LORD in their trouble,
and he saves them from their distress.

20 He sends his word and heals them.
He rescues them from their graves.
21 Let them praise the LORD for his loving kindness,
for the wonderful things he does for people!
22 Let them offer sacrifices of thanks,
and tell about what he has done with songs of joy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The third group: sick people who could not eat anymore and were close to death.

Verse 20: "He sends his word and heals them": God's word has the power to heal. Christians think of Jesus, who healed sick people with his word (Matthew 8:8).

Important: Not every sickness is a punishment for sin (compare John 9:1–3). The psalm tells about certain people who experienced it this way themselves.

In a storm at sea VERSES 23–32

23 Some went out to sea in ships.
They did business on the great waters.
24 They saw what the LORD does,
and his wonders in the deep sea.
25 For he gives the command and stirs up a storm wind,
which lifts up the waves.
26 They go up to the sky. They go down again to the depths.
Their courage melts away because of the danger.
27 They sway back and forth and stagger like a drunk man.
They do not know what to do anymore.
28 Then they cry to the LORD in their trouble,
and he brings them out of their distress.
29 He makes the storm calm,
so that the waves are still.
30 Then they are glad because it is calm,
and he brings them to the harbor they longed for.
31 Let them praise the LORD for his loving kindness,
for the wonderful things he does for people!
32 Let them praise him highly in the assembly of the people,
and praise him in the meeting of the elders.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fourth group: sailors in a storm. The ship is thrown up and down. The men do not know what to do anymore.

God calms the storm and brings them safely into the harbor.

The disciples experienced something like this with Jesus on the Sea of Galilee: He calmed the storm with one word (Mark 4:35–41).

"The harbor they longed for": a beautiful picture for the goal of life.

God changes the world VERSES 33–43

33 He turns rivers into a desert,
and springs of water into thirsty ground.
34 He turns fruitful land into a salty wasteland,
because of the evil of those who live there.
35 He turns a desert into a pool of water,
and dry land into springs of water.
36 He lets the hungry live there,
so that they can build a city to live in.
37 They sow fields and plant vineyards,
and they gather a rich harvest.
38 He also blesses them, so that they become very many.
He does not let their cattle become fewer.
39 Then again they become fewer and are bowed down
by oppression, trouble and sorrow.
40 He pours shame on princes.
He makes them wander in a wasteland without paths.
41 But he lifts the needy out of their misery.
He makes their families grow like a flock.
42 Upright people see it and are glad.
All the wicked have to shut their mouths.
43 Whoever is wise will pay attention to these things.
They will think about the loving kindness of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God can change everything: fruitful land into desert, and desert into fruitful land. He brings down the proud and powerful, and he lifts up the poor (compare 1 Samuel 2:7–8; Luke 1:52).

Verse 43: The psalm ends like a wise saying: Whoever is wise pays attention to God's kindness in his own life and in history.

PSALMS

PSALM 108

My heart is steady

I will wake up the dawn VERSES 1–6

1 A song. A psalm by David.
My heart is steady, God.
I will sing, and I will make music with all my soul.
2 Wake up, harp and lyre!
I will wake up the dawn.
3 I will give thanks to you, LORD, among the nations.
I will sing praises to you among the peoples.
4 For your loving kindness is great, higher than the heavens.
Your faithfulness reaches to the skies.
5 Be lifted up, God, above the heavens!
Let your glory be over all the earth.
6 Save us with your right hand and answer us,
so that the people you love may be rescued.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 108 is put together from two other psalms: Verses 1–5 come from Psalm 57:7–11, and verses 6–13 come from Psalm 60:5–12.

In this way, older prayers were put together in a new way for a new situation. The praise from Psalm 57 and the request

from Psalm 60 become one new prayer.

"I will wake up the dawn": The praise comes so early that it wakes up the morning.

God has spoken VERSES 7–9

7 God has spoken from his holy place:
"I will celebrate my victory and divide up Shechem.
I will measure out the valley of Succoth.
8 Gilead is mine. Manasseh is mine.
Ephraim is my helmet.
Judah is my scepter.
9 Moab is my washbasin.
I will throw my sandal on Edom.
I will shout in triumph over Philistia."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

See Psalm 60:6–8. God declares: The whole land belongs to me, and the neighboring nations are also in my hand.

Verse 8: A scepter is a royal staff. It is a sign of a king's power.

The pictures (washbasin, sandal) are the language of that time for ruling over something and owning it.

With God we will do brave deeds VERSES 10–13

10 Who will bring me into the strong city?
Who will lead me to Edom?
11 God, haven't you rejected us?
God, you do not go out with our armies.
12 Give us help against the enemy,
for human help is worth nothing.
13 With God we will do brave deeds,
for he is the one who will trample our enemies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

See Psalm 60:9–12.

"Human help is worth nothing": Without God, even the best human means do not help.

PSALMS

PSALM 109

God whom I praise, do not be silent

They pay back my love with hatred VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
God, you whom I praise, do not stay silent!
2 For wicked people and liars have opened their mouths against me.
They have spoken to me with lying tongues.
3 They have surrounded me with words of hatred.
They have fought against me for no reason.
4 In return for my love, they are my enemies.
But I pray.
5 They have paid me back evil for good,
and hatred for my love.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 109 is one of the hardest psalms. It contains the harshest curses in the whole book of Psalms.

At the beginning, we see the situation: The person praying is attacked with lies by people he did good to and loved.

Verse 4: "But I pray." In Hebrew, it says: "But I – prayer." His answer to hatred is not to fight back with violence. His answer is prayer.

A terrible curse VERSES 6–15

6 Put a wicked man in charge over him!
Let an accuser stand at his right hand.
7 When he is judged, let him be found guilty.
Let his prayer be counted as sin.
8 Let his days be few.
Let another take his office.
9 Let his children become orphans,
and his wife a widow.
10 Let his children wander around as beggars.
Let them search for food far from their ruined homes.
11 Let the man he owes money to take everything he has.
Let strangers rob him of what he worked for.
12 Let no one show him kindness.
Let no one feel sorry for his orphans.
13 Let his descendants be wiped out.
Let their name be erased in the next generation.
14 Let the LORD remember the sin of his ancestors.
Do not let the sin of his mother be erased.
15 Let their sins always be before the LORD,
so that he may wipe out the memory of them from the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are shocking. They wish the worst on the enemy and even on his family.

There are two ways to understand these verses:

– It is the curse of the person praying against his enemy, coming out of his deepest hurt.

– Many interpreters think: It is a quotation. The person praying repeats what his enemies say against him. One reason for this view is that before and after this part, the psalm speaks of "they" (plural), but here it speaks of "he" (singular). Then the enemies would have spoken this curse over the person praying, and he brings it before God.

What matters: Children and family are not guilty of what their parents did (Ezekiel 18:20). These verses do not allow anyone to wish evil on others or to do evil to them.

Verse 8 ("Let another take his office") is quoted by Peter when a successor for Judas is chosen (Acts 1:20).

Jesus teaches a different way: "Bless those who curse you! Pray for those who mistreat you!" (Luke 6:28).

He loved cursing VERSES 16–20

16 For he did not remember to show kindness.
Instead, he hunted down the poor and needy man,
and the one whose heart was broken, in order to kill them.
17 Yes, he loved cursing, and it came back on him.
He did not enjoy blessing, and it stayed far from him.

18 He put on cursing like his robe.
It soaked into his body like water,
and like oil into his bones.
19 Let it be like the clothes that cover him,
like the belt that he always wears.
20 This is how the LORD pays back my enemies,
those who speak evil against me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the enemy is described: He hunted down the poor and killed them. He loved cursing.

Verses 17–19: Whoever curses others gets wrapped up in the curse himself, like in a piece of clothing. Evil falls back on the one who does it.

Verse 20: The person praying hands everything over to the LORD. He does not take revenge himself.

I am poor and needy VERSES 21–25

21 But you, LORD, the Lord, act for me for the sake of your name.
Because your loving kindness is good, rescue me!
22 For I am poor and needy.
My heart is wounded inside me.
23 I am fading away like an evening shadow.
I am shaken off like a locust.
24 My knees are weak from fasting.
My body is thin and has no fat.
25 I have become someone they mock.
When they see me, they shake their heads.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the person praying turns to God again. He is weak, sick and hurt.

"Like an evening shadow": It grows longer and paler until it disappears. That is how the person praying feels.

"Shaken off like a locust": worthless, simply brushed away.

They may curse, but you bless VERSES 26–31

26 Help me, LORD, my God!
Save me because of your loving kindness,
27 so that they will know that this is your hand,
that you, LORD, have done it.
28 They may curse, but you bless.
When they rise up, they will be put to shame,
but your servant will be glad.
29 Let my enemies be dressed in disgrace.
Let them cover themselves with their own shame as with a coat.
30 I will give great thanks to the LORD with my mouth.
Yes, I will praise him among the crowd.
31 For he will stand at the right hand of the needy person,
to save him from those who want to condemn him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28 is a turning point: "They may curse, but you bless." Human curses have no power when God blesses.

Verse 31 is the answer to verse 6: There, an accuser was to stand at the right hand of the person praying. Now God himself stands at the right hand of the poor, as the one who defends him.

Psalm 109 shows: We may tell God even our deepest anger and pain. God hears that too. But judgment stays with God. And God is on the side of the poor and the hurt.

PSALMS

PSALM 110

Sit at my right hand

The king at God's right hand VERSES 1–3

1 A psalm by David.
The LORD says to my Lord:
"Sit at my right hand,
until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet."
2 The LORD will stretch out your mighty scepter from Zion.
A scepter is a royal staff. It is a sign of a king's power.
Rule among your enemies!
3 Your people will gladly offer themselves on the day of your power,
dressed in holy clothing.
Out of the womb of the morning,
you have the dew of your youth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 110 is the psalm that is quoted most often in the New Testament (more than 20 times).

Verse 1: "The LORD says to my Lord": The LORD is God. "My Lord" means the king. God invites the king to sit at his right side, the place of honor. God will put the enemies under the king's feet. Back then, winners put their foot on the necks of those they had defeated.

Jesus asked the teachers of the law: If David calls the Messiah "my Lord," how can the Messiah be only David's son? (Mark 12:35–37). Christians believe that after his resurrection, Jesus sits at God's right hand (Acts 2:34–36; Hebrews 1:13).

Jewish people have understood the psalm as being about the king from David's family or about the coming Messiah.

Verse 3 is very hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: The king is young and fresh like the dew in the morning.

A priest in the order of Melchizedek VERSE 4

4 The LORD has sworn, and he will not change his mind:
"You are a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Israel, kings and priests were usually different people. Kings came from the tribe of Judah, priests from the tribe of Levi.

But this king is also a priest, following the example of Melchizedek. Melchizedek was king of Salem (Jerusalem) and a priest at the same time. He blessed Abraham (Genesis 14:18–20).

The letter to the Hebrews explains in detail that Jesus is this eternal priest in the order of Melchizedek (Hebrews 5–7).

The king's victory VERSES 5–7

5 The Lord is at your right hand.
He will crush kings on the day of his anger.
6 He will judge among the nations.
He will pile up dead bodies.
He will crush the ruler of the whole earth.
7 He will drink from the stream along the way.
That is why he will lift up his head.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses use the war language of that time to describe victory over all enemies. It is a picture of God's final victory over evil. It is not a call to violence.

Verse 7: A puzzling ending. Maybe it is a picture: The king refreshes himself at a stream on the way and goes on to victory. Maybe it reminds us of a ritual when a king was anointed at the Gihon spring (1 Kings 1:38–39).

PSALMS

Psalm 111

The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom

The works of the LORD are great VERSES 1–5

1 Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart,
in the circle of upright people, and in the assembly.
2 The works of the LORD are great.
All who enjoy them study them.
3 What he does is full of honor and majesty.
His righteousness lasts forever.
4 He has made sure that his wonderful works are remembered.
The LORD is gracious and merciful.
5 He has given food to those who fear him.
He always remembers his covenant.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalms 111 and 112 are twins: Both are alphabet poems, each with 22 half-lines. Psalm 111 praises God. Psalm 112 describes the person who fears God.

Verse 2: God's works are worth studying. This verse is written in Latin over the entrance of a physics laboratory in Cambridge (the Cavendish Laboratory). Science and faith do not have to be enemies.

Verse 4: "He has made sure that his wonderful works are remembered": The festivals of Israel, especially Passover, remind people of what God has done.

Verse 5: Food in the wilderness: the manna.

His commands can be trusted VERSES 6–9

6 He has shown his people the power of his works by giving them the land of other nations.
7 The works of his hands are true and just.
All his commands can be trusted.
8 They stand firm forever and ever.
They are made with truth and uprightness.
9 He has sent rescue to his people.
He has set up his covenant forever.
His name is holy and awesome!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's commands are not random. They are "made with truth and uprightness." They are good and can be trusted.

Verse 9: God has rescued his people, out of Egypt and later out of the exile.

The beginning of wisdom VERSE 10

10 The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom.
All who do what he says have good understanding.
His praise lasts forever!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10 is a famous saying. It also appears in Proverbs 1:7 and 9:10.

"The fear of the LORD" does not mean being scared of God. It means: deep respect for God, taking God seriously. Whoever takes God seriously begins to become wise.

PSALMS

Psalm 112

Happy is the one who fears the LORD

A light in the darkness VERSES 1–4

1 Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
Happy is the person who fears the LORD,
who finds great joy in his commands.
2 His descendants will be mighty in the land.
The generation of upright people will be blessed.
3 Wealth and riches are in his house.
His righteousness lasts forever.
4 For upright people, light rises in the darkness.
They are gracious, merciful and righteous.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 112 is the twin of Psalm 111. What is said there about God is said here about the person who fears God. For example: "His righteousness lasts forever" (111:3 and 112:3), and "gracious and merciful" (111:4 and 112:4).

That means: Whoever honors God becomes like him.

Verse 4: Righteous people also go through dark times. But in the darkness, a light rises for them.

He gives to the poor VERSES 5–9

5 It goes well for the person who is generous and lends to others.
He will defend his case in court.
6 For he will never be shaken.
The righteous person will be remembered forever.
7 He is not afraid of bad news.
His heart is steady, and he trusts in the LORD.
8 His heart stands firm.
In the end, he will not be afraid when he looks at his enemies.
9 He has spread his gifts around. He has given to the poor.
His righteousness lasts forever.
His horn will be lifted up with honor.
That means: He will be strong and honored.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The righteous person is generous. He lends to others. He gives to the poor.

Verse 7: "He is not afraid of bad news": Whoever trusts in God has something firm to hold on to, even when terrible news comes.

Paul quotes verse 9 when he encourages the church in Corinth to give money for the poor (2 Corinthians 9:9).

The wicked person sees it VERSE 10

10 The wicked person will see it and be angry.
He will grind his teeth and melt away.
What the wicked want will come to nothing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm ends with the opposite picture: The wicked person is jealous and angry. His wishes do not come true.

PSALMS

PSALM 113

Who is like the LORD?

From the rising of the sun to its setting VERSES 1–4

1 Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
Praise, you servants of the LORD!
Praise the name of the LORD!
2 Blessed be the name of the LORD,
from now on and forever!
3 From the rising of the sun to its setting,
the name of the LORD is to be praised!
4 The LORD is high above all nations.
His glory is above the heavens.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Psalm 113, the "Hallel" begins (Psalms 113–118). Jewish people still sing these psalms at the great festivals today, especially at Passover. Jesus also sang them with his disciples at the Last Supper (Matthew 26:30).

Verse 3: God should be praised all day long and everywhere in the world, from east to west.

He lifts the poor out of the dust VERSES 5–9

5 Who is like the LORD, our God,
who sits on his throne on high,
6 who bends down to look
at the heavens and at the earth?
7 He lifts the poor out of the dust.
He raises the needy from the garbage heap,
8 to seat them with princes,
with the princes of his people.
9 He gives the woman who could not have children a home.
She becomes a happy mother of children.
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is so high that he even has to "bend down" to see the heavens. And yet he sees the smallest people on earth.

Verses 7–8: God brings poor people out of their misery and seats them with princes. Hannah sang almost the same words (1 Samuel 2:8), and so did Mary in her song of praise (Luke 1:52).

Verse 9: Back then, a woman without children was often looked down on. God gives her joy, as he did for Sarah, Rebekah, Rachel and Hannah.

If you long for children and do not have any: This is not a sign that God loves you less. God's love does not depend on having children.

PSALMS

PSALM 114

When Israel left Egypt

The sea saw it and ran away VERSES 1–4

1 When Israel left Egypt,
when the family of Jacob left a people with a foreign language,
2 Judah became his holy place,
and Israel became the land he ruled.
3 The sea saw it and ran away.
The Jordan turned back.
4 The mountains jumped like rams,
the little hills like lambs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 114 is a short, lively poem about the exodus from Egypt. It belongs to the Hallel, which is sung at Passover.

Verse 3: Two miracles are named together: The Red Sea divided when the people left Egypt (Exodus 14). The Jordan divided when they entered the land (Joshua 3).

Verse 4: The mountains jump like young sheep. This means the earthquake at Mount Sinai (Exodus 19:18). Nature reacts with life when God comes.

What is wrong with you, sea? VERSES 5–8

5 What was wrong with you, sea, that you ran away?
And you, Jordan, that you turned back?
6 You mountains, that you jumped like rams?
You little hills, like lambs?
7 Tremble, earth, before the Lord,
before the God of Jacob.
8 He turned the rock into a pool of water,
the hard flint stone into a spring of water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The poet asks the sea and the mountains, almost with humor: What is wrong with you?

The answer: God has come! The whole earth must tremble before him.

Verse 8: The God who dries up seas can also make water flow out of hard rock (Exodus 17:6). He can make dead things come alive.

PSALMS

Psalm 115

Not to us, LORD, but to your name give glory

Not to us, but to your name VERSES 1–3

1 Not to us, LORD, not to us,
but to your name give glory,
because of your loving kindness and because of your faithfulness!
2 Why should the nations say:
"Where is their God now?"
3 But our God is in heaven.
He does whatever he wants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1 is a humble prayer: We should not be honored, but God should. Many people have chosen this verse as their motto for life (in Latin: "Non nobis, Domine").

The nations mock: Where is your God? You cannot even see him.

The answer: Our God is in heaven. You cannot see him, but he is mighty.

Idols are dead VERSES 4–8

4 Their idols are silver and gold,
made by human hands.
5 They have mouths, but they do not speak.
They have eyes, but they do not see.
6 They have ears, but they do not hear.
They have noses, but they do not smell.
7 They have hands, but they do not feel.
They have feet, but they do not walk.
No sound comes from their throats.
8 Those who make them will become like them,
yes, everyone who trusts in them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

You can see the gods of the other nations. But they are only figures made of metal. They have eyes, ears, hands and feet, but none of them works.

Verse 8: A deep thought: People become like what they worship. Whoever worships lifeless things becomes lifeless inside. This is also true of modern "idols" like money, power or success.

Trust in the LORD! VERSES 9–15

9 Israel, trust in the LORD!
He is their help and their shield.
10 Family of Aaron, trust in the LORD!
He is their help and their shield.
11 You who fear the LORD, trust in the LORD!
He is their help and their shield.
12 The LORD remembers us. He will bless us.
He will bless the people of Israel.
He will bless the family of Aaron.
13 He will bless those who fear the LORD,
both small and great.
14 May the LORD make you grow more and more,
you and your children.
15 You are blessed by the LORD,
who made heaven and earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Three groups are called: the whole people of Israel, the priests (the family of Aaron), and all who fear God. The third group may also include people from other nations who have joined themselves to the God of Israel.

Verse 13: God blesses everyone, "both small and great." No one is too unimportant for God.

We will praise Yah VERSES 16–18

16 The heavens belong to the LORD,
but he has given the earth to human beings.
17 The dead do not praise Yah,
nor does anyone who goes down into silence.
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
18 But we will praise Yah,
from now on and forever.
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: God has trusted people with the earth. That is a gift and a responsibility (compare Genesis 1:28; 2:15).

Verses 17–18: As long as we live, we want to praise God, and to do so "forever."

PSALMS

Psalm 116

I love the LORD, because he hears me

He has turned his ear to me VERSES 1–4

1 I love the LORD, because he listens to my voice
and to my cries for mercy.
2 Because he has turned his ear to me,
I will call on him as long as I live.
3 The ropes of death were all around me.
The pains of Sheol (the world of the dead) took hold of me.
I found trouble and sorrow.
4 Then I called on the name of the LORD:
"LORD, please, rescue my soul!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 116 is a personal song of thanks. The person praying was deathly sick or in danger of losing his life. God saved him.

It begins with a confession of love: "I love the LORD." The reason: God listened.

The psalm belongs to the "Hallel," which is sung at Passover.

Return to your rest, my soul VERSES 5–9

5 The LORD is gracious and righteous.
Yes, our God is merciful.
6 The LORD protects simple people.
I was brought very low, and he saved me.
7 Return to your rest, my soul,
for the LORD has been very good to you.
8 For you have rescued my soul from death,
my eyes from tears,
and my feet from falling.
9 I will walk before the LORD
in the land of the living.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Simple people": These are plain, defenseless people who cannot help themselves. God especially takes care of them.

Verse 7: The person praying speaks to his own soul: Come back to rest! The fear is over. God has helped.

Verse 8: Three kinds of rescue: from death, from tears, from falling.

What can I give back to the LORD? VERSES 10–14

10 I believed, and so I said:
"I was in deep trouble."
11 In my panic, I said:
"All people are liars."
12 What can I give to the LORD
for all the good he has done for me?
13 I will lift up the cup of salvation,
and call on the name of the LORD.
14 I will keep my promises to the LORD,
yes, in front of all his people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: Even in trouble, the person praying did not stop believing. But he was disappointed in people: No one helped him.

Paul quotes verse 10 from the Greek translation: "I believed, and therefore I spoke" (2 Corinthians 4:13).

Verse 12: A beautiful question: How can I thank God for everything he has given me?

Verse 13: The answer: I lift up the "cup of salvation," a cup of wine at the thanksgiving celebration, and I call on God's name. Cups of wine are still drunk at the Passover meal today. Christians also think of the cup at the Lord's Supper.

Precious is the death of his faithful people VERSES 15–19

15 Precious in the LORD's eyes
is the death of his faithful people.
16 LORD, truly, I am your servant.
I am your servant, the son of your servant girl.
You have set me free from my chains.
17 I will offer you a sacrifice of thanks,
and call on the name of the LORD.
18 I will keep my promises to the LORD,
yes, in front of all his people,
19 in the courtyards of the LORD's house,
in the middle of you, Jerusalem.
Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: "Precious in the LORD's eyes is the death of his faithful people": This means: The life and death of people who trust God matter to him. They are very valuable to him. He does not let them die carelessly. This is a comfort at the bedside of dying people.

Verse 16: "The son of your servant girl": I belong to you completely, like a child who was born in your house.

The person praying brings his sacrifice of thanks in public, in the temple. He wants everyone to hear about God's help.

PSALMS

Psalm 117

Praise the LORD, all you nations!

The shortest psalm VERSES 1–2

1 Praise the LORD, all you nations!
Praise him highly, all you peoples!

2 For his loving kindness toward us is great.
The LORD's faithfulness lasts forever.
Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 117 is the shortest psalm, and it is also the shortest chapter in the whole Bible. It is located roughly in the middle of the Bible.

It is short, but its message is huge: All the nations of the world are called to praise God.

The reason: God's loving kindness and faithfulness. These are the two most important qualities of God in the Old Testament.

Paul quotes verse 1 to show: The good news about God is not only for Israel, but for all nations (Romans 15:11).

PSALMS

Psalm 118

This is the day that the LORD has made

His loving kindness lasts forever VERSES 1–4

1 Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
2 Let Israel now say:
"His loving kindness lasts forever."
3 Let the family of Aaron now say:
"His loving kindness lasts forever."
4 Let those who fear the LORD now say:
"His loving kindness lasts forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 118 is the last psalm of the "Hallel" (113–118). It was probably a festival song for a procession to the temple. A leader called out, and the congregation answered.

As in Psalm 115, three groups are named: the people of Israel, the priests, and all who honor God.

The LORD is on my side VERSES 5–9

5 In my trouble, I called to Yah.
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
Yah answered me and set me free.
6 The LORD is on my side. I will not be afraid.
What can a human being do to me?
7 The LORD is on my side among those who help me.
So I will look in triumph at those who hate me.
8 It is better to find safety in the LORD
than to trust in people.
9 It is better to find safety in the LORD
than to trust in princes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: "Set me free": In Hebrew, it says: "into a wide place." God leads us out of the narrow place of trouble into a wide, open space.

Verse 6: "The LORD is on my side. I will not be afraid": compare Hebrews 13:6.

Verses 8–9: People, even powerful ones, can let us down. God is more reliable.

In the name of the LORD VERSES 10–14

10 All the nations surrounded me,
but in the name of the LORD I cut them off.
11 They surrounded me, yes, they surrounded me.
In the name of the LORD I cut them off.
12 They swarmed around me like bees.
They burned out as fast as burning thorns.
In the name of the LORD I cut them off.
13 You pushed me hard to make me fall,
but the LORD helped me.
14 Yah is my strength and my song.
He has become my salvation.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king or the people were attacked from all sides, as if by a swarm of bees. But the enemies burned out quickly, like a fire of dry thorns.

"In the name of the LORD": not by their own strength, but with God's help. The language of war describes being rescued from trouble. It is not a call to use violence in the name of God.

Verse 14 quotes the song of Moses after the rescue at the Red Sea (Exodus 15:2).

I will not die, but I will live VERSES 15–18

15 Shouts of joy and victory are heard in the tents of the righteous:
"The right hand of the LORD does mighty things.
16 The right hand of the LORD is lifted high!
The right hand of the LORD does mighty things!"
17 I will not die, but I will live,
and I will tell what Yah has done.
18 Yah has punished me hard,
but he has not handed me over to death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17 is a strong confession: "I will not die, but I will live." Martin Luther wrote this verse on the wall of his study during hard times.

Verse 18: The person praying has been through hard times, but God did not let him die.

The stone that the builders rejected VERSES 19–24

19 Open the gates of righteousness for me!
I will go in through them. I will give thanks to Yah.
20 This is the gate of the LORD.
The righteous will go in through it.
21 I will give thanks to you, for you have answered me,
and you have become my salvation.
22 The stone that the builders rejected
has become the cornerstone.
23 The LORD has done this.
It is wonderful in our eyes.

24 This is the day that the LORD has made.
We will rejoice and be glad in it!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The procession arrives at the temple gate: "Open the gates of righteousness for me!"

Verse 22 is one of the most important sayings in the Bible: The builders threw away a stone as useless. But it becomes the most important stone of the whole building, the cornerstone. At first, this was a picture for Israel or for the king. The powerful looked down on them, but God chose them.

Jesus applied this verse to himself (Matthew 21:42). The leaders of his people rejected him, and he was crucified. But God raised him from the dead. Peter says the same thing (Acts 4:11; 1 Peter 2:7).

Verse 24: "This is the day that the LORD has made": a well-known verse that is prayed at Easter.

Blessed is the one who comes VERSES 25–29

25 LORD, please save us now!
LORD, please give us success now!
26 Blessed is the one who comes in the name of the LORD!
We bless you from the house of the LORD.
27 The LORD is God, and he has given us light.
Tie the festival sacrifice with ropes
to the horns of the altar!
28 You are my God, and I will give thanks to you.
You are my God, and I will praise you highly.
29 Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: "LORD, please save us now!" In Hebrew, this is "Hosanna!"

Verse 26: "Blessed is the one who comes in the name of the LORD!" With these words, the priests welcomed the pilgrims at the temple.

When Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey, the people shouted words from this psalm: "Hosanna to the son of David! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!" (Matthew 21:9). Christians still sing these words today at the Lord's Supper.

Verse 27: "The horns of the altar": These were the corners of the altar, which stuck up like horns.

The psalm ends the way it began: "His loving kindness lasts forever."

PSALMS

Psalm 119

The great song about God's word

Aleph: Happy are those who live by God's teaching VERSES 1–8

1 Blessed are those whose ways are without blame,
who live by the law of the LORD.
Blessed means: truly happy.
2 Blessed are those who keep his rules,
who look for him with their whole heart.
3 Yes, they do nothing wrong.
They walk in his ways.
4 You have given us your instructions,
so that we obey them fully.
5 Oh, I wish my ways were firm,
so that I would obey your rules!
6 Then I would not be put to shame
when I look at all your commandments.
7 I will thank you with an honest heart
when I learn your right judgments.
8 I will keep your rules.
Do not leave me all alone!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 119 is the longest psalm and the longest chapter in the Bible: 176 verses.

It is a skillfully made alphabet poem. It has 22 sections, as many as there are letters in the Hebrew alphabet. In each section, all eight verses begin with the same letter: in the first section with Aleph, in the second with Beth, and so on. The headings name these letters.

Almost every verse speaks about God's word. In Hebrew, eight different words are used for it. In this book, they appear as words like law (in Hebrew "Torah," which means teaching), rules, teachings, instructions, commandments, rulings, word and promise. They all mean the same thing: what God has told us so that we can live well.

This psalm is not a dry law book. It is a love song to God's word and to God himself. The person praying is happy about God's word. He longs for it. He looks for comfort in it, even in suffering and persecution.

Verses 1–3 remind us of Psalm 1: Happy is the person who lives by God's teaching.

Beth: How can a young person keep their way pure? VERSES 9–16

9 How can a young man keep his way pure?
By living by your word.
10 I have looked for you with my whole heart.
Do not let me wander away from your
commandments!
11 I have hidden your word in my heart,
so that I do not sin against you.
12 Praise be to you, LORD!
Teach me your rules!
13 With my lips I have told about
all the rulings that you have spoken.
14 I have been glad about the way of your teachings,
as glad as about great riches.
15 I will think deeply about your instructions
and pay attention to your ways.
16 I will enjoy your rules.
I will not forget your word.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9 is a question that many young people think about: How do I live the right way? The answer: by God's word.

Verse 11: "I have hidden your word in my heart": Whoever knows God's words by heart and carries them in their heart has them along in hard situations.
Verse 14: For the person praying, God's word is as valuable as great riches.

Gimel: Open my eyes VERSES 17–24

17 Do good to your servant!
Then I will live and obey your word.
18 Open my eyes,
so that I can see the wonderful things in your law!
19 I am a stranger on the earth.
Do not hide your commandments from me!
20 My soul is worn out with longing
for your rulings at all times.
21 You have scolded the proud, who are cursed,
who wander away from your commandments.
22 Take shame and scorn away from me,
because I have kept your rules.
23 Even when princes sit together and say bad things about me,
your servant will think deeply about your rules.
24 Yes, your rules are my joy.
They are my advisers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: A beautiful prayer before reading the Bible: "Open my eyes." We need God's help to understand the depth of his word.
Verse 19: "I am a stranger on the earth": Life is like a journey in a foreign country. God's commandments are like a map.
Verse 24: God's words are like good advisers.

Daleth: My soul lies in the dust VERSES 25–32

25 My soul lies low in the dust.
Give me new life, as your word promises!
26 I told you about my ways, and you answered me.
Teach me your rules!
27 Help me understand the teaching of your instructions!
Then I will think deeply about your wonderful works.
28 My soul is tired with sorrow.
Make me strong, as your word promises!
29 Keep me away from the way of lies!
Be kind and give me your law!
30 I have chosen the way of truth.
I have put your rulings in front of my eyes.
31 I hold on tight to your rules, LORD.
Do not let me be put to shame!
32 I run on the path of your commandments,
because you have set my heart free.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying is discouraged and tired. He asks: Give me new life, make me strong through your word.
Verse 32: "You have set my heart free": God's commandments are not chains. They set us free. Whoever loves them is glad to run on this path.

He: Teach me, LORD VERSES 33–40

33 Teach me, LORD, the way of your rules!
I will keep them to the end.
34 Give me understanding, and I will keep your law.
Yes, I will obey it with my whole heart.
35 Lead me on the path of your commandments,
because I find joy in them.
36 Turn my heart toward your rules,
and not toward selfish gain!
37 Turn my eyes away from looking at worthless things!
Give me new life in your ways!
38 Keep your promise to your servant,
so that people will have deep respect for you!
39 Take away the shame that I am afraid of,
because your rulings are good.
40 Look, I long for your instructions!
Give me new life because you are righteous!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This section is made up almost only of requests: Teach me, give me understanding, lead me, turn my heart, turn my eyes away.
Verse 36: A request for today, too: My heart should not hang on money, but on God.
Verse 37: "Turn my eyes away from looking at worthless things": In a world full of pictures and screens, this is a very fitting prayer.

Vav: I will speak in front of kings VERSES 41–48

41 LORD, let your loving kindness come to me, too.
Let your saving help come to me, as your word promises.
42 Then I will have an answer for the one who insults me,
because I trust in your word.
43 Do not take the word of truth away from my mouth,
because I put my hope in your rulings.
44 So I will obey your law all the time,
forever and ever.
45 I will walk in freedom,
because I have looked for your instructions.
46 I will also speak about your rules in front of kings,
and I will not be put to shame.
47 I will enjoy your commandments,
because I love them.
48 I reach out my hands for your commandments, which I love.
I will think deeply about your rules.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 45: "I will walk in freedom": In Hebrew, it says "in a wide space." God's commandments do not lead into a narrow place, but into freedom.
Verse 46: The person praying has the courage to speak about God even in front of powerful people.

Zayin: Your word is my comfort in my suffering VERSES 49–56

49 Remember your word to your servant,
because you have given me hope.
50 This is my comfort in my suffering:
Your word has given me new life.
51 The proud make fun of me very much,
but I do not turn away from your law.

52 I remember your rulings from long ago, LORD,
and I have found comfort.
53 Anger has taken hold of me
because of the wicked people who turn away from
your law.
54 Your rules have been my songs
in the house where I live.
55 I have remembered your name in the night, LORD,
and I obey your law.
56 This is my way:
I keep your instructions.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 50: In hard times, God's word is a comfort that gives new life.

Verse 54: For the person praying, God's commandments are like songs. He likes to sing them in the place where he lives.

Heth: The LORD is my share VERSES 57–64

57 The LORD is my share.
I promised to obey your words.
58 I looked for your kindness with my whole heart.
Be merciful to me, as your word promises!
59 I thought about my ways,
and I turned my steps toward your rules.
60 I will hurry and not wait
to obey your commandments.
61 The ropes of the wicked tie me up,
but I will not forget your law.
62 At midnight I will get up to thank you
for your right rulings.
63 I am a friend of all who have deep respect for you,
of those who keep your instructions.
64 The earth is full of your loving kindness, LORD.
Teach me your rules!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 57: "The LORD is my share": God himself is the greatest treasure (compare Psalm 16:5).

Verse 59: The person praying has thought about his life and has turned back to God.

Verse 62: He even gets up in the middle of the night to thank God.

Verse 63: Whoever loves God finds friends in all who love him too.

Teth: It was good for me that I suffered VERSES 65–72

65 You have treated your servant well,
as your word promised, LORD.
66 Teach me good judgment and knowledge,
because I believe in your commandments.
67 Before I suffered, I went the wrong way.
But now I keep your word.
68 You are good, and you do good.
Teach me your rules!
69 The proud have spread lies about me.
But I will keep your instructions with my whole heart.
70 Their heart is as dull as fat.
But I find joy in your law.
71 It was good for me that I suffered,
so that I would learn your rules.
72 The law that you have spoken is worth more to me
than thousands of pieces of gold and silver.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 67 and 71: The person praying tells how hard times brought him closer to God. This is his personal experience. It does not mean that God sends every suffering, or that every suffering is good.

Verse 68: "You are good, and you do good": a simple, strong statement of faith.

Verse 72: God's word is worth more than a great treasure.

Yodh: Your hands have made me VERSES 73–80

73 Your hands have made me and shaped me.
Give me understanding, so that I can learn your
commandments!
74 Those who have deep respect for you will see me and be
glad,
because I have put my hope in your word.
75 LORD, I know that your judgments are right,
and that you have let me suffer because you are
faithful.
76 Please let your loving kindness comfort me,
as you promised your servant.
77 Let your tender mercy come to me, so that I may live,
because your law is my joy.
78 Let the proud be put to shame,
because they have brought me down unfairly.
I will think deeply about your instructions.
79 Let those who have deep respect for you turn to me.
They will know your rules.
80 Let my heart be without blame in keeping your rules,
so that I am not put to shame.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 73: God created me. That is why he also knows best how I should live.

Verse 75: Even in hard times, the person praying trusts: God means well with me.

Kaph: Like a wineskin in the smoke VERSES 81–88

81 My soul is worn out with longing for your saving help.
I hope in your word.
82 My eyes grow tired looking for your word.
I say, "When will you comfort me?"
83 I have become like a wineskin in the smoke.
I do not forget your rules.
84 How many days does your servant have left?
When will you judge those who chase after me to hurt
me?
85 The proud have dug pits for me.
That is against your law.
86 All your commandments can be trusted.
They chase after me unfairly. Help me!
87 They almost wiped me off the earth,
but I did not turn away from your instructions.
88 Keep me alive because of your loving kindness.
Then I will obey the rules that you have spoken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the darkest section of the psalm. The person praying is waiting and longing for help. He is being persecuted and

is almost at the end.

Verse 83: "Like a wineskin in the smoke": A wineskin is a bag made of leather that holds wine. In the smoke of the huts, these bags became black, dry and cracked. That is how the person praying feels: dried out and old.

Even so, he holds on to God's word.

Lamedh: Your word stands firm in heaven VERSES 89–96

89 LORD, your word stands firm in heaven forever.
90 Your faithfulness lasts for all generations.
You have set the earth in its place, and it stays.
91 Your laws remain to this day,
because all things serve you.
92 If your law had not been my joy,
I would have died in my suffering.
93 I will never forget your instructions,
because with them you have given me new life.
94 I belong to you. Save me,
because I have looked for your instructions.
95 The wicked have waited for me, to destroy me.
I will pay attention to your rules.
96 I have seen that even the most perfect things have a limit,
but your commands have no limits.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the dark section comes the turning point: God's word stands firm like heaven. It does not change.

Verse 92: God's word has saved the life of the person praying. Without this support, he would have broken down.

Verse 94: "I belong to you": a short, deep prayer.

Verse 96: Everything human has limits, even the very best. God's word has no end.

Mem: Oh, how I love your law! VERSES 97–104

97 Oh, how I love your law!
I think about it all day long.
98 Your commandments make me wiser than my enemies,
because your commandments are always with me.
99 I have more understanding than all my teachers,
because I think deeply about your teachings.
100 I understand more than the old people,
because I have kept your instructions.
101 I have kept my feet away from every evil way,
so that I can keep your word.
102 I have not turned away from your rulings,
because you have taught me.
103 How sweet your promises taste to me,
sweeter than honey in my mouth!
104 Through your instructions I gain understanding.
That is why I hate every false way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 97 is the high point of love: "Oh, how I love your law!"

Verses 99–100: God's word makes people wiser than the smartest teachers. Wisdom does not depend only on education or age, but on God's word.

Verse 103: God's word tastes sweet like honey (compare Psalm 19:10).

Nun: Your word is a lamp to my feet VERSES 105–112

105 Your word is a lamp for my feet
and a light for my path.
106 I have made a promise with an oath, and I have made it firm:
I will obey your right rulings.
107 I am suffering very much.
Give me new life, LORD, as your word promises!
108 Please accept the offerings that my mouth gives you freely, LORD.
Teach me your rulings!
109 My life is always in my hand,
but I will not forget your law.
110 The wicked have set a trap for me,
but I have not wandered away from your instructions.
111 I have taken your teachings as my inheritance forever,
because they are the joy of my heart.
112 I have set my heart on doing what your rules say,
forever, to the very end.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 105 is one of the best-known verses in the Bible. God's word is like a lamp in the night. Back then, people had small oil lamps. They did not shine very far, but far enough for the next step. In the same way, God's word often does not show the whole way, but it shows the next step.

Verse 108: "The offerings that my mouth gives you freely": Prayers and songs are like offerings to God.

Verse 109: "My life is always in my hand": This means: My life is always in danger.

Samekh: You are my hiding place and my shield VERSES 113–120

113 I hate people whose hearts are divided,
but I love your law.
114 You are my hiding place and my shield.
I hope in your word.
115 Go away from me, you people who do evil,
so that I can keep the commandments of my God!
116 Hold me up, as your word promises, so that I may live!
Do not let me be put to shame in my hope!
117 Hold me up, and I will be safe.
I will always pay attention to your rules.
118 You reject all who wander away from your rules,
because their lies are useless.
119 You throw away all the wicked people of the earth like dross.
That is why I love your teachings.
120 My body trembles with fear of you.
I am afraid of your judgments.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 113: "People whose hearts are divided": people who think one way at one time and another way at another time. They are half for God and half against him.

Verse 114: God is a safe hiding place.

Verse 119: "Dross": the worthless leftovers that remain when metal is melted. They are thrown away.

Ayin: It is time to act VERSES 121–128

121 I have done what is fair and right.
Do not leave me to the people who oppress me!
Oppress means: to treat people cruelly and unfairly.
122 Make sure that your servant is well!
Do not let the proud oppress me!
123 My eyes grow tired looking for your saving help
and for your right word.
124 Treat your servant with your loving kindness!
Teach me your rules!
125 I am your servant. Give me understanding,
so that I may know your teachings!
126 It is time to act, LORD,
because they break your law.
127 That is why I love your commandments more than gold,
yes, more than pure gold.
128 That is why I think that all your instructions are right.
I hate every false way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 126: The person praying calls out to God: Now it is time for you to step in! People trample your law.

Verse 127: Just when others look down on God's commandments, the person praying loves them all the more.

Pe: When your words come in, there is light VERSES 129–136

129 Your teachings are wonderful.
That is why my soul keeps them.
130 When your words come in, they give light.
They give understanding to simple people.
131 I opened my mouth wide and gasped for air,
because I longed for your commandments.
132 Turn to me and be merciful to me,
as you always are to those who love your name!
133 Make my steps firm in your word!
Do not let any evil rule over me!
134 Set me free from people who oppress me.
Then I will keep your instructions.
135 Let your face shine on your servant!
Teach me your rules!
136 Streams of tears run down from my eyes,
because people do not keep your law.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 130: When God's word "comes in" to a person, it becomes bright, like when you open a door and light comes in. Even simple people become wise through it.

Verse 131: Like a person gasping for air, the person praying longs for God's word.

Verse 136: The person praying cries because others ignore God's teaching. He is not proud. He is sad.

Tzadhe: You are righteous, LORD VERSES 137–144

137 You are righteous, LORD.
Your judgments are right.
138 You have given your rules in righteousness.
They can be fully trusted.
139 My zeal wears me out,
because my enemies ignore your words.
Zeal means: a strong, burning love for something.
140 Your promises have been tested very carefully,
and your servant loves them.
141 I am small and looked down on.
I do not forget your instructions.
142 Your righteousness lasts forever.
Your law is truth.
143 Trouble and fear have taken hold of me.
Your commandments are my joy.
144 Your teachings are right forever.
Give me understanding, so that I may live!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 140: God's promises are like metal that has been tested in fire: real and pure.

Verse 141: "I am small and looked down on": To the world, the person praying is not important. But he has a great treasure: God's word.

Verse 143: Even in the middle of trouble and fear, God's word can give joy.

Qoph: You are near, LORD VERSES 145–152

145 I have called out with my whole heart. Answer me, LORD!
I will keep your rules.
146 I have called out to you. Save me!
I will obey your rules.
147 I get up before dawn and cry out for help.
I put my hope in your words.
148 My eyes stay open through the hours of the night,
so that I can think deeply about your word.
149 Hear my voice because of your loving kindness!
Give me new life, LORD, by your rulings!
150 Those who chase after evil are coming near.
They are far away from your law.
151 You are near, LORD.
All your commandments are truth.
152 Long ago I learned from your teachings
that you have set them up to last forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying prays early in the morning and late at night.

Verses 150–151: A beautiful contrast: The enemies are coming near. But God is even nearer.

Resh: All your words are truth VERSES 153–160

153 Look at my suffering and rescue me,
because I do not forget your law.
154 Stand up for me in my case and set me free!
Give me new life, as you promised!
155 Saving help is far away from the wicked,
because they do not look for your rules.
156 Your tender mercy is great, LORD.
Give me new life by your rulings!
157 Many people chase after me and are against me.
But I have not turned away from your teachings.
158 I look at the unfaithful people with disgust,
because they do not keep your word.

159 See how I love your instructions!
Give me new life, LORD, because of your loving kindness!
160 All your words are truth.
Every one of your right rulings lasts forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 154: "Stand up for me in my case": God should speak up for the person praying, like a lawyer in court.

Verse 160: All of God's words together are truth. Jesus prays: "Your word is truth" (John 17:17).

Shin: Those who love your law have great peace
VERSES 161–168

161 Princes have chased after me for no reason,
but my heart stands in awe of your words.
162 I am glad about your word,
like someone who finds a great treasure taken in war.
163 I hate lies, and I find them disgusting.
I love your law.
164 Seven times a day I praise you,
because of your right rulings.
165 Those who love your law have great peace.
Nothing makes them stumble.
166 I have hoped for your saving help, LORD.
I have done what your commandments say.
167 My soul has kept your teachings.
I love them very much.
168 I have obeyed your instructions and your teachings,
because you see all my ways.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the WEB, our English source text, this section is called "Sin and Shin," because the Hebrew letter has two ways of being pronounced.

Verse 162: Discovering God's word is like finding a treasure.

Verse 164: "Seven times a day": again and again, all the time. The seven prayer times in many monasteries are based on this.

Verse 165: "Those who love your law have great peace": a beautiful promise.

Tav: I have wandered like a lost sheep
VERSES 169–176

169 Let my cry come before you, LORD!
Give me understanding, as your word promises!
170 Let my prayer for help come before you!
Rescue me, as you promised!
171 Let praise pour out from my lips,
because you teach me your rules.
172 Let my tongue sing about your word,
because all your commandments are right.
173 Let your hand be ready to help me,
because I have chosen your instructions.
174 I have longed for your saving help, LORD.
Your law is my joy.
175 Let my soul live, so that I may praise you!
Let your rulings help me!
176 I have wandered like a lost sheep.
Look for your servant,
because I do not forget your commandments.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The last section sums everything up: crying out, asking for help, praising, singing.

Verse 176 is an amazing ending. After 175 verses full of love for God's word, the person praying admits: "I have wandered like a lost sheep. Look for your servant."

This shows: Even someone who loves God's word is not perfect. In the end, all of us depend on God looking for us and finding us.

Jesus tells the parable of the good shepherd who looks for the lost sheep until he finds it (Luke 15:4–7).

PSALMS

Psalm 120

I am for peace

A stranger among people who love to fight
VERSES 1–7

1 A song of ascents.
That means: a song for going up to Jerusalem.
When I was in trouble, I cried out to the LORD.
He answered me.
2 LORD, save my life from lying lips,
from a tongue that deceives!
3 What will be given to you, and what more will be done to you,
you tongue that deceives?
4 Sharp arrows of a warrior,
together with burning coals of juniper wood!
5 How terrible for me that I live in Meshech,
that I live among the tents of Kedar!
6 My soul has lived too long
with people who hate peace.
7 I am for peace.
But when I speak, they are for war.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Psalm 120, the 15 "songs of ascents" begin (Psalms 120–134). In Hebrew, the name means: songs of going up. Pilgrims sang them when they went up to Jerusalem for the great festivals. Jerusalem lies on a mountain, so people "go up" to it.

The journey begins far away: Meshech was in the north (in today's Turkey). Kedar was a people in the Arabian desert. Both places stand for "very far away, in a hostile place."

Verses 3–4: Lies hurt like arrows and burn like hot coals. The person praying says: Whoever hurts others with lies will be hit himself. He leaves the judgment to God.

Verse 7: A sentence that still fits today: "I am for peace. But when I speak, they are for war." Even so, the person praying holds on to peace.

PSALMS

Psalm 121

The one who protects Israel does not sleep

Where does my help come from? VERSES 1–8

1 A song of ascents.
I lift up my eyes to the hills.
Where does my help come from?
2 My help comes from the LORD,
who made heaven and earth.
3 He will not let your foot slip.
The one who protects you will not fall asleep.
4 Look, the one who protects Israel
will not doze and will not sleep.
5 The LORD is the one who protects you.
The LORD is your shade at your right side.
6 The sun will not harm you during the day,
and the moon will not harm you at night.
7 The LORD will protect you from all evil.
He will protect your life.
8 The LORD will protect you when you go out and when you come home,
from now on and forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 121 is one of the best-loved psalms. People often pray it when they say goodbye, go on a trip, or at baptisms and funerals.

The pilgrim sees the hills in front of him. The way there is dangerous: steep paths, robbers, heat. He asks: Who will help me? The answer: not the hills, but the God who made the hills.

The word "protect" appears six times. God watches over us, like a guard who never falls asleep.

Verse 6: The sun could cause heatstroke. Back then, people believed that the moon could make them sick. God protects us by day and by night.

Verse 8: "When you go out and when you come home": This means the whole of life, every way, every day.

PSALMS

Psalm 122

Pray for peace for Jerusalem!

I was glad when they said to me VERSES 1–9

1 A song of ascents. By David.
I was glad when they said to me,
"Let's go to the LORD's house!"
2 Jerusalem, our feet are standing inside your gates!
3 Jerusalem is built as a city
that is closely joined together.
4 The tribes go up there, the tribes of Yah,
as a rule for Israel says,
to give thanks to the name of the LORD.
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
5 For there the thrones for judging are set up,
the thrones of David's family.
6 Pray for peace for Jerusalem!
May those who love you do well.
7 May there be peace inside your walls,
and may things go well inside your palaces!
8 For the sake of my brothers and my friends,
I will now say, "May there be peace inside you!"
9 For the sake of the house of the LORD our God,
I will look for what is good for you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the pilgrims have arrived. They are standing in the gates of Jerusalem. Their joy is great.

Verse 3: Jerusalem is built closely together, house next to house. This is also a picture of a people that holds together.

Verse 6: In Hebrew, there is a play on words here: "Yerushalayim" (Jerusalem) and "shalom" (peace). The city carries peace in its name.

"Pray for peace for Jerusalem": This request still matters today. Jews, Christians and Muslims have holy places in Jerusalem. To pray for the peace of this city and of all the people there is a good task.

PSALMS

Psalm 123

Our eyes look to the LORD

Like the eyes of servants VERSES 1–4

1 A song of ascents.
I lift up my eyes to you,
you who sit on your throne in heaven.
2 Servants watch the hand of their master.
A maid watches the hand of the woman she works for.
In the same way, our eyes look to the LORD our God,
until he is merciful to us.
3 Be merciful to us, LORD, be merciful to us,
because we have put up with a lot of scorn.
4 Our soul has had more than enough
of the mocking of those who live without worries,
of the scorn of the proud.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A short prayer of people who are looked down on.

Verse 2: Back then, servants watched the hand of their master closely. A small sign was enough. In the same way, the people look to God: paying close attention and full of hope.

Verse 4: "Those who live without worries": people who are doing well and who look down on others. Whoever is mocked may tell God about it.

PSALMS

Psalm 124

If the LORD had not been on our side

The trap is broken VERSES 1–8

1 A song of ascents. By David.
If the LORD had not been on our side,
let Israel now say it,
2 if the LORD had not been on our side
when people rose up against us,
3 then they would have swallowed us alive
when their anger burned against us.
4 Then the waters would have flooded over us.
The river would have gone over our soul.
5 Then the proud waters
would have gone over our soul.
6 Praise be to the LORD,
who has not given us to their teeth to tear apart.
7 Our soul has escaped like a bird
out of the trap of the bird catcher.
The trap is broken, and we have escaped.
8 Our help is in the name of the LORD,
who made heaven and earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people look back: Without God, we would have been lost. The enemies were like wild animals, like a flood.

Verse 7: A beautiful picture: A bird is caught in a trap. Suddenly the trap breaks, and the bird flies away free. That is how God set his people free.

Verse 8 is still spoken at the beginning of many church services today: "Our help is in the name of the LORD, who made heaven and earth."

PSALMS

Psalm 125

Like the mountains around Jerusalem

Whoever trusts the LORD stands firm VERSES 1–5

1 A song of ascents.
Those who trust in the LORD are like Mount Zion.
It cannot be moved, but it stays forever.
2 As the mountains surround Jerusalem,
so the LORD surrounds his people,
from now on and forever.
3 For the rule of the wicked will not stay
over the land given to the righteous.
Then the righteous will not use their hands to do evil.
4 LORD, do good to those who are good,
to those whose hearts are honest!
5 But those who turn away to their crooked ways,
the LORD will lead them away together with those
who do evil.
May there be peace on Israel!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem is surrounded by mountains on all sides. The pilgrims see this with their own eyes. In the same way, the psalm says, God surrounds his people: on all sides.

Verse 3: The rule of evil people will not last forever. Otherwise, good people would also be tempted to do evil.

The psalm ends with a blessing: "May there be peace on Israel!"

PSALMS

Psalm 126

Those who sow in tears

We were like people who dream VERSES 1–6

1 A song of ascents.
When the LORD brought back those who returned to
Zion,
we were like people who dream.
2 Then our mouths were full of laughter,
and our tongues were full of singing.
Then people among the nations said,
"The LORD has done great things for them."
3 The LORD has done great things for us,
and we are glad.
4 LORD, turn things around for us again,
like the streams in the Negev!
5 Those who sow in tears
will bring in the harvest with joy.

6 The one who goes out crying,
carrying seed to sow,
will surely come back with joy,
carrying his bundles of grain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm remembers the return home from exile in Babylon. It was so unbelievably wonderful that it felt like a dream.

Verse 4: The Negev is a desert in the south. The stream beds there are dry most of the time. But when rain comes, they suddenly fill with water, and everything turns green. In the same way, God should bring life again.

Verses 5–6 are a great comfort: Whoever cries now will laugh again. Tears are like seeds. The harvest will come.

The composer Johannes Brahms set these verses to music in his "German Requiem."

PSALMS

PSALM 127

Unless the LORD builds the house

Everything comes from God's hand VERSES 1–5

1 A song of ascents. By Solomon.
Unless the LORD builds the house,
the builders work on it for nothing.
Unless the LORD watches over the city,
the guard keeps watch for nothing.
2 It is for nothing that you get up early
and stay up late
and eat the bread of hard work.
For he gives sleep to those he loves.
3 Look, children are an inheritance from the LORD.
The children a mother bears are his reward.
4 Like arrows in the hand of a warrior,
so are the children a man has when he is young.
5 Happy is the man
who has filled his quiver with them.
A quiver is a bag for carrying arrows.
They will not be put to shame
when they speak with their enemies in the gate.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This psalm is linked with Solomon, the king who built the temple.

Verses 1–2: People can wear themselves out from morning to night. But without God's blessing, all the work brings nothing. This is not a call to be lazy, but a call to be calm. God gives rest and sleep.

Verse 2 also says: Sleep is a gift from God. Whoever allows themselves no rest because of so many worries and so much work may hear this.

Verses 3–5: Children are a gift from God, not a possession. Back then, many children gave a family security. Arguments and court cases were settled in the "gate." Grown children could support their parents there.

People who have no children, or who cannot have children, are not less blessed by God because of it. The Bible tells about many people without children whom God loves.

PSALMS

PSALM 128

A blessing for the home

Happy is the one who has deep respect for the LORD VERSES 1–6

1 A song of ascents.
Blessed is everyone who has deep respect for the LORD,
who walks in his ways.
2 For you will eat what your hands have worked for.
You will be happy, and things will go well for you.
3 Your wife will be like a vine full of fruit
in the inner rooms of your house.
Your children will be like young olive shoots
around your table.
4 Look, this is how the man is blessed
who has deep respect for the LORD.
5 May the LORD bless you from Zion!
May you see Jerusalem doing well
all the days of your life!
6 Yes, may you see your grandchildren!
May there be peace on Israel!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A picture of happiness in everyday life: work that pays off, a family at the table, grandchildren.

Verse 3: The grapevine and the olive tree were the most important plants in the land. They stand for life, joy and new growth. Young olive shoots grow all around the old tree, just as children sit around the table.

This psalm is often prayed at weddings. Blessing does not only show itself in big things, but also in quite ordinary life at home.

People who live alone or who have no family are not shut out from the blessing. God's blessing comes "from Zion," that is, from God himself, not from the circumstances of life.

PSALMS

PSALM 129

They have not defeated me

Plowed on my back VERSES 1–8

1 A song of ascents.
Many times they have made me suffer since I was young.
Let Israel now say it:
2 Many times they have made me suffer since I was young,
but they have not defeated me.
3 The plowmen plowed on my back.
They made their furrows long.
A furrow is a long, deep line that a plow cuts into the ground.
4 The LORD is righteous.
He has cut the ropes of the wicked.
5 Let all those who hate Zion
be put to shame and turned back.
6 Let them be like the grass on the roofs,
which dries up before it grows tall.
7 The one who cuts grain cannot fill his hand with it.
The one who ties bundles of grain cannot fill his arms with it.
8 And those who pass by do not say,
"May the blessing of the LORD be on you.
We bless you in the name of the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel looks back on its long history: Again and again, it was oppressed, from Egypt to Babylon. But it was not destroyed.

Verse 3: A painful picture: Like a plow, the oppressors left deep wounds on the back of the people, like the marks of a whip.

Verse 4: But God has cut the ropes that pulled the plow.

Verses 6–8: Grass on flat clay roofs grows fast, but dries up right away. No one can harvest it. In the same way, the power of the enemies should pass away.

Sadly, the Jewish people also suffered much persecution later, all the way to the Holocaust. This psalm bears witness: Hatred does not have the last word.

PSALMS

Psalm 130

Out of the depths I call to you

With you there is forgiveness VERSES 1–8

1 A song of ascents.
Out of the depths I have cried out to you, LORD.
2 Lord, hear my voice!
Let your ears listen closely
to the voice of my prayers for help!
3 Yah, if you kept a list of sins,
Lord, who could stand?
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
4 But with you there is forgiveness.
That is why people have deep respect for you.
5 I wait for the LORD. My soul waits.
I hope in his word.
6 My soul longs for the Lord
more than guards long for the morning,
more than guards long for the morning.
7 Israel, hope in the LORD,
because with the LORD there is loving kindness.
With him, there is rich freedom from guilt.
8 He will set Israel free
from all their sins.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 130 is one of the best-known psalms of repentance. Repentance means: turning away from what is wrong and turning back to God. Christians count seven psalms of repentance (Psalms 6, 32, 38, 51, 102, 130, 143).

"Out of the depths": The person praying is at the very bottom, as if in deep water. Maybe because of his guilt, maybe because of great trouble.

Verses 3–4: If God wrote down every wrong, no one would have a chance. But God forgives. And just because he forgives, people honor him with deep respect.

Verse 6: A night guard longs for the morning, when his watch is over. He knows: Morning will surely come. That is how the person praying waits for God.

Martin Luther made a hymn out of this psalm. In German, it is called "Aus tiefer Not schrei ich zu dir." That means: "Out of deep need I cry to you."

If you are "in the depths" yourself and do not know what to do: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

PSALMS

Psalm 131

Like a calm child

My soul has become quiet VERSES 1–3

1 A song of ascents. By David.
LORD, my heart is not proud,
and my eyes do not look down on others.
I do not busy myself with great matters,
or with things that are too wonderful for me.

2 Truly, I have calmed my soul and made it quiet,
like a weaned child with his mother.
My soul inside me is like a weaned child.
3 Israel, hope in the LORD,
from now on and forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One of the shortest psalms, but very heartfelt.

The person praying does not have to understand everything or be able to do everything. He is content.

Verse 2: A "weaned child" no longer drinks milk from his mother's breast. He no longer comes to his mother because he is hungry, but simply because he wants to be with her. That is how the person praying rests with God: quiet and safe.

Here God is compared to a mother. The Bible often speaks about God like a mother, too (compare Isaiah 66:13).

PSALMS

PSALM 132

A home for the LORD

David's oath VERSES 1–10

1 A song of ascents.
LORD, remember David
and all his suffering,
2 how he made an oath to the LORD
and a solemn promise to the Mighty One of Jacob:
3 "I will surely not go into my house
and not get into my bed.
4 I will not let my eyes sleep
or let my eyelids rest,
5 until I find a place for the LORD,
a home for the Mighty One of Jacob."
6 Look, we heard about it in Ephrathah.
We found it in the fields of Jaar.
7 "Let's go into his home.
Let's worship at the stool for his feet."
8 Get up, LORD, and come to your resting place,
you and the ark of your strength!
9 Let your priests be dressed in righteousness.
Let your holy people shout for joy!
10 For the sake of your servant David,
do not turn away from your anointed one!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The psalm remembers how King David brought the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6). The ark of the covenant was a chest with the stone tablets of the law in it. It was the sign that God is with his people.

David did not want to rest until God had a place in Jerusalem.

Verse 6: Ephrathah is an area near Bethlehem. "Jaar" probably means Kiriath Jearim, where the ark stood for a long time (1 Samuel 7:1–2).

Verse 7: The "stool for his feet" is the ark of the covenant. People imagined: God sits on his throne, unseen, above it, and the ark is like his footstool.

Verse 8 has almost the same words that Solomon prayed when the temple was dedicated (2 Chronicles 6:41–42).

God's oath for David and Zion VERSES 11–18

11 The LORD has made an oath to David in truth.
He will not turn away from it:
"I will put one of your own children
on your throne.
12 If your children keep my covenant
and my teaching that I will teach them,
then their children will also sit on your throne
forever."
13 For the LORD has chosen Zion.
He wanted it as his home.
14 "This is my resting place forever.
I will live here, because I have wanted it.
15 I will richly bless her food.
I will give her poor people enough bread to eat.
16 I will also dress her priests in salvation.
Her holy people will shout loudly for joy.
17 There I will make a horn grow for David.
I have set up a lamp for my anointed one.
18 I will dress his enemies in shame,
but on him, his crown will shine."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First David made an oath (verse 2). Now God makes an oath (verse 11). God's promise is even greater: David's family is to rule forever (compare 2 Samuel 7).

Verse 15: God cares in a special way for the poor. They are to have enough to eat.

Verse 17: "I will make a horn grow for David": A new, strong king is to grow out of David's family. The "lamp" is a picture that David's family will not die out.

Jews are still waiting today for the Messiah from David's family. Christians believe that this promise came true in Jesus, who is called "Son of David" (Luke 1:32–33).

PSALMS

PSALM 133

How good it is when brothers and sisters live in unity

Like oil and dew VERSES 1–3

1 A song of ascents. By David.

See how good and how pleasant it is
when brothers live together in unity!

2 It is like the precious oil on the head,
that ran down on the beard, Aaron's beard,
that ran down on the edge of his robes.
3 It is like the dew of Hermon,
that comes down on the hills of Zion.
For there the LORD gives the blessing:
life forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A short, joyful psalm about community. "Brothers" means all who belong together: brothers and sisters, families, the whole people. At the pilgrim festivals, people from all the tribes came together.

Verse 2: Aaron, the first high priest, was anointed with sweet-smelling oil (Exodus 29:7). The oil flowed down richly. That is how rich and good it is when people live together in peace.

Verse 3: Hermon is a high mountain in the north with a lot of dew. Zion lies farther south and is drier. Unity is like fresh dew that brings life.

The beginning of this psalm is a well-known Jewish song: "Hine ma tov uma na'im."

PSALMS

PSALM 134

Praise the LORD in the night

The blessing at the end VERSES 1–3

1 A song of ascents.
Look! Praise the LORD, all you servants of the LORD,
who stand in the LORD's house at night!
2 Lift up your hands toward the holy place.
Praise the LORD!
3 May the LORD bless you from Zion,
he who made heaven and earth!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the last of the 15 songs of ascents.

Verses 1–2: The pilgrims call out to the priests and Levites who serve in the temple at night: Praise God in the night, too!

Verse 3: The priests answer with a blessing for the pilgrims, before they go back home.

This is how the journey ends: People do not go home with empty hands, but with God's blessing.

PSALMS

PSALM 135

Praise Yah, for the LORD is good!

God has chosen Jacob VERSES 1–7

1 Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God, the LORD.
Praise the name of the LORD!
Praise him, you servants of the LORD,
2 you who stand in the LORD's house,
in the courtyards of the house of our God!
3 Praise Yah, for the LORD is good!
Sing praises to his name, for that is pleasant!
4 For Yah has chosen Jacob for himself,
Israel as his very own treasure.
5 For I know that the LORD is great,
that our Lord is above all gods.
6 The LORD has done whatever he wanted,
in heaven and on earth,
in the seas and in all the deep places.
7 He makes the clouds rise from the ends of the earth.
He makes lightning together with the rain.
He brings the wind out of his storerooms.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 135 takes up many words from other psalms and from the books of Moses. It is like a bouquet of well-known verses of praise.

Verse 4: "His very own treasure": Israel is God's special treasure (compare Exodus 19:5).

Verse 7: God is in charge of the weather. The neighboring peoples believed in weather gods. The psalm says: There is only one who rules over clouds, lightning and wind.

God has set his people free VERSES 8–14

8 He struck down the firstborn of Egypt,
both people and animals.
The firstborn is the first one born to a mother.
9 He sent signs and wonders into the middle of you,
Egypt,
against Pharaoh and all his servants.
10 He struck down many nations
and killed mighty kings:
11 Sihon, king of the Amorites,
and Og, king of Bashan,
and all the kingdoms of Canaan.
12 He gave their land as an inheritance,
as an inheritance to Israel, his people.
13 Your name, LORD, lasts forever.
LORD, people will remember you through all generations.
14 For the LORD will judge in favor of his people
and have compassion on his servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the history is told in a few words: the way out of Egypt (Exodus 12) and the way into the promised land (Numbers 21).

The battles of that time are part of the history of Israel. They do not allow violence today. The psalm wants to show: God

protected his weak people against great powers.

Verse 14: God gets justice for his people and has compassion on them.

Idols are dead, the LORD is alive VERSES 15–21

15 The idols of the nations are silver and gold,
made by human hands.
16 They have mouths, but they cannot speak.
They have eyes, but they cannot see.
17 They have ears, but they cannot hear.
And there is no breath in their mouths.
18 Those who make them will become like them,
yes, everyone who trusts in them.
19 People of Israel, praise the LORD!
Family of Aaron, praise the LORD!
20 Family of Levi, praise the LORD!
You who have deep respect for the LORD, praise the LORD!
21 Praise be to the LORD from Zion,
who lives in Jerusalem!
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–18 are almost word for word like Psalm 115:4–8. Idols are dead. Whoever trusts in dead things becomes empty inside.

Today, an "idol" can be anything that is more important to us than God: money, power, success.

Verses 19–20: Everyone is called to praise: the whole people, the priests (Aaron), the temple servants (Levi) and all who honor God.

PSALMS

PSALM 136

For his loving kindness lasts forever

Give thanks to the God of gods VERSES 1–3

1 Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
2 Give thanks to the God of gods,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
3 Give thanks to the Lord of lords,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 136 is a song sung in turns. A leader sings the first line, and the whole congregation answers each time: "for his loving kindness lasts forever." This happens 26 times.

The Hebrew word for "loving kindness" is "chesed." It means faithful love that never stops.

In Judaism, this psalm is called "the Great Hallel." Hallel means praise. It is sung at the festival of Passover.

The Creator VERSES 4–9

4 Give thanks to him who alone does great wonders,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
5 Give thanks to him who made the heavens with understanding,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
6 Give thanks to him who spread out the earth above the waters,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
7 Give thanks to him who made the great lights,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
8 He made the sun to rule the day,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
9 He made the moon and the stars to rule the night,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First, God is praised as the Creator: heaven, earth, sun, moon and stars (compare Genesis 1).

Behind every deed of God there is the same reason: his loving kindness.

The one who sets free VERSES 10–22

10 Give thanks to him who struck down the firstborn of Egypt,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
11 He brought Israel out from among them,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
12 He did it with a strong hand and with an arm stretched out,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
13 Give thanks to him who split the Red Sea in two,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
14 He let Israel go through the middle of it,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
15 But he threw Pharaoh and his army into the Red Sea,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
16 Give thanks to him who led his people through the wilderness,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
17 Give thanks to him who struck down great kings,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
18 He killed mighty kings,
for his loving kindness lasts forever:
19 Sihon, king of the Amorites,
for his loving kindness lasts forever,
20 and Og, king of Bashan,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
21 He gave their land as an inheritance,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
22 He gave it as an inheritance to Israel, his servant,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the history of Israel is told: the way out of Egypt, the way through the Red Sea, the wilderness and the arrival in the land.

The battles of that time are part of the history. They do not allow violence today. The psalm does not celebrate killing, but the rescue of a weak people.

He remembers us VERSES 23–26

23 He remembered us when we were at the very bottom,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
24 He has set us free from our enemies,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
25 He gives food to every living creature,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.
26 Oh, give thanks to the God of heaven,
for his loving kindness lasts forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, it becomes personal: God remembered "us" when things were bad for us.

Verse 25: God's loving kindness is not only for Israel. He gives food to every living creature, to people and animals all over the world.

You can keep praying this psalm today with your own experiences: For everything that God has done in my life, it is true: "for his loving kindness lasts forever."

PSALMS

PSALM 137

By the rivers of Babylon

How can we sing in a foreign land? VERSES 1–6

1 By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down.
Yes, we cried when we remembered Zion.
2 On the willow trees in that land
we hung up our harps.
3 For there, those who had taken us away as prisoners
asked us for songs.
Those who tormented us demanded happy songs:
"Sing us one of the songs of Zion!"
4 How can we sing the LORD's song
in a foreign land?
5 If I forget you, Jerusalem,
let my right hand forget its skill.
6 Let my tongue stick to the roof of my mouth
if I do not remember you,
if I do not put Jerusalem above my greatest joy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the year 587 BC, the Babylonians destroyed Jerusalem and the temple. Many people were taken away to Babylon by force (2 Kings 25).

There they sit by the rivers and canals, far away from home. They cannot sing. Their harps hang silent on the trees.

Verse 3: The winners make fun of them: "Sing us one of the songs of Zion!"

Verses 5–6: An oath: I would rather no longer be able to play music or speak than forget Jerusalem. To this day, a glass is broken at Jewish weddings to remember the destruction of Jerusalem.

This psalm is a song for all people who have lost their homeland: refugees, people driven out of their homes, people taken away by force.

The cry for revenge VERSES 7–9

7 LORD, remember what the people of Edom did
on the day Jerusalem fell.
They said, "Tear it down! Tear it down to its
foundations!"
8 Daughter of Babylon, you will be destroyed!
Happy will be the one who pays you back
for what you have done to us.
9 Happy will be the one
who takes your little children and smashes them
against the rock.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are the hardest in the whole book of Psalms. They are shocking.

We do not leave them out, because they are part of the Bible. But we need to understand what is happening here:

The people had seen with their own eyes how the soldiers of Babylon killed their children. The Edomites, a neighboring people, cheered while it happened (compare Obadiah 10–14). Verse 9 is the cry of people who have lived through unimaginable horror. Their pain and their anger are so great that they wish the same thing on their enemies.

Important: The person praying does not do it himself. He tells God about his hatred and leaves justice to God (compare Deuteronomy 32:35, where God says that taking revenge belongs to him).

This verse is not a permission and not a command. Violence against children is always a serious crime. Jesus says: "Love your enemies ... And pray for those who treat you badly and persecute you" (Matthew 5:44). And he puts children in the center and blesses them (Mark 10:13–16).

Here the Bible shows honestly how deeply people can be hurt. Even these dark feelings may be spoken out loud before God, so that they do not turn into actions.

PSALMS

PSALM 138

You have given me strength

I thank you with my whole heart VERSES 1–8

1 By David.
I will thank you with my whole heart.
In front of the gods I will sing praises to you.
2 I will bow down toward your holy temple.
I will thank your name for your loving kindness and
for your faithfulness.
For you have lifted up your name and your word above
everything.

3 On the day I called, you answered me.
You gave me courage and put strength in my soul.
4 All the kings of the earth will thank you, LORD,
because they have heard the words you have spoken.
5 Yes, they will sing about the ways of the LORD,
because the glory of the LORD is great!
6 For even though the LORD is high above,
he cares for those who are low.
But he knows the proud from far away.
7 Even when I walk through the middle of trouble, you will give me new life.
You will stretch out your hand against the anger of my enemies.
Your right hand will save me.
8 The LORD will finish what he has started for me.
Your loving kindness, LORD, lasts forever.
Do not leave the works of your own hands!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A psalm of thanks. God has answered a prayer.

Verse 1: "In front of the gods": Other peoples worshiped many gods. Right in the middle of them, David bravely sings for the one God.

Verse 6: God is at the very top, but he looks all the way down, at the small and the weak. But he stays far away from the proud.

Verse 8: "The LORD will finish what he has started for me": What God has begun, he also brings to an end. I am a work of his hands. He does not leave me half-finished.

PSALMS

Psalm 139

You know me

God knows everything about me VERSES 1–6

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
LORD, you have looked deep inside me, and you know me.
2 You know when I sit down and when I get up.
You understand my thoughts from far away.
3 You look closely at my path and at when I lie down.
You know all my ways well.
4 There is not a word on my tongue
that you, LORD, do not already know completely.
5 You surround me from behind and in front.
You have put your hand on me.
6 This knowledge is too wonderful for me.
It is too high. I cannot reach it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 139 is one of the deepest psalms about the relationship between God and a person.

God knows me completely: what I do, what I think, what I want to say. That could make me afraid. But here it is above all a comfort: I am not unknown, not forgotten.

Verse 5: "You have put your hand on me": like a mother or a father who puts a protecting hand on their child.

God is everywhere VERSES 7–12

7 Where could I go to get away from your Spirit?
Or where could I run away from your presence?
8 If I go up into heaven, you are there.
If I make my bed in Sheol (the world of the dead), look, you are there!
9 If I take the wings of the dawn
and settle down at the farthest end of the sea,
10 even there your hand will lead me,
and your right hand will hold me.
11 If I say, "Surely the darkness will cover me,
and the light around me will turn into night,"
12 even the darkness is not dark to you.
The night shines like the day.
The darkness is like light to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

There is no place where God is not: not in heaven, not in the world of the dead, not at the end of the world.

Verse 9: "The wings of the dawn": to fly as fast as the light of the rising sun, all the way to the end of the world.

Verses 11–12: Even in the darkest times, in depression, grief or fear, God is there. For him, the darkness is not dark.

If you are in deep darkness right now: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Wonderfully made VERSES 13–18

13 For you made the deepest parts of me.
You wove me together inside my mother.
14 I will thank you, for I am made in an amazing and wonderful way.
Your works are wonderful.
My soul knows that very well.
15 My body was not hidden from you
when I was made in secret,
woven together with skill in the depths of the earth.
16 Your eyes saw my body.
In your book they were all written down,
the days that were planned for me,
when not one of them had come yet.
17 How precious your thoughts are to me, God!
How great their number is!
18 If I tried to count them, they would be more than the sand.
When I wake up, I am still with you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God knew me even before I was born. He shaped me inside my mother, with as much skill as someone who weaves a carpet.

Verse 14: "I am made in an amazing and wonderful way": Every person is a wonder, no matter how they look, what they can do, or what other people say about them. This is also true for people with disabilities.

Verse 15: "In the depths of the earth": a poetic picture for the hidden place where a child grows.

Verse 16: God knows my whole life, every day.

Verse 18: God's thoughts about me are countless. He thinks about me much more than I can count.

Search me, God VERSES 19–24

19 God, if only you would kill the wicked!
Get away from me, you men who love to shed blood!
20 For they speak against you with evil words.
Your enemies use your name for worthless things.
21 LORD, don't I hate those who hate you?
Am I not sad about those who rise up against you?
22 I hate them with complete hatred.
They have become my enemies.
23 Search me, God, and know my heart!
Test me, and know my thoughts!
24 See if there is any evil way in me,
and lead me on the way that lasts forever!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 19–22 come as a surprise after such beautiful words. The person praying is full of anger about people who use violence and speak against God. He honestly tells God what he feels.

But then something important happens: He looks at himself. "Search me ... See if there is any evil way in me." He knows: There can be evil in me too, even hatred.

The psalm begins with "You have looked deep inside me" and ends with the request "Search me." The person praying opens himself completely to God.

Hatred is not a way for today. Jesus teaches us to love even our enemies (Matthew 5:44).

PSALMS

PSALM 140

Protect me from violent people

Tongues like snakes VERSES 1–5

1 For the music director. A psalm by David.
LORD, rescue me from evil people!
Protect me from violent men,
2 who plan evil in their hearts.
All the time they get together for war.
3 They have made their tongues sharp like a snake.
The poison of a viper is under their lips.
A viper is a very poisonous snake.
Selah.
4 LORD, keep me from the hands of the wicked!
Protect me from the violent men
who have decided to make me trip and fall.
5 The proud have hidden a trap for me.
They have spread out ropes like a net beside the path.
They have set traps for me.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The person praying is surrounded by enemies. They hurt him with words, as if with snake poison, and they set traps for him.

Paul quotes verse 3 in his letter to the Romans to show how evil words can be (Romans 3:13).

"Selah": probably a musical sign for a pause (see Psalm 3).

God gets justice for those who suffer VERSES 6–13

6 I said to the LORD, "You are my God."
LORD, listen to my loud cry for help!
7 LORD, the Lord, you are my strong help who saves me.
You have protected my head on the day of battle.
8 LORD, do not give the wicked what they want!
Do not let their evil plans succeed,
or they will become proud.
Selah.
9 As for the heads of those who surround me:
Let the trouble their own lips have caused cover them.
10 Let burning coals fall on them.
Let them be thrown into the fire,
into muddy pits, where they never get up again.
11 A person who speaks evil will not last on the earth.
Evil will hunt down the violent man to bring him down.
12 I know that the LORD will stand up for those who suffer,
and he will get justice for the poor.
13 Surely the righteous will thank your name.
The honest will live in your presence.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: God is like a helmet in battle.

Verses 9–11: The person praying wishes that the evil falls back on those who do it. These are hard words. He puts them into God's hands and does not use violence himself. For us today, this is true: Do not pay back evil with evil (Romans 12:17–21).

Verse 12 is the heart of the psalm: God is on the side of the poor and the weak. He makes sure there is justice.

PSALMS

PSALM 141

Let my prayer be like incense

Guard my mouth VERSES 1–5

1 A psalm by David.
LORD, I have called to you. Come to me quickly!

Listen to my voice when I call to you!
2 Let my prayer be set before you like incense,
and the lifting up of my hands like the evening sacrifice.
Incense is something that gives off a sweet smell when it burns.
3 LORD, put a guard in front of my mouth!
Watch over the door of my lips!
4 Do not turn my heart toward anything evil,
so that I do not do wicked things
with people who do wrong.
Do not let me eat their fine foods!
5 If a righteous person strikes me, it is a kindness.
If he corrects me, it is like oil on my head.
Do not let my head refuse it.
But my prayer is always against evil deeds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: Every evening in the temple, incense was burned and a sacrifice was offered. The sweet smell rose up to heaven. In the same way, my prayer should rise up to God. This verse is still sung in evening prayers today.

Verse 3: A good request for every day: God, watch over what comes out of my mouth!

Verse 4: The "fine foods" of the wicked: advantages and pleasures that people get when they take part in doing wrong.

Verse 5: Honest criticism from a good person is a gift, even when it hurts. "Strikes" is a picture here for a hard correction. It does not allow violence.

My eyes are on you VERSES 6–10

6 Their judges are thrown down from the sides of the rock.
Then they will hear my words, because they are well spoken.
7 "As when someone plows and breaks up the ground,
so our bones are scattered at the entrance of Sheol."
Sheol is the world of the dead.
8 For my eyes are on you, LORD, the Lord.
I look for safety in you.
Do not leave my soul without protection!
9 Keep me from the trap that they have set for me,
from the traps of those who do wrong!
10 Let the wicked all fall into their own nets,
while I pass by.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7 are very hard to understand in Hebrew. The translations are very different from each other. It probably means: The unjust leaders will fall. The people suffer so much that they feel like bones lying scattered at the edge of the grave.

Verse 8: Even so, the person praying looks to God.

Verse 10: The wicked are to fall into their own traps, and the person praying walks on unharmed.

PSALMS

PSALM 142

A prayer in the cave

No one cares about me VERSES 1–7

1 A thoughtful poem by David, when he was in the cave.
A prayer.
I cry out loud to the LORD.
With my voice I ask the LORD to be merciful.
2 I pour out my complaint before him.
I tell him about my troubles.
3 When my spirit grew weak inside me,
you knew my way.
On the path where I walk,
they have hidden a trap for me.
4 Look to my right and see:
There is no one who cares about me.
I have no place left where I am safe.
No one cares about my soul.
5 I cried out to you, LORD.
I said, "You are my safe place,
my share in the land of the living."
6 Listen to my cry, for I am in great need!
Rescue me from those who are chasing me,
because they are too strong for me.
7 Bring my soul out of prison,
so that I can thank your name!
The righteous will gather around me,
because you will be good to me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David hid from King Saul in a cave (1 Samuel 22:1; 24:1–4). He was a refugee, hunted and alone.

Verse 4: "Look to my right": In court, the person who defended someone stood on the right. But no one is there. No one helps.

Verse 5: But one remains: God is my safe place.

Verse 7: The cave feels like a prison. But in the end, David will not be alone anymore. The righteous will be all around him.

If you feel lonely and have no one: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

PSALMS

PSALM 143

Teach me to do your will

No one is righteous before you VERSES 1–6

1 A psalm by David.
Hear my prayer, LORD!
Listen to my requests!
Help me, because you are faithful and righteous!
2 Do not take your servant to court,
because in your sight no person alive is righteous.
3 For the enemy is chasing after my soul.
He has crushed my life down to the ground.
He has made me live in dark places,
like people who have been dead for a long time.
4 That is why my spirit grows weak inside me.
My heart inside me is frozen with horror.
5 I remember the days of long ago.
I think deeply about all that you have done.
I think about the work of your hands.
6 I spread out my hands to you.
My soul is thirsty for you, like a dry land.
Selah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 143 is the last of the seven psalms of repentance.

Verse 2: An important sentence: "In your sight no person alive is righteous." No one can say before God: I am completely righteous. That is why the person praying does not ask to be judged by what he has done, but asks for grace. Paul takes up this thought (Romans 3:20; Galatians 2:16).

Verses 3–4: The person praying feels as if he is buried alive. Many people with severe depression know this feeling.

Verses 5–6: What helps? Remembering what God has done before. And reaching out for him, like dry ground reaches out for rain.

Let me hear of your loving kindness in the morning VERSES 7–12

7 Answer me quickly, LORD! My spirit is failing.
Do not hide your face from me,
or I will become like those who go down into the pit.
8 Let me hear of your loving kindness in the morning,
because I trust in you.
Show me the way I should walk,
because I lift up my soul to you.
9 Rescue me from my enemies, LORD!
I run to you so that you can hide me.
10 Teach me to do your will,
because you are my God.
Your Spirit is good.
Lead me in a land where things are right.
11 Give me new life, LORD, for the sake of your name!
Because you are righteous, bring my soul out of trouble!
12 Because of your loving kindness, cut off my enemies.
Destroy all those who trouble my soul,
because I am your servant.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: After a dark night, the person praying hopes for the morning. He wants to hear about God's loving kindness like good news in the morning.

Verse 10: "Teach me to do your will": one of the most beautiful short prayers in the Bible. "Lead me in a land where things are right": God leads us on a straight, honest way.

Verse 12: The person praying asks God to set him free from his enemies. He does not use violence himself, but leaves it to God. For us today, the way of Jesus is: love our enemies and pray for them (Matthew 5:44).

PSALMS

Psalm 144

What are human beings?

God, my rock VERSES 1–4

1 By David.
Praise be to the LORD, my rock,
who trains my hands for war
and my fingers for battle.
2 He is my loving kindness and my fortress,
my high tower and the one who rescues me,
my shield and the one in whom I find safety.
He makes my people obey me.
3 LORD, what are human beings, that you care for them?
What is a son of man, that you think about him?
A son of man means: a human being.
4 A human being is like a breath.
His days are like a shadow that passes by.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 144 takes up many words from Psalm 18 and Psalm 8.

Verse 1: David was a warrior and a king. He thanks God for strength and skill in battle. That was the reality of his life back then. It is not a call to war today.

Verses 3–4: In the middle of his praise, David is amazed: Human beings are so small and pass away so quickly, like a breath. And still, the great God cares for them (compare Psalm 8:4).

Come down and rescue me VERSES 5–11

5 LORD, open up your heavens and come down!
Touch the mountains, and they will smoke.
6 Throw out lightning and scatter the enemies!
Send out your arrows and chase them away!
7 Stretch out your hand from above!
Rescue me and save me out of deep waters,
out of the hands of foreigners,
8 whose mouths speak lies,
and whose right hand is a hand that lies.
9 I will sing a new song to you, God.
I will sing praises to you on a lyre with 10 strings.
A lyre is a small harp.
10 You are the one who saves kings,
who rescues David, his servant, from the deadly sword.

11 Rescue me and save me out of the hands of foreigners,
whose mouths speak lies,
and whose right hand is a hand that lies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: God is to come as if in a mighty thunderstorm, like back then at Mount Sinai.

Verse 8: People raised their "right hand" when they made an oath. The enemies make false oaths. Their promise is worth nothing.

"Foreigners" here means enemy peoples who lie and cheat. It is not a statement against foreigners in general. The Bible often says: God protects strangers (for example, Psalm 146:9).

Happy are the people whose God is the LORD VERSES 12–15

12 Then our sons will be like plants that are well cared for.
Our daughters will be like carved pillars that decorate a palace.
13 Our barns are full,
filled with all kinds of food.
Our sheep have thousands and tens of thousands of lambs
in our fields.
14 Our oxen will pull heavy loads.
No one breaks through our walls, no one has to go away,
and there are no cries of sorrow in our streets.
15 Happy are the people for whom things are like this.
Happy are the people whose God is the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A picture of peace: healthy children, full barns, many animals. No enemies break in, no one has to flee, no one cries out in sorrow.

Verse 14: "No one breaks through our walls": no gap broken into the city wall. "No one has to go away": no one is taken away as a prisoner.

Verse 15: True happiness is not only wealth. It is this: God is our God.

PSALMS

PSALM 145

I will honor you, my God and King

No one can measure God's greatness VERSES 1–7

1 A psalm of praise by David.
I will honor you highly, my God, the King!
I will praise your name forever and ever.
2 Every day I will praise you.
I will praise your name highly forever and ever.
3 The LORD is great, and he deserves great praise!
No one can measure how great he is.
4 One generation will praise your works to the next.
They will tell about your mighty deeds.
5 I will think deeply about the glorious splendor of your majesty,
about your wonderful works.
6 People will speak about the power of your awesome deeds.
I will tell about your greatness.
7 They will gladly tell everyone how very good you are,
and they will sing about your righteousness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Psalm 145 is the last alphabet poem in the book of Psalms: In Hebrew, each verse begins with the next letter of the alphabet.

It is the only psalm that is called a "psalm of praise" (in Hebrew "tehillah") in its heading. The Hebrew name of the whole book of Psalms comes from this word: "Tehillim," songs of praise.

In Judaism, Psalm 145 is prayed three times a day. The Talmud says: Whoever prays it every day belongs to the world to come.

Verse 4: Faith is passed on from generation to generation: from parents to children, from grandparents to grandchildren.

The LORD is good to all VERSES 8–13

8 The LORD is kind and merciful.
He is slow to become angry and rich in loving kindness.
9 The LORD is good to all.
His tender mercy is over everything he has made.
10 Everything you have made will thank you, LORD.
Your holy people will praise you highly.
11 They will speak about the glory of your kingdom
and talk about your power,
12 to let all people know about his mighty deeds
and the glorious splendor of his kingdom.
13 Your kingdom is a kingdom that lasts forever.
Your rule lasts through all generations.
The LORD is faithful in all his words,
and loving in all his deeds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8 is the great statement that God himself said to Moses (Exodus 34:6). It comes up again and again in the Bible.

Verse 9: "Good to all": God's goodness is not only for one people, but for all people and for all of creation.

Verse 13: In the standard Hebrew text, the verse with the letter "Nun" is missing. It has been kept in an old handwritten copy from Qumran and in the Greek translation: "The LORD is faithful in all his words …" The WEB, our English source text, includes it in verse 13. So the alphabet is complete.

The LORD lifts up those who are bent low VERSES 14–21

14 The LORD holds up all who fall,
and lifts up all who are bent low.
15 The eyes of all look to you and wait,
and you give them their food at the right time.

16 You open your hand
and satisfy the wishes of every living thing.
17 The LORD is righteous in all his ways
and kind in all his works.
18 The LORD is near to all who call on him,
to all who call on him in truth.
19 He gives those who have deep respect for him what they wish for.
He also hears their cry and saves them.
20 The LORD protects all who love him,
but he will destroy all the wicked.
21 My mouth will speak the praise of the LORD.
Let all people praise his holy name
forever and ever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: God is there for those who fall and who are bent low. He helps them get up again.

Verses 15–16 are a well-known prayer before meals: "The eyes of all look to you and wait, and you give them their food at the right time. You open your hand and satisfy the wishes of every living thing."

Verse 18: God is near. You do not have to search far for him. An honest prayer is enough.

Verse 20: God will put an end to evil. That is a comfort for the victims of injustice.

The word "all" appears very often in this psalm. God's goodness reaches far.

PSALMS

Psalm 146

Do not trust in princes

The LORD sets the prisoners free VERSES 1–10

1 Praise Yah!
Yah is a short form of the name of God.
Praise the LORD, my soul!
2 As long as I live, I will praise the LORD.
I will sing praises to my God as long as I am here.
3 Do not put your trust in princes,
in a human being who cannot help.
4 His spirit leaves him, and he goes back to the earth.
On that very day, his plans are lost.
5 Happy is the one who has the God of Jacob as his help,
whose hope is in the LORD his God,
6 who made heaven and earth,
the sea and everything in them,
who stays true forever,
7 who gets justice for those who are oppressed,
who gives food to the hungry.
The LORD sets the prisoners free.
8 The LORD opens the eyes of the blind.
The LORD lifts up those who are bent low.
The LORD loves the righteous.
9 The LORD protects the foreigners.
He supports the orphans and the widows,
but he turns the way of the wicked upside down.
10 The LORD will rule as King forever.
Zion, your God will rule through all generations.
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Psalm 146, the final "Hallelujah" of the book of Psalms begins. Psalms 146 to 150 all begin and end with "Praise Yah!" (in Hebrew "Hallelujah").

Verses 3–4: Even the most powerful politicians are only human. They die, and their plans die with them. That is why we should not put our final hope in them.

Verses 7–9 show who God is: He is on the side of the oppressed, the hungry, the prisoners, the blind, the foreigners, the orphans and the widows. This is exactly how Jesus acted (compare Luke 4:18; 7:22).

From this comes a task for us, too: Whoever praises God should also care for these people.

PSALMS

Psalm 147

He heals those whose hearts are broken

He counts the stars and heals hearts VERSES 1–11

1 Praise Yah, for it is good to sing praises to our God.
It is pleasant, and it is right to praise him.
2 The LORD builds up Jerusalem.
He gathers together the people of Israel who were driven out.
3 He heals those whose hearts are broken,
and he bandages their wounds.
4 He counts the number of the stars.
He calls them all by their names.
5 Our Lord is great and very powerful.
His understanding has no end.
6 The LORD lifts up the humble.
He brings the wicked down to the ground.
7 Sing to the LORD with thanks!
Sing praises on the harp to our God,
8 who covers the sky with clouds,
who gets rain ready for the earth,
who makes grass grow on the mountains.
9 He gives food to the farm animals,
and to the young ravens when they call.

10 He does not take delight in the strength of a horse.
He takes no pleasure in the strong legs of a man.
11 The LORD takes pleasure in those who have deep respect for him,
in those who hope in his loving kindness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–3: After the exile, God builds Jerusalem up again and brings the scattered people home. And he heals the hearts that are broken, like a doctor who bandages wounds.

Verses 3–4: A wonderful contrast: The God who knows the billions of stars and gives them names cares about one single broken heart.

Verse 9: God even hears the young ravens that cry out for food. Jesus says: "Consider the ravens ... God feeds them" (Luke 12:24).

Verses 10–11: God is not impressed by war horses or strong muscles, but by people who trust him.

He sends out his word VERSES 12–20

12 Praise the LORD, Jerusalem!
Praise your God, Zion!
13 For he has made the bars of your gates strong.
He has blessed your children inside you.
14 He brings peace inside your borders.
He fills you with the finest wheat.
15 He sends out his command to the earth.
His word runs very fast.
16 He gives snow like wool.
He scatters frost like ashes.
17 He throws down his hail like little stones.
Who can stand up against his cold?
18 He sends out his word and melts them.
He makes his wind blow, and the waters flow.
19 He shows his word to Jacob,
his rules and his rulings to Israel.
20 He has not done this for any other nation.
They do not know his rulings.
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–18: God's word is like a fast messenger. It brings winter with snow, frost and hail. And it also brings the thaw, when the ice melts and the streams flow again.

Verses 19–20: God has given Israel something special: his word, his teaching. That is a privilege and a responsibility. Christians believe that God's word later came to all nations through Israel.

PSALMS

Psalm 148

All creation praises God

Praise him from the heavens VERSES 1–6

1 Praise Yah!
Praise the LORD from the heavens!
Praise him in the heights!
2 Praise him, all his angels!
Praise him, all his army!
3 Praise him, sun and moon!
Praise him, all you shining stars!
4 Praise him, you highest heavens,
and you waters above the heavens!
5 Let them praise the name of the LORD,
for he gave the command, and they were created.
6 He has also set them in their place forever and ever.
He has made a law that will not pass away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A huge choir: Everything that is in heaven is to praise God: the angels, the sun, the moon, the stars.

Verse 4: "Waters above the heavens": That is how people pictured the world back then (compare Genesis 1:7). The rain came from up there.

Verses 5–6: Everything exists because God called it. And he keeps it in its order.

Praise him from the earth VERSES 7–14

7 Praise the LORD from the earth,
you great sea creatures and all the deep places,
8 lightning and hail, snow and clouds,
stormy wind that does what he says,
9 mountains and all hills,
fruit trees and all cedars,
10 wild animals and all farm animals,
small creatures and flying birds,
11 kings of the earth and all peoples,
princes and all judges of the earth,
12 young men and young women,
old men and children!
13 Let them praise the name of the LORD,
for his name alone is lifted up high.
His glory is above the earth and the heavens.
14 He has lifted up the horn of his people,
a reason for praise for all his holy people,
for the people of Israel, a people who are close to him.
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it is the earth's turn: sea creatures, weather, mountains, trees, animals, and last of all people, all people: kings and ordinary people, young and old, men and women, children.

All of creation forms one choir. Each creature praises God in its own way, simply by being there.

Francis of Assisi was inspired by this psalm when he wrote his "Canticle of the Sun."

This psalm also reminds us: Creation belongs to God. We humans are to treat it well.

Verse 14: "He has lifted up the horn of his people": God has given his people new strength and dignity.

PSALMS

Psalm 149

Sing a new song to the LORD

Joy and dancing VERSES 1–5

1 Praise Yah!
Sing a new song to the LORD!
Sing his praise in the gathering of his holy people!
2 Let Israel be glad about the one who made them.
Let the people of Zion be joyful about their King.
3 Let them praise his name with dancing!
Let them sing praises to him with tambourine and harp!
4 For the LORD takes pleasure in his people.
He crowns the humble with salvation.
5 Let his holy people be glad about this honor.
Let them sing for joy on their beds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A joyful celebration with music and dancing. God is glad about his people, and the people are glad about God.

Verse 4: God "crowns the humble": With God, the small and modest receive a crown.

Verse 5: "On their beds": Even at night, while they rest, they still sing for joy.

The sword in their hand VERSES 6–9

6 Let the high praises of God be in their mouths,
and a sword with two sharp edges in their hand,
7 to take revenge on the nations
and to punish the peoples,
8 to tie up their kings with chains
and their nobles with iron chains,
9 to carry out on them the judgment that is written.
All his holy people have this honor.
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are difficult. After joy and dancing, there is suddenly talk of a sword and revenge.

This psalm comes from a time when Israel was oppressed by great empires. It expresses the hope: God will judge the unjust rulers. What is meant is "the judgment that is written," that is, God's judgment, not people's own plans for revenge.

Sadly, in the course of history, these verses have been misused to justify war and violence in the name of God. That is wrong.

Many Jews and Christians today understand the sword in a picture sense. The letter to the Hebrews says that God's word is "sharper than any two-edged sword" (Hebrews 4:12). Paul speaks of "the sword of the Spirit. That is the word of God" (Ephesians 6:17).

Jesus says: "Put your sword back into its place! For all those who take the sword will die by the sword" (Matthew 26:52). Violence in the name of God is not a way.

PSALMS

Psalm 150

Let everything that breathes praise Yah!

The great Hallelujah VERSES 1–6

1 Praise Yah!
Praise God in his holy place!
Praise him in his heavens for his powerful deeds!
2 Praise him for his mighty deeds!
Praise him because his greatness is so wonderful!
3 Praise him with the sound of the trumpet!
Praise him with harp and lyre!
4 Praise him with tambourine and dancing!
Praise him with string instruments and flute!
5 Praise him with loud cymbals!
Praise him with ringing cymbals!
6 Let everything that has breath praise Yah!
Praise Yah!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The last psalm is one single shout of joy. In six verses, the word "praise" appears 13 times.

Verses 1–2: Where should we praise God? Everywhere, in the temple and in heaven. Why? Because he has done great things and because he is great.

Verses 3–5: With what? With all the instruments: trumpets, harps, drums, flutes, cymbals. And with dancing. The whole orchestra plays.

Verse 6: Who should praise? Everything that breathes. Not only Israel, not only people, but all life. Every breath is a gift from God and can be praise for him.

This is how the book of Psalms ends: not with a lament, but with praise. The way goes through many tears, but at the end there is the Hallelujah.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Psalms?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The prayer book of the Bible: The Psalms are 150 songs and prayers. They were written over many centuries, from David until after the exile. They were the songbook of the temple in Jerusalem. To this day, Jews and Christians pray with these words, every day, all over the world.

Five books: The book of Psalms is divided into five books (Psalms 1–41, 42–72, 73–89, 90–106, 107–150), like the five books of Moses. Each book ends with words of praise. At the end of the whole book, Psalm 150 stands as the great final Hallelujah.

There is room for all feelings: In the Psalms there is joy and sorrow, thanks and lament, trust and despair, love and even anger and hatred. The Psalms show: We may tell God

everything. We do not have to pretend to be pious before him.

Lament is prayer: Almost a third of the psalms are laments. "My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?" (Psalm 22) Whoever laments still believes that God is listening. Many psalms of lament end with new trust.

Hard verses: Some psalms wish evil on enemies (for example, Psalm 109 or 137). We have not left them out, because they are part of the Bible. They show honestly how hurt people can be. But they do not allow violence. Those who pray leave the judgment to God. Jesus shows the way of loving our enemies.

God's word: Psalm 1 and Psalm 119 praise God's teaching. It is like a light on the path (Psalm 119:105).

The king: Many psalms speak about the king from David's family, the anointed one (in Hebrew "Messiah"). Jews are waiting for the Messiah. Christians believe that Jesus is this anointed one. Jesus himself prayed the Psalms, even on the cross (Psalm 22:1; 31:5).

Well-known words: "The LORD is my shepherd" (Psalm 23). "Commit your way to the LORD" (Psalm 37). "Out of the depths I have cried out to you" (Psalm 130). "I lift up my eyes to the hills" (Psalm 121). "Praise the LORD, my soul" (Psalm 103). These words have comforted people in every situation of life.

From sighing to praise: The way of the book of Psalms goes from "Blessed is the person" (Psalm 1) through much suffering all the way to "Let everything that has breath praise Yah!" (Psalm 150).

What comes next? Next comes the book of Proverbs. It is full of short, wise sayings for everyday life: about work, friendship, money, words and family. Its guiding sentence: "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge" (Proverbs 1:7).

Help is available

You are not alone.

If you are not doing well, it is okay to ask for help.

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (USA)
Call or text 988
free, 24 hours a day

Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline (USA)
1-800-422-4453
free, 24 hours a day

National Domestic Violence Hotline (USA)
1-800-799-7233
free, 24 hours a day

RAINN Sexual Assault Hotline (USA)
1-800-656-4673
free, 24 hours a day

Samaritans (UK and Ireland)
116 123
free, 24 hours a day

Childline (UK, for children and young people)
0800 1111
free

Other countries
findahelpline.com
free help lines worldwide

Emergency
911 (USA) · 999 (UK) · 112 (Europe)
police, ambulance, fire